THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART ONE OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part One — The Question Underneath the Question

A photograph from a protest. A rumour that followed it. And the machinery underneath both.

Before we can ask what happens when the rules about women change, we have to pull apart three different claims that are almost always spoken as one sentence.

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Why I Wrote This

BEFORE WE BEGIN

A woman stood in front of a police vehicle at a protest. She had one hand flat against it. Somebody took a photograph. The photograph travelled.

Within a few days a second story was travelling alongside it. The woman in the picture, people said, sold intimate photographs of herself online for money. I do not know whether that is true. I have not tried to find out, and I will explain in Chapter One exactly why not. What interests me is not her. It is what happened in the gap between the two stories.

In that gap, a large number of people performed the same manoeuvre at the same time, without coordinating and without noticing they were doing it. They took a claim about a woman's body and used it to settle a question about a woman's politics. Almost nobody stopped to ask what one had to do with the other. The move felt natural. That is the interesting part. When something that does not follow logically feels natural to millions of people at once, there is a machine underneath, and the machine is old, and it is worth taking apart.

I want to be honest about how this series started, because it started with irritation rather than curiosity. I found the manoeuvre disgusting and I wanted to say so. Then somebody told me that rules like this exist for reasons, that they have survived a long time, and that people who tear down old rules without understanding them cause disasters. That is not a stupid thing to say. It is a serious argument with a serious history behind it, and it deserved better than my irritation.

So I decided to do the work properly. Sixteen parts. Where these rules came from. What they were for. Who paid for them. What the evidence actually shows about what happens to a woman who breaks them, and what happens to a society that stops enforcing them. Whether men and women are the same, in what ways, by how much, and what follows from the answer. What sixty years of the equality project has actually produced, measured rather than asserted. What happens to a population that stops having children. And what nobody knows, which turns out to be a great deal more than either side admits.

I am going to be blunt. Not cruel, but blunt. This subject is drowning in politeness in one direction and abuse in the other, and neither produces knowledge. Where the evidence supports something that will annoy people who think of themselves as progressive, it goes in at full strength. Where it supports something that will annoy people who think of themselves as traditional, it goes in at full strength too. If you finish a part of this series without having been made uncomfortable at least once, I have failed at it.

One promise, which is the only promise this series makes. **I am not going to pick a side for you.** I will show you what each position claims, what evidence it actually has as opposed to the evidence it says it has, and where it is guessing. Then you decide. Where my own position could pull the writing, I will say so in the text at the point where it applies, rather than hiding it in a note at the front that nobody reads.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, TAUGHT BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Six kinds of box appear throughout. Each does one job. Here is a live example of each, so you know what you are looking at when it turns up in the middle of a chapter.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Norm:** an unwritten rule about how people should behave. Not a law. Nobody votes on it and nobody signs it. It is enforced by ordinary people through approval and disapproval — a look, a comment, an invitation not extended, a marriage proposal that does not arrive.
>
> Why it matters here: almost everything this series examines is a norm rather than a law. That makes it harder to see, harder to change, and much harder to argue with, because there is no office you can appeal to.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does. Not in a glossary at the back, not later. There is a glossary at the back as well, but you should never need it.

IN REAL TERMS

India has roughly 1.4 billion people. That number is unusable. Here is a usable version: if you shrank the whole world to a single village of one hundred people, about eighteen of them would be Indian, and about nine of those eighteen would be women and girls.

So when this series says something is true of Indian women, it is describing the lives of nine people in a village of one hundred. Whatever the rules do to them, they do at that scale.

Any number too big to picture gets converted into something with a body — a walk, a room, a wage, a village of one hundred.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Much of what we know about sexual behaviour comes from surveys where people are asked to report their own history. This is a weak instrument and it is worth knowing why before you read fifteen parts built partly on it.

In survey after survey, in many countries, men report substantially more opposite-sex partners than women do. In a closed population this is arithmetically impossible. Every act has two participants. The averages must come out close to equal.

What it can show: that men and women answer the same question differently, reliably, everywhere. What it cannot show: which of them is wrong, or by how much. The most likely answer is both, in opposite directions, because the two sexes are punished for opposite answers.

This box names the actual evidence — the survey, the register, the court record, the bone — and then says what that evidence cannot show. It is the box that should make you trust the rest.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD A PERSON'S PRIVATE LIFE COUNT AGAINST THEIR PUBLIC ARGUMENT?

This is the question the protest photograph raises, and people answer it with total confidence in both directions.

IT IS IRRELEVANT

An argument is either sound or it is not. Whether the person making it is a saint or a criminal changes nothing about whether the police were right or wrong that day. Attacking the person instead of the claim is the oldest way of avoiding a claim you cannot answer.

IT IS RELEVANT TO TRUST

We cannot personally check most of what we are told, so we necessarily rely on the character of the teller. A person's conduct is information about how much weight to put on their word. Pretending otherwise is not high-mindedness, it is a refusal to use evidence you actually have.

Where things stand: both are partly right, and they are about different things. For a claim you can check yourself, the character of the speaker is irrelevant. For a claim you must take on trust, it is evidence. The protest case is the first kind. Whether the police acted lawfully is a matter of public record and does not depend on anybody's private life.

What would settle it: nothing general. It has to be settled claim by claim, by asking whether the claim is checkable without trusting the speaker.

Why people care so much: because the second position is a licence. If character is always relevant, then any opponent can be answered by investigating their life rather than their argument, and the investigation only ever has to succeed once.

An Argument box appears wherever people who have studied something genuinely disagree. Each side gets its strongest case, not a version built to lose. Then a verdict that says where things actually stand, what would settle it, and why people are fighting so hard.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides of the argument above assume the same thing without saying it: that the woman's conduct, if real, is *discrediting* in the first place.

Notice that the defence and the attack agree on this. The attack says she sells images, therefore she is not worth listening to. The defence says her private life is irrelevant, so do not bring it up. Neither says the obvious third thing — that selling images might simply not be a mark against a person at all.

> That silence is the shared premise. And a shared premise is invisible precisely because the two loudest voices in the room are not arguing about it.

This is the signature box of the method, and the hardest to write. It is not a caveat or a limitation. It digs out something both sides of a fight are taking for granted while they fight. There are between four and six in every part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these. It restates the chapter in the plainest words available, with the key terms in **bold**.

If you read only the Remember This boxes and nothing else, you should still finish this document holding the whole argument.

A Warning About This Series

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

Three warnings, and then we start.

The material is live and it is personal. This is not a series about a dead empire. It is about rules that are being enforced on somebody today, possibly on you, possibly by you. Later parts contain figures on violence, on suicide, and on the deaths of women and girls who were never born. I am not going to soften those numbers, and some readers will find them hard.

I am not neutral and I will not pretend to be. I am an Indian man. I have never been on the receiving end of a single rule this series examines. That is a serious limitation and it does not go away by my mentioning it, so I will flag it again at each point where it could bend the writing. There is also a well-worn habit among educated Indian men of writing about women's freedom in a way that is mostly about sounding modern to other men. I know that habit is available to me. Watch for it, and write to me when you catch it.

Simple words, serious content. Every hard idea in this series is explained in ordinary English, on the spot, the first time it appears. That is a choice about sentences, not about depth. Nothing is left out to make it easier. If a passage looks simple, it is because the sentences were made simple, not because the argument was made small.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

A Photograph and a Rumour

A woman put her hand on a police vehicle and somebody photographed it. Days later, a different kind of story arrived. What happened in between is the subject of this entire series.

1.1 — What happened, in order

Start with the sequence, because the sequence is the thing people stop being able to see once they have picked a side.

First: a protest. A woman is standing in front of a police vehicle. One hand rests flat against it. She is not throwing anything. She is standing still, which is why the image works — a still body against a machine built to move.

Second: the photograph spreads. People share it. Some share it because they support what she is protesting. Some share it because a single figure against a vehicle is a good picture, and good pictures travel whether or not people care about the cause.

Third, and this is where it gets interesting: a few days pass. Then a second story appears next to the first one. The woman in the picture, it is said, sells intimate photographs of herself on the internet for money.

Fourth: a very large number of people treat the second story as an answer to the first. Not as extra information. As a *reply*. As though somebody had asked a question and this settled it.

Nobody organised this. There was no meeting. Thousands of people who have never spoken to each other performed the same move within a day or two of one another, and almost all of them experienced it as obvious. That is what I want you to hold on to. Not that it was wrong — we will get to that — but that it felt like nothing. It felt like a reply.

1.2 — The manoeuvre, named

Let us be precise about what the move actually is, because naming it correctly matters more than condemning it.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Ad hominem:** Latin, meaning "to the person". It describes any move that responds to an argument by talking about the person who made it rather than the argument itself.
>
> Why it matters here: the phrase is often used as though naming it wins the fight. It does not. As Chapter One will show, going after the person is sometimes legitimate and sometimes not, and the difference is not a matter of manners. It depends entirely on whether the claim under discussion can be checked without trusting the speaker.

There is a second word worth having, because it describes something slightly different and more specific.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Genetic fallacy:** judging a claim by where it came from rather than by whether it is true. "That idea came from a bad person, so it is a bad idea." The word has nothing to do with genes. It comes from the Greek for origin.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the exact shape of the whole conservative argument this series has to deal with, only pointed the other way. "This rule came from a wise tradition, therefore it is a good rule" is the same move as "this claim came from an immoral woman, therefore it is a false claim." Both judge a thing by its parentage. We will meet this again in Chapter Three and it will be much less comfortable there.

So the manoeuvre in full: a claim was made about how the police behaved at a protest. That claim is a matter of public record. There is footage. There are witnesses. There are, in most such cases, official statements. Whether the police acted lawfully can be established without knowing a single thing about the woman in the photograph.

The rumour does not address the claim. It cannot address the claim. It changes the subject from the conduct of an institution to the conduct of a woman, and it does this so smoothly that most participants did not notice a subject had been changed at all.

1.3 — Why I am not going to look

I could try to find out whether the rumour is true. I have decided not to, and the reason is not delicacy. It is method, and it is worth setting out plainly because it applies to the whole series.

She is a private person. She did not stand for office. She did not publish a book. She stood in a street and somebody pointed a camera. Nothing about that act makes her life a public archive, and a series that begins by rummaging through it would be performing the exact behaviour it claims to be studying. You cannot dissect a specimen by becoming one.

There is a second reason, and it is the stronger one. **The truth of the rumour does not matter to any question this series asks.** Consider both outcomes.

Suppose it is false. Then a woman was defamed for standing in a street, and we learn that the accusation is available as a weapon whether or not it is earned. That is a fact about the weapon, not about her.

Suppose it is true. Then a woman who sells images of her body also went to a protest, and the question becomes why one of those facts is supposed to cancel the other. That is a fact about the rule, not about her.

Either way, the interesting object is the same. She is the occasion for this series, not its subject. From here on she does not appear again as a person. She appears as a shape — the shape of what happens when a claim about a woman's body is offered as a reply to a claim about power.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> It is worth understanding the scale of what a rumour like this does, because "it spread online" hides the size of the thing.
>
> A moderately viral post in India reaches a few million people. Take three million as a working figure. If you tried to tell three million people something in person, at one person per minute, working eight hours a day without a single day off, it would take you a little over seventeen years.
>
> Now consider the correction. Corrections travel to a small fraction of the audience of the original — studies of misinformation consistently find the follow-up reaching a much smaller group than the claim. So the practical effect is close to permanent. Seventeen years of speaking, delivered in an afternoon, and no realistic way to take it back.

1.4 — Everybody uses this move

Here is where I have to be careful, because it would be easy to write this chapter as though only one political side does this. That would be false and you should not trust a series that pretends otherwise.

The move is universal. It has no politics. It has a shape, and any group with a grievance will reach for the shape.

A conservative commentator is found to have had an affair, and his arguments about family are treated as thereby refuted. A feminist writer turns out to employ domestic staff on poor wages, and her arguments about exploitation are treated as thereby refuted. A climate scientist takes a flight. A vegetarian is photographed eating fish. A politician who campaigned on austerity is found to have an expensive watch. In every case the same operation runs: locate a gap between the person and their position, then treat the gap as an answer to the position.

Sometimes it genuinely is an answer. If a man argues that his diet is easy to follow and he is secretly not following it, his failure is evidence about the diet. The claim was partly about him.

Usually it is not. Whether the police acted lawfully on a particular afternoon is not partly about the woman standing in front of the vehicle. There is no version of the question where her private conduct is an input.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everyone in this fight — the people making the accusation and the people rejecting it — is assuming that the audience was ever weighing an argument.

The defence says: her private life is irrelevant to whether the police acted lawfully. True. But it assumes the crowd was in the business of evaluating police conduct and has now been distracted from that task.

Look at the behaviour instead of the words and a different picture appears. Most people did not examine the police claim before the rumour arrived, and did not examine it after. What they were doing, before and after, was deciding which side to be on. The rumour did not distract them from an evaluation. It gave them a reason to feel good about a decision they had already made.

The general form: **treating persuasion as the thing that happened, when the thing that happened was permission.** Most public argument is not people changing their minds. It is people acquiring licence for a position they already held. Once you see it, a great deal of what looks like debate in the coming fifteen parts stops looking like debate.

1.5 — What the move is actually for

If the manoeuvre does not work as reasoning, why does it work at all? It clearly works. That is not in question.

It works because it does a different job from the one it appears to do. It appears to be an argument. It functions as a *cost*.

Think of what the woman in the photograph now faces, irrespective of whether the rumour is true. Her name is attached to a claim she cannot disprove. Employers will search for her. So will future landlords, future in-laws, and every person she meets for the rest of her life who has a phone. She did not lose an argument. She acquired a permanent expense.

And every woman watching learned the price of standing in the street. That is the actual output. Not persuasion — pricing. The accusation is a bill sent to one person and a price list published to everybody else.

Hold that idea, because it returns in Chapter Five in a much more uncomfortable form. When somebody warns a woman that she will ruin her life, we are going to have to ask whether that is a forecast or an invoice.

REMEMBER THIS

A woman was photographed at a protest. Days later a rumour about her body was offered as a **reply** to a claim about police conduct. Thousands of people performed this move simultaneously and experienced it as obvious.

Going after the person instead of the claim is legitimate only when the claim cannot be checked without trusting the person. Police conduct at a protest can be checked. So the move was not reasoning.

The move belongs to no political side. Every group reaches for it. Anyone who tells you only their opponents do this is selling something.

I will not investigate the woman, because the truth of the rumour changes nothing. If false, we learn about the weapon. If true, we learn about the rule. Either way she is the occasion, not the subject.

The accusation was not an argument that failed. It was a price, charged to her and published to every woman watching.

CHAPTER TWO

Three Claims Wearing One Coat

"These rules exist for a reason, and if you break them there will be consequences, so behave yourself." That is one sentence. It is three separate claims, and they can be true and false in any combination.

2.1 — One sentence, three jobs

When somebody defends the rules about women, they almost never make one claim. They make three, joined so smoothly that the joins are invisible. Pulling them apart is the single most useful thing in this document, and everything in the remaining fourteen parts depends on it.

Here is the sentence in its most common form:

> *These things have been going on since old times for a reason. If you go changing them it will be a blunder. So a girl should not behave like that.*

Now here are the three claims inside it.

Claim one is about the past. These rules came from somewhere. They had a function. They solved a problem that a society actually had.

Claim two is about the future. If the rules go, something bad follows. Damage. Disorder. Collapse. The "blunder".

Claim three is about you. Therefore a particular woman, today, should behave in a particular way.

These are not three versions of one idea. They are three different kinds of statement, and each requires a completely different kind of evidence.

Claim one is a historical and anthropological question. It is answered by looking at what societies actually did and why, and by comparing societies that did it differently. That is Parts Two and Three.

Claim two is a prediction. It is answered only by looking at what has happened in places where the rules already changed. Not by reasoning about what ought to happen. By counting what did. That is Part Thirteen, and it is the part I expect to annoy the most people.

Claim three is a moral claim about what a specific person owes. Nothing in claims one or two produces it by itself, and Chapter Four explains exactly why not.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Underneath the welded sentence sits a premise that neither side ever states: **that a rule and its justification are the same object.**
>
> Watch what happens in a normal argument. The traditionalist defends the rule by explaining where it came from. The reformer attacks the rule by attacking the explanation — "that is not even where it came from, that is a myth." Both behave as though disproving the story disposes of the rule, or as though establishing the story secures it.
>
> But rules and their stories are separate things, and they come apart constantly. A rule can be excellent and its official story completely invented. A rule can be terrible and its story entirely accurate. Most surviving rules have picked up justifications long after the fact, from whoever needed one — which means the story you are given is usually evidence about the present rather than the past.
>
> The general form: **attacking the deed by attacking the receipt.** You will see this in nearly every argument in this series, on both sides, and once you notice it you cannot stop noticing it.

2.2 — The claim about the past

Claim one — "it exists for a reason" — is the one that sounds most modest and is most often waved through. It should not be.

It contains a hidden strength and a hidden weakness. The strength: it is often true. Rules about women are not random. They cluster around a small number of recurring problems — who inherits, who is responsible for a child, which families may marry which, how a group holds its boundary. Those are real problems and they were solved somehow. Part Two shows the machinery.

The weakness: “it exists for a reason” does not specify *whose* reason. And that omission is not a small gap. It is the whole argument.

Consider a rule that says the eldest son inherits all the land and his brothers get nothing. That rule existed for a reason, and the reason was excellent: it stopped farms being divided into strips too small to feed anybody. It genuinely solved a genuine problem.

Ask the younger brothers whether it worked and you get a different answer. It worked for the estate. It worked for the family as an accounting unit. It worked for the eldest son, spectacularly. It did not work for the second son, who left for the army or the church or the sea, and it is not obvious that his interests are less real than the estate’s.

So “it worked” and “it worked for her” are separate findings, and the first is regularly used as though it establishes the second. Hold that thought for Chapter Three, where it becomes the central problem.

2.3 — The claim about the future

Claim two — “if you change it, there will be a blunder” — is the only one of the three that can be settled by evidence, and it is the one people are least interested in checking.

Notice what kind of statement it is. It is a prediction. It says that if a society removes a rule, specific bad things follow. That is exactly the sort of claim that can be tested, because the experiment has already been run, repeatedly, by real countries, at full scale, within living memory.

Sweden ran it. So did Japan, South Korea, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United States and Ireland, each in a different direction and at a different speed. We have decades of data on marriage, birth rates, violence, employment, disease and reported happiness from every one of them.

This is a gift and almost nobody accepts it. The people most convinced of the coming blunder are usually least able to name what the blunder consists of, or which country has already suffered it, or what number would show it had happened.

So I am going to insist on a discipline throughout this series, and I will apply it to both sides equally.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The rule I will hold myself to: a prediction that cannot say what would count as it being wrong is not a prediction. It is a mood.

“Society will decay” is a mood. It names no measurement. Any outcome can be fitted to it afterwards, which means no outcome can test it.

“Divorce rates will rise, births will fall below replacement, and reported loneliness will increase” is a prediction. Each part is countable. Each can fail.

Here is why this matters more than it looks: when you convert the mood into a prediction and then go and check, some of it comes back *true*. Birth rates really did collapse in the countries that changed fastest. That finding survives the test, and I am not going to hide it because it is inconvenient. Part Nine is built on it.

What the method cannot do: tell you whether a fall in births is a catastrophe or a preference. Counting settles what happened. It does not settle what it is worth.

2.4 — The claim about you

Claim three is the one that actually does the work in a real conversation, and it is smuggled in behind the other two.

Suppose claims one and two are both entirely true. The rules did solve a real problem, and removing them does produce measurable damage. Does it follow that a particular woman today should not wear what she likes, or sleep with whom she likes?

Not by itself, and the gap is not a technicality. There are at least four separate steps still missing, and each of them is contestable.

You would need to show that the damage is large enough to outweigh what the rule costs the person carrying it. A rule that prevents a small harm at the price of a large one is a bad rule even when the small harm is real.

You would need to show that this individual’s compliance actually affects the outcome. One woman’s clothing does not move a national birth rate. Rules that only work in aggregate impose a real cost on each person for a benefit no person produces.

You would need to show that no cheaper solution exists. If the problem was uncertain fatherhood, we now have paternity testing. If the problem was disease, we have antibiotics and contraception. If the problem was destitution after abandonment, we have wage labour and, in some places, a welfare system. A rule justified by a problem that has since been solved another way is a fence around an empty field.

And you would need to show why the cost falls on her rather than on him. Every one of these problems has two participants. The rules are overwhelmingly written for one of them. Part Eleven is about that asymmetry and it does not have a comfortable answer.

2.5 — Eight combinations, and where real arguments live

Because the three claims are independent, they can take any combination of true and false. Three claims, two values each, gives eight possible positions. Most real arguments are two people occupying different boxes and thinking they are in the same one.

PAST	FUTURE	OBLIGATION	WHAT THIS POSITION LOOKS LIKE IN THE WILD
True	True	True	The full traditionalist case. Rare in this pure form, because it requires the fourth step in §2.4 to be argued rather than assumed.
True	True	False	The most defensible conservative position, and the most interesting. Yes it had a function, yes removing it has costs, and no, that does not give anyone authority over this woman.
True	False	False	The standard modernising view. It made sense once, the problem has been solved another way, the fence can come down.
False	True	False	Unusual and worth taking seriously. The origin story is a myth, but the rule is now load-bearing anyway because a society has been built on top of it.
False	False	False	The strong reformist case. Invented past, imagined blunder, no obligation.
False	True	True	Honest authoritarianism. It does not matter where it came from; the consequences of dropping it are severe enough to justify compulsion.

PAST	FUTURE	OBLIGATION	WHAT THIS POSITION LOOKS LIKE IN THE WILD
True	False	True	Incoherent as stated, but common in practice — usually a person defending a rule on the basis of continuity alone.
False	False	True	Naked assertion of authority. Rare to hear out loud, not rare to meet.

Look at the second row. That is the position I think is hardest to beat, and almost nobody argues for it, because it is unsatisfying to both camps. It concedes everything the reformer wants about authority and everything the traditionalist wants about consequences.

2.6 — Running the tool on a real sentence

Take a sentence you have certainly heard, in one form or another.

> *Girls who go around with many boys never end up happy. Ask any elder. They have seen it.*

Separate the three claims and the sentence stops being a wall.

Past: there is a long-standing norm against it, and there was a reason. Very likely true. Part Two gives the reason and it is not mysterious.

Future: such women end up unhappy. This is a measurable claim. There is real research on it, some of which supports the claim more than reformers expect. Part Ten reports it honestly, including the parts I would rather not report.

Obligation: therefore you should not. Does not follow, even if both the others hold, until the four missing steps are argued.

And now the question that Chapter Five is built on, which the elder's sentence conceals completely. *Unhappy because of what?* If the unhappiness comes from the act, that is a fact about the act. If it comes from what the village does to her afterwards, that is a fact about the village — and the elder saying the sentence is one of the villagers.

REMEMBER THIS

The standard defence of the rules about women is one sentence containing three claims: **about the past** (it had a function), **about the future** (changing it causes damage), and **about you** (therefore obey).

Each needs a different kind of evidence. History for the first, measurement for the second, moral argument for the third. They can be true and false in any combination — eight positions in all.

“It exists for a reason” never says **whose** reason. A rule can work perfectly for a family, an estate or a caste while working badly for the person carrying it.

Getting from “changing it causes damage” to “so you must obey” needs four further steps: that the damage outweighs the cost of the rule, that this individual’s compliance matters, that no cheaper solution now exists, and that the burden belongs on her rather than on him.

Almost every argument you have ever had about this was two people arguing about different claims while using the same sentence.

CHAPTER THREE

"It Exists For A Reason"

The strongest argument for leaving old rules alone is about a hundred years old and takes the form of a fence in a field. It is a good argument. It is also missing one word, and the missing word changes everything.

3.1 — The fence in the field

Imagine you are walking across a field and you come to a fence. It runs across open ground. There is no gate, no animal, no crop, nothing on either side that the fence appears to be separating. It seems pointless.

A companion says: this is useless, let us pull it down.

The English writer G. K. Chesterton put the reply in an essay in 1929, and the reply has outlived almost everything else he wrote. He said the correct answer is not "leave it alone" and not "pull it down". It is: *go away and find out why it was put there.* Come back when you know. If you then still think it should go, take it down. But the person who cannot say why the fence exists has not earned the right to remove it, because their confidence is built on their own ignorance.

WORD BOX

Chesterton's Fence: the principle that you should not remove something whose purpose you do not understand, until you understand it. Named after the writer who described it. It is not a rule against change. It is a rule against a specific kind of confidence — the kind that mistakes "I cannot see why this is here" for "there is no reason this is here."

Why it matters here: this is the strongest form of the argument your elders are making, whether or not they have heard of Chesterton. Any honest treatment of the rules about women has to answer it rather than sneer at it.

Notice how good this is. It does not claim old things are wise. It makes a claim about the person doing the removing — that they are likely to be missing information, that a rule's function is often invisible to somebody who has only ever lived downstream of it, and that the cost of the missing information falls on people who had no vote.

Applied here, it goes: you think a rule about how women dress is arbitrary. But you were born after it was already working. You have never seen the problem it prevents, precisely because it prevents it. Your sense that nothing bad would happen is not evidence. It is the expected experience of somebody standing behind a wall.

That is a serious argument. I want it on the table at full strength before I take it apart, because a series that dismisses it has nothing to say to anyone who does not already agree.

3.2 — What the fence argument gets right

Three things, and all three are real.

Invisible success looks like pointlessness. This is genuinely how prevention works. A vaccine that works produces no disease to see, and then people conclude the vaccine is unnecessary. A dam that holds produces no flood, and the town below it forgets what the river does. Any successful protective institution eventually looks like an unexplained fence, and the more successful it is, the more pointless it looks.

Rules encode knowledge nobody has written down. A community can carry a solution for centuries without any individual member being able to explain it. The practice survives; the explanation is lost or was never explicit. If you demand the explanation before you allow the practice, you will destroy working things at a considerable rate.

The people who remove rules rarely pay for removing them. Reform is generally designed by people with resources and absorbed by people without. If a change goes wrong, the person who wrote the article is fine. That asymmetry is real and it is a good reason for caution.

3.3 — The missing word

Now the problem. Chesterton's fence tells you to find out why the fence is there. It quietly assumes there is a *why* — one purpose, held by the field.

Fields do not have purposes. People do. And when you actually go and find out why a fence was built, you almost never discover a purpose. You discover a *beneficiary*.

The honest version of the question is therefore not “why is this fence here?” It is: **who put this fence here, what did they get, and who was on the wrong side of it?**

Once you ask it that way, the whole argument changes shape. Because “this rule has survived four thousand years” is now a much weaker statement than it sounded. Survival tells you a rule served somebody’s interest reliably enough that they kept enforcing it. It says nothing whatever about whether it served the interest of the person it constrained.

In fact, think about the selection pressure. A rule that is enforced by the powerful on the powerless has an obvious survival advantage over a rule that runs the other way, entirely independent of whether it is any good. Longevity is evidence of enforcement, not of benefit. Those are different findings and they are being confused constantly.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Both the traditionalist and the reformer accept, without ever discussing it, that **a custom which survived must have served the person it constrained.**
>
> The traditionalist uses it directly: it lasted, so it works, so it works for her. The reformer accepts the same premise but denies the antecedent: it does not work for her, so it must never have worked at all, so it was pure oppression from the start.
>
> Both are wrong in the same way. A rule can work superbly — solve a real coordination problem, hold a lineage together, prevent a genuine harm — and be paid for entirely by one group. Those are not alternatives. That is the normal case.
>
> The general form: **reading a system’s survival as evidence about everybody inside it.** A machine that runs well tells you it is well engineered. It tells you nothing about what it is made of, or who is inside it.
>
> This single confusion is responsible for more bad argument in this field than any other, and both camps depend on it. Neither can afford to look at it.

3.4 — Four fences that came down

The fence argument is best tested against fences that were actually removed. Here are four, chosen because in each case the defenders made exactly the argument we are examining, and in each case we now know what happened.

Foot-binding in China. For roughly a thousand years, girls' feet were broken and bound to keep them small. It was defended as beauty, as decency, and as the mark of a family that could afford not to have its daughters work. Every defence available today was made then, including the argument that unbound daughters would be unmarriageable — which was *true*, and is the most important thing about it.

It ended fast. The mechanism is worth knowing because it is the most instructive thing in this chapter. Reformers did not primarily argue that binding was cruel; everyone knew it was cruel. They formed pledge societies in which families swore two things together: not to bind their daughters' feet, and not to let their sons marry bound-foot women. Once enough families signed, the marriage penalty inverted. Then it collapsed, in decades, after a thousand years.

Read that again, because it tells you what kind of object we are dealing with. The rule was not held up by belief. It was held up by *every family's correct prediction about every other family*. Nobody had to be persuaded that binding was good. They only had to believe that others would punish them for stopping. Change the expectation and the fence falls over on its own.

Sati in India. Widow-burning was defended as scripture, as tradition, as a woman's own devotion. It was outlawed in 1829, after campaigning by Indians and foreigners together, and the strongest arguments against abolition were about the danger of outsiders touching a people's customs. That argument was not silly. Colonial interference in Indian practice was frequently self-serving and often catastrophic. It was also, in this instance, on the wrong side.

Duelling. Men killed each other over insults for centuries. The practice was defended as the foundation of honour and the only guarantee of civil speech among gentlemen. That last defence contained something true: without duels, what stops men insulting each other? The answer turned out to be that nothing much stops them, and this is fine, and the cost of the insults is enormously lower than the cost of the corpses.

Primogeniture. All land to the eldest son. Defended as the only way to stop estates being cut into unviable slivers. Genuinely solved that problem. It was dismantled across much of the world and the predicted agricultural collapse did not arrive, because other instruments — mortgages, partnerships, land consolidation, wage labour — did the same work without disinheriting four children out of five.

3.5 — And one that came down badly

I would be cheating if I only listed fences whose removal went well. Here is one that did not, because the lesson from it is the most useful thing in the chapter.

Through the middle of the twentieth century, Britain and the United States held large numbers of mentally ill people in institutions. Conditions in many were genuinely appalling, the criticism was justified, and from the 1960s onward the institutions were closed on a large scale.

The replacement — community-based care, funded and staffed — was promised and, in large part, never built. The result was not liberation. In both countries a substantial share of severely mentally ill people ended up homeless or in prison. Prisons became, by default, the largest mental health institutions in both nations.

Now notice precisely what went wrong, because it is not what a traditionalist would predict. The old institutions were not vindicated. Nobody looking at the outcome concluded that the asylums had been good. What went wrong was that the fence was removed and the thing that was supposed to replace it was never constructed.

That is the real lesson, and it applies directly to everything in the remaining parts of this series. **The dangerous move is not removing a rule. It is removing a rule while leaving in place the conditions that made the rule necessary.**

Hold on to that sentence. In Part Thirteen we will find that the countries which suffered most from changing the rules about women were not the ones that changed them hardest. They were the ones that changed half.

> **THE ARGUMENT — IS "IT HAS LASTED A LONG TIME" EVIDENCE THAT A RULE IS GOOD?**
>
> This is the disagreement underneath every conversation in this series, and both sides have more than they are usually given credit for.
>
> **YES — THE CASE FROM FILTERING**
>
> Customs are not designed, they accumulate. Practices that damaged the groups holding them tended to disappear along with those groups. What survives has therefore been filtered by a long and brutal process, and it carries information that no individual possesses. A person reasoning from first principles in one lifetime is competing against a filter that ran for millennia. Betting against it requires better evidence than a strong feeling.

NO — THE CASE FROM SELECTION

The filter selects for what keeps a practice being enforced, which is not the same as what makes people's lives go well. A rule imposed by a powerful group on a weak one survives because the powerful group keeps imposing it. That is a fact about power, not about benefit. Foot-binding survived a thousand years and broke children's feet the entire time. Longevity measures durability, and durability is exactly what you would expect from a rule the beneficiaries control.

THE MIDDLE POSITION

Longevity is weak evidence that a rule solved *something*, and no evidence at all about who it solved it for, or whether the problem still exists. It sets a duty to investigate, not a duty to obey. It also raises the standard of proof for removal without making removal illegitimate.

Where things stand: the middle position is where the honest argument actually is, and it is much closer to the traditionalist than reformers like. It concedes that the burden falls on whoever wants change, and that the burden is real work rather than a slogan. What it denies is that the burden can never be discharged.

What would settle it: in any particular case, an answer to three questions — what problem did this solve, does the problem still exist, and is there now a cheaper instrument? Every one of those is answerable for most of the rules in this series, which is why we are spending fifteen more parts answering them rather than debating in the abstract.

Why people care so much: because the abstract version of this argument is unwinnable, and an unwinnable argument is extremely useful. It lets a person defend any specific rule without ever defending that rule.

REMEMBER THIS

Chesterton's Fence says do not remove something whose purpose you do not understand. It is a serious argument and three parts of it are true: successful prevention looks like pointlessness, rules carry knowledge nobody wrote down, and reformers rarely pay for their own mistakes.

Its flaw is one missing word. It tells you to ask **why** the fence is there. The honest question is **who** — who built it, what did they get, and who was on the wrong side.

A rule surviving a long time proves it kept being **enforced**. That is evidence about power, not about benefit. Both camps confuse these constantly.

Foot-binding lasted a thousand years and fell in decades, once families stopped believing other families would punish them. The rule was held up by **expectations about other people**, not by belief in the rule. Remember that. It is the most important mechanism in this series.

The genuine danger is not pulling down a fence. It is pulling down a fence and never building what was supposed to replace it.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Jump From Is To Ought

Suppose we establish exactly where the rules came from and exactly what they do. There is still a gap between that and what anybody should do. Both sides of this fight jump the gap, in opposite directions, and both think only their opponents do it.

4.1 — The gap

In 1739 a Scottish philosopher named David Hume noticed something about the way moral arguments are written. Authors would spend pages describing how the world *is* — what people do, what nature does, what God is said to have done — and then, without warning, the sentences would quietly change. Instead of saying what *is*, they would start saying what *ought* to be.

Hume's point was not that the conclusion was wrong. It was that a new kind of claim had appeared without anybody explaining where it came from. A description had turned into an instruction and no step had been shown.

WORD BOX

The is/ought gap: the observation that no collection of facts about how the world is, by itself, produces a conclusion about what anybody should do. Getting from one to the other always needs at least one extra ingredient — a value, a goal, or a standard — and that ingredient has to be argued for separately.

Why it matters here: nearly every argument in this series will present facts and then act as though an instruction has been proved. It has not. Watch for the moment the sentences switch, and ask what was added.

Here is the gap in ordinary form. “Most societies have restricted women's clothing.” That is a fact, and as it happens a true one. It contains no instruction. To get to “therefore women should dress modestly”, you need something extra — perhaps “we should do what most societies do.” But *that* is not a fact. It is a value, and a very strange one, since most societies also kept slaves.

The extra ingredient is always there. The dishonesty is never in having one. It is in hiding it.

4.2 — Nature as an argument

The most common version in this field runs through the word *natural*.

It goes: this arrangement is natural, therefore it is right. Women are naturally more nurturing, so they should raise the children. Men are naturally more aggressive, so they should lead. Monogamy is natural, or polygamy is natural, depending on who is speaking.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Appeal to nature:** arguing that because something is natural it is good, or because something is unnatural it is bad.
>
> A related term you will meet is the **naturalistic fallacy**, coined by the philosopher G. E. Moore in 1903. Strictly it means something narrower — the error of defining goodness as some natural property. In everyday use the two have merged, and I will use the plainer phrase.
>
> Why it matters here: this is the single most common move in arguments about men and women, and it is made with total confidence by people who would instantly reject it in any other setting.

The problem is not that the factual claims are always false. Some are true, and Part Four goes through them with actual numbers. The problem is that *natural* does no moral work whatsoever, and everyone knows this in every other context.

Cholera is natural. Childbirth killed a large share of women for most of human history and that was entirely natural. Tooth decay is natural. Dying at thirty-five is natural. Every one of us spends every day fighting nature with soap, spectacles, antibiotics and roofs, and nobody thinks this needs defending.

Meanwhile a great deal we consider obligatory is deeply unnatural. Universal literacy. Refusing to hit a child. Anaesthetic. Not killing your rival. The entire apparatus of law exists precisely because the natural outcome was judged unacceptable.

So when somebody says an arrangement between men and women is natural and therefore correct, they are using a standard they apply nowhere else in their life. The word is not carrying an argument. It is carrying a feeling of inevitability, which is a different thing wearing the same coat.

There is a stronger version of the argument, and it deserves a hearing because it is not silly.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES IT MATTER WHETHER A DIFFERENCE IS “NATURAL”?

The crude appeal to nature fails. But something in the neighbourhood might survive, and dismissing the whole area is its own kind of laziness.

IT MATTERS, BECAUSE IT TELLS YOU THE PRICE

Nothing about a difference being natural makes it good. But it does tell you what changing it will cost. A society trying to produce an outcome that runs against a strong natural tendency will need continuous force to hold it there, and will fail the moment the force is withdrawn. That is not a moral argument. It is an engineering one, and ignoring it wastes enormous quantities of effort and human happiness.

IT DOES NOT MATTER, BECAUSE “NATURAL” IS UNMEASURABLE HERE

Every human trait develops in an environment. There is no version of a person raised outside a society, so there is no baseline to measure against. What gets called natural is almost always just what is common, and what is common is largely produced by the arrangements under examination. The word smuggles in the conclusion it is supposed to prove.

THE EMPIRICAL MIDDLE

Naturalness is not binary and it is not unmeasurable either. Traits vary in how much effort it takes to shift them, and that is a real number that can be estimated — through twin studies, cross-cultural comparison, and natural experiments where societies changed policy sharply. Some differences shrink to almost nothing when conditions change. Others barely move. Both findings exist, and lumping them together is the actual error.

> **Where things stand:** the middle position is correct and is also the least popular, because it hands each camp a defeat. Some differences everybody assumes are fixed turn out to be highly movable. Some everybody assumes are cultural turn out to be extremely stubborn. Which is which is an empirical question with real answers, and Parts Four and Five are entirely about those answers.
>
> **What would settle it:** for any given difference — effect sizes across many societies, what happens to the gap when conditions change sharply, and whether it moves in the direction the cultural explanation predicts. This work has been done for a lot of traits. The results are not what either side expects.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because both camps have accepted a bad bargain — the belief that if a difference is natural, inequality is justified. Both then fight over the facts to protect the moral conclusion. The bargain is what should be rejected. The facts are just facts.

4.3 — The same error, running the other way

Now the part I am obliged to write, having promised that this series would cut in both directions.

There is a mirror-image mistake and it is just as common. It goes: this fact would have unpleasant implications, therefore this fact is false.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Moralistic fallacy:** concluding that something cannot be true because its being true would be morally inconvenient. The reverse of the appeal to nature. If the first says *is* proves *ought*, the second says *ought* proves *is*.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the characteristic error of the progressive side of this argument, and it is not a minor one. It has led to real findings being ignored, real researchers being attacked for reporting them, and real policies being built on claims that were never true.

You can hear it in sentences like these. Men and women cannot differ in any average trait, because admitting a difference would justify discrimination. Traditional societies cannot have offered women anything, because saying so would excuse them. Research showing a cost to some behaviour must be biased, because reporting it would help the wrong people.

Every one of these reasons from the conclusion backwards. And they share a structure with the appeal to nature that is worth seeing clearly: **both accept that facts about difference automatically produce conclusions about worth.** The traditionalist accepts it and embraces the facts. The progressive accepts it and denies the facts. Neither one questions the bargain.

Reject the bargain and both problems evaporate. Men and women can differ substantially in some measurable trait, and it can still be true that no person's rights depend on where they sit in a distribution. Those two sentences are entirely compatible. Holding both is not a compromise. It is just accurate.

4.4 — Why this matters for what comes next

I am setting this out now because of what is in Parts Four, Five, Ten and Nine, and I would rather warn you than surprise you.

Part Four reports physical and psychological differences between men and women with their actual sizes. Some are enormous. That will read, to some people, as though I am building a case against equality. I am not, and Chapter Four is my defence in advance: a fact about averages produces no conclusion about anybody's rights without an extra ingredient that has to be argued separately.

Part Ten reports evidence about sexual behaviour and later outcomes, including findings that support the traditional warning more than reformers expect. That will read to others as though I am building a case for control. I am not, and the defence is the same sentence.

Part Nine reports what is happening to birth rates and it is genuinely alarming. That will read as though I am joining a panic. The defence is again the same. A number tells you what happened. It does not tell you what to do, and anybody who says otherwise has added an ingredient without showing you the label.

So here is the discipline I am adopting, stated plainly so you can hold me to it. **Where I report a fact, I will report it at full strength regardless of who it helps. Where I draw a conclusion about what anybody ought to do, I will show the extra ingredient and name it as a value rather than a finding.** If you catch me skipping that step, I have broken my own rule and I want to know.

REMEMBER THIS

No pile of facts produces an instruction by itself. Getting from **is** to **ought** always requires an extra ingredient — a value or a goal — and honest argument shows that ingredient rather than hiding it.

Natural does no moral work. Cholera is natural; literacy is not. Everybody already knows this and applies it everywhere except here.

Naturalness does tell you something useful but different: **the price of change**. Some differences shrink easily when conditions change. Others barely move. Which is which is a measurable question, not a matter of opinion.

The mirror error — **the moralistic fallacy** — says a fact must be false because it would be inconvenient. It is just as common and just as wrong, and it is the characteristic mistake of the other camp.

Both errors share one bad bargain: that facts about difference decide questions of worth. Refuse the bargain and both collapse. A difference in averages settles nothing about what anyone is owed.

CHAPTER FIVE

When A Warning Is Really A Threat

"She will ruin her own life." It sounds like a forecast made by somebody who has seen it happen. Sometimes it is. Sometimes the speaker is part of the machinery that does the ruining, and the sentence is not a forecast at all.

5.1 — The sentence

You have heard this sentence, or one very like it. An older relative says it. Sometimes a philosopher says it in longer words. Sometimes a woman says it about another woman, which is the version people find hardest to explain.

> *A girl who behaves like that destroys her own life. She kills her own happiness. She will understand when it is too late.*

The sentence arrives dressed as kindness and experience. It says: I have watched this happen. I am telling you what I saw. I am trying to spare you.

And here is the thing that makes it so hard to answer — it is frequently accurate. Women who break these rules in India often do end up worse off by almost any measure you choose. Reduced marriage prospects. Family estrangement. Damaged employment. Sometimes violence. Sometimes death. The elder is not lying about the outcome.

So the reformer's usual reply — that the elder is a bigot inventing consequences — is simply false, and everybody in the room knows it is false, which is why the reply never works. The consequences are real. Anyone arguing here has to start by conceding that.

The interesting question is not whether the prediction comes true. It is *what makes it come true*.

5.2 — Two sentences that sound identical

Compare these.

> *If you jump from that roof, you will break your legs.*

> *If you marry outside the caste, this family will destroy you.*

Both have the form of a warning. Both may be entirely accurate. But they are completely different kinds of object, and the difference sits in one place: **what the speaker's own role is in the outcome.**

The first speaker has no role. Gravity does the work. If she leaves the room, if she dies, if she changes her mind entirely, the legs still break. The prediction is about the world.

The second speaker *is* the mechanism. The destruction is not something that will happen to the listener. It is something the speaker and people like the speaker will do. Remove them and the outcome changes.

Both sentences describe true futures. One is a forecast. The other is a sentence in the legal meaning of that word — a punishment announced in advance by somebody who will help carry it out.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Self-fulfilling prophecy:** a prediction that causes the thing it predicts. Named by the sociologist Robert Merton in 1948. His original example was a bank rumoured to be failing. The rumour is false, but people withdraw their money because of it, and the bank then fails. The prediction was wrong when made and true when finished.
>
> Why it matters here: it means "it came true" is not proof that a warning was knowledge. A prophecy that builds its own outcome will always look, afterwards, exactly like wisdom.

This is the crucial point and it is worth stating as flatly as possible. **A rule that punishes people for breaking it will always produce evidence that breaking it is harmful.** The evidence is manufactured by the punishment. And that evidence is then offered as the justification for the punishment, which completes a circle that can run forever without ever touching the outside world.

5.3 — Why this is not an accusation

I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to read the last section as saying that elders are liars, or that they are consciously threatening people. That is not what I am saying and it would be both unfair and wrong.

Nearly everyone saying this sentence means it kindly. The aunt who warns her niece is not plotting. She has watched women's lives go badly and she is trying to prevent a repetition. Her motive is protective and her observation is real.

The problem is structural, not moral. She has watched the outcome many times. She has never once watched the counterfactual — the same woman making the same choice in a society that did not punish it. Nobody has shown her that comparison, so she attributes the damage to the choice, which is the only part she can see.

She is doing what any of us would do with the data available. She is also, without intending to, one of the hands that produces the pattern she is describing. Both things are true simultaneously and neither cancels the other.

5.4 — A test that actually works

So how do you tell them apart? If a warning is accurate either way, and the speaker is sincere either way, what distinguishes a genuine hazard from a manufactured one?

There is a test, and it is simple enough to state in one line. It is my own formulation rather than a technical term you will find elsewhere, so treat it as a tool rather than an authority.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The test: does the harm travel?

Take the same behaviour and look for it somewhere the punishing community has no power. A different country. A different class. A city where nobody knows the family. If the harm still appears, something in the act itself is producing it. If the harm disappears, the harm was the punishment.

What this can show: it separates hazards that follow a person across a border from hazards that stop at the edge of a community's reach. That is a genuine and testable distinction, and the data to run it exists — the same behaviours have been studied across dozens of societies with wildly different enforcement.

What it cannot show: it is not clean. The women who leave are not a random sample of the women who stay, so differences between them are partly differences in who moves. And no society has zero enforcement, so we are comparing more against less, never presence against absence. This is the central difficulty of Parts Ten to Thirteen and I will flag it every time it applies.

Run the test on the roof and it passes instantly. Broken legs are the same in Delhi and Stockholm. Gravity does not check your passport.

Run it on the caste marriage and it fails just as fast. The destruction is administered by named people with a known address. Move beyond their reach and it does not follow.

Most real cases sit in between, and the middle is where the actual work is. Take the claim that a woman with many partners will be unhappy later. Some of the mechanisms proposed for this — regret, difficulty forming attachment, effects on later relationships — would travel. If they are real, they show up in Denmark. Others — being unmarriageable, family rejection, reputational collapse — clearly do not travel. They are local, and they stop at the boundary of the enforcing group.

So the sentence "she will be unhappy" is not one claim. It is a bundle, and the bundle can be taken apart by asking which pieces cross a border. That is precisely what Parts Ten, Eleven and Thirteen do, and it is why they are separate parts.

THE ARGUMENT — IS "YOU WILL RUIN YOUR LIFE" A PREDICTION OR A PUNISHMENT?

This is the fight underneath the whole series, and it is usually conducted with both sides talking past each other.

IT IS A PREDICTION, AND A KIND ONE

The elder has data the young person does not. She has watched forty years of outcomes and she is reporting a pattern she genuinely observed. Calling that a threat is an insult to somebody trying to help, and it also happens to be a convenient way of avoiding an unwelcome empirical claim. The pattern exists. Denying it does not make the young woman safer; it just leaves her uninformed.

IT IS A PUNISHMENT ANNOUNCED IN ADVANCE

The harm is overwhelmingly administered by the community issuing the warning. Take away the family that stops speaking to her, the marriage market that prices her out, the employer who reads the rumour, and most of the predicted damage vanishes. The speaker is describing what she and her neighbours will do, in the grammar of weather. That grammar is doing enormous work: it converts a choice into a natural fact.

IT IS BOTH, AND THE PROPORTIONS ARE THE QUESTION

Some of the harm travels and some does not. This is not a philosophical dispute but an arithmetic one, and the arithmetic can be done. The honest answer will be a split — this much is intrinsic, that much is imposed — and the split will differ by behaviour, by country and by decade.

Where things stand: the third position is the only one that is not simply an assertion, and it is where this series will spend most of its remaining pages. But I will say now what I expect and what would embarrass me: I expect the imposed share to be much the larger, and if the evidence in Parts Ten to Thirteen comes out the other way I am obliged to report that.

What would settle it: comparison of the same behaviours across societies with sharply different enforcement, tracking the same people over time rather than asking them once, and looking at what happens when enforcement changes suddenly in one place. All three of these exist. None is clean.

Why people care so much: because the answer decides where responsibility sits. If the harm is intrinsic, the woman caused it. If the harm is imposed, the community did — and the community includes the person doing the warning. Almost nobody can examine this question neutrally, including me.

5.5 — The uncomfortable practical problem

Now the part that neither camp likes, and it is the reason this chapter cannot end tidily.

Suppose you fully accept that the harm is imposed rather than intrinsic. Suppose you are certain the punishment is unjust. What advice do you actually give a nineteen-year-old woman in a small town tomorrow morning?

Because the punishment does not care whether it is just. It will be administered anyway. Telling her that the harm is socially constructed is true and completely useless to her, in the same way that telling somebody the road is unfairly designed does not stop the traffic.

This is the genuine dilemma and both sides dodge it. The traditionalist dodges it by pretending the harm is natural, which converts a political fact into a permanent one. The reformer dodges it by pretending the harm is small, which is a lie that costs somebody else and never the person telling it.

The honest position is harder and less satisfying to say. **The danger is real. The danger is also manufactured. Both facts stay true at the same time, and a person deciding what to do tomorrow has to weigh a real cost that should not exist.**

That is not a resolution. It is the actual shape of the problem, and I would rather leave it in that shape than tidy it into something false.

REMEMBER THIS

"She will ruin her life" is usually **accurate**. The consequences are real. Any argument that starts by denying them fails immediately and deserves to.

But accuracy is not the question. The question is **what makes it come true**. A warning where the speaker is part of the mechanism is not a forecast; it is a punishment announced early, in the grammar of weather.

A rule that punishes rule-breaking always manufactures evidence that rule-breaking is harmful. That evidence is then used to justify the punishment. The circle can run forever without ever touching reality.

The test: **does the harm travel?** Look at the same behaviour where the punishing community has no reach. What follows her across the border is intrinsic. What stops at the boundary was imposed.

Almost nobody saying this sentence is lying or threatening. They have seen the outcome many times and have never once seen the comparison. They are reasoning correctly from data that has been built by their own participation.

The danger is real and the danger is manufactured. Both stay true, and the woman deciding tomorrow morning still has to pay.

CHAPTER SIX

Who Is Counting, And What Do They Get

When a question that could be settled by evidence is instead fought like a war, something other than evidence is at stake. It is worth working out what, before we spend fifteen parts on the evidence.

6.1 — A question nobody wants answered

Here is something odd about this whole field, and you should find it odd too.

Most of the disputed claims in this series are countable. Whether women with more partners are less happy later — countable. Whether birth rates fall when rules relax — countable. Whether violence rises — countable. Whether societies that liberalised collapsed — extremely countable, and several of them are still standing there available for inspection.

Yet the arguments do not proceed like arguments about countable things. Nobody says "let us look." People arrive holding conclusions and search for numbers afterwards. When a number goes the wrong way it is attacked rather than absorbed.

That pattern is itself information. When people fight an evidential question politically, it is because something other than the evidence is riding on the answer. Naming what is riding on it does not settle anything, but it tells you what you are watching.

6.2 — What each answer is worth, and to whom

Let me go through this without accusation. These are not conspiracies. Nobody meets. They are incentives, and incentives shape what people find persuasive without anybody having to be dishonest.

Families with unmarried daughters. In a society where marriage is the main route to security, a daughter's reputation is a financial asset. Anything that raises the price of female reputation raises the value of that asset for families who have invested in it. It also raises the risk. Both effects push the same way: towards enforcement.

Families with unmarried sons. Their interest runs the other way and it is rarely mentioned. Strict rules on women reduce the supply of acceptable partners, which is bad for a family holding a son. This is one reason enforcement is never uniform: the same community contains groups with opposing stakes in the same rule, and which group is louder shifts with the sex ratio and the economy.

Religious and community authorities. Any institution whose authority rests on interpreting rules gains when the rules are important and loses when they are ignored. This is not cynicism about faith; it is a straightforward observation about institutions. An office that adjudicates behaviour needs behaviour to adjudicate.

Political movements. Threat to women is among the most reliable mobilising devices ever discovered, and it works for every faction. “Our women are being corrupted by outsiders” builds one kind of movement. “Our women are being destroyed by our own men” builds another. Both are used, both recruit effectively, and neither is primarily a claim about women.

The outrage economy. This one is new and it changes everything, because it is the first stakeholder that profits from the argument itself rather than from either answer. Platforms are paid for attention. Content about women’s bodies and behaviour reliably produces attention. The result is a permanent industrial incentive for the fight to continue and never resolve — which is a genuinely novel condition, and Part Fourteen returns to it.

Researchers. Including the honest ones. Certain findings are easier to publish, easier to fund and safer to hold in some institutions, and the direction of that pressure has flipped at least once in the last fifty years. Part Seven deals with what this does to the evidence base and it is not a small effect.

6.3 — Nobody believes it and everybody obeys it

Now the most useful single finding in this chapter, because it shows that a rule can be enforced by an entire population that privately rejects it.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In the 2010s a team of economists ran a study in Saudi Arabia, published in a leading economics journal in 2020. They asked young married Saudi men, privately, whether they thought it was acceptable for women to work outside the home.

Close to nine in ten said yes. Then they were asked what they thought *other men like them* believed. They substantially underestimated it. Almost everyone privately agreed, and almost everyone thought they were unusual.

The researchers then told a randomly chosen group the true figure — nothing else, just the correct number. Months later, the wives of the men who had been told were measurably more likely to have applied for jobs and to have interviewed.

What it shows: the constraint was not belief. It was a shared mistake about other people's beliefs. Correcting the mistake changed behaviour, with no argument, no persuasion and no change to anybody's actual values.

What it cannot show: that all norms work this way. Some are held up by genuine conviction, some by force, some by real material interest. This mechanism explains a subset, not the field. It also comes from one country and one class of men.

There is a name for the condition that study uncovered.

WORD BOX

Pluralistic ignorance: a situation where most people privately reject a norm but each wrongly believes that most others accept it. Everyone then goes along with it, and by going along with it, supplies the evidence that convinces everyone else.

Why it matters here: it means a rule can be maintained at full strength by a population in which nobody supports it. There is no need for a villain. The enforcement is real and the belief behind it is a shared mistake.

Now put this beside the foot-binding mechanism from Chapter Three and they turn out to be the same object. In both cases the rule was held up not by conviction but by *each person's prediction about everybody else*. In both cases the collapse, when it came, was sudden — because that kind of structure does not erode gradually. It stands until enough people see that others are ready to move, and then it goes over all at once.

6.4 — Whose society, exactly?

Everything above should make you suspicious of the word that appears in every version of this argument: *society*. Something bad will happen to society. Society will break down.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everyone in this fight assumes **society is a thing that can be harmed —** a single body with a single set of interests, which can be well or unwell.
>
> Both sides need this. The traditionalist needs it to say the rules protect it. The reformer needs it to say the rules damage it. Neither pauses to ask what would actually be measured.
>
> Because societies are not bodies. They are large numbers of people with conflicting interests. Almost any change that harms some of them helps others. When a rule relaxes, some people gain freedom, some lose security, some lose status and some lose income, and there is no scale on which those cancel into a single verdict.
>
> So "society will be harmed" nearly always turns out, on inspection, to mean one of three things. That *some particular group* will lose something. That *a specific measure* will move — births, marriages, crime — with the choice of measure smuggling in the conclusion. Or that the speaker will feel that things are not as they should be, which is a real experience and not a fact about a society.
>
> The general form: **a collective noun standing in for the interests of whoever is speaking.** Whenever you meet the word in the next fifteen parts, replace it with "which people, and what happens to them," and watch how many arguments simply stop working.

6.5 — My stake, and yours

It would be dishonest to list everybody else's interests and leave out my own.

I am an Indian man writing about rules that have never once been applied to me. I have never had my clothing assessed, never had a rumour about my body used to settle an argument, never had my worth calculated by a marriage market. That is not a small gap. It means I am describing a weather system from indoors.

There is a specific temptation available to men who write about this, and I want to name it precisely so you can watch for it. It is the temptation to write about women's freedom as a way of demonstrating to other men that one is modern and clever. That produces writing which sounds liberationist and is really about the author. It is a well-worn genre in India and I am fully capable of adding to it.

I also have a stake in the conclusion. I began this project irritated by what was done to a woman in a photograph, and irritation prefers certain findings. If the evidence in Parts Ten and Nine cuts against my instincts, the honest thing is to report it at full strength, and I have built the structure of this series to make that harder to avoid — the chapters that will be most uncomfortable for me have already been announced in the contents.

And you have a stake too. Notice, as you read the coming parts, which findings you find yourself hoping are true. That reaction is not a flaw to suppress; it is a signal. It marks the exact places where you are least reliable, and it is far more useful to you than any conclusion I could hand over.

REMEMBER THIS

Most of the disputed claims here are **countable**. They are not argued as though they were. When a countable question is fought like a war, something other than evidence is riding on the answer.

Real stakes exist on every side: families with daughters, families with sons, institutions whose authority rests on interpreting rules, political movements that recruit through threat, and a new one — an **attention industry that profits from the fight continuing rather than from either answer**.

A norm can be enforced at full strength by a population that privately rejects it. In the Saudi study, nearly nine in ten men approved of women working and nearly all of them thought they were unusual. Correcting the mistake changed real behaviour — with no argument at all.

This is the same machine as foot-binding. Rules held up by **expectations about other people** do not erode gradually. They stand, and then they fall over at once.

"Society will be harmed" almost always means one group loses something, or one chosen measure moves, or the speaker is unsettled. Replace the word with "which people, and what happens to them," and a great many arguments stop working.

CHAPTER SEVEN

How To Read The Next Fifteen Parts

The rest of this series is built on studies, surveys and national statistics. Numbers can be made to say almost anything to a reader who does not know the six ways they go wrong. Here are the six.

7.1 — Two things happening together

This is the first and largest problem, and it is responsible for more confident nonsense in this field than everything else combined.

When two things happen together, there are four possible explanations, and only one of them is the one people assume.

Take a real example we will meet in Part Ten. Women who have had more sexual partners before marriage have, on average, somewhat higher rates of later divorce. That relationship shows up repeatedly in large national datasets. It is not made up and I am not going to pretend it is.

Now, the four explanations.

One: the first thing causes the second. Something about having had more partners makes marriages less stable afterwards.

Two: the second causes the first. Impossible here, since the order is fixed. But in many other cases it is not, and the direction is assumed rather than shown.

Three: a third thing causes both. Perhaps people who are less inclined to stay in relationships have more partners *and* more divorces, and the two outcomes are both symptoms of the same underlying disposition. Nothing is causing anything; both are effects.

Four: it is an artefact. The measurement is bad, the sample is odd, or the effect is small enough to be noise.

Every one of these is live, and the honest reader holds all four until something rules some out.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Confounder:** a third factor that causes the two things you are looking at, creating the appearance of a link between them.
>
> The standard illustration: ice cream sales and drownings rise together. Ice cream does not drown people. Hot weather causes both. Heat is the confounder.
>
> Why it matters here: nearly every claim about women's behaviour and women's outcomes has an obvious candidate confounder sitting right next to it — usually family income, education, religiosity or region, all of which shape both the behaviour and the outcome.

7.2 — Who ended up in the study

The second problem is subtler and it wrecks more research than the first.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Selection effect:** a distortion caused by how people ended up in the group you are examining, rather than by anything the study measured.
>
> Why it matters here: people are never randomly assigned to break social rules. The women who defy a norm differ from those who comply in a hundred ways before they defy anything — in temperament, in family, in money, in what they had to lose. Any difference in their later lives could be caused by those prior differences rather than by the defiance.

Here is the version that matters most for us. Chapter Five proposed comparing women who break a rule in India against women who do the same thing in a country with weak enforcement. That is a good idea and it has a serious flaw: the women who leave India are not a random sample of Indian women. They are richer, more educated, more mobile and differently supported. So a difference in outcomes might be caused by the move rather than the rule.

I flagged this in the box in Chapter Five and I am flagging it again here because it does not go away. It is the central weakness of the comparisons this series depends on, and I would rather you knew that before Part Thirteen than discovered it afterwards.

7.3 — How big is it, actually

Now the most useful skill in this chapter, and the one that will change how you read almost every headline about men and women for the rest of your life.

A finding can be completely real and completely trivial. “Men and women differ in X” tells you nothing until you know *by how much*. Researchers have a standard way of expressing this.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Effect size:** a number describing how big a difference is, expressed in terms of how much the two groups spread out.
>
> The plainest way to think about it. Take two groups. Pick one person at random from each. The effect size tells you how often the person from the higher group will actually be higher.
>
> If the effect size is zero, it is a coin toss — fifty-fifty. Small differences get you to around fifty-six in a hundred. What researchers call a large difference gets you to about seventy-one in a hundred. Even a “large” difference means that nearly three times in ten, the individual from the supposedly lower group comes out on top.
>
> Why it matters here: this single number is the difference between “men are taller than women”, which is true and enormous, and “men are better at maths”, which is a claim about a difference so small it is almost invisible at the level of any individual person.

That definition is abstract, so put it in a room with people in it. This is the picture I want you carrying through the rest of the series, because it is the one that keeps a true sentence from doing dishonest work.

IN REAL TERMS

Picture a school hall with a hundred men on one side and a hundred women on the other.

Height. One of the largest sex differences there is. Line everybody up and the pattern is obvious across the room. But even here, if you pick one man and one woman at random, the woman is taller roughly once every ten or twelve pairs. Even the biggest differences have overlap.

A typical cognitive difference. Most measured mental differences between men and women are so small that if you picked one person from each side, you would be right about which was “better” barely more often than by flipping a coin. Somewhere around fifty-three or fifty-four times in a hundred.

Both of those are real differences. Reporting them the same way — “men and women differ in X” — is how one true sentence gets used to smuggle in a completely different one.

Hold on to that hall, because Part Four takes you through every measured difference between men and women and puts each one in it. Some of them will be visible from the door. Most will not be visible at all.

7.4 — Whose data is it

In 2010 three researchers published a paper pointing out something that should have been noticed decades earlier. The overwhelming majority of published psychology studies had been run on people from Western, educated, industrialised, rich, democratic countries — and a very large share of those on university students in one country.

Those populations are a small minority of humanity. And on many measures they are not a representative minority; they are unusual, sometimes at the far end of the human range.

WORD BOX

WEIRD samples: shorthand for Western, Educated, Industrialised, Rich, Democratic. The point of the acronym is that the people most studied by psychology are among the least typical humans available.

Why it matters here: a great deal of what this series has to draw on was measured on American and European undergraduates and is then applied to Indian women in towns with entirely different economies, family structures and law. Every time I do that, I will say so.

There is a second problem sitting on top of the first, and it is worth knowing about before you read anything built on psychology research.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In 2015 a large collaboration attempted to repeat one hundred published psychology studies, using the original methods and larger samples.

Fewer than four in ten produced the same result. The rest were weaker, absent, or went the other way.

What it shows: that a single published finding, even in a respected journal, is a weak object. Not worthless — but not a fact. What matters is whether a result has been repeated by other people, in other places, with different methods.

What it cannot show: which findings are the bad ones. It does not license dismissing any particular study you dislike. It raises the bar for everything equally, including results that flatter your position.

The rule I will follow: where a claim rests on one study, I will say so. Where it has been repeated across many countries and methods, I will say that too, and I will treat the difference as significant.

7.5 — What would actually settle it

Given all of the above, what counts as strong evidence here? Four things, in ascending order.

A single study. Weak. Interesting, worth reporting, not a foundation.

The same result across many societies. Much stronger, especially where the societies differ in the thing being proposed as the cause. If a difference appears in India and Sweden and Japan and Nigeria, "Indian culture causes it" is in trouble. If it appears in India and vanishes in Sweden, culture is back in the running.

Tracking the same people over years. Stronger again, because it establishes what came first. Most claims in this field are made from single snapshots, which cannot do that.

A sudden change in one place and not another. The strongest thing available outside a laboratory. When one country changes a law or a policy and a neighbouring one does not, you have something close to an experiment that no ethics committee would ever approve.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Natural experiment:** a situation where something outside the researchers' control divided people into groups in a way that resembles a real experiment. A law changing on a particular date. A border. A policy applied in one state and not the next.
>
> Why it matters here: we cannot randomly assign women to societies. Natural experiments are the closest thing available, and Part Thirteen is built almost entirely from them.

One last thing to carry forward, and it is the most valuable habit in this chapter. When somebody makes a claim in this field, ask what would have to be true for them to be wrong, and whether they can say it. Anybody who cannot name the evidence that would change their mind is not holding a position. They are holding a flag.

I will state mine at the end of Chapter Nine.

REMEMBER THIS

When two things occur together there are four explanations, not one: the first causes the second, the second causes the first, a **third thing causes both**, or it is noise. Almost every claim in this field has a strong candidate for the third.

People are never randomly assigned to break social rules. Those who break them differ beforehand in ways that could explain everything afterwards. This is the **central weakness** of the comparisons this series relies on.

Effect size is the most useful number you can learn. It tells you how often a randomly picked person from one group actually beats a randomly picked person from the other. Even large differences leave nearly three in ten going the other way.

Most psychology was measured on unusual populations, and fewer than four in ten of a hundred well-known studies repeated successfully when retested. A single study is not a fact.

Ask what would make somebody wrong. If they cannot say, they are not holding a position — they are holding a flag.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Words Are Doing Work

Some words arrive with a verdict already inside them. Use the word and you have agreed to the verdict without noticing you agreed to anything. This chapter empties out the vocabulary before we start.

8.1 — A word that has already decided

Consider a woman wearing a short dress. Now consider the available descriptions.

She is dressed *immodestly*. She is dressed *provocatively*. She is dressed *freely*. She is dressed *indecently*. She is dressed *confidently*. She is dressed *in a short dress*.

Only the last of those is a description. Every other one contains a judgement, and in most cases a whole theory.

Immodest assumes modesty is the correct default and she has fallen short of it. *Provocative* assumes an audience being provoked, and quietly assigns her responsibility for their reaction. *Indecent* assumes a public standard she has violated. *Free* and *confident* assume she has escaped something, which is also a claim, and one she may not have made.

This is not a small point about politeness. Once a word is chosen, the argument is largely finished. Somebody who accepts the word *provocative* has already conceded that the reaction of onlookers is a property of her clothing rather than of the onlookers. Everything after that is decoration.

8.2 — Counting the words

Here is an exercise that takes two minutes and permanently changes how you read this subject.

Think of every word you know, in English or in your own language, for a woman who has many sexual partners. Do not censor. Just count them. Most people who try this get to a dozen or more without effort, and nearly all of the words are insults.

Now do the same for a man. Most people struggle past three or four, and the striking thing is not the number but the temperature. The male words are milder. Several of them are compliments wearing a thin disguise.

This asymmetry is not an accident of one language, and it is not new. Scholars of language have documented a long-running pattern in English in which words for women drift downwards over centuries into sexual insult, while their male counterparts hold their meaning. *Master* and *mistress* began as equivalents. *Sir* and *madam* began as equivalents. *Bachelor* and *spinster* began as equivalents. Look where each pair ended up.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The evidence is dictionary history. Words are traceable through dated written usage, so a word's meaning at different points in time is a matter of record rather than of opinion.
>
> **What it shows:** a consistent direction of drift, over centuries, in which paired terms for men and women diverge, with the female term acquiring sexual and then derogatory meanings while the male term stays neutral or gains status. It shows up repeatedly across the vocabulary.
>
> **What it cannot show:** the cause. Drift is not proof of intention; nobody decided this. It also cannot easily distinguish a language reflecting a society's judgements from a language helping to produce them. And it is best documented for English, which is a WEIRD language in a WEIRD society — though the same asymmetry is reported widely elsewhere, including in Hindi and Punjabi.

Here is why this matters for everything that follows. If your language supplies twelve ways to condemn a woman's sexual history and three ways to mention a man's, then any conversation you have will be shaped by that supply before you open your mouth. Precision costs effort in one direction and is free in the other. That is not neutral ground.

8.3 — "Westernisation"

This word deserves its own section, because it does a very specific job and does it invisibly.

When somebody says Indian women are becoming westernised, what is being claimed? Unpack it and there are at least four separate things bundled inside.

A description: some Indian women now behave in ways more common in Western countries. Sometimes true.

A causal claim: they do this *because of* Western influence, rather than for reasons of their own arising from Indian conditions — urbanisation, wage work, education, delayed marriage. This is an assertion, rarely defended, and it is often false. A woman taking a job in Bengaluru because her family needs the income is not imitating anybody.

A judgement: that this is a decline. The word carries it. Nobody says a village became westernised when it got clean drinking water.

A claim about ownership: that the behaviour is foreign, and therefore that the people doing it are, in some measure, no longer properly ours. This is the part that does the real work and it is never stated openly.

The fourth is where the damage sits, because it converts a disagreement about behaviour into a question of belonging. A woman who is behaving differently can be argued with. A woman who has become foreign can be expelled.

Part Three will show that the historical claim underneath the word is mostly backwards — that a great deal of what is now defended as Indian tradition arrived with the British in the nineteenth century, and that some of what is now attacked as Western would have been unremarkable in India a thousand years ago. I am not going to make that argument here. I am only pointing out that the word has already assumed the answer.

8.4 — And the words on the other side

I would be doing exactly what this chapter warns against if I only examined the vocabulary of one camp.

Empowerment. Enormously flexible and therefore nearly meaningless. It is applied to a woman becoming a legislator and to a woman buying a face cream. When a word can describe both, it is not describing anything; it is signalling approval. It is also the favourite word of advertising departments, which should tell you something about what it costs to use.

Choice. Often used to end a conversation rather than to have one. Saying a woman chose something is true and frequently uninformative. Everyone chooses within constraints, and the interesting question — what the constraints were, and who set them — is precisely what the word is used to close off.

Patriarchy. A real term describing a real pattern, and Part Fifteen takes it seriously. But it is often used to explain everything, and a theory that explains every outcome forbids none, which makes it unfalsifiable. It also has a specific weakness this series will have to confront: it does not obviously describe a system in which the people at the very bottom — by imprisonment, by workplace death, by suicide — are overwhelmingly male.

Toxic, problematic, regressive. Each converts a disagreement into a diagnosis. That is exactly what *immodest* does, running the other way. A judgement dressed as a description is the same move regardless of which camp is making it.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Look at the entire vocabulary — both camps, every word above — and one thing is common to all of it. **Female behaviour is the variable. Male behaviour is the weather.**
>
> A dress is described as *provocative*. The provocation is treated as an automatic fact about men, like rain. Nobody says a man is *reactive*, because his reaction is not understood as a choice he is making.
>
> Look at what gets counted. There are hundreds of studies on the effects of women's sexual behaviour on their later lives, and a small fraction as many on men's. Both camps do this. The traditionalist studies what women's freedom costs. The reformer studies what constraint costs women. Both have made women the object under examination.
>
> Even the standard progressive sentence, "we must teach men not to harass," treats male behaviour as an input to be adjusted from outside rather than as conduct chosen by an adult.

> The general form: **one party's conduct is treated as behaviour and the other's as conditions.** Whichever side of this argument you are on, you have almost certainly been doing it. I have been doing it in this document — this series is called *The Rules About Women*, and the title was chosen before I noticed what it assumed.

8.5 — What I will do in this series

Some rules for myself, so you can check them.

I will describe before I judge. "A short dress" rather than "immodest" or "liberated". Where I use a loaded word because there is no alternative, I will mark it.

I will name the word choice as a choice. If I write *honour killing*, I will note that the phrase contains the killers' own justification and that some researchers refuse it for that reason. If I write *tradition*, I will say how old the thing actually is, because the word implies an antiquity that is often absent.

I will use both camps' words for their own positions, not the insulting versions their opponents prefer.

I will not use "we" to mean Indians, or Hindus, or men, or the modern. That word quietly assigns the reader to a team and I have no right to do that.

REMEMBER THIS

Words like **immodest**, **provocative** and **indecent** are not descriptions. Each contains a verdict, and accepting the word concedes the argument before it begins.

Every language examined has far more words for a promiscuous woman than for a promiscuous man, and the female ones are harsher. Paired terms drift apart over centuries — **master and mistress, bachelor and spinster**. The supply of vocabulary shapes the conversation before anyone speaks.

Westernisation bundles four claims: a description, a causal story that is usually asserted rather than shown, a judgement of decline, and a claim about belonging. The last is the one doing the work, because a woman who is merely behaving differently can be argued with, while a woman who has become foreign can be expelled.

The other camp's words do the same job. **Empowerment** describes both a legislator and a face cream. **Choice** is often used to close a conversation about constraints.

Underneath every word on both sides sits one assumption: female behaviour is the variable and male behaviour is the weather. Even the title of this series assumes it.

CHAPTER NINE

The Shape Of The Fight

Before we spend fifteen parts gathering evidence, it is worth knowing what each side would have to establish in order to win. Written down plainly, the requirements are startling — mostly because so few people arguing have ever met them.

9.1 — What the traditionalist has to prove

Take the position at its strongest, in the form set out in Chapter Two. Not the version that shouts. The version that would convince a careful reader.

To establish that a rule about women should be maintained, the following would need to be shown. Not asserted. Shown.

That the rule solves a real problem. Not that it once did. That the problem exists now. If the problem was uncertain fatherhood, paternity testing exists. If it was disease, contraception and antibiotics exist. A rule justified by a solved problem needs a new justification.

That the harm from removing it is larger than the harm from keeping it. This requires actually counting the second one. Almost nobody does. The costs of enforcement — the surveillance, the constrained lives, the violence, the women who do not work — are usually left out of the ledger entirely, and a comparison with one column empty is not a comparison.

That no cheaper instrument exists. Most problems have several solutions. If a cheaper one is available that does not require restricting half the population, the rule has to explain itself.

That the burden belongs where it is placed. Every problem here has two participants. The rules land on one. That asymmetry needs an argument and almost never receives one.

That is the honest requirement, and it is heavy. It is also not impossible. For some rules, in some places, I expect the case can be made, and where the evidence supports it I will say so.

9.2 — What the reformer has to prove

Now the other side, held to exactly the same standard.

That the harms are genuinely imposed rather than intrinsic. This is the test from Chapter Five and it is hard work, not a slogan. It requires showing that the damage stops at the boundary of the enforcing community.

That the replacement has been built. This is the lesson of the emptied asylums, and it is the one reformers most consistently skip. Removing a rule while leaving in place the conditions that made it necessary is not liberation. If the old system provided security — badly, unequally, at enormous cost, but provided it — then something has to provide it afterwards, and “she will be free” is not an answer to “who will support her.”

That the predicted costs did not materialise, or were worth paying. Not that they were imaginary. Some were not imaginary. Birth rates really did fall. Marriage really did become less common. The honest reformist position has to either dispute those numbers, or accept them and argue the trade was worth it, and the second is a much harder and more respectable argument than the first.

That women’s own stated preferences are being taken seriously, including when they are inconvenient. Large numbers of women in India endorse the rules under examination. Explaining that away as false consciousness is available, and it is the same move as saying they do not know their own minds — which is precisely what the other side is accused of.

9.3 — Where the burden actually sits

Who has to prove what first? This is not a technicality. In practice it decides most arguments, because whoever holds the burden loses ties.

The traditionalist answer: the rule is in place, it has lasted, and the person proposing change carries the burden. This follows from Chesterton’s fence and it is reasonable.

The reformist answer: the rule restricts a person's life without her consent, and restriction is what requires justification. Long-standing restriction is still restriction. This is also reasonable.

Notice that these are not competing claims about the world. They are competing claims about the *default*, and there is no neutral place to stand between them. Your choice of default is already a moral position, and it usually determines your conclusion before the evidence arrives.

What I will do is state mine, so that you can discount it. **I hold that a rule which constrains a person's life requires justification, and that its age reduces the strength of that requirement but does not remove it.** That is a value, not a finding, and I am not going to pretend I derived it from evidence.

9.4 — The four questions

Everything in the remaining fifteen parts serves four questions. Here they are, with where each is answered.

One. Where did these rules come from, and what problem did they solve? Parts Two and Three. Paternity, property, farming, and the specifically Indian machinery of caste. Including the finding that a great deal of what is now called ancient Indian modesty is roughly as old as the railway.

Two. How different are men and women, really? Parts Four and Five. Every measured difference with its actual size, and the result that most damages the simple cultural explanation — that in the freest and most equal countries on earth, men's and women's choices diverge *more*, not less.

Three. What actually happens when the rules change? Parts Nine, Ten, Eleven, Twelve, Thirteen and Fourteen. What happens to a woman, what happens to a country, what the costs of the old system are when somebody finally counts them, and what happened in every society that already ran the experiment.

Four. What has the equality project actually produced? Parts Six, Seven, Eight and Fifteen. Sixty years of results, measured rather than asserted, including the reversal in education that nobody discusses and the finding that measured female happiness in the West declined across exactly the decades women gained most.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Time to turn this on ourselves, as promised.

Every question above, and the question that started this series, takes the same form: **what happens to a woman who does X?** The traditionalist asks it expecting damage. The reformer asks it expecting none. Both agree, without discussion, that this is the question.

But look at what the form does. It makes a woman's life an outcome to be predicted. It makes her behaviour a variable to be assessed for consequences. It positions everybody else — including me, including you — as the analyst standing outside, examining.

There is a different question available that almost nobody asks: *who is asking, and what do they get from each answer?* That question was Chapter Six, and notice that it is the only chapter in this part that turns the instrument around.

The general form: **a question so universally accepted that its shape becomes invisible.** Fifteen further parts of careful evidence will not fix this. The most I can do is say it out loud: this series is fifteen parts of examining women, produced by a man, and that fact is not neutralised by the quality of the examination.

9.5 — What would change my mind

Chapter Seven said that anybody who cannot name the evidence that would change their mind is holding a flag rather than a position. So here is mine, in advance, before I have gathered the evidence.

I currently expect that most of the harm attributed to women breaking these rules is imposed by enforcement rather than intrinsic to the acts — that it mostly does not travel across a border.

I would abandon that if the harms turn out to appear at similar strength in societies with weak enforcement, controlling for who moves and who stays. If women in low-enforcement countries show the same later damage, my position is wrong and the elders are describing something real about the world rather than something real about villages.

I currently expect that the fertility collapse is genuine, serious, and not something reformers have a good answer to.

I would abandon that if some country demonstrated a sustained recovery to replacement without reversing women's freedoms. As far as I know, none has. If one does, that changes the picture substantially.

I currently expect that some sex differences are large, stable across cultures, and not explicable by socialisation alone.

I would abandon that if those differences shrank as societies became more equal. They do not. In several cases they widen, and that finding is not going to be pleasant for anybody. It gets a full part.

REMEMBER THIS

To win, the traditionalist must show the problem still exists, that removing the rule costs more than keeping it — **counting both columns** — that no cheaper instrument exists, and that the burden belongs on her rather than on him.

To win, the reformer must show the harms are imposed rather than intrinsic, that **the replacement has been built**, and either that the predicted costs did not appear or that they were worth paying. Some of them appeared.

Both sides are really arguing about the **default**, and there is no neutral ground between them. Mine is stated: constraint requires justification, and age weakens that requirement without removing it.

I have written down in advance what would change my mind on three claims. Hold me to it.

And note what every question in this series has in common: it asks what happens to a woman who acts. The shape of that question is not neutral, and fifteen parts of careful evidence will not make it so.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Every part of this series ends this way. Two lists, and no hedging in either direction. What is genuinely unknown, with the reason it is unknown. And what is solid enough to build on.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

This part has been about how to think rather than what is true, so the unknowns here are mostly about the tools themselves. Later parts will have longer lists and harder ones.

How much of the harm is imposed and how much is intrinsic. This is the central question of the series and I do not know the answer. I have stated my expectation and my grounds for abandoning it. The reason it is unknown is not laziness — it is that the clean experiment is impossible. You cannot randomly assign women to societies, and the ones who move are not like the ones who stay. Every estimate will carry that flaw.

Whether the vocabulary shapes the belief or merely records it. Chapter Eight showed that words for women drift downward across centuries. Whether language is producing that judgement or reporting it is not settled, and the honest position is that the evidence cannot currently separate the two.

What norms hold up any specific rule. Chapter Six showed a norm sustained entirely by mistaken beliefs about other people. But it does not follow that all norms are like this. Some rest on real conviction, some on force, some on material interest. For any particular rule in India, which mechanism dominates is an open empirical question, and one that could be answered by exactly the kind of study run in Saudi Arabia. As far as I know, it has not been run here at scale.

How much of the research base survives scrutiny. Fewer than four in ten of a hundred well-known psychology findings replicated. That figure is itself from one project. Which specific results in Parts Four to Twelve are the fragile ones cannot be known in advance, and anyone who tells you they can identify them — always conveniently the ones cutting against their own position — is guessing.

Whether the mechanism that ended foot-binding can be generalised. It is the most hopeful finding in this part, and it may be a special case. Foot-binding had unusual features: it was visible, binary, and imposed on children by parents who could coordinate. Rules about adult behaviour are none of those things. Whether the pledge-society mechanism transfers is unknown.

10.2 — Solid

That the three claims are separable. This is not an empirical finding but a logical one, and it holds regardless of what the evidence turns out to show. Origin, consequence and obligation are different kinds of statement requiring different kinds of support. Nothing in the next fifteen parts can overturn this, and it is the most useful thing in this document.

That no set of facts produces an instruction by itself. Also logical, also settled, also universally violated. The extra ingredient is always a value. It can be a good value. It cannot be hidden.

That longevity is evidence of enforcement rather than of benefit. This is close to definitional once stated. A rule imposed by a strong group on a weak one has a survival advantage independent of its merit. Foot-binding is the proof by example: a thousand years of survival, and it broke the feet of every girl it touched for the entire duration.

That men and women report sexual histories that cannot both be true. This is arithmetic, and it holds across many countries and many surveys. In a closed population the averages must be nearly equal. They are not, consistently, everywhere. Something is wrong with the reporting, reliably, in a patterned way — which is itself a finding about what each sex is punished for admitting.

That norms can be held up by nobody's actual preference. The Saudi study is a genuine experiment with a real behavioural outcome, not a survey correlation. Its scope is limited — one country, one class of men — but within that scope the finding is solid, and it establishes that this mechanism exists.

That the harm to a woman accused in public is real and close to permanent, whatever the truth of the accusation. This needs no study. It follows from how information moves and from the documented asymmetry between the reach of a claim and the reach of its correction.

10.3 — Why the gaps are shaped this way

One last observation, and it is the kind that matters more than the lists.

Look at what is missing. We have a great deal of research on what happens to women who break rules, and very little on what happens to women who keep them. We have extensive study of the costs of change and thin study of the costs of continuity. We can tell you the divorce rate associated with a woman's sexual history and we struggle to tell you the life satisfaction of a woman married at nineteen to a man chosen for her.

That imbalance is not an accident of funding. It reflects which questions somebody wanted answered. The literature was built by people who found one direction interesting, and the shape of the gap is a record of who was doing the asking.

Chapter Six said to notice who is counting and what they get. This is what that looks like when it shows up in a library. **The missing research is itself a finding, and I will point at it every time it appears.**

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: how much of the harm is imposed against intrinsic — the central question, and the clean experiment is impossible. Whether language produces judgements or records them. Which mechanism holds up any particular Indian rule. Which specific findings in the coming parts will survive scrutiny. Whether the foot-binding mechanism generalises.

Solid: that origin, consequence and obligation are separable claims. That no facts produce an instruction without an added value. That longevity measures enforcement, not benefit. That reported sexual histories cannot arithmetically be true. That norms can stand with nobody supporting them. That a public accusation is a near-permanent cost regardless of its truth.

And the shape of the gaps is itself evidence. We know a great deal about what happens to women who break the rules and very little about what happens to women who keep them. That asymmetry records who was asking.

When These Tools Were Named

This part is about thinking rather than about events, so its timeline is a timeline of instruments — the point at which each idea used in these ten chapters was given a name and became usable.

YEAR	WHAT WAS NAMED, AND BY WHOM
c. 1000 CE	Foot-binding becomes established in China. It will last roughly a thousand years, defended throughout by every argument still in use today, and then collapse within a few decades.
1739	David Hume points out that writers slide from describing how the world *is* to instructing what people *ought* to do, without ever showing the step. The gap is still unclosed.
1829	Sati is outlawed in British India after campaigning by Indian and foreign reformers together. The strongest argument against abolition was the danger of outsiders touching a people's customs.
1903	G. E. Moore names the naturalistic fallacy. In everyday use it merges with the older appeal to nature: the claim that natural means good.
1929	G. K. Chesterton describes the fence in the field. Do not remove what you cannot explain. It becomes the most durable conservative argument of the century.
1948	Robert Merton names the self-fulfilling prophecy: a prediction that manufactures its own truth. Chapter Five is built on it.
1960s–1980s	Britain and the United States close their mental institutions. The replacement is promised and largely never built. Prisons become, by default, the largest mental health facilities in both countries.
1975	Linguists document the long downward drift of English words for women — master and mistress, bachelor and spinster — into sexual and then derogatory meaning, while the male terms hold.
2010	Three researchers point out that most of psychology was measured on Western, educated, industrialised, rich, democratic populations, and that these are among the least typical humans available.
2015	A large collaboration retests one hundred published psychology studies. Fewer than four in ten hold up. Every finding in the coming parts must be read against this.

YEAR	WHAT WAS NAMED, AND BY WHOM
2020	Economists publish the Saudi study: nearly nine in ten men privately approved of women working, and nearly all of them believed they were unusual. Correcting the mistake changed real behaviour.
Today	A woman stands in front of a police vehicle. Days later, a rumour about her body is offered as a reply.
↓	**Part Two starts here — and runs the clock backwards, ten thousand years, to the moment somebody first owned a field and needed to know who would inherit it.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. You should not have needed this page — each term was explained where it first appeared — but it is here.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Ad hominem	Latin for "to the person". Answering an argument by talking about the person who made it. Legitimate only when the claim cannot be checked without trusting them.
Appeal to nature	Arguing that natural means good, or unnatural means bad. Cholera is natural; literacy is not.
Chesterton's Fence	The principle that you should not remove something whose purpose you do not understand until you understand it. A rule against a certain kind of confidence, not against change.
Confounder	A third factor causing two things at once, making them look connected. Hot weather causes both ice cream sales and drownings.
Counterfactual	What would have happened otherwise. The comparison nobody ever gets to see, which is why patterns caused by punishment look exactly like patterns caused by nature.
Deinstitutionalisation	The closing of large mental hospitals from the 1960s onwards. Used here as the clearest case of a fence removed without building its replacement.
Effect size	A number saying how big a difference between two groups actually is. Read as: pick one person from each group at random — how often does the higher group win?
Foot-binding	The Chinese practice of breaking and binding girls' feet, lasting about a thousand years and collapsing within decades once families coordinated to stop.
Genetic fallacy	Judging a claim by where it came from rather than whether it is true. Nothing to do with genes; from the Greek for origin.
Is/ought gap	The point that no pile of facts produces an instruction by itself. Getting from one to the other always requires an added value.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Moralistic fallacy	Concluding a fact must be false because it would be inconvenient. The mirror image of the appeal to nature, and just as common.
Natural experiment	A situation where something outside the researchers' control split people into groups — a law changing, a border, a policy in one state and not the next.
Naturalistic fallacy	Strictly, defining goodness as a natural property. In ordinary use, merged with the appeal to nature.
Norm	An unwritten rule enforced by ordinary people through approval and disapproval, rather than by law. Harder to argue with because there is no office to appeal to.
Pluralistic ignorance	When most people privately reject a rule but each believes the others accept it — so everyone complies, and the compliance becomes the evidence.
Primogeniture	The rule that the eldest son inherits everything. Solved a real problem — land being divided into unviable slivers — at the cost of four children in five.
Replication	Repeating a study to see whether the result appears again. Fewer than four in ten of a hundred famous psychology findings did.
Sati	Widow-burning, outlawed in India in 1829. Defended at the time as scripture, tradition and devotion.
Selection effect	A distortion caused by how people ended up in the group being studied, rather than by anything the study measured.
Self-fulfilling prophecy	A prediction that causes what it predicts. False when spoken and true when finished. It always looks like wisdom afterwards.
WEIRD samples	Western, Educated, Industrialised, Rich, Democratic. The populations psychology mostly studied, and among the least typical people available.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and I publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

I am not a sociologist, an anthropologist or a statistician. What I do is read the published record carefully, lay out what each side actually claims and what evidence it actually holds, explain it in language nobody has to fight, and refuse to hand down a verdict where the evidence does not produce one. That is a real job and it has real limits, and the limits are worth stating plainly: I am synthesising other people's work, not producing new findings.

On this particular subject I have a further limitation, and I set it out in the front matter rather than burying it here. I am an Indian man writing about rules that have never been applied to me. I have flagged that at each point in these ten chapters where it could bend the writing, and I will keep doing it for fifteen more parts. If you catch me missing one, tell me.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the survey, the register, the dictionary entry, the natural experiment — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make, not a version built to lose. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not, and that answer is worth more than a manufactured conclusion.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — philosophy, economics, sociology, linguistics and the history of two customs — rather than new primary research. Where I have described a specific study, I have described what it measured and what it found, and said where its limits are.

The archive here is uneven in a way worth knowing about. Philosophy and the history of ideas are extremely well documented; the dates and formulations in the timeline are a matter of record. Research on sexual behaviour and its consequences is far weaker — much of it self-reported, most of it from a handful of rich countries, and a great deal of it never independently repeated. Research on Indian conditions specifically is thinner still, and where it exists it is often government survey data collected for other purposes. I will say which kind of ground I am standing on each time it changes.

Where a claim rests only on an institution's account of itself, I flag it in the text. Where I have used my own formulation rather than an established term — the travel test in Chapter Five is the only case in this part — I have said so.

Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who know a field better than I do. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Two — Where the Rules Came From. It runs the clock back ten thousand years and asks a set of questions this part has only set up.

- If a man cannot know for certain which children are his, and a woman always can, what does that single asymmetry do to every rule a society writes? And how much of the machinery in this series comes from one biological fact?
- Why do foraging societies have looser rules about women than farming ones? What changed when people stopped moving and started owning a field they could not carry?
- There is economic research linking a particular ancient farming tool to women's employment rates in the present day, thousands of years later. What is the mechanism, and how strong is the evidence really?
- Some societies traced descent through the mother, gave property to daughters, and did not care much who a woman slept with. Several were in India. What happened to them, and does their existence disprove the claim that these rules are necessary?
- Which of the problems these rules were built to solve have since been solved another way — and what does a rule become when its problem is gone?
- And the question Chapter Three could not answer: when we finally find out who built the fence, does knowing help the woman standing on the wrong side of it tomorrow morning?

END OF PART ONE OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Two — Where the Rules Came From

One biological asymmetry. A field that cannot be carried. A farming tool that still shapes women's employment four thousand years later.

And the societies that ran the opposite rules, in India, and did not collapse.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Part One was about how to think, not about what is true. It began with a woman photographed at a protest and a rumour that arrived days later, offered as though it were a reply. Nobody organised that. Thousands of people performed the same move at the same time and experienced it as obvious.

The main tool from that part was a separation. When somebody defends the rules about women, they almost always make three claims joined into one sentence. A claim about the past: these rules came from somewhere and had a function. A claim about the future: if they go, damage follows. A claim about you: therefore behave. Each needs a different kind of evidence, and they can be true and false in any combination.

We also took apart the strongest conservative argument, the fence in the field. Do not remove what you cannot explain. It is a serious argument and three parts of it hold. But it tells you to ask *why* a fence is there, and the honest question is *who* — who built it, what did they get, and who was on the wrong side. A rule surviving four thousand years proves it kept being enforced. That is a fact about power, not about benefit.

Then the sharpest tool in the box. When an elder says a woman will ruin her life, that sounds like a forecast. Often the speaker is part of the machinery that does the ruining, which makes it a sentence rather than a prediction. The test proposed was whether the harm travels: look at the same behaviour where the punishing community has no reach. What follows her across a border is intrinsic. What stops at the boundary was imposed.

This part answers the first of the three claims. **Where did these rules actually come from, and what problem did they solve?** Not what people say they solved. What the evidence shows.

I should tell you now that the answer is more interesting than either camp expects. The traditionalist will find that the rules are older and more functional than the reformer admits — they are not arbitrary cruelty and they were not invented by anybody to hurt anybody. The reformer will find something too: that the same problems produced wildly different solutions, that some of those solutions gave women more rather than less, that several of them were in India, and that the specific arrangement now defended as timeless is one option among many that human societies actually built.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box appear throughout the series. If you read Part One you already know them. If not, here is one live example of each.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Kinship system:** the set of rules a society uses to decide who counts as your family, who you may marry, and who inherits what. Every society has one. They differ enormously.
>
> Why it matters here: this whole part is about kinship systems, and the single most useful fact in it is that there is more than one workable design.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does. Never later, never only in the glossary.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> People who look and think like us have existed for roughly three hundred thousand years. Farming is about twelve thousand years old. Those numbers are hard to feel, so compress them.
>
> Put all of human existence into a single day, starting at midnight. For twenty-three hours and twenty minutes, nobody farms anything. Everyone moves, everyone forages, nobody owns a field.
>
> Farming begins at about **twenty minutes to midnight**. Writing appears with about half of that left. The rules this series examines are, on that clock, extremely recent — and they are almost all downstream of those last forty minutes.

Any number too big to picture gets converted into something with a body — a walk, a room, a wage, a single day.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Much of this part rests on the ethnographic record: several hundred societies described by anthropologists, coded into comparable categories, and analysed together.

What it can show: which practices travel together. If societies that farm with a certain tool reliably restrict women more, that pattern is real and is not explained by any one culture.

What it cannot show: the direction of cause, and it carries a serious flaw at its root. Most descriptions were written by European men, in the colonial period, who mostly interviewed men. Where a society had a women's world that men did not enter, the record often simply does not contain it. Absence in this archive is weak evidence of absence in the world.

This box names the actual evidence and then says what it cannot show. It is the box that should make you trust the rest.

THE ARGUMENT — DID FARMING MAKE WOMEN'S LIVES WORSE?

A framing question for the whole part, and the answer is less obvious than either camp assumes.

YES, SHARPLY

Foraging societies are generally more equal between the sexes, with easier divorce, looser control of women and no dowry. Farming brought heritable property, and with it the policing of women's sexuality to secure inheritance. Skeletal remains from early farming populations show shorter, less healthy people than the foragers before them, and the burden of the new work fell heavily on women.

NOT STRAIGHTFORWARDLY

The comparison is between surviving foragers and ancient farmers, which is not a fair test — the foragers we can study are those pushed onto land nobody else wanted. Farming also produced surplus, which produced everything from medicine to literacy, and women's lives in the wealthiest farming societies today are freer than in any forager society ever documented. Judging the transition by its first thousand years is like judging a factory by the first winter.

Where things stand: the specific link between heritable property and control of women is well supported and this part sets out the evidence for it. The broader claim that farming was simply a catastrophe for women is not settled and depends heavily on which century you stop counting.

What would settle it: better skeletal and genetic evidence from the transition period itself, in more regions. Some of this is arriving now and Chapter Three uses it.

An Argument box appears where people who have studied something genuinely disagree. Each side gets its strongest case, then a verdict on where things actually stand.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume that a change can be scored — that farming was, on balance, good or bad for women as a group.

But "women" in this sentence covers a forager in the Kalahari, a Sumerian priestess, a Bengali widow in 1850 and a software engineer in Pune. The claim requires adding their experiences into one number, and there is no scale on which that addition can be performed.

The general form: **demanding a verdict on a change that had different effects on different people.** Watch how often, in this part and the next fourteen, an argument depends on a total that could never actually be computed.

This is the signature box. It digs out something both sides take for granted while they fight. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these. It restates the chapter in the plainest words available, with key terms in **bold**.

A reader who read only the Remember This boxes should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

Two warnings.

This part explains. It does not excuse. Everything here is an account of how these rules came to exist. Part One, Chapter Four established why that is not the same as saying they are right: no set of facts about how the world is produces an instruction by itself. I will explain the machinery of these rules as clearly as I can, including the parts where the machinery is genuinely clever. If at any point that reads as approval, it is not, and I have said so here so that I cannot claim it later.

I am going to talk about biology, and there is a trap on both sides of it. One camp treats any biological fact as a licence. The other treats any biological fact as an attack, and therefore refuses to look. Both are the same error running in opposite directions, and both were named in Part One. I will report what is established, say plainly how far it reaches, and mark the exact point where it stops reaching. That point arrives much earlier than most people on either side would like.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The One Asymmetry

There is a single biological fact underneath a great deal of what follows. It is real, it is not controversial, and it explains far less than the people who cite it believe. Both of those sentences matter.

1.1 — The fact

A woman who gives birth knows the child is hers. She was there for the entire process and there is no version of events in which she is mistaken.

A man cannot know this. Until 1985, when the first genetic fingerprinting technique was demonstrated, no man in the history of the species could establish with certainty that a child was his. He could be confident. He could not be sure.

That is the asymmetry. It is one sentence long and it sits underneath an enormous amount of what this series examines.

Before we go further, note what it is not. It is not a claim that men care more about paternity than women care about anything. It is not a claim about who loves children more. It is a claim about *information* — that one parent has a fact available and the other, for almost the whole of human history, did not.

1.2 — What each parent has to spend

There is a second asymmetry sitting next to the first, and it is about cost rather than information.

Producing a child requires very different minimum contributions from each parent. From the man: a single act. From the woman: nine months of pregnancy, a delivery that was for most of history genuinely dangerous, and then — in societies without bottles or formula, which is all of them until recently — two to four years of nursing during which another pregnancy is unlikely.

IN REAL TERMS

Put the reproductive budgets side by side.

A woman is born with all the eggs she will ever have. Across a lifetime she releases roughly **four hundred**. That is the entire stock, spread over about thirty-five years.

A man produces sperm continuously from puberty. The output of a single day runs to tens of millions.

Here is the version with a body attached. A woman's whole reproductive career, in eggs, would fit in a teaspoon and takes three and a half decades to spend. A man restocks more than his lifetime's worth of opportunities before breakfast.

This does not make anybody good or bad. It means the two sexes were playing a game with wildly different budgets, and the rules a society writes tend to follow the budgets.

Biologists have a term for the thing being measured there, and it is worth having, because it is what makes the difference between the sexes predictable rather than arbitrary.

WORD BOX

Parental investment: anything a parent does for one offspring that costs them the ability to do it for another. Feeding, carrying, protecting, and — for the mother — the pregnancy itself.

The idea comes from a biologist writing in the early 1970s, and the general finding across the animal kingdom is that the sex which invests more per offspring is choosier about partners, while the sex which invests less competes for access.

Why it matters here: in humans the gap in *minimum* investment is very large, but the gap in *actual* investment is often small, because human fathers frequently do a great deal. That difference between minimum and actual is where all the interesting variation lives.

1.3 — What this genuinely predicts

Now the careful part. What does the asymmetry actually let us expect?

It predicts, reasonably well, that **some degree of male concern with paternity will appear in most human societies.** A man who invests years of food and protection in a child has, in evolutionary terms, a stake in whether that investment is going where he thinks it is. And this prediction holds up. Concern with paternity turns up nearly everywhere anthropologists have looked.

It predicts, less strongly, that societies where men invest heavily in children will show more interest in controlling women's sexual behaviour than societies where they do not. This also broadly holds, and Chapter Three shows the mechanism.

Here is what it does *not* predict, and the list is long.

It does not predict that a family will kill a daughter. It does not predict that a woman must cover her hair, or her face, or her ankles, or none of these. It does not predict dowry, or bridewealth, or that a widow may not remarry, or that a girl marries at fourteen, or that a woman may not own land, or work, or travel alone, or that her testimony counts for half.

Every one of those varies enormously between societies that face the identical biological situation. The biology is a constant. The rules are not. A constant cannot explain a variable — that is not a moral objection, it is a logical one.

1.4 — The societies where a child has several fathers

The clearest way to see how far the biology reaches is to look at a case that ought to be impossible.

In parts of lowland South America, a number of societies hold a belief that a child can be fathered by more than one man. The reasoning is straightforward once you accept the premise: a foetus is built up from repeated contributions, so every man who has sex with a woman during her pregnancy contributes to the child. Anthropologists call the resulting arrangement partible paternity.

WORD BOX

Partible paternity: the belief that a child can have several biological fathers, all of whom are genuinely regarded as fathers and carry real obligations to the child.

Why it matters here: this is not a curiosity. It is a society that took the exact biological situation described above and built the opposite institution on top of it. If the biology forced the outcome, this could not exist. It exists.

A belief on its own would prove little — people believe all sorts of things that make no difference to how they live. What makes this case worth the space is that somebody went and measured the consequences.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Anthropologists working with the Barí of Venezuela and the Aché of Paraguay in the late twentieth century collected reproductive histories from women, recording which men were named as fathers of each child and what happened to the child afterwards.

What they found: in the Barí data, children who had a named secondary father survived to fifteen at meaningfully higher rates than children with only one father — roughly four in five against something closer to two in three. Secondary fathers brought fish and game. In a place where a child's main risk is a hungry season or a dead father, a second man with an obligation is insurance.

What it can show: that the arrangement was not a quaint belief floating free of consequences. It had a measurable effect on child survival, which is why it persisted.

What it cannot show: that it would work anywhere else. These are small societies with little storable wealth and no land inheritance — precisely the conditions Chapter Three identifies as the ones that make paternity matter less. And these are single studies of small populations, with all the fragility that implies.

Notice what the Barí did. They faced the same information problem every human population faces. Instead of solving it by restricting women, they solved it by *distributing the obligation* — turning uncertainty from a threat into a source of extra support for the child.

That is not a better solution in some general sense. It works in their conditions and would collapse in a society with heritable land, for reasons Chapter Three explains. The point is narrower and more important: **the same biological fact supported two opposite institutions.** So the fact cannot be what produced either of them.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Both camps in the biology argument share a premise they never state: **that if a rule has a biological root, the biology explains the rule.**
>
> One side says: this is rooted in biology, therefore it is natural and inevitable. The other side says: therefore we must show it has no biological root at all, or we lose.
>
> Both are treating the root as though it determined the plant. But the gap between "men everywhere show some concern about paternity" and "this family will kill this girl" is enormous, and nothing in biology crosses it. Between the fact and the rule sits everything this part is actually about — property, inheritance, farming tools, weak states, marriage payments.
>
> The general form: **mistaking a necessary condition for a sufficient one.** Rain is necessary for a flood. It does not follow that rain explains why this valley floods and the next one does not. The answer to that is drains, and drains are built by people.

1.5 — Where the biology stops

So here is the honest position, and it will satisfy nobody entirely.

The asymmetry is real. It is not a social construction and pretending otherwise is the moralistic fallacy from Part One, Chapter Four — deciding a fact must be false because it is inconvenient. Anybody who tells you that male concern with paternity is purely an invention of patriarchy is asking you to ignore a pattern that shows up in societies with no contact with each other.

And the asymmetry explains almost none of the variation. Every specific rule this series examines — the clothing, the timing of marriage, the property law, the killing — differs wildly between societies whose biology is identical. Anybody who tells you these rules are simply nature is asking you to ignore that the same nature produced the Barí.

The rest of this part is about what fills the gap. It turns out that the strongest single answer is not biological at all. It is a question about whether you own something you cannot pick up and carry away.

REMEMBER THIS

One asymmetry sits underneath much of this series: a mother always knows the child is hers, and until **1985** no father could be certain. That is a difference in information, not in love.

A second sits beside it: the minimum cost of a child is one act for a man and years for a woman. Roughly **four hundred eggs in a lifetime** against tens of millions of sperm a day.

This genuinely predicts that **some** male concern with paternity appears nearly everywhere. It does not predict veiling, dowry, child marriage, property law or killing — all of which vary hugely between societies with identical biology. **A constant cannot explain a variable.**

Several Amazonian societies believe a child can have more than one father, and the extra fathers bring food. In one studied group it raised child survival measurably. Same biology, opposite institution.

Biology is a necessary condition, not a sufficient one. Rain is necessary for a flood, but the reason this valley floods and the next does not is drains — and drains are built by people.

CHAPTER TWO

Before Anybody Owned Anything

For all but the last few minutes of human existence, nobody had land, a granary, or anything they could not carry. The rules about women in such societies are looser almost everywhere they have been recorded. Understanding why is the key to the whole part.

2.1 — What the record shows

Anthropologists have documented foraging societies across four continents — the Hadza in Tanzania, the Ju/'hoansi of the Kalahari, the Aka of the Congo basin, the Aché of Paraguay, groups across Aboriginal Australia and the Arctic.

These groups differ from each other in many ways. But a set of features recurs often enough to be worth stating plainly.

Marriage is easier to leave. Among several documented foragers, divorce is common and carries little stigma. A woman who wants to end a marriage takes her things — which are few — and goes to another camp, frequently to her own relatives. She loses very little because she owned very little to begin with.

There is no dowry and no bride price of the kind Chapter Five describes. What appears instead is often bride service: a young man works for his wife's family for a period, sometimes years. Note the direction. The labour flows towards the woman's family, not away from it.

Female sexual behaviour is regulated but not policed in the way this series is examining. Infidelity causes conflict, as it does everywhere. What is generally absent is the machinery — the seclusion, the veiling, the killing of a daughter to repair a family's standing, the treatment of a woman's chastity as a family asset.

Food is shared beyond the household. In many foraging groups a large kill is distributed across the whole camp by custom rather than by the hunter's choice. This matters more than it sounds, and §2.2 explains why.

Fathers are often heavily involved. Among the Aka, fathers have been recorded holding and caring for infants more than in any other society yet measured. So much for the idea that low male investment is the natural state.

2.2 — Why: there is nothing to leave anybody

The explanation is not that these people were kinder. It is structural, and once you see it the rest of this part follows.

Consider what a mobile foraging group can own. Tools, weapons, clothing, ornaments. Things a person can carry while walking. There is no field, no granary, no herd, no house that stays where you left it.

Now ask the question that drives everything: **what does a man have to pass on, and to whom?**

The answer is: very little of material value. His skill, perhaps his standing, a few possessions. In a society where food is shared across the camp by custom, even the product of his own labour is not fully his to direct.

So the stakes attached to paternity are low. Not zero — a man still prefers to support his own children, and jealousy exists everywhere. But there is no estate, so there is no inheritance question, so there is no reason to construct an elaborate apparatus for ensuring that an estate goes to the right body.

Now hold that sentence up against the next chapter, where somebody plants a field.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Heritable property:** wealth that survives its owner and passes to somebody specific — land, buildings, herds, stored grain.
>
> The contrast is with wealth that cannot be inherited in any meaningful way: a person's skill, strength, or a share of a kill that will be eaten this week.
>
> Why it matters here: this distinction does more explanatory work than anything else in this part. Where wealth is heritable, who gets it becomes a question, and the answer runs through a woman's body.

2.3 — The comparison is not fair, and the unfairness cuts both ways

Before this becomes a story about a lost paradise, several serious problems with the evidence need stating.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN SURVIVING FORAGERS TELL US WHAT THE DEEP PAST WAS LIKE?

Nearly every claim about "how humans originally lived" rests on studying societies that still forage today. That inference is heavily contested.

THEY CAN, WITHIN LIMITS

The pattern is not one group but many, on separate continents, with no contact between them. When societies in Tanzania, Paraguay and the Kalahari independently show looser marriage, easier divorce and no dowry, the common factor is unlikely to be coincidence. And the structural explanation is testable: it predicts the pattern should track mobility and storable wealth, and it does.

THEY CANNOT, AND THE ERROR IS SEVERE

Every forager studied in the twentieth century lives on land that farmers and states did not want — deserts, deep forest, Arctic margins. They have traded with, fled from and been reshaped by agricultural neighbours for thousands of years. They are not a window into the past; they are contemporary societies pushed into extreme environments. Ancient foragers living in rich river valleys may have had storage, hierarchy and rules we would find entirely familiar. Archaeology has begun turning up exactly that.

Where things stand: the second criticism is strong and largely accepted. The strongest surviving version of the claim is not "foragers show us the past" but the narrower structural one: **across societies of every kind, the amount of control over women tracks the amount of heritable, immobile wealth.** That relationship can be tested on farming societies too, and it holds there as well, which is what makes it credible.

What would settle it: archaeological evidence about wealth and inequality in pre-agricultural societies in rich environments. This work is ongoing, and early results suggest more variety in the deep past than the simple story allows.

Why people care so much: because a great deal rides on whether the current arrangement is humanity's default or one recent option. Both camps want the deep past on their side, which is a bad reason to consult it.

2.4 — Not a paradise

The record also contains things the romantic version leaves out, and leaving them out would be exactly the kind of selective reporting this series is supposed to avoid.

Violence in some foraging societies is high. Among several documented groups, the share of deaths caused by another person exceeds that of most modern states by a wide margin. Life was not gentle.

Marriage was frequently arranged, sometimes for girls who were very young, and sometimes to considerably older men. In parts of Aboriginal Australia, betrothal at or before birth was recorded. Freedom to leave a marriage is not the same as freedom to choose one.

Men typically held political authority in the sense that camp decisions and disputes were often settled among them. Greater equality is not equality.

And infanticide, including the sex-selective kind, is recorded in a number of foraging societies. The most humbling thing in this chapter is that a practice we associate with the ultrasound machine long predates it.

So the honest summary is narrow and I want to keep it narrow: **foraging societies show less of the specific apparatus this series examines — the seclusion, the property in a woman's chastity, the marriage payments — and they show plenty of other harms.** The claim is about a particular machine, not about human happiness.

2.5 — What actually changed

One more thing to carry into the next chapter, and it is the hinge of the whole part.

Foragers were not free of jealousy, or of male authority, or of violence against women. All of that was present. What was missing was the *institutional* version — rules written into property law, marriage contracts, inheritance and religious teaching, enforced by whole communities rather than by individual angry men.

That is the difference between a feeling and a system. Feelings are ancient and probably universal. Systems are built, and they are built out of specific materials for specific reasons.

The material that mattered most arrived when somebody planted a seed, waited, and could not walk away.

REMEMBER THIS

Across foraging societies on four continents, a pattern recurs: **divorce is easy, there is no dowry, and the machinery of controlling women's sexuality is largely absent.** Bride service runs the other way — the young man works for her family.

The reason is structural, not moral. A mobile group owns only what it can carry, so there is **no estate**, so there is no inheritance question, so there is no need for an apparatus to route property through the right body.

The comparison has a real flaw: every forager studied in modern times lives on land nobody else wanted. They are not a window into the past. The claim that survives is narrower and stronger — **control over women tracks heritable, immobile wealth**, and that holds across farming societies too.

These were not gentle societies. Violence was often high, marriage was frequently arranged, girls were sometimes betrothed very young, and infanticide including the sex-selective kind is recorded.

What foragers lacked was not jealousy or male authority. It was the institutional version — rules written into property, marriage and inheritance, enforced by everybody. That is the difference between a feeling and a system, and systems are built out of specific materials.

CHAPTER THREE

The Field That Cannot Be Carried

About twelve thousand years ago people began planting seeds and waiting. Everything in this series follows from what that made possible — and from what it made necessary.

3.1 — The seed and the wait

Farming did not arrive once. It appeared independently in at least half a dozen places — the Fertile Crescent, northern China, Mesoamerica, the Andes, the New Guinea highlands, parts of Africa — over several thousand years, among people with no contact with each other.

That independence matters. When separate populations arrive at the same arrangement without copying, the arrangement is being produced by the situation rather than by a culture.

What planting a seed does is create a delay. You put something in the ground and you get nothing for months. During that gap the field is valuable, vulnerable, and — the crucial part — **immobile**. You cannot pick it up. You cannot take it with you if you leave. Its value depends entirely on your being able to come back and on nobody else taking it.

So the first thing farming produces is not food. It is a reason to stay, and a reason to defend.

IN REAL TERMS

The change in what land can support is easy to state and hard to feel, so here is a version with a room in it.

Foraging in a typical environment supports somewhere in the region of one person for every ten square kilometres. Early farming supports something like a hundred times more people on the same ground.

Put it in a village. The land that fed a single foraging family now feeds a settlement of a hundred or more. Those hundred people live within shouting distance of each other, permanently, for generations, and they can all see what everybody else's daughter is doing.

That last sentence is not a joke. Surveillance is a by-product of density, and density is a by-product of the plough. Nobody chose it.

3.2 — Storage, and the first thing worth stealing

The second thing farming produces is a surplus that keeps. Grain can be stored. Stored grain is wealth that survives the person who grew it.

This is genuinely new in human history, and it has three consequences that arrive together.

Inequality becomes possible and then permanent. In a foraging camp where a kill is shared by custom, a good hunter cannot accumulate. With a granary, a household can. And once one household has more, the difference can be passed on, and the gap compounds across generations rather than resetting each time.

Property needs defending. A granary can be raided. A field can be seized. So farming societies develop what foraging bands mostly did not: organised violence over resources, walls, and eventually the specialists we call soldiers.

And property has to go somewhere when you die. This is the one that concerns us.

3.3 — Why the question runs through a woman's body

Here is the chain, and I want to lay it out step by step because it is the engine of this entire series and every later part refers back to it.

A man farms a field. The field will outlive him. When he dies it must go to somebody, or it will be taken by whoever is nearest.

He wants it to go to his children — this preference does not need explaining, it appears everywhere. But recall Chapter One: he cannot verify which children are his. His wife can. He cannot.

So the estate creates a problem that did not previously exist in any serious form. It is not a problem about sex. It is a problem about **verification**, and it becomes urgent precisely in proportion to how much there is to pass on.

A society can solve this in several ways, and different societies chose differently.

Solution one: pass property through women instead. If wealth goes from a woman to her children, verification is unnecessary — she always knows. Chapter Seven is entirely about the societies that took this route, several of which were in India.

Solution two: pass property to your sister's children. Your sister's children are certainly related to you, whatever anybody does. This is a common arrangement and it works, at the cost of a man having no formal stake in the children he raises.

Solution three: control the woman. Restrict her movement, her contacts, her clothing, the age at which she marries, and who she may speak to. Make her behaviour a matter for the whole family rather than for her, so that the family will do the enforcing.

The third solution is expensive. It requires constant effort by many people. But it has one enormous advantage over the others: **it lets a man pass property to children he raises, while remaining reasonably confident they are his.** The first two solutions each break one of those. Only the third delivers both, and that is why it spread.

I want to be precise about what I am claiming here. I am not saying men gathered and chose this. I am saying that among the available arrangements, this one produced a particular outcome — concentrated, defended, heritable wealth in a male line — and societies organised that way tended to out-compete, absorb and displace their neighbours. Nobody had to intend it for it to spread.

3.4 — What the genetics shows

There is physical evidence for something dramatic happening to men's reproduction in exactly this period, and it is one of the strangest findings in the field.

WORD BOX

Y chromosome and **mitochondrial DNA:** two pieces of genetic material that are inherited in a special way. The Y passes only from father to son. Mitochondrial DNA passes only from mother to all her children.

This makes them a pair of measuring instruments. The variety in a population's Y chromosomes tells you roughly how many men were passing on genes. The variety in the mitochondrial DNA tells you the same about women. Comparing the two tells you whether the sexes were reproducing at similar rates.

Nobody set out looking for a fact about ancient marriage. Researchers were sequencing male genomes for entirely unrelated reasons, and the pattern fell out of the data.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Researchers sequencing large numbers of male genomes across Africa, Europe and Asia found something unexpected. Beginning roughly seven thousand years ago and lasting a few thousand years, Y chromosome diversity collapsed — while diversity in the female line, in the very same populations, did not.

What it shows: that during this window, far fewer men than women were passing on their genes. The effect appears in multiple regions independently, which makes a local explanation unlikely. Some analyses put the imbalance at extreme levels; the exact figures depend heavily on the model chosen and should be treated as indicative rather than precise.

What it cannot show: the cause, and there are two serious candidates. One is that a small number of powerful men monopolised reproduction. The other, now widely favoured, is that men had begun organising into competing patrilineal clans, and that whole male lineages were periodically wiped out together in conflict between them — which produces the same genetic signature without requiring extreme polygyny.

Both explanations, note, describe a world newly organised around male descent lines and property. The timing sits directly on top of the spread of farming.

Notice how easily that finding invites a story with a villain in it, and how little the evidence actually supplies one. That pull is worth examining directly, because it operates on both sides of this argument and neither notices.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Almost everybody arguing about this history assumes there was **an author**.

The traditionalist speaks of the wisdom of the ancestors, as though a council of thoughtful elders examined the options and selected well. The reformer speaks of a system built by men to serve men, as though a decision was taken and enforced.

Neither can produce the meeting. There is no document, no founder, no moment. What the evidence actually shows is thousands of separate households making small decisions about land, marriage and inheritance across thousands of years, in which some arrangements happened to spread because the societies holding them grew, absorbed neighbours and lasted.

This matters practically, not just philosophically. If there is no author, then “who is to blame” has no clean answer — which frustrates one camp — and “the ancestors knew what they were doing” has no author either, which should frustrate the other far more than it does.

The general form: **mistaking an outcome for an intention.** A path worn across a park was not designed, and it is still exactly where people wanted to walk. Both facts are true and neither is a plan.

3.5 — What this does and does not establish

The chain in §3.3 is the standard account, it is well supported, and it should not be oversold. Here is the honest scoring.

Strongly supported: that control over women’s sexual behaviour tracks the presence of heritable, immobile property. This holds across the ethnographic record, across historical societies, and — as Chapter Four shows — within farming societies too, which is the strongest version.

Reasonably supported: that inheritance is the mechanism. The alternatives that have been proposed do not fit the pattern as well, and the ones that do fit tend to be inheritance under another name.

Not established: the precise sequence. Whether property produced the rules or the rules made a certain kind of property possible is genuinely hard to disentangle, because in the record they arrive together. Chapter Four contains the closest thing available to an answer, and even that is not clean.

REMEMBER THIS

Farming appeared independently in at least half a dozen places among people with no contact. When separate populations reach the same arrangement without copying, the **situation** is producing it, not the culture.

Planting creates a delay and a thing you cannot carry. From that follow settlement, density, storable surplus, permanent inequality, and organised violence over resources.

And an estate has to go somewhere. A man wants it to go to his children and **cannot verify which they are**. That is not a problem about sex. It is a problem about verification, and it grows in proportion to how much there is to pass on.

Three solutions exist: pass property through women, pass it to your sister's children, or **control the woman**. Only the third lets a man pass wealth to children he raises while staying confident they are his. That is why it spread.

Genetics shows something matching. Around seven thousand years ago the male line's diversity collapsed while the female line's did not, in several regions at once — a world newly organised around male descent and property.

Nobody designed any of this. There was no meeting. Which means blame has no clean target, and "the ancestors knew what they were doing" has no author either.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Plough

Whether your ancestors farmed with a plough or a hoe predicts how many women work in your country today. It predicts it for the grandchildren of people who left those countries. This is the most surprising piece of evidence in the part, and it needs handling carefully.

4.1 — Two ways to break ground

Not all farming is the same, and one distinction turns out to matter enormously.

Shifting cultivation with a hoe or digging stick. You clear a patch, often by burning, and plant with hand tools. The work is spread across the season. It can be interrupted. It can be done while carrying a child, and it can be done in short bursts between other tasks.

Plough agriculture. A heavy blade drawn through the soil by an animal. It requires enough upper-body strength and grip to control both the implement and the animal, and it demands sustained bursts of effort at fixed points in the year. It cannot easily be interrupted, and taking an infant into a field behind an ox is not a serious option.

The consequence is that plough farming pushes field labour towards men. This is not an ideological claim; it is a description of who can physically do the task while also doing the other thing human societies need doing. Part Four takes up the physical differences properly, with numbers. Here it is enough to say that the gap in upper-body strength between men and women is among the largest measured human sex differences, and a plough sits exactly on it.

So in plough societies, the field becomes male space. Women's work moves indoors. And over generations, a division of labour that began as a fact about a tool turns into a belief about what women are *for*.

4.2 — The observation, and then the test

A Danish economist writing in 1970 noticed the pattern first: in Africa, where hoe cultivation dominated, women did a large share of farm work and had corresponding economic independence; in much of Asia and Europe, where the plough dominated, they did not.

It was a good observation. For forty years it remained an observation, because you cannot easily test a claim about thousands of years of history.

Then, in 2013, three economists found a way.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The researchers took a database of several hundred pre-industrial societies, coded by anthropologists for whether they used the plough. They matched each modern population to the traditional practices of its ancestors.
>
> Then they looked at the present day: how many women work outside the home, how many own businesses, how many sit in parliaments, and what people in surveys say about whether men should have priority for jobs.
>
> **The finding:** descendants of plough-using societies score lower on every one of these. The relationship is strong and survives controls for income, religion, geography and colonial history.
>
> **The clever part.** A correlation like this could easily run backwards — perhaps societies that already restricted women adopted the plough. So the researchers used something no society chooses: the physical suitability of its land for crops that need a plough, such as wheat and barley, against crops that do not, such as sorghum and millet. Soil and rainfall are not caused by anybody's opinion about women. The relationship held.
>
> **What it cannot show:** that crop suitability affects nothing else. Wheat-growing regions also developed states, cities, writing and armies earlier, any of which could carry the effect instead. This is the main criticism and it is serious.

4.3 — The grandchildren

Then comes the result that makes this study famous, and it is the one to hold on to.

The researchers looked at the children and grandchildren of migrants living in the United States and Europe — people born in a new country, educated in its schools, working in its economy, subject to none of its ancestors' farming conditions.

The pattern was still there. Women descended from plough-using populations were less likely to work outside the home than women descended from hoe-using populations, *living in the same country, under the same laws, in the same decade*.

Think about what that isolates. The land is gone. The crop is gone. The plough is gone, four thousand years gone. What travelled was the belief about what women do — carried across an ocean inside families, and still measurable in employment statistics generations later.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> A woman in Chicago decides whether to take a job. She has never seen a plough. Her grandmother never saw one.
>
> But somewhere behind her, in a village she has never visited, the soil suited wheat rather than millet. Because of that, men worked the fields. Because of that, a belief formed about where women belong. That belief was taught to children, who taught it to children, who boarded a ship.
>
> Now put a number on the distance. Between the plough that started it and the decision she is making sits something in the order of **two hundred generations**. If each generation were one step, that is a walk of about ten minutes. If each were a year, it would reach back before the Roman Empire.
>
> That is the reach of a farming tool.

4.4 — How much of this to believe

This is a striking result and striking results deserve suspicion, particularly when they flatter a story you already find appealing.

> **THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE PLOUGH FINDING HOLD UP?**
>
> It is among the most cited results in economics on this subject, and it is not unchallenged.

IT HOLDS

The result appears across dozens of countries, several outcome measures and multiple datasets. The migrant test is a genuinely strong design: it removes the land, the crop and the institutions and finds the effect anyway. And the mechanism is not mysterious — the physical demands of a plough are not in dispute, and a division of labour hardening into a belief is a process visible in many other domains.

IT IS WEAKER THAN IT LOOKS

Crop suitability is not a clean instrument. Wheat regions also developed early states, dense cities, standing armies, writing and organised religion. Any of these could be the actual carrier, with the plough merely along for the ride. The ancestral coding comes from the colonial-era ethnographic record, with all the flaws described in the front matter. And migrant communities differ in a hundred ways besides ancestral farming, including why they migrated and where they settled.

THE NARROWER CLAIM THAT SURVIVES

Something about the deep agricultural past transmits through families and shows up in women's employment today. Whether the carrier is specifically the plough, or the wider package of state formation and property law that came with plough regions, is not settled. The persistence is the robust finding. The mechanism is the contested one.

Where things stand: the third position is the honest one. Norms about women's work are transmitted culturally across very long periods and survive the disappearance of the conditions that produced them. That much is solid. Whether one tool did it is not.

What would settle it: finding places where plough use and state formation came apart — regions with early states and hoe farming, or plough farming without states — and testing whether the effect follows the tool or the state. Some work is doing this and the results so far are mixed.

Why people care so much: because the persistence finding cuts both ways and everyone notices only their half. It tells the traditionalist that these norms are historical rather than natural — a farming accident, not a design. It tells the reformer that culture is far stickier than policy, and that norms outlive by centuries the conditions that justified them.

4.5 — What this means for India

India is a useful test because it contains both systems inside one country.

Northern India is largely wheat country, and wheat is a plough crop. Much of the south and east has historically grown rice and millets under different regimes with different labour patterns.

And the north and south of India differ sharply on exactly the measures this chapter is about. Demographers have documented the divide for decades: the north shows lower female workforce participation, more restrictive kinship arrangements, marriage patterns that send a bride far from her own family into a village of strangers, worse child sex ratios, and stronger seclusion norms. The south shows marriage closer to home, more contact with a woman's own relatives after marriage, and higher female participation in public life.

This is not a claim that the south is free of any of this. It plainly is not. It is a claim that the *strength* of the machinery varies inside one country, one religion and one legal system — which is exactly what you would predict if the cause were agricultural and material rather than doctrinal.

Hold that finding, because Chapter Eight will use it. If the rules were produced by scripture, they should not vary this much between regions sharing the same scripture. They do.

REMEMBER THIS

Ploughing needs sustained strength and grip and cannot be interrupted, so it pushes field labour towards men. Hoe cultivation does not. Over generations a fact about a **tool** hardens into a belief about what women are for.

Descendants of plough-using societies today show lower female employment, fewer women in business and politics, and more restrictive attitudes. The researchers tested it against something nobody chooses — whether the local soil suits wheat or millet — and it held.

The finding that matters most: **the effect survives migration**. Women descended from plough societies work less than women descended from hoe societies while living in the same country under the same laws. The land, the crop and the plough are all gone. The belief travelled anyway.

Treat it carefully. Wheat regions also built early states, cities and armies, any of which might be the real carrier. What is solid is the **persistence**; the mechanism is contested.

India contains both systems. The wheat-growing north shows exactly the pattern predicted — and it shares its scripture with the south. If doctrine wrote these rules, they should not vary this much between people reading the same book.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Price of a Bride

In most societies money changes hands at a wedding. Which direction it flows tells you almost everything about how that society values a woman — and India banned its version in 1961, after which it grew.

5.1 — Two payments, opposite directions

Across the ethnographic record, marriage almost always involves a transfer of wealth between families. There are two main kinds and they run opposite ways.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Bridewealth:** payment from the groom's family to the bride's family. Cattle, goods, money, or labour. It is the more common of the two by a wide margin — the majority of societies in the ethnographic record practise some version.
>
> **Dowry:** payment from the bride's family to the groom's family, or to the couple. Much rarer as a share of societies, but those societies include some of the largest populations on earth: historic Europe, and South Asia.
>
> Why it matters here: these are not two versions of the same custom. They point in opposite directions and they mean opposite things.

Bridewealth says, in effect: your daughter is valuable and we are compensating you for the loss of her. Dowry says: taking our daughter is a cost to you and we are compensating you for it.

Same institution, same ceremony, and a completely inverted valuation of the same person. Which one a society has is not random.

5.2 — Which societies have which

The pattern maps almost exactly onto Chapter Four.

Bridewealth is concentrated in societies where women's labour produces visible wealth. Hoe agriculture, especially across sub-Saharan Africa. A woman in such a society is an economic asset in a direct sense: she farms, and the food she grows is real. Her family gives up that production, and the groom's family pays for it.

Dowry is concentrated in societies with plough agriculture, sharp social stratification, and monogamy. A woman in such a society does not work the fields. She is, in the household's accounting, a cost — to be fed, housed, and married off. Her family pays somebody to take on that cost.

There is a second thing dowry does, and it is the more important one. In a stratified society with monogamous marriage, there is a limited supply of desirable grooms, and families compete for them. Dowry becomes a bid. It is not only a transfer of property; it is a price in a market where the item being bought is a son-in-law of good standing.

A scholar working on this in the 1970s made the further point that dowry is often, in origin, a daughter's inheritance paid early — her share of the family property, handed over at marriage rather than at a death. That is a genuinely different thing from a purchase price, and the two functions can coexist in one custom, which is part of why the argument about dowry is so confused.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Every modern argument about marriage — traditionalist and reformist alike — assumes **the couple is the unit**. The debate is about whether two people should choose each other freely, marry young or late, stay or leave.
>
> For most of the history examined in this part, the couple were not the unit and were frequently the least consulted parties. Marriage was a contract between two *families*, transferring property, labour and alliance. The bride and groom were the terms of the agreement, not the signatories.
>
> This is why the modern conversation so often fails to connect. When a young woman says the choice is hers and her family says it is not, they are not disagreeing about her preferences. They are using two incompatible definitions of what a marriage is. Neither is being irrational within their own frame.
>
> The general form: **a dispute where the two sides have different objects in mind and both think it is a dispute about values.** Once you see this one, a very large number of family arguments in India stop looking like generational conflict and start looking like a contract dispute over who the parties are.

5.3 — India banned it, and it grew

Now the fact that should stop anybody who believes a law can settle this.

India passed the Dowry Prohibition Act in 1961. Giving or taking dowry became a criminal offence. The law was strengthened in the 1980s, and specific provisions were added to the criminal code covering cruelty to a wife and deaths occurring in suspicious circumstances within seven years of marriage.

Since then, dowry has not declined. By most accounts it has expanded — in geographic reach, in the communities practising it, and in real value. Groups that historically paid bridewealth have shifted to dowry. Regions where it was once uncommon now report it. The custom did not shrink under pressure. It spread.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Reported dowries in India commonly run to several times a family's annual income. Put that in a household.
>
> Imagine a family whose entire income for a year is a single stack of notes on a table. Marrying one daughter takes the stack — and then two or three more years of stacks that have not been earned yet. It is paid in gold, in a vehicle, in furniture, in cash, and often in debt that outlives the wedding by a decade.
>
> Now put a second daughter in the house. Then a third. And then ask why a family in a hospital, offered a scan that reveals the sex of a foetus, might make the decision that Part Twelve counts.
>
> The line from a wedding gift to a missing girl is not rhetorical. It is arithmetic, and the families doing it can do the arithmetic.

5.4 — Why the ban failed

Understanding why a fifty-year-old criminal prohibition failed is more useful than condemning it.

Both parties want the transaction. This is unlike most crimes. There is no complainant at the moment of the offence. The bride's family pays willingly, because the alternative is their daughter not marrying, and in a society where marriage is the main route to a woman's security, that is a worse outcome for her. The state is trying to prohibit an exchange that both sides prefer to the alternative.

Reporting it destroys the thing it was meant to protect. A woman who reports her in-laws is in most cases ending her marriage, with all that follows for her and for her sisters' prospects. The law asks her to pay the entire cost of its enforcement.

It is easy to relabel. Gifts to a daughter are lawful, and the line between a gift and a payment exists only in intention. A custom that can be renamed cannot be banned.

And the underlying cause was untouched. Dowry is a price in a marriage market. Prices respond to supply and demand, not to legislation. As long as families compete for a limited pool of acceptable grooms, and as long as a daughter's alternative to marriage is poor, there is upward pressure on the bid. Banning the payment does not change the market. It moves it.

Remember Part One, Chapter Three — the asylums closed and the replacement never built. This is the same structure. India removed the legality of a transaction without removing the conditions that produced it. The transaction continued and lost only its records.

Officially recorded deaths connected to dowry disputes in India run into the thousands each year. That figure comes from police records, which means it counts what was classified and prosecuted as such. Everybody working in this area treats it as a floor rather than an estimate. Part One's rule applies: a state with the power to count and a weak record of counting is telling you something.

REMEMBER THIS

Marriage almost always moves wealth between families, in one of two directions. **Bridewealth** — groom's family pays bride's — is the more common worldwide, and appears where women's labour produces visible wealth. **Dowry** runs the other way and appears with plough farming, stratification and monogamy.

The two encode opposite valuations of the same person. Bridewealth says she is worth compensating for. Dowry says taking her is a cost.

Dowry is also a **bid in a competitive market** for a limited supply of acceptable grooms, which is why it inflates.

India banned it in **1961** and it grew — spreading to communities that had never practised it. The ban failed because both families want the transaction, reporting it destroys the marriage it was meant to protect, a payment can be relabelled a gift, and the market underneath was never touched.

The line from a wedding payment to a daughter who is never born is not rhetoric. It is arithmetic, and the families doing it can do the arithmetic.

CHAPTER SIX

Honour Is a Technology

Where there is no police force worth calling, reputation does the work of law. That is not a metaphor. It is a functioning enforcement system, and understanding how it works explains why a family's standing came to be stored inside a woman.

6.1 — The problem honour solves

Imagine you live somewhere with no reliable police, no court you can reach, and no authority that will enforce an agreement. This is not exotic. It has been the ordinary condition of most people in most places for most of history, and it remains the practical situation in parts of the world today.

You have a problem. Anybody stronger than you can take what you have, and there is no institution to stop them. What protects you?

Only one thing: their belief about what you will do afterwards. If people believe that taking from you is expensive — that you will retaliate, at cost to yourself, without calculating whether it is worth it — they leave you alone.

That belief is what honour is.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Culture of honour:** a social system in which a person's or family's reputation for retaliating against insult and injury functions as their main protection, in place of law.
>
> The essential feature is that the response must be *disproportionate and unhesitating*. A man who weighs up whether a small insult is worth fighting over has already lost the protection, because he has shown he calculates. The whole value lies in being known not to.
>
> Why it matters here: this is not backwardness or emotion. It is a functioning security system, and it is rational for exactly as long as no better one is available.

6.2 — Herders and thieves

Honour cultures are not evenly distributed. They cluster, and the clustering has an explanation.

Compare two kinds of property. A field cannot be stolen. Somebody can occupy it, which is visible, slow and contestable, but they cannot take it away in the night.

A herd of animals can be. Livestock walks. It can be moved fifty kilometres before morning, and it is difficult to prove which goat was yours.

So herders face a security problem that farmers do not. Their entire wealth is portable, and in the absence of a state, the only defence is deterrence. Herding societies across the world — the Mediterranean, the Middle East, Central Asia, the Balkans, the mountains of Europe, the American frontier — show markedly more honour-related violence than neighbouring farming populations.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The strongest evidence is not historical but experimental, and it was done on students.

Researchers in the 1990s recruited male university students in the American Midwest, some raised in the South and some in the North. Each was sent down a narrow corridor where a stranger, working for the experimenters, bumped into him and called him an insulting name.

What they found: the Northern students mostly shrugged it off. The Southern students showed sharp rises in stress and dominance-related hormones, judged the insult far more seriously, and behaved more aggressively in unrelated tasks afterwards. The effect appeared in the body, not only in what people said.

The historical link: much of the American South was settled by herding populations from the borderlands of Britain and Ireland. The South's higher homicide rate is concentrated specifically in killings that arise from arguments and insults, not in killings committed during robberies — exactly the signature the theory predicts.

What it cannot show: that herding ancestry is the cause rather than something correlated with it — slavery, poverty, and frontier conditions are all candidates and all present. And these were students in one country in one decade. The cross-cultural pattern is suggestive rather than decisive.

6.3 — Why the reputation was stored in a woman

Now the step that concerns this series, and it is the one that is rarely spelled out.

If a family's safety rests on its reputation, then reputation is capital. It has to be maintained, displayed, and defended. And a reputation needs a *signal* — something visible that outsiders can check.

Here is the problem with most signals: they are easy to fake. A man can claim to be fierce. He can carry a weapon he has never used. Talk is cheap and everybody knows it.

A family's control over its women is different, and this is the uncomfortable core of the chapter. It is **continuously visible, expensive to maintain, and impossible to fake.** Whether a daughter is out after dark, who she speaks to, how she dresses, whether she married the man she was told to — all of it is observable by every neighbour, every day, without anybody having to investigate.

So a woman's conduct becomes the display on which the family's standing is read. Not because anybody decided her behaviour was morally central, but because it was the most reliable signal available in a society with nothing else to go on.

And that explains the feature of honour systems that otherwise makes no sense: **the punishment is wildly out of proportion to the act.** If the offence were the sexual behaviour itself, a smaller response would do. But the offence is a public demonstration that the family cannot control its own household — which is a demonstration that it cannot enforce anything, which is a demonstration that it can be robbed.

The violence is not aimed at the daughter. It is aimed at the audience.

> **THE ARGUMENT — IS HONOUR CULTURE RATIONAL OR PATHOLOGICAL?**
>
> Describing something as a functioning system invites the accusation of defending it, so let us have the argument openly.

IT IS RATIONAL

In the absence of enforceable law, deterrence is the only available protection, and deterrence requires a credible reputation. Families operating this way survived and prospered; families that did not were preyed upon. Calling it irrational is the comfortable judgement of people who have never lived a day without a functioning police force, and it explains nothing.

IT IS PATHOLOGICAL

The system produces enormous, permanent costs — dead daughters, ruined lives, endless feuding — for a benefit that is largely defensive against other people running the same system. Two families locked in mutual deterrence are both worse off than if neither played. Calling that rational is to confuse individual logic with collective disaster. It is a trap, not a solution.

IT IS BOTH, WHICH IS THE ACTUAL FINDING

Each family behaving this way is doing the sensible thing given what the others are doing. The result for everybody is worse than an alternative none of them can reach alone. It is rational at the level of the household and catastrophic at the level of the society, and both statements are true at once.

Where things stand: the third position is standard and correct. What follows from it is more interesting than the argument itself. A trap of this kind cannot be escaped by persuading individuals, because no individual family can safely stop first — and that is exactly the structure Part One described in the collapse of foot-binding, where the escape came from families binding themselves *together* rather than one at a time.

What would settle it: whether honour violence declines when the state becomes capable of enforcing law. Broadly it does — but slowly, and much more slowly than the state's arrival, which tells us the system outlives the problem it solved. Chapter Nine takes that up.

Why people care so much: because “rational” is heard as “justified”. It is not. Part One, Chapter Four: explaining a mechanism does not endorse it, and no fact about how something works produces a conclusion about whether it should continue.

6.4 — Honour in India

India's version has a feature that the Mediterranean and Middle Eastern cases mostly lack, and it makes the Indian system harder to dismantle rather than easier.

In most honour cultures, the offence is a woman's sexual behaviour as such. In India, the most severely punished offence is frequently something more specific: marrying the wrong person. Outside the caste. Inside the wrong sub-group. Against a family's arrangement.

This points at a different machine. It is not primarily about paternity or reputation for fierceness. It is about maintaining a *boundary* — keeping a group closed by controlling who may marry whom. Part Three is entirely about that machine, because it is the specifically Indian one and it is the most powerful thing in this series.

On the numbers, I have to report a gap rather than a figure. India's official crime statistics recorded honour-related killings only as a distinct category relatively recently, and the recorded totals are strikingly low — dozens per year in a country of 1.4 billion. Researchers and organisations working in the field give estimates in the high hundreds or above.

I am not going to pick a number between those, because I cannot justify one. What I will do is apply the rule from Part One: **when a state has the power to count something and the count comes back implausibly small, the absence is itself a finding.** A killing recorded as a suicide, an accident, or a simple murder does not appear in this column. Neither does a girl who was never reported missing.

REMEMBER THIS

Where there is no reachable law, the only protection is other people's belief that attacking you is expensive. That belief is **honour**, and it must be unhesitating — a man who visibly calculates has already lost it.

Honour cultures cluster among **herders**, because livestock can be stolen and land cannot. Insulted Southern American students in one experiment showed measurable hormonal spikes where Northern students shrugged — and the South's excess homicide is specifically in killings arising from arguments, exactly as the theory predicts.

A reputation needs a signal that cannot be faked. Control over a family's women is **continuously visible, expensive, and impossible to fake** — which is why a family's standing came to be stored in a daughter's conduct.

That also explains why the punishment is so wildly out of proportion. The offence is not the act. It is the public demonstration that the family cannot enforce anything — **the violence is aimed at the audience, not the daughter**.

It is rational for each family and catastrophic for all of them together. Which means no single family can safely stop first, and the escape has to be collective.

India's version punishes marrying the wrong person most severely of all. That is not a paternity system. It is a boundary system, and Part Three is about what it is keeping out.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Societies That Did It Backwards

Property through daughters. Husbands who visit rather than move in. Children who belong to their mother's line. All of this existed, some of it in India, some of it within living memory — and knowing exactly how it ended matters more than knowing it existed.

7.1 — Kerala

Among the Nayar communities of Kerala, until the twentieth century, the arrangement worked roughly like this.

The household was a large joint family traced through women — mother, her daughters, her daughters' children, and her brothers. Property belonged to this household as a whole and passed down the female line. It was managed, in practice, by the eldest male, who was typically the mother's brother.

Marriage as most readers understand it did not exist. A woman entered relationships that could be ended by either party without formality or shame. The men in these relationships did not move in, did not own her, and did not support her children. Her children were raised by her household — by her, her sisters, and her brothers.

So a man's economic and paternal role went not to his own children but to his sister's. He was a maternal uncle first and a father second, and the system asked nothing of him as a father at all.

Now notice what that does to Chapter Three. The verification problem simply disappears. Nobody needs to know who fathered a child, because nothing is being transmitted through fathers. There is no reason to restrict a woman's sexual behaviour to protect an inheritance, because the inheritance does not travel that road.

And, as far as the record shows, the restrictions were correspondingly light.

WORD BOX

Matrilineal: a system where descent, family membership and property pass through the mother's line.

Matriarchal: a system where women hold political power.

These are constantly confused and they are not the same. Most matrilineal societies are *not* matriarchal — men typically still hold formal authority, but they hold it as brothers and uncles rather than as husbands and fathers. There is no well-documented human society in which women held political power the way men do in patriarchal ones.

Why it matters here: the honest claim is not that these societies were run by women. It is that **they solved the inheritance problem without controlling women's sexuality**, which is a narrower claim and a much more useful one.

7.2 — Meghalaya, Sumatra, Yunnan

Kerala is not an isolated curiosity. There are others, and several are alive now.

The Khasi, Jaintia and Garo of Meghalaya, in India's north-east, remain matrilineal today. Children take the mother's clan name. Among the Khasi, ancestral property passes to the youngest daughter, who also takes on the care of her parents. A husband typically moves into his wife's household rather than the reverse — which inverts the north Indian pattern where a bride is sent away to a village of strangers.

The Minangkabau of West Sumatra are the largest matrilineal society on earth. Ancestral land passes through women and cannot be sold by men. Houses belong to the female line.

IN REAL TERMS

How large is “the largest matrilineal society on earth”? Somewhere in the region of six to eight million Minangkabau people.

That is roughly the population of Hyderabad. More than Denmark. More than Singapore.

This is worth pausing on, because matriliny is usually presented as a handful of small tribal groups that prove nothing about how a real society can be organised. A population the size of a major city, with cities of its own, universities, a written literature and a long trading history, is not a curiosity. And there is a second thing about the Minangkabau that Chapter Eight is going to need: **they are Muslim, and have been for centuries.**

The Mosuo of Yunnan, in south-western China, are much smaller — some tens of thousands — but the arrangement is the most striking. There is no institution of marriage. A woman may receive a partner at night who returns to his own mother’s house in the morning. Children belong to the mother’s household and are raised by her and her brothers. The partner may be known to everybody or not; either is acceptable.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both camps hear about these societies and make the same mistake. They assume the choice is between **rules** and **no rules**.

The traditionalist hears “no marriage, no restriction on women’s partners” and concludes: chaos, a society without structure. The reformer hears it and concludes: freedom, a society that escaped the machinery.

Neither is right, because these are not unregulated societies. They are heavily regulated societies regulating *different things*. The Mosuo have strict rules about who may not be a partner, about the absolute obligations of a brother to his sister’s children, and about how a household is run. Khasi inheritance is not a free-for-all; it is a specific rule about a specific daughter. The Minangkabau have elaborate law governing ancestral land.

What changed is not the quantity of regulation. It is **who is regulated and in which direction.** In a patrilineal system a woman’s sexual behaviour is constrained and a man’s obligation to his sister’s children is loose. In a matrilineal one, that is reversed: a man’s obligations are heavy and fixed, and her behaviour is her own.

> The general form: **reading an unfamiliar structure as an absence of structure.** It is the same error a foreigner makes on first seeing a caste system and concluding there are no classes because there are no classes he recognises.

7.3 — Why matriliny keeps collapsing

Here is the fact that stops this chapter from being a comfortable story. Matrilineal societies have been disappearing for centuries, almost everywhere, and they have not been replaced by anything more equal. They are replaced by patrilineal systems.

Anthropologists have a name for the internal tension that makes them fragile.

> WORD BOX
>
> **The matrilineal puzzle:** the structural strain in any matrilineal system caused by a man being pulled in two directions. His formal duties are to his sister's children, who share his lineage. His affection and daily life are with his own children, who do not.
>
> Why it matters here: this is not a flaw somebody could fix. It is built into the design, and it becomes acute the moment a man acquires wealth of his own that he could choose to pass on.

That last sentence is the mechanism. As long as property is ancestral land held by the lineage, there is nothing for a man to redirect. But once he can earn — a salary, a business, land he bought himself — he has something that is his, and the obvious person to leave it to is the child he lives with and loves.

So markets, wage labour, individual property and colonial law tend to dissolve matriliny from the inside. Not by conquest. By making fatherhood, in the ordinary modern sense, something a man can afford to want.

7.4 — Who dismantled the Nayar system

The Kerala case is documented well enough to answer this precisely, and the answer is uncomfortable for everybody.

The dismantling ran across roughly eighty years of legislation, beginning under British administration in the 1890s, continuing through provincial acts in the 1910s, 1920s and 1930s, and completed by the Indian state in 1975 with an act that abolished the joint household entirely and converted its property into individual shares.

Three forces drove it, and only one of them is the one people expect.

Colonial law could not process it. British courts needed to identify an owner, an heir and a husband. The Nayar system supplied none of these in a recognisable form. Cases were decided by fitting the arrangement into English categories, and the fitting deformed it.

Colonial and missionary opinion found it scandalous. Nayar women's sexual autonomy was described in the language of immorality, and educated Indians defending their civilisation against that charge had an obvious incentive to distance themselves from it. This is a pattern Part Three examines in detail, because it is the single most under-appreciated fact about modern Indian sexual conservatism.

And Nayar men campaigned for the change. This is the part usually left out. Men who had earned money, or taken a modern profession, wanted to leave it to their own children rather than to their sisters'. They wanted to be husbands and fathers in the way the surrounding world was organised. Reform associations pressing for the abolition of the matrilineal household were substantially staffed by the men it had privileged in one way and constrained in another.

So the system did not fall to an invader. It was pushed by outsiders, embarrassed by a colonial gaze, and pulled apart from inside by men who wanted a different relationship with their own sons.

7.5 — What this establishes

Precision matters here, because this chapter is easy to over-claim from.

It establishes: that the inheritance problem in Chapter Three has more than one solution, that at least one alternative works at the scale of millions of people, and that the specific arrangement now defended as natural and timeless is one option among several that human beings actually built and ran.

It does not establish: that matriliny is better for women overall. Matrilineal is not matriarchal; men still held authority in all of these societies. Meghalaya today has an organised men's movement campaigning against the matrilineal system on the grounds that it marginalises them — which tells you both that the system is real and that it produces its own resentments.

And it does not establish that any of this could be adopted. These systems are not menu items. They collapse when wage labour and individual property arrive, and wage labour and individual property have arrived nearly everywhere.

The honest summary is narrow. The claim "there is no other way to organise this" is false, and we can prove it is false, because other ways existed and one of them was in Kerala within the lifetime of people still alive.

REMEMBER THIS

Among the **Nayar of Kerala**, property passed through women, husbands did not move in, and a man's obligations were to his sister's children. The verification problem from Chapter Three simply vanishes — and the restrictions on women vanished with it.

Others exist now: the **Khasi and Garo** of Meghalaya, the **Mosuo** of Yunnan, and the **Minangkabau** of Sumatra — six to eight million people, the size of Hyderabad, and Muslim.

Matrilineal is not matriarchal. Men still held authority; they held it as brothers and uncles instead of husbands and fathers. The claim is narrow: these societies solved inheritance **without controlling women's sexuality**.

They are not unregulated. They regulate different people in different directions — heavy fixed obligations on men, and her behaviour left to her.

They keep collapsing, because once a man earns something of his own he wants to leave it to the child he lives with. Markets dissolve matriliny from inside.

The Nayar system was ended by colonial courts, by embarrassment at a colonial gaze, and by Nayar men who wanted to leave their money to their own sons. Not by an invader — by all three at once.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Religion Arrived Late

Every rule in this part is older than every scripture now cited to support it. That is a statement about dates, not about faith — and what follows from it is more interesting than either the believer or the critic expects.

8.1 — The dates

Start with the chronology, because it is not in dispute and it does most of the work.

Farming, heritable property and the machinery of Chapter Three are in place from roughly twelve thousand years ago, developing over the following several millennia.

The scriptures now cited in these arguments are all far younger. The Vedic corpus is composed across roughly the second and first millennia before the common era. The Manusmriti is later still. The Hebrew Bible is assembled over centuries in the first millennium BCE. The New Testament belongs to the first century CE, the Quran to the seventh.

So the property system, the inheritance problem, the marriage payments and the honour mechanism were all running for thousands of years before any of these texts existed. Whatever those texts did, they did not start this.

Here is a single fact that makes the point sharper than any argument.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Assyrian law tablets from roughly three thousand two hundred years ago — well over a thousand years before Christianity and nearly two thousand before Islam — contain regulations on veiling.

What they say: respectable married women and daughters were *required* to veil in public. Slaves and prostitutes were *forbidden* to. A slave woman caught veiling faced serious punishment.

What this shows: that veiling, in its earliest legally recorded form, was not primarily about modesty or piety. It was a **status marker** — a uniform announcing which women belonged to a household with standing and which were available. The prohibition on the poor wearing it is the giveaway. You do not ban the poor from being modest. You ban them from displaying a rank they do not hold.

What it cannot show: that this is the origin of every later veiling practice. Customs are reinvented and reinterpreted, and the meaning a practice has for a person today is not fixed by what it meant in Assyria. It shows that the practice is older than the religions it is now attached to, and that its earliest recorded purpose was social rank.

8.2 — Same faith, opposite arrangements

The strongest evidence that doctrine is not driving this comes from putting communities of the same religion side by side.

Islam. The Minangkabau of Sumatra have been Muslim for centuries and are the largest matrilineal society on earth, with ancestral land passing through women. Pashtun communities in Afghanistan and Pakistan are Muslim and among the most strongly patrilineal and restrictive societies documented. Same faith, same core text, opposite kinship systems, opposite treatment of women's property and autonomy.

Hinduism. Chapter Four already noted the divide inside India. Northern communities show village exogamy, seclusion norms and a bride sent far from her own kin. Kerala had the Nayar arrangement in Chapter Seven. Same religion, same scriptures, both regarding themselves as fully orthodox.

Christianity. The same Church presided over regions with dowry and regions without, over communities where widows remarried freely and communities where they did not, over places where women held and traded property and places where they could not.

Now apply the reasoning from Part One. If doctrine were the cause, then a constant — the text — would have to explain a variable — the practice. It cannot. This is the identical logical point made about biology in Chapter One, and it fails for the same reason.

8.3 — What religion actually does

If scripture did not create these rules, what did it do? Something significant, and worth naming precisely.

It codified. A custom becomes a written rule. Writing it down freezes it, makes it portable across regions, and removes the flexibility an oral practice had.

It supplied a justification that cannot be examined. This is the largest change. Before, the honest answer to "why must I?" was: because of the land, because of your brothers' marriages, because of what the neighbours will say. Those are all contestable. Afterwards the answer becomes an appeal to an authority beyond audit — and Part One, Chapter Two showed that a rule and its justification are separate objects. Religion supplied a receipt that no one could check.

It provided enforcement without a police force. An internalised rule is enforced by the person who holds it, at no cost to anybody. That is a technology of extraordinary efficiency, and Chapter Six explains why a society without a functioning state would find it valuable.

And it sometimes restrained. This must be in the ledger too, or the chapter is dishonest. Religious law in a number of traditions established a woman's right to inherit something where custom gave her nothing, capped what could be demanded, granted a wife rights within marriage that local practice denied, and set limits on what a husband could do. Read against a modern standard these provisions look meagre. Read against the customs they replaced, several were improvements, and in some places the enforcement of religious law against local custom remains the more favourable option for women.

> **THE ARGUMENT — DOES RELIGION CREATE THESE RULES OR RECORD THEM?**
>
> This is the most bitterly fought question in the part, and both sides have something.

RELIGION IS THE CAUSE

Whatever the deep origins, doctrine is what people actually cite, obey and enforce now. Billions organise their lives around these texts. A woman prevented from working is not being stopped by a Neolithic property system; she is being stopped by a father quoting a verse. Treating the text as a passive record ignores that it is the operative instruction in the room.

RELIGION IS DOWNSTREAM

The same texts produce opposite arrangements in different places, which is exactly what you would expect if local material conditions were selecting which passages get emphasised. Communities read into their scripture what their economy already required. The verses cited in Sumatra and in Kandahar come from one book.

IT IS A RATCHET

Religion did not originate these rules, and it did not merely record them either. It took local, negotiable customs and converted them into non-negotiable ones — portable across regions, immune to argument, enforced from inside. That is a genuine causal contribution: not creating the rule, but changing its *hardness*.

Where things stand: the third position fits the evidence best. The chronology rules out origination. The variation within each faith rules out simple determination. What is left is a real and substantial effect on how firmly a rule is held and how difficult it becomes to change.

What would settle it: tracking what happens to gender norms when a population converts. Where this has been studied, practices frequently persist through conversion with new justifications attached — which supports the third position and is hard to reconcile with the first.

Why people care so much: because both sides think the whole moral question rides on this. The believer fears that “your rules came from farming” means the faith is fraudulent. The critic hopes it means exactly that. Both are making the genetic fallacy from Part One, Chapter One — judging a claim by its parentage — and the origin of a practice settles nothing about the truth of a religion.

8.4 — Where I have to be careful

The front matter promised I would flag my own position where it could bend the writing, and this is one of those points.

There is a well-worn genre in India in which a writer uses an argument like this one to attack a particular religion while sparing others. It is extremely common, it is usually dishonest, and the tell is asymmetry — the chronology applied to one tradition and quietly not to the rest.

So let me state the finding without a target. **Every religion discussed here inherited these rules rather than inventing them, every one of them has communities that read the same text in opposite directions, and every one contains provisions that restricted women and provisions that protected them.** If any part of this chapter reads as though one tradition is the problem, I have written it badly, and I would want to know.

REMEMBER THIS

Farming, heritable property and the inheritance problem were running for **thousands of years** before any scripture cited in these arguments existed. Whatever the texts did, they did not start this.

Assyrian law from over three thousand years ago required respectable women to veil and **forbade slaves and prostitutes from doing so**. That is not a modesty rule. It is a uniform marking rank — and you do not ban the poor from being modest.

The same faith produces opposite arrangements. The **Minangkabau are Muslim and matrilineal**; Pashtun communities are Muslim and strongly patrilineal. Kerala and north India share scriptures and ran different systems. A constant cannot explain a variable — the same logic that limited biology in Chapter One.

What religion did do is real: it **codified** a custom into a fixed rule, supplied a justification nobody could audit, and moved enforcement inside the person, where it costs nothing. It also, in places, restrained what custom permitted, and that belongs in the ledger too.

Religion is best understood as a ratchet. It did not create these rules and it did not merely record them. It changed how hard they were to undo.

CHAPTER NINE

The Audit

Part One said that a rule justified by a solved problem is a fence around an empty field. This part has now identified the problems. Here they are, scored one at a time, honestly — including the ones still standing.

9.1 — The method

Chesterton's fence tells you to find out why the fence was built before removing it. We have now done that. So the next question is the obvious one, and almost nobody asks it: **is the problem still here?**

I am going to go through them one at a time and score each as solved, partly solved, or still standing. I will not fix the scores to produce a tidy conclusion, and the result is genuinely mixed — some of these fences are around empty fields, and some are not.

9.2 — Problem one: nobody can verify who the father is

Score: solved. Completely, and recently.

Genetic fingerprinting was demonstrated in 1985. A paternity test in India today costs something in the range of an ordinary mobile phone and returns an answer in days.

This is the central problem of Chapter Three — the one that generated the whole apparatus — and it has been technically eliminated within the lifetime of most people reading this. Four thousand years of institutional machinery was built to manage an uncertainty that a laboratory now removes for a few thousand rupees.

Notice, though, what has *not* happened. No society has responded to this by dismantling the rules. Not one. If the rules existed to solve the verification problem, and the verification problem is solved, the rules should be relaxing. They are not, and §9.9 takes up what that tells us.

9.3 — Problem two: land divided among heirs becomes unfarmable

Score: largely solved by other means.

This was a real problem, and Part One used it as an example. It has been substantially addressed by instruments that do not require disinheriting anybody: land markets that let holdings be consolidated, mortgages and partnerships, tenancy arrangements, and above all the fact that most people no longer make their living from a field at all.

Indian agricultural holdings have nonetheless been fragmenting for decades, so this is not a solved problem in the sense of a problem that vanished. It is solved in the sense that *restricting women is not the instrument anybody would now reach for*, and no one arguing about a daughter's clothing is thinking about plot sizes.

9.4 — Problem three: disease

Score: largely solved, and one exception.

The major bacterial infections that historically made sexual contact genuinely dangerous became curable with antibiotics from the 1940s. Barrier contraception is cheap and available. Viral infections remain a real risk and are not eliminated, though several are now manageable or preventable.

What has changed most is the *shape* of the risk. It used to be uncontrollable and often fatal. It is now controllable at low cost by anybody with information and access — which converts it from a reason to restrict a person into a reason to inform them. Those are different responses to the same fact, and Part Thirteen has data on which one actually works.

9.5 — Problem four: pregnancy outside a supporting arrangement

Score: technically solved, practically not.

Reliable contraception exists and is inexpensive. That is a genuine solution to the biological problem.

But a solution nobody can reach is not a solution, and here the Indian picture is honest and unflattering. Access is uneven, information is patchy, unmarried women face real barriers to obtaining contraception, and a great deal of the burden falls on female sterilisation after childbearing rather than on preventing unwanted pregnancy in the first place.

So this fence has a gate in it, and in much of the country the gate is locked. That is a fact about health systems, not about the rule.

9.6 — Problem five: a woman abandoned has no way to live

Score: partly solved, and this is the weakest link in the whole audit.

This was among the strongest original justifications, and I want to give it full weight. In a society where a woman could not own property, could not earn, and had no state to fall back on, her security ran entirely through a man. In that world, rules protecting a marriage were, whatever else they were, also protecting her survival.

What has changed. Indian law has given women inheritance rights, strengthened substantially in 2005 when daughters were given equal rights in ancestral property. Wage employment exists. Divorce and maintenance law exists.

What has not changed enough. Indian women's participation in paid work is strikingly low for a country at this income level, and the practical enforcement of inheritance rights against family pressure is weak — a legal right a daughter is shamed out of claiming is a right on paper. Maintenance awards are slow and often unpaid.

So the honest verdict is that the replacement has been *designed* and only partly *built*. This is the asylum problem from Part One, Chapter Three, and it is the single strongest argument the cautious side has in this entire part. It deserves to be conceded rather than argued around.

9.7 — Problem six: there is no law you can reach

Score: partly solved.

Chapter Six showed that honour is a security technology for people without a state. India has a state, police and courts, which is a genuine difference from the conditions that produced the system.

But reach is uneven, tens of millions of cases sit pending, and for many people the practical cost of using the formal system exceeds what the dispute is worth. Where that is true, the older technology remains in use — not from nostalgia, but because it is the one that functions.

9.8 — Problem seven: who will feed you when you are old

Score: not solved. Not close.

This one is rarely discussed and it may be the most important on the list.

India has no meaningful universal old-age pension. For the overwhelming majority of Indians, the arrangement for old age is: your children look after you. And under a patrilineal system, "your children" in practice means your son, since a daughter leaves for another household and her obligations follow her.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Think of a son, in this system, as a pension policy. It is the only one most Indian families have ever been offered.
>
> Now think of a daughter in the same accounting. She costs eighteen years of food and schooling, then a dowry running to several years of household income — and then the return on all of it goes to a different family.
>
> Set the two side by side and the arithmetic is brutal and clear. This is not a story about people hating girls. It is a story about a **retirement system with only one instrument in it**, and a family being asked to buy the instrument that does not pay out.
>
> Which is why a state pension is, in cold terms, a policy about sex ratios — and why Part Twelve counts what happens where it is absent.

So this fence stands, the field behind it is not empty, and no amount of arguing about attitudes will move it. It would be moved by a pension.

9.9 — Problem eight: keeping the group closed

Score: not solved — and it is the wrong category.

Every other item on this list is a hardship somebody wanted removed. This one is different. Maintaining caste boundaries is not a problem people were suffering under. It is a *goal* that a great many people still actively hold.

You cannot solve a goal with technology. A DNA test does not help. A pension does not help. As long as a substantial number of people want a boundary maintained, the machinery for maintaining it has a live constituency — and in India that machinery runs through controlling who women may marry.

This is the answer to the puzzle in §9.2 — why the rules did not relax when paternity testing arrived. They did not relax because paternity was never the only load on them, and in India it was arguably never the main one.

Part Three is about that machine in full.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> This entire chapter — and the fence argument that motivated it — rests on a premise that has been sitting underneath the whole part: **that a rule persists because of the problem it solved.**
>
> Both camps need it. The reformer audits the original problems and expects the rule to fall when they are gone. The traditionalist defends the rule by pointing at the original problem. Both treat the founding purpose as the thing holding it up.
>
> But rules acquire new supports as they age, and the new ones are often stronger than the original. A practice becomes a mark of identity — proof of who we are against who they are. It becomes a source of status for those who enforce it. It becomes an industry with people employed in it. And it accumulates the most powerful support of all: **everybody who already paid the price.** A woman who gave up what she wanted, and whose sisters did, has an enormous stake in that cost having meant something.
>
> Which means the audit in this chapter may be answering the wrong question. Finding out why the fence was *built* tells you nothing about what is *holding it up now*. Those can be — and after four thousand years usually are — entirely different sets of hands.
>
> The general form: **mistaking a thing's origin for its current cause.** Knowing why a war started tells you very little about why it is still going.

That does not make the audit worthless. Knowing the field is empty is worth having, because it removes an argument from the table. It simply means the removal of an argument and the removal of a fence are two different jobs, and this part has only done the first.

REMEMBER THIS

Solved: paternity uncertainty, completely, since 1985, for the price of a phone. Land fragmentation, by other instruments. Disease, largely, since antibiotics.

Partly solved: unwanted pregnancy — the technology exists and the access does not. Destitution after abandonment — the law has been written and the economy has not been built, which is **the strongest argument the cautious side holds**. Weak law — a state exists, its reach does not.

Not solved: old age. India has no real pension, so a son *is* the pension and a daughter is a cost whose return goes elsewhere. That is arithmetic, not prejudice, and it would be changed by a pension rather than by an argument.

Wrong category: keeping the group closed. That is not a hardship anybody wants removed. It is a goal many still hold, and no technology answers a goal.

The verification problem was eliminated forty years ago and not one society relaxed its rules in response. That is the finding of this chapter.

Because knowing why a fence was built tells you nothing about whose hands are holding it up now — and after four thousand years, those are never the same hands.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, with no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about the origins of these rules, with the reason it is unknown. And what is solid enough to build the next fourteen parts on.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

This part deals with events that left no witnesses and, for most of the period, no writing. The unknowns are correspondingly large.

Which came first, the property or the rules. This is the central gap. Chapter Three's chain is plausible and well supported, but in the archaeological record property systems and kinship rules appear together, and no method currently separates them. It is entirely possible that societies which already restricted women found it easier to develop concentrated heritable wealth, rather than the reverse. The plough study in Chapter Four is the best attempt at an answer and it is not clean.

What women in these societies actually thought. This is not a small gap; it is a hole in the middle of the subject. The ethnographic and historical record was overwhelmingly produced by men, who mostly interviewed men, in societies where women's worlds were frequently closed to outsiders. Where a women's account survives it is usually late, written by an elite, and shaped by whoever was listening. We are reconstructing a system from the testimony of the people it privileged.

Whether foragers tell us anything about the deep past. Chapter Two's argument box could not be resolved. Every foraging society studied in modern times occupies land that farmers rejected, after thousands of years of contact with agricultural neighbours.

Why the male genetic bottleneck happened. The signal is solid. The interpretation is not. Whether it reflects a few men monopolising reproduction or whole patrilineal lineages being wiped out together is unresolved, and the two imply quite different societies.

How much of the plough effect is the plough. Wheat regions also grew states, cities, armies and writing. Separating the tool from its companions has not been done convincingly.

Whether any of the alternative systems could function now. Matriliny exists, so it is possible. It also collapses reliably when wage labour and individual property arrive, and both have arrived nearly everywhere. Whether a modern society could sustain such an arrangement is untested, because none has tried.

10.2 — Solid

That control over women tracks heritable, immobile wealth. This is the strongest finding in the part. It holds across the ethnographic record, across historical societies, within farming societies, and inside single countries. It is not one study; it is a pattern that keeps reappearing in independent bodies of evidence, which is the strongest kind of support available outside a laboratory.

That the biological asymmetry is real and that it does not determine the rules. Both halves are solid. Paternity uncertainty was a genuine and universal condition until 1985. And societies facing that identical condition built opposite institutions — the Barí distributed fatherhood, the Nayar routed inheritance around it. A constant does not explain a variable.

That the practices predate the scriptures cited for them. This is chronology, not interpretation. The dates are not in dispute. Assyrian veiling law is over three thousand years old and its earliest recorded function was marking rank, not piety — the ban on slaves veiling settles that.

That the same faith supports opposite arrangements. The Minangkabau exist, are Muslim, are matrilineal, and number in the millions. Kerala and north India shared scriptures and ran different systems. These are facts about living populations, not reconstructions.

That gender norms outlive the conditions that produced them by many generations. The migrant finding in Chapter Four establishes this even if the specific mechanism is contested. Something is transmitted through families, across an ocean, and shows up in employment statistics.

That the verification problem is solved and nothing relaxed. Both halves are simply observable.

That India banned dowry in 1961 and it expanded. Observable, documented, and the most useful single fact in the part for anybody who believes legislation is the lever.

10.3 — The shape of this archive

One closing observation, in the pattern set in Part One.

Look at what this part could be built from. Property law, inheritance records, legal codes, crop suitability data, genetic samples, marriage payments — all of it material, countable, and mostly generated by administration.

Now notice what is almost entirely absent. What any of it felt like. Whether the arrangement was resented or accepted. What was said between women in rooms men did not enter.

That absence is not random. Administrative records survive because states and households had reasons to keep them, and states and households were interested in property. Nobody was recording the other thing, because nobody with the means to write thought it was information.

So this part can tell you with real confidence how the machine was built and almost nothing about what it was like to be inside it. **That is a limitation of the evidence and it should be read as one — not as a finding that the inside was quiet.**

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: whether property produced the rules or the reverse. What women in these societies actually thought — the record was made by men, about men, for men. Whether foragers tell us anything about the deep past. Why the male genetic bottleneck happened. How much of the plough effect is the plough. Whether any alternative system could work now.

Solid: that control over women tracks heritable immobile wealth, across every body of evidence available. That the biological asymmetry is real and does not determine the rules. That the practices predate the scriptures cited for them. That the same faith supports opposite arrangements, in populations alive today. That these norms survive migration by generations. That paternity became verifiable in 1985 and nothing relaxed. That India banned dowry and it grew.

And note what this archive is made of: property, law, payments, crops, genes. All of it countable, all of it kept because somebody had a financial reason to keep it. What it cannot tell you is what any of it felt like — and that silence is a gap in the record, not evidence that the inside was quiet.

Timeline

From the first planted seed to the laboratory that solved the problem it created. Dates before writing are approximate and contested; the further back, the wider the error.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
c. 300,000 BP	Anatomically modern humans. For the next ninety-six per cent of the story, nobody owns land, a granary or a herd.
c. 10,000 BCE	Farming begins independently in at least half a dozen regions among people with no contact. The field cannot be carried. Settlement, storage, surplus and permanent inequality follow.
c. 5,000 BCE	Beginning of the collapse in male genetic diversity, visible across Africa, Europe and Asia while the female line holds steady. A world newly organised around male descent lines.
c. 4,000 BCE	The ard, the earliest plough, in use in Mesopotamia. Field labour shifts towards men wherever the soil suits wheat and barley rather than sorghum and millet.
c. 1,200 BCE	Middle Assyrian law tablets require respectable women to veil and forbid slaves and prostitutes from doing so. The earliest recorded veiling law is about rank, not piety.
c. 1500–500 BCE	Composition of the Vedic corpus. Every rule in this part is already thousands of years old.
c. 200 BCE – 200 CE	The Manusmriti is compiled. Later cited as the origin of rules that long predate it.
7th c. CE	The Quran. Within a few centuries Islam reaches Sumatra, where the Minangkabau adopt it and keep their matrilineal inheritance. They still have both.
1896–1933	Colonial and provincial legislation begins dismantling the Nayar matrilineal system in Kerala, pressed by British courts that could not process it and by Nayar men who wanted to leave property to their own sons.
1940s	Antibiotics enter mass production. The major bacterial diseases that made sexual contact genuinely dangerous become curable.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
1956	The Hindu Succession Act gives Indian women inheritance rights. Custom continues to override it in practice for decades.
1961	India bans dowry. Over the following decades it spreads to communities that never practised it and rises in real value.
1970	A Danish economist publishes the observation that women's economic position tracks whether their ancestors farmed with a hoe or a plough. It takes forty-three years to test.
1975	The Kerala Joint Hindu Family System (Abolition) Act ends the matrilineal household in law. Roughly eighty years from the first colonial statute to the last Indian one.
1985	Genetic fingerprinting is demonstrated. For the first time in the history of the species, paternity can be established with certainty. **Not one society relaxes its rules.**
2005	India amends the Hindu Succession Act to give daughters equal rights in ancestral property. Enforcement against family pressure remains the difficulty.
2013	The plough hypothesis is tested and holds — including among the grandchildren of migrants, four thousand years and one ocean from the field.
↓	**Part Three starts here — with the one machine this part could not explain: why the most severely punished offence in India is not sex, but marrying the wrong person.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared; this page is a convenience, not a requirement.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Bridewealth	Payment from the groom's family to the bride's. The more common of the two worldwide. Appears where women's labour produces visible wealth.
Bride service	A young man working for his wife's family, often for years, in place of a payment. Common among foragers. Note the direction: labour flows towards her family.
Culture of honour	A system where a family's reputation for unhesitating retaliation replaces law as their protection. Clusters among herders, whose wealth can be stolen.
Dowry	Payment from the bride's family to the groom's. Appears with plough farming, stratification and monogamy. Functions both as a daughter's early inheritance and as a bid in a competitive marriage market.
Ethnographic record	The body of descriptions of several hundred societies collected by anthropologists and coded into comparable categories. Powerful for spotting patterns; compromised by having been written mostly by colonial-era men who interviewed men.
Heritable property	Wealth that outlives its owner and must pass to somebody — land, buildings, herds, stored grain. The single most important concept in this part.
Hoe cultivation	Farming with hand tools, often shifting between cleared patches. Interruptible, compatible with childcare, and historically done heavily by women.
Kinship system	A society's rules for who counts as family, who may marry whom, and who inherits. Every society has one; they differ enormously.
Matrilineal	Descent, family membership and property passing through the mother's line.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Matriarchal	Women holding political power. Not the same as matrilineal, and far rarer — arguably never documented in the form men hold it.
Matrilineal puzzle	The built-in strain in matrilineal systems: a man's formal duties are to his sister's children while his affection is with his own. It becomes acute the moment he has wealth of his own to redirect.
Mitochondrial DNA	Genetic material passed only from a mother to all her children. Used as a measure of how many women were reproducing in a past population.
Parental investment	Anything a parent does for one offspring at the cost of doing it for another. The sex investing more per offspring is generally choosier; the sex investing less generally competes.
Partible paternity	The belief that a child can have several biological fathers, all carrying real obligations. Documented in lowland South America, where extra fathers measurably improved child survival.
Patrilineal	Descent, family membership and property passing through the father's line. The arrangement most of this series examines.
Plough agriculture	Farming with a heavy blade drawn by an animal. Requires sustained strength and grip, cannot be easily interrupted, and pushes field labour towards men.
Sedentism	Living permanently in one place. A consequence of farming, and the origin of both dense settlement and continuous mutual surveillance.
Y chromosome	Genetic material passed only from father to son. Used as a measure of how many men were reproducing in a past population.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

I am not an anthropologist, an archaeologist or an economist. What I do is read the published record carefully, set out what each side claims and what evidence it actually holds, explain it in language nobody has to fight, and refuse to hand down a verdict where the evidence does not produce one. The limits of that are worth stating: I am synthesising other people's fieldwork and other people's statistics, not producing new findings.

On this subject I have a further limitation, stated in Part One and repeated here. I am an Indian man writing about rules that have never been applied to me. In this part it bites in a specific place — Chapter Eight, where the chronology of religion is regularly used in India as a weapon against one tradition while sparing others. I flagged that in the text and applied the argument to every faith discussed. If I have failed at it anywhere, I want to know.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the law tablet, the genome, the crop map, the experiment — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not, and that answer is worth more than a manufactured conclusion.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record in anthropology, archaeology, genetics, economic history and law, rather than new primary research. Where I have described a specific study, I have said what it measured, what it found and where its limits lie.

The archive here is lopsided in a way that shapes everything above. Material evidence is abundant: law codes, land records, marriage payments, crop suitability, genomes. These survive because states and households had financial reasons to keep them. Evidence about what any of it felt like is almost absent, and the ethnographic record that comes closest was largely produced by colonial-era European men who interviewed men. Chapter Ten sets this out plainly rather than burying it, because the silence in this archive is systematic and could easily be mistaken for a finding.

Dates before writing are approximate. Where a figure is contested I have given the direction of the disagreement rather than picking a number that looks authoritative. The genetic bottleneck in Chapter Three is the clearest case: the signal is solid and the magnitude is model-dependent, and I have said so rather than quoting a striking ratio.

Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who know a region or a field better than I do. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Three — The Indian Machine. This part explained rules that exist nearly everywhere. The next one explains the machinery that exists here, and it is not the one most Indians think it is.

- Chapter Six found that India's most severely punished offence is not sex but marrying the wrong person. What is being protected, and why does it require a woman rather than a man?
- A hundred years ago an Indian scholar worked out the mechanism that keeps caste alive, and concluded it runs entirely through the control of women's marriages. Was he right, and why is his answer so rarely quoted by people who quote him constantly?
- Khajuraho exists. So does the Kamasutra. So did the Nayar system, within living memory. How does a civilisation with that record end up regarded — by its own people — as the world's most sexually conservative?
- What happened in the nineteenth century to Indian attitudes about women's bodies, who was in the room, and how much of what is now defended as ancient tradition is roughly as old as the railway?
- A British woman published a book in 1927 attacking Indian society through its treatment of women. The Indian response to it shaped Indian gender politics for a century. What did it do, and is it still doing it?
- And the question this part could not touch: if the machinery is about boundaries rather than paternity, then what exactly is on the other side of the boundary — and who benefits from it staying there?

END OF PART TWO OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Three —
The Indian Machine

A twenty-five-year-old working out, in 1916, that caste survives through a single mechanism — and that the mechanism runs entirely through women.

Plus the uncomfortable question of how much of what is now defended as ancient Indian modesty was written in London.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Part Two went looking for where the rules about women came from, and found a chain that runs through property rather than through morality. A field cannot be carried. It has to be inherited. A man wants it to go to his children and — until 1985 — could not verify which children those were. Societies solved that verification problem in one of three ways, and the one that spread was the one that let a man pass wealth to children he raised while staying confident they were his. That solution is called controlling the woman.

We also found the limits of that story. The biology is real and explains almost none of the variation: societies facing identical facts built opposite institutions, including several in India where property passed through daughters and nobody cared who a woman slept with. We found that a farming tool still predicts women's employment four thousand years later, even among the grandchildren of migrants. We found that dowry is a bid in a marriage market, which is why banning it in 1961 made it grow. And we found that religion did not create these rules — it arrived thousands of years too late — but converted negotiable local customs into non-negotiable ones.

Then Part Two ended on an audit, and the audit left two problems standing. One was old age: India has no real pension, so a son *is* the pension and a daughter is a cost whose return goes to another family. The other was stranger. Paternity became verifiable in 1985 and not one society relaxed anything. Which means paternity was never the only load on the machine — and in India, it may never have been the main one.

This part is about the other load. It is the part where the series stops describing rules that exist nearly everywhere and starts describing the machinery that exists **here**.

Two things in it will be unwelcome, and they will be unwelcome to opposite people. The first is that the mechanism which keeps caste alive was identified in 1916, by an Indian, in precise terms, and it runs entirely through the control of women's marriages — which means the thing most Indians argue about when they argue about caste is not the thing that reproduces it. The second is that a substantial part of what is now defended as timeless Indian modesty can be dated, and some of it has an English birth certificate.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. Here is one live example of each.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Endogamy:** the rule that you must marry inside your own group. Its opposite is exogamy, marrying outside.
>
> Most societies have some version. What makes the Indian case unusual is not that endogamy exists but how many separate groups are simultaneously enforcing it, how small some of them are, and how long it has been running.
>
> Why it matters here: this one word is the subject of the entire part. If you take nothing else from these ten chapters, take this: the Indian machine is an endogamy machine, and women are the component it operates on.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Roughly one Indian marriage in twenty crosses a caste line. That figure has moved very little across decades of surveys.
>
> Put it in a room. Take a hundred married couples at a wedding hall. Ninety-five of them married inside the group they were born into. Five did not.
>
> Now put it against something familiar. In most large countries, the share of marriages crossing whatever the main social boundary is — religion, race, class — has risen substantially over the same period. India's has barely moved. **That is not a leftover. That is a working machine.**

Any number too big to picture gets a body attached — a room, a wage, a walk, a hundred couples.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

You would expect endogamy to be measurable only through surveys, which people can lie to. It turns out to be measurable in blood.

When a group marries only within itself for many generations, everybody inside comes to share a larger portion of their DNA. Geneticists can detect this, estimate how long it has been happening, and identify when a population stopped mixing with its neighbours.

What it shows: across large samples of Indian populations, widespread mixing ends and strict within-group marriage begins somewhere in the range of two to four thousand years ago, and has continued since. Many groups show founder effects — the genetic signature of descent from a small number of ancestors — stronger than those found in Ashkenazi Jewish and Finnish populations, both of which are studied precisely because those effects are pronounced.

What it cannot show: who enforced it, why, or what it felt like. Genetics gives you the fact of the boundary and its approximate age. It says nothing about the machinery, which is what Chapter Two is for.

This box names the actual evidence and then says what it cannot show.

THE ARGUMENT — IS CASTE PRIMARILY ABOUT WORK OR ABOUT MARRIAGE?

A framing question for the part. Almost all public argument in India assumes the first answer.

WORK AND HIERARCHY

Caste is a system of ranked occupations and inherited disadvantage. That is where the damage is: in who gets which job, which school, which house, which treatment from the police. Public policy, reservation, and the entire modern politics of caste address this, correctly, because this is what ruins lives.

MARRIAGE AND BOUNDARY

Occupational ranking is the *output*. The thing that reproduces caste across generations is the rule against marrying out — because a boundary that is never crossed is a boundary that never dissolves. Occupations have changed enormously in a century; the marriage rule has barely moved. Whatever survived that change is the load-bearing part.

Where things stand: these are not competitors. The first describes the harm, the second describes the mechanism. But nearly all Indian public argument concerns the first, and this part is about the second — because a system whose reproduction mechanism is not discussed is a system with a long future.

What would settle it: whether caste identity weakens where inter-group marriage rises. Where it has risen, it does. That is a small dataset and it points one way.

An Argument box appears where people who have studied something genuinely disagree. Each side gets its strongest case.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume that **caste is a thing a person has** — a property of an individual, like a height or a surname.

But nobody has a caste alone. It exists only as a relation between families who will and will not exchange daughters. A single person on a desert island has no caste; a hundred families with a rule about marriage have one between them.

The general form: **treating a relationship as a property.** It matters practically. If caste is a property of persons, then policy addresses persons — quotas, protections, penalties. If caste is a rule about exchange between families, then it survives every policy aimed at individuals, indefinitely, which is roughly what has happened.

This is the signature box. It digs out something both sides take for granted while they fight. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.

Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

Three warnings, and this time they matter more than usual.

This material is politically live in India in a way the previous parts were not. Caste, colonial history and the origins of Indian sexual norms are all currently contested territory, and every finding in this part is already being used as a weapon by somebody. I am going to report what the evidence shows and decline to hand the conclusion to any camp. Where a finding is popular with one side, I will say what that side gets wrong with it too.

The chronology in Chapters Five and Six cuts in more than one direction, and I will point that out where it happens. The finding that some Indian conservatism has colonial origins is used by liberals to argue that the conservatives are not authentic, and by nationalists to argue that pre-colonial India was superior. It supports neither conclusion, and Chapter Nine turns the whole argument back on itself, including on me.

My own position, again. I am an Indian man. I was born into a caste, as everyone reading this in India was, and I have not been on the receiving end of a single rule in this part. In Chapter Two I am going to set out an argument made by B. R. Ambedkar, who was on the receiving end of most of them. His analysis is the spine of this part. Nothing about my reproducing it makes me a good judge of it, and I have tried to present his reasoning rather than my opinion of his reasoning.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The Machine Nobody Names

India argues about caste constantly. It argues about jobs, quotas, discrimination and insult. It very rarely argues about the one rule that keeps the whole thing reproducing itself — and that rule is about women.

1.1 — Not a ladder. A set of closed circles.

Most people, Indian and foreign, picture caste as a ladder. Groups ranked from top to bottom, with occupations attached and privileges distributed accordingly.

That picture captures the harm and misses the machine.

Look instead at what a caste actually *is* in daily practice. Ask what a person cannot do because of theirs, and you find that most of the historical prohibitions have weakened. People of different castes now work in the same offices, eat in the same restaurants, travel in the same carriages, drink the same water. Enormous violations of custom happen in every Indian city, hourly, and nothing collapses.

One prohibition has not weakened. You marry inside.

That is the circle, and the circle is the thing. A caste is not primarily a rank. It is a group of families who will exchange daughters with each other and will not exchange daughters with anybody else. Everything else — the occupations, the ritual rules, the food restrictions — is decoration on that, and much of the decoration has come off in the last century while the frame has not moved at all.

WORD BOX

Jati: the actual unit people belong to and marry within. There are thousands of them, often specific to a region and a language, and they are what people mean in ordinary speech when they say caste.

Varna: the fourfold classical scheme found in ancient texts. Four categories for a country containing thousands of marrying groups.

Why it matters here: arguments about caste in India constantly slide between the two. The texts describe varna. Life is organised by jati. A defence of the texts is not a defence of the system anybody actually lives in, and an attack on the texts does not touch it either.

1.2 — The number that has not moved

How closed are these circles, in measurable terms?

Large household surveys in India have asked married people whether their spouse belongs to their own caste. The answer, consistently, is that around one marriage in twenty crosses a caste line. Estimates differ a little by survey and definition, and the figure has moved only slightly across decades.

Set that beside almost anything else about India over the same period. Literacy transformed. Urbanisation transformed. The share of people working in agriculture collapsed. Life expectancy nearly doubled. Television, then mobile phones, then the internet arrived in villages that had no electricity a generation earlier.

Through all of it, ninety-five marriages in a hundred stayed inside the circle.

Anything that survives that much change is not a residue. It is load-bearing, and something is actively holding it there.

1.3 — A boundary you can read in blood

Here is the part that turns an argument about culture into a matter of physical evidence.

When a population marries only within itself for many generations, its members come to share more of their DNA with each other than with outsiders. This is measurable. From the pattern, geneticists can estimate how long a group has been marrying inside, and when it stopped mixing with its neighbours.

The work has been done on large numbers of Indian populations, and it produces two findings that no survey could give you.

First, there is a date. Widespread population mixing across the subcontinent continues for a long period and then, somewhere in the range of two to four thousand years ago, largely stops. After that, groups marry inside themselves. The boundary has a beginning, and the beginning is not lost in the mists of time; it is roughly datable.

WORD BOX

Founder effect: what happens genetically when a population descends from a small number of ancestors and does not mix with outsiders afterwards. Rare inherited conditions carried by one of those ancestors become common inside the group, because everybody inside is descended from them.

Why it matters here: it converts a social rule into a medical fact. A marriage boundary maintained for eighty generations is not only a social arrangement — it is a mechanism that concentrates inherited disease, and the concentration falls on children who had no part in the rule.

Second, there is a cost. Many Indian groups show strong founder effects — the genetic signature of a population descended from a small number of ancestors. Some show effects more pronounced than in Ashkenazi Jewish and Finnish populations, both of which are studied intensively precisely because their founder effects produce elevated rates of certain inherited diseases.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The method compares stretches of DNA shared between individuals. Two people from a group that has married inside itself for eighty generations share long, distinctive segments that two random Indians do not.
>
> **What it can show:** the fact of a closed boundary, an approximate date for when it closed, and how severe the founder effect is. Independent teams using different samples get compatible answers, which is the strongest kind of support available.
>
> **What it cannot show:** anything about why. Genetics reports that the doors shut. It has nothing to say about who shut them, what arguments were used, or who objected. And the dates carry real uncertainty — a range of two to four thousand years is a range, not a year, and different groups closed at different times.
>
> **The finding that gets least attention:** the recessive disease burden. Marrying inside a small group for a very long time concentrates rare inherited conditions. This is not a moral argument against endogamy. It is a medical consequence of it, it is measurable, and it falls on children.

1.4 — What India argues about instead

Now hold that against the shape of Indian public debate.

Caste is discussed constantly and passionately. Reservations in education and employment. Discrimination in housing and hiring. Violence. Political mobilisation. Representation. Insult and dignity.

Every one of those is real, every one matters, and every one concerns the *output* of the system — the harm it produces in a given generation.

Almost none of it concerns the mechanism by which the system arrives in the next generation. There is no serious mass politics of inter-caste marriage in India. No major party campaigns on it. It is not a manifesto item. Individual couples who cross the line are frequently in danger, and the danger is discussed as a law-and-order problem rather than as the central fact about how the whole structure sustains itself.

I want to be careful here, because this can be read as saying that fighting discrimination is a distraction. It is not, and I do not think that. Discrimination is where the suffering is, and addressing suffering does not require first addressing its cause.

The observation is narrower and stranger: **India has spent a century arguing about caste while leaving almost untouched the one practice without which caste could not exist for another two generations.**

Somebody noticed this in 1916. He was twenty-five, he was sitting in a seminar room in New York, and his explanation of it is the spine of this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Caste is usually pictured as a **ladder**. That captures the harm and misses the machine. Most of the old prohibitions — on shared work, food, water, travel — have weakened enormously. One has not: **you marry inside**.

A caste is best understood as a set of families who will exchange daughters with each other and with nobody else. Everything else is decoration on that frame, and much of the decoration has come off while the frame has not moved.

Roughly **one marriage in twenty** crosses a caste line, and that number has barely shifted through a century in which literacy, cities, work and life expectancy all transformed. Whatever survives that much change is load-bearing.

The boundary is visible in DNA. Widespread mixing stops somewhere between **two and four thousand years ago**, and many groups show founder effects stronger than those in populations studied specifically for their inherited disease burden. That cost falls on children.

India argues about caste constantly and almost never about marriage — which is to say, it argues about the output and leaves the reproduction mechanism alone.

CHAPTER TWO

Ambedkar's Answer

In May 1916 a young Indian student read a paper to an anthropology seminar at Columbia University. In it he worked out why a closed marriage circle produces sati, enforced widowhood and child marriage — not as three cruelties, but as one solution to one arithmetic problem.

2.1 — The problem he started from

B. R. Ambedkar was twenty-five. He would later be the principal architect of India's constitution and the most consequential critic of caste the country has produced. At this point he was a graduate student, and the question he set himself was mechanical rather than moral: *what actually keeps a caste in existence?*

His answer began with a distinction. Many societies have groups. What makes an Indian caste different, he argued, is that the group is **closed by marriage** — and that this closure is not a side effect of the group but the thing that constitutes it. Strip away everything else and a caste is an enclosed circle of marriage. Remove the enclosure and there is no caste left to have.

Then he asked the question that makes the paper remarkable. If you wanted to keep such a circle closed, what would you actually have to do?

2.2 — The arithmetic

Here is the problem, and it is worth working through slowly because everything follows from it.

A closed marriage circle needs its marriageable men and marriageable women to stay roughly in balance. Everyone must be able to find a partner inside. If they cannot, some of them will go outside, and the circle breaks.

Death disturbs this balance constantly. Whenever a married person dies, their spouse becomes surplus — a person of marriageable status, inside the circle, with no partner.

Ambedkar's insight was that the two kinds of surplus create different problems and therefore attract different solutions.

The surplus woman. A widow. She is a problem in two ways. If she remarries outside the group, the boundary is breached. If she remarries inside it, she competes for the limited supply of available men, which leaves some other woman unmarried and pushes *her* towards the boundary. Either way the circle is under strain.

The surplus man. A widower. He creates the same imbalance in reverse. But — and this is the pivot of the whole argument — he is a man, in a society where men hold the power, and a group cannot easily impose a sacrifice on the people who enforce its rules.

2.3 — The three solutions

So what does a society do? Ambedkar answered by looking at the customs that actually existed and asking what problem each one solved.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Sati:** the burning of a widow on her dead husband's funeral pyre. The word is also used for the woman herself.
>
> It was never a universal Indian practice. It was concentrated in particular regions and particular communities, and the numbers involved were small relative to the population — though a small number of very public deaths is exactly what a deterrent requires. It was outlawed in 1829.
>
> Why it matters here: read on its own it looks like an extreme religious observance. Read as part of the argument that follows, it is one of two available answers to a specific problem, and the other answer was applied far more widely.

For the surplus woman, solution one: remove her physically. A widow burned on her husband's pyre is no longer surplus. The practice was never universal in India and was concentrated in particular regions and particular groups — which, as §2.5 shows, is itself evidence for the argument rather than against it.

For the surplus woman, solution two: remove her socially. If you cannot kill her, you can end her existence as a marriageable person. Enforced widowhood does exactly this and does it with precision.

IN REAL TERMS

What enforced widowhood meant in practice, in the communities that enforced it strictly, was a set of rules applied to a woman who might be fourteen.

Her head shaved, sometimes repeatedly. Coloured cloth and ornaments removed, replaced with plain white. Restricted food, often without spices, sometimes one meal a day. Exclusion from weddings, births and festivals, on the grounds that her presence brought misfortune. Frequently confinement to the household of her dead husband's family, working in it without status.

Look at that list as a design problem rather than as cruelty, and notice what every item does. Shaving, white cloth, no ornaments, no festivals **— each one removes a signal of sexual availability.** This is not a set of punishments that happens to be harsh. It is a uniform, and the uniform announces to every family in the circle that this woman is not in the marriage market.

She might live another fifty years inside it.

For the surplus man: give him a girl. Celibacy could be prescribed and largely could not be enforced. So the practical solution was to supply a partner — which means the group needs unmarried girls available at short notice, at any time, which means girls must be married very young, which means marrying them before they are old enough to have any view on the matter.

That is child marriage, arrived at not through any theory about children but as the supply side of an inventory problem.

2.4 — What the argument actually claims

Set out plainly, the claim is this. Sati, enforced widowhood and child marriage are not three separate expressions of contempt for women. They are **three components of one system**, and the system exists to keep a marriage circle closed. Each solves a specific failure mode in the arithmetic.

And that is a much more disturbing account than the one it replaces.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Nearly everybody discussing these customs — those who condemn them and those who explain them away — assumes **that the cruelty was the point**.

> The critic reads sati and enforced widowhood as expressions of hatred or contempt for women. The apologist replies that there was no hatred, that these were spiritual practices, misunderstood by outsiders. Both are arguing about *attitude*.
>
> Ambedkar's account makes attitude irrelevant. In his reading the suffering is not the objective. It is a by-product of solving an inventory problem in a closed group. Nobody has to hate anybody. The arithmetic produces the outcome regardless of what anyone feels.
>
> Notice why this is worse rather than better. Contempt can be argued with — you can change what people feel about a group. **Arithmetic cannot be argued with.** As long as the circle must stay closed, the surplus problem recurs every time somebody dies, and something has to be done with the surplus. Improve everybody's attitude and the problem is exactly where it was.
>
> The general form: **mistaking a by-product for a purpose.** It is the most common error in reading any old institution, and it produces solutions aimed at the wrong thing.

2.5 — Does it hold up?

Ambedkar was working with the anthropology available in 1916, and parts of his framework have not aged well. It is worth separating what has survived from what has not.

> **THE ARGUMENT — WAS AMBEDKAR RIGHT?**
>
> His paper makes two distinct claims: one about how caste *began*, one about what *maintains* it. They have fared very differently.
>
> **THE MECHANISM CLAIM HOLDS**
>
> Three predictions follow from it and all three check out. The customs should be strongest where endogamy is strictest — and they were, being enforced far more severely in groups with the most rigid marriage boundaries and the most property, while many other communities permitted widow remarriage throughout. The marriage rule should outlive the occupational system — and it has, comprehensively. And the genetic evidence should show boundaries closing and staying closed — which it does. A theory that predicts three independent things correctly is doing real work.

THE ORIGIN CLAIM DOES NOT

Ambedkar proposed that Indian society was originally one people, that a priestly group closed itself off first, and that caste spread outward by imitation. Modern genetics and history describe something far messier — a long period of mixing between distinct ancestral populations, boundaries hardening at different times in different regions, and no single point of origin. His account of how it started is a reasonable 1916 hypothesis and is not what the evidence now shows.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE MIDDLE

The functional argument can be correct and still be incomplete. Not everything about widowhood or child marriage reduces to marriage-market arithmetic; ritual purity, property law and simple inherited habit all contributed. Explaining a custom's persistence by its function is a move that can be applied to almost anything, and it needs the specific predictions above to be more than a story.

Where things stand: the mechanism claim is in strong shape and is the most useful single idea in this series. The origin claim should be treated as superseded. Separating them is essential, because his critics attack the second to dismiss the first, and his admirers cite the first while quoting the second.

What would settle it further: systematic comparison of widowhood and marriage-age customs against endogamy strictness across a large number of groups, using historical records. Some of this exists in fragments; nobody has done it at scale.

Why people care so much: because of what follows from it. If the mechanism claim is right, then the remedy for caste is not primarily economic or legal — it is marriage. Ambedkar said exactly that twenty years later, arguing that inter-caste marriage was the only real solvent. That conclusion is inconvenient to nearly everybody, which may be why the paper is honoured far more often than it is used.

2.6 — Why this is barely quoted

Ambedkar is among the most cited Indians in Indian public life. Statues, quotations, parties, holidays. And this particular argument — arguably his sharpest single piece of analysis — is almost absent from the conversation.

Consider who it inconveniences.

It inconveniences anyone defending tradition, because it reframes revered customs as inventory management for a closed group.

It inconveniences caste-based political movements, because it locates the mechanism in the family rather than in the state, and families do not respond to legislation.

It inconveniences reformers who prefer economic explanations, because it says the load-bearing element is who marries whom, not who earns what.

And it inconveniences almost every Indian family, including mine and probably yours, because the remedy it implies is not a policy anyone else has to enact. It is a decision about a daughter, taken at a kitchen table.

REMEMBER THIS

In 1916 Ambedkar asked a mechanical question: what keeps a caste in existence? His answer was that a caste **is** a closed marriage circle, and everything else follows.

A closed circle needs marriageable men and women in balance. Death breaks that balance constantly. Every death produces a **surplus** person who must be dealt with or the boundary leaks.

The surplus woman was removed physically (**sati**) or socially (**enforced widowhood** — the shaved head, white cloth, no ornaments, no festivals: a uniform announcing she is not in the market). The surplus man could not be made to sacrifice, so he was supplied with a girl — which requires girls married young. **That is child marriage as an inventory problem.**

Three customs, one system, one arithmetic problem. And that is **worse** than the cruelty explanation, because contempt can be argued with and arithmetic cannot.

His mechanism claim holds up and predicts three separate things correctly. His account of how caste **started** does not, and should be treated as superseded. His critics attack the second to dismiss the first.

He is among the most quoted Indians alive or dead, and this argument is almost never used — because the remedy it implies is not a policy anyone else has to pass. It is a decision taken at a kitchen table about a daughter.

CHAPTER THREE

How the Rules Travel Downwards

The obvious picture is that the powerful impose restriction on the powerless. In India the movement runs the other way at least as often: groups adopt restrictions on their own women, voluntarily, in order to climb.

3.1 — The picture that does not fit

If a rule is imposed from above, you expect to find it strongest at the top and weakest at the bottom, with the bottom resisting.

That is not what the Indian record shows. For much of the period we can document, communities lower in the caste order permitted things that communities higher up forbade. Widow remarriage was accepted in a great many groups and prohibited in a smaller number near the top. Women in poorer and lower-status communities worked in fields, in markets and in trades, moved in public, and were not secluded — because their labour was needed and the household could not afford to do without it.

So restriction was, in a real sense, a **luxury good**. Keeping a woman out of the fields costs a household her earnings. Only a household that can afford to lose them can buy the status that comes with it.

Which sets up the question this chapter answers. If restriction was concentrated at the top, and if the practices at the bottom were looser, then why did those practices not simply survive as the country changed? Why did they spread *downwards* instead of the freer arrangements spreading up?

3.2 — Climbing by imitation

An Indian sociologist working in the 1950s gave this process a name after observing it in a district of southern India.

WORD BOX

Sanskritisation: the process by which a lower-status group raises its position by adopting the customs, rituals and lifestyle of a higher-status one.

Named by the sociologist M. N. Srinivas in 1952. The word points to the practices associated with Sanskrit textual tradition, but the process is about status rather than about texts.

Why it matters here: it is the mechanism by which restrictions on women *spread* rather than merely persisting. A group that wants to be treated as higher does not petition for it. It changes its behaviour to look like the group it wants to be counted among.

What does a group actually adopt? The list is short and consistent.

Giving up meat. Giving up alcohol. Adopting the ritual markers of higher groups. And — the item that concerns us — changing what its women do.

Specifically: prohibiting widow remarriage where it had been permitted. Withdrawing women from paid work outside the home. Adopting seclusion norms. Switching from receiving a payment for a daughter to paying one, which is the shift from bridewealth to dowry described in Part Two.

Notice that most items on the list are cheap. Giving up meat costs a household very little. Giving up a woman's earnings costs it a great deal — which is precisely what makes it a *credible* signal. Anybody can stop eating meat. Only a household with something to spare can stop needing a woman's wages, and everybody watching knows it.

3.3 — The census made it worse

There is a specific historical accelerant, and it is one of the stranger consequences of colonial administration.

From the 1870s the British began conducting decennial censuses that recorded caste — and, in several editions, attempted to rank castes in order of social precedence. A written, official, national ranking now existed where before there had been thousands of local understandings that varied from district to district.

The response was immediate and rational. Caste associations formed. They petitioned census officials for higher classification. And to support their claims they submitted evidence of their respectability, which meant evidence about their customs — that they were vegetarian, that they did not drink, and that **their widows did not remarry**.

Some associations passed formal resolutions prohibiting practices their members had followed for generations, specifically in order to make the claim. A woman's remarriage stopped being a family matter and became a datum in a national status competition.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The evidence here is administrative paperwork, which is the most reliable kind because nobody generating it was trying to make a point that would matter a century later.
>
> **What it is:** census reports and correspondence, and the petitions caste associations submitted to census officials, along with the resolutions those associations passed and printed. These documents state, in the associations' own words, which customs they were adopting and why.
>
> **What it shows:** that the tightening was deliberate, argued for in writing, and explicitly connected to a claim for higher classification. This is not an inference about motives from a pattern of behaviour. The motive is written down.
>
> **What it cannot show:** how far the resolutions were obeyed. An association printing a rule is not a village following one, and the gap between the two is unmeasured. It also tells us nothing about what the women in those communities said, because they were not the ones petitioning.

This is worth holding beside Chapter Five, where a great deal of Indian sexual conservatism turns out to have colonial fingerprints on it. Here the mechanism is different and more interesting. The British did not prohibit widow remarriage; they abolished sati and legalised widow remarriage. What they did was build a ranking system, and Indian communities then tightened their own rules to score better on it.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Both camps assume that **the people constrained by these rules are reluctant parties to them.**

> The reformer assumes women submit under pressure and would choose otherwise. The traditionalist assumes women accept the rules as right and proper. Both are pictures of a *subject* being acted upon by a rule.
>
> The evidence in this chapter shows something neither expects. Whole communities adopted restrictions on their own women that they had not previously had, voluntarily, at real cost, because doing so raised the standing of everybody in the group — including the women. A woman in a community that has just stopped permitting widow remarriage has gained something real: her family is now treated as higher, her children marry better, her sons' prospects improve.
>
> She has paid for it with the freedom of a future version of herself.
>
> The general form: **assuming that the person who bears a cost did not participate in choosing it.** This is the hardest thing in the part to sit with, and it is why arguments about false consciousness are so common — they exist to dissolve exactly this observation. But dissolving it does not answer it. It says a woman who supports these rules is mistaken about her own interests, which is the identical move the other side makes about women who reject them.

3.4 — The modern version

The process did not end with the census, and this is where it stops being history.

In most of the world, as a country gets richer, more women work for pay. India is a striking exception at the household level: as an Indian family's income rises, the women in it become *less* likely to be in paid work outside the home.

That is a strange pattern until you read it as sanskritisation. Withdrawing a woman from work is a purchase. It buys respectability. When a family cannot afford it, she works; when the family can, she stops, and the family's status rises.

Part Twelve counts what this costs in national terms and the number is large. What matters here is the mechanism, because it explains something that otherwise looks like a paradox: **the restriction is not a hangover from poverty. It is something families buy with their first surplus.**

Which means economic growth, by itself, does not dissolve it. Growth funds it.

REMEMBER THIS

Restriction was concentrated at the **top**, not the bottom. Widow remarriage was permitted in many lower-status groups and forbidden in higher ones. Women in poorer communities worked, moved and were not secluded, because their labour was needed.

That makes restriction a **luxury good**. Keeping a woman out of the fields costs her earnings, so only a household with a surplus can buy the status it brings.

Sanskritisation is the process by which a group climbs by imitating the customs of a higher one. What gets adopted is a short list: no meat, no alcohol, ritual markers — and changing what the group's women may do. Most items are cheap. Giving up a woman's wages is expensive, which is exactly why it works as a signal.

Colonial censuses from the 1870s ranked castes officially, and communities petitioned for higher standing by submitting evidence of their customs. Some passed formal resolutions **banning widow remarriage in order to score better**. The British did not impose that. They built a scoreboard.

And it is still running. In India, as a family's income rises, its women are less likely to work. Restriction is not a hangover from poverty — it is what families buy with their first surplus, which means growth does not dissolve it. Growth funds it.

CHAPTER FOUR

What India Was Actually Like

A country whose temples carry explicit sculpture, whose classical literature includes a manual of sexual technique, and whose Tamil poets wrote about lovers meeting in secret, is now widely regarded — by its own people — as among the most sexually conservative on earth. Both facts are real. Neither means what it is usually made to mean.

4.1 — The evidence people reach for

Three things get cited whenever this argument happens, and all three are genuine.

The temples. At Khajuraho in central India, a group of temples built by the Chandela dynasty around a thousand years ago carries sculpture that includes explicit sexual imagery, on the outside, in public view, on religious buildings. Konark in Odisha, a couple of centuries later, does the same. These are not hidden. They are architecture.

The manual. The Kamasutra, composed in Sanskrit somewhere in the early centuries of the common era, is a systematic treatise on desire, seduction, sexual technique and the conduct of relationships, including material on women's pleasure and a substantial section on courtesans.

The poems. Tamil Sangam literature, from roughly the same era and earlier, includes an entire recognised genre of love poetry with an established set of conventions — among them clandestine love before marriage and elopement, treated not as scandal but as one of the standard situations a poem may describe.

So the claim that Indian civilisation was always sexually restrictive is false, and can be shown false with objects you can go and photograph.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the thing that makes this confusing, put on a single line.

The Manusmriti — the text most often cited for restrictions on women — was compiled roughly two thousand years ago. The Khajuraho temples were built roughly one thousand years ago.

Set that gap against something you can feel. A thousand years is the distance between the Norman conquest of England and today. It is longer than the gap between Khajuraho and the British arrival.

So this is not a civilisation that was one thing and then became another. It is a civilisation that contained a severe legal text and, a millennium later, publicly carved erotic temples, and then a millennium after *that* arrived at the present. **Anybody telling you what "Indian tradition" says about women is choosing which thousand years to stand in.**

4.2 — And here is what it does not prove

Now the correction, because the reformist use of this evidence overreaches badly and the overreach is worth naming precisely.

Temple sculpture is not a photograph of anybody's marriage. The erotic panels at Khajuraho are a minority of the total, they sit within a religious and symbolic programme whose meaning is genuinely disputed, and they were commissioned by a royal dynasty. Elite art tells you what an elite paid for. It does not tell you what happened to a widow in a village fifty kilometres away.

The Kamasutra is an elite urban text. It is addressed to a man of leisure in a city, with money, servants and time. It describes a world of a very small number of people. And it was composed in the same civilisation, in roughly the same era, that produced legal texts of considerable severity towards women. Both existed at once, which is the actual finding.

And "sexually permissive" is not the same as "good for women." This is the error that matters most. A society can be relaxed about sexual imagery, comfortable with courtesans, unbothered by pre-marital love in poetry, and still marry its daughters at ten, forbid its widows to remarry, and prohibit women from owning property. Those are separate variables and they move independently.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT DOES THE EROTIC EVIDENCE ACTUALLY ESTABLISH?

This argument is had constantly in India and almost always badly.

IT SHOWS AN OPEN PAST THAT WAS LOST

Sculpture, literature and manuals from across a millennium show a civilisation at ease with sexuality, discussing it openly in its highest art and its most learned texts. That ease is gone. Something removed it, and Chapters Five to Eight identify what. The present prudery is therefore not authentically Indian and cannot claim the authority of antiquity.

IT SHOWS ALMOST NOTHING ABOUT ORDINARY LIVES

Every item is elite, urban and produced by men. The same period produced restrictive legal codes. Erotic art in a temple may be ritual, symbolic or apotropaic, and even on the most literal reading it tells you what a king commissioned, not what a farmer's daughter was permitted. Reading a nation's sexual culture off its monuments is like reading modern India's off its film industry.

THE FINDING THAT SURVIVES BOTH

What the evidence robustly establishes is **variation** — across region, century, caste and class, within one civilisation, at a scale that no single account of "Indian tradition" can absorb. That is not a weak conclusion. It is fatal to the claim that these rules are timeless, and it is exactly what Part Two predicts if the drivers are material rather than doctrinal.

Where things stand: the third position. The strong reformist reading over-claims and the conservative dismissal under-claims. Variation is the finding, and variation is enough — because a rule defended on the grounds that it has always been this way is refuted by showing that it has not, without needing to prove that the past was better.

What would settle it: evidence about ordinary women rather than elites — property records, court cases, inscriptions naming women as donors. This work is being done and it consistently shows more regional variety than the standard picture allows.

Why people care so much: because both sides want antiquity on their team. That is the genetic fallacy from Part One, and Chapter Nine turns it on this entire part, including on me.

4.3 — The devadasi question

One case deserves separate treatment, because it is the hardest and because both standard versions of it are wrong.

WORD BOX

Devadasi: literally a servant of the deity. A woman or girl formally dedicated to a temple, which placed her outside the ordinary system of marriage, widowhood and inheritance described in Chapter Two.

Why it matters here: being outside that system meant different things at different times. In some periods it meant property, training and a public role that married women did not have. In others it meant no protection at all. The word covers both, which is why arguments using it go in circles.

Devadasis were women and girls dedicated to temples. Over a long history the institution meant different things in different periods and regions. In some, dedicated women held property in their own names, were literate, trained in music and dance, participated in public ritual life, and were not subject to the marriage-and-widowhood system described in Chapter Two. For women of that era those were significant advantages, and they are real.

By the nineteenth century, in most places where it survived, the institution had become something else: a route by which girls from poor and low-caste families were dedicated and then sexually available to men of higher standing, with no exit and no protection.

Both descriptions are accurate for different periods and places, and choosing one is choosing an argument rather than reporting a history.

The campaign to end dedication ran from the 1890s and produced legislation in the 1930s and 1940s. Missionary opinion was involved, which is the fact usually cited to dismiss the campaign as colonial interference. The fact usually left out is who led it: among the most prominent figures was an Indian woman doctor and legislator who came from a devadasi lineage herself, and who pressed the case in an Indian legislative body against Indian opposition.

So this is not a story about foreigners ending an Indian practice. It is a story about a genuinely mixed institution, degraded over time, ended by a campaign in which Indian women from the affected communities were central — and one where the language used against it, drawn from Victorian ideas about respectability, also damaged an entire tradition of women's performing arts that was subsequently reassembled by women of higher caste under a more respectable name.

All of that is true at once. Anybody presenting it as simpler is selling something.

4.4 — The actual finding

Strip away the argument and what this chapter establishes is narrower than either camp wants and stronger than either expects.

Indian practice regarding women has varied enormously — by region, by century, by caste, by class. There were periods and places of considerable openness. There were periods and places of extreme severity. Frequently they coexisted, in the same century, a few hundred kilometres apart, among people who considered themselves to share a religion.

That pattern is not consistent with rules handed down by doctrine, because doctrine did not vary that much. It is entirely consistent with Part Two's account, in which the drivers are property, farming, marriage markets and boundary maintenance — all of which vary exactly this way.

And it means one specific sentence is false, wherever you hear it: **this is how it has always been.** It has not. That is all this chapter needs to establish, and it establishes it comfortably.

REMEMBER THIS

Khajuraho carries public erotic sculpture on temples a thousand years old. The **Kamasutra** is a systematic treatise on desire including women's pleasure. Tamil **Sangam poetry** treats secret pre-marital love as a standard subject. All three are real and photographable.

And none of them proves what it is used to prove. Temple art tells you what a king commissioned. The Kamasutra addresses a wealthy urban man. The same civilisation produced severe legal texts **at the same time**.

Above all: **sexually permissive is not the same as good for women.** A society can be relaxed about erotic art and still marry its daughters at ten and forbid its widows to remarry. Those variables move independently.

The **devadasi** case resists both standard stories. The institution gave some women property, literacy and a public role — and by the nineteenth century had become a route by which poor girls were dedicated and used. The campaign that ended it was led in part by an Indian woman from a devadasi lineage, against Indian opposition.

The finding is variation — across region, century, caste and class, at a scale no single account of "Indian tradition" can hold. That is fatal to the sentence "this is how it has always been," and it does not require the past to have been better.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Victorians Arrive

A great deal of what is now defended in India as ancient modesty can be dated. Some of it was drafted in the 1830s by an Englishman who had been in the country for a few years, and some of it England itself abandoned decades ago.

5.1 — A criminal code written by a committee

India's criminal law was not grown. It was written.

A law commission headed by Thomas Babington Macaulay drafted a penal code for India in the 1830s. It was enacted in 1860 and came into force at the start of 1862. It replaced a patchwork of existing legal systems with a single code applying across the territory — one of the most ambitious pieces of legal drafting ever attempted, and by most accounts an impressive one technically.

It was also, unavoidably, a Victorian document. Its assumptions about sex, decency and public morality were the assumptions of the men writing it, and those men were not Indian.

Two of its provisions matter here.

The provision on so-called unnatural offences criminalised certain sexual acts. Its lineage runs back through English law to a statute of the sixteenth century. It was not a codification of any Indian rule. It was an English prohibition, translated into a new code, and applied to a fifth of humanity. It remained in force, applying to consenting adults, until the Supreme Court of India read it down in 2018 — one hundred and fifty-six years.

The provisions on obscenity are the more revealing case, because of what happened to them afterwards.

5.2 — The test England abandoned and India kept

In 1868 an English court laid down a test for what counted as obscene. The formulation asked whether the material tended to deprave and corrupt those whose minds were open to such influence, and it permitted a work to be judged on isolated passages rather than as a whole. It was, by any modern standard, an extraordinarily broad test — under it, almost any serious treatment of sex could be prohibited.

England moved away from it by statute in 1959.

India adopted it in 1965, in a Supreme Court judgment upholding a conviction over the sale of an English novel, and it remained the operative Indian test for roughly half a century afterwards, before the courts began shifting towards a standard based on contemporary community norms.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> This is not reconstruction. It is a paper trail of dated statutes and reported judgments, all published, all citable, all in English.
>
> **What it shows:** a specific Victorian English legal standard, adopted into Indian law after the English had discarded it, and applied in Indian courts for decades. The judgment adopting it cites the English case by name. There is no ambiguity about the source.
>
> **What it cannot show:** that Indian attitudes were caused by the law. Law and attitude move together and it is genuinely difficult to say which pulls. Indian judges adopting an English test in 1965 were Indians, choosing it, eighteen years after independence. That is a fact about what had already been absorbed, not simply about what was imposed.

There is a further case, and it is the sharpest one in this part, but it belongs in Chapter Six because it concerns a girl who died.

5.3 — Regulating women directly

The colonial state also legislated on women's bodies in a more direct way.

From the 1860s, laws modelled on British legislation provided for the registration and compulsory medical examination of women identified as prostitutes in the vicinity of military stations. Women could be detained, inspected, and confined for treatment. The purpose was the health of soldiers.

Note the structure, because it recurs throughout this series. A problem arising from the behaviour of men was addressed by an apparatus applied to women. Nobody proposed registering and inspecting the soldiers.

Alongside the statutes ran a campaign of a different kind. From the 1890s an alliance of missionary organisations and Indian social reformers pressed against dance performances by professional women and against the temple dedication described in Chapter Four. The vocabulary of that campaign — respectability, decency, the good woman and the fallen one — is Victorian in origin and became fully naturalised in Indian public speech. It is still the vocabulary people use.

5.4 — And the other side of the ledger

Now the correction, because a chapter that only listed colonial impositions would be doing exactly what Chapter Eight criticises.

The same colonial legal apparatus abolished widow-burning in 1829. It legalised widow remarriage in 1856. It raised the age of consent, twice. It restricted child marriage. Every one of these ran against entrenched Indian custom and every one was resisted by substantial Indian opinion.

And Indians were central to all of them. The campaign against sati was driven by Indian reformers. The widow remarriage legislation followed years of argument by an Indian scholar who marshalled scriptural evidence for it. These were not measures done to India by foreigners; they were Indian arguments that used a foreign state as an instrument, which is a different thing and a more complicated one.

So the honest ledger has entries on both sides. The colonial state imported a body of sexual prudery in law and vocabulary. It also forced through liberalisations that Indian society had not managed on its own. Anybody using this history to argue that colonialism was simply the cause of Indian conservatism has to explain the widow remarriage act, and anybody arguing the reverse has to explain the obscenity test.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> The entire argument in this chapter — and the argument it is answering — assumes that **a tradition has one origin.**

The nationalist says: this is ours, it is ancient, it comes from our civilisation. The critic says: no, this is Victorian, it came from England in 1860. Both are arguing about a single point of origin, as though the practice had a birth certificate with one country on it.

Nothing in this part has one origin. What an Indian family enforces about its daughters today is a composite: an endogamy rule that is thousands of years old, marriage-market arithmetic from the medieval period, a status-competition mechanism sharpened by a colonial census, a vocabulary of respectability imported from Victorian England, a legal architecture drafted in the 1830s, and a nationalist meaning attached in the 1920s that Chapter Seven describes.

Those layers came from different centuries and different continents, and they do not agree with each other. What holds them together is not a common source. It is that they all point at the same person.

The general form: **demanding a single origin for a composite object.** The demand is not innocent. Both camps want one, because one origin can be attacked or defended, and a composite cannot.

5.5 — How much of it is colonial?

THE ARGUMENT — IS INDIAN SEXUAL CONSERVATISM A COLONIAL IMPORT?

This claim is made constantly in India, by people who disagree about everything else.

SUBSTANTIALLY, YES

The penal code is dated and its drafters are named. The obscenity test has an English case citation on it. The vocabulary of respectability, the campaigns against performing women, the medical surveillance of prostitutes — all arrive with the colonial state and all can be dated. Meanwhile the erotic sculpture, the manuals and the love poetry described in Chapter Four are indigenous and pre-colonial. Something changed, and the timing is not subtle.

ONLY A LAYER, AND NOT THE IMPORTANT ONE

Every load-bearing element predates the British by a very long way. Caste endogamy closes two to four thousand years ago. Seclusion practices, child marriage, enforced widowhood and dowry are all attested long before any European arrives. The British contributed a legal vocabulary and a set of statutes on public obscenity — which is a real contribution and a shallow one. The machine in Chapters One to Three is entirely indigenous, and blaming colonialism for it is a way of not looking at it.

THE LAYER THAT MATTERED WAS NOT THE LAW

The most consequential colonial contribution may not be any statute. It is that colonial criticism of Indian treatment of women made *defending* that treatment into a patriotic act. That is not a law and cannot be repealed, and Chapters Seven and Eight are about it.

Where things stand: the second and third positions together are the accurate account. The colonial legal layer is real, dateable and comparatively shallow. The mechanism underneath it is indigenous and old. And the most durable colonial effect was not legal at all but political — it welded a set of practices to national identity, where they became far harder to argue about.

What would settle it: comparing Indian regions with different depths of colonial administration on measures of sexual conservatism today, holding other things constant. The princely states versus directly ruled provinces offer a natural experiment nobody has fully exploited.

Why people care so much: because the same finding is used by opposing camps for opposite purposes. Liberals use it to argue that conservatives are not authentically Indian. Nationalists use it to argue that pre-colonial India was superior and that the present should be restored to it. The finding supports neither conclusion — which does not stop either from being drawn.

One thing is worth holding from that verdict before we go on. A finding that both camps can use is usually a finding neither camp has understood, and Chapter Nine returns to this one with a much sharper instrument.

REMEMBER THIS

India's criminal law was **written, not grown** — drafted in the 1830s by a commission headed by an Englishman, enacted 1860. Its assumptions about sex and decency were Victorian assumptions.

The obscenity standard is the clearest case. An English court laid down a very broad test in **1868**. England abandoned it by statute in **1959**. India adopted it in **1965** and applied it for roughly half a century — and the judgment adopting it cites the English case by name.

Colonial law also registered and medically inspected women near military stations, for the health of soldiers. Nobody proposed inspecting the soldiers. That structure — a problem created by men addressed through an apparatus applied to women — recurs throughout this series.

The ledger has entries on both sides. The same apparatus abolished sati, legalised widow remarriage, and raised the age of consent, all against entrenched Indian opinion — and Indians drove every one of those campaigns.

Nothing here has one origin. What a family enforces today is a composite: a rule thousands of years old, medieval marriage arithmetic, a colonial census, a Victorian vocabulary, an 1830s legal code, and a nationalist meaning added in the 1920s. Those layers do not agree with each other. What holds them together is that they all point at the same person.

CHAPTER SIX

Phulmonee

Calcutta, 1890. A girl of about ten died of injuries inflicted by her husband on their wedding night. He could not be convicted of rape. The law that followed produced the fiercest political mobilisation of its decade — and the fury was not about the girl.

6.1 — What happened

Phulmonee Dasi was married, as girls in her community were, before she reached puberty. Her husband was a grown man in his thirties.

On the night the marriage was consummated she suffered internal injuries and bled to death.

The case came to court in Calcutta. The medical evidence was clear about the cause of death. The facts were not in dispute. And the court could not convict him of rape.

The reason was a provision in the penal code described in Chapter Five. Sexual intercourse by a man with his own wife was not rape, provided she was above a stated age. That age was ten. Phulmonee was above it.

He was convicted of causing death by a rash or negligent act and sentenced to twelve months.

6.2 — Where that provision came from

> WORD BOX
>
> **The marital exemption:** a rule in criminal law stating that intercourse by a man with his own wife does not count as rape, whatever she wanted.
>
> The reasoning behind it is that marriage itself constitutes consent, given once and not withdrawable. Note what this implies: not that she agreed on a particular night, but that the question of her agreement stopped being askable on the day she married.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the single clearest case in this part of a rule that is neither ancient nor Indian, is defended as both, and is still in force.

The exemption in question — that a wife cannot be raped by her husband — was not an Indian rule. It came from a doctrine formulated by an English judge in the seventeenth century, holding that a woman gives her consent irrevocably at the moment of marriage and cannot withdraw it.

That doctrine travelled into the Indian Penal Code in 1860 along with the rest of the English legal furniture.

England abolished it in 1991.

India has not. The exemption survived the replacement of the colonial penal code in 2023 — the new criminal law reproduces it, raising the age below which it does not apply to eighteen but otherwise leaving it intact. Petitions challenging it have been before the Supreme Court for years and the matter remains unresolved as this is written. The government's stated position has been that criminalising sex within marriage is unsuited to Indian conditions.

IN REAL TERMS

Lay the dates out in a line, because the shape of it is the point.

A judge in England writes the doctrine in the seventeenth century. It reaches India in **1860**. England throws it out in **1991**. India still has it now.

Put a lifetime against that gap. A woman married in England the year the doctrine fell has an adult daughter today. In India, over the same span, three generations of married women have lived and are living under a rule that the country which wrote it has not applied for thirty-five years.

And when India replaced the colonial code in 2023 — explicitly, in the language used to introduce it, to remove a colonial legacy **— this particular colonial legacy was copied across.**

I want to be careful about what that fact does and does not show. It does not show that the exemption is unpopular in India and imposed from outside; it plainly has substantial domestic support, and that support is the reason it survives. What it shows is something narrower and stranger: a rule that arrived from England, was discarded by England, and is now defended in India as suited to Indian conditions.

6.3 — The Act, and the storm

Phulmonee's death drove a change in the law. In 1891 the age below which the exemption did not apply was raised from ten to twelve.

Twelve. That was the reform.

It produced the largest political mobilisation India had seen on any social question. Public meetings across Bengal and western India. Newspapers on both sides. The most prominent nationalist voice of the era campaigned hard against the measure.

And here is the thing that has to be understood correctly, because getting it wrong makes the whole episode unintelligible. **The opposition was not, in the main, a defence of intercourse with ten-year-olds.** Many opponents said plainly that the practice was indefensible.

Their argument was about sovereignty. A foreign government, of another religion, answerable to nobody in India, was legislating on the domestic and religious practice of a subject population. Accept that, they argued, and you have conceded that Indians cannot govern their own households — which is the whole colonial claim in miniature. Reform was necessary and must come from Indians.

That is a serious argument. It is not a stupid one and it was not made only by cynics. It also had a consequence its makers did not intend.

6.4 — What changed permanently

Before 1891 it was possible in India to be a reformer on the treatment of women and a patriot at the same time, without contradiction. Several prominent figures were both.

After 1891 that combination became difficult, and the difficulty has never gone away.

The reason is structural. Once opposing a reform becomes an act of national self-assertion, supporting the reform acquires the opposite meaning — whatever the supporter intends. An Indian arguing for a higher age of consent was now, whether he liked it or not, arguing on the same side as the colonial government. His opponents did not need to answer his argument. They only needed to point at who else was making it.

That move is the ancestor of the word this series began with. When somebody today says a woman has become westernised, they are performing the manoeuvre first assembled at scale in 1891: not answering the claim, but locating the claimant on the foreign side of a national boundary.

Notice also what this cost the reformers. The 1891 Act was a real improvement on a horrifying baseline. It was also, in the political ledger, a defeat — it confirmed that changes in the treatment of Indian women arrived through foreign power, which is precisely what the opposition said and precisely what made the next reform harder.

The next substantial change came in 1929, when the minimum age for marriage was raised. By then the legislature had a large Indian membership, and the measure was carried by Indians. That is the sequence, and it took thirty-eight years.

REMEMBER THIS

Calcutta, 1890. **Phulmonee Dasi**, about ten, died of internal injuries on the night her marriage was consummated. Her husband could not be convicted of rape, because the code exempted a husband where the wife was above ten. He got twelve months for a rash act.

The exemption was not Indian. It came from a **seventeenth-century English doctrine** holding that a wife consents irrevocably at marriage. It entered Indian law in 1860. **England abolished it in 1991. India has not** — and when the colonial code was replaced in 2023 expressly to shed colonial legacies, this one was copied across.

The 1891 Act raised the exemption age from ten to **twelve**, and produced the largest political mobilisation India had yet seen on a social question.

The opposition was mostly **not** a defence of the practice. It was an argument about sovereignty: a foreign government legislating on Indian households concedes that Indians cannot govern their own. That is a serious argument.

Its unintended consequence was permanent. After 1891, arguing for reform in the treatment of Indian women meant standing on the same side as the colonial state — so opponents no longer had to answer the argument, only point at who else was making it. That manoeuvre is the direct ancestor of the word “westernised.”

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Inner Room

Facing a coloniser who was materially superior, Indian nationalism struck a bargain: concede the outside world, and declare the home the one place where the nation remained undefeated. That bargain is the single most important thing ever done to Indian women, and almost nobody who lives under it knows it was made.

7.1 — The problem

Consider the position of an educated Indian in the second half of the nineteenth century.

The evidence in front of him was humiliating and hard to argue with. The British had better guns, better ships, better medicine, a more effective bureaucracy, railways, telegraphs and a functioning legal system. Indians were being taught in English about the superiority of the civilisation that had conquered them, and much of the specific evidence for that superiority was visible from the window.

To be a nationalist he needed a claim. Not just that foreign rule was unjust — that is easy — but that there was something worth being sovereign *for*. Some domain in which Indian civilisation was not merely equal but better.

Where do you locate it, when the material evidence is all going the other way?

7.2 — The bargain

The answer, worked out across the nineteenth century and articulated most clearly by later historians looking back at it, was to divide the world in two.

WORD BOX

The outer and the inner: in Bengali and other Indian languages the distinction is often put as *bahir* and *ghar* — the world outside and the home.

The nationalist settlement assigned different rules to each. In the **outer** domain — economy, technology, statecraft, science — the West was superior and Indians should learn from it without shame. In the **inner** domain — home, family, religion, and above all women — Indian civilisation was declared spiritually superior and must be protected from contamination.

Why it matters here: this is the moment a woman's conduct stopped being a family matter and became the frontier of a civilisational contest. Everything modern India argues about regarding women runs through this settlement.

Look at how efficient it is as a political move. It concedes exactly the ground that cannot be held, keeps exactly the ground that cannot be inspected, and converts a defeat into a division of labour. The coloniser has the guns; we have the soul. The soul lives at home. Women are at home.

It also produced a specific new figure: the modern Indian woman as nationalism required her. Educated — because an ignorant wife was an embarrassment before the coloniser's gaze — but modest. Capable in the home, active in public life to a controlled degree, and defined by a double contrast. She was not the Western woman, who was portrayed as immodest and selfish. And she was not the coarse woman of the lower classes, who was portrayed as vulgar.

She was, in other words, the nation itself in a sari. Which sounds like a compliment and is a job description.

7.3 — What it cost

The immediate consequence is visible in the historical record and it is startling once you look for it.

IN REAL TERMS

Count the decades of Indian public argument about women.

From the 1810s to the 1890s, the treatment of women is one of the central public controversies in India. Widow-burning. Widow remarriage. Female education. Age of consent. Newspapers, pamphlets, mass meetings, legislation, furious disagreement. Roughly **eighty years** of it.

Then, through the main decades of the mass nationalist movement, it goes quiet as a subject of first-order political dispute. Women enter the movement in very large numbers — that is not in question, and it mattered. But the *question* of what is owed to women inside the household largely leaves the agenda.

Something that occupied eighty years of argument stops being argued about, during the period of the most intense political mobilisation in Indian history. That is not a coincidence and it is not neglect. **It was a settlement.** The question had been answered in advance: the home was already the one part of India that was not defeated, so there was nothing there to reform.

That is a strong claim about an absence, and absences are the easiest thing in history to imagine. So it is worth being explicit about what is actually being counted.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A claim that a subject *stopped being discussed* sounds unfalsifiable. It is not, because the discussion left records.

What the evidence is: newspapers and periodicals, pamphlet literature, the proceedings of political organisations, and legislative records. What was printed, argued and voted on is countable, decade by decade.

What it shows: a subject that generated sustained controversy through the nineteenth century, and then far less as a first-order political dispute during the mass movement, even as women's participation in that movement grew enormously.

What it cannot show: that nobody was discussing it. Household conversation leaves no archive, and women's organisations continued working throughout. The claim is about what the national political argument was *about*, which is narrower than what people cared about — and this is interpretation by historians reading a record, not a measurement.

And the longer consequence is the one that concerns this series.

If the home is the last sovereign territory of a colonised nation, then a woman changing her behaviour inside it is not making a personal choice. She is opening the final gate. Her clothing, her marriage, her movement, her work — every one becomes a national security matter, in the most literal sense the phrase allows.

This is why arguments about Indian women's freedom are so wildly out of proportion to their apparent subject. A dispute about a garment is not really about a garment. Both parties know, without either saying it, that the garment is standing in for something enormous.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everyone in the modern argument assumes **the home is a private space.**
>
> The liberal says: what happens in a family is a private matter, so a woman's choices are hers and the community should stay out. The conservative says: what happens in a family is a private matter, so the state and the courts should stay out.
>
> Both are invoking privacy, and both are working inside a settlement that made the Indian home the most *public* space in the country — the designated site of a contest over civilisation, watched by everybody, standing in for the nation.
>
> Which means a woman appealing to her privacy is appealing to a status that was deliberately removed a century before she was born. It is not that her family fails to respect her private life. It is that in the settlement they inherited, **her private life is the national frontier**, and defending a frontier is what families understand themselves to be doing.
>
> The general form: **claiming a right that the arrangement in force has already spent.** The argument cannot be won by appealing to privacy, because the privacy was traded away for something else — and the thing it was traded for was the self-respect of a colonised people, which is not a small thing and is why the trade has never been reversed.

7.4 — Why it is still running

Colonial rule ended in 1947. The settlement did not, and there are reasons.

Settlements outlive their occasions. Part Two, Chapter Nine established this in general terms: a rule's original purpose and its current supports are different sets of hands. The inner-outer division was built for a specific humiliation, and it has since become simply how a great many Indians understand the difference between what is theirs and what is borrowed.

It is also continuously renewed, because the material asymmetry that produced it has not gone away. The economically dominant civilisation is still elsewhere. Its films, its platforms, its consumer goods and its opinions arrive daily and unbidden. Every one of those arrivals reactivates the original logic: *we take their technology and we keep our home*.

And the settlement has a defender in every household, because it hands ordinary people something valuable. A man with little power in the outer world — no capital, no influence, a job that does not respect him — retains one sovereign domain in which he is the custodian of a civilisation. That is not nothing. Taking it away is not a small ask, and pretending otherwise is why so many arguments about this go nowhere.

REMEMBER THIS

Nineteenth-century Indian nationalism faced a problem: the coloniser was materially superior, and a movement needs a claim to something worth being sovereign for.

The answer was to **divide the world in two**. The outer domain — technology, economy, statecraft — conceded to the West and learned from without shame. The inner domain — home, family, religion, women — declared spiritually superior and protected from contamination.

It is an efficient move: it concedes the ground that cannot be held and keeps the ground that cannot be inspected. And it produced a new figure — educated but modest, defined against both the Western woman and the coarse one. **The nation itself in a sari, which sounds like a compliment and is a job description.**

The immediate cost is visible. Roughly **eighty years** of fierce public argument about women's treatment goes quiet during the most intense political mobilisation in Indian history. Not neglect — a settlement. The home was the one undefeated part of India, so there was nothing there to reform.

Which is why a dispute about a garment is never about a garment. If the home is a nation's last sovereign territory, a woman changing her behaviour inside it is opening the final gate — and both sides know it without either having to say so.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Mother India

In 1927 an American journalist published a book attacking Indian society through its treatment of women. It was propaganda with a political purpose, and most of its specific facts were true. What it did to Indian public life is still doing it.

8.1 — The book

Katherine Mayo was an American writer. In 1927 she published a book about India that became a bestseller in the United States and Britain and one of the most notorious publications in modern Indian history.

Its method was to describe, in detail, the physical condition of Indian women and children. Child marriage and early consummation. Death and injury in childbirth among girls whose bodies were not ready. Maternal and infant mortality. The condition of widows. The treatment of those outside caste society.

Its conclusion was that these conditions arose from Hindu religion and social practice, that they were characteristic of Indian civilisation rather than incidental to it, and that a people organised this way was not fit to govern itself.

That last step is what the book was for.

8.2 — Who wrote it, and why

Mayo had form. She had earlier published a book arguing that Filipinos were unfit for self-government. Her Indian research trip was facilitated by officials of the colonial administration, and her book appeared at a moment when Indian claims to self-rule were under active political consideration in Britain and the United States.

This is not a hidden history requiring detective work. Historians who have gone through the correspondence and the publication record have documented the political context in detail, and the pattern is clear: the book was an intervention in a live argument about whether Indians should govern India, and the condition of Indian women was the instrument.

Gandhi reviewed it and described it, memorably, as the report of a drain inspector — a person who goes through a country looking only at its sewers and then publishes an account of the country. The phrase stuck because it was accurate about the method.

8.3 — And the facts were largely true

Here is where the honest account gets difficult, and where most Indian discussion of this episode stops.

Child marriage was widespread. Girls were being married and their marriages consummated at ages that caused serious injury and death. Maternal mortality was appalling. Widows in many communities lived under the regime described in Chapter Two. Phulmonee had died thirty-seven years earlier and the law had responded by raising the age to twelve.

Indian reformers had been saying all of this, in public, in Indian languages and in English, for a century. The specific horrors Mayo catalogued were not her discovery and were not disputed by the people best informed about them.

So the book was propaganda, written for a political purpose, by an author with a record of writing exactly this kind of thing — and the facts in it were substantially accurate.

Both. At once. That combination is what made it so effective and so damaging.

> **THE ARGUMENT — WAS MOTHER INDIA A LIE?**
>
> Ninety years later this is still fought over in India, and the two standard answers are both incomplete.
>
> > **IT WAS A LIE**
> >
> > The book's purpose was to justify continued colonial rule, its author had a documented record of writing against self-government for colonised peoples, and her access was arranged by the administration. It presented the worst of Indian practice as the whole of it, attributed to religion what was produced by poverty and by law, and omitted everything that did not serve the argument. A work built to mislead is a lie regardless of whether its individual sentences check out.

IT WAS TRUE

Every practice she described was real, documented, and had been denounced by Indian reformers for decades. Girls were dying. The response of Indian public opinion was not to dispute the facts but to attack the author's motives — which is the manoeuvre this entire series began with, applied on a national scale. If the facts were true, the author's purpose is irrelevant to their truth.

BOTH, AND THE COMBINATION WAS THE WEAPON

Accurate facts assembled to support a false conclusion. The facts were real; the claim that they arose from Hinduism as such, characterised the whole society, and proved Indians unfit to govern, was not. And because the facts were real, they could not be refuted — so the defence had to be conducted against the author instead, which is exactly what happened and exactly what a work like this is designed to produce.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is not a compromise but the actual finding. Note what it implies about the argument in Part One, Chapter One. Attacking the messenger is sometimes the only available response — because when the facts are true and the framing is false, there is nothing else to attack. That does not make it good reasoning. It makes it a predictable consequence of a certain kind of attack, and one worth recognising when it happens to you.

What would settle it: nothing further. The facts are documented and the political purpose is documented. What remains is a disagreement about what to call a work that is accurate in its parts and false in its whole.

Why people care so much: because the episode is the founding case of a pattern that has run in India ever since — external criticism of the treatment of Indian women being met with an examination of who is criticising.

8.4 — What it produced

Two effects, running in opposite directions, and both are real.

The first was reform. The controversy mobilised Indian women's organisations, which used it — and used the international embarrassment — to press for change. Two years after the book appeared, Indian legislators raised the minimum age of marriage. Some of the impulse behind that was a determination to demonstrate that Indians could reform themselves without being told to.

So the book, written to prove India unfit to govern itself, contributed to India legislating a reform in order to disprove it. That is genuinely how it happened and it is worth holding on to, because it is the most hopeful thing in this part.

The second effect was a reflex, and it has outlasted the reform.

After 1927, criticism of Indian treatment of women carried a permanent second meaning. However the criticism was framed, and whoever made it, it now had a shape that everybody recognised — the shape of an outsider using Indian women to argue that Indians were backward.

That recognition is not paranoid. It happened, at scale, in a bestseller, for a documented political purpose. The reflex was earned.

But a reflex does not check credentials. Once it exists, it fires at any criticism with a similar shape, including criticism from Indians, including criticism that is entirely correct, including — and this is the part that matters most — criticism from Indian women about their own lives.

Combine that with Chapter Seven and the machine is complete. The home is the nation's last sovereign territory. Criticism of what happens inside it has the shape of a colonial attack. Therefore a woman raising a complaint about her own household is, structurally, in the position of Katherine Mayo — and she will be answered the way Katherine Mayo was answered, by an examination of whose side she is really on.

REMEMBER THIS

In 1927 an American journalist published a book cataloguing the physical condition of Indian women and children — child marriage, injury and death in childbirth, the treatment of widows — and concluded that Indians were unfit to govern themselves.

It was **propaganda with a documented political purpose**. The author had already written against self-government for another colonised people, and her access was arranged by the administration. Gandhi called it a drain inspector's report, which was accurate about the method.

And the facts were largely true. Indian reformers had been saying them for a century. Both things at once — accurate parts, false whole — is what made it so effective.

It produced reform. Indian women's organisations used the embarrassment, and two years later Indian legislators raised the marriage age, partly to prove they did not need to be told.

And it installed a reflex that outlasted the reform: criticism of how India treats its women now carries the shape of a colonial attack. That reflex was earned. But a reflex does not check credentials — it fires at correct criticism, at Indian criticism, and at a woman complaining about her own household, who will be answered not on the facts but by an examination of whose side she is on.

CHAPTER NINE

The Word “Westernisation”

Part One said this word bundles four claims and that the last one does the real work. We can now test it against eight chapters of evidence. The result is that both camps are holding foreign objects and calling them their own — and then the whole argument turns out to be invalid anyway, including mine.

9.1 — The audit

Put every practice discussed in this part into a table and ask a single question of each: where did it actually come from?

PRACTICE	WHERE IT ACTUALLY COMES FROM
Caste endogamy	Indigenous. Boundaries close somewhere between two and four thousand years ago and hold since.
Enforced widowhood	Indigenous and ancient. A solution to the surplus-woman problem in a closed circle.
Child marriage	Indigenous and ancient. The supply side of the same arithmetic.
Dowry	Indigenous in origin — and its modern scale and spread are a twentieth-century development, largely *after* it was banned.
Seclusion norms	Indigenous, pre-colonial, and spread *downwards* through status imitation rather than being imposed from above.
A national ranked caste list	Colonial. A product of the census from the 1870s, which turned local understandings into a national scoreboard groups could compete on.

PRACTICE	WHERE IT ACTUALLY COMES FROM
“Obscenity” as a legal category	English. Statutory architecture from 1860, and a judicial test from 1868 that England dropped in 1959 and India adopted in 1965.
Criminalising certain sexual acts	English, with a lineage back to a sixteenth-century statute. In force in India for 156 years.
A husband cannot rape his wife	English, seventeenth-century doctrine, imported 1860. Abolished in England in 1991. Still Indian law.
Medical surveillance of “prostitutes”	English, imported in the 1860s for the health of soldiers.
The vocabulary of respectability	Victorian. The good woman and the fallen one, decency, vulgarity — naturalised so completely that it now reads as indigenous.
Woman as bearer of national culture	Nationalist, late nineteenth and early twentieth century. A response to colonial humiliation, not an ancient idea.
Treating criticism as foreign attack	Assembled 1891, hardened 1927.
Abolishing sati; legalising widow remarriage	Colonial statutes, driven by Indian campaigns. Foreign instrument, Indian argument.
A woman’s life is hers to direct	As a *political* claim in its modern form: recent, and substantially of European origin. Which is exactly as irrelevant as everything else in this column — see §9.3.

9.2 — What the table shows

Read the column and the neat division collapses.

The conservative is holding foreign objects. The legal architecture within which he prosecutes vulgarity is English. The vocabulary of respectability he uses is Victorian. The scoreboard his ancestors competed on was built in a colonial census office. The doctrine that a husband cannot rape his wife was written by an English judge and thrown out by England thirty-five years ago. A great deal of what he is defending as Indian tradition arrived by ship.

And the liberal is holding foreign objects too. The claim that a person's life belongs to them, that consent is the relevant test, that a family has no standing to direct an adult's choices — as a political demand, in the form now made, this has a traceable European intellectual history. Pretending it is simply what all Indians always wanted is not honest, and Indians hearing it know it is not.

So the argument as normally conducted — *this is ours, that is theirs* — cannot be settled, because both sides are composites and neither can produce a clean pedigree.

And there is a further complication that the table makes visible. The colonial contribution ran in **both** directions at once. The same apparatus that imported obscenity law abolished widow-burning. The same officials whose census tightened caste also raised the age of consent. Anybody who wants a single verdict on what colonialism did to Indian women has to explain both columns, and nobody who offers a single verdict ever does.

9.3 — And now the part where I have to indict myself

Everything above is accurate and most of it is invalid as an argument, and I have been using it anyway.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> This entire chapter — and Chapter Five, and the argument it is answering — assumes that **where a practice came from determines whether it is legitimate.**
>
> That is the genetic fallacy, named in Part One, Chapter One: judging a claim by its parentage rather than by whether it is true. I named it in the first chapter of the series and then built four chapters on it.
>
> Consider what Chapter Five actually establishes. It shows that a body of Indian sexual conservatism has an English origin. What follows about whether those rules are good? **Nothing.** A rule is not made bad by having been drafted in London, and it is not made good by having been written in Sanskrit. If restricting a woman's clothing is wrong, it is wrong whether Manu wrote it or Macaulay did. If it is right, the same.

> So why did I write Chapter Five? Because it is *devastating* — it takes the strongest rhetorical weapon out of the conservative's hand by showing that his tradition has a foreign birth certificate. It wins arguments. It does not establish anything.
>
> And there is a reader-side version of this, which is the more useful half. If Chapter Five was the most satisfying thing you have read in this series, notice what the satisfaction was made of. It was not the pleasure of learning something about whether the rules are justified. It was the pleasure of watching an opponent lose a claim. Part One said to notice which findings you hope are true, because that marks where you are least reliable. This is one of those places, and I built it deliberately.
>
> The general form: **using an invalid argument because it is effective, in a document committed to valid ones.** I am not going to remove the chapter — the history in it is true and worth knowing. I am going to say plainly that it does not do the work it appears to do.

9.4 — What the word actually does

So if origin does not settle legitimacy, what is the word for?

Part One identified four things bundled inside it: a description, a causal claim, a judgement of decline, and a claim about belonging. Eight chapters later we can be specific about each.

The description is often accurate. Some Indian women are behaving in ways more common elsewhere.

The causal claim — that they do so because of foreign influence — is usually wrong, and this part shows why. A woman taking paid work in a city is responding to urbanisation, education and her family's need for income. Those are Indian conditions. Chapter Three showed that the reverse movement, women *leaving* work, is what a family buys when it can afford it. Neither is imitation of anybody.

The judgement of decline is a value, and Part One, Chapter Four says a value has to be argued rather than smuggled inside a noun.

The claim about belonging is the one doing the work, and now we know exactly where it was manufactured. It was assembled in 1891, when opposing a reform became an act of national self-assertion. It hardened in 1927, when accurate criticism arrived inside a hostile book. And it sits on the settlement in Chapter Seven, which made a woman's conduct the frontier of a civilisation.

That is the whole apparatus. When the word is used, all four fire at once, and the fourth is the one that lands — because it does not argue with a woman, it relocates her. She is not wrong. She is *foreign*. And a country that spent two centuries being told it was inferior by foreigners has a well-developed set of responses to that.

REMEMBER THIS

Audit every practice in this part and the clean division collapses. **The conservative is holding foreign objects** — the obscenity law, the vocabulary of respectability, the colonial caste scoreboard, and a marital rape doctrine written by an English judge and abolished in England in 1991.

And the liberal is holding foreign objects too. The claim that a person's life is theirs to direct, in the political form now made, has a traceable European history. Pretending otherwise is not honest and nobody is fooled.

The colonial contribution ran in **both directions at once**: the apparatus that imported obscenity law also abolished sati and legalised widow remarriage.

And then the whole argument is **invalid**. Where a rule came from settles nothing about whether it is good. If restricting a woman's clothing is wrong, it is wrong whether Manu wrote it or Macaulay did. I wrote Chapter Five anyway, because it wins arguments — and if it was the most satisfying thing you have read here, that satisfaction was the pleasure of watching someone lose a claim, not of learning whether the rule is justified.

The word does not argue with a woman. It relocates her. She is not wrong, she is foreign — and a country that spent two centuries being called inferior by foreigners has a very well-developed set of responses to that.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about the Indian machine, with the reason it is unknown. And what is solid enough to carry into the rest of the series.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

This part rests on a mix of genetics, survey data, legal records and historical argument. Each has different failure modes and they do not cancel out.

Whether endogamy is the whole mechanism or one of several. Ambedkar's account predicts three things correctly, which is real support. It does not follow that nothing else contributes. Ritual purity, property law, regional politics and simple inherited habit all plausibly carry some of the load, and nobody has measured their relative weights. A functional explanation that fits is not the same as a functional explanation that is complete.

When exactly the boundaries closed, and why then. The genetic range of two to four thousand years is wide, different groups closed at different times, and the estimates depend on modelling assumptions. What was happening in the subcontinent at the moment of closure — and whether it was one process or many — is not settled.

What India would look like without colonial rule. This is unanswerable and it is worth saying so, because both camps answer it constantly. Whether reform would have come faster from within, or slower, or not at all, cannot be known. The comparison that would help most — princely states, which the British ruled indirectly, against directly administered provinces — has not been systematically exploited on these measures.

Whether status imitation is still the main driver of women leaving work. Chapter Three's account fits the pattern well. So do other explanations: the kinds of jobs available, safety in transport and workplaces, childcare, and the way official statistics count unpaid family labour. Which of these dominates is a live argument among economists and Part Twelve will not resolve it either.

What women thought, at every stage. The same hole as in Part Two, in a sharper form here. The reform debates of the nineteenth century were conducted overwhelmingly by men, on both sides, about women. Where women's own accounts survive they are late, often elite, and shaped by whichever camp was publishing them. Chapter Three's finding — that communities adopted restrictions voluntarily — is drawn from records of decisions in which women's participation is largely invisible. That is a serious limit on how far that finding can be pushed.

Whether the reflex from 1927 can be disarmed. It is real, it was earned, and it now fires at correct criticism from Indians. Nobody knows what dissolves it, and this part offers no method.

10.2 — Solid

That around one Indian marriage in twenty crosses a caste line, and that this has barely moved. Multiple large surveys, decades apart, compatible answers.

That the boundaries are visible in DNA, closed within a datable window, and carry a medical cost. Independent teams, different samples, compatible findings. The founder effects in many groups exceed those in populations studied specifically for their inherited disease burden.

That Ambedkar's mechanism claim makes three correct predictions. The customs were strictest where endogamy was strictest, the marriage rule outlived the occupational system, and the genetic record shows boundaries closing and holding. His account of caste's *origins* is superseded and should be treated separately.

That restriction spread downwards through status imitation, and that colonial censuses accelerated it. Caste associations petitioned for higher ranking and submitted their customs as evidence. Some formally prohibited practices they had permitted. This is documented in the administrative record.

That Indian practice regarding women varied enormously by region, century, caste and class. Khajuraho and the Manusmriti are separated by a thousand years and belong to the same civilisation. That variation is fatal to the sentence "this is how it has always been" and requires no claim that the past was better.

That a specific layer of Indian sexual conservatism has a dateable English origin. Statutes, judgments and case citations, all published. The obscenity test England dropped in 1959 and India adopted in 1965 is the clearest instance.

That the marital rape exemption is English in origin, was abolished in England in 1991, survived India's 2023 replacement of the colonial penal code, and remains in force. Every element is a matter of public record.

That the women's question largely left Indian nationalist politics after roughly eighty years of intense public argument. This is observable in the record of what was debated, and Chapter Seven's explanation of why is the best available.

That Mother India was propaganda and that its facts were largely accurate. Both are documented, and the combination is the finding.

10.3 — Who wrote the record

One closing observation, following the pattern of the previous parts.

Notice what this part could be built from. Genetic samples. Census returns. Statutes and law reports. Caste association resolutions. Newspaper controversies. Legislative debates. Temple sculpture commissioned by kings.

Every single one of those was produced by somebody with power. States counted. Courts recorded. Associations petitioned. Kings commissioned. Newspapers were owned. The archive of the Indian machine is, almost in its entirety, the archive of the people operating it.

There is one exception in this part and it is worth naming. Ambedkar was writing from inside the category the machine was built to exclude. That is not a small thing. It may be the reason he saw the mechanism when others who had studied it far longer did not — and it is a reasonable working hypothesis that the rest of what is missing from this archive would have been visible to people in a similar position, had anybody thought to write it down.

Which is a way of saying: **the thinnest part of the record is the testimony of the people the system was built to act upon, and this is the part of the story that would most change what we think we know.**

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: whether endogamy is the whole mechanism or one of several. Exactly when the boundaries closed and why then. What India would look like without colonial rule — unanswerable, and both camps answer it constantly. Whether status imitation still drives women out of work. What women themselves thought at any stage. Whether the 1927 reflex can be disarmed.

Solid: one marriage in twenty crosses a caste line and has for decades. The boundaries are readable in DNA, datable, and carry a medical cost to children. Ambedkar's mechanism claim predicts three separate things correctly — while his origin claim is superseded. Restriction spread downwards through imitation, accelerated by a colonial scoreboard. Indian practice varied enormously across region and century. A dateable layer of Indian conservatism is English, including a marital rape doctrine England abolished in 1991 and India kept through a 2023 rewrite meant to shed colonial legacies. The women's question left nationalist politics after eighty years of argument. Mother India was propaganda and its facts were largely true.

And notice who made this archive. Genetic samples, censuses, statutes, law reports, petitions, legislative debates, temples commissioned by kings — every source was produced by someone with power. It is almost entirely the archive of the people operating the machine. The one exception in this part is Ambedkar, who was writing from inside the category it was built to exclude, and who saw the mechanism that people who had studied it far longer did not.

Timeline

From the closing of the marriage circles to a doctrine written by an English judge and still in force. Early dates are ranges rather than years, and the uncertainty is genuine.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
c. 2000–4000 BP	Widespread population mixing across the subcontinent ends. Groups begin marrying only inside themselves and continue doing so. The boundary is still readable in DNA today, along with the founder effects it produced.
c. 200 BCE–200 CE	Compilation of the Manusmriti, the text most often cited for restrictions on women.
c. 300 BCE–300 CE	Tamil Sangam poetry, including an established genre treating clandestine pre-marital love as a standard poetic situation.
c. 2nd–4th c. CE	The Kamasutra. A systematic treatise on desire, addressed to a wealthy urban man, in the same civilisation and roughly the same era as the severe legal texts.
c. 950–1050 CE	The Khajuraho temples are built, carrying explicit sculpture in public view — a thousand years after the Manusmriti and a thousand before the present.
1829	Sati abolished, after campaigning by Indian reformers using a colonial state as the instrument.
1856	Widow remarriage legalised, following years of scriptural argument by an Indian scholar.
1860	The Indian Penal Code is enacted, drafted in the 1830s by a commission headed by Macaulay. It carries in an English prohibition on certain sexual acts and an English doctrine that a husband cannot rape his wife.
1860s	Legislation modelled on British statutes provides for registration and compulsory medical examination of women near military stations. Nobody proposes examining the soldiers.
1868	An English court lays down a very broad obscenity test.
1870s	Decennial censuses begin recording and ranking caste. Associations form and petition for higher standing, submitting their customs as evidence — some formally banning widow remarriage to improve their claim.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
1890	**Phulmonee Dasi**, about ten, dies of internal injuries in Calcutta. Her husband cannot be convicted of rape because she was above the age of ten. He receives twelve months.
1891	The age below which the marital exemption does not apply is raised from ten to twelve — and produces the largest political mobilisation India has yet seen on a social question, conducted mainly as an argument about sovereignty.
1890s	The campaign against temple dedication and professional dancing women begins, an alliance of missionary organisations and Indian reformers, using a Victorian vocabulary of respectability.
1916	**Ambedkar**, aged twenty-five, reads a paper in New York setting out why a closed marriage circle produces sati, enforced widowhood and child marriage as one solution to one arithmetic problem.
1927	*Mother India* is published: propaganda with a documented political purpose, and largely accurate in its facts. Dozens of Indian replies follow.
1929	Indian legislators raise the minimum age of marriage, partly to demonstrate that Indians could reform themselves without being told.
1947	Independence. Temple dedication is prohibited in Madras, in a campaign led in part by an Indian woman legislator from a devadasi lineage.
1959	England abandons the 1868 obscenity test by statute.
1965	India adopts it. It remains the operative Indian test for roughly half a century.
1991	England abolishes the doctrine that a wife cannot refuse her husband.
2018	The Supreme Court of India reads down the colonial provision on so-called unnatural offences, 156 years after it came into force.
2023	India replaces the colonial penal code, expressly to shed colonial legacies. The marital rape exemption is carried across. Petitions challenging it remain pending.
↓	**Part Four starts here — and leaves history entirely. It asks how different men and women actually are, measures every difference, and reports the sizes.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared; this page is a convenience.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Bahir and ghar	The outer world and the home. The nationalist settlement gave each different rules: learn from the West outside, keep the inside uncontaminated. Women lived on the inside.
Devadasi	A woman or girl dedicated to a temple. In some periods the arrangement carried property, literacy and a public role; by the nineteenth century it had largely become a route by which poor girls were dedicated and used.
Endogamy	The rule that you must marry inside your own group. The subject of this entire part.
Enforced widowhood	The regime applied to widows in strict communities — shaved head, white cloth, no ornaments, restricted food, exclusion from celebrations. Every element removes a signal of sexual availability. It is a uniform, not a punishment.
Exogamy	Marrying outside a specified group. The opposite of endogamy. Indian kinship typically combines both: marry outside your immediate lineage, inside your caste.
Founder effect	The genetic signature of a population descended from a small number of ancestors. It concentrates rare inherited conditions, and the cost falls on children.
Genetic fallacy	Judging a claim by where it came from rather than whether it is true. Named in Part One and committed deliberately in Chapter Five of this part, as Chapter Nine admits.
Hicklin-type test	The broad Victorian English standard for obscenity, permitting a work to be judged by isolated passages. Abandoned in England in 1959, adopted in India in 1965.
Jati	The actual group people belong to and marry within. Thousands exist, usually regional. This is what Indians mean by caste in ordinary speech.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Marital rape exemption	The rule that intercourse by a husband with his wife is not rape. Written by a seventeenth-century English judge, imported into Indian law in 1860, abolished in England in 1991, retained in India's 2023 criminal code.
Sanskritisation	A lower-status group raising its position by adopting the customs of a higher one — giving up meat and alcohol, and restricting its women. Named in 1952.
Sati	The burning of a widow on her husband's pyre. Never universal, concentrated in particular regions and groups, abolished in 1829. In Ambedkar's reading, one solution to the surplus-woman problem.
Surplus man / surplus woman	Ambedkar's terms. A person left without a partner by a death, inside a closed marriage circle, who must be dealt with or the boundary leaks.
Varna	The fourfold classical scheme in ancient texts. Four categories for a country containing thousands of marrying groups — which is why arguments that slide between varna and jati go nowhere.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

I am not a sociologist, a geneticist or a legal historian. What I do is read the published record carefully, set out what each side claims and what evidence it actually holds, explain it in language nobody has to fight, and refuse to hand down a verdict where the evidence does not produce one.

This part required more care than the previous two and I want to be specific about where. I am an Indian man, born into a caste, writing about a system I have never been on the wrong side of. The spine of this part is an argument made by B. R. Ambedkar, who was. I have tried to present his reasoning rather than my opinion of it, and I have separated the part of his case that has held up from the part that has not, because his admirers and his critics both tend to take the whole thing or none of it.

Chapter Nine contains the sharpest thing in this part and it is aimed at me. I built four chapters on an argument I had already identified in Part One as invalid, because it is rhetorically devastating. I have left them in and said so.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the survey, the genome, the statute, the law report, the census return — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of published work in genetics, sociology, history and law rather than new primary research. Where I have described a specific study, statute or judgment, I have said what it establishes and where its limits lie.

The evidence here is unusually uneven in quality, and it is worth knowing which ground you are standing on at each point. The legal material is the strongest: statutes and reported judgments are dated, published and citable, and nothing in Chapters Five and Six depends on interpretation of a contested source. The genetic material is strong on the fact of endogamy and weak on its timing, where estimates depend heavily on modelling choices. The survey material on inter-caste marriage is good and consistent. The historical argument in Chapters Seven and Eight is interpretation — well supported interpretation, made by historians working from the record, but interpretation, and I have marked it as such rather than presenting it as measurement.

One current fact was checked at the time of writing rather than recalled: the status of the marital rape exemption, which survived the 2023 criminal code and remains subject to pending litigation. If that has changed since publication, the change is more important than the chapter. The systematic gap in the rest is stated in Chapter Ten: nearly every source used here was produced by somebody operating the system rather than subject to it. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who know a community, a region or a field better than I do, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Four — The Bodies Themselves. Three parts of history end here. The next one leaves it entirely and asks a question with numbers attached: how different are men and women, actually?

- Every argument in this series so far has assumed the differences between men and women are small enough that the rules must be explained by something else. Is that assumption correct — and for which differences?
- Some measured differences between men and women are among the largest effects in the whole of psychology, and some are so small they are almost invisible in any individual. Which are which, and how do you tell without being fooled?
- What does an effect size actually look like in a room with a hundred men and a hundred women in it? And why does that picture defeat almost every headline you have ever read on this subject?
- How much of the brain-difference literature survives scrutiny, and how much of it is the kind of finding Part One warned about — published once, never repeated, and quoted for twenty years?
- What is the variability hypothesis, why is it more consequential than any average difference, and why is it almost never discussed outside specialist literature?
- And the question the whole equality argument turns on: what is the difference between *same*, *equal in worth*, and *equal in outcome* — and how many arguments are two people using one word for three ideas?

END OF PART THREE OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Four — The Bodies Themselves

Three parts of history end here. This one asks how different men and women actually are, measures every difference, and reports the size.

Some are enormous. Most are almost invisible. The largest one is not an ability at all.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Three parts of history are now behind us. Part One separated the three claims welded into every defence of these rules — where they came from, what changing them costs, and what you should therefore do — and showed that each needs a different kind of evidence. Part Two found the origin: a field cannot be carried, so it must be inherited, and a man could not verify which children were his. Part Three found the specifically Indian machine, which turned out not to be about paternity at all but about keeping marriage circles closed, and found that a dateable layer of Indian modesty was written in London.

Part Three ended by turning its own argument on itself. Where a rule came from settles nothing about whether it is good. That was the genetic fallacy, named in Part One and then used for four chapters because it wins arguments.

So history has now done what history can do. It has established that these rules are not timeless, that they had functions, that some of the functions are gone and some are not, and that the specific arrangement defended as natural is one option among several that human beings actually built.

What it has not done is answer the question underneath all of it. **How different are men and women, actually?**

That question has been sitting under every chapter so far. Both camps have an answer they need to be true. One needs the differences to be large, because large differences make the rules look like a reasonable response to reality. The other needs them to be small, because small differences make the rules look like an imposition on people who are basically the same.

This part measures them. Every difference, with its actual size, reported at full strength regardless of which camp it helps. Some of what follows is going to be unwelcome to readers who think of themselves as progressive. Some of it is going to be much more unwelcome to readers who think of themselves as traditional, because the largest measured difference is not an ability and does not support a single one of the rules in Parts Two and Three.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. One live example of each.

WORD BOX

Distribution: the full spread of a measurement across a group — not just the average, but how many people sit at every value from lowest to highest.

Almost every mistake in this subject comes from talking about averages when the interesting thing is the spread. Two groups can have the same average and produce wildly different numbers of people at the extremes, and Chapter Four is entirely about that.

Why it matters here: whenever you read "men are more X than women," ask whether the claim is about the middle of the distribution or the edge of it. They are different claims with different consequences.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the picture this entire part is built on. Hold it in your head and you can read any claim about sex differences without being fooled.

A hall with **one hundred men** on one side and **one hundred women** on the other. Somebody walks in, picks one person at random from each side, and measures whatever is being argued about.

The only question that matters is: **how often does the man come out higher?**

If the answer is fifty times in a hundred, there is no difference at all. If it is fifty-five, the difference is real and nearly useless for predicting anything about a person. If it is seventy-five, it is large. If it is ninety, it is enormous and visible from the door.

Every number in this part will be translated into that hall.

Any number too big to picture gets a body attached.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This part rests on a different kind of evidence from the previous three: meta-analyses, large national assessments and population databases rather than law reports and genomes.

What that buys: scale. Several findings here rest on hundreds of thousands of people, and the largest on more than half a million. At those sizes, sampling noise stops being the problem.

What it cannot buy: causation, and it does not cure the problems Part One described. A meta-analysis pools existing studies, so it inherits their biases — including publication bias, where results showing a difference are more likely to be written up than results showing none. And a very large sample makes tiny differences statistically detectable, which is why every number in this part is reported as an *effect size* rather than as whether it reached significance.

The rule I will follow: where a finding rests on one study, I will say so. Where it has been repeated across countries and methods, I will say that too, and I will treat the difference as decisive.

This box names the actual evidence and then says what it cannot show.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD DIFFERENCES BETWEEN MEN AND WOMEN BE RESEARCHED AT ALL?

A framing question, and worth settling before ten chapters of measurement.

THE CASE AGAINST

Findings in this area are reliably misused. They are quoted out of context to justify exclusion, they reach the public stripped of their effect sizes, and the harm from a misread result vastly exceeds the benefit from a correct one. The field also has a documented history of producing confident conclusions that later collapsed, nearly always in the direction of justifying the arrangements of the day.

THE CASE FOR

The claims are being made anyway, constantly, by people with no data at all. A vacuum is not neutral — it is filled by assertion, and assertion favours whoever is louder. Refusing to measure also means being unable to answer, and the specific pattern of “men and women are identical” arguments collapsing on contact with evidence has done more damage to the credibility of equality arguments than any finding ever did.

Where things stand: the second position, with the first taken seriously as a warning about method rather than a case for silence. The correct response to a finding being misusable is to report it with its size attached, which is what this part does and what almost no popular coverage does.

What would settle it: nothing empirical. This is a disagreement about risk, and reasonable people land differently.

An Argument box appears where people who have studied something genuinely disagree.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume **that the answer matters for the political question.**

One side fears the findings because it believes large differences would justify unequal treatment. The other wants the findings because it believes the same thing in reverse.

Part One, Chapter Four already showed this is a bad bargain: no fact about averages produces a conclusion about anybody's rights without an added value, and the added value has to be argued separately. Both camps accepted the bargain and are now fighting over the evidence to protect a moral conclusion neither has defended.

The general form: **arguing about the premise because you have conceded the inference.** Chapter Nine takes this up properly and turns it on this whole part, including on my decision to write it.

This is the signature box. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.

Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

I am not a psychologist, a physiologist or a statistician. I am reading the published literature and reporting it. In previous parts that limitation was manageable because the material was historical. Here it matters more, because the technical questions are genuinely difficult and specialists disagree about several of them. Where they do, I have put the disagreement in an Argument box rather than adjudicating it.

Every number in this part is a group average or a group spread. None of them is a fact about any individual, and Chapter One exists to make that impossible to forget. If at any point a sentence in this part reads as a statement about a person, I have written it badly.

And I have a specific worry about this part that I did not have about the others. The findings here are the ones most commonly quoted, stripped of their sizes, to justify keeping women out of things. I am going to report them anyway, because refusing to look is the moralistic fallacy from Part One and because the claims circulate regardless. But I want to say plainly, before the first number: nothing in this part supports a single rule described in Parts Two and Three. Chapter Nine explains why in detail, and if you only read one chapter, read that one.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

How To Read A Difference

“Men are more X than women” is not a claim. It is the beginning of one. Until you know how big the difference is, the sentence carries no information — and almost everything written about this subject stops before that point.

1.1 — The hall

Put a hundred men on one side of a hall and a hundred women on the other.

Somebody walks in, picks one person at random from each side, and measures whatever is being argued about — height, memory, patience, grip, anything.

The only question worth asking is how often the man comes out higher. That number, and nothing else, tells you what a difference between men and women is worth.

Fifty in a hundred means no difference at all. Fifty-six means a difference that is real and almost useless for predicting anything about a person you have just met. Seventy-one is what researchers call a large difference. Ninety-two is enormous — visible across a room, obvious to a child.

Researchers do not usually report the number that way. They report something called an effect size, and this chapter exists to let you convert one into the other.

WORD BOX

Effect size: a number expressing how big a difference between two groups is, measured against how spread out those groups are.

The version used almost everywhere in this literature is written as **d**. A d of zero means the two groups have the same average. A d of 1 means the averages are one full "spread" apart.

The reason spread has to be involved: a difference of five centimetres is enormous for the width of a hand and trivial for the height of a tree. You cannot say whether a gap is big until you know how much things vary anyway.

Why it matters here: **d is the single most important number in this part.** A headline that reports a difference without it is not reporting a finding; it is reporting that somebody measured something.

1.2 — The conversion table

Here is the table. It is worth returning to, because every number in the next nine chapters will be read through it.

EFFECT SIZE (D)	THE MAN IS HIGHER, OUT OF 100 PAIRS	WHAT THAT MEANS IN THE HALL
0.0	50	Nothing. A coin toss.
0.1	53	Detectable with a huge sample. Invisible in a room.
0.2	56	Conventionally "small". Useless for predicting a person.
0.5	64	Conventionally "medium". You would notice it in a large group and be wrong about individuals constantly.
0.8	71	Conventionally "large". Three times in ten the woman still wins.
1.0	76	Very large for a psychological trait. Almost nothing in psychology reaches this.
1.5	86	The territory of physical measurements.
2.0	92	Obvious. Height sits near here.

EFFECT SIZE (D)	THE MAN IS HIGHER, OUT OF 100 PAIRS	WHAT THAT MEANS IN THE HALL
3.0	98	Nearly categorical. Very few human traits are here.

Look at the row for 0.8 and stay there a moment, because it is the one that does the most damage in public argument.

A “large” difference means that if you pick one person from each group, the woman comes out higher **three times in ten**. That is not a small residue. In a company of a thousand, it is three hundred people.

So a large sex difference in something does not license a rule about who may do it. Even at the top of this table, using sex to predict an individual means being wrong at a rate no employer, teacher or family would accept in any other context.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both camps assume, without ever stating it, **that a fact about a group is a fact about its members.**

One side hears “men are on average stronger” and treats it as a description of the man in front of them. The other side hears the same sentence, understands that it will be treated that way, and therefore attacks the finding rather than the inference.

Both are working inside the same error. A distribution is not a person. The sentence “men are on average taller” is true and tells you almost nothing about whether the man walking towards you is taller than the woman beside him.

Notice what follows for the argument this series is about. Every rule in Parts Two and Three is applied to *individuals* — this daughter, this widow, this woman at a protest. A group average cannot justify any of them, not because the average is false but because **it is the wrong kind of object**. Even a difference at the very bottom of this table would misclassify one woman in ten.

The general form: **reasoning from a distribution to an instance.** It is the most common error in this subject and it is committed by everybody, including by people who could recite this box.

1.3 — What the headlines do

Three specific moves account for nearly all bad coverage of this subject, and once you can name them you are largely immune.

Reporting a difference without its size. "Study finds men and women differ in X." True of almost everything, at almost any sample size, because with enough people even a d of 0.03 becomes detectable. The finding is not that a difference exists. The finding is how big it is, and that number is usually in the paper and not in the article.

Converting an average into a category. "Men are the ones who X." An average difference becomes a statement about kinds, and the enormous overlap disappears. This is the error in the box above, dressed as a headline.

Reporting the exception as the rule, or the rule as the exception. Both directions happen. A single unreplicated study showing a difference gets a headline; so does a single study showing none. Part One's rule applies to both: one study is not a fact.

REMEMBER THIS

Put a hundred men and a hundred women in a hall, pick one at random from each side, and ask **how often the man comes out higher**. That number, and nothing else, tells you what a sex difference is worth.

Effect size (d) is how researchers report it. Convert it: 0.2 means the man wins 56 times in 100. 0.5 means 64. 0.8 — conventionally "large" — means **71**, so the woman still wins three times in ten.

Almost nothing in psychology reaches 1.0. Physical measurements live above 1.5. Height sits near 2.0, which is 92 in 100.

A distribution is not a person. **The rules in Parts Two and Three are applied to individuals, and a group average is the wrong kind of object to justify any of them** — not because it is false, but because even a very large difference misclassifies three women in ten.

"Men and women differ in X" is true of almost everything and means nothing. The finding is always the size, and the size is always in the paper and almost never in the headline.

CHAPTER TWO

The Body

This is where the differences are largest, and there is no honest way to soften them. Physical sex differences are among the biggest measured differences between any two human groups — and the one with the greatest consequence of all runs the other way.

2.1 — Size and composition

Start with the easy one. Men are taller, by something in the region of thirteen or fourteen centimetres on average in most populations. In the language of Chapter One, that is an effect size of roughly two — the man is taller about ninety-two times in a hundred pairs.

Underneath height sit differences that matter more for what a body can do.

Men carry substantially more lean muscle mass and less body fat as a share of weight. The muscle difference is not evenly distributed: it is considerably larger in the upper body than the lower. Men also have larger hearts relative to body size, more circulating haemoglobin — meaning more oxygen delivered per litre of blood — and denser, heavier bones.

Women have, on average, greater joint flexibility, better tolerance of some kinds of sustained low-intensity effort, and different injury patterns rather than uniformly more or fewer injuries.

2.2 — Strength

Strength is where the numbers become extreme, and I am going to report them plainly because rounding them off would be dishonest.

Upper-body strength shows the largest gap. Across studies the male advantage in upper-body strength is commonly in the range of forty to sixty per cent; in the lower body it is smaller, often around twenty-five to thirty per cent, partly because everybody's legs are trained by walking.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Grip strength is the standard measure, because it is cheap, quick and hard to fake, so it has been recorded on very large numbers of people.

One large study of young adults measured grip in over two thousand people in their early twenties. The grip strength of about ninety per cent of the women fell below that of about ninety-five per cent of the men. The study also included highly trained female athletes; their results overlapped with the untrained men, at the lower end of the male range.

What it shows: a difference so large that the distributions barely overlap. In the language of Chapter One this is above the bottom of the table — it is off it. There is no psychological trait in this entire part that comes close.

What it cannot show: anything about training history, which differs systematically between the sexes and is not fully controlled in most such samples. The athlete comparison partly addresses this and does not eliminate it. And grip is one measure; it is not a summary of physical capability.

2.3 — Sport as an accidental experiment

Competitive sport is the best available natural experiment on physical capacity, because it is the one domain where enormous numbers of people are measured on identical tasks under identical rules with maximum motivation.

The results are consistent. In running, the gap between the best men and the best women is roughly ten to twelve per cent. In swimming it is smaller, around six to ten per cent, because water reduces the advantage of mass. In jumping and throwing it is larger. In events dominated by upper-body power it is larger still.

Those percentages sound modest. At the elite level they are not, because the top of any distribution is crowded.

IN REAL TERMS

In 2017 the United States women's national football team — then among the strongest sides in the world, holders of a World Cup — played a practice match against the under-fifteen boys' academy team of a domestic club.

The boys won.

Sit with what that involves. On one side, adult professionals, the best in the world at their sport, with a decade of full-time training each. On the other, boys of fourteen and fifteen who were not among the best of anything and would mostly never play professionally.

A comparable thing happened in tennis in the 1990s, when a man ranked around two hundredth in the world played exhibition sets against each of the two best women in the game and won both comfortably.

This is what a ten per cent difference in the average looks like once you go to the far edge of the distribution. **Chapter Four is about why the edge behaves so differently from the middle**, and it is the most important statistical idea in this part.

2.4 — Where the gap narrows, and where it closes

Now the part usually left out, and it is not a consolation prize — it is evidence about mechanism.

The gap is not constant across activities. It shrinks as events get longer and as raw power matters less. In ultra-endurance events the difference is markedly smaller than in the marathon, and in some very long swimming events women have won outright against mixed fields. In events requiring extreme cold tolerance, women's higher body fat is an advantage rather than a disadvantage.

That variation tells you the gap is not a general fact about capability. It is specific to the demands of a task, and it can reverse when the demands change.

Which sets up the correct way to read this chapter. **The male physical advantage is real, very large, and narrow.** It concerns power, speed and the ability to apply force. That is not a summary of what a human body is for. It is one axis, and it is the axis on which almost all competitive sport happens to be built, which is why sport makes the difference look like the whole story.

2.5 — The difference that kills

There is one more physical difference, it is the largest in consequence of anything in this chapter, and it runs the other way.

Men die younger. In essentially every country on earth, at every income level, under every political system and every religion, female life expectancy exceeds male. The global gap is in the region of five years, and it has been consistently in one direction for as long as reliable records have existed.

It is not a single cause. Male infants die at higher rates than female infants from the first days of life, before any behavioural explanation can apply. Men are more vulnerable to a range of infections. They die more from most major causes of death, at most ages. And they die vastly more from the causes that involve doing something dangerous — which is behaviour, and which Chapter Six takes up.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Five years is hard to feel as a number, so convert it into a household.
>
> Take a couple married at twenty-five, the same age. On average figures, she will outlive him by around half a decade. Multiply that across a country and you get the composition of every old people's home, every widowhood statistic, and a substantial part of why elderly poverty is disproportionately female — a woman is much more likely to reach the age at which savings run out, and to reach it alone.
>
> Now set it against the rest of this chapter. The male physical advantages — more muscle, more power, more oxygen-carrying capacity — are real and large. They come attached to a body that fails earlier, in every population ever measured. **Whatever the male body is optimised for, it is not lasting.**

This belongs in a chapter about physical differences and it is almost never in one, because it does not fit the shape of the argument either camp is having. Part Fifteen counts what it costs in full.

2.6 — And what it does not establish

Two things need saying before this chapter can be used for anything.

Almost no modern work requires the capacities where the gap is largest. The tasks that separate the sexes most sharply are the ones machines took over first. Upper-body power is not what a surgeon, a lawyer, an engineer, a farmer with a tractor or a soldier with modern equipment is primarily selling. Where the requirement is genuine — some emergency and military roles — the honest response is a job-relevant physical standard applied to every applicant, which is a test of the person rather than of the category, and which some women pass and many men fail.

And nothing in this chapter reaches a single rule in Parts Two and Three. Grip strength does not explain why a widow may not remarry, why a woman must marry inside her caste, why she may not go out after dark, or why a photograph of her at a protest was answered with a rumour about her body. The largest measured difference between men and women is irrelevant to every one of them.

That mismatch is worth holding on to for the rest of the part. Whenever somebody reaches for biology to justify one of these rules, ask which measured difference is being invoked and what it has to do with the rule. The answer is usually that the rule was there first and the biology was recruited afterwards.

REMEMBER THIS

Physical differences are the largest in this part and there is no honest way to soften them. Height sits near an effect size of **2.0** — the man is taller 92 times in 100 pairs.

Strength is more extreme. Upper-body strength differs by roughly **forty to sixty per cent.** In one large study of young adults, the grip strength of about nine in ten women fell below that of about ninety-five per cent of men — a gap larger than anything psychological in this entire part.

At the elite edge this compounds. A world-champion women's football side lost a practice match to an **under-fifteen boys' academy team**. That is what a ten per cent difference in averages does at the far edge of a distribution.

But the gap is **narrow as well as large.** It shrinks in ultra-endurance events, closes in some, and reverses where body fat is an advantage. It concerns power and speed — one axis, and the one competitive sport happens to be built on.

And the largest physical difference by consequence runs the other way. **Men die around five years earlier**, in essentially every country, at every income level — starting with higher infant mortality, before behaviour can explain anything. Whatever the male body is optimised for, it is not lasting.

And it reaches none of the rules. Grip strength does not explain why a widow may not remarry or why a woman at a protest was answered with a rumour about her body. When somebody reaches for biology to justify a rule, ask which difference is being invoked and what it has to do with the rule — usually the rule came first and the biology was recruited afterwards.

CHAPTER THREE

The Mind, Measured

Take every mental ability that has been measured and put each one in the hall from Chapter One. Nearly all of them come out close to a coin toss. The exceptions are real, and one of them runs in a direction almost nobody discusses.

3.1 — The general finding is similarity

In 2005 a researcher reviewed forty-six meta-analyses of psychological sex differences — a review of reviews, covering thousands of studies. She found that around **four fifths of the measured differences were small or close to zero.**

That is the headline finding of this field and it is almost never reported as one, because a finding of "not much" does not travel.

WORD BOX

Meta-analysis: a study of studies. Rather than running a new experiment, researchers gather every published study on a question and combine their results into a single estimate.

The strength is scale: a meta-analysis can pool hundreds of thousands of people and drown out the noise that makes any individual study unreliable.

The weakness is that it inherits whatever is wrong with what it pools. Chiefly **publication bias** — the tendency for studies that found a difference to be written up and printed, while studies that found nothing quietly are not. That bias runs one way, and it means a pooled estimate of a sex difference is more likely to be too large than too small.

Why it matters here: most numbers in this part come from meta-analyses. Read every one of them as a probable slight overstatement rather than a floor.

It should be held firmly, because everything that follows is a list of exceptions, and a list of exceptions read on its own gives a false impression of the whole.

3.2 — The list

Here is what has actually been measured, converted into the hall. The final column is how often a randomly picked man scores higher than a randomly picked woman. Fifty is no difference; below fifty means women score higher.

ABILITY	EFFECT SIZE	MAN HIGHER, PER 100 PAIRS
General intelligence	about 0	50
Mathematics (school assessments)	about 0.05	51
Vocabulary	about 0	50
Verbal ability, general	about −0.1	47
Spatial visualisation	about 0.15	54
Verbal and episodic memory	about −0.2	44
Object location memory	about −0.25	43
Perceptual speed	about −0.25	43
Reading	about −0.3	42
Spatial perception	about 0.45	62
Writing	about −0.5	36
Mental rotation of 3D shapes	0.5 to 0.9	64 to 74

Read the middle of that table and the picture is unmistakable. Most of the abilities people argue about most furiously sit within a few points of a coin toss.

3.3 — Mathematics

The maths gap deserves its own section because it is the most confidently asserted difference in this field and the mean difference is, to a very good approximation, nothing.

Large national assessment data covering millions of schoolchildren produces an effect size close to zero. Meta-analyses of the research literature agree. In some countries girls score higher. The average boy and the average girl are, on this measure, the same.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THERE A SEX DIFFERENCE IN MATHEMATICAL ABILITY?

Everybody arguing about this is talking about a different part of the distribution, which is why the argument never ends.

THERE IS ESSENTIALLY NONE

National assessment data on millions of students shows an average difference indistinguishable from zero. It varies by country, and in several countries it favours girls — which no biological account predicts. Where a gap exists, it tracks measures of the society rather than measures of the brain.

THE AVERAGES ARE THE WRONG PLACE TO LOOK

Equal averages are compatible with very unequal extremes, and the extremes are what produce mathematicians. Among American twelve- and thirteen-year-olds scoring at the very top of a difficult mathematics test in the early 1980s, boys outnumbered girls by roughly thirteen to one. That is where the professions come from, not from the middle.

AND THE EXTREME RATIO MOVED

The strongest evidence is what happened next. That thirteen-to-one ratio fell over the following two decades to something in the region of four to one, and has been comparatively stable since. Whatever produced the original figure, a large part of it changed within twenty years — which no account resting on fixed biology can accommodate.

> **Where things stand:** the mean difference is settled and is essentially zero. A difference at the very top is real and is discussed in Chapter Four. And the fact that it shrank by roughly two thirds in twenty years is the most informative single number in this section, because it puts a floor under how much of the original was social.
>
> **What would settle the remainder:** whether the ratio continues to move. It has been roughly stable for some time, which is consistent with either a biological floor or a social one that has stopped shifting. Nobody can currently distinguish those.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because this specific claim has been used to explain the composition of entire professions, and because a stable ratio is read by one camp as nature and by the other as unfinished business.

3.4 — The gap nobody mentions

Now look at the two rows near the bottom of the table, and notice that they run the other way.

In reading, girls outperform boys. This is not a local finding. In international assessments covering dozens of countries, girls have scored higher in reading in **every participating country, in every cycle**. There is no country in the dataset where boys read better.

In writing, the gap is larger still, and on some large national datasets it is the biggest sex difference in academic achievement that has been measured — around half an effect size, which puts it in the hall at roughly thirty-six in a hundred.

Put that beside the maths gap of approximately zero and consider how the two are treated. One is a matter of national concern, funded programmes, and decades of public argument. The other is roughly ten times larger, entirely consistent across countries, and most readers of this document are learning about it now.

I want to be careful about what I am claiming. I am not saying the attention to girls in mathematics was wrong; there were real barriers and the gap in participation was never only about scores. I am saying that the pattern of what gets measured, funded and discussed does not track the size of the difference — which is a finding about us rather than about children, and Part One, Chapter Six predicted exactly this.

3.5 — The one large difference

Mental rotation is the exception at the top of the table, and it is worth being precise about what it is.

The task is to look at a three-dimensional shape, then look at another shape, and decide whether the second is the same object rotated or a mirror image. It is a narrow, specific ability, tested in a laboratory, and the male advantage on it is the largest cognitive sex difference reliably found — depending on the version of the test, somewhere between 0.5 and 0.9, which is sixty-four to seventy-four in the hall.

Two honest qualifications sit next to it.

It trains. Performance on mental rotation improves substantially with practice, including with practice on action video games, and the sex gap narrows when both groups are trained. It does not usually vanish, but a difference that moves with a few hours of training is not a fixed property of anything.

And its real-world reach is smaller than it sounds. Mental rotation correlates with some engineering and technical outcomes, modestly. It is not a general spatial faculty, and other spatial abilities in the table show much smaller differences. A single narrow laboratory task is doing a great deal of rhetorical work in public argument that the underlying finding does not support.

REMEMBER THIS

The headline finding of this whole field is **similarity**. A review of forty-six meta-analyses found around four fifths of measured psychological sex differences to be small or close to zero. Everything below is a list of exceptions, and exceptions read alone mislead.

Mathematics: the average difference is essentially zero, across millions of students, favouring girls in some countries. A gap at the extreme top was once about thirteen to one — and fell to around four to one within two decades, which no fixed-biology account can accommodate.

Two differences run the other way and are larger. Girls outperform boys in **reading in every country measured, every cycle**, and the **writing gap is around half an effect size** — roughly ten times the maths gap and among the largest in academic achievement.

Notice which of those two receives national attention and funding. The pattern of what gets measured and discussed does not track the size of the difference.

The largest cognitive difference is mental rotation — deciding whether a 3D shape is the same object turned around. It is real, it is 64 to 74 in the hall, it improves with practice, and it is one narrow laboratory task carrying far more rhetorical weight in public than the finding supports.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Tails

Two groups can have exactly the same average and produce very different numbers of people at the extremes. This is the most consequential idea in the part, it is used badly by everybody, and it cuts in a direction almost nobody expects.

4.1 — Same middle, different edges

Everything so far has been about averages. Averages are the wrong place to look for most of the outcomes people actually argue about.

WORD BOX

Variability: how spread out a group is. Two groups can share an average while one is tightly bunched around it and the other is stretched out towards both extremes.

The measure used here is the **variance ratio** — how much wider one group's spread is than the other's. A ratio of 1.0 means identical spread. Ratios found for human cognitive traits are typically small, in the region of 1.05 to 1.20, with males the wider group on most measures.

Why it matters here: a spread difference this small sounds negligible and is not. At the far edge of a distribution it multiplies, and the far edge is where professorships, prizes, prisons and diagnoses are.

4.2 — The arithmetic

The best way to see this is to do it, so here it is with numbers.

Take two groups with **exactly the same average**. Give one group a spread seven per cent wider than the other — a difference far too small to notice in any ordinary setting.

Now count how many people from each group appear above various thresholds.

HOW FAR ABOVE AVERAGE	RATIO, WIDER GROUP TO NARROWER	ROUGHLY WHAT THIS LEVEL MEANS
1 spread	about 1.1 to 1	Above average. Nearly balanced.

HOW FAR ABOVE AVERAGE	RATIO, WIDER GROUP TO NARROWER	ROUGHLY WHAT THIS LEVEL MEANS
2 spreads	about 1.35 to 1	Top few per cent. A noticeable tilt.
3 spreads	about 1.9 to 1	Roughly one in a thousand. Nearly two to one.
4 spreads	about 2.9 to 1	Roughly one in thirty thousand. Almost three to one.

Read that again with the first line of §4.2 in mind. **The averages are identical.** Nothing in this table comes from one group being better at anything. All of it comes from a seven per cent difference in spread.

And if the spread difference is fifteen per cent rather than seven, the ratio at four spreads above average rises to something in the region of eight to one.

This is the single most important statistical fact in the part, and it explains why arguments about averages so consistently fail to explain what people see. You can have complete equality in the middle and a large imbalance at the edge, produced by nothing except a difference in spread.

4.3 — Does it actually happen?

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> International school assessments test hundreds of thousands of fifteen-year-olds across dozens of countries on identical instruments. They are the best data available for comparing spreads.
>
> **What they show:** greater male variability on most measures in most countries. In one widely cited analysis of a large international assessment, male variance in mathematics exceeded female variance in the large majority of participating countries, and in reading it did so in all of them.
>
> **What it can show:** that the pattern is broad, cross-national, and not an artefact of one country's schooling.
>
> **What it cannot show:** that it is fixed. The size of the variance ratio *differs between countries*, sometimes considerably, and has changed over time in some. A biological constant does not vary by nation. Whatever produces this is at least partly responsive to something about societies, and nobody has established how much.
>
> One further caution: these are school populations. Boys are more likely to be excluded, to drop out, or to be absent on test day, which can distort a tail measurement in either direction.

4.4 — The half that is never mentioned

Here is where this chapter turns, and it turns hard.

Greater variability means more people at **both** extremes. Not one. Both. The same arithmetic that puts more men at the top of a distribution puts more men at the bottom of it, in exactly the same proportion.

And that is what the data shows. Males are substantially over-represented in intellectual disability, in severe learning difficulties, in diagnoses of attention and developmental disorders, in school exclusion, in failure to complete education, and — as Part Fifteen will count in detail — in almost every measure of catastrophic life outcome.

So anybody invoking male variability to explain why the top of a profession is male has, in the same breath and by the same mathematics, explained why the bottom of society is male. The argument does not have a top-only setting.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both camps assume **that the interesting question is the average.**

The entire public argument about sex differences is conducted in the language of averages. Are women as good at X. Are men more Y. Every study reported, every headline written, every dinner-table row.

But almost nothing that people actually fight about is decided at the average. Professorships are not awarded at the fiftieth percentile. Neither are prime ministerships, patents, prison sentences, or diagnoses. **The socially consequential outcomes are all at the edges of distributions, and the edges obey different arithmetic from the middle.**

This means both camps are frequently arguing correctly about the wrong thing. The reformer who establishes that average maths ability is identical has established something true that does not touch the question of who becomes a mathematician. The traditionalist who points at the top of a field has said nothing about the vast middle where most people live.

The general form: **arguing about the middle of a distribution when the decisions happen at its edge.** It is why two people can both be right and still disagree completely.

4.5 — What it explains, and what it cannot

THE ARGUMENT — DOES MALE VARIABILITY EXPLAIN THE COMPOSITION OF ELITE FIELDS?

This is the most consequential live dispute in the part.

IT GOES A LONG WAY

The arithmetic in §4.2 is not a theory; it is a consequence of the shapes of the distributions. Greater male variability is documented across most countries and most measures. Given that, an imbalance at the extreme top of ability-intensive fields would occur even with perfectly equal averages and perfectly fair treatment. Any explanation that ignores it is incomplete by construction.

IT EXPLAINS FAR LESS THAN CLAIMED

Four problems. The extreme mathematics ratio fell by roughly two thirds in twenty years, and nothing biological moves that fast. Variance ratios differ between countries, so they are responsive to something social. The fields with the largest gaps are not reliably the ones demanding the most extreme ability. And representation gaps exist throughout these professions, not only at the very top — which is the only place this mechanism operates.

VALID MATHEMATICS, OVERLOADED

The mechanism is real and contributes something. It cannot account for the *size* of observed gaps, their *timing*, or their *variation between countries*, because it is a constant and those are variables. Anybody presenting it as a sufficient explanation is misusing valid mathematics, and anybody denying it operates at all is denying arithmetic.

Where things stand: the third position. This is a genuine mechanism producing a genuine effect of unknown and probably modest magnitude, routinely inflated into a complete account by people who like the conclusion.

What would settle it: tracking variance ratios and elite representation together across countries and decades. If representation gaps move while variance ratios stay still, the mechanism is not doing the work. Preliminary comparisons point that way and the analysis has not been done properly.

Why people care so much: because it is the last remaining argument that can explain unequal outcomes without anybody having done anything wrong. That is an enormously attractive property, and it is exactly why the claim needs checking rather than adopting.

One practical note before leaving this chapter. Whenever somebody invokes the tails at you, ask which end they are invoking. Almost everybody who reaches for this argument reaches for one end only, and the arithmetic does not have a one-ended setting.

REMEMBER THIS

Two groups with **identical averages** can produce very different numbers at the extremes, if one is more spread out. Male variability is slightly greater on most cognitive measures — variance ratios around 1.05 to 1.20.

That sounds negligible and is not. With identical averages and a spread just **seven per cent wider**, the ratio at the extreme rises to about 1.35 to 1 at two spreads above average, 1.9 at three, and **2.9 at four**. At fifteen per cent wider, roughly eight to one.

The pattern is real and cross-national — but variance ratios **differ between countries and have changed over time**, and a biological constant does not vary by nation.

And it works at both ends. The same arithmetic that puts more men at the top puts more men at the bottom: intellectual disability, learning difficulties, exclusion, dropout, catastrophic outcomes. Anybody using this to explain why the top of a profession is male has, in the same breath, explained why the bottom of society is.

Almost nothing people fight about is decided at the average. Professorships, prizes, prisons and diagnoses are all at the edges — which is why two people can both be right about the middle and still disagree completely.

CHAPTER FIVE

What People Want To Do

The largest psychological difference between men and women that has ever been measured is not an ability. It is a preference. It is bigger than every gap in Chapter Three combined, it has been measured on half a million people, and it is bad news for both camps.

5.1 — The finding

In 2009 a group of researchers pooled every study they could find on vocational interests — what work people say they would like to do — and analysed them together. The combined sample was **over half a million people**.

They found one dimension along which men and women differ more than on anything else in psychology. They called it Things versus People.

WORD BOX

The Things–People dimension: a measure of whether somebody prefers work oriented around objects, systems and machines, or work oriented around persons.

At the Things end: engineering, mechanics, construction, physics, computing hardware. At the People end: teaching, nursing, counselling, human resources, social work.

It is not a measure of ability, sociability or warmth. It asks what a person would *choose* to spend their working life doing.

Why it matters here: the sex difference on this one dimension is roughly 0.93 — **seventy-four in the hall —** which is larger than any cognitive difference in this part and larger than most differences measured between any two human groups on anything psychological.

5.2 — The numbers

INTEREST AREA	EFFECT SIZE	MAN HIGHER, PER 100 PAIRS
Engineering	about 1.11	78
Things versus People	about 0.93	74
Realistic — hands-on, mechanical	about 0.84	72
Science	about 0.36	60
Mathematics as an interest	about 0.34	59
Investigative — research, analysis	about 0.26	57
Enterprising — business, persuasion	about 0.04	51
Conventional — records, administration	about −0.33	41
Artistic	about −0.35	40
Social — teaching, helping, caring	about −0.68	32

Two things in that table deserve attention beyond the top line.

Interest in mathematics differs by 0.34 while ability differs by roughly zero. That is the whole argument about mathematics and women, relocated. The gap was never in what girls could do. It was, at least substantially, in what they wanted to do with it — which is a completely different problem requiring a completely different response.

And business interest is dead level. An effect size of 0.04 is nothing at all. Whatever explains the composition of company boards, it is not a difference in wanting to be there.

IN REAL TERMS

Take the engineering figure of about 1.11 and put it in a lecture theatre.

Suppose a country had removed every barrier — no discrimination in admissions, no hostility in the workplace, no cultural discouragement, nothing at all except each person choosing freely from an identical menu. If the only remaining input were the measured strength of interest, that engineering class would still not be half women.

Now hold the other end. In a nursing intake, a social work programme, a primary school staffroom, the same arithmetic running the other way produces the imbalance everybody has already seen and nobody calls a crisis.

The uncomfortable observation is that both imbalances have the same cause and only one of them is treated as a problem — which tells you the concern was never really about imbalance.

5.3 — Where does the preference come from?

The obvious reply is that interests are shaped by society, and this is clearly partly true. Children are handed different toys, praised for different things, and shown different futures. Nobody serious disputes that this affects what they later want.

Two findings complicate the simple version.

The first is that the Things–People difference appears in every country where it has been measured, across more than fifty nations with very different economies, religions and gender arrangements.

The second is the one that does real damage to the simple version, and it is the subject of the whole of Part Five: the difference tends to be **larger in richer and more gender-equal countries**, not smaller. Whatever produces it, the pattern does not shrink as barriers come down.

I am not going to resolve that here. Part Five is entirely about it, including the serious criticisms of the finding. What matters for this chapter is that the straightforward socialisation account predicts the opposite of what is observed, and an account that predicts the opposite of the observation has a problem.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

> Every argument about women and work assumes **that the question is ability.**
>
> Can women do engineering. Are women as good at mathematics. Is there a difference in capability. Both camps have spent decades on this, one trying to establish a difference and the other trying to refute it.
>
> And on the evidence, ability is largely not where the action is. Ability differences in the relevant domains are close to zero. **Interest differences are among the largest measured differences in psychology.** The variable everybody argues about is the small one.
>
> Now notice why this is worse for both sides, not better.
>
> An ability gap is a *solvable* problem. Teach, train, fund, remove the barrier, and the gap closes — the mathematics ratio in Chapter Three fell by two thirds in twenty years. Everybody knows how to work on ability.
>
> A preference gap has no such handle. You cannot train somebody into wanting a different life. Addressing it requires either accepting unequal outcomes as legitimate, or telling large numbers of people that what they want is wrong and was installed in them — and that second option is a thing nobody wants to say out loud about adults, in either direction.
>
> The general form: **arguing about the tractable variable because the intractable one has no acceptable answer.**

I want to be clear that naming the dilemma is not the same as resolving it, and I am not resolving it here. Chapter Nine takes it up properly, once the rest of the measurements are on the table.

REMEMBER THIS

The largest psychological sex difference ever measured is **not an ability. It is a preference.** On the Things–People dimension — objects and systems against persons — the effect size is about **0.93**, or 74 in the hall, from a pooled sample of over half a million people.

Engineering interest is larger still at about 1.11. Interest in caring and teaching work runs the other way at about −0.68.

Two rows matter most. **Interest in mathematics differs by 0.34 while ability differs by about zero** — the whole argument relocated. And business interest is **0.04**, which is nothing, so whatever explains the composition of boards, it is not a difference in wanting to be there.

The difference appears in every country measured — and tends to be **larger in richer and more gender-equal ones**, which is the opposite of what a straightforward socialisation account predicts. Part Five is about that.

Both camps argue about ability because ability is fixable. A preference gap has no handle: you cannot train somebody into wanting a different life. Addressing it means either accepting unequal outcomes as legitimate, or telling adults that what they want is wrong and was installed in them.

CHAPTER SIX

Personality, And A Statistical Trap

Measured one trait at a time, personality differences are modest. Measured all at once by one particular method, they look enormous. And one disposition — aggression — shows more clearly than anything else in this part what a moderate average does at the far edge of a distribution.

6.1 — One trait at a time

Personality research mostly organises itself around five broad traits, and the sex differences on them have been measured many times in many countries.

WORD BOX

The Big Five: the five broad dimensions most personality research uses.

Agreeableness — warmth, trust, cooperation. **Neuroticism** — how readily a person experiences negative emotion. **Extraversion** — sociability and assertiveness. **Conscientiousness** — orderliness and self-discipline. **Openness** — interest in ideas, art and novelty.

Why it matters here: these are the units in which the argument in this chapter is conducted, and the argument turns on whether you look at them one at a time or all together.

Taken separately, the findings are consistent and moderate. Women score higher on agreeableness by around 0.4 to 0.5 — roughly sixty-two to sixty-four in the hall, running the other way. Women score higher on neuroticism by a similar amount. Differences on conscientiousness and openness at the broad level are small. Extraversion is close to level.

There is one wrinkle worth knowing, because it explains part of the dispute that follows. Each broad trait contains narrower components, and the sexes sometimes differ in *opposite directions* within the same trait. Within extraversion, for instance, women tend to score higher on warmth and enthusiasm while men score higher on assertiveness. Average those together and they cancel, producing a broad difference near zero that conceals two real ones.

6.2 — The move

Now the trap.

Suppose you have sixteen personality measurements rather than five. On each one, men and women differ modestly. What happens if you ask not "how different are they on this trait" but "how well could you tell a man from a woman using all sixteen at once?"

That is a different question, and it has a different answer. Because the small differences do not all point the same way, combining them can separate the groups far better than any single measure. A team applying this method to a large sample reported a combined distance so large that it implied only around one tenth of the two groups overlapped — a figure vastly beyond anything in Chapter Three.

That claim has been quoted enormously widely, usually without the argument that followed it.

THE ARGUMENT — ARE PERSONALITY DIFFERENCES SMALL OR ENORMOUS?

Two teams of competent researchers, looking at overlapping data, reporting answers an order of magnitude apart. The disagreement is genuine and it is about method rather than data.

THEY ARE LARGE, AND SINGLE TRAITS ARE THE WRONG UNIT

Nobody meets a person's agreeableness score. They meet a whole personality, and a whole personality is a combination. Analysing traits one at a time systematically understates how different two groups are, because it throws away the information contained in the pattern. If you can separate two groups almost completely using the full profile, then the groups *are* almost completely separable, whatever any individual trait shows.

THEY ARE MODEST, AND THE COMBINED FIGURE IS INFLATED

Three objections. The method corrects for imperfect measurement in a way that substantially enlarges the result. The size of the combined distance depends on how many measures you throw in, so it can be pumped up by adding more. And it answers a classification question, not a difference question — being able to guess somebody's sex from a profile does not mean any trait differs much, only that many tiny signals add up.

TWO QUESTIONS, ONE WORD

Both results are correct answers to different questions. "How different are men and women on trait X?" — modest, and the numbers in §6.1 are right. "How well can you tell them apart using everything at once?" — surprisingly well, and the combined figure is right. The dispute exists because both are reported using the word *difference*.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is not a dodge — it is the actual structure of the disagreement. A later analysis with a larger sample produced a smaller combined figure than the original, which suggests the first number was somewhat inflated while the phenomenon is real.

What would settle it: agreement on which question is being asked, which is not an empirical matter. For any practical purpose — hiring, teaching, predicting what a person will do — the single-trait numbers are the relevant ones, because you are dealing with a person and not classifying a sample.

Why people care so much: because the combined figure sounds like a licence. "Ninety per cent non-overlapping" reads as two kinds of creature, and it is repeated constantly in exactly that spirit. What it actually describes is a statistical classification exercise, and Chapter One's rule applies with full force: a classification is not a person.

6.3 — Aggression, and the clearest tail in the book

One disposition deserves separate treatment, because it is among the largest behavioural differences and because it demonstrates Chapter Four's arithmetic more clearly than any other example available.

Men are more physically aggressive. Meta-analyses put the difference somewhere around 0.5 to 0.6 — in the hall, roughly sixty-four to sixty-six in a hundred. That is a moderate difference, comparable to writing ability running the other way, and if you stopped there you would conclude it was interesting and not dramatic.

Two details make it more than that.

It appears very early. The sex difference in physical aggression is detectable in children by around the age of two or three, before most proposed socialisation could plausibly have done its work, and it is found across cultures.

And indirect aggression runs the other way. Aggression conducted through exclusion, reputation and social manoeuvre — damaging somebody without touching them — shows either no sex difference or one favouring girls and women, depending on age and measure. So the honest statement is not that one sex is more aggressive. It is that the sexes differ in *method*, and that the male method is the one that leaves marks and enters crime statistics.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Now watch what a moderate average difference does at the extreme, because this is the cleanest demonstration in the whole part.
>
> Physical aggression differs by roughly 0.6 — **about sixty-six in a hundred pairs**. Two thirds. Not remotely categorical. Pick a man and a woman at random and the woman is the more physically aggressive of the two a third of the time.
>
> Now go to the far end of that same distribution. Homicide is committed by men in the region of **nine cases out of ten**, worldwide, in every country that keeps records. Men are also the substantial majority of the victims.
>
> Sixty-six per cent in the middle. Ninety per cent at the edge. Nothing extra was added — no additional difference, no separate explanation. **That is Chapter Four's arithmetic happening to real people**, and it is why average differences and extreme outcomes so often look like evidence about different worlds.

The same structure applies to risk. Men take more physical and financial risk, by a modest margin on most measures — the effect varies a great deal by the kind of risk, and is smaller than most people assume. And men die from accidents, drowning, falls and violence at rates far beyond that modest margin, for the same reason.

Hold this beside §2.5. Men die around five years earlier, everywhere. A meaningful share of that gap is not a fact about male bodies at all. It is the tail of a moderate difference in behaviour, arriving as a mortality statistic.

6.4 — What survives

Strip the dispute away and three things are solid.

Women score higher on agreeableness and on neuroticism, by moderate amounts, consistently, across many countries. These are among the more replicable findings in personality research.

Broad traits hide opposite-running components, so a reported difference of zero at the broad level is not evidence of no difference underneath.

And personality differences, like the interest differences in Chapter Five, tend to be larger in richer and more gender-equal countries. The same pattern, in a different literature, measured by different people. Part Five deals with it properly, and the fact that it appears independently in interests and in personality is the reason it cannot be waved away.

REMEMBER THIS

One trait at a time, personality differences are moderate. Women score higher on **agreeableness** and on **neuroticism** by around 0.4 to 0.5. Other broad traits are close to level.

Broad traits **hide opposite-running parts**. Within extraversion, women score higher on warmth and men on assertiveness; averaged, they cancel into a difference near zero that conceals two real ones.

Combine many measures at once and the picture changes dramatically — one widely quoted analysis reported only about a tenth of the two groups overlapping. That figure has been criticised for correcting measurement error in an inflating way, for growing as you add variables, and for answering a **classification** question rather than a difference question.

Both answers are correct to different questions. How different are men and women on a given trait — modest. How well can you tell them apart using everything at once — surprisingly well. They collide because both use the word **difference**.

On **aggression**: men are more physically aggressive by about 0.6 — sixty-six in a hundred, so a third of the time the woman is the more aggressive of a random pair. Indirect aggression runs the other way. The sexes differ in **method**, and the male method is the one that leaves marks.

And at the extreme, that sixty-six per cent becomes roughly ninety per cent of homicides, worldwide, with men also the majority of victims. Nothing was added between those two numbers except distance from the average. That is Chapter Four's arithmetic happening to real people.

For anything practical — hiring, teaching, predicting a person — the single-trait numbers are the relevant ones. “Ninety per cent non-overlapping” is a statistical classification exercise, and a classification is not a person.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What Is Actually In The Brain

More has been written about male and female brains than about any other topic in this part, and a large share of it is unreliable. This chapter separates what survives scrutiny from what does not, and the second pile is much bigger.

7.1 — The one solid number, and why it means less than it looks

Men's brains are larger, by roughly ten to twelve per cent on average. This is not in dispute.

Nearly all of it is body size. Larger bodies come with larger brains across the animal kingdom, and within each sex the same relationship holds — taller people have bigger brains. Once you account for body size, most of the gap goes.

And brain size is a poor predictor of anything cognitive within the human range. The correlation between brain volume and measured intelligence is real and modest, and it does not do the work that people who cite brain size want it to do — which is why Chapter Three found essentially no difference in general intelligence despite this ten per cent gap.

7.2 — What is reliably found

The best current evidence comes from very large population imaging studies rather than the small laboratory samples that dominated earlier decades.

WORD BOX

Grey matter is the tissue where the cell bodies of neurons sit — roughly, where processing happens. **White matter** is the wiring between them, wrapped in a fatty sheath that gives it its colour and speeds signals up.

Cortical thickness is how deep the outer sheet of grey matter is at a given point on the brain's surface. It is measured in millimetres and varies across the brain in everybody.

Why it matters here: these three are what large imaging studies actually measure, and none of them has a simple meaning. More is not better and thicker is not smarter. A reported difference in any of them is a difference in a physical measurement whose behavioural consequence, in nearly every case, has not been established.

Those studies do find average differences: in the raw volumes of many regions, in the proportions of grey and white matter, and in cortical thickness, where women tend to score higher. The differences are statistically robust at these sample sizes.

They are also, without exception, differences with **large overlap**. Not one of them separates the sexes. In the language of Chapter One, they sit in the small-to-moderate range, and most shrink further once total brain size is accounted for.

So the honest summary of the reliable brain literature is: measurable average differences in many structures, none of them large enough to characterise an individual, and none of them yet connected to a specific behavioural difference by a demonstrated causal chain.

That last clause is the important one, and it is where most popular writing goes wrong. Finding that a region differs on average is not the same as showing that the difference causes anything.

7.3 — A famous finding that was never there

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In 1982 a study reported that a particular bundle of fibres connecting the two halves of the brain was larger in women. It was published in a leading journal and became one of the most widely repeated claims in popular science — the anatomical basis, it was said, for female intuition, for women's supposedly greater emotional integration, for a dozen confident stories.

The sample was fourteen brains. Nine male, five female, obtained post mortem.

Over the following fifteen years, dozens of studies attempted to reproduce it. In 1997 a meta-analysis pooled forty-nine of them and found **no reliable sex difference** in the size or shape of that structure once overall brain size was accounted for.

What this shows: not that the original researchers were dishonest. They found a difference in fourteen brains, which is exactly what small samples do — they produce large, striking, unreplicable results. The finding entered public knowledge in the 1980s and is still repeated today, four decades after the evidence stopped supporting it.

What it cannot show: that all such findings are wrong. Some replicate. The lesson is about sample size and about how long a dead claim survives in public circulation, not about the field as a whole.

That case is not an isolated embarrassment. It is representative of a structural problem in this literature, and the scale of the problem is worth stating with a number attached.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the scale problem in this literature, laid out plainly.

For decades, a typical brain-imaging study comparing men and women used a few dozen people per group. Recent work on how many participants are actually needed to get a reproducible result linking brain measurements to behaviour suggests the answer runs into the **thousands**.

Put those side by side. A field spent thirty years running studies at a size now understood to be one or two orders of magnitude too small — and publishing the results, which were then read, quoted and turned into books.

There is a second problem sitting on top. In 2016 researchers found that a widely used statistical procedure in brain imaging had been generating false positives at rates far above what anybody assumed, affecting a substantial share of the published literature.

So when you encounter a striking claim about male and female brains, the base rate matters more than the claim. The default assumption should be that it came from a study too small to be trusted, because for most of the history of this field, that is what it was.

7.4 — Two brains or a mosaic?

THE ARGUMENT — ARE THERE MALE AND FEMALE BRAINS?

This dispute has the same structure as Chapter Six, which is worth noticing, because a pattern that appears twice in one part is telling you something about how these arguments work.

BRAINS ARE MOSAICS

A large analysis of brain scans looked at whether individuals were internally consistent — whether a person with one “male-typical” feature tended to have the others. Overwhelmingly they did not. Most brains are patchworks, combining features that are more common in men with features more common in women. Brains that are consistently male-typical or female-typical throughout are rare. So there is no such thing as a male brain or a female brain, only a population of mosaics with differing average feature frequencies.

BRAINS ARE CLASSIFIABLE

If brains carried no sex information, you could not guess a person's sex from a scan. You can, well above chance, using standard statistical methods on the full pattern. That accuracy has to come from somewhere. A claim that the categories do not exist is hard to square with the fact that a computer can sort them.

TWO QUESTIONS, ONE WORD — AGAIN

Both findings are correct and they answer different questions. *Is any individual brain reliably identifiable as male or female by inspection?* No — the mosaic result stands. *Does the overall pattern carry sex-related information detectable in aggregate?* Yes — the classification result stands. Exactly as in Chapter Six, the dispute survives because both are reported using the same vocabulary.

Where things stand: the third position, and its recurrence is the finding. Twice in one part, competent researchers have produced apparently opposite conclusions by asking a classification question and a difference question and calling both "difference." That is not a failure of any particular team; it is a structural weakness in how this whole field reports itself.

What would settle it: nothing empirical, because there is no empirical disagreement. Both results replicate.

Why people care so much: because "male and female brains exist" reads as a licence for everything in Parts Two and Three, and "there is no such thing" reads as a refutation of it. Neither follows. A brain difference would still be a group average, and Chapter One already disposed of what a group average can justify about a person.

So the practical instruction from this chapter is unglamorous. Treat any striking claim about male and female brains as probably wrong until you know the sample size, and treat any claim that connects a brain difference to a behaviour as almost certainly unestablished, because that chain has very rarely been demonstrated.

REMEMBER THIS

Men's brains are about **ten to twelve per cent larger**, almost entirely because of body size, and brain size is a weak predictor of anything cognitive within the human range — which is why Chapter Three found no difference in general intelligence.

Large modern imaging studies do find average differences in regional volumes and cortical thickness. Every one has **large overlap**, none separates the sexes, and none has been connected to a behavioural difference by a demonstrated causal chain.

A 1982 finding that a fibre bundle was larger in women became one of the most repeated claims in popular science. **The sample was fourteen brains.** A meta-analysis of forty-nine later studies found no reliable difference. It is still being repeated today.

Typical studies in this field used a few dozen people per group. Reproducible brain-behaviour findings are now understood to need **thousands**. A widely used statistical procedure was also found to be producing false positives far above assumed rates.

Are there male and female brains? Individual brains are mosaics — internally inconsistent patchworks. And a computer can still sort them above chance. Both are true. It is the same two-questions-one-word collision as Chapter Six, and its appearing twice is itself the finding.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Where The Differences Come From

Having measured the differences, the obvious next question is whether they are built in or taught. That question has been dead in the research for about fifty years, and understanding why it died is more useful than any answer to it.

8.1 — The strongest evidence available

You cannot run the experiment. Assigning babies to hormone levels or to upbringings is not something any ethics committee will approve, and the one notorious attempt to raise a child as the opposite sex was a single case, ended in tragedy, and is cited with equal confidence by both camps — which is what a single case always permits and never justifies.

So researchers use situations where nature has arranged something close to an experiment.

WORD BOX

Prenatal androgens: hormones, chiefly testosterone, present in the womb. Male foetuses are exposed to substantially more than female ones during specific developmental windows.

Congenital adrenal hyperplasia: an inherited condition in which the adrenal glands produce excess androgens from before birth. A girl with the condition develops with androgen exposure far above the usual female range.

Why it matters here: this is the closest thing to a controlled experiment that exists in humans. It varies prenatal hormone exposure without anybody choosing to, and it allows a comparison with unaffected sisters raised in the same households.

The comparison with sisters is what makes this worth the space. Two girls in one house, one exposed to high androgens before birth and one not, raised by the same parents with the same expectations. Whatever differs between them cannot easily be explained by upbringing.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Girls with this condition have been studied for decades, compared with their own unaffected female relatives.

The most robust finding is about play. Affected girls show markedly more interest in toys and activities typically preferred by boys, and less in those typically preferred by girls. This has been reproduced across many studies and pooled analyses. Follow-up work finds shifts in later occupational interests in the same direction — which connects directly to the Things–People dimension in Chapter Five.

The strongest detail: the toy-preference difference persists even where parents actively encourage female-typical play. If it were simply a response to how these girls are treated, encouragement in the opposite direction should reduce it, and it does not.

What it cannot show: a great deal. Girls with the condition often have visibly different bodies and know they are different; parents know the diagnosis and cannot be blinded to it; the condition has other physical effects and requires lifelong medication. Sample sizes are usually small because the condition is rare. And the finding is about the direction of interests, not about ability, and not about anything in Parts Two and Three.

8.2 — Monkeys and toys

A second line of evidence removes human socialisation entirely.

Researchers offered toys to monkeys — animals with no exposure to advertising, parental expectation, school, or any idea of what a toy is for. Male monkeys spent more time with wheeled objects and female monkeys more with plush ones. The result has been found in more than one species.

It is striking and it should not be over-read. Critics have pointed out that the objects differed in colour, shape and how they moved, any of which could drive a preference without anything sex-typed being involved. The effects are moderate. And a monkey has no concept of a doll, so what the animals were responding to is genuinely unclear.

What the studies do establish is narrower and still useful: **a sex difference in object preference can arise without human culture.** That does not tell you how much of the human difference is cultural. It tells you the answer is not all of it.

8.3 — The most misused number in the subject

Before the framing itself, one term has to be dealt with, because it appears in almost every argument about this and almost nobody using it means what it means.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Heritability:** the share of the *variation* in a trait, *within one population*, that is statistically associated with genetic variation in that population.
>
> Read that definition twice, because three words in it are doing work people routinely ignore.
>
> **Variation —** it is about differences between people, not about how much of any one person's trait is genetic. Asking how much of your height is genetic is like asking how much of a rectangle's area is its width.
>
> **Within one population —** the number is a property of a group in a place at a time. Change the environment and the same trait can have a different heritability.
>
> **Associated —** not caused by, not fixed by, not unchangeable by.
>
> Why it matters here: "this trait is sixty per cent heritable" is quoted constantly as though it meant "sixty per cent unchangeable." It does not, and the next section shows why with a case everybody can check.

8.4 — Why the question is broken

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Everything above assumes what everybody assumes: **that a trait is either innate or learned, and the job is to work out the proportions.**
>
> This framing is dead in developmental biology and has been for decades, and its persistence in public argument is doing serious damage.
>
> Nothing about an organism is specified by genes alone. A gene is an instruction that only means anything in an environment; change the environment and the same gene produces a different outcome. Equally, nothing is learned except through a biological system that determines what can be learned, how fast, and with what effect. There is no stage at which one hands over to the other.

> Consider height. It is one of the most heritable traits there is — and average height in many countries rose by ten centimetres or more in a century, which is nutrition, not genetics. Both statements are entirely true. Height is highly heritable *and* highly responsive to environment, because heritability was never a measure of how fixed something is.
>
> Now the consequence that matters most, and it is routinely got backwards by people quoting these numbers. **Heritability within a group tells you nothing about differences between groups.** A trait can be eighty per cent heritable inside each of two populations while the entire gap between them is environmental. This is not a technicality; it is the single most misused statistic in the whole subject.
>
> The general form: **a false binary imported from an argument that ended before most of the participants were born.**

8.4 — The honest scoring

Given all that, here is what can actually be said about causes, scored plainly.

Physical differences (Chapter Two): overwhelmingly biological. Driven by hormones at puberty, visible in every population, and unchanged by any social arrangement anybody has tried. Training moves individuals substantially and does not close the population gap.

Interest differences (Chapter Five): mixed, with a real biological component and a real social one. The prenatal hormone evidence and the animal work establish that some of it is not taught. The size of the effect in humans, and the share of the total it accounts for, are not established. Anybody giving you a percentage is guessing.

Cognitive differences (Chapter Three): mostly too small to have an interesting cause. Where a difference exists and is large enough to study, such as mental rotation, it responds to training — which does not make it purely learned, but does mean it is not fixed.

Personality differences (Chapter Six): unresolved, and complicated by the cross-country pattern. Differences being larger in freer societies is not what either a simple biological or a simple social account predicts. Part Five is about that.

And the tail differences (Chapter Four): unknown. The mathematics ratio moved by two thirds in twenty years, which rules out anything wholly fixed, and it then stopped moving, which rules out nothing else.

REMEMBER THIS

You cannot run the experiment, so researchers use situations nature arranged. Girls with a condition causing high **prenatal androgen exposure** show markedly more male-typical play and later interests than their own unaffected sisters — and the difference persists even when parents actively encourage the opposite.

Monkeys offered toys show a similar split, with no advertising, parents or schooling involved. Read narrowly: a sex difference in object preference **can** arise without human culture. That does not say how much of the human difference is cultural — only that it is not all of it.

The whole "innate or learned" question is **dead in the science**. Genes only mean anything in an environment; learning only happens through a biological system. Height is among the most heritable traits there is, and average height rose ten centimetres in a century on better food. Both true.

Heritability within a group tells you nothing about differences between groups. A trait can be eighty per cent heritable inside each of two populations while the whole gap between them is environmental. This is the most misused statistic in the subject.

Honest scoring: physical differences, overwhelmingly biological. Interests, genuinely mixed and nobody can give you the proportions. Cognitive differences, mostly too small to have an interesting cause. Personality and the tails, unresolved — and anyone quoting a percentage for any of them is guessing.

CHAPTER NINE

Same, Equal, And Equal Outcomes

Three completely different ideas share one word, and almost every argument about equality is two people using it to mean different things. Separating them dissolves most of the argument — and leaves one genuine dilemma that nobody has an answer to.

9.1 — Three ideas

Take the sentence “men and women are equal.” It can mean three unrelated things.

Same. That men and women have the same distribution of traits. This is an *empirical* claim. It can be measured, and eight chapters have just measured it. The answer is: identical or nearly so on most cognitive measures, substantially different on some physical ones, and substantially different on interests. So as a general claim it is false, and as a claim about any specific trait it needs checking one trait at a time.

Equal in worth. That men and women are owed the same consideration, the same rights, the same standing. This is a *moral* claim. No measurement bears on it. You cannot confirm it with a study and you cannot refute it with one.

Equal in outcome. That men and women should end up in the same proportions in every role, at every level, with the same pay and the same representation. This is a *political* claim about results, and whether it follows from anything depends entirely on arguments that have to be made separately.

Now the observation that matters. **Nobody has ever derived the second from the first, and nobody needs to.**

Consider how obvious this is elsewhere. A weak man and a strong man are not the same on any measure of strength — the difference is larger than most in this part. Nobody concludes that the weak man has fewer rights. A person with a measured intelligence of 90 and one with 140 differ enormously. Nobody thinks the first should be governed by the second.

Equality of worth was never a claim about measurements. It has never rested on sameness in any other context, and there is no reason it should be made to rest on sameness here.

Which means the entire eight chapters you have just read are irrelevant to it. Every number in this part could double and the moral claim would be untouched.

9.2 — What separate categories actually concede

There is a version of this worth taking seriously because it is what people usually mean when they say the sexes cannot really be equal. It goes: if a man lifts a hundred kilos and a woman lifts fifty, then calling them equal is a fiction — real equality would mean the same number, and since the numbers differ, the equality is invented.

Look at what competitive sport actually does with that problem, because sport has been running the experiment for a century.

It creates separate categories. And a separate category is an explicit, public admission that **the sameness claim is false in this domain** — nobody sets up a women's hundred metres if the times are the same.

But notice what it is *not* conceding. It is not conceding that women's competition is less worth having, or that female athletes are lesser people, or that the winner deserves less. Weight classes in boxing work identically, and nobody thinks a flyweight champion is a fraud.

So the argument proves less than it seems to. Separate categories are not a fudge covering an embarrassment. They are what you do when a difference is real and the activity is still worth having for both groups. That is a coherent position, held openly, in public, by millions of people every weekend.

There is a limit to it, and the limit is the useful part.

Adjusted standards make sense where the activity is the point. A race exists to find the fastest person in a field. You can define the field however you like, because the race has no purpose outside itself.

Absolute standards make sense where the outcome is the point. A person trapped in a burning building weighs what they weigh. There is no adjusted category of human being to be carried down a ladder. Where a job genuinely requires a physical capacity, the honest arrangement is a standard set by the task and applied to every applicant regardless of sex — which some women pass and many men fail, and which is a test of the person rather than of the category.

Almost every real dispute about physical standards is a dispute about which of those two situations applies, conducted by people who have not noticed there are two.

9.3 — The dilemma nobody wants

Now the genuine problem, which the separation above does not dissolve.

Chapter Five found that men and women differ substantially in what they want to do — around 0.93 on the Things–People dimension, larger than any ability difference in this part.

Follow that through. If a society removed every barrier — no discrimination, no harassment, no discouragement, nothing but people choosing freely — the outcomes would **not** be equal. Engineering would remain disproportionately male. Nursing and primary teaching would remain disproportionately female. Not because anybody was stopped, but because of what people chose.

Which produces the following, and it is the crux of the entire modern argument:

Equality of opportunity and equality of outcome are not two ways of saying the same thing. Given a real difference in preferences, they are in conflict, and you cannot have both.

Neither camp can accept this cleanly.

For the equality-of-outcome position, it means that any programme aiming at proportional representation must, past some point, be working against what people want — and the honest versions of that programme have to say either that the preferences are illegitimate, or that the outcome matters more than the preference. Both are sayable. Neither is usually said.

For the traditionalist position, it is worse than it looks, and the reason is the pattern in Chapters Five and Six. The interest and personality differences get *larger* in freer and richer societies. Which means the preferences being appealed to are most visible precisely where women have most choice — so they cannot easily be used to justify restricting choice. You do not need a rule to make people do what they were going to do anyway. Every rule in Parts Two and Three exists to stop somebody doing something. A preference argument cannot justify a prohibition, because a preference needs no enforcement.

And the whole thing sits on an unresolved question. Preferences form inside societies. If they were installed, the argument changes completely. The cross-country pattern is the strongest evidence against the simple installation story, and it is contested, and Part Five is about it.

9.4 — What this part actually established about the rules

Set every finding beside the thing this series is about.

The largest difference measured here is physical, in power and speed. It does not explain why a widow may not remarry.

The next largest is interests. It does not explain why a woman must marry inside her caste.

Cognitive differences are mostly close to zero. They do not explain seclusion, dowry, or a girl married before puberty.

Male variability is real at the extremes. It does not explain why a photograph of a woman at a protest was answered with a rumour about her body.

Not one measured difference in this part maps onto a single rule in Parts Two and Three. The rules are not what you would design if you were responding to these findings; they bear no relationship to them at all. They are what you would design if you were solving an inheritance problem and a boundary problem, which is what Parts Two and Three found.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> And now the one aimed at this part, and at me.
>
> Both camps assume **that the size of these differences bears on the political question.** Part One named this as a bad bargain and Chapter One of this part repeated the warning. Then I wrote sixty pages of measurement anyway.

> Ask why. Not one number in Chapters Two through Eight was needed to establish anything about what anybody is owed. Section 9.1 shows that equality of worth never rested on sameness in any other context, and does not here. The moral question was settled before the first measurement and is unaffected by all of them.
>
> I wrote the part because **the argument is being conducted in these terms and a person who refuses to engage with the numbers loses to whoever quotes them loudest.** That is a reason to write it. It is not a reason to believe the numbers matter, and there is a real cost: participating in an argument on false terms lends those terms credibility. Every careful, honest, well-sourced page I have just written is also sixty pages of implicitly agreeing that this is what we should be arguing about.
>
> The general form: **fighting on ground you have already shown to be the wrong ground, because that is where the other side is standing.** I do not have a better answer, and I would rather name it than pretend I do.

What I can do is keep saying it. Every time a number in this part is quoted at you as though it settled something about what a woman may do, the missing step is the same one, and it has never been supplied by anybody.

REMEMBER THIS

Three ideas share one word. **Same** is an empirical claim — measurable, and mostly false for physical traits and interests, mostly true for cognitive ones. **Equal in worth** is a moral claim that no measurement touches. **Equal in outcome** is a political claim about results.

Nobody ever derived the second from the first, and nobody needs to. A weak man and a strong man differ more than most gaps in this part, and nobody concludes the weak man has fewer rights. **Equality of worth never rested on sameness anywhere else.**

Separate sporting categories concede that the sameness claim is false in that domain, and concede nothing else. Adjusted standards make sense **where the activity is the point**; absolute job-relevant standards where **the outcome is the point**, because a person in a burning building weighs what they weigh.

The genuine dilemma: given a real difference in what people want, **equality of opportunity and equality of outcome are in conflict and you cannot have both**. But a preference argument cannot justify a prohibition — you do not need a rule to make people do what they were going to do anyway, and every rule in this series exists to stop somebody.

Not one difference measured in this part maps onto a single rule in Parts Two and Three. And I wrote sixty pages measuring them anyway, because that is where the argument is being held — which is also sixty pages of agreeing that this is what we should be arguing about.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about differences between men and women, with the reason. And what is solid enough to carry into the rest of the series.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

This part rests on measurement, which makes its gaps sharper and easier to state than the historical parts.

How much of the interest difference is biological. This is the central unknown and it is the one everybody claims to know. The prenatal hormone work and the animal studies establish that some of it is not taught. Nothing establishes the proportion, and the cross-country pattern points in a direction that neither simple account predicts. Anybody quoting you a percentage is guessing.

Why the differences are larger in freer societies. The pattern appears independently in interests, in personality and in preferences, measured by different teams using different instruments — which is why it cannot be dismissed. Every proposed explanation has serious problems, and the finding itself has been challenged on methodological grounds. Part Five is about this and will not resolve it either.

What produces the difference at the extremes. The mathematics ratio at the very top fell by roughly two thirds in twenty years and then stopped. That the movement happened rules out anything wholly fixed. That it stopped rules out nothing else, and nobody can currently distinguish a biological floor from a social one that has ceased shifting.

Whether variance ratios are stable. They differ between countries and have changed in some. A biological constant does not vary by nation, so something social is involved — how much, nobody has established.

How much of the brain literature is real. Chapter Seven's honest position is that a large share of published findings came from samples now understood to be far too small, compounded by a statistical problem discovered in 2016. Which specific results survive is not knowable in advance, and the field is only now producing studies at the required scale.

Whether the mental rotation gap means anything outside a laboratory. It is the largest cognitive difference and it is one narrow task. Its connection to real-world outcomes is modest and its relationship to broader spatial ability is unclear.

10.2 — Solid

That physical differences are very large, and narrow. Height near an effect size of two, strength larger still, grip so separated that the distributions barely meet. And confined to power, speed and force application — shrinking in ultra-endurance events and reversing where body composition helps.

That most cognitive differences are close to zero. A review of forty-six meta-analyses found around four fifths small or negligible. This is the headline finding of the field and the least reported.

That average mathematical ability does not differ. Millions of students, multiple countries, favouring girls in several. Settled.

That girls read and write better, everywhere measured. The reading advantage appears in every participating country in every cycle. The writing gap is around half an effect size — roughly ten times the maths gap, and largely absent from public discussion.

That the Things–People interest difference is the largest measured psychological sex difference. About 0.93, from over half a million people, present in every country studied.

That greater male variability is real and operates at both ends. The arithmetic is not a theory. And it puts more men at the bottom in exactly the proportion it puts more at the top.

That equal averages are compatible with very unequal extremes. A seven per cent wider spread produces nearly three to one at four spreads above the mean, with identical means. This is arithmetic and cannot be argued with.

That heritability within a group says nothing about differences between groups. Not contested by anybody who works on this, and misused constantly.

And that none of the above bears on what anybody is owed. Established in Part One, restated in Chapter Nine, and the only conclusion in this part that does not depend on a single measurement.

10.3 — Who this was measured on

One closing observation, following the pattern of the previous parts.

Look at where these findings come from. University students, mostly. School assessments in wealthy countries. Population databases in Britain and Scandinavia. Volunteers who answered online surveys in English.

Part One named this problem: the people most studied by psychology are among the least typical humans available, drawn from countries holding a small minority of the world's population. Nearly every number in this part carries that limitation.

The specifically Indian version is worse. There is comparatively little of this research on Indian populations, and where cross-national work includes India it is usually as one data point among dozens. So a series about Indian women has just spent sixty pages on measurements taken largely elsewhere.

I have applied them anyway, because the alternative is applying nothing. But the reader is entitled to know that when this part says "men and women differ by 0.93 on interests", the sentence is built substantially out of people who have never been to the country this series is about — and that the one finding most relevant to India, the pattern in Chapter Five and Six about freer societies, is precisely the one nobody can explain.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: how much of the interest difference is biological — the central question, and everybody claims to know it. Why differences are larger in freer societies. What produces the gap at the extremes, given that it moved by two thirds and then stopped. Whether variance ratios are stable. How much of the brain literature survives. Whether mental rotation means anything outside a lab.

Solid: physical differences are very large and narrow. Most cognitive differences are near zero — four fifths small or negligible across forty-six meta-analyses. Average maths ability does not differ. Girls read and write better everywhere measured. The Things–People interest gap is the largest measured psychological sex difference. Greater male variability is real and operates at both ends. Equal averages are compatible with very unequal extremes. Heritability within groups says nothing about gaps between them.

And that none of it bears on what anybody is owed — the only conclusion here that rests on no measurement at all.

Note who was measured. University students, school assessments and databases in rich countries, online volunteers answering in English. There is comparatively little of this research on Indian populations. A series about Indian women has just spent sixty pages on numbers built largely from people who have never been there.

Every Difference, In One Table

This part had no chronology to offer, so its reference table is the measurements themselves. Every difference discussed, sorted from largest to smallest, with the hall figure attached. Positive means men score higher.

WHAT IS MEASURED	EFFECT SIZE	MAN HIGHER, PER 100
Grip strength	very large — off the table	above 95
Upper-body strength	very large	above 95
Height	about 2.0	92
Interest in engineering	about 1.11	78
Things versus People interests	about 0.93	74
Realistic — hands-on interests	about 0.84	72
Physical aggression	0.5 to 0.6	64 to 66
Mental rotation of 3D shapes	0.5 to 0.9	64 to 74
Spatial perception	about 0.45	62
Interest in science	about 0.36	60
Interest in mathematics	about 0.34	59
Investigative interests	about 0.26	57
Spatial visualisation	about 0.15	54
Mathematical ability	about 0.05	51
Enterprising — business interests	about 0.04	51
General intelligence	about 0	50
Vocabulary	about 0	50
Verbal ability, general	about −0.1	47

WHAT IS MEASURED	EFFECT SIZE	MAN HIGHER, PER 100
Verbal and episodic memory	about −0.2	44
Object location memory	about −0.25	43
Perceptual speed	about −0.25	43
Reading	about −0.3	42
Conventional — administrative interests	about −0.33	41
Artistic interests	about −0.35	40
Neuroticism	about −0.4	39
Writing	about −0.5	36
Agreeableness	about −0.5	36
Social — teaching and caring interests	about −0.68	32

Three things are visible in that table that are not visible in any single chapter.

The top of it is entirely physical and interests. Not one ability appears above 0.5 except a single narrow laboratory task.

The middle is a coin toss. Everything from mental rotation down to writing sits between 40 and 62 in a hall of a hundred — which means that for any of these, sex is a poor guide to a person.

And the largest non-physical differences at both ends are about what people want, not what they can do. Engineering at one end, caring work at the other. The abilities are in the middle where nothing much happens.

Figures are approximate and drawn from published meta-analyses and large assessments. Ranges are given where studies disagree. Chapter Ten states which are solid and which are not.

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Big Five	The five broad dimensions most personality research uses: agreeableness, neuroticism, extraversion, conscientiousness, openness.
Congenital adrenal hyperplasia	An inherited condition producing excess androgens from before birth. Provides the closest thing to a controlled experiment on prenatal hormones in humans.
Distribution	The full spread of a measurement across a group — not just the average but how many people sit at every value. Most mistakes in this subject come from discussing averages when the action is in the spread.
Effect size (d)	How big a difference between two groups is, measured against how spread out they are. Convert it using the hall: 0.2 is 56 in 100, 0.5 is 64, 0.8 is 71, 2.0 is 92.
Heritability	How much of the variation in a trait *within a population* is associated with genetic variation. It is not a measure of how fixed something is, and it says nothing about differences between groups.
Mental rotation	Deciding whether a three-dimensional shape is the same object turned around or a mirror image. The largest reliably found cognitive sex difference, and one narrow laboratory task.
Meta-analysis	A study that pools many earlier studies to produce a combined estimate. Buys scale; inherits the biases of everything it pools, including the tendency for findings of “no difference” not to be published.
Prenatal androgens	Hormones, chiefly testosterone, present in the womb. Male foetuses are exposed to substantially more during specific developmental windows.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Publication bias	The tendency for results showing a difference to be written up and printed more often than results showing none, which inflates the apparent size of differences across a literature.
Things–People dimension	Whether somebody prefers work oriented around objects and systems or around persons. The largest measured psychological sex difference, at about 0.93.
Variability / variance ratio	How spread out a group is, and how much wider one group's spread is than another's. Ratios for cognitive traits are typically 1.05 to 1.20, with males wider — small in the middle and consequential at the extremes.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

This part sits further outside my competence than the three before it. Those were historical, and reading history carefully is something a diligent outsider can do. This one is quantitative psychology, physiology and statistics, and the technical disputes inside it are genuinely difficult. Where specialists disagree — over multivariate personality distances, over the mosaic brain, over what male variability explains — I have put the disagreement in an Argument box and declined to adjudicate, because I am not qualified to and pretending otherwise would be worse than the gap.

Every figure here is an approximation drawn from published meta-analyses and large assessments. Different studies produce somewhat different numbers, and where the range is wide I have given a range rather than picking the value that reads best.

My own position in this part is a specific temptation rather than a general bias. I began this series annoyed at what was done to a woman in a photograph, and a person in that state would prefer the differences to be small. Several of them are not. The interest difference in Chapter Five is inconvenient to nearly everything I would have expected to find, and it is reported at full strength with the qualifications it actually carries rather than the ones I would like it to carry.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the meta-analysis, the assessment, the sample size — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of published meta-analyses, large-scale national and international assessments, and population imaging databases, rather than new research. Where a claim rests on a single study I have said so in the text.

The archive here has a different shape from the previous parts, and its weaknesses are specific. Meta-analyses inherit publication bias, which inflates apparent differences because a study finding nothing is less likely to be printed. Very large samples make trivial differences detectable, which is why everything here is reported as an effect size. Brain imaging carries a history of underpowered studies and a statistical problem found in 2016, and Chapter Seven treats it with corresponding suspicion. And nearly all of it was measured on populations unrepresentative of humanity and particularly of India, which Chapter Ten states plainly rather than burying.

Where a number is contested I have given the direction of the disagreement rather than a figure that looks authoritative — the personality distance in Chapter Six and the tail explanation in Chapter Four are the clearest cases. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who work in these fields, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Five — The Paradox of the Free Countries. Chapters Five and Six kept running into the same finding and deferring it. The next part is nothing but that finding.

- In the richest and most gender-equal countries on earth, men's and women's occupational choices diverge *more*, not less. Scandinavia has a wider gap in some technical fields than several far poorer and far less equal countries. Is that real, and how well does it survive scrutiny?
- The same pattern shows up independently in interests, in personality, and in measured preferences over risk and patience — different teams, different instruments, different decades. What explains a result that keeps arriving from unrelated directions?
- Every explanation on offer has a serious problem. Economic security, self-expression, measurement artefacts, statistical ceilings — what is the strongest version of each, and where does each one break?
- The finding is genuinely contested, including on the grounds that it depends on how you measure the gap in the first place. What did the critics actually show, and what did they not?
- If freedom widens the gap, what happens to the argument that the gap is caused by constraint? And what happens to the opposite argument, that a widening gap proves the difference was innate all along?
- And the question India has to answer: a country in the middle of exactly this transition, with the machine of Part Three still running underneath it. Which pattern is India actually on?

END OF PART FOUR OF SIXTEEN

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THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART FIVE OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Five — The Paradox of the Free Countries

In the richest and most gender-equal countries on earth, men's and women's choices diverge more, not less. Algeria produces a higher share of female science graduates than Norway.

The finding keeps arriving from unrelated directions. It is also contested. And India is sitting inside it.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Part Four measured every difference between men and women that has been measured, and reported each one with its size attached. Most cognitive differences turned out to be close to a coin toss. Physical differences turned out to be enormous and narrow. And the largest psychological difference of all turned out not to be an ability at all but a preference — the Things–People dimension, at roughly 0.93, from over half a million people.

Three times in that part I ran into the same finding and deferred it. Interest differences appeared to be *larger* in richer and more gender-equal countries. Personality differences did the same. So did measured preferences over risk and patience. Each time I said that Part Five would deal with it.

This is Part Five, and it deals with nothing else.

The reason it needs a part to itself is that it is the single most consequential empirical claim in this series. If it holds, it damages the simplest version of the argument that these differences are produced by constraint — because removing constraint should shrink them, and it appears to do the opposite. And if it does not hold, then a great deal of what has been built on it over the last twenty years has to come down.

I want to be honest about the shape of this part before you start it. It is the most technical part of the series and the least conclusive. There is a genuine, unresolved, professionally conducted dispute at the centre of it, involving competent researchers on both sides, and I am not going to pretend otherwise or pick the side that suits the story. Four chapters of this part are about the finding and four are about why it might not mean what it appears to mean.

What I can promise is that by the end you will know exactly which parts of it are solid, which are contested, and which are being oversold — including by people you agree with.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. One live example of each.

WORD BOX

The gender-equality paradox: the observed pattern in which differences between men and women — in occupational choice, personality, and stated preferences — appear *larger* in countries that are richer and score higher on measures of gender equality.

It is called a paradox because it is the opposite of what the most straightforward account predicts. If differences are produced by constraint, removing constraint should shrink them.

Why it matters here: this is the whole subject of this part, and it is the finding that most seriously complicates the argument made in Parts Two and Three.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the finding in its rawest form, with no statistics at all.

Look at the share of science, technology, engineering and mathematics graduates who are women, country by country. Near the top of that list you find **Algeria, Tunisia, Albania, Oman and the United Arab Emirates.**

Near the bottom you find **the Netherlands, Switzerland, Belgium, Norway and the United States.**

That is not a subtle statistical artefact requiring a specialist to see. It is a list, and the list is upside down relative to every expectation anybody would have brought to it.

Chapters Three to Five are about whether the list means what it looks like it means. Chapter One is about taking it seriously first.

Any number too big to picture gets a body attached.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence in this part comes from three very different kinds of source, and they have different weaknesses, which matters enormously for Chapters Four and Five.

Administrative records — how many women actually graduated in which subject, collected by national education ministries and compiled internationally. Nobody is reporting a feeling. These are counts.

Standardised tests — international assessments of fifteen-year-olds, using identical instruments in dozens of countries. Also not self-report about traits, though the questionnaires attached to them are.

Self-report surveys — asking people to rate their own personality, interests, patience or willingness to take risks. This is where most of the personality evidence comes from and it carries a specific cross-country problem set out in Chapter Two.

Why the distinction matters: the most serious objection to the paradox applies to the third category and not to the first. Any argument that dismisses the whole finding on measurement grounds has to explain the graduation counts, which are not measurements of anybody's mind.

That split runs through the whole part and is worth carrying with you from here.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE PARADOX A FINDING OR AN ARTEFACT?

The dispute at the centre of this part, stated at the front so you know what is coming.

A FINDING

It appears in graduation statistics, in international assessments, in personality inventories, and in behavioural preference measures, produced by different teams using different instruments in different decades. A pattern that keeps arriving from unrelated directions is not usually an artefact of any one of them.

AN ARTEFACT

Much of it depends on how you choose to measure "the gap," and different reasonable choices produce different answers from identical data. Much of the rest rests on self-reports, which are known not to be comparable across countries in the way this argument requires. And the equality indices being used measure something odd.

Where things stand: both are partly right and the honest position is that the pattern is real in some measures and shaky in others. This part sorts them one at a time. Chapter Ten states which is which without hedging.

An Argument box appears where people who have studied something genuinely disagree.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume **that the paradox, if real, would settle something.**

One camp treats it as proof that the differences are innate and were merely being suppressed. The other treats it as so damaging that it must be dismantled. Both are behaving as though the result decides the argument.

It does not, and Chapter Eight is about why. A growing difference needs explaining just as much as a shrinking one, and "freedom lets what was always there come out" is only one of several accounts that fit — several of which are entirely social.

The general form: **treating a result as decisive because both sides have agreed in advance that it would be.**

This is the signature box. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.

Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

This is the least conclusive part of the series and I am not going to disguise that. The previous four parts each ended with something solid. This one ends with a finding that is partly established, partly contested, and entirely unexplained. If that is unsatisfying, it is unsatisfying because the state of the evidence is unsatisfying, and manufacturing a conclusion here would be the worst thing I could do.

The finding is politically loaded in a specific way, and I want to name it in advance. It is quoted constantly by people arguing that efforts to increase women's participation in technical fields are futile or misguided. It is dismissed just as constantly by people who have not read the criticisms and are relying on somebody else having answered them. I have tried to give the strongest version of each, and the reader who finishes this part with their prior view fully intact has probably read it badly.

And Chapter Nine is where this stops being abstract for an Indian reader. India sits in an unusual position on every measure in this part, and the Indian numbers turn out to say something quite different from what either camp expects. If you read one chapter, read that one.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The Result

Algeria produces a higher share of female science graduates than Norway does. That sentence is true, it is not disputed by anybody, and everything in this part follows from working out what it means.

1.1 — The list

Take the share of graduates in science, technology, engineering and mathematics who are women, and rank the countries of the world by it.

Near the top you find Algeria, Tunisia, Albania, Oman, the United Arab Emirates. Near the bottom you find the Netherlands, Switzerland, Belgium, Norway and the United States.

Nothing about this requires interpretation. These are counts of graduates, compiled by education ministries, collated internationally. Nobody is being asked how they feel about anything.

And the ordering is upside down relative to every expectation anybody would bring to it. The countries with the strongest legal protections for women, the longest histories of feminist organisation, the most funding aimed specifically at getting girls into science, and the highest scores on every index of gender equality — those countries produce proportionally *fewer* female scientists and engineers than countries where women's lives are, by almost any measure, considerably more restricted.

1.2 — The study that made it a subject

The list had been visible in international data for some time. In 2018 two researchers made it into an argument, in a paper that has been among the most cited and most fought-over in this field ever since.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The study combined two sources. The first was an international assessment of around **470,000 fifteen-year-olds across 67 countries**, testing science, mathematics and reading with the same instruments everywhere. The second was national data on what subjects people actually graduated in.

What they found in the test data: girls matched or outperformed boys in science achievement in the majority of countries. This is not a story about girls being worse at science, and the authors said so explicitly.

What they found in the graduation data: the share of STEM graduates who were women correlated *negatively* with a widely used index of national gender equality. More equal country, smaller share.

What it cannot show: why. The paper proposed an explanation involving economic security, which is discussed in Chapter Six and is not established by the correlation itself. And the way the graduation gap was calculated became the centre of a serious methodological dispute, which is Chapters Three and Four.

1.3 — The finding inside the finding

There is a second result in that paper which is more interesting than the headline and gets almost no attention. It concerns not how good students are, but what each student is *relatively* best at.

Consider a girl who scores in the ninetieth percentile in science. That is excellent. Now suppose she also scores in the ninety-seventh percentile in reading.

She is very good at science. Science is also, for her personally, her **weaker** subject.

Now consider a boy in the eighty-fifth percentile in science and the sixtieth in reading. He is less good at science than she is, in absolute terms. But science is clearly what he is best at.

Ask each of them what they are good at, or ask a careers adviser, or simply let each follow their comparative advantage, and the two will sort in opposite directions — despite the girl being the better scientist of the two.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Relative strength** (researchers say *intra-individual* strength): what a person is best at compared with their own other abilities, rather than compared with other people.
>
> Why it matters here: this is a completely different quantity from ability, and it can move in the opposite direction. A population of girls could be better at science than boys in every country on earth, and still contain fewer people for whom science is their personal best subject — because of Part Four's finding that girls read and write better, everywhere measured.
>
> The consequence is uncomfortable for everybody: **the reading advantage from Part Four may be part of what steers girls out of science.** Being better at something else is a reason not to do this thing.

That mechanism deserves to be much better known than it is, because it requires no discrimination, no discouragement and no difference in scientific ability to produce a sorting effect. It requires only that people, or the adults advising them, pay attention to what each individual is comparatively best at — which is what everybody thinks good careers advice consists of.

1.4 — It is not only science

Before testing the result, one broadening is needed, because a great deal of argument about the paradox proceeds as though it were a fact about engineering departments. It is not.

Ask a wider question: across a whole economy, how separated are men's and women's jobs? Not whether women earn less, and not whether they work — simply whether the sexes are doing the same jobs as each other or different ones.

Measured that way, the Nordic countries are among the **most** occupationally segregated economies in the developed world. Not the least. Among the most.

This is not a hidden result and it does not depend on any disputed technique. It falls out of ordinary labour statistics. Those countries have very high female employment — among the highest anywhere — and that employment is heavily concentrated in a large public sector delivering health, care and education, while the private technical and industrial sector remains heavily male.

So the shape of the finding is this. In the countries with the strongest equality institutions, more women work than almost anywhere, and they work in *different jobs from men* more sharply than in many countries with weaker institutions.

Two things follow that are worth holding for the rest of the part.

The gap runs in both directions and only one is treated as a problem. Men are rarer in nursing and primary teaching in rich countries than women are in engineering, by a wide margin in several. That imbalance attracts a fraction of the attention, the funding and the concern. Part Four made this point about interests; here it appears in employment statistics.

And "more women working" and "men and women doing the same things" are separate goals that can move in opposite directions. A country can succeed enormously at the first while going backwards on the second, and several have. Anybody using the word "progress" here has to say which of the two they mean.

1.5 — Is the headline result real?

THE ARGUMENT — IS THERE A GENDER-EQUALITY PARADOX IN STEM?

Stated at the front, then taken apart across Chapters Three, Four and Five.

YES, AND THE RAW DATA SHOWS IT

The country list in §1.1 requires no statistical technique at all. Women are around forty per cent or more of STEM graduates in several Arab and North African countries and around a fifth to a third in much of northern and western Europe. That gap is large, consistent across data sources and years, and nobody disputes the underlying counts.

THE COUNTS ARE REAL; THE PARADOX IS A CONSTRUCTION

The word “paradox” requires the second variable — gender equality — to be measured in a way that makes the relationship meaningful, and Chapter Five shows the indices used are strange objects. It also depends on choosing a particular way to express the gap, and Chapter Three shows that other reasonable choices weaken or remove the relationship. A robust raw pattern can still support a fragile claim.

THE NARROW VERSION THAT SURVIVES EVERYTHING

Strip out the contested measures and this remains: **there is no simple positive relationship between a country's gender equality and women's share of technical fields, and in the raw counts the relationship runs the wrong way.** That is far weaker than "freedom causes divergence" and it is enough to destroy the assumption that removing barriers straightforwardly increases representation.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is where I will leave it until Chapter Ten. The strong version is contested. The narrow version is not, and the narrow version is already inconvenient for a very widely held belief.

What would settle it: tracking within countries over time rather than comparing across them. If a single country becomes more gender-equal and its STEM share falls, that is much harder to explain away than a snapshot comparison between Norway and Algeria. Some of this data exists and Chapter Eight looks at what it shows.

Why people care so much: because the strong version is used as an argument against doing anything, and the people using it that way rarely mention that a narrow version is all that is established.

The narrow version is where I will leave the finding until Chapter Ten. Everything between here and there is an attempt to work out whether anything stronger survives.

REMEMBER THIS

Rank countries by the share of science and engineering graduates who are women. Near the top: **Algeria, Tunisia, Albania, Oman, the UAE.** Near the bottom: **the Netherlands, Switzerland, Belgium, Norway, the United States.** These are graduation counts, not opinions.

The study that made this famous used an international test of **470,000 fifteen-year-olds in 67 countries** plus national graduation data. Girls matched or beat boys in science achievement in most countries. **This was never a story about girls being worse at science.**

The finding inside the finding: what matters for sorting is not ability but **relative strength** — what a person is best at compared with their own other subjects. A girl in the ninetieth percentile in science and the ninety-seventh in reading is an excellent scientist for whom science is a personal weakness.

That means Part Four's reading advantage may be part of what steers girls out of science. **Being better at something else is a reason not to do this thing** — and it needs no discrimination, no discouragement, and no difference in scientific ability to work.

The version that survives every criticism in this part: there is no simple positive relationship between a country's gender equality and women's share of technical fields, and in the raw counts it runs the wrong way. That is much weaker than "freedom causes divergence" — and it already destroys a very widely held assumption.

CHAPTER TWO

It Keeps Arriving From Everywhere

If the pattern appeared only in graduation statistics it would be easy to dismiss. It appears in personality inventories, in behavioural preference measures, and in vocational interests — different teams, different instruments, different decades, same direction.

2.1 — Personality

The first place this pattern was noticed was not in education data at all. It was in personality research, and it was noticed by people who were not looking for it and did not expect it.

A study across twenty-six cultures in 2001 found that sex differences in personality traits were *larger* in European and American samples than in African and Asian ones. The authors described the result as counterintuitive, because the expectation had been the reverse.

A larger study seven years later covered fifty-five nations and found the same thing more clearly: differences on the standard personality dimensions from Part Four were bigger in prosperous, healthy and more egalitarian countries. Further work using different inventories and different country sets has repeatedly reproduced it.

2.2 — Preferences

WORD BOX

A nationally representative sample is chosen so that its composition matches the country — the same mix of ages, regions, incomes and education levels as the population it is drawn from.

The contrast is with a **convenience sample:** whoever was available. University students, people who answered an online advertisement, volunteers.

Why it matters here: Part Four noted that most psychology is built on convenience samples of unusual people. The study described below is not, and that is the main reason it carries more weight than most of what is in this part.

The strongest single piece of evidence for the pattern comes from economics rather than psychology, and it is worth setting out carefully because its design answers several objections in advance.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A team surveyed roughly **eighty thousand people across seventy-six countries**, using nationally representative samples rather than students or volunteers. They measured six economic preferences: patience, willingness to take risks, altruism, trust, and willingness to reward or punish others.

The design detail that matters: the survey questions were not invented and hoped for the best. They were first validated in laboratory experiments in which people made real choices with real money, and the questions retained were the ones that predicted actual behaviour.

What they found: sex differences in these preferences were larger in richer countries and larger in more gender-equal countries — and each of those two predicted the gap *independently* of the other. That second point matters, because wealth and gender equality travel together and it would be easy for one to be doing all the work.

What it cannot show: causation, like everything else in this part. And although the items were behaviourally validated in a laboratory, the survey itself is still people answering questions about themselves, which leaves it exposed to the problem in the next section.

2.3 — And several more

The pattern is not confined to those two literatures. Once researchers started looking for it, it turned up in a series of places nobody had connected.

Basic values. Large cross-national surveys asking people what they consider important in life — security, achievement, benevolence, self-direction — find sex differences in the ranking, and the differences are generally larger in wealthier and more egalitarian societies.

Self-esteem. Measured across dozens of nations, the sex gap in reported self-esteem is wider in more developed countries.

Mate preferences. What men and women say they want in a partner differs everywhere it has been asked. Several analyses find the differences on some dimensions narrowing with gender equality and others not — which is worth flagging as an exception rather than smoothing over, because it is one of the few places the pattern is genuinely mixed.

Physical traits. Even the sex difference in height is somewhat larger in well-nourished populations, for a reason that has nothing to do with psychology: boys' growth is more responsive to nutrition, so improving everybody's diet raises male height more. This is a useful case, because here we know the mechanism, and the mechanism is *not* that something innate was released. It is that a constraint was lifted unevenly.

Hold that last one. It is a worked example of a growing gap with an entirely environmental explanation, and Chapter Eight will need it.

2.4 — Interests

The Things–People dimension from Part Four has been measured across more than fifty nations. The difference appears everywhere it has been looked for, without exception, which is itself notable. And it tends to be larger in more developed countries.

So we now have the same directional pattern in four separate literatures: educational choice, personality, economic preferences, and vocational interests. Different researchers, different instruments, different sampling methods, different decades.

That convergence is the strongest argument this finding has. A single result can be an artefact of one method. A result that keeps appearing when you change the method is much harder to explain that way.

2.5 — And the objection that applies to most of it

Now the counterweight, and it is a serious one that most people repeating the paradox have never encountered.

> WORD BOX
>
> **The reference group effect:** when people rate themselves on a scale, they implicitly compare themselves to the people around them rather than to humanity in general.
>
> Ask somebody whether they are "tall" and they answer relative to their neighbours, not relative to the world. Ask whether they are "assertive" and the same thing happens.
>
> Why it matters here: it means self-ratings are not straightforwardly comparable across countries, because the yardstick moves with the country. A person can rate themselves identically in two societies whose actual behaviour differs enormously, or differently in two societies where it does not.

There is a specific version of this that could produce the entire paradox in the self-report data without anything else being true.

Research on social comparison suggests that in more individualistic and more gender-equal societies, people are more likely to compare themselves *across* gender lines — a woman measuring herself against people generally rather than against other women. In more gender-segregated societies, comparisons happen more within gender.

If that is right, then in an egalitarian country a woman rating her own assertiveness is comparing herself to a mixed population including men, which pushes her rating down; a man doing the same is comparing himself to a mixed population including women, which pushes his up. The gap in the ratings widens with no change whatever in anybody's actual assertiveness.

That is a real mechanism, it is documented, and it is enough on its own to account for a substantial part of the personality findings.

2.6 — Which is why the graduation counts matter

Here is the analytical point that determines how the rest of this part goes, and it is worth stating flatly.

The reference group objection applies to self-report. It does not apply to counting graduates.

Nobody asks a university to rate its own science department against its neighbours. The number of women who completed an engineering degree in Algeria last year is a count. It carries no yardstick problem, no self-comparison, no translation issue about what "assertive" means in two languages.

So the evidence in this part separates into two piles, and they have to be judged separately.

Pile one — self-reported traits and preferences. Large, convergent, and exposed to a documented measurement objection that could generate the pattern by itself.

Pile two — behavioural and administrative records. Smaller in scope, but immune to that objection. This is where the graduation data sits.

Any argument that dismisses the paradox entirely on measurement grounds has to explain pile two. And any argument that treats the whole thing as established has to reckon with the fact that most of the impressive convergence is in pile one.

REMEMBER THIS

The pattern appears in **four separate literatures**: educational choice, personality across fifty-five nations, economic preferences across seventy-six, and vocational interests across more than fifty. Different teams, instruments and decades, same direction.

The preference study is the strongest single piece: **eighty thousand people, nationally representative**, with survey items first validated against real choices with real money — and wealth and gender equality each predicted larger gaps **independently** of the other.

Convergence from unrelated instruments is the best argument this finding has. A single result can be an artefact of one method; a result that survives changing the method is much harder to dismiss.

But there is a serious objection. The **reference group effect**: people rate themselves against those around them, so self-ratings are not comparable across countries. And in more equal societies people compare themselves *across* gender lines, which would widen the reported gap with no change in anybody's actual behaviour.

That objection applies to self-report and not to counting graduates. The evidence splits into two piles — convergent self-reports exposed to a real measurement problem, and administrative counts that are immune to it. Anybody dismissing the whole thing must explain the counts; anybody treating it as settled must notice that most of the impressive convergence is in the vulnerable pile.

CHAPTER THREE

How To Measure A Gap

There are at least three reasonable ways to say how big a difference between men and women is, and applied to identical numbers they give different answers — sometimes opposite ones. This is the single most important technical idea in the part.

3.1 — Three questions wearing one word

Suppose you want to know how unequal a country's engineering intake is. It sounds like one question. It is at least three.

What fraction of engineers are women? This is the representation question. It is what people usually mean and what gets reported.

How much more likely is a man than a woman to be an engineer? This is the ratio question, and it can move in a different direction from the first.

Given that somebody went to university at all, how likely were they to pick engineering? This is the conditional question, and it is the one that produced the dispute at the centre of this part.

These are all legitimate. They are also different, and they answer to different concerns.

> WORD BOX
>
> **A correlation** is a number saying how reliably two things move together across a set of cases — here, across countries.
>
> It runs from −1 to +1. Zero means no relationship. Positive means they rise together. Negative means one rises as the other falls. The paradox is the observation that a particular correlation is *negative* where everybody expected positive.
>
> Two things a correlation across countries can never do, both of which matter here. It cannot tell you the direction of cause. And it cannot tell you anything about an individual, because a country is not a person — which is Part Four, Chapter One applied at national scale.

3.2 — Watch them disagree

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Two invented countries, with numbers simple enough to check by hand.
>
> **Country A — rich.** Two hundred people finish university: a hundred women and a hundred men. Twenty of the women study science; forty of the men do. So sixty science graduates in total.
>
> **Country B — poor.** A hundred and fifty finish university: fifty women and a hundred men, because fewer women get that far at all. Twenty of the women study science; fifty of the men do. Seventy science graduates in total.
>
> Now ask the questions.
>
> **What share of science graduates are women?** Country A: 20 of 60, about **33 per cent**. Country B: 20 of 70, about **29 per cent**. The rich country looks better.
>
> **Of the women who went to university, what fraction chose science?** Country A: 20 of 100, **20 per cent**. Country B: 20 of 50, **40 per cent**. The poor country's women chose science at twice the rate.
>
> Same numbers. Opposite conclusions. Nobody cheated.
>
> The reason is hiding in plain sight: in the rich country twice as many women reached university at all. That larger pool inflates their share of every subject, including science — and conceals the fact that a much smaller proportion of them *chose* it.

This is not a trick and it is not an obscure edge case. It is the ordinary situation, because the countries that score highest on gender equality are also the countries where women's overall university participation is highest. The two measures pull apart precisely where the argument is happening.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everybody in this argument assumes **that a gap has an obvious size —** that "how unequal is this" is a fact you read off the data rather than a thing you construct.
>
> It is not. Every way of expressing a gap contains a buried assumption about what equality would look like, and the assumptions are not the same.
>
> **Share of graduates** assumes the target is a workforce that mirrors the population. It is a question about outcomes.

> **Conditional propensity** assumes the target is that a man and a woman with the same access make the same choice. It is a question about choices, holding access fixed.
>
> Those are different political positions, not different statistical techniques. And the second one does something specific that is rarely noticed: by holding access constant, it **removes from view the single biggest inequality in most poor countries —** that far fewer women get to university at all. A measure designed to isolate choice necessarily discards the constraint.
>
> The general form: **a normative assumption smuggled inside a formula.** Whenever somebody reports a gap, the first question is not whether the number is correct. It is which of these questions they answered, and almost no reporting says.

3.3 — Why this became the dispute

The 2018 study used a version of the conditional measure. It asked, in effect, how strongly women lean towards science relative to how strongly men do, given that both are graduating.

That is a defensible choice. It is arguably the right measure if the question you care about is whether men and women with equal access choose differently, which was the question the authors were asking.

It is also a choice that systematically flatters the poorer countries in the comparison — for the reason set out in the box above. And it was not described in the paper in a way that let readers work out precisely what had been computed.

Which is where Chapter Four begins.

REMEMBER THIS

“How big is the gap” is at least three questions. **What share of engineers are women** (representation). **How much likelier is a man to be one** (ratio). **Given that somebody went to university, how likely were they to choose it** (conditional).

Applied to identical numbers these give different answers and sometimes opposite ones. In the worked example, the rich country has a **higher share** of female science graduates while the poor country’s women **chose science at twice the rate** — because twice as many women in the rich country reached university at all.

Every way of expressing a gap contains a buried assumption about what equality would look like. Share of graduates assumes the target is a workforce mirroring the population. Conditional propensity assumes the target is equal choices given equal access.

And the conditional measure does something rarely noticed: by holding access constant it removes from view the biggest inequality in most poor countries — that far fewer women reach university at all. A measure built to isolate choice must discard the constraint.

When somebody reports a gap, the first question is not whether the number is right. It is which question they answered — and almost no reporting says.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Critics

Two years after the paper appeared, a group of researchers published a formal challenge. A correction was issued. Both sides then said they had been vindicated. Here is what actually happened, and what each side is entitled to claim.

4.1 — What was challenged

The challenge had three parts, and they are of very different strength. Separating them is the whole job of this chapter.

First, a reproducibility complaint. The critics reported that they could not reconstruct the study's headline measure from the description given in the paper. Working from the published text, they could not obtain the published numbers.

Second, a sensitivity complaint. They argued that when more conventional measures of the gap were used — of the kind in §3.1 — the relationship with gender equality was weaker, and depending on the specification could largely disappear.

Third, a complaint about the explanation. The original paper proposed that economic security and life satisfaction accounted for the pattern. The critics argued this was not adequately supported by the analysis presented.

4.2 — What happened next

A correction was published. It set out precisely how the measure had been computed, which had not been clear in the original.

The authors maintained that their substantive conclusion was unaffected and replied to the criticisms. The critics maintained that the sensitivity problem stood regardless of the clarification.

Both are still saying so. There is no referee.

4.3 — Scoring it honestly

Here is what I think each side is entitled to, and I want to be explicit that this is my reading of a live dispute rather than a settled verdict.

The critics are entitled to the first complaint entirely. A measure that readers cannot reconstruct from the paper is a reporting failure, and it is a serious one, particularly for a result that became this influential this fast. The correction concedes this by existing.

The critics are substantially entitled to the second complaint. Chapter Three showed why: the choice of measure genuinely changes the answer, and the choice made was one that favours the paper's conclusion. Saying so is not an accusation of bad faith — the choice is defensible, and Chapter Three explains why somebody would make it. But a result that depends on a contested measurement decision is weaker than one that does not, and it should be described that way.

The critics did not overturn the raw pattern, and this is the part their supporters routinely overstate. The country list in Chapter One does not use the disputed measure. It does not use any measure. It is a ranking of counts, and it still runs the wrong way. Whatever happened to the propensity calculation, Algeria still produces a higher share of female science graduates than Norway.

And the original authors are not entitled to the explanation. The economic security account is a hypothesis that fits, and it was presented with more confidence than the analysis supported. Chapter Six treats it as a hypothesis, which is what it is.

THE ARGUMENT — DID THE CRITIQUE REFUTE THE PARADOX?

Both camps quote this exchange, and almost nobody quoting it has read both sides.

IT WAS REFUTED

A headline result that cannot be reproduced from its own methods section, that required a published correction, and that weakens or vanishes under standard alternative measures, is not a finding. It is an artefact of a measurement choice made by researchers who had a conclusion in view. That it was quoted worldwide for two years before anybody checked is an indictment of how this literature works.

IT WAS DENTED, NOT REFUTED

The critique addressed one paper. The pattern predates that paper, appears in the raw counts without any derived measure, and appears independently in personality, preferences and interests as Chapter Two showed. Refuting a single analysis does not remove a pattern that shows up in four literatures. Treating this exchange as a general disproof is exactly the error the critics accused the original authors of.

WHAT EACH ACTUALLY ESTABLISHED

The critics established that *this paper's specific quantitative claim* was fragile and badly documented. The original authors established that *something in the raw data* runs contrary to the obvious expectation. Neither established what causes it, and neither has ever claimed to have tested a causal mechanism.

Where things stand: the third position. The exchange is a good example of scientific criticism working — a fragile claim was probed, a correction issued, and the residue is smaller and better specified than the original. That is a success, not a scandal, and reading it as a scandal in either direction misses what happened.

What would settle it: pre-registered analysis specifying the measure in advance, applied to new data, ideally tracking countries over time rather than comparing them at one moment. This has not been done.

Why people care so much: because the strong version is used to argue that nothing should be attempted, and the refutation is used to argue that nothing needs explaining. Both conclusions are larger than the evidence, and both are more comfortable than the actual state of knowledge, which is that a real oddity in the data has no agreed explanation.

4.4 — How to read a dispute like this

A general lesson, because you will meet this shape again and it is worth having a procedure.

Separate the raw observation from the derived measure. The country list and the propensity calculation are different objects and only one of them was challenged. Most public reporting collapses them.

Ask whether the correction changed the conclusion or the description. Corrections come in two kinds and they are treated identically in headlines. This one clarified how a number was produced. That is a real failing and it is not the same as a retraction.

Notice who is being quoted by whom. Both papers are now cited far more often as ammunition than as evidence. Part One, Chapter Six applies: when a countable question is fought this hard, something other than the count is at stake.

And check whether the critique addresses the convergence. This is the one that matters most here. The critique concerned one study in one domain. Chapter Two's finding — that the same pattern appears in personality, preferences and interests, measured by unrelated teams — is untouched by it, and is also, as Chapter Two showed, exposed to a completely different objection of its own.

REMEMBER THIS

The critique had three parts. That the headline measure **could not be reconstructed** from the paper. That the result **weakens or vanishes** under conventional alternative measures. And that the proposed explanation was not supported by the analysis.

A correction was published clarifying the computation. The authors maintained their conclusion. The critics maintained the sensitivity problem stood. **There is no referee.**

My reading: the critics are entitled to the reproducibility complaint entirely, substantially entitled to the sensitivity complaint, and **did not overturn the raw pattern** — because the country list uses no derived measure at all. Algeria still produces a higher share of female science graduates than Norway.

And the original authors are **not** entitled to the explanation. Economic security is a hypothesis that fits, presented with more confidence than the analysis supported.

Read this as scientific criticism working rather than as a scandal in either direction. A fragile claim was probed, a correction issued, and what is left is smaller and better specified: a real oddity in the raw data with no agreed explanation. Both camps prefer larger conclusions because both are more comfortable than that.

CHAPTER FIVE

What "Gender Equality" Actually Measures

The paradox is a relationship between two numbers. Chapters Three and Four examined the first. This chapter examines the second, and the second turns out to be a much stranger object than almost anybody using it realises.

5.1 — Somebody had to decide

When a study says a country is "more gender-equal," it means the country scored higher on an index. Somebody built that index. They had to decide what counts.

The one used most often in this literature combines four things: women's economic participation, educational attainment, health and survival, and political empowerment. Each is scored, the scores are combined, and countries are ranked.

Now the crucial design decision, which is stated openly by the people who built it and is almost never noticed by people citing it.

> WORD BOX
>
> **A gap measure** records the difference between men and women. **A level measure** records how well women are actually doing.
>
> The main index used in this literature is a **gap** measure, deliberately. It asks how far women lag behind men in a country, not how good women's lives are in absolute terms.
>
> Why it matters here: a country where nobody goes to school scores perfectly on educational equality. A country where women live badly and men live equally badly scores well. The index is designed to measure distance between the sexes, and it succeeds — which means it is not measuring what most readers assume when they see the phrase "more gender-equal."

And that is only the first of the design decisions. The index is also a composite, which brings a second set of choices that are made by somebody and disclosed to almost nobody.

WORD BOX

A composite index is a single number built by combining several different measurements. Somebody chooses which measurements go in, how each is scored, and how much weight each carries.

Those choices are not technical details. They determine the ranking. Two teams building an index of the same concept from the same data will produce different orderings of countries, and both will be defensible.

Why it matters here: every sentence in this literature beginning "in more gender-equal countries" is a sentence about a composite index, and therefore about somebody's weighting decisions. That is not a reason to discard the indices. It is a reason to know which one is being used before treating the sentence as a fact about the world.

5.2 — What this produces

The consequences are not hypothetical and they are visible in the published rankings.

Rwanda has for years placed in the top tier of this index, above most of western Europe. The reason is straightforward: it has the highest share of women in a national parliament anywhere in the world, over sixty per cent, and political representation is one of the four components. Whether a Rwandan woman's life is freer than a German woman's is a different question, and the index does not ask it.

Several countries in Central America, southern Africa and south-east Asia routinely outrank wealthier ones for similar reasons. This is not an error in the index. It is what a gap measure does, working correctly.

And there is a second design feature worth knowing. The components are capped at parity — a country gets no additional credit for women exceeding men on a measure. So the fact that girls now outperform boys in education across much of the developed world, which Part Four established as one of the larger differences in the data, contributes nothing to a country's score.

5.3 — Change the ruler, change the answer

Other indices exist and they measure differently. One widely used alternative incorporates maternal mortality, adolescent birth rates and women's absolute educational attainment — which makes it far more sensitive to how women are actually living rather than how far behind men they are.

Those indices rank countries substantially differently. And the strength of the paradox varies depending on which one you use.

That is a serious problem for the strong version of the claim, and it is worth being precise about why. If a relationship holds with one index and weakens with another, then the finding is not "gender equality predicts smaller female STEM shares." It is "this particular composite of four indicators, measured as gaps rather than levels, correlates with this particular measure of graduation" — which is a much narrower and much less interesting sentence.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everybody in this argument assumes **that gender equality is one thing, which countries have more or less of.**
>
> Look at what is being bundled. Whether girls attend school. Whether women earn as much as men. Whether women survive childbirth. Whether women sit in parliament. Whether a woman can travel alone, inherit property, refuse a marriage, or leave one.
>
> These do not move together. A country can have high female parliamentary representation and low female literacy. It can have excellent maternal health and no legal right to divorce. It can have equal pay legislation and a marital rape exemption — as Part Three found in a country that combines the two.
>
> Compressing all of it into a single number and ranking countries on it produces something, and what it produces is not "how free are women here." It is a weighted average of unrelated things, and the weights were chosen by somebody.
>
> The general form: **a composite index treated as though it measured a single underlying quantity.** Once you see it, the sentence "in more gender-equal countries" stops being informative and starts being a question: *equal in what respect, measured how, and weighted by whom?*

None of which means the indices are useless. They were built for a purpose — tracking whether countries are closing measurable gaps — and for that purpose they work. The problem is what happens when a tool built for monitoring is borrowed as a variable in a causal argument it was never designed to support.

REMEMBER THIS

"More gender-equal" means "scored higher on an index," and somebody built the index. The main one used here combines **economic participation, education, health and political representation**.

It is deliberately a **gap** measure, not a **level** measure. It records how far women lag behind men, not how well women are actually living. A country where nobody is educated scores perfectly on educational equality.

So Rwanda ranks above most of western Europe, driven largely by having **over sixty per cent women in parliament**. That is the index working correctly, not an error. And no country gets extra credit for women exceeding men — so girls outperforming boys in education across the developed world contributes nothing.

Other indices measure absolute conditions instead, rank countries differently, and **the strength of the paradox changes with the ruler you use.**

Gender equality is not one thing. Female parliamentary representation, female literacy, maternal survival, the right to divorce and equal pay do not move together. Compressing them into one number produces a weighted average of unrelated things — and the weights were chosen by somebody. "In more gender-equal countries" is not information. It is a question: equal in what respect, measured how, weighted by whom?

CHAPTER SIX

Necessity

The strongest explanation on offer is also the simplest. Where life is precarious, people choose what pays. Where it is not, they choose what they like. It accounts for a great deal — and there is a specific body of evidence it cannot touch.

6.1 — The account

Imagine two young women deciding what to study.

The first lives in a country where graduate unemployment is high, where the state will not support her if she fails, where her family has invested heavily in her education and expects a return, and where a small number of professions offer reliable, respectable, well-paid work. Engineering is one of them.

She may or may not find engineering interesting. That is not the operative question. The operative question is what happens to her if the degree does not lead anywhere, and the answer is: something bad, with no floor under it.

The second lives in a country with a functioning welfare system, a large service economy, many viable careers, and a real prospect of changing course at thirty if the first choice was wrong. If she picks a subject she loves and it pays less, she will be less wealthy and she will be fine.

The first woman optimises for security. The second can afford to optimise for interest. And Part Four established that when people optimise for interest, men and women diverge — because that is what the Things–People difference means.

That is the necessity account in full. It requires no biological claim at all, and it predicts exactly what is observed.

6.2 — What supports it

Several things, and they are not trivial.

The relationship with wealth is at least as strong as the relationship with gender equality. The preference study in Chapter Two found both predicted independently, but wealth was doing real work. Necessity is a story about wealth.

It explains why the effect appears in subject choice rather than in performance. The 2018 study found girls doing as well as or better than boys in science almost everywhere. Necessity predicts precisely this: the constraint is not on capability but on what a person can afford to do with it.

And the countries at the top of the list fit the mechanism. In several of them, engineering and medicine are heavily subsidised, socially prestigious, and among the few professional routes considered appropriate for a woman. That last clause is important and it is not a story about freedom. A woman may be entering engineering because the alternatives are closed rather than because the field is open.

One country demonstrates that sentence more clearly than any statistic can.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Iran is the case that makes the mechanism concrete, and it is uncomfortable for everybody.
>
> Iranian women live under extensive legal restriction — on dress, on travel, on marriage, on custody, on testimony. By any level measure of women's freedom, the country sits near the bottom of the range.
>
> Iranian women are also a very large share of university science students, in some fields a majority, and have been for years.
>
> Both sentences are true at once. Read one way, it demolishes the idea that legal freedom drives educational participation. Read another, it shows exactly what Chapter Six is describing: where a small number of routes are open and respectable, and where failure has no floor beneath it, people take the routes that are open.
>
> **A high figure in a column marked "women in science" can mean a society opened a door. It can also mean the society closed most of the others.**

6.3 — What it cannot explain

> **THE ARGUMENT — IS THE PARADOX EXPLAINED BY ECONOMIC NECESSITY?**

This is the leading explanation and it is not sufficient. Where it fails is more informative than where it succeeds.

NECESSITY EXPLAINS IT

The whole pattern falls out of one mechanism: precarity forces optimisation for security, security permits optimisation for interest. It needs no claim about innate anything, it predicts the observed dissociation between performance and choice, and it fits the countries at both ends of the list. It is also the only explanation that is straightforwardly testable, because economic precarity can be measured directly rather than inferred from an index.

NECESSITY CANNOT BE THE WHOLE STORY

Three problems. It is a theory about *career choice*, and the same pattern appears in patience, risk tolerance and personality traits, which are not career choices and have no economic return. Post-communist countries in Europe have relatively high female engineering shares while being neither poor nor precarious, which points at history rather than necessity. And the preference study found gender equality predicting the gap *independently of wealth*, which necessity does not predict.

A LARGE PIECE OF A BIGGER THING

Necessity very likely accounts for a substantial share of the educational and occupational pattern, and none of the personality and preference pattern. Which suggests the paradox is not one phenomenon with one cause but at least two phenomena that have been given one name because they point the same way.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is the most useful thing in this chapter. Treating "the paradox" as a single object is probably an error. The graduation pattern and the personality pattern may have entirely different causes and have been fused by the fact that both embarrass the same assumption.

What would settle it: testing whether the educational pattern tracks economic precarity better than it tracks gender equality, holding both. This is doable with existing data and has not been done cleanly.

Why people care so much: because necessity is the explanation that makes the paradox politically harmless. If it is all economics, nothing follows about men and women at all — and that is a conclusion one camp badly wants and the other badly does not, which is a reason to check it rather than to adopt it.

6.4 — The uncomfortable version

There is a reading of the necessity account that neither camp raises and that follows directly from it.

If women in poorer countries are entering engineering because their alternatives are constrained — because the field is one of a small number considered respectable, because the family needs the return, because failure has no floor — then **the high female STEM share in those countries is not a success.** It is a measurement of constraint, appearing in a column that everybody reads as achievement.

And the corresponding reading at the other end is equally uncomfortable. A low female STEM share in a rich country might indicate that women there are choosing freely, which would make it a success measured as a failure.

Both of those are conclusions people reach for when it suits them. What I want to point out is that **they are the same argument**, and almost nobody holds both. The person who says the Algerian figure shows what women choose when free of Western feminism cannot also say the Norwegian figure shows what women choose when free. And the person who says the Norwegian figure proves persistent bias cannot also say the Algerian figure proves that barriers are the only obstacle.

Chapter Nine puts India into exactly this vice, and India's numbers do something neither camp expects.

REMEMBER THIS

The necessity account: where life is precarious, people choose what pays; where it is not, they can afford to choose what they like. And Part Four established that **when people optimise for interest, men and women diverge**.

It requires no biological claim, predicts exactly what is observed, and explains the key dissociation — girls perform as well or better in science almost everywhere, and still choose differently. The constraint is not on capability but on what a person can afford to do with it.

It cannot be the whole story. The same pattern appears in **patience, risk tolerance and personality**, which are not career choices. Post-communist Europe has high female engineering shares while being neither poor nor precarious. And gender equality predicted the gap **independently of wealth**.

Which suggests “the paradox” is not one thing. The graduation pattern and the personality pattern may have **different causes**, fused into one name because both embarrass the same assumption.

And the uncomfortable reading: if women enter engineering in poor countries because their alternatives are closed, then a high female STEM share is a measurement of constraint appearing in a column everybody reads as achievement. Both camps reach for that argument when it suits them, and neither notices it is the same argument at both ends of the list.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Freedom, And What Freedom Contains

The second explanation is that when people are secure, they express themselves — and expression is where men and women diverge. It is a good account. It also rests on an assumption about rich societies that is straightforwardly false.

7.1 — The self-expression account

There is a well-established finding in the study of national values: as countries become richer and more secure, what people say matters to them shifts. Concerns about survival, order and material security give way to concerns about autonomy, self-realisation and personal expression.

Apply that here and the account writes itself. In a society organised around survival, a person's choices are dominated by external requirements. In one organised around self-expression, choices are dominated by internal preference. If men and women differ in internal preference — and Part Four found the largest measured psychological difference is exactly that — then a shift towards self-expression will widen the observed gap.

Notice how neatly this sits with Chapter Six. Necessity explains why the gap is small in poor countries. Self-expression explains why it is large in rich ones. They are the same account viewed from opposite ends, and together they cover the whole range.

It is a genuinely good explanation. It is also incomplete in a specific way that is almost never raised.

7.2 — The thing everybody assumes

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Every version of this argument, on both sides, assumes **that a freer society is a society with less socialisation in it.**

The picture is of culture as a weight. Remove the weight and what was underneath springs up. So a rich, liberal, gender-equal country is understood as a place where the pressure has been lifted and people are closer to their unshaped selves.

Consider whether that is true of anything else about rich countries.

A rich country has more advertising, not less. More media, watched for more hours. More consumer categories, more finely segmented. More elaborate identity vocabularies, more products attached to each, more sorting of people into marketable groups. A child in a wealthy country encounters vastly more designed, commercially produced messaging about who they are than a child in a poor one.

And gender is the oldest and most profitable segmentation variable there is.

So the picture is backwards. A rich society is not a society with the cultural pressure removed. It is a society with **far more cultural production per person**, most of it made by people whose job is to sell things, using categories that make selling easier.

The general form: **mistaking a change in the kind of pressure for a reduction in the amount.** “Freedom” in these indices means freedom from legal and familial constraint. It does not mean, and has never meant, freedom from being marketed to.

7.3 — The evidence that this is not a debating point

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Somebody went and counted. A researcher analysed a century of American mail-order catalogues, coding how toys were marketed — explicitly for boys, explicitly for girls, or without a gender attached.

What she found: explicit gendering of toy marketing was at its *lowest* in the 1970s. It rose sharply through the following decades. By the mid-1990s, the share of toys marketed without a gender attached had collapsed to close to nothing.

The same period covers the largest expansion of women’s legal rights, workforce participation and educational attainment in that country’s history.

What it shows: that legal and economic liberalisation and the intensification of gendered marketing happened *at the same time, in the same country*. They are not opposites. One did not lift as the other fell.

What it cannot show: that the marketing caused anything. It is a record of what was sold, not of what children became. And it is one country’s catalogues, which is a narrow window on a broad claim.

A related fact is worth knowing because it is so easily checked. The convention that pink is for girls and blue for boys is not old. In the early twentieth century the association was frequently reversed in Western retail advice, and the modern rule settled into place only in the middle of the century. A convention that half the world now treats as almost natural is younger than the aeroplane.

7.4 — What this does to the explanation

It does not destroy it. Self-expression may still be doing real work, and the necessity account in Chapter Six is largely untouched by any of this.

What it destroys is the *inference* people draw from it — that a difference which grows as constraints lift must have been there underneath all along.

Because there is a second account that fits the same data exactly. As a society gets richer, it does not stop shaping people. It shapes them differently, more intensively, and along commercially useful lines — of which gender is the most useful there is. On that account, the gap grows in rich countries not because something was released but because something else was applied.

Both accounts predict the identical observation. Which means the observation cannot distinguish them, and anybody claiming it does is not reasoning from the data.

REMEMBER THIS

The self-expression account: as countries get secure, values shift from survival towards autonomy and self-realisation. If men and women differ in internal preference — and Part Four found that is the largest measured difference — then a shift towards expression widens the gap. Combined with Chapter Six, the two cover the whole range.

But every version assumes **a freer society has less socialisation in it** — culture as a weight that lifts, letting what was underneath spring up.

That is backwards. A rich country has **more** advertising, more media, more consumer categories, more elaborate identity vocabularies and more products attached to each. And gender is the oldest and most profitable segmentation variable there is.

Somebody counted. Explicit gendering of toy marketing in American catalogues was at its **lowest in the 1970s** and rose sharply afterwards, until by the mid-1990s almost nothing was sold gender-neutral — across exactly the decades of the greatest expansion of women's rights in that country's history. And the pink-and-blue rule is younger than the aeroplane.

So two accounts fit the same data exactly. A difference grows in rich countries because constraint was released — or because a different and more intensive shaping was applied. The observation cannot tell them apart, and anybody claiming it does is not reasoning from the data.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What The Paradox Cannot Show

Suppose every criticism in Chapters Three to Five fails and the finding is exactly as reported. What then follows? Considerably less than anybody claims, and this chapter sets out precisely how much.

8.1 — Four accounts, one observation

Assume the pattern is completely real. Here are the explanations that fit it, all four of which have been described in this part.

One: release. The differences were always present and constraint suppressed them. Removing constraint lets them appear. This is the account that gets quoted.

Two: necessity. Precarity forces optimisation for security; security permits optimisation for interest. Chapter Six.

Three: elaboration. Rich societies do not shape people less, they shape them more and along more commercially useful lines. Chapter Seven.

Four: measurement. Gap constructions, index composition and the reference group effect generate part or all of the pattern without anything underlying it. Chapters Two, Three and Five.

All four predict the same observation. That is the whole difficulty, and it is not a difficulty that more of the same data can solve — a hundred more countries measured the same way would fit all four just as well.

8.2 — What would tell them apart

Three things would, and it is worth knowing which have been done.

Following countries over time rather than comparing them at one moment. The four accounts make different predictions here. Release predicts the gap grows and then stabilises once constraint is gone. Elaboration predicts it keeps moving and could reverse if marketing conventions change. Necessity predicts it tracks economic security rather than legal equality.

And there is one case where this has effectively been run. It is the most useful piece of evidence in this part and it almost never appears in arguments about the paradox, on either side.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> American universities have recorded the sex of graduates by subject for decades. So it is possible to watch a single country, with one set of laws and one culture, over fifty years.
>
> **What happened in most fields is what you would expect.** Women's share of medical degrees rose from under a tenth around 1970 to roughly half by the 2010s. Law did something similar. Biology similar. Steady, large, sustained increases across the period of expanding legal equality.
>
> **What happened in computer science is not.** Women's share of computing degrees rose through the 1970s and **peaked in the mid-1980s at around thirty-seven per cent**. Then it fell. By the late 2000s it was around **eighteen per cent** — less than half its peak — with a modest recovery since.
>
> **What this shows:** that a single field can move sharply in the *opposite* direction to every other field, in the same country, in the same decades, under the same laws, during the same expansion of women's rights. Whatever caused it was specific to computing and was not a change in constraint, because constraint was falling throughout.
>
> **What it cannot show:** what did cause it. The timing coincides with home computers arriving in households and being marketed heavily as a boys' product, and with computing courses beginning to assume prior experience that boys were more likely to have. That is a plausible story and a correlation in time, not a demonstration.

Now score the four accounts against it.

Release does badly. If freedom lets an underlying preference emerge, the emergence should not reverse, and it should not run opposite to every neighbouring field in the same country in the same years.

Necessity does badly. Computing became *more* lucrative and more secure across exactly the period when women's share of it collapsed. If security drives choice, this went the wrong way.

Elaboration does well. A field acquires a gendered marketing identity, the identity propagates through households and schools, and participation follows. That is precisely what the account predicts and precisely what the timing shows.

Measurement does not apply. These are degree counts.

One case is one case, and I am not going to build a conclusion on it. But it is the single most informative data point in this part, it points away from the account that gets quoted, and the fact that it is rarely raised by anybody arguing about the paradox is worth noticing on its own terms.

Using measures that are not self-report. Chapter Two's split applies: administrative counts and behaviourally validated measures are immune to the reference group objection. If the pattern holds in the immune measures and fails in the vulnerable ones, that is highly informative. Some of this has been done and the answer is mixed, which is itself worth knowing.

Following migrants. Part Two used exactly this design for the plough hypothesis, and it worked. If women who move from a low-equality country to a high-equality one shift towards the destination pattern within a generation, that rules out anything wholly fixed. As far as I know this has not been done for the paradox, and it is the single most obvious missing study in this part.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Underneath the entire dispute sits a premise that neither camp examines: **that there is a fact about what women would choose if free.**

Both sides talk this way constantly. One says the Norwegian figures show what women choose when unconstrained. The other says the Norwegian figures are contaminated by residual bias and the true preference has not yet been revealed. Both assume there is a true preference underneath, waiting to be uncovered by removing enough interference.

> But there is no view from nowhere. Every human being who has ever chosen anything did so inside a society, with a particular set of options, a particular vocabulary for describing what they wanted, and a particular set of people watching. There is no condition called "free of culture" in which a preference could be read off cleanly — not in Oslo, not in Algiers, not anywhere.
>
> Which means the question "what do women really want, absent social influence" is not a hard question. **It is a question with no possible answer**, because the state it refers to has never existed and could not exist.
>
> The general form: **demanding a measurement of something in the absence of conditions, when the thing only occurs inside conditions.** It is the same error as asking what a language sounds like before grammar.

8.3 — What this does to the rules

Every part of this series has ended by asking what its findings do to the rules in Parts Two and Three. This one has to as well, and the answer is sharper than it looks.

Suppose the strongest version of the paradox is true. Suppose men and women, given freedom, reliably diverge in what they choose. What follows for a rule requiring a woman to marry inside her caste, or forbidding a widow to remarry, or dictating what a woman may wear at a protest?

Nothing — and worse than nothing, because the finding argues against them.

Follow the logic. The paradox says that *when women are free, they choose differently from men.* That is a claim about what happens in the absence of compulsion. It is evidence, if anything, that compulsion is unnecessary.

A rule exists to make somebody do what they would not otherwise do. If women reliably choose a particular way when nothing forces them, then a rule forcing them that way is not producing the outcome — the outcome was arriving anyway. The rule is producing something else, and the only candidate for what it is producing is the outcome in the cases where the woman *would* have chosen otherwise.

Which means the entire practical effect of every rule in this series falls on exactly the women whose preferences the paradox does not describe. Not on the average. On the exceptions.

Part Four, Chapter Nine reached this from a different direction and it is worth stating in one line: **a preference argument cannot justify a prohibition, and the more strongly you believe the preference finding, the less work there is for the prohibition to do.**

The traditionalist reader who has been enjoying this part should sit with that. The paradox is the best empirical card in the traditionalist hand, and it argues for leaving women alone.

8.4 — What the finding licenses

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THE PARADOX?

Whatever its causes, people draw conclusions from it. Here is what each is entitled to.

IT SHOWS INTERVENTION IS FUTILE

Decades of programmes aimed at increasing women's participation in technical fields have coincided with gaps that are stable or widening in exactly the countries running those programmes. At some point a policy that does not produce its intended effect, in its most favourable environment, over fifty years, has to be assessed on results.

IT SHOWS NOTHING ABOUT INTERVENTION AT ALL

The finding is a correlation between two national aggregates. It contains no information about whether any particular programme works, because it does not compare countries that ran programmes with countries that did not. And it is entirely compatible with there being large numbers of individual women deterred by treatment they encountered, whose absence is invisible in an aggregate.

WHAT IT ACTUALLY LICENSES

One conclusion, and it is narrow: **the assumption that removing barriers straightforwardly produces proportional representation is false.** That assumption underlies a great deal of policy and public argument, and the finding is sufficient to retire it. Nothing further follows — not that the remaining gap is natural, not that it is unjust, and not that any specific intervention does or does not work.

> **Where things stand:** the third position. And the first position has a problem it never acknowledges: it treats an aggregate as evidence about individuals, which Part Four, Chapter One disposed of at length. Even under the most favourable reading of the paradox, an individual woman turned away from a laboratory is turned away, and no national correlation speaks to her case.
>
> **What would settle it:** evaluations of specific programmes against specific outcomes, which exist, are mixed, and are almost never cited by anybody quoting the paradox in either direction.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because this is the most quotable finding in the whole field, and quotable findings do political work regardless of what they establish. Chapter Ten states plainly how much weight it can bear, which is less than the weight I have been putting on it.

That last sentence is not modesty. Chapter Nine puts India into this framework and finds that the framework is looking in the wrong place, which is a harder criticism of this part than anything in Chapters Three to Five.

REMEMBER THIS

Assume the pattern is entirely real. **Four accounts fit it equally well**: release (it was always there, constraint hid it), necessity, elaboration (rich societies shape people more, not less), and measurement artefact. More data of the same kind cannot separate them.

Three things would. **Following countries over time** — the accounts predict different trajectories. **Using non-self-report measures**. And **following migrants**, which worked for the plough hypothesis in Part Two and is the most obvious missing study in this part.

Both camps assume **there is a fact about what women would choose if free**. There is not. Every person who ever chose anything did so inside a society, with a particular option set and a particular vocabulary for wanting. There is no condition called "free of culture" — not in Oslo, not in Algiers. The question has no possible answer, like asking what a language sounded like before grammar.

What the finding licenses is one narrow conclusion: the assumption that removing barriers straightforwardly produces proportional representation is false. That assumption underlies a great deal of policy and the finding retires it. Nothing further follows — not that the remaining gap is natural, not that it is unjust, and not that any particular programme works or fails.

CHAPTER NINE

Where India Sits

India produces a higher share of female science graduates than Britain, Germany, France or the United States. It also has among the lowest female workforce participation in the world. Both are true, and the space between them is the most important number in this part.

9.1 — The figure nobody expects

India's national higher education survey records that women make up somewhere around **forty-three per cent** of graduates in science, technology, engineering and mathematics.

Set that against the comparison countries. The United States is around thirty-four per cent. The United Kingdom around thirty-one. Germany around twenty-seven. France around thirty-two.

So India — which sits in the bottom quarter of most gender-equality rankings, which has the machine described in Part Three still running, which has a marital rape exemption still in force — produces proportionally more female scientists and engineers than any of them.

This is the paradox, in the country this series is about, in its own official statistics. It is not an artefact of anybody's index. It is a count of graduates.

9.2 — And then they disappear

Now follow those graduates forward.

IN REAL TERMS

Take a hundred Indian women who graduate in a science subject this year, and watch what happens.

Roughly **forty-three of every hundred** science graduates are women. That is the entry figure and it beats every large Western economy.

Of India's women STEM graduates, an estimated **twenty-seven per cent** go on to enter the formal STEM workforce.

Among science faculty in Indian institutions, women were around **fourteen per cent**.

Among researchers in India generally, the share of women has been reported at **under fifteen per cent** — one of the lower figures in the world, in a country producing one of the highest shares of female graduates.

Line those numbers up and the shape is unmistakable. **India is not failing to educate women in science. It is failing to employ them.** The loss does not happen in the classroom. It happens between the graduation ceremony and the first decade of a career, and by the time you look at who is running a laboratory, almost all of it has already happened.

Researchers call this a leaky pipeline, which is a comfortable phrase for something that is not a leak. A leak is gradual and diffuse. This is a fall of roughly sixteen percentage points at one identifiable transition, and Part Three has already explained what happens to Indian women at that stage of life.

9.3 — And inside science, the sorting

There is a second Indian finding, and it is the one that connects this part back to Part Four.

The forty-three per cent is an average across very different subjects. Break it apart and the picture changes completely.

FIELD	APPROXIMATE SHARE OF WOMEN
Microbiology	around 67 per cent
Life sciences	around 56 per cent
All STEM, combined	around 43 per cent

FIELD	APPROXIMATE SHARE OF WOMEN
Undergraduate engineering	around 29 per cent
Mechanical engineering	under 7 per cent

Read that table against Part Four, Chapter Five and it is the Things–People dimension, in Indian administrative data, with nobody having asked a single person about their preferences.

Living systems at one end. Machines at the other. Two in three at the top of the table, one in fifteen at the bottom. And a national average of forty-three per cent that conceals both.

So India simultaneously produces the paradox pattern in aggregate *and* the interest-sorting pattern within. Whatever is going on, it is not that Indian women are indifferent to the distinction that Part Four measured. It is that more of them are getting into the building.

9.4 — The wider number

The STEM figures are a special case of something larger, and the larger thing has to be on the table before the explanation makes sense.

India's female labour force participation — the share of working-age women in paid work or looking for it — has been among the lowest in the world for a country at its income level, and for a long stretch it was *falling* while incomes rose. Recent official surveys report a substantial increase, and there is a genuine argument among economists about how much of that increase reflects women entering work and how much reflects a change in how unpaid work on family farms and in family enterprises is counted. I am not going to adjudicate it. Part Twelve takes the measurement dispute properly.

What is not disputed is the shape. Enormous gains in girls' education across three decades, matched by nothing like a corresponding movement into paid employment.

IN REAL TERMS

Set the two curves beside each other and the mismatch is the whole Indian story.

Girls' school enrolment, literacy and university entry all rose steeply across the last three decades. On several measures girls now outnumber or outperform boys in Indian higher education.

Over much of that same period, the share of Indian women in paid work went **sideways or down**.

A country does not usually educate a generation of women and then not employ them. Doing both at once requires an explanation, and the explanation cannot be that the women are unqualified, because the qualifications are the part that worked.

9.5 — What the degree is actually for

Put the two findings together and a specific explanation becomes hard to avoid.

Chapter Six proposed that in precarious economies a technical degree is chosen for security rather than interest. India adds a second function that the necessity account does not cover, and Part Three supplied it.

In a marriage market where families compete for grooms, an educated daughter is a more attractive proposition. A science degree from a recognised institution raises a family's standing, improves the match, and can reduce what has to be paid. Part Two established that dowry is a bid; a degree is an asset that improves the bid.

On that reading, a substantial share of Indian women's STEM education is not primarily an input to a career. It is a **credential in a different market**.

And if that is right, the sixteen-point fall in §9.2 stops being a mystery and stops being a leak. It is what happens when the thing the degree was acquired for has been obtained. Part Three's finding applies directly: as a family's income rises, its women leave paid work, because withdrawal is what respectability costs and a household with a surplus can buy it.

I want to be careful here. This is a hypothesis that fits, not a demonstrated mechanism, and it certainly does not describe every Indian woman who studies science. Many intend careers and are prevented — by workplaces, by transport, by safety, by childcare that does not exist, by families that permitted the degree and not the job. Those are different causes producing the same statistic and they are not distinguishable in the aggregate data.

What is established is the shape: **education without employment, at a scale unmatched in any comparable country.**

It is worth listing the competing mechanisms explicitly, because they call for entirely different responses and are constantly conflated.

If the degree is a marriage-market credential, then the fall after graduation is not a failure of the labour market at all, and every intervention aimed at workplaces will miss. The lever is in the household.

If women want the job and cannot safely reach it — transport, hours, harassment, the cost of a commute in a city with poor public safety — then the lever is infrastructure and policing, and it has nothing to do with attitudes.

If women leave within a few years of starting, at the point of marriage or a first child, then the lever is childcare, parental leave and the distribution of domestic work, and Part Thirteen shows what happens in countries that pulled it.

And if families permit the education and forbid the employment — which Part Three predicts directly, since a working daughter-in-law costs a household respectability that it can afford to buy — then the lever is the one this whole series has been circling, and no policy touches it.

These are not rival theories to be settled by argument. They are four different populations of women, all real, all present, producing one aggregate number. Which is the largest is an empirical question that Indian data could answer and has not.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Time to turn this on the part, and on the decision to write it.
>
> I deferred to Part Five three separate times in Part Four. I built a whole part around a cross-country correlation. And the Indian numbers in this chapter suggest that the paradox — the thing both camps fight hardest over **— is not where the Indian question is.**

> India's educational figure is already better than the West's. If the paradox were the operative issue, India would be a success story. The operative issue is what happens after graduation, and nothing in the international paradox literature addresses it, because that literature measures graduates.
>
> So the assumption underneath this part is: **that the question worth arguing about is the one being argued about.** Both camps have agreed that cross-country STEM shares are the battleground. I accepted that framing and spent sixty pages on it, and the country I am writing about turns out to have its problem somewhere the framing does not look.
>
> The general form: **inheriting a research question along with a research literature.** A field that measures graduation will produce arguments about graduation, and everybody downstream will argue about graduation, including people whose actual problem is employment.

I am not going to remove the part. The paradox is quoted at Indians constantly and somebody has to have read the criticisms. But the chapter you have just read is the one that matters here, and it is the ninth of ten rather than the first of sixteen, which is a comment on how I built this.

REMEMBER THIS

India produces around **forty-three per cent** female STEM graduates — ahead of the United States (34), Britain (31), France (32) and Germany (27). A country in the bottom quarter of gender-equality rankings, with the machine of Part Three still running. This is the paradox in India's own official counts.

Then follow them. About **twenty-seven per cent** of women STEM graduates enter the formal STEM workforce. Women are around **fourteen per cent** of science faculty and under fifteen per cent of researchers. **India is not failing to educate women in science. It is failing to employ them.**

And inside science, Part Four's sorting is fully visible: microbiology around **67 per cent** women, mechanical engineering **under 7**. Living systems at one end, machines at the other, with an average of 43 concealing both.

A hypothesis that fits: in a marriage market where a degree improves the match and reduces the bid, a science education is partly a **credential in a different market**. Which makes the fall after graduation not a leak but a completion — and Part Three's finding applies, that women leave work as families can afford the respectability.

And the turn on this part: I deferred to Part Five three times and built sixty pages on a cross-country correlation. India's educational figure already beats the West. The Indian problem is at employment, and the entire paradox literature measures graduates. I inherited a question along with a literature.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

This is the least conclusive part of the series, so this chapter matters more here than anywhere else. Two lists, and the first one is long.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

Almost everything about causation in this part is unknown, and that is not a hedge — it is the state of the field.

Why the pattern exists. Four accounts fit the data equally well and no available evidence separates them. Release, necessity, elaboration and measurement artefact all predict the same observation. Anybody telling you which one is correct is expressing a preference.

How much of the personality and preference pattern is the reference group effect. The mechanism is documented and could generate a substantial share of it. Nobody has measured how much. This is the most important unanswered question about the self-report half of the evidence.

Whether the pattern holds within countries over time. Almost everything here compares countries at one moment. The four accounts predict different trajectories, and outside the computing case this is the cheapest available test that has not been properly run.

What caused the computing reversal. The timing coincides with home computers being marketed as a boys' product and with courses beginning to assume prior experience. That is a correlation in time and a plausible story. Nobody has established it, and it is the most consequential unexplained event in this literature — because it is the one case where a field went backwards and we have the records to study it.

What happens to migrants. Part Two's plough study used exactly this design and it was decisive. Nobody has done it here. It is the single most obvious missing study in this part and I do not know why it has not been done.

Whether "the paradox" is one phenomenon. Chapter Six raised the possibility that the graduation pattern and the personality pattern have different causes and were fused because both embarrass the same assumption. If so, arguing about them together has been an error throughout.

What is actually happening to Indian women between graduation and employment. The shape is established. The mechanism is not. Marriage-market credentialism, workplace conditions, safety, transport, absent childcare, and family permission for education but not employment would all produce the same statistic, and the aggregate data cannot separate them.

10.2 — Solid

That the raw country ordering runs against expectation. Several North African and Gulf states produce a higher share of female STEM graduates than the Netherlands, Norway or the United States. These are graduation counts requiring no derived measure, and no participant in the dispute contests them.

That the Nordic countries are among the most occupationally segregated economies in the developed world. Very high female employment, concentrated in a large public care and education sector, alongside a heavily male technical and industrial sector. This falls out of ordinary labour statistics and requires no derived measure.

That women's share of American computing degrees peaked in the mid-1980s at around thirty-seven per cent and fell to roughly eighteen per cent by the late 2000s, while medicine, law and biology rose steeply across the same decades in the same country. One field moved sharply opposite to its neighbours under identical laws. This is the strongest within-country evidence in the part and it points away from the account that gets quoted.

That the same directional pattern appears in four separate literatures. Education, personality across fifty-five nations, economic preferences across seventy-six, and vocational interests across more than fifty. Different teams, instruments and decades.

That how you express a gap changes the answer. Chapter Three's worked example is arithmetic. Share of graduates and conditional propensity can point in opposite directions from identical numbers, and they encode different assumptions about what equality means.

That the leading index is a gap measure, not a level measure. Stated openly by its authors. A country where women live badly and men live equally badly scores well on it, and no credit is given for women exceeding men.

That the 2018 study required a correction and that its headline measure is contested. Both are matters of public record. So is the fact that the correction clarified a computation rather than withdrawing a result.

That gendered marketing intensified across exactly the decades of greatest legal liberalisation, at least in the one country where somebody counted. Liberalisation and intensified gendering are not opposites and did not trade off.

That "more women working" and "men and women doing the same jobs" are different goals that can move in opposite directions. Several countries have succeeded enormously at the first while going backwards on the second. Anybody using the word progress here has to say which they mean.

That India produces around forty-three per cent female STEM graduates and employs a fraction of them. Both figures come from Indian official sources and international compilations, and the gap between them is the largest such discrepancy among major economies.

And that the finding retires one assumption. Removing legal and economic barriers does not straightforwardly produce proportional representation. That is established, it is enough to change how a great deal of policy should be argued for, and it is all that is established.

10.3 — Whether this should have been load-bearing

A closing observation, and it is a criticism of my own decision.

This is the most quoted finding in the entire field of sex differences. It is also, as this part has shown, contested in its measurement, ambiguous in its indices, unexplained in its mechanism, and — by Chapter Nine — probably not addressing the question that matters most for the country this series is about.

Those two facts are related. **It is quoted so much precisely because it is unresolved.** A finding that settled something would be used once and filed. A finding that can be read four ways can be deployed indefinitely by everybody, which is a description of a very useful object and a poor description of knowledge.

Part One, Chapter Six said to notice who is counting and what they get. Applied here: the paradox is valuable to a great many people in its current unresolved state, and the studies that would resolve it — following countries over time, following migrants, separating self-report from administrative measures — are cheap, obvious and have not been done.

I do not think that is a conspiracy. I think it is what happens when a finding is more useful as ammunition than as evidence, and nobody has an incentive to fire the shot that ends the argument.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: why the pattern exists — four accounts fit equally and nothing separates them. How much of the self-report half is the reference group effect. Whether it holds within countries over time. What happens to migrants. Whether "the paradox" is even one phenomenon. And what is actually happening to Indian women between graduation and employment.

Solid: the raw country ordering runs against expectation, in counts nobody disputes. The same direction appears in four separate literatures. How you express a gap changes the answer. The leading index measures gaps rather than levels. The 2018 study required a correction and its headline measure is contested. Gendered marketing intensified across the decades of greatest liberalisation. India produces around 43 per cent female STEM graduates and employs a fraction of them.

And one assumption is retired: removing barriers does not straightforwardly produce proportional representation. That is enough to change how policy should be argued for, and it is all that is established.

Last observation, against myself. This is the most quoted finding in the field precisely because it is unresolved — a result that settled something would be used once and filed, while a result readable four ways can be deployed indefinitely by everybody. The studies that would settle it are cheap and obvious and nobody has run them.

Four Accounts, One Observation

This part has no chronology to offer either. Its reference table is the state of the argument: the four explanations that fit the data, what each predicts, and what would tell them apart.

ACCOUNT	THE CLAIM	WHAT WOULD SUPPORT IT	ITS MAIN PROBLEM
Release	Differences were always present; constraint suppressed them; freedom lets them appear.	Gaps grow and then stabilise once legal constraint is gone. Migrants' children shift to the destination pattern only slowly.	It is not the only account that predicts a growing gap, and it is treated as though it were.
Necessity	Precarity forces optimisation for security; security permits optimisation for interest.	The gap tracks economic risk more closely than it tracks legal equality. Sudden welfare expansion widens it.	It is a theory about careers, and the same pattern appears in patience, risk and personality.
Elaboration	Rich societies shape people more, not less, along commercially useful lines. Gender is the most useful line there is.	Gendered marketing intensity tracks the gap. Conventions change and the gap follows.	Documented for marketing content; the link to what children become is not demonstrated.
Measurement	Gap constructions, index composition and the reference group effect produce part or all of the pattern.	The pattern fails in administrative counts and behavioural measures while holding in self-report.	It cannot account for the graduation counts, which carry none of these problems.

Three tests appear in that table more than once, and none of them has been done properly.

Follow countries over time rather than comparing them at one moment. The accounts predict different trajectories and the data largely exists.

Separate self-report from administrative and behavioural measures and check whether the pattern holds in both. Chapter Two showed why this is the sharpest available cut.

Follow migrants. Part Two used exactly this design for the plough hypothesis and it was decisive. Nobody appears to have done it here.

Figures throughout are drawn from published studies, international assessments and national education statistics. Chapter Ten states which are solid and which are contested.

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Conditional propensity	Of the people who reached university at all, what fraction chose a given subject. A measure that isolates choice by holding access fixed — and therefore removes access, the biggest inequality in poor countries, from view.
Gap measure	An index recording the distance between men and women rather than how well women are actually living. A country where both sexes fare equally badly scores well.
Gender-equality paradox	The pattern in which differences between men and women appear larger in richer and more gender-equal countries. Called a paradox because the most straightforward account predicts the opposite.
Level measure	An index recording women's absolute conditions — maternal survival, literacy, income — rather than the gap between the sexes. Ranks countries very differently from a gap measure.
Reference group effect	People rating themselves compare themselves to those around them rather than to humanity in general, so self-ratings are not comparable across countries. Applies to self-report and not to counting graduates.
Relative strength	What a person is best at compared with their own other abilities, rather than compared with other people. A girl can be an excellent scientist for whom science is a personal weakness.
Self-expression values	The finding that as countries become secure, stated priorities shift from survival and order towards autonomy and personal realisation.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

This part is a synthesis of a live academic dispute by somebody who is not a participant in it. That is a real limitation and it cuts in a specific direction: I can read what each side published and report where they disagree, and I cannot independently evaluate a statistical method. Where the dispute is technical — the propensity measure, the index composition, the reference group correction — I have set out both positions and said which I find more persuasive while marking it as my reading rather than a verdict.

My own temptation in this part was the opposite of the usual one. The paradox is inconvenient to almost everything I would have expected to conclude when I started this series, and there was an available route in which I reported the criticisms at full strength and the finding at half. I have tried not to take it. Chapter Four states plainly that the critics did not overturn the raw pattern, which is the sentence I least wanted to write in this part.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the assessment, the survey, the graduation count, the catalogue — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not, and this part says it more often than any other.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of published studies, international assessments, national education statistics and a documented academic exchange, rather than new research.

The evidence here divides sharply and the division matters more than in any previous part. Administrative graduation counts are strong: they are compiled by education ministries, they measure completed degrees, and they carry none of the problems that affect the rest. Behaviourally validated preference measures are next strongest. Standard self-report personality inventories are exposed to the reference group problem set out in Chapter Two, which is documented and unquantified. And the gender-equality indices are composites whose construction is discussed in Chapter Five and which should never be treated as measuring a single quantity. Any claim in this part inherits the weakness of whichever pile it came from, and I have said which pile throughout.

The Indian figures in Chapter Nine come from national higher education survey data and international compilations, checked at the time of writing rather than recalled. They vary somewhat between sources and years, and I have given them as approximate. The workforce and faculty figures in particular are compiled differently by different bodies and should be read as indicating a shape rather than a precise value. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who work in these fields, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Six — The Case for the Old Rules, at Full Strength. Five parts of taking the traditional position apart. The next one is spent building the best version of it that can be built.

- What is the strongest argument for the old arrangement that anybody has ever made — not the version that shouts, but the version that would persuade a careful reader who started out unsympathetic?
- What does the evidence actually say about children raised in different family structures, and how much of it survives once income and selection are accounted for?
- There is a claim that a society which stops arranging marriage does not get freer partnerships but fewer of them. Marriage rates, partnership rates and reported loneliness are all countable. What do they show?
- The sexual marketplace argument holds that when the cost of sex falls, men's incentive to commit falls with it, and that women bear the cost of that shift. It is unpleasant and it is not stupid. How much of it is supported?
- What was your grandmother's rulebook actually for — and how much of it was technology for a world without antibiotics, contraception, paternity tests or a welfare state?
- And the question this series has been circling for five parts: if every problem the rules solved has a modern replacement, why does no society that acquired the replacements dismantle the rules?

END OF PART FIVE OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Six — The Case for the Old Rules

Five parts spent taking the traditional position apart. This one is spent building the best version of it that can be built.

Not the version that shouts. The version that would persuade a careful reader who started out unsympathetic — and then an honest account of exactly where it fails.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Five parts are now behind us. Part One separated the three claims welded into every defence of these rules. Part Two found their origin in property and inheritance. Part Three found the Indian machine, which runs on marriage rather than paternity. Part Four measured every difference between men and women and found most of them close to a coin toss. Part Five examined the finding that differences appear to grow when constraints lift, and concluded that the finding is real in some measures, shaky in others, and unexplained in all of them.

Each of those parts ended by asking the same question: does any of this justify the rules? Each time the answer was no.

A reader could be forgiven for concluding that the traditional position has been dealt with. It has not. It has been examined in pieces, on my terms, in a sequence I chose.

So this part does something different. **It argues for the other side.**

Not a version built to lose. Not a summary of what traditionalists say, with the weak bits included. The strongest case that can be constructed from the best available evidence, assembled by somebody trying to win — and in several places it will be a better case than the one its actual advocates make, because they tend to reach for arguments that fail while leaving the ones that work unused.

Then, in Chapter Nine, I score it. Honestly, including the parts that survive.

I want to say plainly what this part will contain, because some of it will be uncomfortable for readers who have found the previous five congenial. It contains real evidence that children raised in stable two-parent households do better on average. It contains real evidence that marriage changes men's behaviour rather than merely selecting for it. It contains the fact that partnership is collapsing across the developed world and that the collapse is measurable. And it contains the strongest argument of all, which is made most often by women and dismissed most often by men: that the old arrangement was a guarantee, that the replacement was promised and only partly built, and that the entire risk of the transition falls on the person being asked to make it.

Every one of those is true. What Chapter Nine asks is what they actually justify.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. One live example of each.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **A steelman** is the strongest possible version of a position you disagree with — the version its best advocate would give, with the weak arguments removed and the good ones stated at full force.
>
> The opposite is a **strawman**: a version built to be easy to knock down.
>
> Why it matters here: this whole part is a steelman, and Chapter Nine argues that steelmanning is not the neutral act it appears to be. Building somebody's best case gives them something they did not have.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Before any argument, one number, because it does more work than any argument in this part.
>
> In a society without antibiotics, without safe surgery and without blood transfusion, a woman's chance of dying in any given childbirth was somewhere around one in a hundred. Over a reproductive life of six or eight births, her cumulative chance of dying in the process ran into the **high single figures or above**.
>
> Put that in a village. Take a hundred women who reach childbearing age. Somewhere between five and ten of them will die producing the next generation — not from war, not from famine, from an ordinary event that happens in a room.
>
> Every rule in this series was written by and for people living with that number. It does not make the rules right. It makes them **a response to something**, and Chapter Two is about what.

Any number too big to picture gets a body attached.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Much of this part rests on studies comparing children, adults or households in different family arrangements. That design has one dominant weakness and it has to be named before any number is quoted.

The problem: nobody is randomly assigned to a marriage. People who marry and stay married differ from those who do not — in income, education, health, temperament and a hundred other things — *before* the marriage exists. Any difference in their children could be caused by those prior differences rather than by the marriage.

What better designs do: compare siblings who experienced different family arrangements, follow the same individuals before and after a change, or use a change in law that affected some people and not others. These strip out much of the selection.

What they find, consistently: the effects are *real* and *smaller* than the raw comparisons suggest. Both halves of that sentence matter, and each camp reliably quotes one of them.

That box names the evidence and its limits. The next one appears wherever competent people genuinely disagree.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD THE STRONGEST VERSION OF A POSITION BE BUILT FOR IT?

Worth settling before eight chapters of doing it.

YES

An argument you have only met in its weakest form is an argument you have not met. Defeating a bad version of a position tells you nothing about the position, and it leaves you unprepared for the good version when somebody finally makes it. It is also the only honest way to find out whether you are right.

NO

Real positions are held by real people for real reasons, and a philosopher’s improved version is not what anybody is actually defending. Building it lends respectability to a set of practices whose actual justification is worse, and then the improved version gets quoted by people who hold the unimproved one.

> **Where things stand:** the first, with the second as a genuine cost rather than a quibble. Chapter Nine returns to this and concludes that the objection is stronger than it looks.

An Argument box appears where people who have studied something genuinely disagree.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Both sides above assume **that there is a position here to be steelmanned** — one traditionalist case, which can be made better or worse.
>
> There is not. What follows is at least four separate arguments, and they do not support each other. An argument about children. An argument about partnership. An argument about male behaviour. An argument about women's economic security.
>
> They point at different problems, imply different remedies, and in places **contradict each other outright**. The argument about male behaviour says the difficulty is men and the intervention belongs there. The argument about women's security says women need protection. Those are not the same claim and a policy following one will not follow the other.
>
> The general form: **treating a coalition of arguments as a single position.** Coalitions look strong from outside because every member's weakness is covered by somebody else's strength — and they cannot be defeated or adopted as a unit, because they were never one thing.

This is the signature box. There are five in this part.

> REMEMBER THIS
>
> Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.
>
> **Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.**

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

I am arguing for something I do not hold, and I am going to do it properly. Chapters Two through Eight contain no hedging, no undercutting asides, and no signals to the sympathetic reader that I do not mean it. That would be cowardice dressed as balance. The scoring happens in Chapter Nine, in one place, where you can see it.

If you find yourself persuaded somewhere in the middle of this part, that is the point. Part One said to notice which findings you hope are true, because that marks where you are least reliable. This part is designed to locate that spot for a reader who has enjoyed the previous five.

And a warning about what this part is not. It is a case for stable families, for partnership, and for taking the costs of transition seriously. It is not a case for caste endogamy, enforced widowhood, dowry, seclusion, or a rumour published about a woman who stood in a street. Chapter Nine shows that the strongest traditionalist arguments do not reach those things — and that this is a much more serious problem for the position than any objection I could raise from outside it.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

What A Steelman Requires

Building somebody else's best argument has rules. The first is that you have to actually try. The second is that you have to understand what kind of thing you are defending — and the rules in this series are not a morality. They are a technology.

1.1 — The discipline

There is a test for whether you have understood a position you disagree with. Can you state it in a form its holders would recognise, and would want to sign?

Most people cannot, about most things they oppose. What they can produce is a version assembled from the worst thing anybody on that side has said, which is easy to defeat and tells you nothing.

So this part follows three rules, and they are worth stating because you should hold me to them.

No undercutting. Chapters Two to Eight contain no asides winking at the sympathetic reader, no "of course this is nonsense but", no adjectives doing quiet damage. If an argument is strong, it is stated as strong.

Use the best available evidence, not the evidence the position's advocates usually cite. In several places the strongest support for a traditionalist claim comes from research that traditionalists do not know about and would find surprising. It goes in anyway.

Drop the arguments that fail. A steelman is not a survey. Several things routinely said in defence of these rules are simply wrong, and including them would be a way of losing on purpose.

1.2 — Technology, not morality

Here is the frame that makes the whole case work, and it is the thing its advocates most often get wrong about their own position.

The rules in this series are usually defended as *values* — as an account of what is decent, pure, honourable, appropriate. Defended that way they are very hard to argue for, because a value has no evidence behind it and the person on the other side simply does not share it. The conversation ends immediately.

Read them instead as **technology** and everything changes.

A technology is a solution to a problem. It can be assessed. It can be compared with alternatives. It can be judged on whether it worked, at what cost, and to whom. And crucially, a technology can be *obsolete* without ever having been wrong — the way a well-designed oil lamp is not a mistake, merely superseded.

Part Two already established that these rules solved real problems. The traditionalist who says “these things exist for a reason” is making a technological claim and then, almost always, defending it in the language of morality — which is the weakest ground available and the ground they choose.

This part will not make that mistake. Every argument in it is of the form: *here is a problem, here is what the old arrangement did about it, here is the evidence, and here is what happens where the arrangement is gone.*

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everything above — and every version of this argument on both sides — assumes **that we know what the rules were for.**

We do not, in the sense that matters. What we have is a set of *functions,* worked out retrospectively by researchers looking at outcomes: inheritance security, boundary maintenance, disease avoidance, insurance. Those are real and Part Two established several of them.

But almost nobody who ever lived under these rules held them for those reasons. They held them because it was what was done, because their mother had, because the alternative was unthinkable, or because they were told. A functional account is a description of what a practice *achieved,* not of what anybody was trying to achieve.

Which means this entire part is a modern reconstruction. I am building a case that no traditional society ever made, out of evidence none of them had, and attributing it to people who would not recognise a word of it. The traditionalist reading this chapter with satisfaction should notice that the argument being made on their behalf is not their argument. It is mine.

> The general form: **reconstructing a rationale and attributing it to people who never had one.** It is what makes a functional explanation so persuasive and so slippery, and Chapter Nine asks what building it may have done.

1.3 — What a fair test looks like

Finally, the standard. Part One, Chapter Nine set out what the traditionalist would have to show to win, and it is worth restating because this part is an attempt to meet it.

That the rule solves a real problem — not that it once did, but that the problem exists now.

That the harm from removing it exceeds the harm from keeping it — which requires counting both columns, and Part Twelve counts the second.

That no cheaper instrument exists.

That the burden belongs where it is placed.

Four conditions. Chapters Two to Eight assemble the strongest available case. Chapter Nine checks it against all four, and tells you honestly how many it clears.

REMEMBER THIS

A steelman has rules. **No undercutting** — no asides winking at the sympathetic reader. **Use the best evidence**, including evidence the position's advocates do not know about. **Drop the arguments that fail**, because including them is a way of losing on purpose.

The frame that makes the case work: read these rules as **technology, not morality**. A value has no evidence behind it and the conversation ends. A technology solves a problem, can be compared with alternatives, and can be **obsolete without ever having been wrong** — the way an oil lamp is not a mistake, merely superseded.

Traditionalists make a technological claim and then defend it in moral language, which is the weakest ground available and the ground they choose.

But we do not know what the rules were for. We know what they achieved — worked out retrospectively by researchers. Almost nobody who lived under them held them for those reasons. So this part is a modern reconstruction, built from evidence none of them had, and the traditionalist enjoying it should notice that the argument being made on their behalf is not theirs. It is mine.

CHAPTER TWO

The World The Rules Were Built For

Before you can judge a set of instructions you have to know what they were instructions about. The world these rules were written for had no antibiotics, no contraception, no paternity test, no welfare and no law a woman could reach. Take those five away and read the rulebook again.

2.1 — Childbirth

Start with the thing modern readers most consistently fail to imagine, because it has been solved so completely in rich countries that it has left ordinary memory.

Childbirth killed women. Not rarely, not in unlucky cases — as a normal feature of life. Before antisepsis, safe surgery and transfusion, the chance of dying in any single delivery ran at somewhere around one in a hundred, and a woman had six or eight of them.

The causes were haemorrhage, obstructed labour, and infection — the last of which was frequently introduced by the person attending. It took decades for the medical profession to accept that doctors moving between patients without washing their hands were killing them.

And a pregnancy could not be prevented. Reliable contraception did not exist. Abortion existed, was dangerous, and frequently killed the woman as well.

So set out the situation as it presented itself to somebody actually living in it. A sexual encounter carried, for a woman, a meaningful probability of a pregnancy she could not prevent and could not end, and that pregnancy carried a meaningful probability of killing her.

Whatever you think of the rules that followed, they were not a response to nothing.

2.2 — Disease

The second danger has also left living memory in rich countries, and it should not have.

Syphilis had no cure until the twentieth century. Untreated it disfigured, then destroyed the nervous system, then killed. It passed to infants in the womb. Gonorrhoea, also incurable, caused sterility and blinded newborns as they were delivered.

There was no test, no treatment and no way to know. A person could not tell whether a partner was infected, and frequently the partner could not tell either.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Put the two dangers together and price a single act.
>
> For a woman, in a world with no contraception, no antibiotics and no test, one sexual encounter carried: a real chance of pregnancy; a real chance that the pregnancy would kill her; a real chance of an incurable disease that would disfigure and then kill her slowly; and a real chance of passing that disease to a child.
>
> Now compare it with the same act today for a woman with access to contraception and a pharmacy. Pregnancy is preventable at a cost of a few rupees a month. The great bacterial diseases are curable in a week. The chance of dying in childbirth in a country with functioning hospitals is a small fraction of one per cent.
>
> **These are not the same act.** They have the same name and they are separated by a difference in consequence of two or three orders of magnitude.
>
> Anybody who wants to argue that the old rules were irrational has to explain how a rational person prices that first act. And anybody who wants to argue that they still apply has to explain why a rule written for the first act governs the second.

2.3 — No way to know

The third absence is the one Part Two built its argument on, and it is worth restating from the inside.

A man could not establish that a child was his. Not with difficulty — at all. Blood testing from the early twentieth century could exclude a man; it could not confirm one. Certainty arrived in 1985.

Now consider what a man in this position is being asked to do. He is asked to spend twenty years of labour, food, protection and inheritance on a child, on the basis of a belief he cannot check. In a society without a welfare state, that transfer is not a gesture. It is most of what he will produce in his life.

Any arrangement that could not give him reasonable confidence would not attract that investment. And a society in which men do not make that investment is a society in which children are raised by their mothers alone, in an economy where a woman's independent earning capacity was frequently zero.

That is the problem. It is not a nice problem and the solution was not nice either.

2.4 — No floor

The fourth absence is the one that most changes how the rules read.

There was no state that would feed you. No pension, no unemployment payment, no housing, no support for a woman with a child and no husband. In most of the societies in this series, a woman also could not own land, could not inherit in her own right, and could not earn a wage sufficient to live on.

Which means her survival ran through a household, and losing her place in one was not a hardship. It was a category of destitution with no bottom to it.

Read the rules in Part Three again with that in view. Enforced widowhood is monstrous. It is also, from the inside of a system with no floor, a place in a household — food, shelter, a roof — for a woman who has lost the person her position depended on. The alternative on offer was not freedom. It was nothing at all.

I want to be exact about what I am and am not saying. I am not saying the widow was well treated or that the arrangement was justified. I am saying that a system offering a bad position to somebody whose alternative is starvation is doing something, and that calling it pure cruelty misdescribes the mechanism and therefore misdescribes what would be needed to replace it.

2.5 — No law you could reach

The fifth absence completes the picture. Professional policing is about two centuries old and arrived in most of the world much later than that. For most people in most places, there was no authority that would enforce an agreement, punish an assault, or recover what was taken.

Part Two, Chapter Six set out what people do in that situation: they build reputations for retaliation, because deterrence is the only protection available when there is no law. A family's standing was its security system, and a woman's conduct was the most visible and least fakeable signal of that standing.

Again, monstrous in operation and functional in design. Both.

2.6 — The rulebook as engineering

Now assemble it. Take a world with those five absences and ask what instructions you would write.

You would restrict sexual activity outside a committed arrangement, because the cost of it falls catastrophically on women and children and cannot be mitigated.

You would make the arrangement hard to leave, because the alternative to a household is destitution and because male investment requires confidence about duration.

You would place enormous weight on paternity confidence, because that is what buys the investment.

You would tie a family's public standing to visible conduct, because standing is the security system and it needs a signal.

And you would enforce all of it socially rather than legally, because there is no law to reach.

That is the rulebook. Not most of it — nearly all of it, derived from five absences without any appeal to purity, honour, scripture or the nature of women.

This is the strongest thing in this part and it should be sat with. The rules are not arbitrary and they are not primarily an expression of contempt. They are what a reasonable and even a kind person might write, given those five conditions, trying to protect the people in front of them from dangers that were entirely real.

REMEMBER THIS

Five absences define the world these rules were written for. **No contraception and no safe childbirth** — roughly one death per hundred deliveries, six or eight deliveries a life. **No cure for the great sexual diseases**, which disfigured, killed slowly and passed to infants.

No way to establish paternity until 1985 — so a man was asked to spend twenty years of labour on a belief he could not check. **No floor** — no state that would feed a woman without a household, in economies where she could not own, inherit or earn. And **no law anybody could reach.**

One sexual act, for a woman in that world, carried a real chance of pregnancy, of dying from it, of an incurable disease, and of passing it to a child. **The same act today is separated from that one by two or three orders of magnitude of consequence.** They share only a name.

Now derive the rulebook from the five absences: restrict sex outside a committed arrangement, make the arrangement hard to leave, weight paternity heavily, tie standing to visible conduct, enforce it socially because there is no law. That is nearly all of it — with no appeal to purity, honour, scripture or the nature of women.

These are not the rules of people expressing contempt. They are what a reasonable and even a kind person might write, given those conditions, trying to protect the people in front of them from dangers that were entirely real.

CHAPTER THREE

Children

This is the strongest empirical card the traditional position holds. Children raised by two parents who stay together do better, on nearly every measure anybody has looked at. The interesting question is not whether that is true but how much of it survives when you ask it properly.

3.1 — The raw picture

The associations are not subtle and they are not disputed.

Compared with children raised by two married parents, children raised in single-parent households are substantially more likely to leave school without qualifications, more likely to have a child as a teenager, more likely to be neither working nor studying in early adulthood, more likely to encounter the criminal justice system, and more likely to report psychological difficulties.

Landmark work in the 1990s put the schooling risk at roughly double. Subsequent studies in many countries have found the same direction, repeatedly, on many outcomes.

That is the raw finding, and anybody arguing about family structure who begins by disputing it is arguing about something that is not in dispute.

3.2 — And then the problem

Nobody is randomly assigned to a family. That single sentence governs this entire literature.

WORD BOX

Selection: the problem that arises when people are not randomly sorted into the groups being compared, so the groups differ in ways that have nothing to do with what is being studied.

An illustration that makes it obvious. People who go to hospital die at much higher rates than people who do not. Nobody concludes hospitals are lethal, because the comparison is between the sick and the well, not between two similar groups given different treatment.

Why it matters here: every comparison of family arrangements has this shape. It cannot be removed, only reduced, and the whole quality of a study in this field is a question of how well it was reduced.

Parents who marry and stay married differ from those who do not, before any child is born. They have more money, more education, more stable employment, better health, lower rates of addiction and, on average, different temperaments. Every one of those independently affects children.

So the raw gap contains two things fused together: whatever the family arrangement does, and whatever the people who end up in each arrangement were already like.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Researchers have several ways of separating them, and they converge on a similar answer.

Comparing siblings who experienced different arrangements — one child born before a separation, one after — holds the family constant and looks only at exposure.

Following the same child before and after a change, which asks whether the child's trajectory bends at the moment the arrangement changes.

Using changes in divorce law that made separation easier in some places and years and not others. This is the strongest design available, because a legislature changing a statute is not responding to any individual family.

What they find: the effects are real and smaller than the raw comparisons. A substantial share of the raw gap is accounted for by what the families were like beforehand — income in particular does a great deal of the work. A meaningful part is not, and survives every adjustment researchers have applied.

What they cannot show: which specific mechanism does it. Money, supervision, stability, conflict, the number of adults in the house and the number of transitions a child experiences are all candidates, and separating them has not been done convincingly.

3.3 — Boys

One finding in this literature is larger and more consistent than the rest, and it is barely present in public argument.

The effects of family disruption fall harder on boys.

Studies using large administrative datasets and comparing brothers and sisters within the same families find that boys' behaviour, schooling and later employment are more damaged by family instability and disadvantage than their sisters' are. The gap between boys and girls in behavioural difficulty is itself wider in disadvantaged and disrupted households.

This is the traditionalist case at its sharpest and it is almost never made. A society that stops forming stable two-parent households is not producing an evenly distributed cost. It is producing a specific, measurable, sex-differentiated cost, concentrated on boys, showing up as school failure and disconnection from work — which Part Fifteen counts and which is the largest social problem nobody is arguing about.

IN REAL TERMS

There is a second pattern that changes the shape of this entire argument, and it is about class rather than culture.

In the wealthy world, marriage has not declined evenly. Among the university-educated it remains common and comparatively stable. Among those without a degree it has fallen sharply. The result is that the two-parent household has become, in effect, a **class marker**.

Put it in two streets. On one, professional couples marry in their thirties, stay married, and raise children with two incomes and two adults' attention. On the other, partnerships form early, dissolve often, and children pass through several household arrangements before adulthood.

The children who most need the stability are concentrated in the second street.

Which means the decline of the two-parent family is not a story about liberal values reaching everybody. It is a story about a stabilising arrangement being retained by the people who need it least.

3.4 — The comparison nobody makes

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Every argument in this area assumes **that the alternative to a broken family is the same family, unbroken.**

Both camps do it. The traditionalist compares children of divorce with children of intact marriages and concludes the divorce caused the difference. The reformer disputes the size of the gap. Neither asks what the actual alternative was.

Because for the child in question, the counterfactual is not "the same parents, happily married." It is "the same parents, in the marriage they were actually in" — the one that ended.

And when researchers make that comparison, the answer splits. Where a marriage was **high in conflict**, children generally do *better* when it ends. Where it was low in conflict — an unhappy marriage rather than a hostile one — children generally do worse. Estimates put the high-conflict category at something like a third of separations.

So "divorce harms children" is true on average and false for a substantial minority, and there is no way to know from the average which child is in front of you.

> The general form: **comparing what happened with an alternative that was never available.** It is the most common error in policy argument of any kind, and it is why the family-structure evidence supports “fewer bad marriages forming” far better than it supports “fewer marriages ending.”

With that counterfactual on the table, the professional argument about causation can be stated properly.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES FAMILY STRUCTURE CAUSE THESE OUTCOMES?

The central methodological dispute in the field, and both sides have serious people in them.

IT CAUSES THEM

The association appears in every country studied, across dozens of outcomes, and survives every statistical adjustment researchers have applied. Natural experiments using changes in divorce law — where no individual family chose anything — find worse adult outcomes for the affected cohorts. At some point a relationship that survives this much testing is a relationship.

IT IS LARGELY POVERTY WEARING A COSTUME

Most of the raw gap disappears when income and parental education are properly accounted for, and the residue is small enough to be explained by variables nobody has measured. Single parenthood in countries with strong income support produces far smaller gaps than in countries without — which is what you would expect if the operative variable were money rather than structure.

REAL, MODEST, AND UNEVENLY DISTRIBUTED

A genuine effect remains after adjustment, it is considerably smaller than the raw numbers, it is larger for boys than girls, it is larger where income support is weaker, and it is driven more by instability and transitions than by the number of parents at any moment.

Where things stand: the third position, and note what it implies. If the damage comes mainly from *instability* rather than from single parenthood as such, then the policy that follows is not "make marriage harder to leave." It is "make households less precarious" — which is an economic instrument, not a rule about women.

What would settle it: comparing outcomes across countries with similar family structures and very different levels of income support. This has been done partially and points towards money doing a large share of the work.

Why people care so much: because this is the one place where the traditional position has genuinely strong quantitative evidence, and both camps know it.

Which is why this chapter matters more than its length suggests. If the traditional case has a foundation anywhere, it is here.

REMEMBER THIS

The raw associations are large and undisputed. Children in single-parent households leave school without qualifications at roughly **double** the rate, and show worse outcomes on many other measures across many countries.

But nobody is randomly assigned to a family. Parents who marry and stay married differ in income, education, health and temperament **before any child is born**. Better designs — sibling comparisons, divorce-law changes — find the effects are **real and smaller**. Each camp quotes one of those two words.

The sharpest finding is barely discussed: **the damage falls harder on boys**. Family instability hits boys' behaviour, schooling and later employment more than their sisters'.

And marriage has become a **class marker**. It remains common among the university-educated and has collapsed among everyone else — so a stabilising arrangement is being retained by the people who need it least.

The comparison nobody makes: the alternative for a child of divorce is not "the same parents, happily married." It is the marriage they were actually in. Where conflict was high, children do better when it ends. Where it was merely unhappy, they do worse. Which means this evidence supports "fewer bad marriages forming" far better than it supports "fewer marriages ending."

CHAPTER FOUR

The Vanishing Couple

The promise was freer partnerships. What arrived in much of the developed world was fewer of them. This is countable, it is happening almost everywhere, and it is the part of the traditional case that requires no interpretation at all.

4.1 — Marriage

Marriage rates across the wealthy world have roughly halved since the 1970s. That is a large change in a short period for an institution of that age.

But rates per year are a poor way to see it, because they move with the age structure of a population. The clearer measure is how many people never marry at all.

IN REAL TERMS

In the United States in 1980, around **six per cent** of forty-year-olds had never been married.

By the early 2020s that figure was around **twenty-five per cent**.

Put it in a room of a hundred people at their fortieth birthdays. Four decades ago, six of them had never married. Now twenty-five have.

That is not a shift in when people marry, which is what a rising average age at marriage would show. Forty is late enough that most of those twenty-five will not. It is a change in **whether**.

The pattern is not American. Japan and South Korea show it more sharply, with lifetime never-married shares rising steeply in recent cohorts. Southern Europe shows it. It is arriving in urban India.

4.2 — And not replaced

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Cohabitation:** living as a couple in one household without being married.
>
> It is worth distinguishing three different things that a falling marriage rate could mean, because they have very different implications. People marrying *later*. People partnering without marrying. Or people not partnering at all.
>
> Why it matters here: the first is not a decline in partnership, the second is a change in its legal form, and only the third is what the traditional case is describing. Chapter Four is an attempt to work out how much of each is happening.

The obvious reply is that marriage was replaced by cohabitation — that people still partner, without the ceremony.

Cohabitation did rise substantially, and for a period it absorbed much of the decline. But two things complicate the reply.

Cohabiting unions are less stable. They dissolve at higher rates than marriages, including where children are present. So a child in a cohabiting household experiences, on average, more transitions — and Chapter Three found that transitions, rather than the number of adults at any given moment, may be the operative variable.

And the growth of cohabitation has not kept pace with the decline in marriage. Across a number of countries, the share of adults in any co-residential partnership at all has fallen. Not merely unmarried — unpartnered.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

These figures come from two different kinds of source, and the difference matters.

Marriage and never-married shares come from registries and censuses. A marriage is a legal event that gets recorded, and a census asks a factual question with a definite answer. This is about as reliable as social data gets.

Cohabitation and partnership come from surveys, and are harder. Whether two people living together count as partners is a judgement, definitions differ between countries, and the category has changed meaning over the period being measured — which makes long comparisons shakier than they look.

What follows: the marriage decline is solid. The claim that partnership overall has fallen is real but weaker, and anybody presenting the two with equal confidence is overstating the second.

4.3 — The recession

There is a further measure, and it is the one that most surprised the people who first reported it, because everyone expected the opposite.

Surveys of sexual behaviour in the United States show a rising share of young adults reporting no sexual activity in the previous year. Among men in their late teens and twenties the share reporting none roughly tripled over the decade to the late 2010s. Japanese surveys report high and rising shares of young adults with no sexual experience at all.

This is worth pausing on, because it inverts every prediction anybody made. The expectation, from both camps, was that liberalisation would produce more sex among the young. The measured result in several wealthy countries is *less*.

The traditionalist reading writes itself: the arrangement that was dismantled was not primarily a restriction on sex. It was an **infrastructure for pairing people** — arranged introductions, community supervision, clear expectations, a defined sequence with a defined endpoint. Removing the restrictions also removed the machinery, and nothing was built to replace it.

On that reading, what looks like liberation for the confident and attractive is abandonment for everybody else, and the measured decline in partnership is what abandonment looks like in a survey.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE DECLINE IN PARTNERSHIP A PROBLEM?

The numbers are agreed. What they mean is not.

IT IS A SERIOUS PROBLEM

Partnership is among the strongest correlates of reported wellbeing, of physical health and of longevity that has ever been measured. A society producing fewer partnerships is producing more unhappiness, more illness and more early death, and doing so at scale. The people worst affected are not the ones writing about it — they are the least advantaged, for whom the old machinery did the most work.

IT IS A TRANSITION, NOT A CATASTROPHE

What declined was a system in which enormous numbers of people were compelled into partnerships they did not want and could not leave. Fewer marriages also means fewer forced marriages, fewer women trapped with violent men, and a sharp fall in intimate partner violence across the same period. Counting the missing marriages without counting the marriages that no longer have to happen is a one-sided ledger.

BOTH, AND THEY LAND ON DIFFERENT PEOPLE

The people freed by the change and the people stranded by it are largely different populations. Women in bad marriages gained enormously. Men and women who would have been matched by the old machinery and are not matched by anything now have lost something with no compensation. Averaging them produces a number describing nobody.

Where things stand: the third position. And it carries a specific implication that neither camp likes: the change was *good* for people with options and *bad* for people without them, which makes this — like Chapter Three's class gradient — a distributional question wearing a moral costume.

What would settle it: measures of wellbeing among the never-partnered, tracked over time and separated by whether the state was chosen. That distinction is rarely made and it is the whole question.

Why people care so much: because both sides are describing real people and neither is describing all of them.

4.4 — What is countable and what is not

A discipline before leaving this chapter, because the traditional case is often overstated here by people who have the good arguments available and use the weak ones.

Countable and solid: marriage rates, never-married shares, partnership rates, the timing of first births, the share reporting no recent sexual activity. These are survey and registry data and they show what they show.

Countable and contested: loneliness. Measures disagree, definitions differ, and the claim that loneliness has risen sharply among the young is weaker than it is usually presented. Some datasets show it; others show it flat.

Not countable at all: whether people are less happy in some general sense, whether communities have less warmth in them, whether something has been lost that does not appear in a survey. These may be true. They are the mood, not the prediction, and Part One's rule applies: a claim that cannot say what would count as it being wrong is not a claim.

REMEMBER THIS

Marriage rates across the wealthy world have **roughly halved since the 1970s**. The clearer measure is never-married shares: in the United States, around **six per cent** of forty-year-olds had never married in 1980, against around **twenty-five per cent** in the early 2020s. That is a change in whether, not in when.

Cohabitation absorbed part of it, but cohabiting unions are **less stable**, producing more transitions — which Chapter Three suggested is the operative variable. And in several countries the share in **any** co-residential partnership has fallen.

The measure that inverted everybody's predictions: the share of young adults reporting **no sexual activity in the past year** has risen, roughly tripling among young American men over a decade. Both camps expected the opposite.

The traditionalist reading: what was dismantled was not mainly a restriction on sex but an **infrastructure for pairing people** — introductions, supervision, expectations, a sequence with an endpoint. Removing the restrictions removed the machinery, and nothing replaced it.

The change freed people with options and stranded people without them, and those are different populations. Which makes this, like the class gradient in Chapter Three, a distributional question wearing a moral costume.

CHAPTER FIVE

Cheap Sex

The most unpleasant argument in this part, and it is not stupid. If sex becomes available without commitment, the argument goes, then commitment becomes scarce — and the people who wanted commitment are the ones who pay.

5.1 — The argument

State it in its own terms, without flinching, because a version that flinches is a version that has not been understood.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Sexual economics:** a framework analysing sexual behaviour as an exchange, in which sex is treated as a resource that women supply and men seek, with a "price" — paid in commitment, attention or resources — set by women's collective behaviour rather than by any individual.
>
> Why it matters here: this framework generates the argument in this chapter. It is a model rather than a finding, it does real analytical work, and §5.3 examines what it assumes before any evidence arrives.

Historically, the argument runs, sex outside a committed arrangement was expensive for a woman — Chapter Two priced it — and therefore scarce. A man who wanted it generally had to offer something substantial in exchange: marriage, support, permanence, the whole apparatus.

Contraception removed most of the cost. Antibiotics removed the rest. Modern arrangements for meeting people expanded the field of possible partners from a village to a city to a country.

The consequence, on this account, is that sex became obtainable without commitment. And once it is obtainable without commitment, a man who does not want commitment has no reason to offer it — which means the men most willing to commit are competing against an option that did not previously exist.

So who loses? Not the men who wanted sex without commitment; they gained. Not the small number of men most in demand; they gained enormously. The losers are **women who wanted a committed partnership** and now find that the thing they are offering no longer purchases what it used to, and **men who are not in demand**, who under the old arrangement would have been matched by machinery that no longer exists.

That is the argument. It is uncomfortable, it is put more crudely than this by most of the people who hold it, and it deserves a hearing.

5.2 — The arithmetic underneath

There is a version of this that requires no claim about sex at all, and it is stronger.

Women now substantially outnumber men in higher education across most of the developed world — in the United States earning close to sixty per cent of first degrees, with similar patterns across Europe. Part Four noted this reversal; here is what it does.

Suppose, as surveys consistently find, that women on average prefer partners of equal or greater education and earnings, and men are more indifferent to this. That preference is not required to be innate, universal or admirable. It only has to exist.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Take a hundred graduates from a city's universities this year. Roughly sixty are women and forty are men.
>
> If every one of those forty men partners with a graduate woman, twenty women are left over with nobody in the category they were looking in. Not because anybody was rejected. **Because of subtraction.**
>
> And the same arithmetic running the other way strands men without degrees, who are competing for partners in a pool where the women's expectations were set by a different distribution.
>
> Now notice the property that makes this argument hard to answer. It requires **no bad behaviour by anybody**. Not one person in the example is selfish, exploitative or unreasonable. Every individual acts on a preference nobody would call outrageous, and the aggregate produces two groups of people who cannot find what they are looking for.
>
> This is the strongest form of the case in this chapter, and it is not about sex. It is about counting.

5.3 — What a market metaphor does

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The whole argument runs on a metaphor: that there is a **market**, in which sex is a good, women are the suppliers, men are the buyers, and there is a price.

Everybody in the dispute accepts the metaphor. Its advocates build on it. Its critics attack the conclusions while leaving the frame in place.

Look at what the frame does before any evidence arrives. It makes sex something women *have* and men *want* — so a woman who wants it is anomalous within the model rather than ordinary. It makes female collective behaviour the variable that sets the price, so the responsibility for the outcome sits with women. And it makes male demand a constant, the way demand for wheat is a constant, which places it outside the analysis entirely.

That last move is Part One, Chapter Eight in economic dress: **female behaviour is the variable and male behaviour is the weather.** The metaphor performs it automatically, before anybody has argued for anything.

The general form: **a metaphor doing analytical work while presenting as description.** The test is what happens if you swap the roles — if commitment is the scarce good and men are the suppliers, every conclusion reverses using the same data. Nothing in the evidence tells you which way round to run it. Somebody chose.

5.4 — And a rival explanation with better evidence

THE ARGUMENT — DID CHEAP SEX CAUSE THE COLLAPSE IN PARTNERSHIP?

Chapter Four established the decline. This is a claim about its cause, and there is a serious competitor.

CHEAP SEX EXPLAINS IT

The timing fits: contraception, then the sexual revolution, then falling marriage. The mechanism is coherent and requires no exotic assumptions. And the arithmetic in \u00a75.2 operates whether or not anybody accepts the moral framing \u2014 an educational reversal of that size mechanically produces unmatched people at both ends.

ECONOMICS EXPLAINS IT BETTER

Marriage did not decline evenly. It collapsed among men whose earnings and employment collapsed, and held up among men whose did not. Where regions lost manufacturing employment for reasons entirely external to them \u2014 a genuine natural experiment \u2014 young men\u2019s earnings fell, and marriage rates fell with them while single parenthood rose. Nobody in those places changed their views about sex. The factories closed.

THE EDUCATIONAL ARITHMETIC SURVIVES EITHER WAY

The two accounts disagree about culture and agree about counting. Whether the driver is the price of sex or the price of labour, a large imbalance in who obtains credentials and earnings produces unmatched people. That part requires no theory of anything.

Where things stand: the economic account has better evidence, because it has a natural experiment behind it and the cheap-sex account has a fitted narrative. The arithmetic in \u00a75.2 stands independently of both. The moral framing \u2014 that women collectively lowered a price and are paying for it \u2014 has no evidence behind it at all and is the part most often stated with most confidence.

What would settle it: more shocks of the kind described. Every time an economy removes male employment from a region for external reasons, it runs the experiment again, and so far the results point one way.

Why people care so much: because one account locates the problem in women\u2019s choices and the other in the labour market. Those imply completely different responses, and only one of them requires anybody to be told how to behave.

The chapter after this takes the argument that survives best in the whole part, and it is not this one.

REMEMBER THIS

The argument: contraception and antibiotics removed the cost of sex, so sex became obtainable without commitment, so men who did not want commitment stopped needing to offer it. The losers are **women who wanted partnership** and **men who were not in demand.**

The stronger version requires no claim about sex at all. Women now earn close to **sixty per cent** of first degrees. If women on average prefer partners of equal or greater education, then in a hundred graduates \u2014 sixty women, forty men \u2014 twenty women are left over. **Not through rejection. Through subtraction.** It requires nobody to behave badly.

But the market metaphor is doing work before any evidence arrives. It makes sex something women **have** and men **want**, makes female collective behaviour the price-setting variable, and places male demand outside the analysis as a constant. That is Part One's finding in economic dress: **female behaviour is the variable and male behaviour is the weather.**

And there is a rival with better evidence. Marriage collapsed where male employment collapsed. Where regions lost manufacturing for entirely external reasons, young men's earnings fell and marriage fell with them. Nobody there changed their views about sex. The factories closed.

CHAPTER SIX

What Marriage Does To Men

Married men earn more, drink less, commit fewer crimes and live longer. The obvious reply is that better men get married. The obvious reply is only partly right, and what remains is the most under-used argument in the traditional case.

6.1 — The pattern

On almost every measure anybody has recorded, married men do better than unmarried men.

> WORD BOX
>
> **The marriage premium:** the consistent finding that married men earn more than otherwise similar unmarried men. Estimates vary by country and method and commonly fall somewhere in the range of ten to twenty per cent.
>
> The word "premium" is doing something worth noticing — it implies the marriage caused the earnings. §6.2 is about whether that is true, and part of it is not.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the headline number in this chapter and the one most often quoted without its caveat.

They earn more — the gap is large enough to have its own name in economics. They work more hours and are less likely to be out of the labour force. They drink less and take fewer physical risks. They report better health and they live substantially longer.

Two features of this pattern are worth noticing immediately.

It is much larger for men than for women. Marriage is associated with better outcomes for women too, but the size of the male advantage is in a different range. Whatever is happening, it is happening more to men.

And it applies to crime. This is the finding that matters most, because crime is where the social cost sits.

6.2 — Selection, and what survives it

The obvious objection is the right one to raise. Men who are employable, stable, sober and law-abiding are more likely to be chosen as husbands. The correlation could be entirely a description of who gets married rather than of what marriage does.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The way round it is to follow the same man over many years and ask whether *he* changes when his circumstances do.
>
> **The strongest evidence** comes from long-running studies that tracked men from adolescence into late middle age, including men with substantial criminal records. Rather than comparing married men with unmarried men, these compare each man with himself \u2014 the same person, offending at one rate before a marriage and another rate during it.
>
> **What they find:** offending falls within individuals during periods of marriage, by a substantial margin, and rises again if the marriage ends. Because the comparison is a man against his own earlier self, it cannot be explained by the kind of man he is.
>
> **There is a physiological finding pointing the same way.** A long-term study following men in the Philippines measured testosterone before and after partnership and fatherhood. Men who became partnered fathers showed markedly larger declines than men who did not \u2014 and the men who went on to become fathers had *higher* testosterone beforehand, which rules out the simplest selection story.
>
> **What it cannot show:** what specifically does it. Routine, supervision, a person who notices, obligations that make risk expensive, or a change in how a man sees himself are all candidates. And these are studies of particular cohorts in particular countries; the mechanism may not travel.

6.3 — The society-level version

Now the argument that follows, and it is the one with the sharpest edge.

Violent crime is overwhelmingly committed by young men, and disproportionately by young men who are not partnered. Part Four’s arithmetic explains the shape: a moderate average difference in aggression becomes a nine-in-ten outcome at the extreme.

If marriage reduces offending within individuals, then a society that produces fewer marriages is producing more offending, mechanically, without anybody's character having changed.

And there is a natural experiment for the extreme version. Where sex ratios have been distorted — by war, by migration, or by the sex-selective abortion Part Twelve counts — societies end up with large numbers of men who will not find partners. Research on China's skewed sex ratio has attributed a substantial share of the rise in crime over a period to precisely this. The finding is contested, and the correlation is there.

India has the same problem, for the same reason, on a similar scale. A country with several million more young men than young women has a structural feature that no amount of policing addresses.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES MARRIAGE CHANGE MEN, OR SELECT THEM?

The dispute that decides how much weight this chapter can carry.

IT CHANGES THEM

Within-individual designs remove the selection objection by construction. The same man offends less while married and more after it ends. The hormonal evidence points the same way and rules out the simple version of selection, because the men who became fathers started higher. Something about the arrangement acts on the person.

SELECTION IS STILL DOING MOST OF IT

Even within-individual studies cannot rule out that a man was already changing \u2014 maturing, finding work, tiring of the life \u2014 and that marriage is a symptom of that change rather than its cause. People marry at the point when their lives are improving, so improvement precedes the marriage and gets credited to it.

BOTH, IN UNKNOWN PROPORTIONS

Selection is real and cannot be fully removed. A causal component survives the best available designs. Nobody has established the split, and the honest range is wide.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is stronger for the traditional case than it sounds \u2014 because even a modest causal component, multiplied across a population, is a large number of offences.

What would settle it: a policy that increases marriage rates without changing anything else, which is close to impossible to arrange. Studies of marriage-promotion programmes exist and their results are weak, which is evidence, though weak programmes are also just weak programmes.

Why people care so much: because if marriage changes men, then family policy is crime policy, and that is a conclusion with very large consequences that almost nobody on either side wants to own.

6.4 — Where this argument actually points

One observation before leaving the chapter, and it is the reason this argument is under-used by the people it would most help.

Every finding here is about **men**. Men's earnings, men's offending, men's drinking, men's hormones, men's mortality. The claim is that a certain arrangement acts on male behaviour and improves it.

Which means the problem being described is a male problem, and the intervention being proposed is an intervention on men.

Traditionalists reaching for this argument almost always deploy it as a reason to restrict women — to make marriage more available, more compulsory, harder to leave. But nothing in the evidence supports that direction. The evidence says that being in a stable partnership changes a man. It says nothing about how the partnership should be obtained, and it certainly does not say that a woman should be required to supply one.

Chapter Nine returns to this, because it turns out to be the pattern in nearly every argument in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Married men earn more, work more, drink less, offend less and live longer. The advantage is **much larger for men than for women**.

The obvious objection is selection — better men get chosen. The way round it is to follow the same man over decades. Studies doing this find offending **falls within individuals during marriage and rises again when it ends**. A long-term study measuring testosterone found men who became partnered fathers dropped sharply — and had started *higher*, which rules out the simple selection story.

At society level: if marriage reduces offending within individuals, a society producing fewer marriages produces more offending with nobody's character having changed. Research on China's skewed sex ratio attributes a substantial share of a rise in crime to surplus unpartnered men. **India has the same problem for the same reason.**

Selection is not fully removable and the split is unknown. But even a modest causal component, multiplied across a population, is a very large number of offences.

And notice where the evidence points. Every finding here is about men — men's earnings, offending, drinking, mortality. The problem described is a male problem and the intervention is an intervention on men. Traditionalists deploy this as a reason to restrict women, and nothing in it supports that direction.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Insurance That Was Cancelled

This is the strongest argument in the part. It is made most often by women and dismissed most often by men, and it does not require a single claim about biology, morality or tradition. It is about who carries the risk of a change.

7.1 — The argument

Suppose everything the reformer says is true. The rules are unjust, they were built for a world that no longer exists, and the costs fall on women.

A woman is now asked to stop complying. What is she being offered in exchange?

Under the old arrangement she had a guarantee. It was a bad guarantee — constrained, humiliating in places, administered by people with power over her. It was also a guarantee. If she followed the rules, a household was obliged to house and feed her, her children had a claim on a lineage, and she had a defined position that could not simply be withdrawn.

The replacement is not a guarantee. It is an **opportunity**. She may work, own property, leave a marriage, marry whom she chooses. Every one of those is a chance rather than a promise, and every one requires a functioning labour market, enforceable law, safe transport, childcare, and a family that will not cut her off.

So the offer is: give up a bad certainty for a good chance.

That is a real trade with a real downside, and the person being asked to make it is not being irrational when she hesitates. She is pricing an option correctly.

7.2 — Why she had nothing to fall back on

The argument above assumes the woman has no outside option. It is worth explaining how she came not to have one, because the mechanism is an argument in its own right and it is the most respectable economic case ever made for the traditional household.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Specialisation:** two people producing more together by each doing one thing well than by both doing everything adequately.
>
> It is the oldest idea in economics. A village where one person farms and another makes tools produces more than two people each doing half of both, because skill accumulates with practice and switching between tasks wastes effort.
>
> Why it matters here: applied to a household, it is the strongest economic argument for the traditional division of labour — and it contains, built into it, the reason that division became a trap.

The argument, made carefully in economics in the twentieth century, runs like this. A household is a small productive unit. It has to generate income and it has to produce a home, meals, childcare and everything else that keeps people alive and functioning.

If both adults split their time across both tasks, neither becomes very good at either, and both keep interrupting one task to do the other. If instead one specialises in earning and the other in the household, each accumulates skill, neither wastes effort switching, and the total output is higher.

Which one specialises in which is then a question of comparative advantage — and in a world where employers paid women less, where childbirth interrupted employment repeatedly, and where infants required a nursing mother, the answer fell out without anybody needing to hold a view about women.

Notice what this argument does not require. No claim that women are better at domestic work. No claim that men are better at earning. It works even if both are false, provided only that the labour market treats them differently — and it did.

So the traditional household was, on this account, not an expression of contempt or a theory about female nature. It was a firm, organised the way firms are organised, extracting the gains that specialisation produces.

7.3 — And why that is exactly the problem

Now the part that makes this the best argument in the chapter rather than merely a clever one.

Specialisation has a cost, and the cost is **concentrated entirely on the specialising partner**.

The person who specialises in earning acquires skills, contacts, a record and a wage — all of which are portable. If the household dissolves, he takes them with him.

The person who specialises in the household acquires skills that are real, demanding and valuable, and that no employer will pay for. Twenty years of running a home produces no salary history, no references, no promotion record and no market wage. If the household dissolves, she takes with her nothing that can be sold.

Which means the arrangement is only rational for her if it is **permanent**. Specialisation is a bet on the durability of the partnership, and the whole return on her side of the bet arrives only if it lasts.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Put two people at the start of a marriage and run them forward twenty years.
>
> He has two decades of employment. A wage that rose. A profession. People who would hire him. If the marriage ends, every one of those walks out of the door attached to him.
>
> She has two decades of work that was equally real — and there is no institution anywhere that will convert it into an income. If the marriage ends, she is a person with no recent employment at forty-five.
>
> **The arrangement did not make her dependent by accident. Dependence is what specialisation produces, and it was the price of the extra output the household enjoyed for twenty years — output he also consumed.**
>
> Which is why the old system had to make marriage hard to leave. Not from cruelty. Because an arrangement that requires one partner to make herself unemployable is not survivable for her unless the exit is closed for him.

And that yields the sharpest version of this chapter's argument. Divorce became easy in the second half of the twentieth century. The specialisation arrangement did not immediately stop — large numbers of women were already twenty years into a bet whose terms had just been rewritten without their agreement.

A generation of women had made an irreversible investment on the assumption of permanence, and the permanence was removed retrospectively. Whatever else the traditional position gets wrong, it is right about that, and it happened to real people who are still alive.

7.4 — What the numbers say about the trade

IN REAL TERMS

Follow a household through a separation, using the pattern found across many countries.

After a divorce, a woman's household income typically falls sharply \u2014 in a number of studies by something in the region of a third or more, and considerably further where children remain with her. A man's household income falls less, and in some studies rises.

Put that in a house. The same woman, the same qualifications, the same city, one year later, running the same household on substantially less money with the same number of children in it.

Now add the Indian conditions. Maintenance exists in law and is slow and difficult to enforce. Inheritance rights exist in law and are frequently signed away under family pressure. Paid work is available to a minority of women. Returning to her own family is a request that may be refused, and Part Three explains why a family might refuse it.

The right to leave is not the ability to leave. A legal right that a person cannot exercise without destitution is a document rather than an option, and everybody in the situation knows the difference.

7.5 — Why women make this argument

One of the persistent puzzles for reformers is that large numbers of women support the arrangement, enforce it on other women, and object to its removal. The usual explanations are that they have been conditioned, or that they are complicit.

There is a simpler explanation and it does not require anybody to be deceived.

A woman deciding whether to support the old arrangement is not choosing between the system and freedom. She is choosing between the system and *whatever exists where she lives*. If what exists is an unenforced maintenance law, no childcare, unsafe transport and a labour market that will not employ her, then the arrangement is the better of the two options actually on the table.

Part Three found something related and worth restating here: women in communities that adopted stricter norms gained real things — standing, better marriages for their children, security for the household. That was not false consciousness. It was a purchase, made with somebody's freedom, by people who were paying for a benefit they received.

Any argument that treats women who defend these rules as merely brainwashed has not looked at what they are being offered instead.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The whole chapter so far \u2014 and every version of this argument, on both sides \u2014 assumes **that the old arrangement was insurance.**

Notice what insurance actually is. You pay a premium. When the bad thing happens, you are paid, *regardless of your conduct*, by an institution with no interest in whether you deserve it, and you can enforce the claim against them.

Now check the old arrangement against that description.

The payout was conditional on continuous compliance, judged by the people making the payment. There was no enforcement against them. And the same household that provided the security also administered the punishment for failing to earn it \u2014 which means the protector and the threat were the same body.

That is not insurance. There is an older word for an arrangement in which somebody guarantees your safety on condition of your obedience, and in which they are also the danger you are being protected from.

The general form: **a comforting name applied to a structure whose actual shape is different.** And the correction matters practically, because the reform implied by "restore the insurance" is completely different from the reform implied by "build actual insurance" \u2014 which is a welfare state, and which nobody has to obey.

7.6 — The Indian version

Everything above applies with more force in India than in the countries where the argument is usually made, and it is worth setting out specifically.

Widows. India has one of the largest widowed populations in the world, and their circumstances are documented and poor. Part Three explained the historical machinery; what persists is a group of women whose position depended on a person who has died, in a country with no general old-age support.

The elderly. Part Two, Chapter Nine identified this as the problem the audit could not clear, and it belongs here too. India has no meaningful universal pension. For most families, old age means being supported by a son. That single fact makes a son an asset and a daughter a transfer to another household — and it means the insurance argument is not historical. It is a live description of how most Indian retirement is financed.

Enforcement. Maintenance after separation exists in law and moves slowly through overloaded courts. Inheritance rights exist in law and are, by consistent report, frequently surrendered under family pressure by daughters who do not wish to be the person who sued their brother. A right that costs a relationship to exercise is priced differently from one that does not.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The financial consequences of separation are among the better-measured things in this literature, because they can be traced through tax and survey records rather than asked about.

What the data shows: across many countries, women's household income falls substantially after a separation and men's falls much less. The gap is wider where children remain with the mother, which is most cases. The pattern holds in countries with strong welfare systems, and is far larger in those without.

What it can establish: that the financial risk of a marriage ending is distributed very unevenly, and that this is a feature of the arrangement rather than of any individual's conduct.

What it cannot establish: the Indian magnitude. Indian data on post-separation income is thin, because separation is under-reported, informal separation is common and not recorded, and household surveys are not designed to follow a household that has divided. The direction is not in doubt. The size is not known.

Put those together and the Indian version of Chapter Seven's argument is stronger than the version made in richer countries. The floor there is thin. The floor here has holes you can see through.

7.7 — What follows

The argument in this chapter is the strongest in the part and it points somewhere specific, so it is worth being exact.

It does **not** establish that the rules are good. It establishes that the *transition* is dangerous, and that the danger falls on the person being asked to make it.

Which is the asylum lesson from Part One, Chapter Three, arriving for the third time in this series. Removing a system that provided something, without building the replacement, does not produce liberation. It produces people who have lost something and gained a document.

And it tells you what the replacement has to be. Not a change in attitudes. Enforceable maintenance. Enforceable inheritance. Employment a woman can actually reach. Childcare. Transport she can use after dark. A pension, so that Part Two's unsolved problem stops making sons into assets and daughters into costs.

Every one of those is expensive, boring, and does not require anybody to be persuaded of anything.

REMEMBER THIS

Grant that the rules are unjust and built for a vanished world. A woman is now asked to stop complying. **What is she offered in exchange?**

The old arrangement was a bad guarantee \u2014 constrained, humiliating, administered by people with power over her \u2014 and it was a guarantee. The replacement is an **opportunity**: a chance requiring a functioning labour market, enforceable law, safe transport, childcare and a family that will not cut her off. The offer is **a bad certainty for a good chance**, and hesitating is correct pricing rather than false consciousness.

And the dependence was not accidental. A household that **specialises** produces more — that is the oldest idea in economics, and it needs no claim about female nature, only a labour market that paid women less. But specialisation is portable for the earner and worthless outside the home for the other partner. **It is only rational for her if the marriage is permanent**, which is why the old system closed the exit. Then divorce became easy, and a generation of women found the terms of a twenty-year bet rewritten retrospectively.

The numbers support her. Women’s household income falls sharply after separation \u2014 often by a third or more \u2014 and in India maintenance is slow, inheritance is signed away under pressure, and paid work reaches a minority. **The right to leave is not the ability to leave.**

But it was never insurance. Insurance pays out when the bad thing happens, whatever your conduct, from an institution you can enforce against. This paid out only on continuous obedience, judged by the payer, with no appeal \u2014 and the household providing the security also administered the punishment. The protector and the threat were the same body.

Which changes what follows. “Restore the insurance” and “build actual insurance” are different programmes. The second is a welfare state — enforceable maintenance, reachable employment, childcare, transport, a pension — and nobody has to obey it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Argument From Uncertainty

Part One examined the fence in the field and found it missing a word. Now that six parts have identified what the fence actually does, the argument is considerably stronger than it was — and its best version is genuinely hard to answer.

8.1 — The fence, after the investigation

Part One, Chapter Three set out the rule: do not remove what you cannot explain. And it found the flaw — the argument tells you to ask *why* the fence is there when the honest question is *who* built it and who was on the wrong side.

That objection was correct and it has now been answered, at length, by the intervening parts.

We know what these rules did. They secured inheritance. They maintained group boundaries. They managed disease and pregnancy in a world with no defence against either. They bought male investment in children. They provided a floor for women in economies that offered none. They domesticated men, apparently causally. They produced the household arrangement in which, on the best available evidence, children do somewhat better.

The traditionalist can now say something they could not say at the start of this series: **we did the investigation you demanded, and the fence turns out to be load-bearing in at least six places.**

That is a substantially stronger position than “leave it alone because it is old.”

8.2 — Asymmetric risk

The second component is about the shape of the bet rather than its content.

WORD BOX

Irreversibility: the property of a change that cannot be undone by reversing the decision that caused it.

Repealing a law is reversible — you can pass it again. A generation that did not have children is not, because the decision and its consequence are separated by biology and time.

Why it matters here: the whole argument in this chapter turns on the claim that the two possible errors differ in this property, and it is worth checking that claim carefully rather than accepting it because it sounds cautious.

Suppose you are uncertain whether a change is beneficial. The rational response depends not only on the probabilities but on what happens if you are wrong in each direction.

Keeping a rule that is no longer needed costs something real: constrained lives, wasted talent, unnecessary suffering. That cost is continuous, visible, and — this is the point — **reversible**. A rule can be removed next year.

Removing a rule that was doing something may cost something that cannot be put back. A generation that did not form families does not form them retrospectively. A body of tacit knowledge about how to run a household, once a generation has not learned it, is not recoverable from a book. And the demographic version, which Part Nine takes up, may be the clearest case: a population that falls below replacement for long enough cannot decide to reverse it, because the people who would have had the children were not born.

So the two errors are not symmetrical. One is expensive and undoable. The other may be cheap and permanent.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the version of that argument with the least rhetoric in it.

Every claim in this series has been tested against evidence from societies. There is no laboratory, no control group and no second attempt. **There is one run of the experiment and everybody is inside it.**

A medical trial that goes wrong is stopped, and the next trial is designed better. A society that changes its family arrangements and finds out in forty years that it went badly has no equivalent move. The forty years happened. The people are the age they are. The children who were not born are not available to be born later.

This is not an argument that change is wrong. It is an argument about **what standard of evidence a person should want before making an irreversible move in a system they cannot test** \u2014 and the honest answer is: a higher standard than we have for almost anything in this series.

8.3 — And who has to prove what

There is a component of this argument that is not about evidence at all, and it decides more arguments than any evidence does.

Whoever carries the burden of proof loses ties. So the question of where the burden sits is worth more than most of the facts in this series, and it cannot be settled by facts.

The traditionalist position: the arrangement exists, it has lasted, people live inside it, and the person proposing to change it must show that the change is safe. This follows directly from §8.1 and §8.2, and it is how we treat almost everything else. Nobody demands that an existing bridge prove itself before being allowed to remain standing.

The reformist position: the arrangement restricts a person’s life without her consent, and restriction is the thing requiring justification. A rule that has constrained people for four thousand years has been unjustified for four thousand years, and the passage of time is not a defence.

Both are reasonable and there is no neutral ground between them. Part One, Chapter Nine said this and declined to hide it, and it is worth repeating here because this part is written from the other side.

What can be said is that the two positions are not symmetrical in one respect. The traditionalist default protects an arrangement; the reformist default protects a person. Which of those you think should be protected first is a value, it is stated rather than derived, and everybody arguing about this has one whether or not they have noticed.

8.4 — Where the argument breaks

I said this part would drop arguments that fail. This one nearly fails, and it is worth showing exactly where, because what survives is the useful part.

The problem is that it proves too much.

Run the identical reasoning in 1828. Widow-burning has been practised for centuries. Nobody fully understands its function. The consequences of abolishing it are unknown and possibly severe. Society is a complex system, the change is irreversible, and there is only one run of the experiment.

Every premise holds. The conclusion is that sati should have been left alone.

The same applies to foot-binding, to slavery, to the abolition of duelling, to every reform in Part Two, Chapter Three. An argument that would have blocked all of them is not a decision procedure. It is a general-purpose brake, and a brake that stops everything is not a brake, it is a wall.

8.5 — And what survives, which is not nothing

Strip out the part that proves too much and something specific remains, and it is the strongest thing the traditional position holds.

The argument is not *do not change*. It is: **build the replacement before you remove the thing, and check that it works.**

That version does not block sati's abolition, because nothing was needed to replace it. It does not block widow remarriage. It does not block letting women work or own property or choose a husband.

What it does block is the specific move this series has now identified three times. Part One found it in the emptied asylums, where an institution was closed and the promised community care was never built. Part Two found it in India's dowry ban, where a transaction was prohibited and the market that produced it was untouched. Part Seven of this part found it in a woman being offered a document instead of a guarantee.

Each is the same failure. **The rule was removed and the function it was performing was not reassigned to anything.**

That is a real argument, it is empirically supported, and it is the one thing in this part that survives Chapter Nine intact.

REMEMBER THIS

Part One found Chesterton's fence missing a word. Six parts later the traditionalist can answer it: **we did the investigation, and the fence is load-bearing in at least six places** — inheritance, boundaries, disease, male investment, women's floor, and male behaviour. That is much stronger than "leave it alone because it is old."

Then the shape of the bet. Keeping an unnecessary rule is expensive and **reversible**. Removing a rule that was doing something may be cheap and **permanent** — a generation that did not form families does not form them retrospectively, and children who were not born cannot be born later.

And there is **one run of the experiment and everybody is inside it**. No control group, no second attempt, no stopping the trial.

But the argument nearly fails, because it proves too much. Run it in 1828 about widow-burning and every premise holds and the conclusion is that sati should have been left alone. **A brake that stops everything is a wall.**

What survives is narrow and it is the best thing in this part: not "do not change" but "build the replacement before removing the thing." That blocks nothing worth doing — and it blocks the failure this series has now found three times, where a rule was removed and the function it was performing was reassigned to nothing.

CHAPTER NINE

Scoring It

Seven chapters of the best case that can be built. Now it gets tested against the four conditions set out at the start — and against the thing this whole series is actually about.

9.1 — The four conditions

Chapter One set the standard, taken from Part One. For a rule to be justified, four things must hold. The problem must still exist. The harm from removing the rule must exceed the harm from keeping it, counting both columns. No cheaper instrument must be available. And the burden must belong where it is placed.

Take the arguments one at a time.

The five absences (Chapter Two). As history, unanswerable — the rules were a response to real dangers and a reasonable person might have written them. As present justification, it fails the first condition comprehensively. Contraception exists. Antibiotics exist. Paternity became verifiable in 1985. Law is reachable for most people in most places. Four of the five dangers are gone. **The fifth is not**, and that is Chapter Seven.

Children (Chapter Three). Passes the first condition: children exist and stability affects them. Struggles on the second, because the effect is real and smaller than claimed. And fails the third badly — the damage appears driven by *instability and income* rather than by marriage as such, and income support is a cheaper instrument that restricts nobody. On the fourth it does not even engage: nothing in the evidence says the burden of household stability belongs to the mother rather than the father.

Partnership decline (Chapter Four). Passes the first condition cleanly; it is happening and it is countable. Fails the second as usually presented, because the credit column — collapsing intimate partner violence, fewer forced marriages, women able to leave — is real and is almost never counted. On the third and fourth, the argument identifies a missing *matching infrastructure*, and nothing about a matching infrastructure requires restricting anybody.

Cheap sex (Chapter Five). The arithmetic passes; the moral framing does not. Fails the third condition, because the economic account has a natural experiment behind it and this one has a fitted narrative. And fails the fourth by construction — the market metaphor assigns the burden to women before any evidence is heard.

Marriage and men (Chapter Six). Passes the first condition and has real causal evidence. Fails the fourth completely and obviously. Every finding in it concerns men. The problem described is a male problem and the intervention indicated is on men.

The insurance argument (Chapter Seven). This is the one that scores best. Passes the first condition in India, where the floor genuinely has not been built. Passes the second, for the transition. And then fails the third — because a cheaper instrument exists, is well understood, and does not require anybody's obedience. It is a welfare state.

Uncertainty (Chapter Eight). Survives only in the narrow form: build the replacement before removing the thing. In that form it passes everything, because it is not a defence of any rule.

9.2 — The gap the case cannot cross

Now the finding that matters, and it took seven chapters of arguing the other side to make it visible.

Every argument in this part is about one of four things: **household stability, partnership formation, male behaviour, or women's economic security.**

Not one of them is about the rules this series began with.

Nothing in Chapter Three requires that a woman marry inside her caste. Stability is not produced by endogamy; endogamy narrows the pool and produces matches nobody chose.

Nothing in Chapter Four requires that a widow may not remarry. A widow remarrying is a partnership forming — the exact thing Chapter Four says there is too little of. **The rule and the argument point in opposite directions.**

Nothing in Chapter Five requires a dowry, which by Part Two's account is a bid in a marriage market and by Part Three's account is the reason a family may not want a daughter at all.

Nothing in Chapter Six requires anything of women whatsoever.

Nothing in Chapter Seven requires seclusion, veiling, or a restriction on movement — every one of which reduces a woman's ability to earn, and therefore makes the insecurity in that chapter worse rather than better.

And nothing in any of them, at any point, licenses publishing a rumour about a woman who stood in front of a police vehicle.

That is the result. **The strongest case for the old rules that can be assembled from the best available evidence is a case for stable families, functioning partnership, intervention on male behaviour, and a welfare state. It is not a case for controlling women, and in several places it argues against it.**

I did not set out to reach that. I set out to build the best traditionalist argument I could, and this is where it went.

9.3 — What I have actually done here

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The whole exercise assumes **that steelmanning is a neutral act** — that building somebody's best case is a courtesy, costing nothing, from which truth benefits.

It is not neutral, in two directions, and both are against me.

The first is against the traditionalist. Chapter One admitted that this case is a modern reconstruction built from evidence nobody in a traditional society had. So Chapter Nine has just scored an argument that nobody actually makes. The real position is not the one I built. It is closer to *this is how it is done, this is what your mother did, and you will bring shame on us.* I have defeated an opponent I invented, which is a rigged game running in a subtler direction than the usual one \u2014 and a person whose real reasons are untouched by all of this will be exactly as convinced tomorrow.

The second is against me. Chapters Two through Eight are now written down, at full strength, with no undercutting, by design. They are quotable. Somebody will quote them without Chapter Nine, and the quotation will be accurate.

I decided that a reader who has never encountered the good version of an argument cannot be said to have rejected it. I still think that. But it is a decision with a cost, the cost falls on people who are not me, and pretending otherwise would be the one dishonest thing in a part built to be honest.

> The general form: **improving an argument and then treating the improved version as the one that was on trial.**

I am leaving the part as it stands. But if you carry one thing from it into an argument, carry the scorecard rather than a chapter.

REMEMBER THIS

Scored against the four conditions: the **five absences** are unanswerable as history and fail as present justification, because four of the five dangers are gone. **Children** passes on the problem and fails on the instrument — the damage tracks instability and income, and income support restricts nobody. **Partnership decline** is real and its credit column is never counted. **Cheap sex** loses to an economic account with a natural experiment behind it. **Marriage and men** has real causal evidence and concerns men entirely.

The insurance argument scores best and then fails on the third condition, because a cheaper instrument exists that nobody has to obey: a welfare state. And **uncertainty** survives only as "build the replacement before removing the thing," which is not a defence of any rule.

And here is the result that took seven chapters of arguing the other side to see. Every argument in this part is about household stability, partnership formation, male behaviour or women's economic security. Not one is about the rules this series began with — and several argue against them. A widow remarrying is a partnership forming, which is the exact thing Chapter Four says there is too little of.

The strongest case for the old rules that can be built is a case for stable families, functioning partnership, intervention on men, and a welfare state. It is not a case for controlling women.

And steelmanning was not neutral. I defeated an argument nobody makes, while writing seven quotable chapters that somebody will use without this one.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about the case for the old rules, and what is solid enough that any honest opponent has to concede it.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

This part rests on outcome research, and outcome research about families has a specific and unfixable problem at its root.

How much of the family-structure effect is causal. The honest range is wide. Selection cannot be fully removed because nobody is randomly assigned to a marriage. The best designs agree the effect is real and smaller than raw comparisons; none of them can put a confident number on it.

What the mechanism is. Money, supervision, the number of adults, the number of transitions, conflict levels and parental attention are all candidates, and separating them has not been done convincingly. This matters enormously for policy: if it is money, the instrument is cash; if it is instability, the instrument is anything that reduces churn; if it is two adults specifically, the instrument is something else again.

Whether marriage changes men or selects them, and in what proportion. Within-individual designs find a real effect and cannot rule out that a man was already changing. The split is unknown and the honest range is wide.

Why partnership is collapsing. Economic precarity has the best evidence and a natural experiment behind it. Sexual liberalisation, housing costs, delayed independence, screens and changed expectations are all live. Nobody has apportioned them.

Whether loneliness has risen. Measures disagree. This is the weakest claim in the part and it is asserted with the most confidence.

What women in these arrangements actually wanted. The same hole as in Parts Two and Three. Chapter Seven argues that women defending the arrangement are pricing an option correctly rather than being deceived. That is an inference from their circumstances, not a report of their reasons, and I do not have their reasons.

10.2 — Solid

That the rules were a response to real dangers. The five absences in Chapter Two are matters of historical record. Childbirth killed at roughly one death per hundred deliveries. The great sexual diseases were incurable. Paternity was unverifiable until 1985. There was no floor and no reachable law. Any account of these rules as pure malice is false.

That children in stable two-parent households do better on average, and that the effect is smaller than the raw numbers. Both halves. Each camp quotes one.

That the effect falls harder on boys. Consistent across large administrative datasets and comparisons within families.

That marriage has become a class marker, retained by the university-educated and collapsing among everybody else \u2014 so the stabilising arrangement is held by the people who need it least.

That partnership is declining across the developed world. Never-married shares at forty rising from around six per cent to around twenty-five in the United States over four decades, with sharper versions in East Asia. And the share of young adults reporting no recent sexual activity has risen, which inverted everybody's predictions.

That married men offend less, and that a causal component survives. Within-individual designs, plus the hormonal evidence pointing the same way.

That women lose more than men financially when a marriage ends, in every country where it has been measured, and that in India the legal remedies are largely unenforced.

That "build the replacement before removing the thing" is supported by three separate cases in this series — the emptied asylums, the dowry ban, and a woman offered a document instead of a guarantee.

And that none of the above reaches a single rule in Parts Two and Three. This is the finding of Chapter Nine and it is not a matter of interpretation. The arguments are about stability, partnership, male behaviour and economic security. The rules are about caste, widows, dowry, clothing and movement. They do not touch.

10.3 — The studies nobody wants to run

One closing observation, following the pattern of the previous parts.

Notice which questions in \u00a710.1 could be answered and have not been.

Whether the family-structure effect is money or structure could be settled by comparing outcomes across countries with similar family patterns and very different income support. Partial versions exist and point towards money. Nobody has done it properly.

Whether marriage-promotion works has been tested, weakly, and the results were weak. Whether cash support to unstable households produces the same benefits as stability has been tested in places and is rarely cited in this argument.

Each of these would resolve something. Each is expensive, unglamorous, and would produce an answer that disappoints somebody powerful.

Part One, Chapter Six applies for the last time in this part. **When a countable question stays uncounted for decades, the absence is a finding.** The family argument is more useful to everybody in its current state \u2014 where the traditionalist can quote the raw gap and the reformer can quote the adjusted one, indefinitely, without either being refuted.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: how much of the family-structure effect is causal, and what the mechanism is — money, instability, adults, conflict, attention. Whether marriage changes men or selects them, and in what proportion. Why partnership is collapsing. Whether loneliness has risen, which is the weakest claim asserted with the most confidence. And what women defending these arrangements actually want, as opposed to what their circumstances imply.

Solid: the rules answered real dangers, and any account of them as pure malice is false. Children in stable two-parent households do better, and the effect is smaller than the raw numbers, and it falls harder on boys. Marriage has become a class marker. Partnership is declining across the developed world and never-married shares at forty rose from about six to about twenty-five per cent in four decades. Married men offend less and a causal component survives. Women lose more financially when a marriage ends. And "build the replacement first" is supported by three separate cases in this series.

And that none of it reaches a single rule in Parts Two and Three. The arguments are about stability, partnership, male behaviour and economic security. The rules are about caste, widows, dowry, clothing and movement. They do not touch.

Last, notice which questions could be settled and have not been. The family argument is more useful to everybody unresolved — the traditionalist quotes the raw gap, the reformer quotes the adjusted one, and neither can be refuted.

The Scorecard

Seven arguments, four conditions. This is Chapter Nine as a single sheet, so that anybody quoting a chapter from this part can be shown what it scored.

ARGUMENT	PROBLEM STILL EXISTS?	CHEAPER INSTRUMENT?	BURDEN IN THE RIGHT PLACE?
The five absences Chapter Two	No — four of five are gone. Contraception, antibiotics, paternity testing, reachable law.	Not applicable.	Unanswerable as history. Fails as present justification.
Children Chapter Three	Yes. Stability affects children and the effect is real.	Yes — income support and anything reducing household churn.	No. Nothing says the burden is the mother's rather than the father's.
Partnership decline Chapter Four	Yes. Countable and happening nearly everywhere.	Untested — the argument identifies a missing matching infrastructure.	No. A matching infrastructure restricts nobody.
Cheap sex Chapter Five	The arithmetic, yes. The moral framing, no.	Yes — the economic account has a natural experiment behind it.	No. The market metaphor assigns it to women before evidence is heard.
Marriage and men Chapter Six	Yes, with real causal evidence.	Unknown.	No — and obviously not. Every finding concerns men.
Insurance Chapter Seven	Yes in India. The floor has not been built.	Yes — a welfare state, which nobody has to obey.	It is an argument about the transition, not about the rules.
Uncertainty Chapter Eight	Survives only as "build the replacement first."	In that form it is not a defence of any rule.	Passes, because it demands nothing of anybody.

Read the right-hand column downwards. That is the finding of this part.

Every argument is about **household stability, partnership formation, male behaviour or women's economic security.** Not one is about caste endogamy, enforced widowhood, dowry, child marriage, seclusion, or a rumour published about a woman at a protest. Several argue against them: a widow remarrying is a partnership forming, which Chapter Four says there is too little of.

Every argument in Chapters Two to Eight is stated at full strength and without undercutting, by design. This sheet is what each one scored.

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Asymmetric risk	A situation where being wrong in one direction costs far more than being wrong in the other, so the right level of caution differs by direction regardless of the probabilities.
Cohabitation	Living as a couple without marriage. It absorbed part of the decline in marriage and dissolves at higher rates, so children in cohabiting households experience more transitions.
Counterfactual	What would have happened otherwise. For a child of divorce it is not "the same parents, happily married" but the marriage they were actually in — which is why the evidence supports fewer bad marriages forming better than fewer marriages ending.
Irreversibility	The property of a change that cannot be undone by reversing the decision that caused it. Repealing a law is reversible; a generation that did not have children is not. The whole argument in Chapter Eight turns on whether the two possible errors differ in this respect.
Marriage premium	The consistent finding that married men earn more, work more and live longer than unmarried men. Partly selection, and a causal component survives within-individual designs.
Natural experiment	A situation where something outside anybody's control divided people into groups — a change in divorce law, a factory closing for reasons external to a town. The strongest evidence available where real experiments are impossible.
Selection	The problem that people who end up in an arrangement differ from those who do not, before the arrangement exists. Governs the entire family-structure literature.
Sexual economics	The framework treating sex as a good women supply and men demand, with a collectively set price. Generates the cheap-sex argument — and assigns the burden to women through its metaphor rather than through evidence.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Specialisation	Two people producing more together by each doing one thing well than by both doing everything adequately. The strongest economic case for the traditional household — and the reason it became a trap, because the earner's skills are portable and the other partner's are not.
Steelman	The strongest possible version of a position you disagree with, with the weak arguments removed. The opposite of a strawman. Not a neutral act, as Chapter Nine argues.
Within-individual design	Comparing a person with their own earlier self rather than with other people. Removes selection by construction, which is why it carries the weight in Chapter Six.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

This part is different from the five before it and the difference should be stated. It is written as an advocate rather than a reporter. Chapters Two to Eight argue for a position I do not hold, deliberately and without hedging, because the alternative — a summary of the traditional case with the weak parts left in and a disclaimer attached — is a way of appearing fair while conceding nothing.

The risk in doing that is obvious and Chapter Nine names it. Seven quotable chapters now exist and the tenth is the one people will skip. I decided that a reader who has never met the good version of an argument cannot be said to have rejected it, and that the cost of writing it down is worth paying. That is a judgement and it may be wrong.

My own position has not changed and I have not pretended it has. What did change while writing this is where I think the traditional position is strongest, and it is not where I expected. Chapter Seven — the argument about who carries the risk of a transition — is better than anything I had anticipated having to answer, and the answer to it is not an argument. It is a budget.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the sibling comparison, the law change, the longitudinal study — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. This part is that rule taken to its conclusion.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of published research in sociology, economics, criminology and demography rather than new work. Where a claim rests on a single study I have said so.

The whole part inherits one structural weakness, stated at the front and worth repeating here: nobody is randomly assigned to a family, so every comparison of family arrangements is contaminated by who ends up in each. The better designs — comparisons between siblings, changes in divorce law, the same individual before and after — reduce this substantially and do not eliminate it. Where a finding rests on a raw comparison I have said so, and where it survives a stronger design I have said that too, because the difference between those two is the entire argument in Chapter Three.

Figures are approximate and drawn from published studies and national statistics, and several vary between sources. Where the range is wide I have given a range. The claim about loneliness in Chapter Four is the weakest in the part and is marked as such in the text rather than smoothed over, because it is the one most often asserted with confidence it has not earned. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who work in these fields, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Seven — What Feminism Actually Claims. This part gave one side its best case. The next one does the same job on the other, and then scores it claim by claim.

- "Feminism" is treated as one object by everybody arguing about it. What are the actual positions inside it, how far apart are they, and which of them are in open conflict with each other?
- Indian feminism is routinely described as a Western import. It has a documented history reaching back to the 1840s, and its founders were arguing about caste while European feminists were arguing about property. What is that history and why is it so rarely cited?
- Claim by claim, scored: supported, contested, or falsified. Some claims made in feminism's name are dead on the evidence. Some are among the best-supported findings in social science. Naming which is which is the whole value.
- What did the movement predict would happen, in terms specific enough to be wrong? And what happened?
- There is a serious internal argument about whether the goal was ever equal outcomes or equal freedom, and Part Four showed those are in conflict. Which did the movement actually pursue, and what did it cost when it chose?
- And the question this series has been building towards: after two hundred years, what has been achieved, what has been abandoned, and what turned out to be a claim about the world that the world did not confirm?

END OF PART SIX OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Seven — What Feminism Actually Claims

Four movements sharing one name, several of which contradict each other. A history that begins in a Pune schoolroom in 1848, not in Europe.

And then the claims themselves, scored one at a time: supported, contested, or dead.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Part Six built the strongest case for the old arrangement that could be assembled, argued it without hedging for seven chapters, and then scored it. The result was that every argument in it turned out to be about household stability, partnership, male behaviour or women's economic security — and not one of them reached a single rule this series began with. Several argued against them.

The obvious next step is to do the same job on the other side.

That is what this part does, and I want to be precise about a structural difference between the two, because it matters and Chapter Nine returns to it. Part Six was written as an *advocate* — I built an argument nobody had made. This part is written as an *auditor* — the arguments already exist, in enormous quantity, made by people far better placed to make them than I am. What is missing is not advocacy. It is somebody going through them one at a time and saying which ones the evidence supports.

So this part does three things.

It separates the movements. "Feminism" is used as though it named one position. It names at least four, they disagree about fundamental questions, and several of them regard the others as the problem.

It corrects a history. Indian feminism is routinely described, by its opponents and sometimes by its supporters, as a Western import. It is not. A woman opened a school for girls in Pune in 1848, another published a book in 1882 arguing that men were morally worse than women, and a third wrote a feminist utopia in 1905 in which men were kept in seclusion. None of them was waiting for a translation.

And it scores the claims. Supported, contested, or falsified — with the specifics named in each case. Some claims made in feminism's name are among the best-supported findings in social science. Some are dead. A person who cannot tell you which are which does not have a view about feminism; they have a loyalty.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. One live example of each.

WORD BOX

An empirical claim says something about how the world is, and can be checked. **A moral claim** says something about what is owed, and cannot be checked by measurement. **A strategic claim** says what a movement should do, and is judged by whether it works.

Why it matters here: political movements make all three constantly, in the same sentences, and the whole job of this part is separating them. A moral claim is not refuted by data. An empirical claim is not defended by conviction. And Part One, Chapter Two showed what happens when different kinds of claim are welded together and argued as one.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

IN REAL TERMS

One figure, before any argument, because it does more to explain the modern earnings gap than every other explanation combined.

Follow a man and a woman with the same education, the same job and the same earnings. Then follow them past the birth of a first child.

His earnings continue on their previous path. Hers drop sharply — and in the country where this was measured most precisely, they **never recover**. Not for the next decade, not for the next two.

In Denmark, where the records allow the calculation to be done properly, researchers found that by the 2010s something in the region of **four fifths** of the entire remaining gender earnings gap was attributable to this one event.

Not to unequal pay for the same work. Not to men being preferred at interview. To children — and to the fact that a society decided, without ever voting on it, which parent absorbs them.

A finding that large invites suspicion, so it is worth knowing exactly how it was obtained.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

That finding comes from a design worth understanding, because it is the strongest kind available outside a laboratory.

What was done: researchers used national administrative records covering an entire population over decades — every person's earnings, employment and children, linked. Rather than comparing mothers with non-mothers, which runs straight into the selection problem from Part Six, they compared each person with *their own earnings path before the birth*, and against the path of a similar person whose first child arrived later.

What that buys: the comparison is a woman against herself. It cannot be explained by the kind of woman she is, because she is the control.

What it cannot show: why the burden lands where it does. Biology, employer behaviour, partner behaviour, policy and preference all remain candidates, and the design says nothing about which. It measures the penalty with great precision and is silent on its cause.

An Argument box appears wherever competent people genuinely disagree, and there is one about this part's whole undertaking.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN A POLITICAL MOVEMENT BE SCORED ON ITS CLAIMS?

Worth settling before eight chapters of doing it.

YES

A movement that makes factual claims in public, and uses them to argue for laws and budgets, has invited exactly this. If the claims are wrong, the policies built on them are built on nothing, and no amount of good intention repairs that.

NO

Movements are not research programmes. They are coalitions doing politics, and they are judged by what they achieve, not by the accuracy of their slogans. Scoring feminism's claims is like scoring the claims of a trade union or an independence movement: technically possible, and beside the point.

Where things stand: the first, with the second as a genuine warning. A claim used to justify a law can be checked. But Chapter One argues that the accurate claims and the effective claims were frequently different claims, and that this is a fact about politics rather than a scandal about feminism.

And underneath that argument sits something both sides are taking for granted.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume **that a movement's claims and its achievements are connected** — that it won because it was right, or that being wrong should have cost it.

Movements do not work like that. They win through mobilisation, coalition, timing and the exhaustion of opponents. The arguments that mobilise best are chosen for their power to move people, and there is no reason those should be the same arguments that survive scrutiny.

Which produces the situation this part has to navigate. Feminism achieved enormous legal change — property, franchise, divorce, employment, the criminalisation of things that had not been crimes. Several of the empirical claims made along the way have since failed. **Both of those are true and neither bears on the other.**

The general form: **assuming the persuasive argument and the correct argument are the same argument.** They rarely are, in any movement, on any subject — and a person who discovers this about a movement they dislike, and not about one they support, has discovered nothing.

This is the signature box. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.

Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

This part contains a chapter listing claims that failed, and it is specific. Not "some feminists have said silly things," which is true of every movement and worth nothing. Named claims, with what was asserted, what was found, and by whom. If that chapter reads as an attack, check Chapter Six's opening: nearly every one of those claims was overturned by researchers working inside the tradition, not by its opponents.

It also contains a chapter on claims that hold, and that chapter is longer. Several of them are among the more robust findings in the social sciences, and a reader who arrived expecting a demolition will find the opposite in Chapter Four.

My own position, and the asymmetry. Part Six gave the traditional case a lawyer. This part gives feminism an examiner. Those are not the same treatment, I chose it deliberately for reasons Chapter Nine sets out, and the reader is entitled to weigh it. I do not think the choice was wrong. I do think it should be visible rather than buried, and it is the kind of thing a writer normally hopes nobody notices.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

Four Movements With One Name

"Feminism says" is the opening of an unreliable sentence, whoever is speaking. There are at least four positions under the word, they disagree about fundamental questions, and several of them regard the others as part of the problem.

1.1 — The four

Start by laying them out, because most people arguing about this have met one and assume it is the whole.

Liberal feminism. The problem is exclusion. Women were kept out of property, law, education, employment and the vote, and the remedy is to remove the barriers and let them in on the same terms as everybody else. This is the strand that produced almost all of the legal change of the last two centuries, and it is what most people mean by the word without knowing there is another kind.

Radical feminism. The problem is not exclusion from a good system but the system itself. On this account male dominance is not an accident of history to be legislated away but the organising structure of society, reaching into the family, sexuality and the household — which is what the phrase about the personal being political was for. The remedy is not entry. It is transformation.

Socialist feminism. The problem is the way women's unpaid domestic labour underwrites an economy that does not count it. On this account a woman succeeding in a corporation has not solved anything; she has joined the thing that was extracting the labour. The remedy runs through economics rather than through law.

Difference feminism. The problem is that qualities and work associated with women — care, relationship, nurture, the running of households — are systematically undervalued. The remedy is not to make women more like men but to *revalue what women already do*. This strand takes sex differences seriously and treats them as a resource rather than an embarrassment.

And running across all four, a fifth position that is less a strand than a critique.

WORD BOX

Intersectionality: the idea that a person's situation is produced by several categories acting together rather than by any one of them separately — so a Dalit woman's position is not simply a woman's position plus a Dalit's position, but something the two make jointly.

The term was coined in American legal scholarship in the late 1980s. The observation is much older in India, where the interaction of caste and sex was the first thing the movement in §2.1 ran into.

Why it matters here: it is the basis of the sharpest internal criticism the Indian women's movement has faced, and it is domestic rather than imported.

The intersectional and Dalit critique. That "women" is not one category. A woman's situation is produced jointly by sex and by caste, class, religion and region, and a movement led by women at the top of those hierarchies will produce a programme suited to them. In India this critique is specific and it is domestic: that the mainstream women's movement was substantially upper-caste, and that its priorities reflected that.

1.2 — Where they collide

These are not four emphases within one view. On several questions they give opposite answers, and the disputes are conducted with more heat than any argument with outsiders.

Is selling sex work or exploitation? One strand holds it is an institution of male dominance and should be abolished, with the buyers criminalised. Another holds it is labour, that criminalising it endangers the people doing it, and that the abolitionist position is a middle-class judgement about poor women. Both call themselves feminist. Neither regards the other as a variation on itself.

Is staying at home oppression or a choice? Liberal feminism's whole case rests on women entering paid work. Difference feminism regards that as accepting a male standard and abandoning the argument that domestic work has value.

Should differences be minimised or celebrated? One strand's central empirical claim is that psychological sex differences are largely constructed and will diminish. Another's central claim is that women bring something distinct and that erasing it is the injury. Part Four's findings are welcome news to one and a problem for the other.

And in India, whether to reform religious personal law. This split the Indian women's movement genuinely and painfully. Reforming personal law would improve many women's legal position. It would also hand a weapon to a politics that wants to reform minority practice for reasons that have nothing to do with women. Feminists took both sides, in public, and the argument is not resolved.

1.3 — What this does to the sentence

The consequence is that "feminism claims X" is nearly always false, and it is false in a specific and useful way.

An opponent picks the strand with the least defensible position on a given question and attributes it to the whole. A supporter picks the strand with the strongest and does the same. Both sentences are accurate about somebody and misleading about the movement, and neither person is lying.

So this part will not say what feminism claims. It will name claims, say who makes them, and score them individually. Where a claim is contested inside the movement, that will be stated, because a claim that half of feminism rejects is not a claim about feminism.

REMEMBER THIS

At least four positions share the name. **Liberal** — the problem is exclusion, the remedy is entry, and this strand produced nearly all the legal change. **Radical** — the problem is the system itself, not exclusion from it. **Socialist** — the problem is uncounted domestic labour, and a woman succeeding in a corporation has joined the thing extracting it. **Difference** — the problem is that women's work is undervalued, and the remedy is to revalue it rather than make women more like men.

Across all four, the **intersectional and Dalit critique**: that "women" is not one category, and that a movement led from the top of a hierarchy produces a programme suited to the top. In India this critique is domestic and specific.

They collide on real questions. Is selling sex work or exploitation. Is staying home oppression or a choice. Should differences be minimised or celebrated — where Part Four's findings are good news for one strand and a problem for another. And whether to reform religious personal law, which split the Indian movement genuinely.

So "feminism claims X" is nearly always false. An opponent picks the weakest strand and attributes it to all; a supporter picks the strongest and does the same. Both are accurate about somebody. This part will name claims, say who makes them, and score them one at a time.

CHAPTER TWO

It Did Not Come From The West

The accusation that Indian feminism is a foreign import has a date problem. A woman opened a school for girls in Pune six months before the first women's rights convention was held in America.

2.1 — 1848

On the first day of January 1848, Savitribai Phule and her husband Jyotirao opened a school for girls in a house in Pune. She taught in it. She is generally regarded as the first Indian woman to work as a teacher in the modern sense, and the school was for girls of all castes at a time when that was itself the offence.

What happened to her for doing it is recorded. She was abused in the street on her way to the schoolroom, and reportedly carried a second sari to change into after arriving.

IN REAL TERMS

Put that date beside the one usually treated as the beginning.

The Seneca Falls Convention — the meeting in New York generally described as the founding event of the American women's rights movement — took place in **July 1848.**

The Pune school opened in **January 1848.**

Six months earlier. In a country under colonial rule, by a woman from a caste excluded from literacy, teaching girls from castes excluded from literacy, while being abused in the street for it.

Whatever Indian feminism is, it is not a translation of something that had not happened yet.

2.2 — And then it kept happening

The 1848 date would be a curiosity if it were isolated. It is not.

1882. Tarabai Shinde published *Stri Purush Tulana* — a comparison between women and men — in Marathi, prompted by the case of a widow prosecuted for infanticide. Its argument is that men are morally worse than women and that the entire apparatus of blame is inverted. It is frequently described as the first modern Indian feminist text and it was written for an Indian audience in an Indian language.

1887. Pandita Ramabai, a Sanskrit scholar honoured for her learning by the pandits of Calcutta, published *The High-Caste Hindu Woman*. She went on to found institutions for widows and for women with nowhere to go.

1905. Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain published *Sultana's Dream* in an Indian magazine. It describes a country in which women run everything and men are kept in seclusion, having proved unfit for public life. It was written in English, by a Bengali Muslim woman, as a satire on purdah — inverting the practice she lived under, in the language of the people ruling her country, in 1905.

Then the organisations. A women's association in 1917. A national council in 1925. An all-India conference in 1927. All of them Indian, all of them predating independence, all of them arguing about Indian law.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This chapter is unusual in the series because its evidence is almost entirely documentary, which makes it stronger than most of what surrounds it.

What the evidence is: published books with dates and printers. Magazine issues. School and institutional founding records. Organisational constitutions and conference proceedings. Government reports with publication dates. Court judgments.

Why that matters: nothing here depends on a survey, a sample, a statistical model or an interpretation of somebody's motives. The claim is that a text existed in a year, and the text exists.

What it cannot show: reach. A book published in 1882 tells you somebody wrote it and somebody printed it. It does not tell you how many people read it, whether anybody agreed, or whether it changed a single household — and the honest position is that these were minority voices in their own time, as reformers usually are.

2.3 — Different problems, different movement

The most useful thing about this history is not the dates. It is what the arguments were about, because the Indian and European movements were addressing different worlds.

European and American feminists of the nineteenth century were arguing about property rights for married women, the franchise, and access to professions.

Indian feminists of the same period were arguing about child marriage, widow remarriage, the treatment of widows, purdah, temple entry, and — from the beginning — **caste**. The Pune school was a caste offence before it was a gender offence.

That difference matters, because it means the two movements were not the same movement at different stages of development. They were separate responses to separate problems, and the Indian one was engaging from its first year with a question the European one did not have.

THE ARGUMENT — IS INDIAN FEMINISM A WESTERN IMPORT?

The accusation is constant and it deserves a proper answer rather than an indignant one.

SUBSTANTIALLY, YES

The vocabulary is English. The theoretical frameworks taught in Indian universities are largely Western in origin. The organisational forms — the conference, the association, the petition — were colonial. And the nineteenth-century reformers were operating inside a colonial education system, addressing a colonial state, using arguments that state would recognise. Independence of origin is not established by being early.

NO, AND THE DATES ARE THE LEAST OF IT

The Pune school predates Seneca Falls. Tarabai Shinde wrote in Marathi for Marathi readers. The problems addressed — child marriage, widowhood, purdah, caste — were Indian problems with no European equivalent, and no imported framework generates them. A movement is defined by what it is fighting, and this one was fighting things that did not exist in the countries it is accused of copying.

BOTH, BECAUSE MOVEMENTS ARE NOT PURE

Indian feminism has always been in conversation with foreign ideas, as every Indian intellectual movement has, including the nationalism that accuses it. Colonial encounter supplied vocabulary and institutional forms. It did not supply the grievance, the analysis, or the people. Part Three, Chapter Nine established that **nothing in this series has a single origin**, and this is another composite.

Where things stand: the third, and it dissolves the accusation rather than answering it. The demand for a pure indigenous pedigree is one nothing passes — not Indian nationalism, not Indian constitutionalism, not the Indian legal system, and not the conservatism that makes the demand.

What would settle it: nothing, because it is a question about origin and Part One, Chapter One established that origin does not determine legitimacy. That is the genetic fallacy, and Part Three, Chapter Nine caught me committing it deliberately.

Why people care so much: because "foreign" is not an argument about a claim. It is a way of relocating the person making it, which Part Three identified as the manoeuvre assembled in 1891 and hardened in 1927.

There is something further underneath that dispute, shared by both sides of it, and it is the more interesting thing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides of that argument — the Indian conservative and the Western feminist — share a premise neither states: **that there is one feminism, with an origin, which spread.**

The conservative uses it to say the thing arrived from elsewhere and is therefore alien. Western accounts use it to describe waves emanating outward from Europe and America, with other countries joining later. Both are describing diffusion from a source.

The evidence does not look like diffusion. It looks like **several movements arising independently, in different places, in response to different local problems, at roughly the same time.** Pune in January and New York in July did not learn it from each other. Neither had heard of the other.

> Part Two found exactly this shape once before. Farming appeared independently in at least half a dozen places among people with no contact — and the conclusion drawn there applies here. **When separate populations arrive at the same arrangement without copying, the situation is producing it, not the culture.**
>
> The general form: **reading independent invention as transmission, because a single origin is easier to argue about.** A thing with one source can be rejected as foreign or claimed as an inheritance. A thing that arose in six places at once can only be responded to.

2.4 — And then it was restarted, by a government report

One more piece of this history, because it explains the shape of the movement in India today and is almost unknown outside it.

After independence the women's question largely went quiet in Indian politics, for reasons Part Three, Chapter Seven set out — the nationalist settlement had answered it in advance by declaring the home already sovereign.

In 1974 a government committee published a report on the status of women in India. It had been expected to document progress.

It documented the opposite. On several central measures — the ratio of women to men in the population, women's share of paid work, women's political participation — the report found that things had got **worse** since independence.

That finding, produced by the state's own committee, is generally credited with restarting the Indian women's movement. What followed within a decade was a campaign over a Supreme Court judgment acquitting policemen of raping a girl in custody — a case that produced an open letter from four law professors, nationwide protest, and a change to the criminal law in 1983.

Note what that sequence contains. A state committee producing an inconvenient count. Academics writing a letter. Street protest. Statutory change. It is an entirely Indian sequence, conducted in Indian institutions, about an Indian case, and it is the founding event of the movement as it now exists.

REMEMBER THIS

January 1848: Savitribai Phule opens a school for girls in Pune and teaches in it, taking a second sari to change into after being abused in the street. **July 1848:** the Seneca Falls Convention. Six months later.

Then it kept happening. **1882**, Tarabai Shinde publishes in Marathi that men are morally worse than women. **1887**, Pandita Ramabai publishes on the high-caste Hindu woman. **1905**, Rokeya Hossain publishes a utopia in which men are kept in seclusion and women run the country — a satire on purdah, written in English, in 1905.

And they were arguing about **different things**. Europeans argued about property and the franchise. Indians argued about child marriage, widowhood, purdah, temple entry and — from the first year — **caste**. The Pune school was a caste offence before it was a gender offence.

Both the Indian conservative and the Western account assume **one feminism with an origin that spread**. The evidence looks like independent arising in several places at once — the same shape Part Two found in farming, where the conclusion was that the situation produces it, not the culture.

And it was restarted by a government report. In 1974 a state committee expected to document progress found that on the sex ratio, on women's paid work and on political participation, things had got worse since independence. That count, produced by India's own committee, is what relaunched the movement.

CHAPTER THREE

The Claims, Extracted

Before anything can be scored it has to be separated. A movement's output is a mixture of findings, values and slogans, and only one of the three is the kind of thing that can be right or wrong.

3.1 — Three kinds of sentence

Part One's central tool was separating three claims welded into one sentence. The same operation is needed here and it separates different things.

An empirical claim says how the world is. *Women do more unpaid work than men. The pay gap is caused by discrimination. Sex differences in personality are socially produced.* Each can be checked, and each is either true, false, or currently unresolved.

A moral claim says what is owed. *Women are entitled to equal standing. A person's opportunities should not depend on their sex.* No measurement bears on these. They cannot be confirmed by a study or refuted by one, and Part One, Chapter Four established why.

A strategic claim says what should be done. *Quotas work. Legal change should come before cultural change.* These are judged by results, and they can fail without anything moral or factual being wrong.

Most public sentences about feminism contain at least two of these fused, and the fusion is where the arguments go wrong. Somebody presents a moral claim, an opponent attacks an empirical one, and both leave satisfied.

3.2 — The standard this part applies

Only empirical claims are scored here. That is not a demotion of the others; it is the only category that can be scored at all.

Three verdicts are available.

Supported. The claim has been tested by people trying to break it, using designs strong enough to have found it false, and it survived. Repeatedly, across countries or methods.

Contested. Competent researchers disagree, the evidence is mixed, or the finding has replication problems. This verdict is not a polite way of saying false. Several claims here are contested and may well be true.

Failed. The claim was made, it was specific enough to be checked, it was checked, and the evidence went the other way.

One rule governs all three, and it is the one this series has applied to every camp. **A claim is scored on the evidence, not on whether the person making it was sympathetic.** Part Six scored the traditional case that way and this part scores this one identically.

3.3 — Why this is harder for a movement than for a theory

A scientific theory has an agreed statement. A movement does not, and this creates a real problem that is worth acknowledging rather than exploiting.

Any claim attributed to feminism can be disowned. *Serious feminists never said that.* Sometimes true — Chapter One showed how many positions the word covers. Sometimes it is a way of never being wrong about anything.

The discipline this part adopts: a claim is scored if it was **made in public by people with standing in the movement, used to argue for a policy, and repeated widely enough to shape what non-specialists believe.** That excludes anything found in one obscure paper. It includes things that appeared in campaigns, in training materials, in legislative testimony and in ordinary conversation.

By that standard, everything in Chapters Four to Six qualifies, and I have tried to note where a claim is disputed inside the movement rather than pretending it is universal.

REMEMBER THIS

Three kinds of sentence get fused. An **empirical claim** says how the world is and can be checked. A **moral claim** says what is owed and no measurement touches it. A **strategic claim** says what should be done and is judged by results.

Most public argument fuses at least two, so somebody presents a moral claim, an opponent attacks an empirical one, and both leave satisfied.

Only empirical claims are scored here, with three verdicts. **Supported** — tested by people trying to break it and it survived. **Contested** — competent researchers disagree, which is not a polite way of saying false. **Failed** — specific enough to check, checked, and the evidence went the other way.

A claim is scored if it was made publicly by people with standing, used to argue for a policy, and repeated widely enough to shape what non-specialists believe. And it is scored on the evidence, not on whether the person making it was sympathetic — which is exactly how Part Six scored the other side.

CHAPTER FOUR

What Holds

This is the longest of the three scoring chapters, which will surprise a reader who came for the demolition. Several claims made in feminism's name are among the better-supported findings in the social sciences, and one of them was settled by a randomised experiment across Indian villages.

4.1 — The historical claims

Start with the ones nobody disputes, because they are the foundation and they are frequently skipped past as though everyone already agrees.

Women were systematically excluded from property ownership, from inheritance in their own right, from higher education, from the professions, from the franchise, and from legal personhood in specific respects — in most of the world, for most of recorded history, by law rather than by custom alone.

This is not an interpretation. It is a description of statutes, and the statutes are published. Part Three found one such provision still in force in India.

Verdict: supported, and not contested by any serious person.

And a second historical claim, which is contested by some: **that removing those barriers produced very large changes.** Within a century of the relevant legal reforms, women went from a small minority to a majority of university graduates in most of the developed world, and from near-absence to substantial presence in medicine, law and public administration. Whatever else is disputed, the barriers were load-bearing.

4.2 — Unpaid work

The claim: that women perform a large majority of unpaid domestic and care work, that this work is economically substantial, and that it is excluded from the measures by which countries judge themselves.

IN REAL TERMS

India ran a national time use survey, asking people to account for their day.

Women reported spending roughly **five hours a day** on unpaid domestic work. Men reported roughly **an hour and a half**.

Put that in a week. The difference is somewhere in the region of **twenty-four hours** — a full extra day, every week, performed by one half of the population, for no wage, and counted in no national account.

Now put it in a working life. Over forty years, that difference is roughly equivalent to **twelve additional years** of unpaid full-time work.

This is not disputed by anybody. It is measured by governments, using their own surveys, and published. The dispute is entirely about what should follow from it.

Verdict: supported. Time use surveys in dozens of countries find the same direction, with India at the more extreme end. The exclusion from national accounts is a definitional fact, not an allegation.

4.3 — The child penalty

This is the most important entry in the chapter, because it is a feminist finding that overturned a feminist claim.

WORD BOX

The child penalty: the permanent drop in a person's earnings following the birth of a first child, measured against the path their own earnings were on beforehand.

The word "penalty" is not moral language here. It is the technical name for a measured quantity — the vertical distance between the earnings path a person was on and the one they ended up on.

Why it matters here: it is measured for both parents, and in every country studied it is close to zero for one of them.

For decades the pay gap was described in public campaigns as women being paid less for the same work. Chapter Six scores that version and it does not survive.

What replaced it is stronger. Using national administrative records covering whole populations, researchers tracked men and women through the birth of a first child. Before the birth, their earnings paths are indistinguishable. After it, hers falls sharply and does not return to the previous path — not in five years, not in ten, not in twenty.

In Denmark, where the records allow the cleanest calculation, the share of the total gender earnings gap attributable to this single event rose over three decades to something in the region of four fifths. The same pattern, at varying magnitudes, has been found across many countries.

Verdict: supported, strongly. The design compares a woman with her own earlier earnings path, which removes the selection problem that governs Part Six. This is among the best-identified findings in labour economics.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everybody arguing about the pay gap assumes **there are two possible explanations: discrimination or preference.**

One camp says employers pay women less. The other says women choose differently — fewer hours, different fields, more time with children. The entire public argument is conducted between those two options.

The child penalty is neither, and that is why it took so long to find.

No employer is deciding to pay mothers less. And no woman is freely choosing a twenty per cent permanent earnings cut in the way a person chooses a career. What is happening is **structural**: work is organised around uninterrupted availability, care is organised around one person absorbing the interruption, and the two are incompatible. Neither institution intended this. Both would deny responsibility, correctly.

The general form: **a false dichotomy that hides the mechanism.** When the only options on offer are somebody's bias and somebody's choice, any cause that is nobody's bias and nobody's choice becomes invisible — and structural causes are usually of exactly that kind.

Notice what follows practically. If it is discrimination, the remedy is enforcement. If it is preference, there is no remedy. If it is structural, the remedy is neither — it is changing how work and care are arranged, which is expensive, boring, and requires nobody to be blamed.

4.4 — Undercounted violence

The claim: that violence against women within households and relationships was massively under-recorded, under-prosecuted, and in some respects not legally recognised as violence at all.

The evidence is documentary. For long periods there was no offence corresponding to violence by a husband against a wife in the ordinary sense; the marital rape exemption in Part Three is one surviving instance. Reporting rates measured against survey prevalence show large gaps in every country where both have been measured. Conviction rates for reported sexual offences are low nearly everywhere.

Verdict: supported. The claim that these were undercounted is established by comparing survey prevalence with recorded crime — two independent measures of the same thing, differing by a large factor.

And there is a specifically Indian instance of this claim producing change, worth recording because it is recent and because Part Three left it hanging.

After a case in Delhi in late 2012 that produced sustained national protest, a committee headed by a former Chief Justice was constituted to recommend reform of the criminal law. It reported in under a month. Legislation the following year broadened the legal definition of rape, created offences for stalking, voyeurism and acid attacks, and increased penalties.

The committee also recommended removing the marital rape exception described in Part Three. **Parliament did not.** Which is a precise illustration of Chapter Three's categories: a movement made an empirical case about undercounted violence, it was accepted, a strategic recommendation followed, and the part touching the household was the part that did not pass.

What is *not* settled by that evidence is prevalence itself. Estimates vary widely depending on definitions and instruments, and Chapter Five takes up a specific case where the variation is an order of magnitude and the figure is quoted without it.

4.5 — The experiment India ran on itself

The claim: that women in positions of political power produce different decisions, and that seeing women in power changes what girls expect of themselves.

These sound like the kind of claims that can never be settled, because you cannot randomly assign leadership. Except that India did.

WORD BOX

Random assignment means deciding who gets a treatment by a process unconnected to anything about them — a lottery, a rule based on an arbitrary number.

It is the single most powerful tool in empirical research, and the reason is worth stating plainly. If assignment is random, the two groups cannot differ systematically beforehand, so any difference afterwards must come from the treatment. The selection problem that governs Part Six — that people who end up in an arrangement differ before it — **cannot arise**.

Why it matters here: almost nothing in this series has it. This does.

What follows is therefore not a correlation and not an inference. It is the result of an experiment, run at national scale, by a government that was not trying to run one.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A constitutional amendment in the early 1990s reserved a third of village council leadership positions for women. Crucially for research purposes, the villages selected were chosen by a rule that amounted to **random assignment —** which means India accidentally ran one of the largest randomised experiments in the history of political science.

What was found on policy: councils led by women invested differently, and the difference tracked what women in those regions had said they wanted. In one state that meant more spending on drinking water; in another, more on roads. Not a general “female” priority — the local priority that local women had stated.

What was found on aspirations: after two rounds of reservation, the gap between parents’ aspirations for sons and for daughters narrowed substantially, adolescent girls’ own aspirations rose, and **the gender gap in adolescent educational attainment was closed**. Girls also spent less time on household work.

Why this carries so much weight: the villages were assigned randomly. There is no selection story. The difference cannot be that better villages got women leaders, because assignment was not by merit, ambition or wealth.

What it cannot show: whether the effects persist once reservation ends, whether they transfer to national politics, or whether the mechanism is the leader’s decisions or simply the fact of being seen. And it is one country.

Verdict: supported. Both claims — that representation changes decisions, and that visible female authority changes what girls expect — have randomised evidence behind them at national scale. Very few claims in this entire series are supported this well.

It is worth noting who this inconveniences. It is evidence for quotas, from India, produced by economists, using a policy that Indian conservatives largely opposed. And it is evidence against the argument in Part Five that representation efforts achieve nothing — because here is a representation effort, randomised, that measurably achieved something.

REMEMBER THIS

Supported and undisputed: women were excluded from property, inheritance, education, the professions and the franchise **by statute**. And removing those barriers produced very large changes, which means the barriers were load-bearing.

Supported: Indian women report roughly **five hours a day** of unpaid domestic work against about **an hour and a half** for men — a full extra day every week, counted in no national account. Governments measure this themselves.

Supported strongly: the **child penalty**. Earnings paths are indistinguishable before a first birth; hers falls sharply after and never returns. In Denmark, around four fifths of the remaining gap traces to this one event. The design compares a woman with her own earlier self.

And it is neither discrimination nor preference — no employer decides to pay mothers less, and no woman chooses a permanent twenty per cent cut. It is **structural**: work organised around uninterrupted availability, care organised around one person absorbing the interruption.

Supported by randomised evidence at national scale: India reserved a third of village council leaderships for women, assigned randomly. Women leaders spent differently, matching what local women had said they wanted. And after two rounds, the gender gap in adolescent educational attainment was closed. Very little in this entire series is supported that well.

CHAPTER FIVE

What Is Contested

Three claims that are genuinely open. One of them has an industry built on top of it that is considerably more confident than the evidence underneath.

5.1 — Stereotype threat

The claim: that reminding people of a negative stereotype about their group, immediately before a test, depresses their performance on it. Applied to women and mathematics, the finding was that simply mentioning sex before an exam produced a measurably worse result.

It is an elegant idea. It became one of the most cited findings in social psychology, it was taught in teacher training, and it shaped a generation of interventions.

The problem is replication. Attempts to reproduce the effect, particularly in large samples of schoolchildren rather than selected university students, have often failed. Analyses pooling the published studies have found signs that results showing the effect were more likely to be published than results showing none — which inflates the apparent size of anything.

Verdict: contested, with recent weight against the strong version. Something may be there in specific circumstances. The claim that it explains a substantial part of measured performance gaps is not supported by the current evidence, and it was asserted with far more confidence than that.

5.2 — Implicit bias

This one matters more than the others, because a large industry rests on it.

WORD BOX

Implicit bias is the idea that people hold associations they are not aware of and would deny, which shape their behaviour towards others.

The main instrument for measuring it asks people to sort words and images into categories as fast as they can, and treats the difference in reaction time between pairings as evidence of an association.

Why it matters here: the existence of automatic associations is not seriously disputed. Three further claims are, and they are the ones the industry rests on: that the test measures an individual's bias reliably, that the measure predicts how a person will actually behave, and that training reduces it.

Those three have been examined and they do not fare equally.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES IMPLICIT BIAS PREDICT DISCRIMINATORY BEHAVIOUR?

An unusual dispute, in that several of the sharpest critics are people who think discrimination is a serious problem.

IT DOES

Automatic associations are real and measurable, they differ systematically between groups of respondents, and it would be strange if mental content that reliably shows up on a timed task had no effect on behaviour. Discrimination in the modern world is rarely announced, so a measure of what people will not say is exactly what is needed.

THE MEASURE DOES NOT DO WHAT IS CLAIMED

Analyses pooling hundreds of studies find that scores on the test correlate weakly with actual behaviour, weakly enough to be useless for predicting any individual. The same person retested gets noticeably different scores. And a large pooled analysis found that interventions which successfully shifted the measure produced **no corresponding change in behaviour —** which is the finding that matters, because changing behaviour was the entire point.

WHAT IS LEFT STANDING

Automatic associations exist. Whether this instrument measures an individual's are doubtful. Whether it predicts what they will do is weakly supported at best. Whether training changes conduct is not supported. Those are four separate claims and public discussion runs them together.

Where things stand: the third position. And it has a practical consequence at scale — organisations across the world run mandatory training built on the weakest of the four claims, and reviews of whether such training changes behaviour find effects that are small, short-lived, or absent.

What would settle it: studies measuring actual behaviour rather than the test, before and after, over time. Some exist and they are not encouraging.

Why people care so much: because it is a rare thing that is simultaneously a research question, a very large budget, and a public ritual. Part One, Chapter Six applies: when a countable question has an industry attached, the counting gets harder rather than easier.

5.3 — Hiring discrimination

The claim: that women face bias in hiring and evaluation, demonstrable by sending identical applications under different names.

WORD BOX

An audit or correspondence study sends identical applications, differing only in a name that signals sex or ethnicity, and records how each is treated.

It is the cleanest test of discrimination available, because the applications are genuinely identical — there is nothing else that could produce a difference in response.

Why it matters here: this is one of the few methods in the whole field with the power to settle a question, and when applied at different levels of seniority it has produced answers pointing in opposite directions.

This method is powerful and it has produced results in both directions, which is the honest finding.

One influential study sent identical applications for a junior laboratory position to science faculty and found the male-named applicant rated more competent and offered a higher salary. Another, examining hiring for permanent academic posts at national scale, found the opposite — a substantial preference for the female-named candidate across most fields.

These are not contradictory in the way they are usually presented. They examined different levels, in different decades, with different designs. Taken together they suggest something more interesting than either: **that the direction and size of bias varies by field, by seniority and by period**, and that confident general statements in either direction are not supported.

Verdict: contested. Discrimination in hiring is real, it has been demonstrated, and the claim that it uniformly disadvantages women in all fields at all levels today is not established. Anybody quoting one of those two studies without the other is selecting.

5.4 — How common is it?

One further contested area, and it is a measurement problem rather than a dispute about reality.

Estimates of how many women experience sexual assault vary between surveys by something close to an order of magnitude. This is not because one set of researchers is dishonest. It is because the surveys ask different questions, over different periods, with different definitions of what counts, and small changes in wording produce very large changes in the number.

The honest position is that the true figure is not known within a narrow band, that the low estimates are almost certainly too low because of under-reporting, and that the high estimates depend on definitions many respondents would not themselves apply to their experience.

Verdict: contested, and usually quoted without the range. A figure that varies tenfold by method is a figure that should always arrive with its method attached, and it almost never does — by either side, since opponents quote the low estimate with equal confidence.

REMEMBER THIS

Stereotype threat — that mentioning a stereotype before a test depresses performance — became one of the most cited findings in social psychology and has serious replication problems, particularly in large samples of children. Contested, with recent weight against the strong version.

Implicit bias involves four separate claims that get run together. That automatic associations exist — not disputed. That the standard test measures an individual's reliably — doubtful. That it predicts behaviour — weakly supported at best. That training changes conduct — **not supported**, and a large pooled analysis found that interventions which shifted the measure produced no change in behaviour.

Hiring discrimination has been demonstrated in both directions. One study found a male-named applicant preferred for a junior lab post; another, at national scale for permanent academic posts, found a substantial preference the other way. Different levels, decades and designs — which suggests direction and size vary by field and period rather than that one study is wrong.

And prevalence estimates for sexual assault vary by close to a factor of ten depending on wording and definition. That is a figure which should always arrive with its method attached, and it almost never does — from either side.

CHAPTER SIX

What Failed

Four claims that were made publicly, used to argue for policy, specific enough to be checked, and checked. They did not survive. And the people who overturned them were mostly not the movement's opponents.

6.1 — "The same work"

The claim, as it appeared on posters, in speeches and in legislative campaigns for decades: that women are paid a fraction of what men are paid **for the same work.**

The raw figure was real. Comparing all working women with all working men, a large gap exists in every country.

The framing was not. Once you compare people doing the same job, with the same hours, the same seniority and the same continuity of employment, the gap shrinks to a small fraction of the headline number. What produces the headline figure is that men and women are distributed differently across occupations, hours and career continuity — and, as Chapter Four established, overwhelmingly that the interruption of a first child is absorbed by one parent.

IN REAL TERMS

Take the headline gap and pull it apart, in the order the pieces come off.

A large slice is **hours —** men work more paid hours on average, and part-time work pays less per hour.

A large slice is **occupation —** men and women are distributed differently across fields, and the fields pay differently. Part Four found the largest measured psychological sex difference is precisely an occupational preference.

A large slice is **continuity —** time out of employment costs earnings permanently, and it is overwhelmingly women who take it.

What is left after all of that is **small**, and it is not zero.

Now notice what has happened to the claim. “Women are paid less for the same work” is false as stated. “Women earn substantially less over a lifetime, and the mechanism is that society allocates the cost of children to one parent” is true, larger, harder to fix, and was not what the posters said.

The campaign chose the version that was easier to explain and could be shown false. The version that was true was more damning.

That decomposition is not a rhetorical move and it is worth knowing how it is done, along with what it quietly hides.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Pulling a pay gap apart is done with a standard technique that has been applied to this question in dozens of countries for fifty years.

What it does: take the raw difference in average earnings, then ask how much of it is accounted for by measured differences — hours worked, occupation, industry, years of experience, breaks in employment. Whatever is left over after all of those is the part that measured factors cannot explain.

What it shows: the explained portion is large. The unexplained residue is much smaller than the headline figure, and it shrinks further as the measurement of experience and continuity improves.

What it cannot show: that the residue is discrimination, or that the explained part is innocent. If women are steered into lower-paying fields, that steering is a real phenomenon which this method files under "occupation" and thereby removes from view. The technique measures what is accounted for, not what is justified — and both camps read it as though it measured the second.

Verdict: failed as stated. The underlying inequality is real and Chapter Four scored it as supported. The mechanism was misdescribed for decades, and the misdescription handed opponents a permanent and legitimate objection.

6.2 — That the differences are constructed

The claim: that psychological differences between men and women are produced by socialisation, and will diminish as societies become more equal.

This was not a fringe position. It was the working assumption of a great deal of writing and teaching for several decades, and it generated a specific, checkable prediction.

Parts Four and Five checked it. Several differences are real and substantial — the Things–People interest difference is the largest measured psychological sex difference there is. And the prediction runs the wrong way: in richer and more gender-equal countries the differences are generally *larger*, not smaller.

Part Five spent sixty pages establishing how contested that finding is. What is not contested is the narrower point that kills this claim: **the differences did not disappear as barriers came down.** Whatever explains the pattern, the prediction failed.

Verdict: failed. The strong version — all differences constructed, all will vanish — is dead. Weaker versions survive: that many differences are smaller than assumed, that some are constructed, and that the causes are unresolved. Those are much more modest claims than the one that was made.

6.3 — Patriarchy as a general explanation

The claim: that the distribution of advantage and disadvantage in society is organised by male dominance, and that this explains the pattern of outcomes generally.

As an account of specific domains it does real work. Property law, franchise, personal law, the composition of governments and boards, the marital rape exemption — all of these fit, and Chapter Four scored several as supported.

As a general theory of who does well and who does badly, it has an obvious problem: **the bottom of society is overwhelmingly male.**

Prison populations. Homelessness. Deaths at work. Deaths by suicide. Deaths of despair. Failure to complete school. Disconnection from employment and from family. Part Four found that a moderate average difference in aggression becomes a nine-in-ten outcome at the extreme, and that the same arithmetic putting more men at the top puts more men at the bottom. Part Fifteen counts all of it.

A theory saying society is organised for the benefit of men has to explain why nearly everybody at the very bottom of it is one. The available answers — that these men are casualties of a system that still benefits men overall, or that the metric is wrong — are not absurd, and they are additions to the theory rather than predictions from it.

Verdict: failed as a general explanation; supported in specific domains. That distinction is doing a lot of work and it is the honest position. A theory that explains every outcome forbids none, and Part One noted that a claim which cannot be wrong is not a claim.

6.4 — That removing barriers produces proportional representation

The claim: that the absence of women from particular fields is caused by barriers, and that removing the barriers will produce something close to proportional presence.

Part Five is entirely about this. The finding that retires it is narrow and survives every criticism made of the wider literature: **there is no simple positive relationship between a country's gender equality and women's share of technical fields, and in the raw counts it runs the wrong way.**

Chapter Four of this part complicates it usefully, and I am not going to smooth that over. The Indian randomised evidence shows a representation policy that measurably changed both decisions and girls' aspirations. So "representation efforts never work" is also false.

Verdict: failed as stated, in a specific way. Barriers were real and removing them produced enormous change — Chapter Four scored that as supported. What failed is the further assumption that removal would continue producing change all the way to proportionality. That assumption underlies a great deal of policy and it is not supported.

6.5 — And one that was simply not true

A short entry, included because it illustrates something about how claims travel.

A widely repeated assertion held that reports of domestic violence spike dramatically on the day of a major American sporting event. It was announced at a press conference, reported everywhere, and repeated for years.

Journalists went to look for the underlying data. It was not there. The researchers whose work had been cited said their findings did not show it.

Verdict: failed, and it was never supported at any point.

Two things are worth taking from it. The claim was corrected — by reporters, within a couple of years, in public. And it is still repeated, decades later, which tells you that correction and circulation operate on different timescales. Part One, Chapter One measured that asymmetry in a different context and it applies identically here.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everybody assumes **that a movement's failed claims are exposed by its opponents.**

> Both camps need this. The critic tells a story in which brave outsiders punctured an ideology. The defender tells a story in which hostile actors attacked good work. Both are describing an assault from outside.
>
> Look at who actually did the work in this chapter.
>
> The child penalty finding, which overturned the "same work" framing, came from economists whose research programme is gender inequality. The replication failures in stereotype threat came from psychologists, several of whom had built careers on studying disadvantage. The most damaging analyses of implicit bias measures include work by researchers who think discrimination is a serious problem and wanted a better instrument. The false claim in §6.5 was corrected by journalists within two years.
>
> **This was self-correction, and it is what a functioning field looks like.** A movement that produced no falsified claims would not be one that was always right; it would be one that had never said anything checkable.
>
> The general form: **crediting a field's self-correction to its critics.** It flatters the critics, insults the correctors, and makes the whole process look like a scandal instead of the thing that is supposed to happen.

Which is worth holding through Chapter Nine, where the failures in this chapter get weighed against the record in Chapter Four.

REMEMBER THIS

“The same work” failed as stated. Pull the headline gap apart and hours, occupation and continuity take most of it, with the child penalty underneath. The true version — that a lifetime gap exists and society allocates the cost of children to one parent — is larger, harder to fix, and more damning. **The campaign chose the version that was easier to explain and could be shown false.**

That all differences are constructed and would vanish, failed. They did not disappear as barriers came down, and the largest measured psychological sex difference is an occupational preference. Weaker versions survive; the strong one is dead.

Patriarchy as a general explanation failed; it holds in specific domains. A theory saying society is organised for men’s benefit has to explain why nearly everybody at the very bottom — prison, homelessness, workplace death, suicide — is one.

That removing barriers produces proportional representation failed, in a specific way: barriers were real and removing them produced enormous change, and the assumption that removal continues all the way to proportionality is not supported.

And nearly all of this was done by people inside the tradition — economists studying gender inequality, psychologists studying disadvantage, researchers who wanted a better instrument. That is self-correction, and it is what a functioning field looks like. A movement producing no falsified claims would not be one that was always right. It would be one that had never said anything checkable.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Predictions

A claim about the world is one thing. A forecast is better, because it can be checked against what arrived. Here are five that were made in terms specific enough to be wrong — and one result nobody forecast at all.

7.1 — Five forecasts

Part One set the standard: a prediction that cannot say what would count as it being wrong is not a prediction, it is a mood. By that test, the movement made several genuine predictions, which is more than most political movements manage.

One: legal equality would produce equal participation. Remove the bars and women will enter in proportion.

Two: women entering paid work would produce shared domestic work. If she earns, the household tasks redistribute.

Three: the earnings gap would close.

Four: educational parity would produce earnings parity. The gap was attributed substantially to women's lower qualifications, so equalising qualifications should equalise pay.

Five: women in positions of power would change what institutions do.

7.2 — What arrived

On the first: partly, then a stall. Entry into education, medicine, law and public administration was enormous and rapid. Entry into technical and manual fields was much smaller and has been flat or reversing for decades. Part Five is about why, and it does not resolve it. **Half right.**

On the second: partly. Men's share of domestic and care work rose substantially through the later twentieth century. It did not reach parity, and the convergence slowed considerably. The phrase for what happened — a woman finishing paid work and beginning a second unpaid one — entered the language because it described something real. **Half right, and the half that failed is the one Chapter Four scored as the mechanism behind the earnings gap.**

On the third: partly, then a stall. The gap narrowed sharply for about two decades and then largely stopped narrowing in many countries. **Half right.**

On the fourth: wrong. Women overtook men in educational attainment across most of the developed world — Part Four found the reversal is now large and rarely discussed. The earnings gap did not close correspondingly. This is the cleanest failed prediction in the list, and it failed because the mechanism had been misidentified: the gap was never primarily about qualifications, it was about the allocation of children. **Wrong.**

On the fifth: right, with the strongest evidence in this part behind it. Chapter Four's randomised Indian evidence establishes that women in council leadership changed spending, and that visible female authority closed the gap in girls' educational attainment. **Right.**

7.3 — And one nobody forecast

IN REAL TERMS

Across roughly thirty-five years — a period covering the greatest expansion of women's legal rights, education, earnings and employment in history — researchers tracked how women in the United States rated their own happiness.

It **fell**. Absolutely, and relative to men, whose ratings held steadier.

The same pattern was found in most of the developed countries where comparable data existed.

Nobody predicted this. Not the movement, which expected the opposite, and not its opponents, who mostly expected social collapse rather than a quiet decline in self-reported wellbeing among the beneficiaries.

And nobody has explained it. Proposed accounts include rising expectations against which reality is measured, the second shift in \u00a77.2, comparison across gender lines rather than within it — which Part Five identified as a real mechanism — and the possibility that self-reported happiness scales do not mean the same thing across decades. None is established.

Part Eight examines it properly. It is included here because a movement's forecasting record should include the thing it did not see coming, and this is the largest.

I want to be careful about what this finding does and does not license, because it is quoted constantly by people who have not read past the headline.

It does **not** establish that the changes made women worse off. Reported happiness is one measure among many, and the same period saw enormous gains in life expectancy, education, earnings, physical safety within marriage and control over reproduction — every one of which most people would take over a point on a happiness scale.

What it establishes is narrower and still important: **that a movement's beneficiaries reporting lower wellbeing than before is a real result which nobody predicted and nobody can account for.** An honest movement has to hold that rather than explain it away, and an honest opponent has to notice it does not say what they want it to.

REMEMBER THIS

Five predictions specific enough to be wrong. **Legal equality producing equal participation** — half right, enormous in the professions, flat or reversing in technical fields. **Paid work producing shared domestic work** — half right, men's share rose substantially and convergence stalled short of parity. **The earnings gap closing** — half right, narrowed sharply for two decades then stopped.

Educational parity producing earnings parity — wrong. Women overtook men in education and the gap did not close, because the mechanism had been misidentified: it was never about qualifications, it was about who absorbs children.

Women in power changing institutions — right, with the randomised Indian evidence from Chapter Four behind it.

And one nobody forecast. Across thirty-five years of the greatest expansion of women's rights in history, women's self-reported happiness fell — absolutely and relative to men — in most developed countries measured. Neither camp predicted it and nobody has explained it.

It does not establish that the changes made women worse off; the same period brought enormous gains in safety, health, earnings and control over reproduction. It establishes that a real result exists which nobody saw coming and nobody can account for — and that both camps have to hold it rather than use it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Fork

Part Four established that given a real difference in what people want, equal opportunity and equal outcomes are in conflict. A movement built on one of those has spent forty years being measured by the other, and largely without noticing.

8.1 — Two goals that came apart

The argument that won the legal battles was an argument about **freedom**.

A woman should be able to own what she earns, to enter a profession, to vote, to leave a marriage, to choose a husband, to control whether she becomes a mother. Every one of those is a claim about a person directing her own life, and every one is a moral claim of the kind Chapter Three said no measurement can touch. They were argued that way and they won that way.

The way institutions now measure whether that argument succeeded is **outcomes**. Percentage of board seats. Share of graduates in each field. Representation in a legislature. Pipeline metrics. Proportions.

Those are different things and Part Four, Chapter Nine established that they are not merely different — given a real difference in preferences, they are *in conflict*. Perfect freedom does not produce proportional outcomes. Producing proportional outcomes requires acting against what some people choose.

8.2 — Why the drift happened

It is worth understanding how a movement founded on one goal came to be measured by another, because nobody decided it.

Freedom is not countable. There is no statistic for how free a woman is to direct her life, and an institution cannot put it in an annual report or a policy target.

Outcomes are countable. A percentage of board seats is a number that can be reported, compared, targeted and improved.

So when the argument moved from courtrooms and parliaments into organisations, it acquired the metric that organisations can use. Not because anybody preferred it. Because it was the one that fits on a form.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD THE GOAL BE EQUAL FREEDOM OR EQUAL OUTCOMES?

The live dispute inside the movement, usually conducted without either side stating which they are defending.

FREEDOM

The moral case was always about a person's right to direct her own life, and that case is complete when the barriers are gone. Pursuing proportional outcomes past that point means overriding what women actually choose, which contradicts the founding argument. A movement that started by insisting women can decide for themselves cannot end by deciding for them.

OUTCOMES

Freedom on paper is not freedom. Preferences form inside a society that spent centuries teaching girls what to want, so a choice made under those conditions is not a clean signal. And outcomes are the only way to detect barriers that nobody admits to — if the field is genuinely open, the numbers should move, and when they do not, something is still operating.

THEY ARE DIFFERENT PROJECTS

These are not two routes to one destination. They are two destinations, and past a certain point pursuing one means giving up the other. Both are defensible. Neither is *the* feminist position, because Chapter One showed there is no such thing.

Where things stand: the third, and the practical consequence is that a great many arguments are unresolvable because the parties are pursuing different objectives while using one word. Part Five, Chapter Eight added the hardest constraint: there is no condition called “free of culture” in which a true preference could be read off, so the outcomes side cannot appeal to what women would want absent influence, because that state has never existed for anybody.

What would settle it: nothing empirical. This is a choice between values and it has to be made rather than discovered.

Why people care so much: because the outcomes goal is the one that generates budgets, targets and jobs, and the freedom goal is the one that generates moral authority. Most institutions want both and say the second while measuring the first.

But there is a prior question that neither side of that argument raises, and answering it changes what the fork is a fork in.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The entire dispute above assumes **that equality is the goal** — that the question is how much of it and of what kind.

Chapter One showed that is one faction’s framing. The difference strand never wanted equality in the sense of sameness; it wanted the *revaluation* of work and qualities associated with women, which is a different objective and is not achieved by putting women into men’s roles. The socialist strand did not want women’s equal access to a labour market it regarded as the problem.

So the fork in this chapter — freedom or outcomes — is a fork inside **liberal** feminism, presented as the central question of feminism as a whole. Both camps in the public argument accept that framing, which means both are arguing on the territory of one strand while believing they are arguing about the movement.

Notice what disappears when they do. The claim that raising children and running a household is valuable work that a society has chosen not to pay for is not a claim about equality at all. It is not answered by getting more women into engineering, and it is not answered by leaving them alone either. It simply drops out of a debate organised around proportions.

The general form: **adopting one faction’s framing as the description of the whole dispute.** The faction that supplies the vocabulary wins before anybody speaks.

8.3 — What the drift cost

Three things, and they are the reason this chapter matters more than it looks.

It made the movement vulnerable to Part Five. A programme measured by proportions is embarrassed by a finding that proportions do not respond to freedom. A programme measured by freedom would not be.

It put the movement into conflict with some women's stated preferences, and gave it only one available reply — that the preferences were installed. That reply is not absurd and Part Five, Chapter Eight showed why it cannot be established either.

And it obscured the finding in Chapter Four. The child penalty is the largest thing in this part. It is not a representation problem and no proportion measures it. A movement organised around counting seats will systematically under-address a mechanism that operates through the structure of work and care — which is where nearly all of the remaining inequality actually is.

REMEMBER THIS

The argument that won the legal battles was about **freedom** — to own, to earn, to vote, to leave, to choose. Every one a moral claim of the kind no measurement touches.

The way institutions measure success is **outcomes** — board seats, graduate shares, pipeline metrics. Part Four established these are not merely different but **in conflict**: perfect freedom does not produce proportional outcomes, and producing them requires acting against what some people choose.

Nobody decided the drift. **Freedom is not countable and outcomes are**, so when the argument moved into organisations it acquired the metric that fits on a form.

And the fork is inside **liberal** feminism, presented as the central question of the whole. The difference strand wanted revaluation of women's work, not sameness. The socialist strand did not want equal access to a labour market it thought was the problem. Both drop out of a debate organised around proportions.

The drift cost three things. It made the movement vulnerable to Part Five, which embarrasses a proportions programme and would not touch a freedom one. It put the movement against some women's stated preferences with only one available reply. And it obscured the child penalty — the largest thing in this part, which no proportion measures and which is where nearly all the remaining inequality actually is.

CHAPTER NINE

Scoring It

Eight chapters of claims, sorted. Now what the sorting actually establishes — which is less than either camp will want, and includes an admission about how these two parts were built.

9.1 — The ledger

Set the three categories side by side.

Supported: that women were excluded by statute from property, inheritance, education, the professions and the franchise. That removing those barriers produced enormous change. That women perform several times more unpaid work, measured by governments. That the child penalty is the dominant mechanism of the modern earnings gap, established by comparing women with their own earlier earnings. That violence within households was massively undercounted. And that female political representation changes both spending and girls' aspirations — established by a randomised experiment across Indian villages.

Contested: stereotype threat, with recent weight against the strong version. Implicit bias measures, where the existence of associations is not in doubt and the predictive claim is weak. Hiring discrimination, which has been demonstrated in both directions at different levels and periods. Prevalence figures for sexual assault, which vary by close to a factor of ten with method.

Failed: the pay gap as described on the posters. That psychological differences are constructed and would vanish. Patriarchy as a general explanation of who ends up where. That removing barriers produces proportional representation. And at least one widely circulated statistic that was never supported at all.

9.2 — What the failures establish

Specific things were wrong. That is the whole of it, and it needs saying because two larger conclusions get drawn and neither follows.

The failures do not touch the moral claims. Chapter Three separated them for this reason. That a woman is entitled to own what she earns, to leave a marriage, to vote and to choose a husband is not a finding and cannot be falsified by one. Every legal change the movement won rested on that kind of argument. You could delete Chapters Four to Seven entirely and the case for a married woman's right to her own property would be exactly where it was.

And the failures were mostly produced from inside. Chapter Six's hidden assumption box set this out and it bears repeating in the scoring: the child penalty finding came from economists studying gender inequality, the replication failures came from psychologists studying disadvantage, and the sharpest critiques of implicit bias measures include work by people who wanted a better instrument for detecting discrimination.

A movement whose claims get corrected by researchers working inside its own tradition is behaving like a field. The alternative — no falsified claims at all — would not indicate a movement that was always right.

9.3 — The result that mirrors Part Six

Now the thing that took two parts to see, and it is the most interesting finding in either.

Part Six built the strongest case for the old rules and found that every argument in it was about household stability, partnership, male behaviour or women's economic security — **and none of them reached the rules.** The best traditionalist arguments pointed away from the thing they were supposed to defend.

This part has produced the same shape.

The strongest finding here is the child penalty. It accounts for most of the remaining earnings gap, it is established by the best design available, and it is a mechanism operating through the structure of work and care.

And no representation metric measures it. Not board seats. Not graduate shares. Not pipeline percentages. A woman's earnings collapsing permanently after a first birth does not appear in any of the numbers the movement's institutions report against, because it is not a proportion.

So the same thing has happened twice. In Part Six, the best arguments for the traditional position argued against the rules it defends. In Part Seven, the best evidence for the feminist position points away from the metric its institutions use.

Each side's strongest evidence is inconvenient to its own programme. That is a strange result and I did not expect it, and it is the most useful thing these two parts produced.

9.4 — And how I built these two parts

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> A reader who has just finished both parts has encountered **one written by an advocate and one written by an examiner**, and this part is the examiner.
>
> Part Six argued a position at full strength for seven chapters with no undercutting. This part sorted claims into piles. Those are not the same treatment, and I made the choice deliberately.
>
> **My reason:** the traditional case had no lawyer available. Nobody had assembled it from the best evidence, so somebody had to. Feminism has thousands of advocates, in print, better placed than me. What it did not have was somebody going through the claims one at a time with a scorecard.
>
> **Why that reason is not sufficient.** It is an argument about what was missing from the literature. It is not an argument about what a reader experiences. Somebody reading these in sequence meets a warm part and a cold one, and will attribute the difference to the subject matter rather than to my construction — because that is what tone does, and it does it below the level at which arguments operate.
>
> The general form: **a defensible reason for a choice that still produces an effect the reason does not justify.** Every writer has this available. The honest move is not to claim the reason cancels the effect. It is to say what I did and let you discount it.

9.5 — What survives

Set the failures against the record and the honest summary is short.

A movement that arose independently in several places at once, including in India six months before it arose in America. That won a set of legal changes resting on moral arguments no evidence can touch. That made a series of empirical claims in support, several of which were wrong, most of which were corrected by its own researchers. That has one finding — the allocation of children — larger and better established than anything its opponents have produced, and which its own institutions do not measure. And that has a genuine unresolved fork at its centre between two goals it has never chosen between in public.

That is a mixed record. It is also a considerably better record than most political movements can show, because most political movements do not make claims specific enough to be scored at all.

REMEMBER THIS

Supported: exclusion by statute; the enormous effect of removing barriers; several times more unpaid work, measured by governments; the child penalty; massively undercounted household violence; and female political representation changing spending and girls' attainment, by randomised evidence in India.

Contested: stereotype threat; implicit bias measures; hiring discrimination, demonstrated in both directions; and prevalence figures varying tenfold with method.

Failed: the pay gap as described; that differences are constructed and would vanish; patriarchy as a general explanation; that removing barriers produces proportionality.

The failures touch **none of the moral claims** — the case for a married woman's right to her own property is exactly where it was — and most of them were produced by researchers inside the tradition. That is a field correcting itself.

And the same shape appeared twice. In Part Six, the best arguments for the old rules argued against the rules. Here, the best evidence for the feminist position — the child penalty — points away from the metric its institutions use, because a woman's earnings collapsing after a first birth is not a proportion and no representation target measures it.

Each side's strongest evidence is inconvenient to its own programme. I did not expect that, and it is the most useful thing these two parts produced.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about the claims scored here, and what is solid enough that anybody arguing about feminism has to concede it.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

The unknowns in this part cluster around causes rather than measurements, which is the usual pattern and is worse here than most.

Why the child penalty falls on mothers. The size is measured precisely. The cause is not. Biology, employer expectations, partner behaviour, policy and preference all remain live, and countries with very different parental leave arrangements still show a penalty — which weakens the pure-policy explanation without establishing anything else.

Why women's reported happiness declined. The finding is real and replicated across countries. Every proposed explanation is a hypothesis. Part Eight examines them and does not resolve it.

Whether the contested claims in Chapter Five are true. Contested means contested. Stereotype threat may exist in specific conditions. Implicit associations may affect behaviour in ways the current instruments cannot detect. Saying a claim is unsupported is not saying it is false.

What the true prevalence of sexual violence is. Not known within a narrow band, for reasons of definition and method rather than dishonesty. Both camps quote the estimate that suits them.

Whether the Indian panchayat findings generalise. They are strong and they are about village councils in one country over a specific period. Whether the mechanism transfers to national politics, to corporate boards, or to other countries is untested.

And what women want, which this series has now failed to establish four separate times. Part Five, Chapter Eight explained why: there is no condition free of social influence in which a preference could be read cleanly. This is not a gap that better research fills.

10.2 — Solid

That Indian feminism has its own history, beginning no later than 1848. A school in Pune six months before Seneca Falls, a Marathi text in 1882, a feminist utopia in 1905. Dates, publications and institutions, all documented.

That the movements arose independently rather than spreading from one source. The problems addressed were different — caste, child marriage, widowhood, purdah — and no imported framework generates them.

That women were excluded by statute. Not by custom alone. The statutes are published and Part Three found one still in force.

That women perform several times more unpaid work. Measured by national governments in their own surveys.

That the child penalty is real and dominant. Established with the strongest design available, replicated across countries.

That the "same work" framing was false as stated. This is solid and it is a failure. Both halves belong on this list.

That female political representation changed outcomes in India, by randomised assignment. Very little in this series is supported this well.

That women's reported happiness declined across the period of greatest gains. The measurement is solid. The interpretation is not, and the finding does not say what its usual quoters want.

And that equal freedom and equal outcomes are different goals that conflict. Established in Part Four, not disputed by anybody who has looked at it, and almost never stated by institutions pursuing one while claiming the other.

10.3 — What a movement is for

One closing observation, following the pattern of the previous parts.

This part scored a political movement as though it were a research programme. Chapter One's hidden assumption box flagged that as a category error and I did it anyway, for a reason worth stating at the end rather than the beginning.

Movements are not in the business of being right. They are in the business of changing things, and the arguments that change things are selected for their power to move people rather than for their accuracy. That is not a criticism of feminism. It is a description of politics, and it applies identically to the nationalism in Part Three, to the reform campaigns that abolished sati, and to whatever movement the reader happens to belong to.

Which produces the honest closing position. **The score in this part tells you about the claims. It does not tell you whether to support the movement, because movements are not judged on their claims and never have been.**

What the score is good for is narrower and still worth the eight chapters: knowing which sentence you are allowed to say in an argument. A person who cannot tell you which claims failed does not have a view about feminism. They have a side.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: why the child penalty falls on mothers — the size is measured precisely and the cause is not. Why women's reported happiness declined. Whether the contested claims are true, since contested is not false. The true prevalence of sexual violence. Whether the Indian panchayat findings generalise. And what women want, which this series has now failed to establish four separate times for a reason no research fixes.

Solid: Indian feminism's own history from 1848 and its independent arising. Exclusion by statute. Several times more unpaid work. The child penalty. That the "same work" framing was false as stated. That female representation changed outcomes in India by randomised assignment. That women's reported happiness declined across the period of greatest gains. And that equal freedom and equal outcomes conflict.

And a closing admission. This part scored a political movement as though it were a research programme, which is a category error I flagged in Chapter One and committed anyway. Movements are not in the business of being right; they are in the business of changing things, and the arguments that change things are selected for their power to move people. That applies to feminism, to the nationalism in Part Three, and to whatever movement you belong to.

So the score tells you about the claims and not about whether to support the movement. What it is good for is knowing which sentence you are entitled to say — and a person who cannot tell you which claims failed does not have a view. They have a side.

The Claims, Scored

Chapter Nine as a single sheet. Every claim examined in this part, with its verdict and the reason. This is the page to carry into an argument.

CLAIM	VERDICT	WHY
Women were excluded by statute from property, education, professions, franchise	Supported	The statutes are published. Not disputed by anybody serious.
Removing the barriers produced enormous change	Supported	From a small minority to a majority of graduates within a century.
Women perform far more unpaid work	Supported	National time use surveys. In India, roughly five hours a day against an hour and a half.
The earnings gap is driven by the arrival of children	Supported	Whole-population records, comparing each woman with her own earlier path. Around four fifths of the remaining gap in the cleanest study.
Household and sexual violence were massively undercounted	Supported	Survey prevalence against recorded crime — two independent measures differing by a large factor.
Female political representation changes outcomes	Supported	Randomised assignment of village council leadership in India. Spending changed; the gap in girls' educational attainment closed.
Stereotype threat explains performance gaps	Contested	Replication failures, particularly in large child samples, and signs of publication bias.
Implicit bias tests predict discriminatory behaviour	Contested	Weak correlation with behaviour; shifting the measure does not shift conduct. The existence of associations is not in doubt.
Women face hiring discrimination	Contested	Demonstrated in both directions at different levels and periods. General claims either way are unsupported.

CLAIM	VERDICT	WHY
Prevalence of sexual assault	Contested	Estimates vary by close to a factor of ten with definition and method.
Women are paid less for the same work	Failed as stated	Hours, occupation and continuity take most of the headline gap. The true mechanism is larger and more damning.
Psychological differences are constructed and will vanish	Failed	They did not vanish as barriers fell, and the largest measured psychological sex difference is an occupational preference.
Patriarchy explains the distribution of outcomes generally	Failed as general theory	The bottom of society — prison, homelessness, workplace death, suicide — is overwhelmingly male. Holds in specific domains.
Removing barriers produces proportional representation	Failed	No simple positive relationship between national gender equality and women's share of technical fields; in raw counts it runs the wrong way.
Educational parity would produce earnings parity	Failed prediction	Women overtook men in education and the gap did not close, because the mechanism was misidentified.

Read the verdict column and note the proportions. Six supported, four contested, five failed. That is a mixed record and a better one than most political movements can produce, because most do not make claims specific enough to score.

And note the two entries doing the most work. **The child penalty** is the strongest supported claim and no representation metric measures it. **"The same work"** is the clearest failure and the true version underneath it is more damning than the slogan was.

An Indian Timeline

Because the claim that this is a foreign import is answered better by dates than by argument.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
Jan 1848	Savitribai and Jyotirao Phule open a school for girls in Pune. She teaches in it, and is abused in the street on the way.
Jul 1848	The Seneca Falls Convention, New York. Six months later.
1882	Tarabai Shinde publishes *Stri Purush Tulana* in Marathi, arguing that men are morally worse than women. Frequently called the first modern Indian feminist text.
1887	Pandita Ramabai, a Sanskrit scholar honoured by the pandits of Calcutta, publishes *The High-Caste Hindu Woman*.
1905	Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain publishes *Sultana's Dream* — a utopia in which women govern and men are kept in seclusion. Written in English, by a Bengali Muslim woman, as a satire on purdah.
1917–1927	Indian women's organisations form: a women's association, a national council, an all-India conference. All predating independence, all arguing about Indian law.
1951	Ambedkar resigns as Law Minister, with the stalling of the Hindu Code Bill among his reasons. It passes in pieces over the following five years.
1974	A government committee reports on the status of women, expecting to document progress. It finds that on the sex ratio, women's paid work and political participation, things have got **worse** since independence. The report is credited with restarting the movement.
1979–1983	A Supreme Court acquittal in a custodial rape case produces an open letter from four law professors, nationwide protest, and a change to the criminal law.
1993	A constitutional amendment reserves a third of village council leaderships for women, with villages effectively randomly assigned — accidentally creating one of the largest randomised experiments in political science.
2000s	Analysis of that experiment finds women leaders spend differently, and that after two rounds the gender gap in adolescent educational attainment closes.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
2012–13	After a case in Delhi produces sustained national protest, a committee headed by a former Chief Justice reports in under a month. Legislation the following year broadens the definition of rape and creates offences for stalking, voyeurism and acid attacks. The committee's recommendation to remove the marital rape exception is not adopted.
2023	India replaces the colonial penal code. The marital rape exception is carried across, as Part Three recorded.
↓	**Part Eight starts here — and counts what sixty years of the equality project actually produced, measured rather than asserted.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Child penalty	The permanent fall in a woman's earnings following the birth of a first child, measured against her own previous earnings path. The dominant mechanism of the modern earnings gap, and something no representation metric captures.
Difference feminism	The strand holding that qualities and work associated with women are undervalued, and that the remedy is to revalue them rather than to make women more like men.
Empirical claim	A statement about how the world is, which can be checked. Distinguished from a moral claim, which says what is owed, and a strategic claim, which says what should be done.
Implicit bias	Associations a person is unaware of and would deny. Their existence is not disputed; whether the standard test measures an individual's, predicts behaviour, or responds to training are three further claims, and they fare differently.
Intersectional critique	That "women" is not one category, because sex interacts with caste, class, religion and region. In India this appears as the Dalit feminist argument that the mainstream movement was substantially upper-caste.
Liberal feminism	The strand holding that the problem is exclusion and the remedy is equal access. Produced nearly all of the legal change of the last two centuries.
Radical feminism	The strand holding that male dominance is the organising structure of society rather than a removable defect, reaching into family and sexuality. Source of the phrase about the personal being political.
Second shift	The unpaid domestic work a person begins after finishing paid work. Named because men's share of domestic labour rose substantially and stopped short of parity.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Socialist feminism	The strand holding that women's uncounted domestic labour underwrites the economy, and that a woman succeeding within that economy has not solved the problem.
Stereotype threat	The proposed effect by which reminding people of a negative stereotype before a test depresses their performance. Heavily cited, and with serious replication problems.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

This part is written as an auditor rather than an advocate, which is the opposite of the part before it, and Chapter Nine says plainly why and what it costs. A reader meeting Parts Six and Seven in sequence encounters one warm treatment and one cold one, and I would rather name that than let it operate quietly.

The specific temptation available to me in this part was to run the failures long and the supported claims short, because a demolition reads better than a ledger. Chapter Four is the longest of the three scoring chapters for exactly that reason, and if it does not feel that way while reading, that is worth noticing about how these things land rather than about the chapter.

One further limitation. I am a man scoring a movement about women's lives, using research produced mostly elsewhere, in a series whose earlier parts established four separate times that nobody has established what women actually want. Chapter Ten states that plainly rather than treating it as a footnote.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the administrative record, the randomised assignment, the time use survey — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of published research in economics, psychology, sociology and Indian history, together with a documented record of what a movement claimed in public.

The evidence divides sharply by quality and the divisions matter. The Indian historical material is documentary — publications with dates, institutions with founding records, government reports that can be read. The child penalty and the panchayat findings rest on the strongest designs available in social science: whole-population administrative records in one case, randomised assignment in the other. The contested claims in Chapter Five rest on literatures with known replication problems, which is why they are in that chapter rather than either of the others. And the claims scored as failed were, in every case, checked by researchers rather than argued down by opponents.

Where a figure varies between sources I have given a direction rather than a false precision — the Indian time use figures and the Danish child penalty share are both reported approximately for that reason. Where a claim is contested inside the movement rather than universally held, Chapter One's framework applies and I have tried to say so. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who work in these fields or who hold a position I have described badly, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Eight — The Ledger of the Equality Project. This part scored the claims. The next one counts the results.

- Sixty years, measured rather than asserted. What actually changed in education, earnings, employment, safety, health and political representation — with the numbers rather than the adjectives?
- The educational reversal is total and barely discussed. Women now out-graduate men at every level across most of the developed world, and the gap is still widening. What happened to boys, and when did anybody notice?
- What is the earnings gap actually made of, once the child penalty from this part is taken out? And what is left after that?
- Women's reported happiness declined across exactly the decades of greatest gain. This part flagged it; the next one examines every explanation on offer and reports which survive.
- What did the project cost, and who paid? Not rhetorically — in hours, in earnings, in the things that were given up to obtain the things that were won.
- And the question that decides how the rest of this series reads: after sixty years, is the remaining gap evidence of unfinished business, or evidence that the project reached the edge of what removing barriers can do?

END OF PART SEVEN OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Eight — The Ledger of the Equality Project

Sixty years, counted rather than asserted. The reversal in education that nobody planned and nobody discusses. What the earnings gap is actually made of.

The largest gain of all, which is medical and barely mentioned. And the one measure that went the wrong way.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Where We Left Off

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Parts Six and Seven built each side's best case and scored it. Part Six found that the strongest traditionalist arguments were about household stability, partnership, male behaviour and women's economic security — and that not one of them reached the rules they were supposed to defend. Part Seven found six feminist claims supported, four contested and five failed, and that the strongest supported claim of all points away from the metric the movement's institutions use.

Both parts scored *claims*. This one counts *results*.

Sixty years have passed since the legal architecture began coming down in most of the world. Long enough for the effects to be visible, and short enough that most of the people who made the arguments are still alive to see them. What actually happened?

The answer has four parts and they do not point the same way.

Some changes are enormous and went further than anybody predicted. The reversal in education is the clearest: women now out-graduate men at every level across most of the developed world, and the gap is still widening. Nobody forecast that. Nobody campaigned for it. It happened anyway.

Some changes stalled halfway. Earnings narrowed sharply for two decades and then largely stopped narrowing. Employment rose and then plateaued. Part Seven identified the mechanism and this part measures what is left of it.

The largest gain of all is medical, and it is almost never counted on this ledger at all. Chapter Five is about it and it dwarfs everything in the political column.

And one measure went the wrong way. Across the decades of greatest gain, women's own reports of their happiness fell. That finding is real, it has been checked, nobody predicted it, and Chapter Six goes through every explanation on offer and reports that none is established.

How to Read the Boxes

THE NOTATION, IN CASE THIS IS WHERE YOU STARTED

Six kinds of box run through the series. One live example of each.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **A ledger** is a record with two columns: what came in and what went out. The word is chosen deliberately for this part.
>
> Almost all writing about this subject reports one column. Advocates list gains; critics list costs. Both are accurate and neither is a ledger, because a ledger requires that the same person count both sides using the same units.
>
> Why it matters here: this part attempts both columns. Chapter Seven is the second one, and a reader who finds it uncomfortable after six chapters of the first should notice that the discomfort is what a ledger is for.

A Word Box appears the first time a hard word does — never later, never only in a glossary.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> One number, before any argument, because it is the largest thing on the ledger and it is almost never on it.
>
> In 1990, for every hundred thousand babies born alive in India, somewhere in the region of **five hundred and fifty women died** in the process of giving birth.
>
> By the end of the 2010s that figure was under **a hundred**.
>
> Put it in a district. Take a town where two thousand children are born each year. Three decades ago, that town buried around eleven women a year for having them. Now it buries about two.
>
> Nine women a year, in one town, every year, who used to die and now do not.
>
> **No change in employment, earnings, representation or law comes close to that number, and it appears on almost no list of what changed for women.** Chapter Five asks why not.

A figure that large should be checked before it is used, and the checking is the job of the next box.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A ledger is only as good as its measurements, and the ones in this part vary enormously in quality. It is worth knowing the ranking before the numbers start.

Strongest: administrative counts. Degrees awarded, births registered, deaths recorded, seats in a legislature. These are counted because an institution needed to count them, and nobody is reporting a feeling.

Strong: large national surveys with stable instruments over time — labour force surveys, time use surveys, health surveys.

Weaker: anything measured by asking people to rate something on a scale. Chapter Six rests entirely on this and its limitations are the reason that chapter cannot be resolved.

And a limitation running through all of it: the further back you go and the poorer the country, the worse the data. Several figures for India in the 1950s and 1960s are estimates rather than counts, and the improvement in the numbers partly reflects improvement in the counting.

With the measurements ranked, the argument that governs how to read every one of them can be stated.

THE ARGUMENT — DID THE MOVEMENT CAUSE THE CHANGES?

The question that governs every number in this part.

LARGELY YES

The legal barriers were removed by campaigns that took decades and met fierce resistance. Property, franchise, divorce, employment, credit, education — none of these fell on their own, and in each case there is a documented record of who pushed and who opposed. Attributing the result to impersonal forces erases the people who did the work.

LARGELY THE CENTURY

The washing machine, the contraceptive pill, antibiotics, the shift from manual to service employment, and the collapse in child mortality would each have transformed women's lives with no politics at all. Countries with no feminist movement worth the name show many of the same trends. The movement may have arrived alongside the change rather than causing it.

Where things stand: both are partly right and the split is not established for any single change. Chapter One sets out why this is not a technicality — it is the difference between a ledger of what a movement achieved and a ledger of what a century did.

And underneath that argument sits something both sides need and neither examines.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides above assume **that there is a baseline** — a year to count from, against which everything is measured.

Almost everybody uses the 1960s. It is a strange choice, and it is strange in a way that flatters one side.

Because the mid-twentieth century was not a stable ancient condition. Part Three found that Indian women's position on several measures had *deteriorated* across the colonial period, and Part Seven found a government committee reporting in 1974 that things had got worse since independence. Measuring from a trough produces a rising line.

Choose 1900 and the slope changes. Choose 1800 and it changes again. Choose the eleventh century, when Part Three found publicly carved erotic temples and Part Two found property passing through women in Kerala, and the shape of the graph is not obvious at all.

The general form: **choosing a baseline that produces the desired slope.** Every ledger in every field has this problem and almost none of them state which year they started from and why.

This is the signature box. There are five in this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter closes with one of these, restating it in the plainest words available, key terms in **bold**.

Read only these and you should still finish holding the whole argument.

A Note on This Part

READ THIS BEFORE CHAPTER ONE

This part is mostly numbers and it is the least argumentative in the series. That is deliberate. Six parts of argument have established what each side claims; this one asks what happened. Where a figure is disputed I have given a range, and where a trend is contested I have said so rather than picking the version that fits.

Chapter Seven is the costs column and it exists because a ledger requires one. A reader who has found the previous chapters congenial may find it unwelcome. It contains no claim that the project was not worth it — that is a value judgement and Chapter Nine declines to make it for you.

And a warning about Chapter Six. The declining happiness finding is quoted constantly by people who have not read what it does and does not establish. It does not establish that women were made worse off. It establishes something narrower and stranger, and both camps consistently overstate it in opposite directions.

What Is in This Part

CHAPTER ONE

How To Read A Ledger

Three questions have to be answered before a single number means anything. Compared to what. Caused by what. And for whom. Almost every published account of what changed for women skips at least two of them.

1.1 — Compared to what

The front matter set this out and it needs saying once more in the chapter, because it governs everything that follows.

A number is a change only against a baseline, and the baseline is chosen. Nearly everybody writing about this counts from somewhere in the middle of the twentieth century, without saying why, and the choice is not innocent.

The mid-twentieth century was in several respects a low point rather than a stable condition. Part Three found that Indian women's position on several measures had deteriorated across the colonial period. Part Seven found a committee of the Indian government reporting in 1974 that things had got *worse* since independence on the sex ratio, on women's paid work and on political participation.

Measuring from a trough produces a rising line. That is arithmetic rather than achievement, and a ledger that does not state its starting year is not reporting a result. It is reporting a choice.

What this part does about it: where the starting point matters to the conclusion, I give it, and where a longer baseline changes the picture I say so. Chapter Five is the clearest case — the medical gains are enormous from any baseline you choose, which is one reason they are the most solid entry on the whole ledger.

1.2 — Caused by what

The second question is harder and it is where both camps do their most convenient reasoning.

Consider what changed in the world between 1950 and today, entirely independently of anybody's politics.

Antibiotics became general. Childbirth stopped being dangerous. Child mortality collapsed, so a woman no longer needed six pregnancies to raise three children. Reliable contraception was invented. Piped water, gas cooking, refrigeration and washing machines arrived in ordinary houses. And the economy shifted from work requiring physical strength — where Part Four found the largest measured sex difference — to work requiring literacy, where Part Four found essentially none.

Each of those changes women's lives enormously. None of them requires a movement.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Attribution:** the problem of deciding what caused an observed change, when several things were happening at once and none can be switched off to check.
>
> It is the central difficulty in evaluating any social movement, and it is not solvable in general. What can be done is to look for places where the causes separate — a country that got the technology and not the movement, or a law that changed on a particular date while everything else stayed still.
>
> Why it matters here: both camps attribute confidently and in opposite directions. Supporters credit the movement for the century's work. Opponents credit the century for the movement's work. Neither has the evidence for the confidence, and the honest answer is a split that nobody has calculated.

There is one useful complication, and it cuts against the simple technological story.

Household technology was expected to reduce women's domestic hours dramatically. Careful historical work found something different: as machines arrived, standards rose. Clothes that had been washed weekly were washed daily. Floors that had been swept were now expected to be clean. The hours did not fall as predicted, because the work expanded to fill the capacity.

Which is a warning against the tidy version of either account. **Technology changes what is possible. It does not decide what is expected, and what is expected is social.**

1.3 — For whom

The third question is the one this part takes most seriously, because it is where the honest answer is least comfortable.

“Women gained” is a sentence about an average, and Part Four established what an average conceals. The gains of the last sixty years were not distributed evenly. They went overwhelmingly to women with education, in cities, in rich countries, in advantaged castes and classes — and Chapter Eight sets out how stark the pattern is.

For a substantial number of women the ledger has barely moved. For some, in specific respects, it has moved backwards.

Any account reporting a single figure for what changed for women is averaging across those groups, and Part Four, Chapter One disposed of what an average can tell you about a person.

REMEMBER THIS

Three questions before any number means anything. **Compared to what** — the mid-twentieth century was a trough on several measures, and measuring from a trough produces a rising line by arithmetic rather than achievement.

Caused by what — antibiotics, safe childbirth, collapsing child mortality, contraception, piped water and the shift from physical to literate work each transformed women’s lives and none required a movement. Supporters credit the movement for the century’s work; opponents credit the century for the movement’s. Neither has the evidence.

With one complication against the tidy technological story: household machines did **not** cut domestic hours as predicted, because standards rose to fill the capacity. **Technology changes what is possible and does not decide what is expected.**

And for whom. The gains went overwhelmingly to educated women in cities in rich countries. For a substantial number the ledger has barely moved. Any single figure for “what changed for women” is averaging across those groups.

CHAPTER TWO

The Reversal

The largest single change of the period was not planned, not campaigned for, and is barely discussed. Women now out-graduate men at every level across most of the developed world, and the gap is still widening.

2.1 — The crossover

In the United States, women passed men in the award of first degrees in the early 1980s. They have not looked back. Women now take somewhere around three in five bachelor's degrees, a larger share of master's degrees, and a majority of doctorates.

The pattern is not American. Women are a majority of university graduates in nearly every country in Europe, across most of Latin America, and in much of East Asia.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Put a graduating class of a hundred on a stage in three different decades.
>
> **1960:** roughly sixty-five men and thirty-five women.
>
> **1982:** fifty and fifty. The crossover.
>
> **Today:** roughly forty men and sixty women.
>
> Now the fact that makes this chapter necessary. **The gap today, favouring women, is larger than the gap favouring men was in the early 1970s —** the gap that produced a generation of campaigning, legislation and public concern.
>
> The first gap was a national issue with a name. The second is roughly the same size, in the other direction, and most people reading this have never seen it stated as a number.

Before going further it is worth pausing on how these particular figures are obtained, because they are the most reliable in the series and the reason is instructive.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This is the most reliable measurement in the entire series and it is worth saying why.

What the evidence is: universities record every degree they award, with the recipient's sex, because they are required to. Governments compile the totals. The series run continuously for decades in every country with a functioning education ministry.

Why that is unusually strong: nobody is sampled, nobody is asked how they feel, and no definition is in dispute. A degree was awarded or it was not. There is no reporting bias, no recall problem, no scale that drifts.

What it still cannot show: what the degrees are worth. A count of qualifications is not a count of skills, and if the same credential means something different than it did in 1970, a stable-looking series can conceal a changing thing. That criticism applies to both sexes equally, so it does not touch the comparison — which is what this chapter is about.

2.2 — And India

The Indian version arrived later and moved faster, and it is not widely known even in India.

Female enrolment in Indian higher education has risen steeply for three decades. Women are now around half of all students in higher education, and on the standard measure of what share of the relevant age group is enrolled, women have drawn level with men and in recent years edged ahead.

Part Five added the detail that makes this remarkable: women are around forty-three per cent of Indian STEM graduates, ahead of the United States, Britain, France and Germany.

So India has produced, within one generation, an educational transformation of women that most of its public argument has not registered — while, as Part Five established, employing almost none of the result.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everybody in this argument, for two centuries, assumed **that education was the bottleneck** — that once women were educated, the rest would follow.

It was a reasonable assumption. Education was genuinely blocked, unblocking it was genuinely hard, and it is genuinely a precondition for almost everything else.

> The assumption has now been tested, and it failed.
>
> Women out-graduate men across the developed world and the earnings gap stalled decades ago. India produces a higher share of female science graduates than Britain and employs a fraction of them. The education arrived. The rest did not follow.
>
> The general form: **mistaking a necessary condition for the binding one.** A thing can be genuinely required and still not be what is holding the outcome back — and a movement organised around removing it will keep removing it long after it has stopped being the constraint, because that is the machinery it has.
>
> Notice which chapter this points at. If education is no longer binding, the binding constraint is in Chapter Three, and Chapter Three is about what happens after a first child.

2.3 — The boys nobody was watching

A reversal has two sides and the other one is now the larger problem.

Part Four established that girls outperform boys in reading in **every country** where it has been measured, in every cycle, and that the writing gap is around half an effect size — roughly ten times the mathematics gap and largely absent from public discussion.

Downstream of that: boys are more likely to be excluded from school, more likely to leave without qualifications, less likely to apply to university, and less likely to complete a course once enrolled.

This is not a small effect at the margins. It is the education system producing, at scale, a growing population of young men with no credential in an economy that increasingly requires one — and Part Six, Chapter Six established what happens to the earnings, offending, drinking and mortality of men who do not form stable attachments, while Part Five established that women's partner preferences track education.

Those findings interlock. Fewer credentialed men, in a marriage market where credentials matter, produces both the unmatched women of Part Six, Chapter Five and the unattached men of Part Six, Chapter Six. It is the same arithmetic seen from two ends.

THE ARGUMENT — WHY ARE BOYS FALLING BEHIND?

A live dispute with several serious candidates and no settled answer.

DEVELOPMENT AND BEHAVIOUR

Boys mature later on the specific capacities schooling rewards — sitting still, sustained attention, self-regulation, organised written work. A system that assesses continuously from age five, on exactly those capacities, will systematically disadvantage the later-developing sex. The remedy on this account is structural: later school entry for boys, or assessment that does not compound early differences.

ECONOMIC RETURNS

Boys respond to incentives. When manufacturing and manual employment offered a decent living without a degree, staying in school had a visible cost. Those jobs went, and the incentive to be educated rose — but the belief that a man can earn without qualifications lags the labour market by a generation, and the boys following it are following advice that used to be correct.

FAMILY STRUCTURE

Part Six, Chapter Three found that the effects of family instability fall harder on boys, and family instability rose most exactly where educational outcomes fell most. On this account the education gap is a symptom and the household is the cause.

NOTHING CHANGED EXCEPT THE COMPARISON

Boys' absolute attainment has risen throughout. What changed is that girls' rose faster, because girls were starting from an artificially suppressed position and released. There is no boy crisis — there is a girl recovery, and describing it as a crisis is a way of resenting it.

> **Where things stand:** the last position is correct about the absolute numbers and wrong about what follows. Boys' attainment did rise, and the socially consequential quantity is not absolute attainment but position in a queue for jobs and partners — which is relative by construction. All three other accounts have supporting evidence and none has been shown to dominate.
>
> **What would settle it:** the school-entry-age question is directly testable, and where it has been examined the results are suggestive rather than conclusive. The economic-returns account is testable against regional labour market shocks and this has been done partially.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because the answer determines whether this is somebody's problem to fix. If it is development, schools must change. If it is returns, nothing needs fixing and the market will do it. If it is family structure, it belongs to Part Six. And Part Fifteen counts what happens to these men if none of it is fixed.

What is not disputed is the direction, and the direction has now run for four decades.

REMEMBER THIS

Women passed men in first degrees in the United States in the early **1980s** and now take around three in five, plus a majority of master's and doctoral degrees. The pattern holds across nearly all of Europe, most of Latin America and much of East Asia.

The gap today favouring women is larger than the gap favouring men was in the early 1970s — the gap that produced a generation of campaigning and legislation. Most readers have never seen the second one stated as a number.

India's version arrived later and moved faster. Women are now around half of higher education enrolment, have drawn level or ahead on enrolment ratios, and are around **43 per cent** of STEM graduates — while, as Part Five found, being employed at a fraction of that rate.

Everybody assumed education was the bottleneck. That assumption has now been tested and it failed. The education arrived and the rest did not follow. A necessary condition is not the same as the binding one, and a movement organised around removing it will keep removing it long after it stops being the constraint.

And the other side of the reversal is now the larger problem. Boys read worse in every country measured, are excluded more, complete less and apply less — producing men without credentials in a market that requires them, and in a partner market where Part Five found credentials matter. The unmatched women of Part Six and the unattached men of Part Six are the same arithmetic seen from two ends.

CHAPTER THREE

Work

Employment rose enormously and then stopped. Earnings narrowed sharply and then stopped. Both plateaus arrived around the same time and for the same reason, and one profession accidentally demonstrated what would fix it.

3.1 — The rise, and where it stopped

Across the developed world, the share of women in paid work rose steeply from the middle of the twentieth century. In the United States it went from around a third of working-age women to around three fifths.

WORD BOX

Labour force participation rate: the share of working-age people who are either in paid work or looking for it.

Two things it excludes are worth holding. Somebody working unpaid on a family farm or in a family business may or may not be counted, depending on how the survey is written — which is the heart of the Indian dispute in Chapter Ten. And somebody who has stopped looking because there is nothing to find drops out of the numerator entirely, so the rate can improve when conditions worsen.

Why it matters here: this is the headline measure of whether women are working, and it is considerably less straightforward than it looks.

Then, around the turn of the century, it stopped. American women's participation peaked and has drifted slightly downwards since. Several European countries continued rising, some steeply, and the Nordic countries reached the highest levels recorded anywhere.

The earnings figures show the same shape. The raw gap in the United States narrowed from women earning around sixty per cent of men's median to around three quarters by 1990 — a very large change in twenty years. Since then it has moved to somewhere in the low eighties and has been close to flat for a decade.

Two decades of rapid convergence, then three of very little. That is the shape of this chapter and every explanation has to account for it.

3.2 — What the remaining gap is made of

Part Seven scored the “same work” framing as failed and identified the mechanism. Here is the arithmetic.

Take the raw gap and remove hours worked, occupation, industry and years of experience. What is left is small — commonly estimated at somewhere between five and eight per cent — and it is not zero.

But the removed portions are not innocent, and Part Seven’s evidence box on this technique said why: if women are steered into lower-paying fields, the method files that under “occupation” and thereby removes it from view. What the decomposition establishes is that the gap does not operate through *unequal pay for identical work*. It does not establish that the rest is fair.

And underneath all of the removed portions sits one event.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everybody calls it **the gender pay gap**, and the name is wrong.
>
> Look at what happens when the data is split by parenthood rather than by sex. In several countries where this has been done carefully, the earnings of women *without children* track men’s closely — far more closely than they track the earnings of mothers. The gap between mothers and childless women is larger than the gap between childless women and men.
>
> Which means the phenomenon is not primarily a gap between men and women. It is a gap between **parents who absorb the interruption and everybody else**, and it appears as a gender gap because of who does the absorbing.
>
> The general form: **naming a phenomenon after the wrong variable.** And the naming has consequences, because a thing called a gender gap attracts gender remedies — representation targets, unconscious bias training, pipeline programmes — none of which touch the mechanism. Part Seven found that the movement’s strongest finding is invisible to its own metrics. This is why.
>
> Notice also who is missing from the conversation entirely. If the penalty is for absorbing the interruption, then a father who absorbs it should show the same pattern. Where this has been measured, he does. Almost nobody measures it, because the question is not asked.

3.3 — And the same shape again

One further measure moves in exactly the pattern of the other two, and it is worth adding because three measures with the same shape are more informative than one.

Ask how separated men's and women's occupations are — not what they earn, simply whether they are doing the same jobs. That separation fell substantially through the 1970s and 1980s as women entered fields that had been closed, and then it largely stopped falling.

Part Five found the end state of that process: the Nordic countries, with the strongest equality institutions anywhere, are among the **most** occupationally separated economies in the developed world, with very high female employment concentrated in public health, care and education.

So the same shape appears three times. Employment: steep rise, then plateau. Earnings: rapid convergence, then stall. Occupational separation: sharp fall, then flat.

Three measures stopping at roughly the same time is unlikely to be three coincidences. Whatever the binding constraint became around 1990, it was the same constraint for all three — and §3.4 is the best available account of what it is.

3.4 — Greedy work

The most useful account of why the convergence stalled comes from an economic historian who was awarded the Nobel prize for it, and it is specific enough to be actionable.

WORD BOX

Greedy work: a job that pays disproportionately more for long, inflexible and unpredictable hours. Working sixty hours earns not one and a half times a forty-hour salary but two or three times it.

The opposite is **substitutable work**, where one qualified person can hand a task to another without loss, so hours can be arranged and nobody is irreplaceable at short notice.

Why it matters here: where work is greedy, a couple maximises household income by having one person take all of it and the other absorb everything else. That is not discrimination and it is not a preference about careers. It is arithmetic, performed by the household, and it produces the specialisation Part Six described.

The account explains the stall precisely. The gap closed rapidly while the barriers were the binding constraint. Once they were gone, what remained was the structure of high-paying work itself — and no amount of legal equality touches that, because there is nothing illegal about a job that pays more for being available at eleven at night.

It also predicts where the gap should be largest, and it is right. Law, finance, consulting and senior corporate management are the greediest occupations and have the widest gaps. Fields where work is substitutable have narrower ones.

3.5 — The profession that fixed itself by accident

IN REAL TERMS

Pharmacy used to be a small business. A pharmacist owned a shop, was known to the customers, kept the records, and could not be replaced on a Tuesday. Long hours, personal client relationships, irreplaceability — a greedy occupation in every respect.

Then the industry consolidated. Pharmacists became employees of chains and hospitals. Records went into shared systems. Any qualified pharmacist could pick up where another left off.

Nobody did this for equality. It was consolidation and computerisation, driven by cost.

The result is one of the smallest gender earnings gaps of any high-paying profession. The penalty for working part-time nearly disappeared, because two pharmacists working half a week became genuinely equivalent to one working the whole of it. Women are now a majority of pharmacists, and they earn close to what the men earn.

Set that beside a generation of pipeline programmes, mentoring schemes and representation targets. **The thing that closed the gap in pharmacy was making the work substitutable — and it happened by accident, for reasons that had nothing to do with women at all.**

Which leaves the question of what the part of the gap that pharmacy did not eliminate is actually evidence of.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT IS THE REMAINING GAP ACTUALLY EVIDENCE OF?

Everybody agrees a residue exists after adjustment. What it means is the dispute.

DISCRIMINATION

A residue that survives every measured control is what unmeasured discrimination looks like. Audit studies have demonstrated differential treatment directly, and the fact that a gap shrinks when you control for occupation does not exonerate the process that sorted people into occupations.

STRUCTURE, NOT BIAS

The residue is small and shrinking, and the large explained portions are not mysterious — they are hours, continuity and occupational choice, all downstream of who absorbs children. No employer is deciding anything. The greedy-work account predicts the pattern, predicts the stall, and predicts where the gap is largest, and it does all three correctly.

BOTH, AND THE PROPORTIONS ARE UNKNOWN

Discrimination is demonstrated to exist and is not large enough to account for the observed gap. Structure accounts for most of it and does not account for all. Nobody has apportioned them and the honest range is wide.

Where things stand: the third, with the structural account carrying most of the weight because it makes correct predictions and the discrimination account mostly explains a residue after the fact.

What would settle it: more cases like pharmacy. Every time an occupation becomes substitutable for unrelated reasons, the experiment runs again, and the structural account predicts the gap should fall without any equality intervention.

Why people care so much: because the remedies are completely different. Discrimination calls for enforcement. Structure calls for redesigning how high-paying work is organised, which is expensive, benefits men who want to see their children too, and requires nobody to be accused of anything.

Which is a pattern this series has now met several times: the remedy that would work is the one nobody can campaign on.

REMEMBER THIS

Women's employment rose steeply for four decades and **stopped around 2000**. The raw earnings gap narrowed fast to about 1990 and has been close to flat since. Two decades of convergence, three of very little — and every explanation has to account for that shape.

Remove hours, occupation, industry and experience and the residue is **five to eight per cent**. That establishes the gap does not work through unequal pay for identical work. It does not establish that the removed portions are fair.

And the name is wrong. Split by parenthood rather than sex and childless women's earnings track men's closely. The gap between mothers and childless women is larger than the gap between childless women and men. It is a **parenthood gap appearing as a gender gap** because of who absorbs the interruption — which is why gender remedies do not touch it.

Greedy work explains the stall: jobs paying disproportionately for long unpredictable hours make it arithmetically rational for a couple to specialise. Law and finance are greediest and have the widest gaps.

And pharmacy proves the point by accident. Consolidation and computerisation made pharmacists substitutable — for cost reasons, with no thought of women — and it now has one of the smallest gender earnings gaps of any high-paying profession. What closed it was redesigning the work.

CHAPTER FOUR

Power

Representation in the world's parliaments has more than doubled in thirty years and is still nowhere near half. Where quotas were imposed the numbers moved immediately — and in one well-studied case, moved nothing else at all.

4.1 — Parliaments

In the mid-1990s, women held roughly one seat in nine across the world's national legislatures. Today it is somewhere above one in four.

That is a real change and it is also, after three decades, still a long way from anything proportional. On the current trajectory the arithmetic does not reach parity within the working lives of anybody reading this.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Put a national legislature in a room of a hundred people.
>
> **1995:** eleven women, eighty-nine men.
>
> **Now, world average:** around twenty-six women.
>
> **Rwanda:** above sixty — the highest anywhere, and the reason it outranks most of western Europe on the index Part Five took apart.
>
> **India:** around fourteen. In the lower house of the world's largest democracy, roughly seven seats in fifty are held by women — which places India below the world average and well below several of its neighbours.
>
> That last figure sits beside Part Seven's randomised evidence that women in Indian village councils changed spending and closed the gap in girls' schooling. **The country with the strongest experimental evidence that female representation works has among the weakest representation at national level.**

4.2 — India's law, and why it is not yet doing anything

India passed a constitutional amendment in 2023 reserving one third of seats in the lower house and in state assemblies for women.

It is not yet in operation. Implementation was made conditional on a census and a subsequent redrawing of constituency boundaries, neither of which had been completed as this is written. So the law exists, the reservation does not, and the gap between those two states is itself worth noting — it is the same structure Part Two found in the dowry ban and Part Seven found in the marital rape recommendation. **The provision that would change a household's arrangements is the one that does not commence.**

Whether it will work when it does commence is a genuine question, and India has unusually good evidence bearing on it, because the village council reservation described in Part Seven is the same instrument at a smaller scale — and it worked.

4.3 — Boards, and a quota that did exactly one thing

The corporate story is where the honest ledger gets least comfortable for the case that representation is self-propagating.

Norway required listed companies to have at least forty per cent of board seats held by women, with real penalties. The requirement was met. Board composition changed almost overnight, and several countries followed with similar rules.

Then researchers looked at what else changed.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The Norwegian quota is an unusually clean case to study, because it applied to one category of company on a fixed date, leaving comparable companies unaffected — which supplies a comparison group.

What changed: the boards, immediately and completely. The women appointed were more qualified on measurable criteria than the men they joined.

What did not change: almost everything else. Analysis found little effect on women in the senior positions just below the board, little effect on the gender gap in earnings within these firms, and little sign of the change propagating downwards through the organisation.

What it shows: that a quota reliably changes the thing it is applied to, and that the assumption of a knock-on effect through the rest of the organisation is not supported in this case.

What it cannot show: that no such effect exists anywhere. One country, one policy, a period of about a decade. And Part Seven's Indian evidence found effects that did propagate — on spending, and on what girls in those villages expected of themselves. Both results are solid and they differ.

Set the two side by side, because the contrast is the most useful thing in this chapter.

In Indian village councils, putting women in charge changed what was built and changed what girls expected. In Norwegian boardrooms, putting women on boards changed the boards.

The most plausible difference is what the position controls. A village council head decides where the money goes, on things — water, roads — where local women's stated priorities differed from men's. A board member sits on a committee overseeing a company whose operations she does not run.

Which suggests the useful question is not how many women are present but whether the position they hold decides anything that a differently-composed group would decide differently. Counting seats does not ask that.

4.4 — Underneath the national number

India's fourteen per cent is a national figure and it conceals two things worth separating.

State assemblies are generally lower than parliament, not higher. Several large state legislatures sit in single figures. So the low national number is not an artefact of one chamber; it runs through the system.

And underneath both sits the tier where the reservation already operates. Following the amendment described in Part Seven, women hold a third or more of village council seats across the country — in some states well above a third, because the reservation is a floor rather than a ceiling.

Which produces an unusual structure. India has, simultaneously, one of the world's largest bodies of women in elected office and one of the lower rates of women in its national legislature. Hundreds of thousands of women decide where a village's money goes; a much smaller share decide anything at state or national level.

Part Seven established that the village tier *works* — randomised evidence, changed spending, closed attainment gaps. So India has run the experiment, obtained a positive result, and not yet applied it upwards. The 2023 amendment is the attempt to do so and it awaits a census.

4.5 — The top

At the very top the numbers remain small. Women run somewhere around one in ten of the largest American companies, a share that has risen slowly. Heads of government remain a small minority worldwide, and the count fluctuates by a handful each year.

Part Four's arithmetic is worth recalling here without being over-applied. The very top of any distribution is where small differences in the middle produce large imbalances — and it is also where the greedy-work structure of Chapter Three operates most severely, since a chief executive's job is the least substitutable there is.

Both mechanisms predict a persistent gap at the summit even under complete fairness. Neither predicts its current size, and neither is evidence that the current size is right.

REMEMBER THIS

Women held roughly **one seat in nine** in the world's parliaments in the mid-1990s and somewhere above **one in four** today. Real, and after thirty years still far from proportional.

India is at about fourteen per cent — below the world average — while holding the strongest experimental evidence anywhere that female representation changes outcomes. India passed a one-third reservation for parliament and state assemblies in 2023 and it is **not yet operating**, being conditional on a census and boundary redrawing. Same structure as the dowry ban and the marital rape recommendation: the provision touching households is the one that does not commence.

Norway's board quota worked and did nothing else. Boards changed immediately and completely; the women appointed were more qualified than the men they joined. Effects on senior women below the board, on the internal earnings gap, and on the rest of the organisation were slight.

Set that against India's village councils, where putting women in charge changed what was built and what girls expected. The likely difference is what the position controls — a council head decides where money goes; a board member oversees a company she does not run. So the useful question is not how many women are present but whether their position decides anything a differently-composed group would decide differently. Counting seats does not ask that.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Body

The largest improvement in women's lives over this period is not on anybody's ledger. It is not employment, earnings or representation. It is that childbirth stopped killing them, and the numbers are not close.

5.1 — Dying in childbirth, and then not

Part Six, Chapter Two priced a single sexual act in a world without antibiotics, contraception or safe delivery, and found a real chance of pregnancy, a real chance of dying from it, and a real chance of an incurable disease. That was the world the rules were written for.

Here is what happened to the first of those dangers in India, within one lifetime.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Maternal mortality ratio:** the number of women who die from causes related to pregnancy and childbirth, for every hundred thousand babies born alive.
>
> It is expressed per hundred thousand rather than per hundred because, in a country with functioning hospitals, the figure per hundred would be a decimal too small to compare. That fact is itself the achievement being measured.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the single cleanest measure of whether a society keeps its women alive through the most dangerous ordinary thing most of them will do.

In 1990, the number of women dying for every hundred thousand live births was somewhere above **five hundred**. By the end of the 2010s it was **below a hundred.** It has continued falling since.

That is a reduction of more than four fifths in thirty years, in a country of a billion people, in the single most dangerous ordinary event in a woman's life.

Globally the direction is the same and the change is smaller, because much of the world started lower.

5.2 — The crossover India took forty years to reach

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> In almost every country in the world, women outlive men. Part Four established this and found the global gap runs to around five years.
>
> India was, for most of the twentieth century, one of the very few exceptions. **Indian women died younger than Indian men.**
>
> That is not a small anomaly. It is a measurable statement that something was being done to women, at scale, across a population — because there is no biological reason for it. Part Four found that male infants die at higher rates from the first days of life, everywhere. For a population to invert that requires the deliberate allocation of food, medicine, attention and care.
>
> The crossover happened in the **early 1980s**. Indian women now outlive Indian men by around three years.
>
> Put that in a household. For most of the century, a girl born in India could expect fewer years than her brother — not because of her body, but because of what would be spent on her. Within one generation that reversed.
>
> **It is among the largest changes in this entire series and it appears on no political ledger, because neither camp can claim it and neither wants to explain it.**

I want to be careful about what that reversal does and does not mean. It does not mean the discrimination that produced the anomaly has ended — Part Twelve counts what is still happening before birth, and the sex ratio at birth remains skewed. It means that the excess mortality of girls and women *after* birth, which used to be large enough to invert a biological constant, has largely gone.

5.3 — Control

The third medical entry is the one that changes what a life can contain.

India's total fertility rate — the number of children an average woman has across her life — has fallen below replacement. Modern contraception is used by a majority of married women. Both of those would have been unimaginable to the people writing the rules in Parts Two and Three, and both arrived within about fifty years.

Part Two, Chapter Nine scored this problem as "technically solved, practically not," because access in India is uneven and much of the burden falls on female sterilisation after childbearing rather than on preventing unwanted pregnancy. That criticism stands. It sits on top of a change that is nonetheless enormous.

5.4 — And the entry that goes the other way

The medical column is not uniformly positive, and the exception is the most uncomfortable finding in this part because it comes from the same source as the gains.

The technology that made pregnancy safe also made it visible. Ultrasound imaging arrived in India through the 1980s and spread rapidly. It is the reason obstructed labour can be anticipated, complications detected and lives saved.

It is also the reason a family can find out the sex of a foetus.

India's sex ratio at birth — the number of girls born for every thousand boys — **worsened** across exactly the decades when maternal and child mortality were collapsing. Determining the sex of a foetus for this purpose was prohibited by law in 1994 and the prohibition has been extensively documented as poorly enforced. Part Twelve counts the totals and they are very large.

So the same medical advance appears in both columns. It stopped women dying in childbirth and it supplied the instrument by which daughters are not born.

Which is worth holding against the whole of Chapter Eight's argument. **A gain that arrives at the door reaches everybody — including the households that will use it for something else.** Public health delivers a capability, and what a family does with a capability is decided by the arithmetic in Part Two, Chapter Nine: no pension, a son as the only instrument, a daughter as a transfer to another household.

5.5 — Violence, counted honestly

The last entry in this chapter is the one where the ledger is genuinely mixed and the reporting is worst.

In the United States and several comparable countries, intimate partner violence against women fell sharply from the mid-1990s — by a large fraction over about two decades, on the national victimisation surveys. Killings of women by partners fell alongside it. This is one of the clearest improvements on the whole ledger and it is almost never mentioned by either camp.

In India the change is much smaller. National health surveys ask ever-married women directly about spousal violence, and the share reporting it has moved from roughly three in ten to slightly under three in ten across the most recent survey rounds. That is a decline. It is not a transformation, and Part Twelve counts what it means at population scale.

And a caution that applies to both. Survey prevalence and reported crime measure different things, Part Seven scored the undercounting claim as supported, and a fall in reported incidents can reflect a fall in incidents or a change in what gets reported. The Indian surveys ask women directly, which is why they are the better instrument, and they still depend on what a woman will say to a stranger in her own house.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both camps assume **that the important changes are the ones being argued about.**

Sixty years of public argument about women has been conducted almost entirely over employment, earnings, representation and law. Those are the columns everybody counts.

Now compare magnitudes. The earnings gap moved from roughly sixty to roughly eighty-two cents in the dollar. Parliamentary representation moved from one in nine to one in four. Real changes, decades of work.

And maternal deaths in India fell by **more than four fifths**. And women went from dying younger than men to outliving them by three years. Nothing in the political column is the same order of magnitude as either.

Why are they not on the ledger? Because **neither camp can claim them.** They were produced by antibiotics, antenatal care, trained birth attendants, blood transfusion and vaccination — by public health systems, largely staffed by people with no position on any of this. A gain nobody can take credit for generates no argument, and a change that generates no argument does not get counted.

> The general form: **arguing about the column that produces argument rather than the one with the largest number.** It is not a feature of this subject. It is a feature of every subject where the accounting is done by the participants.

The next chapter is the one entry on this ledger that everybody counts, and it is the only one that goes the wrong way.

REMEMBER THIS

Indian maternal deaths fell from above **five hundred** per hundred thousand live births in 1990 to **below a hundred** by the end of the 2010s. More than four fifths, in thirty years, in the most dangerous ordinary event of a woman's life.

And India was one of the very few countries where **women died younger than men** — an anomaly with no biological basis, requiring the deliberate allocation of food, medicine and care. The crossover came in the **early 1980s**. Indian women now outlive Indian men by around three years.

India's fertility has fallen below replacement and a majority of married women use modern contraception — on top of the access problems Part Two recorded, not instead of them.

Violence is mixed. Intimate partner violence against women fell sharply in the United States and comparable countries from the mid-1990s. In India it has moved from roughly three in ten to slightly under.

None of the medical gains appears on anybody's ledger, and the reason is that neither camp can claim them. They came from antibiotics, antenatal care, trained birth attendants and vaccination — from people with no position on any of this. A gain nobody can take credit for generates no argument, and what generates no argument does not get counted.

CHAPTER SIX

The Happiness Problem

Across the decades of greatest gain, women's own ratings of their happiness fell. The finding is real, nobody predicted it, and it is quoted constantly by people who have not checked what it establishes — which is narrower and stranger than either camp wants.

6.1 — The finding

Large national surveys have asked people the same question about their own happiness, in the same words, for decades. That consistency is what makes a long comparison possible.

WORD BOX

Subjective wellbeing: what a person says when asked to rate their own life or happiness, usually on a short scale with three or five options.

Three properties matter for everything in this chapter. The scale has **no fixed meaning** — one person's "very happy" is another's "pretty happy," and there is no external anchor. It is **ordinal**, so the distance between options is unknown and cannot be averaged in the way it routinely is. And what a person is willing to say depends on what is socially acceptable to admit, which changes across decades.

Why it matters here: this is the only measure in this entire part that is not a count of something, and it is the only one that moved in the unexpected direction. Those two facts have to be held together.

Researchers examining the American series across roughly thirty-five years found that women's average reported happiness **declined** — both in absolute terms and relative to men, whose ratings held steadier. Examining European data, they found the same direction in most of the countries where comparable series existed.

The period covered is the one in Chapters Two to Five. Education, earnings, employment, legal rights, physical safety within marriage, control over childbearing and survival of childbirth all improved substantially, several of them enormously.

Nobody predicted this. Part Seven established that the movement expected the opposite and its opponents expected something else entirely — social disorder rather than a quiet decline in self-reported wellbeing among the people who had gained most.

6.2 — Seven explanations

Every one of these has been proposed by serious people. None is established.

One: expectations rose faster than conditions. A person rates their life against what they thought it would be. If the horizon expanded faster than the reality, the gap widens even as the reality improves.

Two: total work increased. Part Seven's second shift. If paid work was added and unpaid work was not correspondingly removed, the result is more hours and less rest, which would plausibly show up in a wellbeing measure.

Three: the comparison group changed. Part Five identified this mechanism precisely. In more gender-integrated societies people compare themselves across sex rather than within it. A woman comparing her life to a mixed population rather than to other women is measuring against a different standard, and the rating can fall with nothing else changing.

Four: the people being measured changed. As more women entered paid work, the population answering the survey shifted in composition. The average woman in 1975 and the average woman in 2005 are not the same sample in the ways that matter for a wellbeing question.

Five: reporting norms changed. If it became more acceptable for a woman to say she was not happy, the measured decline is a decline in the pressure to say she was. This would be a change in candour, not in wellbeing, and the two are indistinguishable in the data.

Six: the scale is the problem. Answers are on a short ordinal scale with no fixed meaning, and the meaning of the middle option can drift across decades. This is not a marginal objection; it applies to every long comparison of self-rated anything.

Seven: it is real. Something in the changes made women's lives worse in a way the objective measures do not capture.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the fact that reframes the whole chapter, and it comes from outside this subject entirely.

Self-reported happiness barely moves for anybody, in response to almost anything.

Rich countries got several times richer across the second half of the twentieth century. Average reported happiness in those countries was roughly flat. This is one of the most replicated findings in the study of wellbeing and it has its own long literature.

So a group's happiness line failing to rise during a period of enormous objective gain is not an anomaly requiring explanation. It is **what these measures do**. Nothing has ever made a national happiness average go up much — not wealth, not health, not peace.

Which means the expectation that women's happiness would rise with their gains was an expectation that has never been met by any improvement, for any group, anywhere.

The genuine puzzle is therefore narrower than it is usually stated. It is not that happiness failed to rise. **It is that it fell, and fell relative to men.** That is a smaller finding and it is still a real one.

Which is where the dispute about what to do with it begins.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT DOES THE DECLINING HAPPINESS FINDING SHOW?

Quoted in every direction, usually by people who have read the headline.

THE CHANGES MADE WOMEN WORSE OFF

The people who received the benefits are reporting lower wellbeing than the people who did not. That is the most direct evidence available about whether a change was good for its intended beneficiaries, and dismissing it because it is inconvenient is exactly the moralistic fallacy Part One named.

THE MEASURE IS NOT DOING WHAT THAT READING REQUIRES

Self-rated happiness is flat against everything, moves with reporting norms, has an unstable scale and is measured on a shifting population. And the same period produced women living years longer, dying in childbirth at a fraction of the rate, and being beaten by partners far less. If a wellbeing measure disagrees with survival, health and safety, the question is what the measure is tracking.

REAL AND SMALL AND UNEXPLAINED

The relative decline against men is a genuine result for the period examined, and its continuation into more recent data is disputed. Seven explanations fit and none has been established. It is a fact in search of a cause and it should be held that way.

Where things stand: the third. And it is worth stating what a person is entitled to say. You may say that measured female happiness fell over that period, absolutely and relative to men, and that nobody predicted it or has explained it. You may not say that the changes made women worse off, because that requires ruling out six explanations that have not been ruled out.

What would settle it: the same question asked with better instruments — measures anchored to something stable rather than to a respondent's own scale. Some exist and the series are too short.

Why people care so much: because it is the only number in this entire part that goes the wrong way, and a single contrary number in a long ledger attracts attention out of all proportion to its weight. That is worth noticing about the number and also about the attention.

Part Nine returns to one of the seven explanations with much better data behind it, because postponement leaves a trace that a happiness scale does not.

REMEMBER THIS

Across roughly thirty-five years covering the greatest gains in women's education, earnings, rights, safety and survival, women's **reported happiness fell** — absolutely and relative to men — in the United States and in most European countries with comparable data. Nobody predicted it.

Seven explanations have been offered: rising expectations, more total work, comparison across sex rather than within it, a changed sample, changed reporting norms, an unstable scale, and genuine decline. **None is established.**

And the reframing that matters comes from outside the subject. Self-reported happiness barely moves for anybody in response to anything. Rich countries got several times richer and their happiness lines were flat. So the expectation that women's happiness would rise with their gains was an expectation never met by any improvement for any group.

Which narrows the puzzle. It is not that happiness failed to rise — that is what these measures do. **It is that it fell relative to men.** Smaller, and still real.

What you are entitled to say: measured female happiness fell over that period, nobody predicted it, nobody has explained it. What you are not entitled to say: that the changes made women worse off — because that requires ruling out six explanations nobody has ruled out.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Bill

A ledger needs a second column. Some of the entries usually placed in it do not survive checking. The ones that do are not the ones most often named.

7.1 — The claim that does not survive

The most frequently stated cost is that women took on paid work without putting down unpaid work, and therefore ended up doing more in total than men.

It has a name, it entered the language, and it described something real when it was first written about in the 1980s.

WORD BOX

A time use survey asks people to account for a whole day — usually in a diary, in intervals, recording what they were doing at each point.

It is a much better instrument than asking "how many hours a week do you spend on housework," because people are poor at estimating totals and systematically over-report activities they think they should be doing. A diary of yesterday is harder to get wrong.

Why it matters here: nearly everything in this chapter rests on these surveys, including India’s own, and they are the reason the second-shift claim can be checked at all rather than merely asserted.

The current evidence is more awkward than that.

IN REAL TERMS

Add up everything a person does that counts as work — paid employment, plus cooking, cleaning, childcare, shopping, repairs, care of the old. Then compare the totals.

In rich countries, men and women do roughly the same total. The composition differs sharply — women do far more of the unpaid, men more of the paid — but the sum comes out close to level. This has been found across many wealthy countries.

In poorer countries it does not. There, women's total work substantially exceeds men's, and India is well inside that group. Indian women report roughly **five hours a day** of unpaid domestic and care work against about an hour and a half for men, and the paid hours do not compensate.

So the second-shift claim, as a general statement about women everywhere, is not supported. As a statement about **Indian women** it is supported, and by India's own national survey.

Which is a pattern worth noticing across this entire part. Several claims that have become weak in rich countries remain accurate here, and a reader importing the rich-country version of either camp's argument will get India wrong.

7.2 — What is genuinely on the bill

Three entries survive checking, and they are not the ones most often named.

Leisure, not child time. The expectation was that working parents would spend less time with their children. Measured, the opposite happened: parental time with children *rose* in rich countries across exactly the decades when both parents took paid work. What fell was everything else — sleep, rest, time alone, unstructured hours. The cost of the transition was not paid by children. It was paid out of the parents' own remaining hours, and it was paid disproportionately by mothers.

Postponement, and the gap it leaves. The age at which women have a first child rose sharply across the developed world and is rising in urban India. One consequence is measurable and is genuinely a cost: surveys in rich countries consistently find that women end up with **fewer children than they say they wanted**. Not fewer than a demographer would like — fewer than they themselves reported wanting. That gap between intended and achieved family size is a real deficit and it is one of the clearest entries on this side of the ledger. Part Nine takes up what it does at population scale.

And the care that was moved rather than removed. When women in rich countries entered paid work, a large part of the domestic and care work did not disappear and was not redistributed to men. It was *purchased* — from other women, frequently poorer, frequently migrants, frequently leaving their own children behind to do it.

That last entry deserves emphasis because it is the one that most complicates the ledger. A gain recorded for one woman was in part a transfer from another, and the second woman appears in nobody's accounting because she is in a different country's statistics.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Everything in this chapter assumes **that unpaid work is a cost.**
>
> Look at the accounting. Hours of childcare, cooking and care of the old are entered as burden — something to be reduced, redistributed, outsourced or compensated. Both camps do this. The traditional side says women should bear it willingly; the reformist side says it should be shared or paid. Neither questions that it is a debit.
>
> But a substantial part of what is being counted is the raising of children and the tending of the dying. Those are not chores that happen to fall on somebody. For a great many people they are the content of a life, and the reason the rest of it is for anything.
>
> Part Seven, Chapter One identified a whole strand of feminism built on precisely this objection: that the remedy is not to escape this work but to stop treating it as the absence of achievement. That strand loses the argument automatically the moment the accounting begins, because a ledger has no column for it.
>
> The general form: **adopting the accounting system of the thing you are criticising.** If only paid work counts as achievement, then a movement measuring its success in paid work has conceded the premise it started by attacking — and every hour of care becomes a loss, including the hours somebody would not have given up.

I am not going to resolve that, and the next chapter proceeds with the accounting anyway, which is itself the concession the box describes.

REMEMBER THIS

The most-quoted cost — that women took on paid work without putting down unpaid work — **does not survive checking as a general claim.** In rich countries, men's and women's **total** work is roughly level; the composition differs sharply and the sum does not.

In India it does survive. Women report roughly five hours of unpaid work a day against about an hour and a half, and paid hours do not compensate. Several claims that have gone weak in rich countries remain accurate here.

Three entries survive. **Leisure, not child time** — parental time with children rose across the transition, and what fell was sleep, rest and unstructured hours, paid disproportionately by mothers. **Postponement** — women in rich countries end up with fewer children than they themselves said they wanted. And **care that was moved rather than removed** — purchased from poorer women, often migrants, who appear in nobody's accounting because they are in another country's statistics.

And the whole chapter assumes unpaid work is a cost. Much of what is counted is raising children and tending the dying — for many people the content of a life rather than a chore. A ledger has no column for that, which means the strand of feminism built on exactly this objection loses automatically the moment the accounting starts.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Who Actually Gained

"Women gained" is a sentence about an average, and the distribution behind it is stark. The gains went overwhelmingly to one group — with a single exception, and the exception is the most important thing in this chapter.

8.1 — By education

Take the changes in Chapters Two, Three and Four and ask which women received them.

A woman with a university degree gained on nearly every measure. Earnings rose substantially. Occupational range expanded. Autonomy within marriage increased. Her marriage, as Part Six established, is more likely to be stable than a marriage in any other educational group.

A woman without one received a much smaller share. Her earnings rose less. The jobs that opened were mostly not open to her. And — this is the entry that matters most — Part Six, Chapter Three found that the collapse in marriage was concentrated in exactly her group, which means she is far more likely to be raising children alone, in the household type with the least money and the fewest adults.

So the same period produced, for one group of women, more income and a stable partnership, and for another, slightly more income and a substantially higher chance of raising children without one.

8.2 — By country, and by caste

The second and third cuts run the same way.

By country: the gains recorded in this part are concentrated in rich countries. In much of sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia the political and economic columns moved far less, and Part Five's paradox complicates any simple ranking.

By caste, in India: the gaps are large and documented in the national health and education surveys. Literacy, maternal outcomes, age at marriage, exposure to violence and schooling all differ substantially between caste categories, and the differences have narrowed less than the headline national figures suggest.

With one complication that inverts the expected pattern and is worth stating carefully. Dalit and Adivasi women's participation in paid work is *higher* than that of women in higher-status groups — for the reason Part Three identified. Withdrawing a woman from work is a purchase, and only a household with a surplus can make it. So a measure that reads as advancement in one context reads as necessity in another, and Part Five, Chapter Six found the same inversion at country level.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Two Indian women, the same age, the same year, the same country.
>
> The first has a degree, lives in a city, married at twenty-eight, has one child, works in an office, has a bank account in her own name and a phone nobody else uses. On almost every measure in this part, her life differs from her grandmother's beyond recognition.
>
> The second left school before finishing, married at nineteen in a village, has three children, works in fields or in somebody's house for wages that are not recorded anywhere, and has no independent claim on any asset. Her life differs from her grandmother's in some respects and not in most.
>
> **Both are covered by the sentence "Indian women gained."**
>
> And there is exactly one column where their gains are similar, which is the subject of §8.3.

Claims about distribution are harder to establish than headline averages, so it is worth setting out what makes these ones possible.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Distributional claims are harder to establish than headline averages, because they require the data to be broken down without the subgroups becoming too small to measure.

What makes it possible here: India's national health surveys interview several hundred thousand households and record caste category, education, wealth quintile and location for every respondent. That sample is large enough that a figure for, say, maternal care among rural Dalit women in a particular state is a real measurement rather than a handful of cases.

What it shows: gaps between groups on literacy, age at marriage, antenatal care, exposure to violence and schooling, and — the finding that matters most here — that the health indicators have converged between groups considerably more than the economic and educational ones.

What it cannot show: why a household did what it did. A survey records that a woman had antenatal care or did not. It does not record whether she was prevented, could not travel, was not told, or chose otherwise — which are four different problems requiring four different remedies, and the aggregate cannot distinguish them.

8.3 — The exception

Chapter Five's medical gains are the exception, and it is the most important finding in this chapter.

Maternal mortality did not fall only for educated urban women. It fell across the population. The collapse in child mortality reached villages. Vaccination reached villages. The life expectancy crossover happened for Indian women as a group, not for a segment of them.

The reason is structural. Public health reaches people who are not asking for it. A vaccination campaign, an antenatal programme, a trained birth attendant scheme and a supply of antibiotics deliver to whoever is there, and do not require the recipient to have education, income, mobility, confidence, a supportive family or a functioning labour market.

Every other gain on this ledger required something of the woman receiving it. She had to be able to attend, to apply, to travel, to be permitted, to compete. Which means every other gain was filtered through exactly the constraints Parts Two and Three described, and reached the women who had least of them.

The gains that arrived without being asked for are the gains that arrived for everybody.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE UNEVEN DISTRIBUTION A FAILURE?

Everybody agrees the gains were concentrated. What follows is disputed.

IT IS A FAILURE, AND A PREDICTABLE ONE

A project designed by educated women delivered to educated women, and the women who needed it most got least. The priorities that were pursued — professional entry, boardrooms, representation — were the priorities of the people setting them, which is exactly the criticism Part Seven recorded from the intersectional and Dalit critique, made from inside and largely not acted on.

IT IS HOW EVERY CHANGE DIFFUSES

Nothing arrives evenly. Literacy, electricity, medicine, the vote and the telephone all reached the advantaged first and spread. Judging a sixty-year process by its distribution at year sixty mistakes a stage for an outcome, and the alternative — refusing gains to anybody until they are available to everybody — helps nobody.

THE DISTRIBUTION TELLS YOU WHICH INSTRUMENT WORKED

Both of the above are about blame. The useful reading is diagnostic. The gains that required something of the recipient reached the women who had most; the gains delivered by a system reached everybody. That is not a fact about intentions. It is a fact about **mechanisms**, and it says what to build.

Where things stand: the third, and it is the most practically useful conclusion in this part. If the constraint on a woman is her family, her mobility, her confidence or her permission, then any remedy requiring her to come and get it will be captured by the women who are least constrained. Remedies that arrive at the door will not be.

What would settle it: comparing the distributional reach of delivered programmes against opt-in programmes, on the same population, over the same period. India has run enough of both to make this answerable and I have not found it done.

Why people care so much: because the first two positions are about who is at fault and the third is about what to do, and the first two generate more conversation.

Chapter Nine takes that diagnostic reading and asks what it says about the whole ledger.

REMEMBER THIS

“Women gained” is an average. A woman with a degree gained on nearly every measure — earnings, occupation, autonomy, and a marriage more stable than in any other group. A woman without one gained less on all of them, and Part Six found the **collapse in marriage was concentrated in exactly her group**, so she is far more likely to be raising children alone.

The same cuts run by country and by caste. And with one inversion: Dalit and Adivasi women’s paid work participation is **higher** than higher-status women’s, because withdrawal is a purchase only a household with a surplus can make — the same inversion Part Five found at country level.

There is one exception and it is the most important thing here. The medical gains in Chapter Five reached everybody — maternal mortality, child mortality, vaccination, the life expectancy crossover. Because public health reaches people who are not asking for it.

Every other gain required something of the woman receiving it: to attend, apply, travel, be permitted, compete. So every other gain was filtered through exactly the constraints Parts Two and Three described, and reached the women who had least of them. The gains that arrived without being asked for are the gains that arrived for everybody — and that is a fact about mechanisms rather than intentions, which means it says what to build.

CHAPTER NINE

Scoring The Ledger

Eight chapters of counting. The remaining question is what the leftover gaps are evidence of — unfinished business, or a tool that reached the limit of what it can do. The answer differs by country and depends on a goal nobody chose.

9.1 — The shape of the result

Put the columns together and a specific pattern appears, and it is not the pattern either camp describes.

The medical column is enormous, broadly distributed, and uncontested. Maternal deaths down by more than four fifths in India. A life expectancy crossover that reversed an anomaly with no biological basis. Child mortality collapsed. Fertility below replacement and under control. Nothing else on the ledger is the same size, and it reached everybody because it did not require anybody to come and ask.

The educational column went further than anybody predicted and then stopped mattering as much as expected. Women out-graduate men across the developed world, India has drawn level, and the assumption that this would unlock the rest turned out to be wrong.

The economic column moved fast for twenty years and then stalled. And the stall has an identified cause that is not legal and not attitudinal: the structure of high-paying work, and who absorbs a first child.

The political column moved slowly and steadily and is nowhere near proportional. Where quotas were imposed the numbers changed immediately, and whether anything else changed depended on whether the position decided anything.

The costs column has three real entries — leisure rather than child time, a gap between children wanted and children had, and care purchased from poorer women — and one widely repeated entry that does not survive checking in rich countries and does survive in India.

And one measure went the wrong way, in a way nobody predicted, that nobody has explained, and that neither camp is entitled to use the way they use it.

9.2 — Unfinished, or the edge of the instrument?

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT ARE THE REMAINING GAPS EVIDENCE OF?

The question that decides how the rest of this series reads.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

Sixty years is nothing against several thousand. The gaps that remain are the residue of a system still operating — in hiring, in expectation, in who is asked to leave work when a child arrives. Every previous generation was told the remaining gap was natural and every previous generation was wrong, which is a reason to distrust the claim now.

THE EDGE OF THE INSTRUMENT

The instrument was removing legal and formal barriers, and it worked spectacularly — Part Seven scored that as supported. But its returns fell as it ran out of barriers. What remains is not a barrier: it is the structure of greedy work, the allocation of children within couples, and the preference differences of Parts Four and Five. None of those is illegal and none responds to the tool that produced every previous gain.

DIFFERENT ANSWERS IN DIFFERENT COUNTRIES

Both of the above are answers about rich countries. In India the barrier-removal instrument has an enormous amount left to do — Part Three's machine is intact, the marital rape exception stands, Part Five found 43 per cent of science graduates and a fraction employed, and Chapter Four found national representation below the world average. The question "is the project finished" has one answer in Norway and another here.

Where things stand: the third contains the other two. The tool has largely exhausted itself where the barriers are gone and has barely started where they are not — and almost all the writing on this subject is produced in the first kind of country and read in the second.

What would settle it: whether the structural remedies work. If redesigning work reduces the gap where legal remedies stopped — as Chapter Three's pharmacy case suggests — the second position is right about the instrument and wrong about the ceiling.

Why people care so much: because "unfinished" licenses continued effort and "finished" licenses stopping, and both conclusions are being drawn from a ledger that supports neither.

9.3 — What the ledger does to the rules

Every part of this series ends by asking what its findings do to the rules in Parts Two and Three. A ledger of results has a specific answer and it is sharper than the earlier ones.

The rules in this series exist to constrain women's behaviour — who they marry, whether they remarry, what they wear, where they go, what is said about them. Sixty years of counting produces four findings that bear on them, and every one runs the same way.

The gains that arrived reached women through capability, not through permission. Chapter Eight's finding was that what was delivered reached everybody and what had to be claimed reached the least constrained. Every rule in Parts Two and Three operates on the second channel — by determining what a woman is permitted to go and get. Which means the rules did not stop the medical gains and did throttle almost everything else.

The bottleneck moved and the rules did not. Chapter Two found that education was unblocked and stopped being the constraint. Chapter Three found the constraint is now the structure of work and the allocation of children. No rule in Parts Two and Three addresses either. They were built for a world in which a woman's problem was access, and access is no longer the binding problem in the places where they are most strictly enforced.

The one entry that went the wrong way in the medical column was produced by the rules, not by the reforms. Section 5.4 found that ultrasound gave families a capability, and Part Two, Chapter Nine established what a family does with it: no pension, a son as the only instrument, a daughter as a transfer. That is the machine in Parts Two and Three, operating on a modern technology, producing a modern harm.

And the strongest positive result in the whole part is a case of the rules being suspended. India's village council reservation works by removing, for a third of positions, the ordinary operation of who gets to hold power. It is a rule about women, imposed against the existing rules about women, and it produced measurable change in spending and in what girls expected of themselves.

So the ledger does not merely fail to support the rules. It records that where they were suspended, outcomes moved, and where they operate, the gains that require permission do not arrive.

9.4 — And the question underneath

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Every attempt to score this ledger assumes **that the project had a goal.**
>
> You cannot say whether something succeeded without knowing what it was for. And Part Seven, Chapter Eight established that this particular thing had two aims which conflict: **equal freedom** and **equal outcomes**. Nobody chose between them. The philosophical case rested on the first; the institutions measure the second; and the drift happened because one is countable and the other is not.
>
> So the ledger gives two different verdicts and both are correct.
>
> **Measured against freedom** — can a woman own, earn, vote, leave, choose, refuse — the project in rich countries has substantially succeeded, and in India substantially has not. That is a clear answer and it is the answer to the question the movement originally asked.
>
> **Measured against outcomes** — proportional presence in fields, earnings and leadership — it stalled decades ago and Part Five suggests the target may not be reachable by these means.
>
> The general form: **scoring against a target chosen after the fact.** Whoever gets to name the goal determines the verdict, and in a dispute where nobody chose the goal, everybody names the one that produces the answer they wanted.

9.5 — What a ledger cannot do

One closing limitation, stated plainly because this part is the most numerical in the series and numbers invite more confidence than they earn.

A ledger records magnitudes. It cannot weigh them against each other, because the entries are in different units and no exchange rate exists.

How many percentage points of representation is a maternal death worth? How many hours of lost sleep against the ability to leave a marriage? How does a child a woman wanted and did not have compare against the years she gained by not dying in childbirth?

These are not hard questions. They are questions with no answer, because they require a common unit that does not exist — and Part Two's front matter identified the same problem in its first pages, when it noted that "was this good for women" requires adding together experiences that cannot be added.

What a ledger can do is stop people asserting magnitudes that are not there. It establishes that the medical column is larger than the political one, that the education reversal is larger than anybody says, that the earnings gap is not what it was described as, and that one number went the wrong way. Those are all real constraints on what a person may claim.

Anybody who tells you the ledger comes out positive or negative is adding across units. That is not a calculation they performed. It is a preference they held before they started.

REMEMBER THIS

The **medical column** is enormous, broadly distributed and uncontested, and reached everybody because it did not require anybody to ask. The **educational column** went further than predicted and mattered less than expected. The **economic column** moved fast for twenty years and stalled on a cause that is neither legal nor attitudinal. The **political column** moved slowly and is nowhere near proportional. The **costs column** has three real entries. And one measure went the wrong way.

The remaining gaps are evidence of different things in different places. **The barrier-removal instrument has largely exhausted itself where the barriers are gone, and has barely started where they are not** — and almost all the writing on this is produced in the first kind of country and read in the second.

And you cannot score a project without knowing its goal. Measured against **freedom**, it has substantially succeeded in rich countries and substantially not in India. Measured against **outcomes**, it stalled decades ago. Both verdicts are correct, nobody chose between the goals, and whoever names the goal determines the answer.

Finally, a ledger records magnitudes and cannot weigh them, because the entries are in different units. How many points of representation is a maternal death worth? Anybody telling you the ledger comes out positive or negative is adding across units — which is not a calculation they performed but a preference they held before they started.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List Of What We Do Not Know

Two lists, no hedging in either. What is genuinely unknown about the last sixty years, what is solid enough to build on, and the columns nobody keeps.

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

The unknowns in a ledger are of a particular kind: not what happened, but why, and what would have happened otherwise.

How much of this the movement caused. Chapter One set out why this is unresolvable in general. Antibiotics, contraception, collapsing child mortality, piped water and the shift from physical to literate work each transformed women's lives without requiring any politics. Nobody has apportioned them and both camps apportion confidently in opposite directions.

Why women's reported happiness fell. Seven explanations fit. None is established. Whether the decline continued past the period originally studied is disputed.

Why the economic convergence stalled when it did. The greedy-work account fits well and makes correct predictions. How much of the residue is structure and how much is discrimination has not been apportioned, and the honest range is wide.

Whether the education reversal will correct itself. Boys' relative decline has continued for four decades. Four accounts compete and none dominates. Nobody knows whether it stabilises, continues, or reverses.

What India's employment numbers actually mean. Part Five flagged this and it is unresolved. Recent Indian surveys report a substantial rise in women's workforce participation, and economists disagree about how much reflects women entering work against a change in how unpaid family labour is counted. Part Twelve takes it up and will not settle it either.

And whether the structural remedies work. The pharmacy case is one occupation that became substitutable by accident. Whether the effect generalises — whether deliberately redesigning work reduces the gap where legal remedies stopped — has not been tested at scale anywhere.

10.2 — Solid

That maternal mortality in India fell by more than four fifths in thirty years, from above five hundred per hundred thousand live births to below a hundred. Registered deaths against registered births, in a national system.

That Indian women went from dying younger than Indian men to outliving them. The crossover happened in the early 1980s. The anomaly it corrected had no biological basis, which means it recorded a deliberate allocation of food, medicine and care — and its reversal records the end of most of that.

That women out-graduate men at every level across most of the developed world, and that the gap favouring women now exceeds the gap that favoured men in the early 1970s. Administrative counts of degrees awarded.

That the assumption education was the bottleneck has been tested and failed. The education arrived and the rest did not follow — most starkly in India, which produces 43 per cent female STEM graduates and employs a fraction of them.

That earnings convergence stalled around 1990 in the United States and comparable countries, after two decades of rapid movement.

That the residue after adjustment is small — commonly five to eight per cent — which establishes the gap does not operate through unequal pay for identical work, and establishes nothing about whether the adjusted-away portions are fair.

That parliamentary representation rose from about one in nine to above one in four globally, and stands at about fourteen per cent in India.

That Norway's board quota changed boards and little else, while India's village council reservation changed spending and girls' attainment. Both findings are solid and they differ, and the likely difference is what the position controls.

That women's reported happiness declined absolutely and relative to men over the period studied, and that self-reported happiness barely moves for anybody in response to anything — which narrows the puzzle to the relative decline rather than the failure to rise.

That total work is roughly level between the sexes in rich countries and substantially higher for women in India.

And that the gains were distributed unevenly, with one exception. Everything requiring the recipient to attend, apply, travel or compete reached the women who were least constrained. The medical gains, which required nothing of her, reached everybody.

10.3 — The columns nobody keeps

One closing observation, following the pattern of the previous parts.

Look at what this part could be built from. Degrees awarded. Earnings recorded for tax. Seats counted in a chamber. Births and deaths registered. Hours reported to a time use survey.

Every one of those exists because an institution needed it for a purpose unconnected to this argument. Which is exactly what makes them reliable — and also what determines what could be counted at all.

So notice what has no column. Whether a woman was consulted about her own marriage. Whether she can leave a room without asking. Whether her opinion is solicited when money is spent. Whether the work she does is regarded by the people around her as work. Whether she is afraid in her own house.

Some of these are asked in specialised surveys and none is counted routinely, over decades, in a series that could show a trend. Which means **the entire ledger in this part is a record of the things that governments and employers had a reason to write down** — and Part Two, Chapter Ten reached the same conclusion about a very different archive four thousand years earlier.

The instruments changed. What they are pointed at did not.

REMEMBER THIS

Genuinely unknown: how much of this the movement caused rather than the century. Why reported happiness fell. Why economic convergence stalled when it did, and how much residue is structure against discrimination. Whether the education reversal corrects itself. What India's employment numbers actually mean. And whether structural remedies generalise beyond the one occupation that ran the experiment by accident.

Solid: Indian maternal mortality down more than four fifths. Indian women went from dying younger than men to outliving them, crossing over in the early 1980s. Women out-graduate men everywhere in the developed world, by a margin now exceeding the one that favoured men in the 1970s. Education was not the bottleneck. Earnings convergence stalled around 1990 and the adjusted residue is five to eight per cent. Representation rose to above one in four globally and stands at fourteen per cent in India. Norway's quota changed boards and little else while India's changed spending and girls' attainment. Reported happiness fell relative to men. Total work is level in rich countries and higher for women in India. And the gains were uneven except where they were delivered rather than claimed.

And notice what has no column. Whether a woman was consulted about her own marriage. Whether she can leave a room without asking. Whether her opinion is solicited when money is spent. Whether she is afraid in her own house. This ledger is a record of what governments and employers had a reason to write down — which is exactly what Part Two concluded about an archive four thousand years older. The instruments changed. What they are pointed at did not.

The Ledger

Sixty years on one sheet. Direction, rough magnitude, and — the column almost never included — which women it reached.

MEASURE	DIRECTION AND SIZE	REACHED WHOM
Maternal deaths (India)	Fell from above 500 per 100,000 live births to below 100. More than four fifths, in thirty years.	Everybody. Delivered rather than claimed.
Female against male life expectancy (India)	Crossed over in the early 1980s. Women now outlive men by around three years.	Everybody.
Child mortality (India)	Fell by roughly three quarters since 1990.	Everybody.
Fertility and contraception (India)	Total fertility below replacement. Majority use of modern contraception.	Broad, with the access problems Part Two recorded.
Higher education	Reversed. Women a majority of graduates across the developed world; India level or ahead on enrolment.	Educated and urban first; now broad in India.
STEM graduation (India)	Around 43 per cent women — ahead of Britain, France, Germany, the United States.	Urban and educated.
Employment (rich countries)	Rose steeply for four decades, then plateaued around 2000.	Educated women most.
Employment (India)	Flat or falling for decades; a recent reported rise whose interpretation is disputed.	Barely, and contested.
Earnings gap	Narrowed fast to about 1990, then close to flat. Residue after adjustment five to eight per cent.	Educated women most.

MEASURE	DIRECTION AND SIZE	REACHED WHOM
Parliamentary representation	From about 1 in 9 globally in 1995 to above 1 in 4. India at about 14 per cent.	Not a personal gain; an institutional one.
Corporate boards under quota	Changed immediately and completely where required. Little propagation below board level.	A very small number of women.
Intimate partner violence (US and comparable)	Fell sharply from the mid-1990s. Partner killings of women fell with it.	Broad.
Spousal violence (India)	From roughly three in ten ever-married women to slightly under. A decline, not a transformation.	Broad and small.
Total work, paid plus unpaid	Roughly level between the sexes in rich countries. Substantially higher for women in India.	—
Time with children	Rose across the transition. What fell was sleep, rest and unstructured hours.	Cost paid disproportionately by mothers.
Children wanted against children had	A persistent deficit in rich countries. Women end with fewer than they reported wanting.	Rich countries; arriving in urban India.
Marriage and partnership	Fell sharply, and the fall was concentrated among the less educated.	Negative, and concentrated on those with least.
Reported happiness	**Fell** — absolutely and relative to men — over the period studied. Unpredicted and unexplained.	Measured almost entirely in rich countries.

Two things are visible in that sheet that are not visible in any single chapter.

The largest entries are at the top and they are medical. Nothing in the political or economic rows is the same order of magnitude as maternal mortality falling by four fifths, and none of the medical rows appears on the ledgers either camp publishes.

And the right-hand column sorts almost perfectly. Everything that required a woman to attend, apply, travel, compete or be permitted reached the women who were least constrained. Everything delivered to her door reached everybody. That is the most useful line in this part and it is a fact about mechanisms, not about intentions.

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English. Each was explained where it first appeared.

TERM	PLAIN MEANING
Attribution	Deciding what caused an observed change when several things were happening at once and none can be switched off to check. Unsolvable in general; both camps do it confidently in opposite directions.
Baseline	The year a comparison counts from. Chosen rather than given, and choosing a trough produces a rising line by arithmetic rather than achievement.
Greedy work	A job that pays disproportionately more for long, inflexible and unpredictable hours. Where work is greedy, a couple maximises income by having one person absorb all of it — which produces specialisation without anybody discriminating.
Ledger	A record with two columns. Advocates publish gains and critics publish costs; neither is a ledger, because a ledger requires the same person to count both sides.
Maternal mortality ratio	Deaths of women from causes related to pregnancy and childbirth, per hundred thousand live births. India's fell from above 500 to below 100 within thirty years.
Substitutable work	Work where one qualified person can take over from another without loss, so hours can be arranged and nobody is irreplaceable at short notice. Pharmacy became this by accident and its gender earnings gap nearly closed.
Total fertility rate	The number of children an average woman has across her lifetime. India's has fallen below the level required to replace the population.
Total work	Paid employment plus unpaid domestic and care work added together. Roughly level between the sexes in rich countries; substantially higher for women in India.

About the Author

Who wrote this, what he is qualified to say, and what he is not.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it as The Living Archive. The previous project was a fourteen-part history of Punjab, running to roughly nine hundred and fifty pages, built on the same method as this one.

This is the most numerical part of the series and the least argumentative, deliberately. Six parts established what each side claims; this one asks what happened. Where I have an opinion it is confined to Chapter Nine and marked as one.

The specific error available in a part like this is false precision — reporting a figure to two decimal places when the underlying measurement is an estimate with a wide interval. Several Indian figures for earlier decades are reconstructions rather than counts, and I have given them as approximations and as directions rather than as values. Where a trend is disputed among people who work on it, Chapter Ten says so rather than picking the version that fits the surrounding argument.

The finding that most changed my own view while writing is in Chapter Eight. I had expected the distribution of gains to be uneven. I had not expected the pattern to sort so cleanly by *how a gain was delivered* — that everything requiring a woman to come and claim it reached the women who were least constrained, and that the one column reaching everybody was the one that arrived at the door. That is the most practically useful sentence in this part and I did not go looking for it.

The Living Archive — the three rules

Plain language. Every hard idea explained in ordinary words, on the spot, the first time it appears. Simplification is not compression — the simple version is usually longer, and nothing is dropped to make it easier.

Evidence, named. Where a claim rests on something, the something is named — the registered death, the degree awarded, the time use survey, the quota with a comparison group — along with what it cannot show.

Competing views at full strength. Every position gets the best case its own advocates would make. Where the evidence does not settle a question, the honest answer is that it does not.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of national statistics, international compilations and published research rather than new work.

The evidence here is unusually easy to rank and the ranking is stated in the front matter. Administrative counts are strongest: degrees awarded, births and deaths registered, seats in a chamber. Large national surveys with stable instruments come next — labour force surveys, time use surveys, the Indian health surveys. Self-rated measures are weakest, and Chapter Six rests entirely on them, which is why that chapter cannot be resolved and says so. Running through all of it is a limitation worth stating twice: the further back and the poorer the country, the worse the data, and part of the improvement in India's numbers reflects an improvement in India's counting.

Figures are given as approximations and as directions where the underlying estimates vary between sources, which is most of the Indian series before about 1990. Where a recent trend is contested among specialists — India's reported rise in women's workforce participation is the clearest case — I have said it is contested rather than choosing. Corrections are welcome and wanted, particularly from readers who work with these datasets, and later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Part Nine — The Arithmetic of Descendants. This part found a persistent gap between children wanted and children had. The next one follows that gap to its conclusion, which is the strongest argument the traditional side possesses.

- South Korea's fertility rate is around 0.7 children per woman. What does that number actually mean when you compound it — and how many generations does it take to become irreversible?
- The relationship between gender equality and fertility is not a downward line. It is a J. The countries collapsing fastest are not the most equal ones. What is the shape actually telling us, and which side does it favour?
- Traditional and religious populations out-reproduce secular ones, consistently, and the effect compounds across generations. How fast, and what does that do to a population's composition over a century?
- Has any country ever reversed a sustained fertility decline without reversing women's freedoms? What was tried, what was spent, and what happened?
- India crossed below replacement while this series was being written. What follows for a country with no pension system, where Part Two found a son *is* the pension?
- And the question this part could not answer: if women in rich countries end up with fewer children than they say they wanted, whose failure is that — and what would it take to close the gap between the two numbers?

END OF PART EIGHT OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part Nine — The Arithmetic of Descendants

Across most of the world, women are having fewer children than are needed to replace the people already alive. This part asks what that number really measures, why it fell, whether anybody has ever turned it round, and who would have to pay if somebody tried.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Eight was the least argumentative thing in this series. It was a ledger. I stopped arguing about whether the changes in women's lives over the last century were good or bad, and simply counted what had actually changed, and then added a second column that most people leave out: **who it reached**.

The counting showed something uncomfortable in both directions. A great deal really did change. Girls' schooling, women in paid work, laws on property and violence and divorce, deaths in childbirth, seats in legislatures — on almost every line the number moved, and on most of them it moved a long way. But the second column showed that the movement was not spread evenly. Many of the biggest gains landed hardest on women who were already urban, already schooled, already from families with money or standing. For a woman in a poor rural district, several lines on the ledger had barely moved at all. And on a few lines — unpaid work at home, safety, the amount of the day a woman gets to decide for herself — the number had hardly moved for anybody.

That part ended with one entry left blank. Every ledger has a column for what a thing cost, and I said I was not going to fill it in there, because the cost of the changes in Part Eight is not paid by the women in the ledger. It is paid, if it is paid at all, by people who do not exist yet.

This part fills that column in. It is about the one consequence of the last century that nobody planned, nobody voted for, and almost nobody predicted: across most of the world, and now across most of India, women are having fewer children than are needed to replace the people already here. That fact is now being used, very loudly, as an argument. It is being used to say the old rules were right after all. Before anybody can judge that argument, we have to know what the number actually is, what it measures, why it fell, and what happens next. That is this part.

How this document is built

If you have read the earlier parts you already know the notation. If this is the first one you have picked up, here is the whole system. There are six kinds of box. Each does one job, and each looks different so you can see at a glance what you are about to read.

The first kind explains a hard word the moment it turns up, so you never have to carry an unexplained term forward.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Demography:** the study of populations by counting them — how many people are born, how many die, how many move, and how old everybody is. It is one of the least glamorous fields in the social sciences and one of the most reliable, because most of what it studies can be counted rather than argued about.
>
> Why it matters here: nearly every claim in this document rests on a count, which means you can usually check who did the counting and how.

The second kind takes a number too big to picture and turns it into something with a body — a room, a wage, a walk, a week.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> India's population is around 1.46 billion people. That number means nothing to anybody. Try it this way instead: if you stood at a window and counted one Indian per second, without sleeping, without stopping, you would finish in about forty-six years.

The third kind shows you the actual evidence behind a claim, and then tells you what that evidence cannot show. It is the box that lets you decide how much to trust a sentence.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India does not learn its birth rate from the census. It learns it from the **Sample Registration System**, a survey that has watched the same set of about 8,800 sample areas continuously since the 1970s, recording every birth and death in them twice over — once by a local recorder living there, once by a visiting official — and then comparing the two lists.

What it is good at: consistency. The same method, year after year, so a change over time is a real change and not a change of ruler. What it is bad at: small groups. It does not report by caste, income or religion, so several arguments in this document have to be settled with other data or not settled at all.

The fourth kind is for places where informed people genuinely disagree. Each side gets its best case, not a version I find easy to knock down.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

Every one of these has the same shape. A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not pretend to more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds stupid here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes the honest answer is that nothing available would, and saying so tells you something.

The fifth kind is the one this series is built around. It does not argue with either side. It digs out the thing both sides are quietly assuming without noticing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

These are not caveats and not disclaimers. They are unexamined premises sitting underneath an argument everybody is having. There are five of them in this part. One of them is turned on this document itself, near the end.

The sixth kind closes every chapter. It restates the whole chapter in the plainest words available. If you read only these, you should still have the entire argument of this part.

REMEMBER THIS

Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.

The rule I hold myself to: simple words, serious content, nothing left out.

A warning specific to this part

Two, actually.

The first is about me. I am an Indian man, in my twenties, unmarried, with no children. This part is about how many children women have. I have never been on the receiving end of a single one of the costs I am about to describe, and I never will be. That does not disqualify me from writing it — but it does mean there is one particular mistake I am likely to make, which is to treat the number of babies as an interesting arithmetic problem rather than as several hundred million individual pregnancies happening inside individual bodies. Where I catch myself doing it, I will say so in the text. Chapter Nine is where this matters most, and I flag it again there.

The second is about the material. Fertility numbers are now political ammunition in India, in Europe, in America and across East Asia. They are used to argue about immigration, about religion, about feminism, about which states get how many seats in a parliament. That means a great deal of what is published about them is written to reach a conclusion. I am going to give you the numbers, tell you who produced them, and tell you where the honest disagreements are. Where a figure is contested I will give the range and explain why the ends of it differ. Where I do not know, I will say so, and Chapter Ten is nothing but that.

One more thing before we start. This part contains no argument that any woman should have more children, and no argument that any woman should have fewer. That is not modesty. It is the method. My job is to show you what is actually happening and what each side actually has, and then get out of the way.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The Number That Decides Everything

> *One figure is doing all the work in this argument. Almost nobody who quotes it knows what it measures. It is not a count of anybody's children, and it is not a record of what any woman decided.*

1.1 — A rate is not a count

You will have seen the number. Someone says India's fertility rate has fallen to 1.9. Someone else says South Korea's is 0.8. A third person says that below 2.1 a country is finished. The number gets thrown around in newspaper headlines, in speeches by chief ministers, in arguments online about feminism and immigration and the end of the West.

Almost everyone quoting it thinks it means something like "the average woman is having 1.9 children." That is close enough to be useful and wrong enough to matter. Before we go any further we have to be exact about what is being measured, because half the arguments in the rest of this document turn on the difference.

WORD BOX

Total Fertility Rate (TFR): take every woman in a country in a single year. Sort them by age. For each age, work out what share of the women that age gave birth this year. Then add all those shares together, from age fifteen to age forty-nine.

The answer is the number of children one imaginary woman would end up with *if* she lived her whole life through, and *if* at every age she behaved exactly like the real women of that age did this year.

Why it matters: that woman does not exist. She is a construction. The TFR is not a count of anybody's family. It is a summary of one year, dressed up to look like a life.

Read that last line twice, because it is the source of most of the confusion in this field. When a newspaper says the fertility rate is 1.9, no woman anywhere has had 1.9 children. What has happened is that this year's births, spread across this year's women of each age, add up to a pattern which — if frozen and run through a whole lifetime — would produce 1.9 children.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The figure comes from adding up **age-specific fertility rates**. In India's Sample Registration System for 2023, the highest of those rates is among women aged 25 to 29, at about 137 births per thousand women that age in that year. The next highest is the 20-to-24 group, at about 108.
>
> What that tells you: roughly fourteen out of every hundred women aged 25 to 29 gave birth during 2023. What it cannot tell you: whether those were the same women who gave birth two years earlier, whether they intend to have more, or whether the women who did not give birth are childless or simply not this year.
>
> Independent confirmation exists. Hospital delivery records, immunisation registers and the household surveys run every few years by the health ministry produce the same broad picture. When a survey, a hospital ledger and a village recorder all agree, the number is real.

So the number is a snapshot, not a biography. Hold on to that. Now to the line everybody quotes.

1.2 — Why the line sits at 2.1, and not at 2

Two people make a child. So you might think that two children per woman would keep a population exactly level. It does not, for two reasons, and both of them are arithmetic rather than opinion.

The first is that slightly more boys are born than girls. Everywhere in the world, without anybody arranging it, about 105 boys are born for every 100 girls. So to replace one woman with one woman, you need a bit more than two births.

The second is that not every girl born survives to have children of her own. In a country where almost every child lives, that adds only a small amount. In a country where children still die, it adds a lot.

WORD BOX

Replacement level: the fertility rate at which each generation exactly replaces the one before it, ignoring migration.

In a rich country with very low child mortality it is about **2.1**. In a country where children still die in significant numbers it can be 2.3, 2.5, or higher. The commonly quoted 2.1 is not a law of nature. It is a figure that assumes almost every girl born will live to adulthood.

This matters more than it sounds. When someone says India crossed below replacement, they are using 2.1 as the line. Fifty years ago, India's true replacement level would have been noticeably higher than 2.1, because more Indian children died. The line has moved down towards us at the same time as the number has fallen towards it. Both halves of that are the same underlying story: children stopped dying.

1.3 — The snapshot problem

Now the hardest idea in this chapter, and one you need in order to read Chapter Six honestly.

Suppose every woman in a country decides to have exactly two children, but the whole country decides to start five years later than their mothers did. In the years while everyone is postponing, very few births happen. The TFR collapses — perhaps to 1.2. Newspapers announce a crisis. Then the postponement finishes, those women start having their two children each, and the TFR climbs back up.

Nobody changed their mind about how many children to have. Only the timing changed. But the yearly number swung wildly, because the yearly number is a snapshot of a moving thing.

WORD BOX

Period fertility: the snapshot. All the births in one calendar year, across women of every age. This is what the headline TFR is.

Cohort fertility: the real thing. Take all the women born in, say, 1975. Wait until they are fifty. Count how many children they actually had. That is a true average, and it has one enormous drawback: you have to wait thirty-five years to learn it.

Tempo effect: the distortion the snapshot suffers when people are shifting the timing of births. Postponement pushes the period number down below the truth. A catch-up pushes it up above the truth.

Demographers have known this since the 1990s, and there are standard adjustments for it. The most widely used, developed by John Bongaarts and Griffith Feeney in 1998, strips out the timing shift and estimates what the number would be if nobody were postponing. Almost always, the adjusted figure is higher than the headline figure — usually by a tenth to three tenths of a child.

IN REAL TERMS

Across Europe, women born in the 1970s are finishing their reproductive lives with a real, completed average of roughly 1.7 to 1.8 children each. During the same decades, the headline period rate for those countries was often quoted at 1.4 or 1.5.

The gap between those two figures is roughly one extra child for every four women. That is not a rounding error. It is the difference between a slow decline and a collapse, and it is entirely produced by the fact that women were having their children later, not by their having fewer.

Now the honest complication. Tempo adjustment does not make the problem go away, and it can be misused in the other direction. Postponement is not free. A woman who plans two children at thirty-eight does not always get two children at thirty-eight. Some of the postponed births are never made up. So the truth sits between the two figures: the headline number overstates the fall, and the adjusted number understates it.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE HEADLINE NUMBER TELLING US THE TRUTH?

This is the first real disagreement in this document, and it sits underneath everything that follows. When Korea reports 0.72, or India reports 1.9, how much of that is a genuine drop in how many children women will end up with, and how much is an artefact of a moving clock?

READ IT AT FACE VALUE

The period rate is what it is, and it is the number that determines how many babies are actually born this year. Schools, hospitals, pension funds and labour markets do not respond to a woman's eventual completed family — they respond to how many children are actually in the country. Postponed births are also births that are not happening now, and a birth delayed twelve years is a generation lengthened by twelve years, which itself slows population growth even if the total is unchanged. And in the very low countries the postponement explanation has run out of room: Korean women have been postponing for thirty years, and at some point a permanent delay is simply a decline.

ADJUST BEFORE YOU PANIC

Almost every dramatic fertility headline of the last twenty years has been at least partly a timing illusion, and the illusion runs in a predictable direction. Look at what happened in Central Europe: the celebrated fertility *rises* of the 2010s largely vanish once you adjust for the slowing of postponement, which means the rises were not real either. If the adjustment cuts against your side sometimes and for it other times, it is a measurement correction and not a debating trick. Judge a country by the completed families of women who have finished, not by a synthetic woman who has never lived.

Where things stand: both sides are right about different things, and specialists mostly agree on this. Tempo effects are real, large, and explain a substantial share of the decline in countries in the middle of the range. They do not explain the extreme cases. Korea's completed cohort fertility is falling too, just less steeply than the headline. The honest summary is that the world's real fertility decline is smaller than the headlines suggest and still very large.

What would settle it: waiting. In about fifteen years we will know the completed family size of women born in the 1990s, and the argument will be over for that generation. There is no way to get the answer sooner, which is precisely why the argument persists.

Why people care so much: because the size of the number decides whether governments are facing a manageable adjustment or an emergency, and emergencies justify measures that adjustments do not.

That argument is about measurement. There is a bigger thing being assumed underneath it, by both sides, and neither of them says it out loud.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE NUMBER IS A DECISION

Listen to how the fertility rate gets discussed, by anyone, on any side. "Women are choosing to have fewer children." "Young people have decided family is not for them." "She is choosing a career instead." Even the people who disagree furiously about whether this is good or bad agree completely that what the number records is a **choice**.

But the TFR does not measure choices. It measures outcomes. Between the choosing and the outcome sit a great many things that are not choices at all: whether you found a partner, whether the partner wanted the same thing, whether either of you could afford a flat, whether the pregnancy took, whether the pregnancy held, whether the job survived it, whether anybody was available to mind the child, whether your body was still fertile by the time the rest of your life had arranged itself.

The surveys make the gap visible, and it runs both ways. People in low-fertility countries typically say they want about two children and end up with roughly half a child fewer. In India, about one woman in five reports having had *more* children than she intended. Chapter Nine goes through that evidence properly.

> **The general form:** reading a result as an intention. The same mistake appears everywhere. Exam results are read as effort. Wealth is read as choice. A number that emerges from thousands of constraints is handed back to the person as though they had picked it off a menu.
>
> Why this one matters so much: if the number is a choice, then the correct response is persuasion or pressure, and both are aimed at women. If the number is an outcome, then the correct response is to look at the constraints. Every argument in Chapters Six and Nine is really a fight about which of those two it is.

1.4 — Why the population keeps growing anyway

One last piece of arithmetic before we look at what actually happened, because it explains something that confuses almost everybody.

India's fertility rate has been at or below replacement for several years. India's population is still growing, and is projected to keep growing for decades, peaking somewhere around 1.7 billion. How can both be true?

> WORD BOX
>
> **Population momentum:** the tendency of a population to keep growing after fertility has fallen to replacement, because of the shape of its age pyramid.
>
> Picture it with a family. Suppose your grandmother had six children, and each of them had two. There are now far more women of childbearing age in your family than there were in hers, even though every one of them is having a small family. The total number of babies being born in the family goes up, not down, for a whole generation.
>
> India is that family. It has a very large number of young women, because their mothers' generation was large. Even at 1.9 children each, that produces a great many births.

Momentum is why the two commonest claims about India — "we have far too many people" and "we are about to run out of people" — are both being made at the same time by serious people, and why both can point at real numbers. One is describing the size of the population. The other is describing its direction. They are different facts.

It also means something else, which matters for everything in Chapter Seven. Momentum runs in reverse too. Once the large generations pass through, a country with few young women has few births even if each of them has three children. By the time a shrinking population becomes obvious, the decisions that caused it were taken thirty years earlier. There is no fast lever. That is not a political claim; it is a property of how generations work.

REMEMBER THIS

The **Total Fertility Rate** is not a count of anybody's children. It is a snapshot of one year, arranged to look like a lifetime. The imaginary woman it describes does not exist.

The **replacement line** sits at about 2.1 rather than 2.0 because slightly more boys are born than girls, and because not every girl survives to adulthood. In poorer countries the true line is higher.

The snapshot is distorted by **timing**. When people postpone childbearing, the yearly number falls below the truth. Adjusting for that usually adds a tenth to three tenths of a child. It does not make the decline disappear, but it does make it smaller than the headlines say.

Momentum means a population keeps growing for decades after fertility falls, and keeps shrinking for decades after it rises. Nothing here responds quickly to anything.

The number everybody is arguing about is not a record of what women decided. It is a record of what happened.

CHAPTER TWO

What Actually Happened

> *In one human lifetime the world's fertility rate has roughly halved. It has happened in rich countries and poor ones, in Catholic countries and Muslim ones, under communism and under capitalism, and almost nobody predicted the speed.*

2.1 — The whole world, in one paragraph

In the early 1950s, the average woman on Earth had about five children. As of the mid-2020s she has about 2.25. That is the entire story in two numbers, and it is one of the largest changes in human behaviour ever recorded.

It did not happen evenly. It started in Europe in the nineteenth century and moved slowly. It reached the rest of the world in the second half of the twentieth century and moved fast. In some countries the fall from six children to two took a hundred and fifty years. In others it took twenty-five.

IN REAL TERMS

Take a woman in Iran born in 1955. Her mother had six or seven children. Her granddaughter is likely to have one, or none. Three generations — grandmother, mother, daughter — and the family has gone from a crowded house to an empty one.

Now put a number on the speed. Iran's fertility rate fell from about 6.5 in the mid-1980s to about 2.0 by the year 2000. That is the same distance England travelled between roughly 1850 and 1970, done in fifteen years.

The United Nations estimates that one in four people on Earth now lives in a country whose population has already peaked and begun to fall. That group includes China, Japan, Germany, Italy and Russia. The world total is still rising, and on the UN's central projection will keep rising to a peak of about 10.3 billion in the middle of the 2080s, from about 8.2 billion in 2024. After that it goes down.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

There are two kinds of evidence behind these numbers and they have different weaknesses.

Vital registration. Rich countries record every birth as a legal event, because a birth certificate is needed for school, passport and inheritance. These numbers are close to exact. Korea can tell you how many babies were born last September.

Sample surveys. Poorer countries estimate from surveys — the Demographic and Health Surveys, and in India the Sample Registration System and the National Family Health Survey. These have real error bars, particularly for small states and short time periods.

What both are bad at: the very recent past. Anything from the last twelve months is provisional and gets revised. What they are good at: direction. When registration data, survey data and school enrolment numbers all point the same way for a decade, the direction is not in doubt even if the second decimal place is.

2.2 — The bottom of the table

The lowest fertility rates ever recorded in peacetime are being recorded now, and almost all of them are in East Asia.

South Korea is the extreme case and deserves its own paragraph, because it has now done both things — fallen further than anyone and then started to come back. Its rate fell to **0.72 in 2023**, the lowest national figure ever recorded anywhere. Then it rose to 0.75 in 2024 and to about 0.80 in 2025, on provisional figures. In Seoul, the capital, the 2025 figure was 0.63. Chapter Six deals with what that rebound does and does not mean; for now, note only that even after two years of rising, Korea sits at roughly a third of replacement.

Around it: Taiwan and Hong Kong are below 0.9. China is somewhere around 1.0, and its population has been falling since 2022. Japan is at about 1.2 and has been below replacement since 1974 — half a century. Singapore, which has run pronatalist policy since 1987, fell below 1.0 for the first time in 2023.

Europe is less extreme but the direction has surprised people who thought the Nordic countries had solved it. Finland's rate fell from about 1.87 in 2010 to below 1.3. Norway fell from about 1.98 to around 1.4. These are countries with a year of paid parental leave, cheap universal childcare and among the highest rates of women in paid work in the world. Whatever the answer is, generous family policy alone is not it. That fact is inconvenient for two different political camps at once, which is a good sign it is worth taking seriously.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Lowest-low fertility:** a term coined by demographers in the year 2000 for a total fertility rate at or below 1.3. At the time it was thought of as a rare, temporary state that a few countries had stumbled into.
>
> Why it matters: at 1.3, each generation is about 40 per cent smaller than the one before it. Two generations of that and the number of young people has roughly halved. When the term was invented, a handful of countries were there. Several are now well below it, and 1.3 has stopped being the floor of the conversation and become the middle of it.

The United States is at about 1.6, France at about 1.6 to 1.7 after decades as the highest in Western Europe, Italy and Spain around 1.2. None of these is the anomaly. Israel is the anomaly, at about 2.9, and it is the only rich democracy that has never fallen below replacement. Chapter Six comes back to it, because it is the single most important test case anyone has.

2.3 — The middle of the world caught up faster than anyone expected

The part that broke the old textbooks is what happened in countries that were still poor.

Thailand, a middle-income country with no coercive population policy, is now around 1.0 to 1.2, lower than most of Europe. Iran, an Islamic republic that once actively encouraged large families, is around 1.6. Brazil, Turkey, Chile, Colombia and Tunisia are all below replacement. Bangladesh, the standard example of hopeless overpopulation in the 1970s, is at about 2.1.

This mattered intellectually. The old model said fertility falls when a country gets rich. These countries fell before they got rich, so whatever drives this is not simply money.

WORD BOX

The demographic transition: the standard model of how populations change. Stage one: many births, many deaths, population flat. Stage two: deaths fall first (because of clean water, vaccines and food), births stay high, population explodes. Stage three: births fall too. Stage four: few births, few deaths, population flat again at a much larger size.

Why it matters: every country that has gone through it has followed the same sequence. What the model got wrong was the timing of stage three, which has arrived earlier and moved faster almost everywhere than the people who built the model expected. It also assumed stage four was a resting place. It is now clear that many countries do not stop at replacement. They go straight through it.

2.4 — India is fourteen different countries

Now to India, where the national number hides more than it shows.

The Sample Registration System reported India's total fertility rate at **1.9 in 2023**, down from 2.0 in 2021 and 2022. By Indian official estimates the country crossed below replacement around 2019. Urban India crossed in 2004 — twenty years earlier. In 2023, for the first time, rural India reached 2.1 as well.

Underneath that national 1.9 the range is enormous. Delhi reported 1.2. West Bengal and Tamil Nadu reported 1.3. Maharashtra 1.4. Andhra Pradesh and Telangana are around 1.6 to 1.7. Kerala has been below replacement since the late 1980s. At the other end, Bihar reported 2.8. Eighteen states and union territories are now below the replacement line, and a handful of northern states are holding the national average up almost single-handedly.

IN REAL TERMS

Tamil Nadu at 1.3 is at roughly the same fertility level as Italy. Delhi at 1.2 is at roughly the same level as Spain. Bihar at 2.8 is at roughly the level of Egypt.

Put it another way. Two women meet on a train between Patna and Chennai. Statistically, the first will have about twice as many children as the second. They hold the same passport, vote in the same national election, and are governed by the same central laws on marriage and inheritance. Almost nothing else about their reproductive lives is the same.

The urban–rural split says the same thing from another angle: urban India is at 1.5, rural India at 2.1. And the strongest single predictor of all — stronger than religion, stronger than income — is how long the mother stayed in school. Chapter Five takes that apart properly.

There is one more Indian number that belongs here, because it is the hinge of Chapter Seven. Those below-replacement states are also the ones that are ageing fastest. In Kerala, about fifteen in every hundred people are already over sixty. Nationally the figure is under ten. The parts of India that succeeded at family planning are the parts that will hit the pension problem first, and they will hit it while the country as a whole still thinks of itself as young.

2.5 — The part of the world that has not done it yet

Sub-Saharan Africa is the exception, and its numbers are the biggest single source of uncertainty in every long-run projection on Earth. The region's average is around 4.3. Niger is close to 6. The Democratic Republic of Congo and several neighbours are above 5. Nigeria, with more than 200 million people, is around 4.5.

Fertility there is falling, but slowly, and the pace of the fall is genuinely disputed.

THE ARGUMENT — HOW FAST WILL AFRICAN FERTILITY FALL?

This sounds like a technical question for demographers. It is not. Whether world population peaks at 9 billion in 2060 or 10.3 billion in 2085 depends almost entirely on the answer, and so does every argument in Chapter Eight about whether humanity is about to shrink.

IT WILL FALL AS FAST AS EVERYWHERE ELSE, OR FASTER

Every region that has begun this transition has completed it more quickly than the region before it, because the tools arrive ready-made. Contraception, girls' schooling, mobile phones and urban living all arrive in Africa simultaneously rather than over a century. Iran did it in fifteen years. Bangladesh did it while poor. Recent survey rounds in several African countries have come in below what the UN projected, and the UN has revised its global peak down by about 700 million people compared with what it was saying a decade ago. The revisions have all gone one way.

IT WILL TAKE MUCH LONGER

The countries with the highest fertility are also the ones with the weakest schooling systems, the least urbanisation, the youngest age at marriage and the highest child mortality — and child mortality is the strongest single brake, because parents who expect to bury children have more of them. Desired family size in surveys across much of West and Central Africa remains genuinely high, at four, five or six children, which is not a supply problem that contraception fixes. Projecting a fast African decline mostly assumes that the future will not look like the past twenty years there, and that is an assumption, not a finding.

Where things stand: the direction is agreed and the speed is not. Everybody expects African fertility to fall. The credible range for when the region reaches replacement runs from around 2050 to around 2090, which is a forty-year spread and produces wildly different worlds.

What would settle it: the next three rounds of Demographic and Health Surveys, over roughly the next decade. This is one of the rare arguments in this document where the settling evidence is actually coming, on a known schedule.

Why people care so much: because one answer produces a story about a crowded, young, African-majority future and the other produces a story about global depopulation. Both stories are already being used in immigration politics in Europe, and both sides reach for the projection that suits them.

One honest note about all projections, including the ones I have just quoted. Demographers have a poor record on fertility and a good one on mortality. Deaths are predictable; people age at a fixed rate. Births are not. Almost every major projection of the last seventy years has been wrong about fertility, usually by assuming the current trend would flatten out when it did not. Treat the population peak numbers in this document as the best available guesses and not as facts.

REMEMBER THIS

In one lifetime, the average number of children per woman worldwide has fallen from about **five to about 2.25**. This is one of the biggest behavioural changes ever recorded, and it happened almost everywhere.

The lowest figures are in **East Asia**. Korea hit 0.72 in 2023, the lowest ever recorded anywhere, and has since risen to about 0.80. Even the generous Nordic countries have fallen sharply, which means money and childcare alone are not the answer.

It happened in **poor countries too**, and fast. Iran fell from 6.5 to 2.0 in fifteen years. Thailand and Brazil are below most of Europe. The old idea that fertility falls only when a country gets rich is dead.

India is not one country on this measure. Delhi is at 1.2 and Bihar at 2.8. Eighteen states are below replacement. Urban India crossed the line in 2004; the nation crossed around 2019.

Sub-Saharan Africa is the only region still well above replacement, and how fast it falls decides what the whole world's population does this century.

CHAPTER THREE

Why It Fell

> *Seven explanations are offered, and they are usually offered as rivals. Most of them are true. The interesting question is not which one is right but which one arrives first, because that determines what you would have to undo.*

3.1 — Children stopped dying

This is the first cause, the biggest, and the one people leave out of political arguments because it is not politically useful to anybody.

For almost all of human history, a very large share of children died before they were five. In many places it was one in three. A woman who wanted two grown-up children had to give birth four, five or six times, and bury the difference. High birth rates were not a sign of enthusiasm. They were a response to death.

Then, over roughly a century, that stopped. Clean water, sewers, vaccines, antibiotics, oral rehydration for diarrhoea, more food. India's infant mortality rate has fallen to about 25 deaths per thousand live births, from more than 140 in the 1970s.

IN REAL TERMS

An Indian woman giving birth in 1970 could expect roughly one in seven of her babies to die before their first birthday. Today it is about one in forty.

Turn that around into the decision she faces. In 1970, to be reasonably confident of ending up with two adult children, she needed to give birth three times. Today she needs to give birth twice. The **same want, the same worry, produces one fewer pregnancy.** Not one woman in that story changed her mind about anything.

This is why the demographic transition happens in that order everywhere: deaths fall, then births fall, with a lag of a generation or two. The lag is the whole problem — it is the population explosion. It is also why a country's fertility decline usually cannot be stopped by persuasion. What is being adjusted to is a change in survival, and nobody wants to undo that.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The strongest evidence is not a correlation, it is a set of long-running field studies. The best known is at **Matlab in Bangladesh**, where since 1966 a research station has recorded every birth, death and move in a set of villages, house by house, for sixty years. In 1977 half the villages were given an intensive family planning and maternal health programme and half were not, and both halves have been followed ever since.

What it shows: fertility fell in the treated villages faster than in the untreated ones, so services matter. But it also fell substantially in the **untreated** villages, so services are not the whole story. And in both halves, the fall followed improvements in child survival rather than leading them.

What it cannot show: whether the same would happen in a country with a different family structure. One district in Bangladesh is one district in Bangladesh. Its great value is that it is real, long, and not reconstructed from memory.

3.2 — The child stopped being an asset

On a farm, a child of eight can weed, carry water, mind goats and watch a younger sibling. By twelve a child is close to an adult worker. Children cost food and produce labour, and past a certain age the labour is worth more than the food.

In a city, with a school, a child is a pure cost for twenty years. Fees, books, uniforms, tuition, a room, and — this is the part people underestimate — an adult's attention, every day, for two decades.

WORD BOX

The quantity–quality trade-off: an idea from the economist Gary Becker in the 1960s. Parents are not choosing only how many children to have. They are choosing how much to invest in each one. Once investing more in each child starts to pay — because schooling leads to jobs — parents shift towards fewer children with more spent on each.

Why it matters: this predicts that fertility falls fastest exactly where education starts to pay off, which is what the data shows. It also predicts something less comfortable: the shift is not a retreat from family. It is a family strategy. Fewer children is what caring about your children looks like once schooling is the route out.

You can watch this happen inside a single Indian family across two generations. The grandfather has five children and no fees to pay. The son has two children and pays for coaching classes for both. Ask either of them whether they love their children and you get the same answer. The arithmetic underneath is completely different.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> For an urban household with one modest salary, a private school place, books, uniform, transport and a couple of tuition subjects can absorb most of what is left after rent and food. Two children can be carried. A fourth cannot, unless all four get the cheaper version.
>
> So the trade-off is not between children and no children. **It is between two children with coaching and four children without.** Almost every Indian family making that calculation now makes it one way, their parents made it the other way, and neither generation was being foolish.

3.3 — Schooling, and what it actually does

Across almost every dataset ever assembled, the strongest single predictor of how many children a woman has is how long she stayed in school. It beats income. It usually beats religion. In India's own health surveys the gap between women with no schooling and women who finished twelve years is often more than a full child.

The interesting question is *why*, because at least four different mechanisms are hiding inside "education", and they have different implications.

Schooling delays marriage, which shortens the years available for childbearing. It teaches literacy, which changes what health information a woman can get and act on. It changes what a woman believes she is allowed to want, and what she can argue for at home. And it raises what her hour of time is worth on the open market, which is the mechanism the economists care about most.

WORD BOX

Opportunity cost: what you give up in order to do a thing. Not what it costs in money — what it costs in the next-best option you had to drop.

Applied here: for a woman with no schooling and no paid work available, the opportunity cost of a pregnancy is close to zero, because there is nothing else she would have been paid for. For a woman with a degree and a salary, a pregnancy may cost several years of earnings, a promotion, and a permanent step down in what she is paid for the rest of her working life.

Why it matters: this is the single most important idea in the chapter. Nothing about her desire for children has changed. **The price has changed.** And the price rose precisely because her options improved.

That last line is uncomfortable for both camps in the argument this series is about, which is why I want it stated plainly. If you believe expanding women's options was right, you have to accept that the fertility decline is partly a direct result of it, and not an unrelated accident. If you believe the fertility decline is a disaster, you have to accept that reversing it means either lowering the price of children or lowering the value of a woman's alternatives. Chapter Nine is where that fork gets examined properly, and there is no third road that anybody has found.

3.4 — Contraception: necessary, not sufficient

The pill, the intrauterine device, sterilisation, the condom. Obviously these matter. A woman cannot act on a decision to stop having children if she has no means of stopping.

But contraception on its own explains much less than people expect, and there are two clean pieces of evidence for that. First, fertility fell dramatically in nineteenth-century France and in parts of Europe long before modern contraception existed, using withdrawal, abstinence and later marriage. Second, in the Matlab study above, fertility fell in the villages that got no programme too.

The honest way to put it: contraception is the **tool**, not the **motive**. Where people want fewer children and have no tools, they find worse tools and use them, at real cost to women's health. Where people want more children, handing out contraception does very little. India's own experience proves the point from the ugly side — the coercive sterilisation drive of 1975 to 1977 produced millions of operations and a political catastrophe, and India's fertility decline continued afterwards at roughly the pace it would have anyway.

3.5 — The pension that used to have a face

Here is a cause that gets almost no attention outside demography, and it is the one that connects this chapter to Chapter Seven.

For most of human history, children were the retirement system. There was no other. You had sons so that somebody would feed you at seventy, and you had several because some would die and some would leave. In much of India this is still literally true, and it is still enforced — India has a law, the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act of 2007, that obliges children to maintain their elderly parents and gives parents a tribunal to go to if they do not.

When a state pension arrives, that motive weakens. You no longer need a son to survive old age. Several careful studies across different countries have found that the introduction or expansion of public pensions is followed by measurable falls in fertility.

Note what this means. A society that builds an old-age safety net reduces the reason to have children, which reduces the number of workers available to fund the safety net. That is not an argument against pensions. It is a genuine circularity sitting inside the design of every modern welfare state, and almost nobody planned for it.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT ACTUALLY CAUSED THE DECLINE?

Everything above is agreed to matter. The dispute is about which cause does the heavy lifting, because that determines what a government could even in principle change.

IT IS DEVELOPMENT

Fertility falls when child mortality falls, cities grow, schooling spreads and children become expensive. The mechanism is material, it is the same everywhere, and the sequence is remarkably consistent across a hundred and fifty years and every continent. The best evidence is the sheer regularity: countries as different as Sweden, South Korea, Iran and Brazil have followed the same curve at different times. That is not a coincidence of culture. It is a response to conditions.

IT IS IDEAS, AND THEY TRAVEL

Development cannot explain the speed. Iran did in fifteen years what England did in a hundred and twenty, without a comparable rise in income. Fertility fell in Thailand and Bangladesh while both were still poor. What actually spreads is the **idea** that a small family is normal, respectable and achievable — carried by radio, then television, then the phone. The classic finding here is that fertility decline in nineteenth-century Europe followed language and cultural boundaries more closely than it followed income. It spread the way a fashion spreads, not the way a price responds.

IT IS THE PRICE OF A WOMAN'S TIME

Both of the above are describing the same underlying thing badly. What changed is that women acquired alternatives. Every factor listed — schooling, cities, jobs, contraception, later marriage — raises what a woman gives up by having a child. On this account fertility did not fall because families got richer or because ideas travelled, but because the cost of childbearing shifted onto a person who now had something else to do with her twenties. The strongest evidence is that within every country, at every income level, the women with the most alternatives have the fewest children.

Where things stand: these are less rival than they sound, and most demographers now hold a mixed position. Development sets the stage, ideas set the speed, and the price of a woman's time determines where the number settles. The genuine dispute is about the last one: whether it is the master variable or one factor among several.

What would settle it: nothing clean, and this is worth being honest about. You cannot run the experiment. The closest thing available is careful comparison of places where one factor moved and the others did not — a state that expanded schooling without industrialising, a region that got television before it got roads — and that work exists but is patchy and contested.

Why people care so much: because each answer implies a different lever. If it is development, nothing can be done and nothing should be. If it is ideas, then propaganda and cultural revival might work, which is what religious and nationalist movements believe. If it is the price of a woman's time, then raising fertility means changing something about women's options or about who bears the cost of children — and those are very different policies with very different politics.

Underneath that whole argument, all three positions share a picture of who is doing the deciding, and it is worth stopping on.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT CHILDREN ARE DECIDED ON BY COUPLES

Every model above imagines a woman, or a woman and a man, weighing costs and benefits and arriving at a family size. Economists model it as a household budget. Sociologists model it as a couple negotiating. Traditionalists model it as a couple failing in their duty. Feminists model it as a woman finally being allowed to decide. All four are assuming the same thing: that the decision is made by the people who will raise the child.

For most of history, and for a very large number of Indian households right now, it is not. In a joint family, whether and when a young wife becomes pregnant has often been decided, or heavily steered, by her mother-in-law and by her husband's family — for reasons to do with property, labour, the succession of the household, and the standing of the family in the village. Studies of contraceptive use in north India repeatedly find that the mother-in-law's view predicts the daughter-in-law's behaviour better than the daughter-in-law's own stated preference does. The United

> Nations survey mentioned in Chapter One found one Indian woman in five reporting more children than she intended, and the most common reason given was what her community expected.
>
> So when a country urbanises and young couples move away into their own flats, something happens that has nothing to do with income, schooling or contraception: **the decision changes hands.** A whole layer of people who wanted more grandchildren is removed from the room. Some part of the fertility decline is not a change of mind at all. It is a change of who holds the pen.
>
> **The general form:** assuming that the modern decision-unit was always the decision-unit. It appears everywhere — in economics, where the household is treated as a single mind; in law, where the couple is treated as the family; in policy, where a cash incentive is aimed at a person who may not be the one deciding.
>
> What follows is practical. A payment offered to a young couple for a third child is being offered into a negotiation whose other participants are invisible to the policy — which may be part of why such payments work as poorly as Chapter Six shows.

Put all seven causes together and they point one way. Every single one of them made a child more expensive — in money, in years, in attention, or in what somebody had to give up to have one. Nobody legislated that. It is what a century of falling child mortality, spreading schools and growing cities does to the arithmetic of a family.

REMEMBER THIS

Children stopped dying. That is the first and biggest cause. When a woman no longer has to give birth five times to raise three adults, she gives birth fewer times without changing a single thing about what she wants.

Children stopped being workers and became investments. On a farm a child earns; in a city with a school a child costs for twenty years. Families shifted from many children to few children with more spent on each. That is a family strategy, not a rejection of family.

Schooling is the strongest single predictor — stronger than income, usually stronger than religion. It works by delaying marriage, changing what a woman knows, changing what she can argue for, and raising what her time is worth elsewhere.

Contraception is the tool, not the motive. Fertility fell in Europe before modern contraception existed, and India's coercive sterilisation drive of the 1970s did not change the underlying trend.

Every explanation on the table describes the same event from a different angle: having a child got more expensive, and the person it got most expensive for was the mother.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Curve That Was Supposed to Come Back Up

> *For about a decade there was a comforting answer: development pushes fertility down, and then, past a certain point, pushes it back up again. The comfort has largely gone. What replaced it is more interesting and much harder to act on.*

4.1 — The paper that gave everyone hope

In August 2009 three demographers — Mikko Myrskylä, Hans-Peter Kohler and Francesco Billari — published a short paper in the journal *Nature* that changed the conversation. They plotted every country's fertility rate against a broad measure of its development, and found something nobody expected.

Fertility fell as development rose, exactly as the textbooks said. But past a very high level of development, the line turned. In the most developed countries, further development was associated with fertility going back *up*. Drawn on a chart, the relationship looked like the letter J lying on its side: a long fall, a bottom, and a lift at the far end.

WORD BOX

Human Development Index (HDI): a single score between 0 and 1 that combines three things — how long people live, how much schooling they get, and how much income they have. Invented by the United Nations in 1990 so that countries could be compared on something other than money alone.

Why it matters here: the entire J-curve finding was expressed in terms of the HDI. The turning point was put at about 0.85 to 0.86. That is a level reached by countries like Sweden, the Netherlands and the United States, and not by India, which sits closer to 0.64.

You can see why this landed. It said the fertility problem was a phase. Push development far enough, keep going, and the number comes back. Every government facing a birth-rate panic had a reason to be patient. The paper was cited thousands of times and quoted in newspapers all over the world.

4.2 — What happened to it

Two things went wrong, one technical and one simply factual.

The technical problem came first. In 2014 Kenneth Harttgen and Sebastian Vollmer showed that the upturn was highly sensitive to how you built the index. The HDI's own formula had been changed in 2010. Rebuild the measure a slightly different way, or use a longer run of years, and the lift at the far end shrank or disappeared. A finding that depends on which version of a composite index you use is not a law of nature. Others pointed out that much of the apparent upturn was the tempo effect from Chapter One: several very developed countries had finished a long period of postponement, so their headline numbers rose without their completed families rising.

The factual problem came later and was decisive. After about 2010, and sharply after 2015, fertility in the most developed countries did not carry on up. It fell. Finland, one of the most developed societies on Earth by any measure, went from about 1.87 to below 1.3 in little more than a decade. Norway fell by around half a child. The United States drifted from about 2.1 down to about 1.6. The countries that were supposed to demonstrate the recovery instead demonstrated the opposite.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence in the original paper was a **cross-country scatter plot**: one dot per country, development on one axis, fertility on the other. This is the most common kind of evidence in this whole field and it is worth understanding what it can and cannot do.

What it is good at: showing that a relationship exists across many places at once, using data everybody can check.

What it is bad at: telling you about people. A pattern between countries does not have to hold inside them. Rich countries may have higher fertility than middle-income countries while, inside every one of those countries, rich people have fewer children than poor people. Both statements can be true simultaneously. Demographers call the mistake of confusing the two the **ecological fallacy**, and it is the single most common error in popular writing about fertility.

The decisive evidence against the J-curve was not a better scatter plot. It was time passing.

To be fair to the original authors, they described a correlation in the data as it then stood and were careful about it, and Myrskylä himself later published work qualifying it. What was oversold was not the paper but the reading of it — worth remembering whenever a single striking chart becomes a reason not to worry.

4.3 — The theory that replaced it

If development alone does not bring fertility back, what determines where a country lands? The most influential answer came from the Australian demographer Peter McDonald in the year 2000, and it is more subtle than the J-curve.

McDonald's argument was that you should not ask how equal a society is. You should ask whether it is equal **in the same way in both of the places a woman lives.**

Modern societies have granted women near-equal treatment in what he called individual-oriented institutions — schools, universities, the labour market, the law. A girl gets the same education as her brother; a woman applies for the same job. But in family-oriented institutions — the household, the division of housework, the assumption about who leaves work when a child is ill, the expectations of in-laws — many of those same societies changed far less.

The result is a trap. A woman is educated as an equal and employed as an equal, and then, on becoming a mother, is expected to carry a load her husband is not. She is not choosing between a traditional life and a modern one. She is being offered a modern life on the condition that she also does the traditional one.

IN REAL TERMS

Time-use surveys across many countries find the same shape. In India, one of the widest gaps ever measured, women spend several hours a day on unpaid domestic and care work while men spend well under an hour. In Italy, Spain, Japan and Korea — all countries with very low fertility — the gap is narrower than India's but still large.

Put it in a working week. If a woman does a full day of paid work and then four hours of unpaid work at home, and her husband does a full day of paid work and forty minutes at home, she is working roughly a six-day week to his five, every week, for as long as the children are small.

The theory's claim in one sentence: **a woman looking at that arithmetic before her first child can see exactly what a second one costs, and she is not wrong.**

This theory has one great strength. It explains the pattern the J-curve could not: why the lowest fertility in the developed world is not in the least equal countries but in the ones that are highly equal in public life and stubbornly unequal at home. Italy, Spain, Japan, Korea. And it explained, for a while, why the Nordic countries — the most equal at home as well as at work — had the highest fertility in Europe.

4.4 — The revolution in two halves

A group of researchers led by Frances Goldscheider extended this in 2015 into a framing that is easier to hold in the head. They described the change in women's lives as a **gender revolution in two halves**.

The first half is women moving into the public world: school, university, paid work, public life. That half is largely done in rich countries and well advanced in urban India. It reduces fertility, because it raises the cost of a woman's time without reducing what is asked of her at home.

The second half is men moving into the private world: nappies, school runs, sick days, the emotional management of a household. On this account, the second half raises fertility again, because it spreads the cost of a child across two people instead of loading it onto one.

So the low-fertility countries are not the ones that went too far. They are the ones that stopped halfway.

4.5 — And then the Nordic countries fell

This is where honesty is required, because the theory has taken a serious blow and its supporters do not always say so.

If the two-halves account is right, the countries furthest through the second half should have held up best. They did not. Finland's collapse from 1.87 to below 1.3 happened during a period when Finnish men's share of domestic work was still rising, not falling. Norway and Sweden fell too. The Nordic exception, which was the single strongest piece of evidence for the gender equity theory, stopped being an exception.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE GENDER EQUITY THEORY STILL STANDING?

The question matters far beyond academia, because it is the only theory on offer that says a country could raise its birth rate *without* asking women to give anything up. If it is wrong, that option may not exist.

THE THEORY SURVIVED AND WAS MISREAD

Nothing in the theory ever promised that equality at home would push fertility back to two. It said unequal loading depresses fertility. Remove that and other things — housing costs, insecure work, the collapse of early partnering — can still push it down. Within countries, the micro evidence still supports it: studies in the Nordic countries and elsewhere find that couples who share domestic work more equally are more likely to go on to a second and third child. Finland's fall coincided with a severe and prolonged economic slump and a steep fall in the number of young people forming couples at all. Judge the theory on whether unequal households have fewer children, which they do, not on whether it can single-handedly hold a national rate up against everything else.

THE THEORY HAS FAILED ITS MAIN TEST

A theory that predicts a rise, and gets a fall in exactly the places where the mechanism was strongest, has failed. The micro evidence is weak protection here: couples who share housework equally may simply be couples who were more committed to each other and to having children in the first place, which makes the correlation a description of the couples rather than an effect of the sharing. And the crucial point is the size of the thing. Even in the most equal societies on Earth, no combination of equal housework, universal childcare and a year of paid leave has held a national rate at replacement. If the strongest version of the treatment does not work, the treatment is not the answer.

Where things stand: partial retreat. Almost nobody now claims that domestic equality alone will restore replacement fertility. Many demographers still hold that unequal loading is one real depressant among several, and that removing it is worth doing on its own merits. The theory has gone from being the explanation to being a factor.

What would settle it: a rich country that reaches genuine equality in domestic work — not policy on paper, but measured hours — and holds it for twenty years, while housing and job security stay stable. No such country exists, which is why this argument will not be settled soon. The honest position is that the strongest form of the test has never been run.

Why people care so much: because this is the last place to look for a solution that costs women nothing. Every other lever on the table involves either large sums of public money, which has been tried, or a change in what is expected of women, which is the subject of this whole series. If domestic equality does not do it, the menu gets much uglier.

One more thing has changed since these theories were written, and it may end up mattering more than either of them. In much of East Asia and increasingly in the West, the fertility decline is now largely a **partnership** decline. People are not having fewer children inside their relationships; they are not forming the relationships. In Korea, births outside marriage remain rare, and the entire recent rise in births tracked a rise in marriages one to two years earlier. If people are not pairing up, no amount of childcare policy reaches them, because policy for parents arrives after the point where the number is being decided. That is a different problem with a different shape, and it is taken up later in this series.

REMEMBER THIS

In 2009 a famous paper found a **J-curve**: fertility falls as countries develop, then rises again at very high development. It was widely read as proof that the problem would fix itself.

It did not hold. The finding was **sensitive to how the development index was built**, some of the upturn was a timing illusion, and after 2015 the most developed countries fell instead of rising. Finland went from 1.87 to below 1.3.

The theory that replaced it says the problem is **uneven equality**: women are treated as equals at school and at work, and not at home. A woman carrying a six-day week to her husband's five can see exactly what a second child costs.

The **two-halves** version of this says the first half of the revolution — women entering public life — lowers fertility, and the second half — men entering domestic life — should raise it again.

But the countries furthest through the second half fell too. Nobody has yet found a way to hold a rich country at replacement, and the honest position is that the strongest version of the cure has never actually been tested.

CHAPTER FIVE

Who Is Having the Children

> *A national average tells you nothing about who is inside it. Once you look, you find that the people having children and the people not having them differ in ways that are being used, right now, as political ammunition in India.*

5.1 — The average hides the argument

A country with a fertility rate of 1.9 could be a country where every woman has about two children. It could also be a country where half the women have three and half have one. These are completely different societies with the same headline number, and which one you are living in matters enormously for what happens next.

WORD BOX

Differential fertility: the fact that different groups within the same country have different numbers of children — sorted by education, income, religion, region, caste, or anything else you care to measure.

Why it matters: over generations, the composition of a population shifts towards whichever group is having more children, even if nobody's individual behaviour changes. This is arithmetic, not ideology. What is fiercely contested is how strong the effect is and whether it survives contact with the real world, which is what most of this chapter is about.

5.2 — Schooling beats everything else

Start with the biggest differential, because it is the one that gets the least political attention despite being the largest.

In India's health surveys, the fertility gap between women with no schooling and women who completed twelve years or more has consistently run at more than a full child. That is a bigger gap than the one between any two religions, bigger than the gap between most income groups, and roughly the same size as the gap between Bihar and Kerala.

It is also the gap that has been closing fastest, because schooling has spread fastest. Much of India's fertility decline is simply this: the share of Indian women who never went to school has collapsed, and those women are the ones who used to have five children.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India has two big fertility datasets and they answer different questions. The **Sample Registration System** gives the best year-by-year national and state numbers, but it does not break results down by religion, caste or income. The **National Family Health Survey**, run every few years across several hundred thousand households, does.

What that means in practice: every claim in this chapter about religion or education comes from the NFHS, and the most recent full round covered 2019 to 2021. So the religious comparisons are a few years older than the state comparisons in Chapter Two, and cannot simply be updated by taking the newer national figure and assuming the gaps stayed the same.

Why the survey is trustworthy on this: it asks women directly about every birth in their lives, and it has repeated the same questions across five rounds since 1992, which makes the trend more reliable than any single round's level.

5.3 — The Indian religion gap, and how fast it is closing

Now the number that gets shouted about in India. I am going to give it to you plainly, with the trend, because the trend is the whole point and it is almost always left out.

In the 2019–21 survey, Hindu fertility was about 1.94 and Muslim fertility about 2.36. So Muslim fertility was higher. That is true, and pretending otherwise helps nobody.

Now the part that is usually omitted. In the survey of 1992–93, the same gap was about 1.1 children. By 2019–21 it was about 0.42. Muslim fertility in India has fallen faster than Hindu fertility over the last three decades — it has fallen further, from a higher starting point, in less time. And in the most recent rounds, Muslim fertility itself has come very close to the replacement line.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Think of two runners. In 1992 one was 1.1 kilometres behind. By 2021 the gap was 0.42 kilometres. The runner behind is running faster, and both are approaching the same finish line.
>
> Here is the fact that settles most of the argument on its own: **Muslim fertility in India's southern states is lower than Hindu fertility in India's northern states.** A Muslim woman in Tamil Nadu is likely to have fewer children than a Hindu woman in Bihar. If religion were the driver, that could not happen. Where you live, how long you were in school and whether your children survive predict your family size far better than which building you pray in.

This is a place where I should say what I am doing. The Hindu–Muslim fertility gap in India is not primarily a demographic subject. It is a political weapon, used to argue that one community will outnumber another. I am reporting the numbers because a series that claims to face facts cannot skip the ones that are being misused. The trend is the fact that matters: the gap has narrowed by more than half in thirty years and is still narrowing. Anyone quoting the level without the trend is either uninformed or is choosing not to tell you.

5.4 — The inheritance argument

The differential fertility idea has a serious version, and it is worth taking seriously because it is not obviously wrong.

It was set out most fully by the political scientist Eric Kaufmann in a 2010 book asking whether the religious will inherit the Earth. The argument runs like this. Secular, liberal, highly educated people have fewer children than devout, traditional people, in nearly every country where it has been measured. Compound that over several generations and the share of the population raised in devout households rises, regardless of whether anybody converts anybody. The future belongs not to whoever wins the argument but to whoever shows up.

The examples are real. In Israel, the ultra-Orthodox community has fertility far above the national average and its share of the population has risen steadily for decades. In the United States, the Amish population has roughly doubled every twenty years for a century. Across Europe and America, regular religious attendance is one of the few individual characteristics that still predicts having more children.

WORD BOX

Retention rate: the share of children raised in a group who still belong to that group as adults.

Why it matters: it is the hinge of the whole inheritance argument. A group with high fertility and low retention grows slowly or not at all, because it is losing at the back door what it gains at the front. A group with high fertility and near-total retention compounds. Almost every fight about the argument below is really a fight about this one number.

With that word in hand, the argument becomes tractable. Both sides below accept the same multiplication. What they disagree about is whether the groups doing the multiplying stay intact long enough for it to matter.

THE ARGUMENT — WILL THE MORE TRADITIONAL INHERIT THE FUTURE?

The mathematics is not in dispute. If group A averages three children and group B averages 1.5, then after four generations group A's descendants outnumber group B's by roughly sixteen to one, starting from equal size. The dispute is whether groups stay groups.

YES, AND THE EFFECT IS ALREADY VISIBLE

The arithmetic is relentless and it does not need anyone to change their mind. Israel's ultra-Orthodox share has risen from a tiny minority to a substantial one within living memory, and it is now large enough to shape national politics, school curricula and the military draft. The same compounding is visible among conservative religious communities in the United States and Europe. Critically, the groups that hold their children are exactly the groups that build separate institutions — their own schools, their own marriage markets, their own neighbourhoods — and those institutions are getting easier to maintain, not harder, because a community can now educate and entertain its children entirely inside its own network. The secular assumption that everyone eventually drifts to the centre was a feature of twentieth-century mass media, and mass media is gone.

NO, BECAUSE GROUPS LEAK

Every historical case of high-fertility religious growth has been accompanied by defection, and defection scales with contact. Quebec had among the highest fertility in the Western world and became one of the most secular societies on Earth within a single generation. Iran's fertility collapsed under a religious government that wanted the opposite. The high-retention communities that get cited — the Amish, the ultra-Orthodox — are small, unusual, and maintain their retention through a degree of separation from the wider economy that does not scale. And there is a simpler point: the trait being inherited is not a gene. It is a way of life, and it is transmitted only as long as the children want it. As soon as a community becomes big enough to need the outside economy, its retention rate starts to fall, and the compounding stops.

Where things stand: both halves are true at different scales. Differential fertility is real, measurable and does shift the composition of populations over decades — the Israeli case is not disputed by anybody. But the extrapolations are unreliable, because they hold retention constant and retention is exactly what changes as a community grows. The honest summary: expect composition to shift noticeably over fifty years, and treat any projection running to two hundred years as arithmetic dressed up as prophecy.

What would settle it: long-run retention data on large high-fertility communities as they urbanise and enter the wider labour market. Some of this exists for Israel and is genuinely contested, with each side reading the same numbers differently. There is no clean answer available yet.

Why people care so much: because in India, Europe and Israel alike, this argument is the respectable form of a demographic anxiety about who a country will belong to. That is worth naming. The evidential question — how strongly does group fertility compound — is real. But it is being fought at a volume that only makes sense if the actual stake is something else.

5.5 — The other differential, which nobody campaigns about

There is a differential inside every country that gets far less attention than religion, and it is larger.

In almost every society ever measured, the people with the most education and the highest incomes have had the fewest children. This was true in nineteenth-century Britain and it is true in India today. It is the pattern that alarmed the eugenicists a century ago, and their alarm is one reason the topic is handled so nervously now.

Two things have changed recently and they cut in opposite directions. In several rich countries the pattern at the very top has partially reversed: the highest-earning men and, increasingly, the highest-earning couples now have slightly more children than those just below them, because they can buy the labour that makes a third child possible. At the same time, the sharpest fertility falls in rich countries have been among the young and less secure — people without stable jobs or affordable housing.

Put those together and something is happening that the political argument has not caught up with. In several countries, having children is quietly becoming a thing that the secure can afford and the insecure postpone until it is too late. That is a class story, not a culture war story, and it is much less useful to everybody's politics, which may be why you hear about it less.

REMEMBER THIS

A national average hides who is inside it. **Differential fertility** — different groups having different numbers of children — shifts a population's composition over generations without anyone changing their mind.

In India, the biggest fertility gap is **education**, not religion. Women with no schooling have had more than a full child more than women who finished school.

The **Hindu–Muslim gap is real and shrinking fast**: about 1.1 children in 1992–93, about 0.42 in 2019–21. Muslim fertility in south India is lower than Hindu fertility in north India. Geography and schooling beat religion.

The **inheritance argument** — that the devout will out-reproduce the secular — is arithmetically sound and empirically shaky, because it assumes children keep their parents' way of life. That assumption is called the **retention rate**, and it is the whole ballgame.

The differential nobody campaigns about is the largest one: in country after country, children are becoming something the secure can afford and the insecure postpone until it is too late.

CHAPTER SIX

Has Anyone Ever Turned It Round

> *Governments have been trying to raise birth rates for a hundred years, and several are spending enormous sums on it right now. This is the record. It is not encouraging, and the one clear exception is not an exception anybody can copy.*

6.1 — What "it worked" would have to mean

Before looking at the cases, we need a test, because otherwise every government can claim victory. Almost all of them do.

WORD BOX

Pronatalism: any deliberate effort by a state to increase the number of births. It runs from cash payments and tax breaks at one end to bans on contraception and abortion at the other.

Quantum and tempo: two different things a policy can change. **Quantum** is how many children a woman ends up with in total. **Tempo** is when she has them. A payment that persuades a couple to have their second child at twenty-nine instead of thirty-two changes tempo. A payment that persuades a couple to have a third child they were never going to have changes quantum.

Why it matters: only quantum changes the long-run size of a population. But tempo is what shows up in the headline rate immediately, and it is what governments announce. Almost every claimed pronatalist success in the last twenty years has turned out, on inspection, to be mostly tempo.

So the test is: did completed family size rise? Not the headline number, not the number of births in one good year — the total that a generation of women ended up with. That test is demanding and slow. It is also the only one that means anything.

6.2 — Hungary: the most-watched attempt in the world

Since 2010, Hungary's government has run the most ambitious pronatalist programme in any democracy. Zero-interest loans for couples expecting a child, with portions of the debt forgiven as more children arrive. Income tax exemption for mothers of four or more children. Housing subsidies tied to family size. Spending on family support of around five per cent of national income — among the highest in the world by that measure, and several times what most rich countries spend.

For a decade it looked like it was working. Hungary's rate rose from about 1.23 in 2011 to about 1.59 in 2021. Conservative politicians across Europe and America pointed at it. Italy's government announced it would copy the approach.

Then it went into reverse. By 2024 the figure was about 1.38. By 2025 it was about 1.31 — not much above where the programme started. Meanwhile, across the eleven years between two censuses, Hungary's population fell by about 334,000 people, because a rise in the rate from 1.23 to 1.59 does not produce population growth. It produces a slightly slower decline.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The most informative analysis of the Hungarian case did not use the headline rate at all. It used the **tempo-adjusted** rate from Chapter One — the estimate of what the number would be if nobody were shifting the timing of their births.

What it showed: most of the celebrated fertility rises across Central Europe in the 2010s disappear once timing is stripped out. The rises were largely the tail end of a long postponement finishing, not a change in how many children women were having. And on the adjusted measure, Hungary and Poland stand out as the two countries whose underlying fertility genuinely did **not** recover.

Why this is strong evidence: the adjustment was not invented to embarrass Hungary. It is a standard tool applied across all of Europe at once, and it makes some countries look better and others worse. A correction that cuts both ways is a measurement, not an argument.

The demographer Tomas Sobotka of the Vienna Institute of Demography put it about as bluntly as a specialist ever does: judged against what the policies set out to achieve, this is clearly a failure. Hungary's own government continues to expand the programme.

6.3 — The rest of the case file

Poland. In 2016 Poland introduced a large monthly child benefit, generous by regional standards and paid to a very wide range of families. The rate rose from about 1.29 to about 1.45 within two years. Then it fell, and kept falling, to the lowest levels in Polish history — below where it had been before the benefit existed.

Russia. In 2007 Russia introduced "maternity capital", a large lump sum for a second child, usable for housing or education. The rate rose from about 1.3 to about 1.78 by 2015 — one of the largest rises anywhere. Then it fell back towards 1.4. The most careful studies of the scheme found that a substantial part of what it did was bring forward births that would have happened anyway, and shift them towards the second child specifically, which is what the money was attached to.

Singapore. Pronatalist since 1987, after a famously successful antinatalist campaign before that. Cash bonuses, tax rebates, housing priority, matched savings accounts for children, state-supported matchmaking. The rate has fallen throughout, and dropped below 1.0 for the first time in 2023.

France. Often cited as the success story, and it is the best of them. Decades of consistent family policy — universal childcare places, a tax system that explicitly rewards larger families, long paid leave — kept France at or near the top of Western Europe for forty years, at about 1.9 to 2.0. It has now drifted down to about 1.6. The fair reading is that France bought itself several tenths of a child and forty years, which is more than anybody else managed, and did not stop the direction.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> What does a tenth of a child cost? Take a country spending an extra one per cent of national income on family support. Studies that find a positive effect usually put it somewhere between a few hundredths and about two tenths of a child per woman.
>
> Turn that into households. If a country of ten million women of childbearing age raises the rate by 0.1, that is roughly one additional child for every ten women — spread across everybody, over a generation. The spending, meanwhile, goes to every family, including the very large majority who were going to have that child anyway.
>
> This is why estimates of the cost of one *additional* birth — one that would not otherwise have happened — routinely run into the hundreds of thousands of pounds or dollars in rich countries. The money is not wasted; it goes to families and it makes their lives easier. But as a way of buying babies it is close to the most expensive method available.

6.4 — Korea, and what a rebound looks like from inside

Korea deserves careful handling, because it is the live case and it is being read badly by both sides right now.

The facts first. Korea has spent, by its own government's accounting, more than 280 trillion won on low-fertility policy over about sixteen years — something over two hundred billion US dollars. Cash grants, extended parental leave, childcare, housing support, plan after plan. Through all of it the rate fell, from about 1.24 in 2015 to 0.72 in 2023, the lowest national figure ever recorded anywhere on Earth.

Then it turned. The rate rose to 0.75 in 2024 and to about 0.80 in 2025. Births rose 6.8 per cent in 2025 to about 254,500, the largest annual increase since 2007, and the second consecutive annual rise after eight straight years of decline.

Two readings are available and the difference between them matters.

The tempting reading is that the money finally worked. The evidence points elsewhere. In Korea, births outside marriage remain uncommon, so marriages are a reliable leading indicator of births one to two years later — and marriages jumped about 14.8 per cent in 2024, the biggest rise since records began in 1970, followed by a further 8.1 per cent in 2025. A large part of that was weddings postponed during the pandemic finally happening. On top of that, the women currently in their early thirties are from a relatively large birth cohort. The cohorts behind them are much smaller, which puts a ceiling on how long any rebound can run.

In other words: this looks, so far, mostly like tempo. Korean researchers have made the point directly — the level has not recovered to where it was before the pandemic, and an echo is not a reversal. It may become more than that. Two years is not enough to know, and anyone telling you confidently in either direction is telling you their politics.

6.5 — The one country that never fell

Israel is the only rich democracy that has never gone below replacement. Its rate is around 2.9, higher than several developing countries, in a society with high female education, high female employment and a large technology sector. It is the single most important case in this chapter, and the most misused.

It is misused because people assume the answer is the ultra-Orthodox, whose fertility is very high. That is part of it, but it is not the interesting part. The striking fact is that **secular Israeli Jews are also above replacement**, at roughly 2.2. Take the religious communities out entirely and Israel still has higher fertility than any other rich country.

What is going on there appears to be several things at once, and none of them is a policy you can order off a shelf. Almost everybody marries, and marries relatively young. Having children is treated as a normal part of adult life rather than a project to be attempted once other things are secure. The state funds fertility treatment more generously than anywhere else on Earth, with treatment cycles covered up to two children for essentially any woman who wants them. Extended family childcare is widely available because families live close together. And underneath all of it sits a collective story — about a small population, about survival, about a national future — that gives childbearing a public meaning it has lost almost everywhere else.

That last item is the one nobody knows how to reproduce. It is also, uncomfortably, closely bound up with a permanent security threat. The honest summary of the Israeli case is that it shows high fertility is compatible with a rich, modern, educated society — which is genuinely important, because it refutes the claim that development makes low fertility inevitable. What it does not show is any transferable method.

THE ARGUMENT — DO PRONATALIST POLICIES WORK?

Every government facing this now has to decide whether to spend. The record above is not ambiguous about the size of the effect, but it is genuinely ambiguous about what to conclude from it.

THEY DO NOT WORK, AND THE SPENDING IS A TRANSFER DRESSED AS A SOLUTION

Not one country has returned to replacement through policy. Hungary spent five per cent of national income and ended roughly where it started. Korea spent over two hundred billion dollars and set a world record for the lowest rate ever measured. Poland's benefit was followed by the lowest fertility in its history. The measured effects are small, mostly on timing, and cost a fortune per additional birth. The reason is not that governments picked the wrong policy. It is that the things actually driving the decision — whether you found a partner, whether you can see a stable ten years ahead, what a child will cost you in career and in hours — are not things a monthly payment reaches.

THEY WORK, AND YOU ARE MEASURING AGAINST THE WRONG BASELINE

The right question is not "did the rate return to two" but "what would the rate have been without the policy". Fertility fell across all of Europe over this period, including in countries that spent nothing. Hungary rose while its neighbours fell and then fell alongside them during an inflation shock; that is a policy holding a line, not a policy failing. France's forty years at the top of Western Europe cost money and bought real children. And the effects that are measured are almost all measured on cash transfers, which are the crudest instrument available. The evidence on services — actual childcare places, actual job protection, actual housing — is stronger than the evidence on cash, and most countries have not seriously tried the expensive version.

> **Where things stand:** the specialists mostly agree on the magnitude and disagree on the interpretation. Nobody serious claims a country has restored replacement fertility with policy. Nobody serious claims the effect is exactly zero either. The realistic range is a lift of somewhere between a few hundredths and about two tenths of a child, for very large sustained spending — enough to matter over a century, nowhere near enough to close a gap of half a child or more.
>
> **What would settle it:** a country that sustains a serious programme for thirty years without a recession or a political reversal, and reports completed cohort fertility at the end of it. France is the closest thing we have to that trial, and its result is "a few tenths, then decline anyway".
>
> **Why people care so much:** because if policy cannot raise the number, the conversation moves on to things that might — immigration, or changing what is expected of women, or accepting a smaller population. All three of those are far more politically explosive than writing cheques, and writing cheques lets a government be seen to act while the harder argument is postponed.

6.6 — And now India is trying it

This is no longer a foreign story. India, the country that ran one of the world's largest and most coercive family-limitation programmes, has begun to reverse.

In 2024 the Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh, N. Chandrababu Naidu, publicly urged families to have more children, citing his state's fertility rate of around 1.6 to 1.7 and an elderly population heading from about eleven per cent towards nineteen per cent by 2047. His government repealed the long-standing rule barring people with more than two children from contesting local body elections, and floated a law that would allow *only* those with more than two children to stand. The state has since announced cash payments for third and fourth births. The Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, M. K. Stalin, asked publicly why Tamil families should not have sixteen children. In 2026 the Telangana assembly passed a bill abolishing its own two-child norm, citing a rural fertility rate of 1.7.

At the same time, in the north, the opposite argument continues. Uttar Pradesh has drafted population control legislation proposing to bar people with more than two children from government jobs and benefits.

So one country is now running pronatalist policy in the south and antinatalist proposals in the north, simultaneously. That is not incoherence. It is two different states responding to two genuinely different demographic situations — and, underneath, to a fight about parliamentary seats that Chapter Seven has to explain.

REMEMBER THIS

The test of a pronatalist policy is whether it changes **quantum** (how many children a woman ends up with) or only **tempo** (when she has them). Almost every claimed success has turned out to be mostly tempo.

Hungary spent about five per cent of national income for fifteen years. The rate rose from 1.23 to 1.59, then fell back to about 1.31. The population fell by 334,000 between two censuses anyway.

Korea spent over two hundred billion dollars and hit 0.72 in 2023, the lowest ever recorded anywhere. Its rise to 0.80 by 2025 tracks a surge in postponed weddings and a temporarily large cohort of women in their thirties — an echo, not yet a reversal.

Israel is the only rich democracy never to fall below replacement, and even its secular population is above it. The reasons are near-universal early marriage, heavily funded fertility treatment, close family networks and a collective story about the future. None of that can be bought.

No country has ever restored replacement fertility through policy. The effects that exist are real, small, and cost a fortune per additional child. India has just started spending anyway.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Bill Nobody Has Costed

> *Every society has a system for keeping old people alive after they stop working. In India that system is called "your children". This chapter is about what happens to it when there are fewer of them.*

7.1 — Ageing is not what people think it is

When people hear that a country is ageing they picture more old people. That is half of it, and it is the harmless half.

More old people means people are living longer, which is the single greatest achievement of the last two centuries and nobody wants it reversed. The problem is the other half, which is fewer young people. A population ages from the bottom as much as from the top, and the bottom is where the workers, the taxpayers and the carers come from.

WORD BOX

Old-age support ratio: how many working-age people there are for each person over sixty-five. It is the number that decides whether an ageing society is comfortable or strained.

India today has roughly ten working-age people for every person over sixty-five. On current projections that falls to somewhere around four by 2050. Japan is already at about two. Korea is heading for less than that.

Why it matters: everything an old person needs — a pension, a doctor, a nurse, a hand getting out of a chair — is provided by someone of working age, whether it is paid for through taxes or provided directly by a family member. When ten become four, either each of the four does more, or each old person gets less. There is no third option, and this is true regardless of how the system is financed.

7.2 — Three ways to pay for old age, and only three

Every society that has ever existed has used some combination of the same three methods.

Children. Your grown children feed and house you. This is the oldest system and still the most common one worldwide. Its advantage is that it needs no institutions. Its disadvantage is that it needs children, and it collapses if they move away, if they are poor, or if you did not have any.

Pay-as-you-go pensions. The state taxes today's workers and pays today's pensioners. Most rich countries do this.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Pay-as-you-go (PAYG):** a pension system in which the money paid to today's pensioners comes from today's workers, not from a pot saved up earlier.
>
> The thing to understand: despite the language of "contributions", nothing is stored. What a worker buys is a promise that the next generation will do the same for them. A PAYG pension is therefore **the children system, run through a government instead of a family**. It depends on the next generation existing in the same way a family does. It just hides the dependency inside an institution.

Saving. You put money aside and live off it. This looks as though it escapes the problem, and it does not entirely: when you retire you sell your assets, and you sell them to younger people. Fewer younger buyers with less money means lower prices. Saving softens the blow without removing the fact that what a retired person consumes must be produced, that year, by somebody working.

That is the hard core of this chapter, and it applies to every country regardless of ideology: **you cannot store labour.** The care an eighty-year-old needs in 2055 must be delivered by a person alive and working in 2055.

7.3 — India's system is children, and there is a law about it

India has not built a general old-age pension. What it has is a patchwork covering a minority, and underneath it, an explicit legal instruction to families.

The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act of 2007 makes it a legal obligation for children to maintain their elderly parents, and gives parents a tribunal to apply to if they do not. Read that again in the context of this document. India's principal old-age security policy is a statute telling adult children to pay. That is not a criticism of the law, which was passed because the informal system was already failing some people. It is a description of what the system is.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The best evidence on how India's elderly actually live comes from the **Longitudinal Ageing Study in India**, which since 2017 has interviewed a nationally representative sample of more than thirty thousand people aged sixty and over — asking about income, health, work, living arrangements and who supports whom.

What it shows: only about one in five people over sixty is covered by any central or state pension programme, and only about two in a hundred by a private or employer pension. Financial transfers from adult children to parents are about three times as common as transfers from parents to children. And of those elderly who spent their working lives in the organised sector — the minority most likely to be covered — around 78 per cent receive no pension at all. For women who worked in that sector the figure is starker: fewer than one in twelve receives a pension, against roughly one in four of the men.

What it cannot show: what people would do under different arrangements, or how much support is given informally in kind — a room, food, medicine — rather than in cash. Some of what looks like independence in the data is a widow living in a son's house and counted separately.

There is a state pension for the very poor, the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme. The central government's contribution to it has been ₹200 per month for those aged sixty to seventy-nine. States add their own top-ups, so what an individual actually receives varies enormously — some states pay a genuinely useful amount, others barely more than the central share.

IN REAL TERMS

₹200 a month is about ₹6.60 a day. At recent prices that is somewhere around a kilogram of rice, or a single cup of tea and a snack, or roughly one-fifth of a day's wage for unskilled work in most of the country.

Put it against the thing it is meant to cover. Basic groceries for one person, plus routine medicine for the ordinary conditions of old age, do not come to ₹6.60 a day anywhere in India.

The central share has not been raised since 2007. So a scheme designed to keep the poorest old people alive is now worth, in what it will actually buy, a fraction of what it was worth when it was set. **India's public old-age pension for the poorest is not small. It is close to symbolic, and the actual system is the family.**

7.4 — Growing old before growing rich

Here is why India's situation is not simply "what happened to Japan, arriving later".

Japan's fertility fell below replacement in 1974. Korea's in the mid-1980s. China's in the early 1990s. India's around 2019. Now rank those four countries by how wealthy the average person was at the moment their country crossed the line. India comes last, by a very wide margin — poorer at the crossing point than Japan was fifty years earlier, and poorer than China was in the 1990s.

The comparison needs care, because comparing incomes across fifty years requires adjusting for inflation and for what money buys in different places, and different adjustments give different multiples. But every reasonable method gives the same ranking and the same qualitative answer: **India has begun ageing at a much lower level of income than any large country that went before it.**

The practical meaning of that is simple. Japan built its pension system, its hospitals and its nursing homes while it was rich and still had a young population paying for them. India has to build the same things while it is much poorer, and it has perhaps two decades to do it in.

IN REAL TERMS

India's population aged sixty and over is projected to grow from about 149 million in 2022 to roughly 347 million by 2050. That is an increase of about 198 million people over 28 years — an average of about seven million more elderly people every single year.

Seven million a year is, roughly, adding the entire population of a large Indian city to the retired population annually, for a quarter of a century, without stopping.

Kerala is already there: about fifteen in every hundred Keralites are over sixty, against under ten nationally. The southern states will hit this a full generation before the north.

None of that is in dispute. What is in dispute is whether India has enough time, and the disagreement is sharp enough that the two sides produce completely different pictures of the 2040s from exactly the same population figures.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN INDIA GET RICH BEFORE IT GETS OLD?

This is the single most consequential open question in Indian economics, and it is genuinely open.

YES — THE WINDOW IS STILL OPEN AND WIDE

India still has one of the youngest large populations on Earth, with a quarter of its people between ten and twenty-four. The working-age share is still rising and will keep rising into the 2040s. That is a two-decade window in which a large young workforce supports a small number of dependants at both ends — exactly the configuration that powered East Asia's growth. Growth of six or seven per cent a year compounds fast: at seven per cent, income per head doubles in ten years. Two doublings before the ageing bites would put India in a completely different position, and the ageing itself will arrive unevenly, with the north still young while the south ages, which buys internal time through migration between states.

NO — THE DIVIDEND NEEDS JOBS, AND THE JOBS ARE NOT THERE

A young population is not a dividend. It is a potential dividend, and it converts only if the young are employed in productive work. India's rate of women in paid work is among the lowest in the world for a country at its income level, which means half the potential workforce is not in the calculation at all. The large majority of Indian workers are in informal employment with no contract, no pension and no social insurance, so even a growing workforce does not automatically build a contributory pension base. Meanwhile the south, which is the productive core, is ageing now — and it is doing so with a per-head income far below what Japan or Korea had at the same stage. The window is not twenty years everywhere. In Kerala and Tamil Nadu it has already closed.

Where things stand: the disagreement is not really about demography, which both sides read the same way. It is about whether India creates formal jobs fast enough, and particularly whether women enter paid work. Every serious projection turns on those two variables. On the demographic facts there is no dispute: the window exists, it is roughly two decades wide at national level, and it has already shut in several states.

What would settle it: the formal employment numbers over the next ten years, and the female labour force participation rate. Those are measurable, they are published, and they will answer this question in public and in real time.

Why people care so much: because if the answer is no, India will be the first country in history to have a very large elderly population and no general pension system — and the people who absorb that are not governments. They are families, and inside families, overwhelmingly, they are daughters and daughters-in-law.

That last sentence is doing more work than it looks, and it points at something both sides of the whole fertility argument are quietly assuming.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT SOMEBODY WILL BE THERE TO DO THE CARING

Read any projection of population ageing, from any direction. The alarmed version says the ratio of workers to pensioners is collapsing and the state cannot pay. The relaxed version says productivity, automation and immigration will cover the gap.

> Both are arguing about money. Both are assuming that the **physical work of care** — the bathing, the feeding, the lifting, the sitting with someone through a long afternoon — will get done.
>
> It does not get done by itself, and in almost every society on Earth it is done, unpaid, by women. It is the largest single block of unpaid labour in the world economy and it appears in no national accounts anywhere. When a government says its pension system is sustainable, what it usually means is that its *cash* obligations are sustainable. The hours are not on the balance sheet, because the hours have never been priced.
>
> This produces a specific and rarely stated trap. Ageing increases the hours of care needed. Low fertility means fewer daughters and daughters-in-law to provide them. Rising female employment — which everybody, including every government worried about growth, is actively trying to increase — removes those same women from availability during working hours. All three trends push in the same direction at once, and no country's plan accounts for the third one.
>
> **The general form:** an input treated as free because it has never been priced. It runs through economics everywhere: household labour, environmental services, the unpaid work of raising the workers themselves. When something has always been supplied for nothing, its disappearance is not forecast, because it was never counted.
>
> The uncomfortable implication for this document: a large part of what is called "the fertility crisis" is really a care crisis wearing a demographic costume. And a society that cannot find carers has exactly two options — pay for them, which nobody has costed, or lean harder on the women it already has, which is a rule about women arriving by the back door.

7.5 — Why India's fertility argument is really about seats

One last thing, and it is the piece that explains why Indian politicians have suddenly started talking about birth rates.

Seats in India's national parliament are allocated between states according to population. But that allocation was frozen in 1976, using the 1971 census, and then frozen again until 2026. The freeze existed precisely so that states which succeeded at family planning would not be punished for it by losing representation.

That freeze is now expiring. When seats are redistributed on current populations, the states that reduced their fertility fastest — Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka — stand to lose weight relative to the states that did not. From the southern point of view: we were told to have fewer children, we did it, and the reward is fewer seats.

So when an Andhra chief minister asks families to have more children, and a Tamil Nadu chief minister jokes about sixteen, they are making a demographic argument and a constitutional one at the same time. It is worth naming plainly what is happening, because it explains the volume: **a question about how many children women should have is being fought as a question about political power between regions.** The women in the middle of it are the mechanism, not the subject.

REMEMBER THIS

Ageing is not mainly about more old people. It is about **fewer young ones**. India has about ten working-age people per person over sixty-five today, heading for roughly four by 2050.

There are only three ways to fund old age: children, taxing today's workers, or saving. All three depend on the next generation existing, because **you cannot store labour**. Care needed in 2055 must be delivered by a person working in 2055.

India's system is **children, plus a law telling them to pay**. About one in five people over sixty has any pension at all. The central share of the pension for the poorest has been ₹200 a month since 2007 — around ₹6.60 a day.

India is **ageing at a much lower income than any large country before it**, and its elderly population is growing by roughly seven million people a year. Kerala is already where the rest of the country will be in twenty years.

Underneath the whole argument sits an unpriced assumption: that the hours of care will simply be there. In India, and everywhere else, those hours belong to women — and nobody's plan has costed them.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What Follows From Fewer People

> *One camp says a shrinking population is the end of progress. The other says it is the correction the planet needed. Both have real arguments, and the thing they are actually disagreeing about is not the arithmetic.*

8.1 — The strongest case for alarm

Let me put this side as well as I can, because it is usually caricatured as nostalgia for large families and it is not.

The first argument is about **compounding**, and it is the one people underrate. A population at replacement is stable. A population below replacement does not settle at a smaller size; it keeps shrinking, generation after generation, for as long as the rate stays below the line. There is no floor. The only thing that stops it is fertility returning to about 2.1, and no country has managed that once it fell.

IN REAL TERMS

Suppose a country's fertility settles at 1.3 and stays there. Each generation is roughly 40 per cent smaller than the one before.

Start with a hundred people. The next generation is about sixty. Then thirty-six. Then twenty-two. Then thirteen. In five generations — about a hundred and fifty years — a hundred people have become thirteen.

Now hold that against a single family. If your line runs at 1.3 for five generations, you have roughly one great-great-great-grandchild for every eight you would have had at replacement. This is what the alarmed side means when it says the situation is not a plateau. **Below-replacement fertility is not a smaller population. It is a continuous decline that only stops when the rate changes.**

The second argument is about **ideas**. Knowledge, unlike land or oil, is not used up when it is shared: a vaccine invented once can be used by everyone forever. That means the number of people is directly linked to the rate of discovery, because inventors are drawn from the population. Halve the number of young people and you halve the draws from the tail of the distribution where the rare inventors are. This is not a claim that crowded countries are cleverer. It is a claim about sample size, and it is the core of the case made by the economists Dean Spears and Michael Geruso, who argue that a permanently shrinking world would mean permanently slowing progress.

The third argument is **fiscal and physical**. Public debt is a claim on future taxpayers, and it was issued assuming there would be more of them. Pensions and health systems are promises to be paid by a generation that is now smaller than the promise assumed. And beyond money, there is the plain arithmetic of Chapter Seven: someone has to actually do the caring.

The fourth is about **the character of an old society**. A society whose median voter is sixty behaves differently from one whose median voter is thirty. It is more protective of asset values and less tolerant of disruption, because its wealth is in houses and pensions rather than in future earnings. Whether you call that stability or stagnation is a value judgement. That it is different is not.

The fifth is **concentration**. National averages hide the fact that decline is not spread evenly. It empties the periphery first. Japan has millions of abandoned houses. Whole districts of rural Spain and Italy have lost their schools, their doctors and their bus routes. The last person to leave a village is not experiencing a gentle national adjustment.

8.2 — The strongest case for calm

Now the other side, also at full strength.

The first argument is **the track record of population panic**, and it is a serious argument rather than a debating point.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In 1968 the biologist Paul Ehrlich published *The Population Bomb*, which opened by stating that the battle to feed humanity was over and predicted that hundreds of millions would starve in the 1970s. It was enormously influential. It shaped aid policy, and it shaped India's own coercive sterilisation programme of the mid-1970s.

What actually happened: world population roughly doubled, and the share of people who are undernourished fell substantially. Food production rose faster than population, largely through the crop varieties of the Green Revolution.

What this evidence establishes: that confident projections about population and catastrophe have a poor record, and that acting on them has done real harm to real people — in India's case, millions of coerced operations.

What it does not establish: that today's forecasts are wrong. Ehrlich was wrong about famine because of an innovation nobody had predicted. That is a reason for humility in both directions, not a reason to assume every worry is unfounded.

The second argument is that **income per person does not depend on the number of people**. There is no relationship in the data between a country's population size and how well off its citizens are. Switzerland, Norway and Singapore are small and rich. If the concern is living standards rather than national bulk, a smaller population is not obviously worse.

The third is that **scarce labour has historically been good for workers**. After the Black Death killed a third of Europe, wages for ordinary labourers rose sharply and stayed high for a century. Smaller generations tend to face less competition for jobs, housing and university places. If you are a young person in a shrinking country, some of the arithmetic runs in your favour.

The fourth is **the environment**, and this is the one that made depopulation a hopeful idea for a generation of people who are now being told to panic about it. Fewer people means less land cleared, less water drawn, fewer emissions. Every serious climate scenario is easier at nine billion than at twelve.

The fifth is that **Japan already ran the experiment**. Japan has had below-replacement fertility for over fifty years and a falling population since around 2010. It has not collapsed. Unemployment is low, life expectancy is the highest in the world, the streets are safe and income per person has continued to rise. Adjustment has been expensive and slow, and rural Japan has genuinely hollowed out. But the catastrophe has not arrived, and it has had five decades to.

8.3 — The distinction that resolves half the argument

A great deal of this dispute dissolves once you separate two things that are constantly confused.

A smaller population is not a problem. A country of forty million can be as prosperous, healthy and pleasant as a country of eighty million. Nothing in economics says otherwise.

The transition to a smaller population is the problem, because during it the age structure is lopsided: many old, few young. That is when the support ratio is worst and the bills fall due.

Now the sting. If fertility fell to 1.6 and then rose back to 2.1, the transition would be a bad thirty years followed by a stable, slightly smaller country. Difficult, survivable, over. If fertility stays below replacement indefinitely, the transition never ends. Every generation is the lopsided one. That is why the honest version of the alarmed case is not "the population will be small" but "the adjustment period has no exit unless the rate comes back up" — and Chapter Six showed how hard it is to bring back up.

8.4 — What immigration can and cannot do

The obvious answer to a shortage of young workers is to import some, and it works. Immigration is the single most effective tool any individual country has for fixing its own age structure. It is fast, it is proven, and it delivers exactly the demographic profile a shrinking country needs — people arriving already grown, already trained, at the start of their working lives.

It has three limits, and they are all real.

The first is political. In most rich democracies immigration at the scale required is not achievable, whatever anyone thinks it should be. The scale is genuinely large: to hold a support ratio constant purely through migration usually requires inflows far above anything currently politically survivable.

The second is arithmetic. Immigrants age too. A migrant who arrives at twenty-five is a pensioner in forty years, so migration postpones the problem rather than solving it, unless the flow keeps growing.

The third is the one that changes everything, and it is new. **The sending countries are running out of young people as well.** India, the world's largest source of migrants, is now below replacement. Mexico, the main source for the United States, is below replacement. The global pool of surplus young workers is shrinking, and within a few decades most of what remains will be in sub-Saharan Africa. Countries are now beginning to compete for migrants rather than merely to control them, and that competition will get sharper.

THE ARGUMENT — IS DEPOPULATION A CATASTROPHE OR A CORRECTION?

This is the argument the whole chapter has been building to, and I want to be clear that I am not going to settle it, because it is not fully settleable by evidence.

IT IS THE DEFINING PROBLEM OF THE CENTURY

Nothing else on the policy agenda compounds like this. Every other problem — climate, debt, disease — is a problem for people, and this one is a problem about whether there are people. A permanently below-replacement world means a permanently shrinking one, and shrinking is not a state you settle into; it is a direction you keep travelling. Progress in medicine, technology and living standards has been driven by more people building on each other's work, and there is no example in history of sustained progress in a shrinking population. Add to that the fact that nobody has ever reversed it, and the honest conclusion is that we are running an experiment with no known exit and no precedent.

IT IS AN ADJUSTMENT, AND THE PANIC IS DOING THE HARM

Every previous population panic was wrong, and each one licensed coercion — forced sterilisation in India, the one-child policy in China, abortion bans in Romania. The current panic is already producing proposals about what women should do with their bodies, which is a predictable cost and should be weighed against a speculative benefit. Meanwhile the change is slow enough to adapt to: a population falling one per cent a year gives a country decades. Japan proves a rich society can shrink for fifty years and remain one of the best places on Earth to live. And the environmental gains are real and immediate, while the innovation losses are theoretical and centuries away.

Where things stand: the factual disagreement is narrower than the volume suggests. Both sides accept the projections. Both accept that ageing costs money and that shrinking helps the climate. What they actually disagree about is a value question — how much weight to give people who do not exist yet against people who do, and how much coercion risk to accept for a benefit that arrives in a century.

What would settle it: nothing, and I want to say that plainly rather than pretend otherwise. There is no measurement that tells you how much a future person's existence is worth. That is a moral question wearing a statistical costume, and it will still be a moral question when all the data is in.

Why people care so much: because the answer determines whether governments are entitled to intervene in reproduction at all, and everyone on both sides knows it. The evidential dispute is a proxy. What is being fought over is permission.

There is one more thing both sides have in common, and neither of them mentions it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE NATION IS THE CONTAINER

Every fertility statistic in this document is national. Korea's rate. India's rate. Hungary's rate. The alarm is national — "our" population is falling. The reassurance is national — "our" economy will adapt. Even the migration argument is framed as what migration does for the receiving country.

But people are not contained by borders, and neither is the care they provide. Right now the global picture looks like this: rich ageing countries recruit nurses and care workers from poorer, younger countries. Those workers arrive already raised and

> already trained, at the cost of the country that raised and trained them. An Indian nurse working in Italy improves Italy's support ratio and worsens Kerala's, and appears in Italy's national accounts as a gain and in nobody's as a loss.
>
> So when a country announces a demographic crisis, the first question worth asking is: crisis for which container? A world with eight billion people, many of them young, has no shortage of humans. What some countries have is a shortage of humans *who are theirs*. Those are extremely different problems, and only one of them is about fertility.
>
> **The general form:** choosing the boundary that produces the crisis. The same move appears in every field. A firm reports a labour shortage at the wage it wants to pay. A city reports a housing shortage inside its own limits. A country reports a population crisis while the planet has more people than ever. The boundary is doing the work, and the boundary is a choice.
>
> Why it matters for this series specifically: the national framing is what turns a private question into a public duty. Nobody can be asked to have a child for the world. People can be, and are, asked to have children for a nation. The container is what makes the demand sayable.

Keep that in mind through the next chapter, which is where the demand gets made explicitly, and where we finally look at what it asks of the people who would have to satisfy it.

REMEMBER THIS

The alarmed case at its strongest: below-replacement fertility **compounds**. At 1.3, a hundred people become thirteen in five generations. Fewer people also means fewer inventors, unpayable pension promises, and a society whose politics is organised around protecting what already exists.

The calm case at its strongest: **every previous population panic was wrong**, income per person does not depend on population size, scarce labour has historically helped workers, fewer people helps the climate, and Japan has shrunk for fifty years while remaining one of the best places on Earth to live.

The distinction that resolves half of it: **a smaller population is not the problem; the transition is**. And if fertility never returns to replacement, the transition never ends.

Immigration works for an individual country and cannot work for the world. It is fast and proven and limited by politics, by the fact that migrants also age, and by the new fact that the sending countries are below replacement too.

What the two sides actually disagree about is not the data. It is how much a person who does not yet exist is worth, and how much coercion is acceptable in pursuit of them.

CHAPTER NINE

Who Pays For The Reversal

> *Suppose you accept the alarmed case. Suppose you want the number to go back up. This chapter is about what that actually requires, from whom, and what has happened every previous time somebody tried to require it.*

9.1 — The question, stated without decoration

A fertility rate is not raised by a government. It is raised by women being pregnant more often. Every policy, every campaign, every appeal to national duty ends at the same place: a specific woman, in a specific body, having a specific pregnancy she would not otherwise have had.

I will keep saying it, because this subject floats off into the abstract very easily. When a chief minister says the state needs a higher birth rate, he is not describing an economic target. He is describing something he wants several million individual women to do with their bodies over the next decade.

That does not make the wish illegitimate — societies ask things of people all the time, including taxes, jury service and conscription. It does mean the request has to be examined the way we examine any claim one group makes on another group's bodies, and not the way we examine a budget line.

9.2 — The gap runs in both directions

Here is the fact that makes this chapter more complicated than either side wants it to be.

Ask people in low-fertility countries how many children they would ideally like. The answer, consistently, across Europe, East Asia and America, is around two — sometimes a little more. Then look at what they end up with: often half a child less. There is a persistent gap between the family people say they want and the family they get.

That gap is the strongest card in the pronatalist hand, and it deserves to be played properly. It means the low numbers are not, mostly, a story of people who do not want children. They are a story of people who wanted children and ran out of time, money, partner or health. On that reading, raising fertility does not require persuading anybody of anything. It requires removing obstacles between people and something they already said they wanted.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
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> The most useful recent evidence is the United Nations Population Fund's 2025 report on fertility, which surveyed fourteen thousand adults across fourteen countries covering a large share of the world's population — and asked, unusually, about failure in **both** directions.
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> What it found: large numbers of people had fewer children than they wanted, mostly for economic reasons and lack of a partner. And large numbers had more than they wanted. In India, about one woman in five reported having had more children than she intended, most often because of what her community expected. Around three in ten Indian women reported feeling pressured to continue a pregnancy they did not want, and roughly one in seven said pressure from health workers had affected their reproductive goals.
>
> What it is good at: showing that the standard framing — women choosing fewer children — misses half the picture. What it is bad at: stated preferences are shaped by what people think they are supposed to want. A woman in a society that expects three children will often report wanting three. The gap is real; the ideal number it is measured against is not a fixed fact about human nature.

So the honest position is this. Some of the shortfall is genuinely unmet demand, and closing it costs women nothing and would help them. And some of it is not — some of it is that people, given the actual choice, want fewer children than the state wants them to have. No policy can tell the two apart in advance, and every government facing this problem has to decide how much of the gap it believes is the first kind.

9.3 — Three roads, and there is no fourth

Strip away the rhetoric and there are exactly three ways to raise a birth rate. Every scheme ever tried is one of these, or a mixture.

Road one: make children cheaper. Cash, tax breaks, childcare, housing, paid leave, job protection, fertility treatment, and men doing half the work at home. This is the humane road. It asks nothing of women that they have not already said they want. Chapter Six is the record of what it achieves: real effects, small effects, expensive effects, and no country back to replacement.

Road two: make the alternatives worse. This is never announced in these words, but it is what much of history consists of. If a woman cannot own property, hold a job, get an education, travel alone, or survive outside a marriage, then marriage and motherhood are not one option among several. They are the only option. Fertility is reliably high under those conditions. It is the most effective pronatalist technology ever devised, and every society that has had high fertility has had some version of it.

Road three: remove the exit. Restrict or ban contraception and abortion. Make divorce difficult. This does not change what anybody wants; it changes what they can do about it.

Almost every public argument about fertility is an argument about which of these three roads is being proposed while pretending to propose road one. That is worth watching for, in both directions — the pronatalist who talks about family values while meaning road two, and the opponent who treats every childcare subsidy as though it were road three.

9.4 — Romania, 1966, and what road three actually did

There is one clean, large, well-documented experiment on road three, and it is worth going through in detail because it is the closest thing this subject has to proof.

In October 1966 the government of Nicolae Ceaușescu, worried about a falling population, issued Decree 770. Abortion, which had been legal and was the main method of family limitation in Romania, was banned for most women. Contraceptive imports were cut off. Divorce was made harder. Childless adults were taxed. Women were subjected to regular workplace gynaecological examinations to detect and monitor pregnancies.

It worked, immediately and dramatically. The fertility rate roughly doubled within a year, from about 1.9 to about 3.7. The number of births in 1967 was nearly twice that of 1966. Measured against its own stated goal, Decree 770 is the single most successful pronatalist policy in recorded history.

Now the rest of it.

Within a few years the rate began falling again as people found their way around the ban, and within about a decade it was back down close to where it had started, despite the law remaining in force for twenty-three years. Illegal abortion became widespread and dangerous. Estimates of the number of Romanian women who died from unsafe abortions during the decree's lifetime run to around ten thousand, and maternal mortality rose to the highest in Europe by a wide margin. Many of the children born into families that could not support them ended up in state institutions, which is the origin of the Romanian orphanage crisis discovered by the world in 1989.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
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> Ten thousand deaths over twenty-three years is roughly one Romanian woman dying every twenty hours, for a generation, from a procedure that had been safe and legal the year before.
>
> And the payoff for that: a fertility rate that ended the period roughly where it began. The policy did not even deliver its own objective in the long run. It delivered one enormous cohort — the generation born in 1967, who went through overcrowded schools, then overcrowded universities, then a labour market with no room in it — and then a return to the previous trend, at that cost.

China provides the same lesson from the opposite direction. The one-child policy was the most aggressive antinatalist programme ever attempted, running from 1980 to 2015 with fines, forced insertions of contraceptive devices, and coerced abortions and sterilisations. When the state reversed course — two children permitted in 2016, three in 2021, and effectively no limit after that, with cash incentives attached — fertility carried on falling. Coercion could push the number down. Money and permission could not pull it back up.

That asymmetry is one of the most robust findings in this entire document, and it deserves stating on its own line. **Stopping births is easy and cheap. Causing births is hard and expensive. Force works in one direction only.**

9.5 — Where I have to be careful

I said in the front matter that I would flag this at the point where it applies, so here it is.

I am an Indian man in my twenties with no children. Everything in this chapter is a description of a cost I will never pay. There is a specific failure available to someone in my position, and it is not bias in the ordinary sense — it is that road two can be written down as a third bullet point on a list of options, in the same typeface as the other two, when for the people it applies to it is not an option among others but the removal of a life.

I have tried to guard against it by writing what each road requires in physical terms rather than policy terms. Whether that worked is not something I can judge from here. What I can do is tell you which way the error would run, so you can correct for it as you read.

There is a second thing. In India, a man writing about how many children women should have is writing inside a live political fight in which women are almost entirely the object and almost never the speaker. The chief ministers in Chapter Six are men. The seat calculation in Chapter Seven is being run by men. The community pressure recorded in the survey above is applied largely to daughters-in-law. I am one more male voice in a conversation that has never lacked one, and my only defence is to keep pointing at what the women in the data actually said — which is that many of them are already having a different number of children than they wanted, in both directions.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN A BIRTH RATE BE RAISED WITHOUT TAKING SOMETHING BACK FROM WOMEN?

This is the question the whole series has been walking towards. I am not going to answer it, and I want to be clear that this is a refusal, not an oversight.

YES, AND THE FAILURE SO FAR IS A FAILURE OF SERIOUSNESS

Nobody has actually tried road one properly. What has been tried is cash — the cheapest, laziest instrument available — plus childcare in some countries and paid leave in others, almost never all at once, almost never for thirty years, and almost never including the one thing that matters most, which is a labour market that does not punish a woman permanently for taking two years out. Add secure housing for people in their twenties, genuine job protection, fully funded fertility treatment, and men taking half the domestic load, and you are addressing the actual reasons people give in surveys for not having the children they said they wanted. The gap between wanted and achieved is real and it is roughly half a child. Closing it would get most countries most of the way back, and it would cost women nothing — it would give them something.

NO, AND PRETENDING OTHERWISE IS THE PROBLEM

Look at what has actually happened where road one was tried hardest. The Nordic countries built the most generous version of it in existence and their fertility fell by half a child anyway. Hungary spent five per cent of national income and ended where it started. If the strongest available version of the humane road produces a fifth of a child at enormous cost, then a country that genuinely needs another half a child cannot get there that way — and a government that genuinely believes it faces an existential crisis will not stop at policies that do not work. Historically it never has. The high-fertility societies of the past were not societies with better childcare. They were societies where women had fewer options, married younger, and could not leave. That is not a coincidence or a slander; it is what the record shows, and everyone arguing about this knows it.

A THIRD POSITION: THE QUESTION IS WRONG

Both sides above assume that some number is correct and the job is to reach it. Perhaps there is no correct number. Perhaps a fertility rate is simply the sum of several hundred million private lives and is not a policy variable at all, any more than the national average height is. On this view the right response to ageing is to build the institutions that ageing requires — pensions, care systems, immigration, automation — and to stop treating the birth rate as a lever, because treating it as a lever is what produces Decree 770.

Where things stand: unresolved, and genuinely so. The evidence establishes that road one has real but small effects, and that roads two and three work but at costs that most people, when the costs are named plainly, will not accept. It does not establish whether a much more serious version of road one would work, because no country has built one.

What would settle it: a rich country that spends at Hungarian levels, on services rather than cash, with equal domestic labour and secure housing for the under-thirties, sustained for thirty years, and then reports its completed cohort fertility. Until somebody runs that, both sides are arguing from the same absence.

Why people care so much: because if the answer is no — if fertility cannot be raised without taking something back from women — then a society facing demographic decline has to choose between two things it says it values. Everyone involved can see that fork coming, and the argument is fought at this volume because both sides would rather win it before the choice becomes explicit.

One last thing, and it is aimed at this document rather than at anybody else's.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — MINE

I have now written nine chapters treating the number of children born in a country as a thing that can be evaluated, worried about, projected and, if necessary, managed. I have weighed the alarmed case against the calm case as though the question were open and interesting. I have used phrases like "the bill", "the reversal" and "what would settle it".

Every one of those framings assumes something I never argued for: that **the sum of several hundred million private reproductive lives is a legitimate object of public policy**, and that there exists a "we" with standing to have a view about it.

Notice that both sides of every argument in this part share that premise. The pronatalist wants the number up. The relaxed side says the number is fine. The environmentalist wants it down. All three are treating the aggregate as something a society is entitled to hold an opinion about. The only position that does not is one almost nobody defends in public: that the number is simply what it is, that it belongs to the people who produced it, and that having a national view about it is already the beginning of the problem.

> I do not know whether that position is right. I notice that I did not consider it until I had written eighty pages, and that the entire structure of this part — its chapters, its arguments, its arithmetic — only makes sense if it is wrong. That is exactly the kind of assumption this series exists to dig out, and I found it underneath my own document rather than underneath somebody else's.
>
> **The general form:** treating the sum of private decisions as a lever. It appears wherever an aggregate has a name — the birth rate, the savings rate, the marriage rate, the crime rate. Naming a total makes it feel like a thing that someone is responsible for, and once a total has a custodian, the individuals inside it become inputs.
>
> I am leaving this part standing as written rather than rewriting it around this, because the point of the box is to show you the floor you have been walking on for eighty pages. But read the last eight chapters again with it in mind. Several of the arguments look different.

That is where this part ends, and it ends without a verdict, which I know is unsatisfying. The next chapter is the standing accounting: what in all of this is genuinely unknown, and what is solid enough to build on.

REMEMBER THIS

A birth rate is not raised by governments. It is raised by **specific women having specific pregnancies**. Every policy in this part ends there.

The gap between the children people say they want and the children they have is real, roughly half a child, and runs in **both directions** — in India, about one woman in five reports having had more children than she intended.

There are exactly three roads: **make children cheaper**, **make the alternatives worse**, or **remove the exit.** Most public arguments are about roads two or three while claiming to be about road one.

Romania's Decree 770 doubled the birth rate in a year — and within a decade it was back near where it started, at a cost of roughly ten thousand women's lives. China's reversal shows the same thing from the other side: force can push births down and cannot pull them up.

Nobody has yet shown that a birth rate can be raised substantially by any method that costs women nothing. That is the honest state of the evidence, and it is why this argument is being fought so hard.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Every part of this series ends the same way. Two lists: what is genuinely unknown, and what is solid enough to build on. This is the most useful chapter in the document and the one almost nobody else writes.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

The reason a thing is unknown is usually more interesting than the gap itself. Each item below comes with its reason.

WHERE FERTILITY SETTLES

Nobody knows whether the very low rates in East Asia are a floor, a passing low, or a station on the way further down. Every projection published in the last thirty years has assumed some floor and most have been wrong. The reason we do not know: we have never observed a society at 0.8 for a full generation, so there is no case to reason from. Korea will be the first, and it will take twenty years to read.

HOW MUCH OF THE DECLINE IS TIMING AND HOW MUCH IS TOTAL

Chapter One set this out. The period rate overstates the fall; the tempo-adjusted rate understates it. We will know the answer for women born in the 1990s in about fifteen years and not before. The reason we do not know: you cannot measure a completed family before it is completed. This is the only item on this list with a guaranteed answer and a known delivery date.

WHETHER A SERIOUS VERSION OF THE HUMANE ROAD WOULD WORK

The great absence in this whole field. No country has ever run the full package — generous services rather than cash, secure housing for people in their twenties, genuine job protection through childbearing, and equal domestic labour — sustained for a generation, without a recession or a change of government. Every claim that it would work and every claim that it would not is therefore an extrapolation. The reason we do not know: the experiment is expensive, slow, and politically impossible to hold steady for thirty years.

HOW FAST AFRICAN FERTILITY WILL FALL

The single largest source of uncertainty in every world population projection. The credible range for when sub-Saharan Africa reaches replacement spans about forty years. The reason we do not know: the region is in the early part of its transition, and every previous region has moved faster than forecast, but the countries with the highest rates also have the weakest schooling and the highest child mortality. Genuine data is coming, on a known schedule.

WHETHER THE RECENT KOREAN REBOUND IS REAL

Two years of rising births after eight years of falling. It tracks a surge in postponed weddings and a temporarily large cohort of women in their thirties, both of which will pass. Whether anything underneath it has changed is not knowable yet. The reason we do not know: two data points do not distinguish an echo from a turn, and no method exists that can.

WHAT THE RETENTION RATES OF HIGH-FERTILITY RELIGIOUS COMMUNITIES WILL BE

The inheritance argument in Chapter Five stands or falls on this and the data is thin, contested, and mostly about small communities. The reason we do not know: retention only becomes measurable when a generation has grown up and chosen, and the communities in question have only recently become large enough for the question to matter.

WHETHER AGEING SOCIETIES ACTUALLY INNOVATE LESS

The claim that fewer people means slower progress is theoretically well grounded and empirically almost untested, because no large society has yet been through a sustained population decline in a modern economy. Japan is the closest case and its record is genuinely mixed. The reason we do not know: the sample size is one, and it is only fifty years in.

WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY WANT

Every survey of desired family size is measuring an answer given inside a set of expectations. A woman who says she wants three in a society that expects three, and a woman who says she wants one in a society that expects one, may or may not want different things. The reason we do not know: there is no way to ask a person what they would want in a society they have never lived in.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> One absence on the list above is worth treating as evidence rather than as a gap.
>
> India has run a Sample Registration System since the 1970s and a National Family Health Survey since 1992. It has counted births, deaths, infant mortality and fertility by state, by residence and by education, continuously, for fifty years. It has one of the better demographic statistical systems in the developing world.
>
> What it has not done is publish a decennial census since 2011. The census due in 2021 was postponed, and the delimitation of parliamentary seats — the fight described in Chapter Seven — depends on it.
>
> When a state has the capacity to count something and the count is delayed while a political question rides on it, the delay is a finding rather than an oversight. It does not tell you what the numbers would show. It does tell you that somebody understands what they would trigger.

10.2 — Solid

Now the other list. These things can be built on. Each comes with the reason it is solid, which is usually that independent sources with no shared interest agree.

THE FALL HAPPENED, AND IT IS VERY LARGE

World fertility has roughly halved in seventy years, from about five to about 2.25. This is confirmed by vital registration in rich countries, household surveys in poor ones, school enrolment numbers, and the age structures visible in every census on Earth. Nobody disputes it in any direction.

INDIA IS BELOW REPLACEMENT, AND ITS STATES DIFFER ENORMOUSLY

The Sample Registration System put India at 1.9 in 2023, with urban India at 1.5 and rural India at 2.1. Delhi is at 1.2, Bihar at 2.8, eighteen states and union territories below the replacement line. Urban India crossed in 2004. These figures come from a system that has used the same dual-recording method for fifty years, which makes the trend particularly reliable.

CHILD SURVIVAL CAME FIRST

Everywhere it has been studied, the fall in child mortality preceded the fall in fertility. This is visible in European parish registers, in Indian survey data, and in the sixty-year field study at Matlab in Bangladesh. Three completely different kinds of record, in three centuries, agreeing.

EDUCATION IS THE STRONGEST SINGLE PREDICTOR

Across countries and within them, how long a woman stayed in school predicts how many children she has better than her income or her religion. In India the gap between no schooling and completed schooling has consistently exceeded a full child. This has held across five rounds of the National Family Health Survey over thirty years.

THE HINDU–MUSLIM FERTILITY GAP IN INDIA IS REAL AND HAS MORE THAN HALVED

About 1.1 children in 1992–93; about 0.42 in 2019–21. Muslim fertility in the southern states is lower than Hindu fertility in the northern states. Same survey, same questions, five rounds, one direction.

NO COUNTRY HAS RESTORED REPLACEMENT FERTILITY THROUGH POLICY

This is solid because it is a negative claim about a well-documented set of attempts. Hungary, Poland, Russia, Singapore, Japan, Korea and France have all tried, several at enormous expense, and their completed fertility figures are published. The effects that exist are small. The claim is not that policy does nothing; it is that nothing has got a country back to 2.1.

FORCE WORKS IN ONE DIRECTION ONLY

Coercive antinatalism has repeatedly and rapidly reduced births — China's one-child policy, India's sterilisation drive of 1975–77. Coercive pronatalism produces a large one-off spike and then decays, as Romania's Decree 770 showed across twenty-three years. And China's post-2016 reversal, with permission and money attached, did not raise fertility at all. Different countries, different systems, same asymmetry.

AGEING IS ARITHMETIC, NOT OPINION

India's old-age support ratio falls from roughly ten working-age people per person over sixty-five to roughly four by 2050. That is not a forecast about behaviour. The people who will be sixty-five in 2050 are alive now and can be counted. Fertility projections are unreliable; near-term ageing projections are close to certain, because everyone involved has already been born.

INDIA'S OLD-AGE PROVISION IS THIN, AND THE SYSTEM IS THE FAMILY

About one in five people over sixty has any pension. The central share of the pension for the poorest has been ₹200 a month since 2007. A 2007 statute obliges children to maintain their parents. Survey data, administrative data and the law itself all say the same thing.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: where fertility settles, how much of the fall is timing, whether a serious version of the humane road would work, how fast Africa falls, whether Korea's rebound is real, and what people would want in a society that expected something different from them.

Solid: the fall happened and is very large; India is below replacement with enormous variation between states; child survival came first; education predicts fertility better than religion or income; the Hindu–Muslim gap is real and has more than halved; no country has policied its way back to replacement; force works only downwards; and near-term ageing is arithmetic rather than forecast.

One absence is itself informative. India can count and has counted for fifty years, and the census that would trigger the redistribution of parliamentary seats has not been held since 2011.

The most important thing on either list is the third item: the humane road has never been properly tried, so the central question of this part is genuinely open — and everybody arguing about it is arguing from the same missing experiment.

Timeline

Two hundred and thirty years of counting people, and of governments deciding what the count meant.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1798	Thomas Malthus publishes his essay arguing that population grows faster than food. Wrong about the future, enormously influential about it.
1877	The Bradlaugh–Besant trial in London puts birth control information in front of a jury and on the front pages. British fertility begins its long fall shortly afterwards.
1934	Alva and Gunnar Myrdal publish *Crisis in the Population Question* in Sweden, arguing that the answer to falling births is a welfare state rather than a ban. The first modern statement of road one.
1952	India becomes the first country in the world to adopt a national family planning programme.
1960	The contraceptive pill is approved in the United States.
1966	Romania issues Decree 770. Abortion is banned, contraception cut off, divorce restricted. Births nearly double within a year.
1968	Paul Ehrlich publishes *The Population Bomb*, predicting famines that do not arrive.
1974	Japan's fertility falls below replacement. At Bucharest, the world population conference hears the argument that development is the best contraceptive.
1975–77	India's Emergency. A mass sterilisation campaign produces millions of operations, lasting public distrust, and no change in the underlying trend.
1980	China's one-child policy begins.
1987	Singapore reverses from antinatalist to pronatalist policy. Its fertility continues to fall for the next thirty-six years.
1992–93	India's first National Family Health Survey. Hindu–Muslim fertility gap measured at about 1.1 children.
1994	The Cairo conference shifts global policy from population targets towards reproductive rights and women's health.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2000	Peter McDonald publishes the gender equity theory. The term "lowest-low fertility" is coined for rates at or below 1.3.
2004	Urban India falls below replacement fertility, fifteen years before the country does.
2007	Russia introduces maternity capital. India passes the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, obliging children to support their parents, and sets the central old-age pension share at ₹200 a month.
2009	The J-curve paper appears in *Nature*, suggesting fertility rises again at very high development.
2010	Hungary begins the most ambitious pronatalist programme in any democracy.
2015	China ends the one-child policy. Fertility keeps falling.
2016	Poland introduces a large universal child benefit. A two-year rise is followed by the lowest fertility in Polish history.
2019	India's fertility rate falls below the replacement line by official Indian estimates.
2022	China's population falls for the first time in six decades.
2023	South Korea records 0.72, the lowest national fertility rate ever measured anywhere. Singapore falls below 1.0. India's Sample Registration System reports rural India at replacement for the first time.
2024	Andhra Pradesh repeals its two-child bar on contesting local elections and urges larger families. The United Nations projects a world population peak of about 10.3 billion in the 2080s.
2025	Korea's rate rises to about 0.80 on a surge of postponed marriages. The United Nations Population Fund reports that people are missing their fertility goals in both directions.
2026	Telangana abolishes its own two-child norm. India's freeze on the redistribution of parliamentary seats reaches its expiry.
Next	**Part Ten starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Age-specific fertility rate	The share of women of one particular age who gave birth in a given year. Add these up across all ages and you get the total fertility rate.
Antinatalism	Policy aimed at reducing births. India's sterilisation drive and China's one-child policy are the two largest examples in history.
Cohort fertility	The real average number of children had by women born in the same year, counted once they have finished. Accurate, and available only decades late.
Crude birth rate	Births per thousand people in a year. Easier to measure than fertility but misleading, because it depends on how many young women a country happens to have.
Decree 770	Romania's 1966 law banning abortion for most women. The most successful pronatalist policy ever measured, and the most costly.
Delimitation	Redrawing constituency boundaries and reallocating parliamentary seats between Indian states according to population. Frozen since 1976; the freeze expires in 2026.
Demography	The study of populations by counting them — births, deaths, moves and ages.
Demographic dividend	The temporary economic advantage a country gets when it has many working-age people and few dependants. It is a window, not a gift, and it converts into growth only if the workers have work.
Demographic transition	The standard sequence: deaths fall, then births fall, with a population explosion in between.
Differential fertility	Different groups within a country having different numbers of children, which shifts the population's composition over generations.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Ecological fallacy	Assuming that a pattern between countries also holds inside them. The commonest mistake in popular writing about fertility.
IGNOAPS	The Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme, India's pension for the very poor. The central government's share has been ₹200 a month since 2007.
Human Development Index	A single score combining life expectancy, schooling and income, used to compare countries on something other than money.
LASI	The Longitudinal Ageing Study in India, a large repeated survey of Indians aged sixty and over, covering income, health and who supports whom.
Lowest-low fertility	A total fertility rate at or below 1.3. Named in 2000, when it was thought to be rare and temporary.
NFHS	The National Family Health Survey, India's large household survey, run in five rounds since 1992. The only Indian source that breaks fertility down by religion, caste and education.
Old-age support ratio	How many working-age people there are for each person over sixty-five. India is at roughly ten and heading for about four.
Opportunity cost	What you give up in order to do something — not the money it costs, but the next-best option you had to drop.
Pay-as-you-go	A pension system that pays today's pensioners out of today's workers' taxes. Nothing is stored; it is the children system run through a government.
Period fertility	The snapshot version of the fertility rate: all births in one year, across women of every age. This is what the headlines quote.
Population momentum	The tendency of a population to keep growing for decades after fertility falls to replacement, because of the shape of its age pyramid. It also runs in reverse.
Pronatalism	Policy aimed at increasing births, from cash payments at one end to bans on contraception at the other.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Quantity–quality trade-off	The idea that parents choose not only how many children to have but how much to invest in each, and shift towards fewer children once investing pays.
Quantum	How many children a woman ends up with in total, as opposed to when she has them.
Replacement level	The fertility rate at which each generation exactly replaces the last. About 2.1 where almost all children survive; higher where they do not.
Retention rate	The share of children raised in a group who still belong to it as adults. The hinge of the whole inheritance argument.
SRS	The Sample Registration System, India's continuous dual-recording survey of births and deaths, running since the 1970s.
Tempo effect	The distortion in the yearly fertility rate caused by people shifting the timing of births. Postponement pushes the number below the truth.
Total Fertility Rate (TFR)	A summary of one year's births, arranged to look like a lifetime. Not a count of anybody's actual children.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and I publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This series began with something small and ugly. A woman was photographed at a protest and was attacked online with a claim about how she earns money. I found I was less interested in her, or in the people attacking her, than in the machinery underneath — the rules about what women may do, where those rules came from, what they were for, and what actually happens when they change. Nine parts later I am still working through it, and I have changed my mind about several things on the way.

I am not a demographer. I am someone who reads the primary sources carefully, follows the numbers to whichever conclusion they reach, and writes down what I find in language that does not require a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — national statistical agencies, United Nations population data, peer-reviewed demography, and India's own Sample Registration System, National Family Health Survey and Longitudinal Ageing Study — rather than new primary research. Where a figure is contested I have given the range and said why the ends of it differ.

What that archive is good at: counting. Births, deaths, ages and pensions are recorded by institutions that had to record them for other reasons, which makes them hard to bend. What it is bad at: intentions. Almost everything in this part about what people *wanted* comes from surveys, and a survey answer is shaped by what the person answering thinks they are supposed to say. I have flagged this wherever a claim rests on it, and Chapter Ten lists it among the things we do not know.

Where a claim rests only on an institution's account of itself — a government's own estimate of what its family policy achieved, for instance — I have said so in the text rather than passing it on as established.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

This part has been about what happens to a society when the number falls. Part Ten narrows all the way down, to the level at which the whole argument is actually conducted: what the evidence says happens to a woman.

This is the part the series has been circling since Chapter Five of Part One, and it is where the traditionalist warning gets tested directly rather than described. The questions it takes on:

- What does the research actually find about the number of partners a woman has had and the stability of a later marriage — how large is the association, how consistent is it, and what happens to it once you account for everything that comes bundled with it?
- Is there a regret asymmetry between men and women in the survey data, how big is it, and does it survive the obvious objection about who is willing to report what?
- What do the health and mental-health findings genuinely establish, and where does the reporting of them outrun what the studies measured?
- How much of this literature is correlation being sold as causation — and what would a study have to look like before it could tell the two apart?
- Does the portability test from Part One, Chapter Five hold here: do the same findings appear in societies with completely different rules, or do they travel with the rules rather than with the behaviour?
- And the question underneath all of it: if a cost is real but is produced by the punishment rather than by the act, whose cost is it?

END OF PART NINE OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Ten — What the Evidence Says Happens to a Woman

The warning at the centre of this whole series is a prediction: that a woman who breaks the rules damages her own life. This part treats it as a prediction, checks it against the research, and reports what the research can and cannot show.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Nine was about arithmetic. Across most of the world, and now across most of India, women are having fewer children than are needed to replace the people already alive. I went through what that number actually measures, why it fell, whether any government has ever pushed it back up, and who would have to pay if one tried.

The short version. The fertility rate is not a count of anybody's children — it is a snapshot of one year dressed up to look like a lifetime. It fell because children stopped dying, because children stopped being workers and became investments, and above all because the cost of a child rose sharply for the person who bears it. No country has ever restored replacement fertility through policy, though several have spent enormous sums trying. Coercion works in one direction only: it can push births down, and it cannot pull them up. And underneath the whole argument sat an unpriced assumption — that somebody would be available to do the physical work of caring for the old, which in every society on Earth means women.

Part Nine was written at the scale of nations. Millions of people, decades, national statistics. That scale is honest for the question it was asking, and it is also where this subject goes to hide. It is very easy to discuss birth rates for eighty pages without once picturing a person.

So this part goes the other way. All the way down.

Every part of this series so far has circled one specific claim without ever testing it head-on. The claim is that a woman who breaks the rules about sexual behaviour damages her own life — that she will struggle to marry, that her marriage will fail, that she will regret it, that she will be less healthy, less happy, less able to attach to anyone. It is the warning your grandmother gives. It is the warning a stranger gives a woman on the internet. It is offered not as a moral rule but as a kindness: *I am telling you this for your own good.*

That is a prediction. Predictions can be checked. This part checks it.

How this document is built

If you have read earlier parts you know the notation already. If not, here is the whole system. Six kinds of box, each doing one job, each looking different so you can see at a glance what you are about to read.

The first explains a hard word the moment it appears, so you never carry an unexplained term forward.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Association:** two things going up and down together. Taller people tend to weigh more, so height and weight are associated.
>
> Why it matters here: almost every finding in this document is an association. An association tells you that if you know one thing about a person, you can guess a little better about the other. It does not tell you that one caused the other, and the gap between those two sentences is what most of this part is about.

The second takes a number too big or too abstract to picture and turns it into something with a body.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> A researcher says a factor "doubles the risk" of something. That sounds enormous. Then you learn the risk went from two in a hundred to four in a hundred.
>
> Both statements are true. One of them makes you frightened and the other makes you shrug, and the second one is the one that tells you what to expect. Whenever you meet a multiplied risk in this document, I will give you the underlying numbers as well.

The third shows the actual evidence behind a claim, and then says what that evidence cannot show. It is the box that lets you decide how much to trust a sentence.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Most of what is known about sexual behaviour and later life outcomes comes from a handful of large national surveys, which ask people about their own pasts. In the United States that is chiefly the **National Survey of Family Growth**. In Britain it is the **National Survey of Sexual Attitudes and Lifestyles**. In India it is the **National Family Health Survey**.

What they are good at: size, repetition and consistency. Tens of thousands of people, the same questions across decades, so a change over time is a real change.

What they are bad at: they are asking people to report, honestly, on the thing they have most reason to lie about. Chapter One is entirely about how badly that goes.

The fourth is for places where informed people genuinely disagree. Each side gets its best case, not a version I find easy to knock down.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

Every one of these has the same shape. A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not claim more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes the honest answer is that nothing available would.

The fifth is the signature of this series. It does not argue with either side. It digs out what both sides are assuming without noticing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Not caveats, not disclaimers. Unexamined premises sitting underneath an argument everybody is having. There are five in this part, and the last one is turned on this document.

The sixth closes every chapter, restating it in the plainest words available. A reader who read only these should still have the whole argument.

REMEMBER THIS

Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.

Simple words, serious content, nothing left out.

Three warnings specific to this part

The first is about me, and it is heavier here than anywhere else in the series. I am an Indian man in my twenties. This part is about women's sexual histories and what happens to them afterwards. I am not a neutral instrument pointed at this question: I grew up inside the culture that issues the warning, I have heard it applied to women I know, and I have almost certainly repeated versions of it without examining them. There are two errors available to someone in my position. One is to find the warning confirmed because it is familiar. The other is to overcorrect and find it refuted because refuting it feels modern. I have tried to guard against both by writing down the effect sizes rather than the conclusions, and by giving the traditionalist case its genuinely strongest form in Chapter Nine rather than a version I can dismiss. Where I think I am at risk, I say so in the text.

The second is about tone. Nothing in this part is advice to any woman about what to do, and nothing in it is a judgement of any woman for what she has done. A document that reported “the research finds X” and then added “so be careful” would be smuggling a recommendation in behind a finding. I am not doing that. What each reader should do with this is genuinely their business, and Chapter Nine explains why I think handing down advice here would be a category error rather than modesty.

The third is about the evidence itself. This is one of the most politically loaded research literatures in the social sciences. Findings here are picked up within hours by people who want them to mean something. Studies get quoted with the confounders stripped out, effect sizes get inflated in the retelling, and null results get very little attention in either direction. I have tried to give you the original size of every finding, who produced it, and what it does not establish. Where a claim is popular but weakly supported I say so — **in whichever direction that cuts**, and in this part it cuts both ways more than once.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

What Is Actually Being Claimed

> *Before you can test a warning you have to know what it predicts. This one turns out to be four different warnings wearing the same coat, and the central number it depends on is among the least reliable in social science.*

1.1 — Four warnings in one coat

The warning sounds like a single thing. *She will ruin her life.* Listen closely and it is four separate claims, and they do not stand or fall together.

The market claim. She will struggle to find a husband. Men will not want her. Her family will not be able to arrange a match.

The bond claim. Even if she marries, the marriage will be worse. She will compare. She will not attach properly. It will end.

The feeling claim. She will regret it. She will carry something heavy. She will be less happy, and the unhappiness will come from inside her rather than from anybody else.

The body claim. She will pick up infections. She will be less able to have children when she wants them.

Separate these and something becomes visible immediately. The market claim is not a claim about her at all. It is a claim about what other people will do to her. If it is true, the warning is not describing a consequence. It is describing a punishment, and it is being delivered by the same community that administers it.

The other three are genuinely about her. They say something happens inside a woman, or to her body, that would happen whether or not anybody found out. Those are the claims that can be tested against research, and they are what Chapters Two to Six are for. Chapter Seven then does the test that separates the two kinds.

1.2 — The number that cannot be true

Nearly all of this research rests on one variable: how many sexual partners a person has had. So before anything else, we should look at how well that number can be measured. The answer is: badly, in a way that is not a small technical problem.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> Take any large national survey of sexual behaviour — the American National Survey of Family Growth, the British National Survey of Sexual Attitudes and Lifestyles, and their equivalents elsewhere. Ask men how many women they have slept with. Ask women how many men. Then add up each side.
>
> The totals do not match. Men report substantially more opposite-sex partners than women do — commonly around twice as many, sometimes more, and the gap appears in survey after survey, decade after decade, country after country.
>
> This is not a finding about behaviour. It is arithmetically impossible. In a population with roughly equal numbers of men and women, every heterosexual encounter is counted once by a man and once by a woman. The two totals have to be equal. They never are.

So at least one side is wrong, and probably both. Researchers who have investigated this find several things happening at once. Men with high counts tend to estimate rather than count, and estimates round upwards. Women appear to undercount, particularly encounters they would rather not include. Both sexes answer differently depending on how the question is asked, who is asking, and whether the answer is typed privately or spoken aloud to an interviewer. And some of the gap is definitional — people disagree about what counts.

WORD BOX

Social desirability bias: the tendency to give the answer that makes you look the way you are supposed to look, rather than the true one. It is not usually deliberate lying. It is the pull of the expected answer.

Why it matters here: the pull runs in **opposite directions for men and women** on exactly this question. A high number is a credit to a man and a debit to a woman in most cultures on Earth. So the error is not random noise that averages out. It is systematic, and it is pointed.

The scale of that is easier to see if you take the arithmetic seriously for a moment.

IN REAL TERMS

Imagine a village of a hundred men and a hundred women who only ever sleep with each other. Every encounter involves one of each. If you ask everybody and add up the answers, the men's total and the women's total must come to the same number. They must. There is no arrangement of behaviour that makes them differ.

Now run the actual surveys and the men's total comes out roughly double. That is the size of the reporting problem sitting underneath every study in this part. **Not a rounding error — a factor of two, in the single variable everything else is measured against.**

Hold that in mind through the next four chapters. It does not make the research worthless. Errors of this kind mostly blur associations rather than invent them, which means a real relationship will show up weaker than it is, not stronger. But it does mean that precise-sounding numbers — “women with exactly two partners” — are being built on a variable that cannot bear that much weight.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN THIS BE STUDIED AT ALL?

Some people conclude from the above that the whole literature is unusable. That is a serious position and it deserves a serious answer.

THE CORE VARIABLE IS CORRUPTED

You cannot build knowledge on a number that is provably wrong by a factor of two, and wrong in a direction that tracks exactly the social pressure the research is supposed to be studying. Worse, the misreporting is not evenly spread: the women most exposed to shame are the ones most likely to under-report, which means the survey category "women with one partner" quietly contains an unknown number of women with more. Every finding about partner count is therefore a finding about *reported* partner count, which is a measure of willingness to disclose as much as of behaviour.

IMPERFECT MEASURES STILL CARRY INFORMATION

Almost everything in social science is measured imperfectly — income, health, happiness — and we do not throw those out. What matters is whether the error is likely to create a false finding or hide a true one, and random or blurring error does the second. Where the same association appears across different countries, different decades, different survey methods and different research groups, it is unlikely to be an artefact of one questionnaire. And some of these studies do not depend on exact counts at all: comparing women with zero partners to women with many is robust to a good deal of misreporting at the edges.

Where things stand: the honest middle. Broad comparisons — none versus several, few versus many — survive the measurement problem. Fine-grained comparisons between adjacent categories do not, and should be read as suggestive at best. Any finding that depends on the difference between two partners and three is standing on sand.

What would settle it: validation against something that is not self-report. Some of this exists indirectly — infection rates, pregnancy records — but there is no way to independently verify a life history, and there never will be.

Why people care so much: because the finer the category, the more specific the advice that can be built on it. "Women with exactly two partners" makes a headline. "Women with several rather than none" does not.

There is one more thing about how this evidence is collected, and it is the largest fact in the chapter. It is not in the numbers. It is in what was never collected.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THERE IS ONLY ONE PERSON TO MEASURE

Every study in this part asks what happens to **women.** The warning is issued to women. The research question is asked about women. And, quietly, the data needed to ask it about men often does not exist.

The American survey that produced the best-known findings on premarital partners and divorce does not carry full information on men's premarital sexual behaviour. The researcher who published those findings said so himself, in the same paper. So when the results appeared and were used to argue that a woman's history predicts her marriage, the comparison that would have told you whether this is a fact about sexual history or a fact about *women's* sexual history had already been made impossible at the design stage.

That is not a conspiracy. It is what happens when a question feels natural in one direction and strange in the other. Nobody set out to make the male comparison unavailable. They simply never felt the need to collect it, because the interesting question — the one that seemed worth funding a survey to answer — was always about her.

The general form: a question asked about only one group, so the data that would allow comparison is never gathered, and the absence is then read as though the answer were known. It appears everywhere. Pain research conducted on men. Crash-test dummies built to a male body. Drug trials that excluded women for decades. In each case the missing half is not a gap in the findings — it is a gap in what was ever asked.

Why this one matters for everything that follows: a large share of the arguing in this field is about how big the effect on women is. Almost none of it is about whether the same effect exists in men. If it does, then this is not a rule about women at all, and the warning has been aimed at the wrong half of the population for a century. If it does not, that is a genuine finding — and one nobody has properly established, because the survey did not ask.

1.3 — What would count as the warning being true

Let me set the bar before we look at any evidence, so I cannot move it afterwards.

For the warning to be true in the way it is meant — as advice, as a kindness, as a fact about the world — three things would have to hold.

The association would have to be real. Women with more partners would have to do measurably worse on the outcomes named, in good data, more than once.

It would have to be caused by the behaviour, rather than by something that produces both. If the same trait or circumstance leads a woman both to have more partners and to have a rockier marriage, then changing the first would change nothing.

It would have to be large enough to matter to a person. An effect can be real, causal, and still too small to base a life on.

Those three tests structure the rest of this part. Chapter Two takes the first. Chapter Three takes the second. And the third — the size — is why every number in this document comes with its underlying figures rather than a multiplier.

REMEMBER THIS

The warning is **four claims, not one**: that she will not be able to marry, that her marriage will be worse, that she will feel worse, and that her body will suffer. They need different evidence and they have different implications.

The first of those — that men will not want her — is **not a claim about her**. It is a claim about what other people will do, delivered by the people who will do it.

The whole literature rests on **self-reported partner counts**, and men's and women's totals do not match. They cannot both be right; in a closed population the two sums must be equal. The gap is often around a factor of two.

The error is not random. It runs in **opposite directions for men and women**, because a high number is a credit to one and a debit to the other.

The data needed to ask the same question about men was frequently never collected — so the comparison that would tell you whether this is about sexual history or about women's sexual history has been unavailable from the start.

CHAPTER TWO

The Divorce Question

> *This is the oldest finding in the field and the one the warning leans on hardest. The association is real. It is also smaller, stranger and less stable over time than almost anyone quoting it realises.*

2.1 — Ninety years of the same result

In 1938 the American psychologist Lewis Terman published a study of marital happiness which reported that women who had had sex before marriage were more likely to have unstable marriages, and that more partners went with more instability. Terman was a pioneer of psychological testing. He was also an enthusiastic eugenicist, which is worth knowing, because the question of what a woman's sexual history does to her did not arrive in the research literature neutrally. It arrived carried by people who already had views about which women should be having children.

Since then the basic association has been found again many times, in different countries, with better methods. That matters. A finding that survives ninety years, several changes of research fashion, and a complete transformation in the behaviour being studied is not nothing.

So let us be clear at the outset: **the association is real.** Anyone who tells you the research shows no relationship between premarital sexual history and later marital stability is not describing the literature.

The interesting questions are what shape it has, how big it is, and what causes it. All three answers are surprising.

2.2 — The actual numbers

The most detailed public analysis comes from Nicholas Wolfinger, a sociologist at the University of Utah, using the American National Survey of Family Growth. He looked at more than ten thousand women and calculated the share whose marriages ended within five years, sorted by how many sexual partners they reported before marrying.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The **National Survey of Family Growth** is a large, repeated, nationally representative American survey run by the federal statistics agency. It asks about partners, marriages, cohabitation, births and separations, and it has run in waves for decades. Wolfinger used the three most recent waves available to him, collected in 2002, 2006–2010 and 2011–2013, and grouped women by the decade in which they married.

What that design is good at: sample size, national representativeness, and the ability to compare decades using the same instrument.

What it is bad at: everything in Chapter One. It is self-report, it depends on remembering and being willing to say, and — as noted there — it does not carry equivalent data on men.

One more thing you should know and weigh for yourself. These analyses were published through the Institute for Family Studies, an American organisation with a stated commitment to marriage. That does not make the numbers wrong; the underlying survey is public and the finding long predates the organisation. It does mean you are reading a result produced by people who were pleased to find it, and the honest thing is to say so rather than present it as though it came from nowhere.

Here are the figures for women who married in the 2000s. The number is the percentage whose marriage had ended within five years.

PREMARITAL PARTNERS	DIVORCED WITHIN FIVE YEARS
None (married as a virgin)	About 6 per cent
One	Just over 20 per cent
Three to nine	About 25 per cent
Two	About 30 per cent
Ten or more	About 33 per cent

Read that table slowly, because it does not say what people think it says.

2.3 — The curve is not a line

The warning predicts a line. More partners, worse outcome, all the way up. That is not what the table shows.

Women with **two** partners divorced more than women with **three to nine**. In earlier decades the pattern was even stranger: among women marrying in the 1980s and 1990s, those with exactly two premarital partners were more likely to divorce than those with ten or more.

Wolfinger's own summary of this was that if you are going to have comparisons to your future husband, it is better to have more than one. Whether or not that explanation is right, the shape is the point. A dose-response relationship — more of the thing, more of the harm — is what you expect when something is genuinely causing damage. This is not that shape.

WORD BOX

Dose-response relationship: when more of a cause produces more of an effect, steadily. More cigarettes, more lung cancer. It is one of the strongest signs that a relationship is genuinely causal.

Non-monotonic: a relationship that goes up and then down, or down and then up. The middle is worse than either end, or better.

Why it matters: a non-monotonic relationship is a warning sign that you are looking at several different groups of people mixed together, rather than one process operating at different strengths. Women with two partners are probably not “women with one partner, only more so”. They are likely a different kind of situation altogether.

The other feature of the table is the size of the first step. The gap between no partners and one partner is about fourteen percentage points. The gap between one partner and ten or more is about thirteen. In other words, **roughly half of the total range in this table is crossed between zero and one** — between never having had sex before marriage and having had sex only with the man you married.

That is not a story about how many. It is a story about whether at all, and it points at something other than accumulation. Women who marry as virgins in a country where five per cent of brides do are an extremely distinctive group — highly religious, usually marrying young into a community that supports the marriage heavily, and often facing a much higher barrier to divorce regardless of how the marriage is going. Chapter Three takes that apart.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Take a hundred American women who married in the 2000s having had ten or more partners. Within five years, about 33 of those marriages had ended, and about 67 had not.
>
> Now take a hundred who had three to nine. About 25 ended; 75 did not.
>
> The difference between those two groups is about eight women in a hundred. Real, and worth knowing. But the sentence "having many partners increases your divorce risk" and the sentence "eight women in a hundred" describe the same fact, and they do not feel the same at all.
>
> And the majority outcome in **every single row of that table** is a marriage that was still going.

2.4 — The finding will not sit still

Now the part that should make everybody cautious, on all sides.

The behaviour being studied has changed beyond recognition within the span of the data. Among American women marrying in the 1970s, about 21 per cent married as virgins; by the 2010s it was about 5 per cent. The share who had had ten or more partners went from about 2 per cent to about 18 per cent. The share with exactly one premarital partner — nearly always the husband — fell from about 43 per cent to about 22 per cent.

When a behaviour goes from unusual to normal, the people doing it change completely. In 1970, having ten partners marked a woman out as very unusual in her community, with everything that implies about her circumstances and how she was treated. In 2015 it marks her out as ordinary. Any association between the behaviour and an outcome is therefore measuring something different in each era, even with identical questions.

And the numbers moved accordingly. Divorce rates fell for the shrinking group of virgin brides. They rose most for women with ten or more partners. The relationship between two partners and ten or more flipped. These are not the fingerprints of a stable biological or psychological mechanism. They are the fingerprints of a social process.

THE ARGUMENT — HOW MUCH DOES THIS FINDING ACTUALLY ESTABLISH?

Both sides here accept the table. They disagree about what a person should take from it.

IT ESTABLISHES A REAL AND SERIOUS RISK

Ninety years, many countries, many research teams, one direction. The association survives controls for age, education, income and religion in study after study. It is bigger than plenty of risk factors that public health bodies act on without hesitation. And the effect on the extremes is not trivial: a third of marriages ending within five years, against six per cent, is an enormous difference in life outcomes by any standard. Dismissing it because the middle of the curve is untidy is holding this finding to a standard no other social science result is held to.

IT ESTABLISHES FAR LESS THAN IT APPEARS TO

The shape is wrong for a causal story, the association moves around by decade, and half the range sits in the step from zero to one, where the comparison group is a tiny and unrepresentative religious minority who also face the highest barriers to leaving a marriage. A "divorce" is not the same event for a devout woman in a close community and a secular woman in a city, so the outcome variable is not measuring the same thing across the rows. And the whole table is built on a self-reported number that cannot be verified and is misreported in a patterned way.

Where things stand: the association is genuinely established and its interpretation is genuinely not. Nobody serious disputes that reported partner count and marital dissolution are related in American data. What that relationship consists of is the open question, and Chapter Three shows that the researcher who produced the best-known version of these numbers went looking for the mechanism and did not find one.

What would settle it: a design that separates the woman from her circumstances — comparing sisters, or following people from before any of this happened. Some of that exists. It is in the next chapter, and it does not favour the simple reading.

Why people care so much: because this table is the closest thing the traditionalist case has to a hard number, and the closest thing the other side has to a target. Both have an incentive to read it as more decisive than it is.

2.5 — The exception that survives

One finding in this area has held up better than the rest, and it is worth stating precisely because it is the one most often mangled.

In 2003 the sociologist Jay Teachman published an analysis showing that women whose only premarital sexual partner — and only cohabiting partner — was the man they went on to marry had **no elevated risk of divorce** compared with women who had had no premarital sex at all.

Note what that does and does not say. It does not say premarital sex is harmless in general. It says that premarital sex *with your eventual husband* did not carry the penalty. Which means whatever the association is tracking, it is not the act.

REMEMBER THIS

The association is **real.** It has been found since 1938, across countries and decades. Anyone who says the research shows nothing is misdescribing it.

But the shape is wrong for damage. It is **not a line.** Women with two partners divorced more than women with three to nine, and in earlier decades more than women with ten or more. That is not what a dose of harm looks like.

Roughly **half the whole range sits between zero partners and one —** and women who marry as virgins are now about five in a hundred American brides, a tiny and highly distinctive group who also face the biggest barriers to leaving.

The finding **will not sit still.** As the behaviour went from rare to normal, the numbers moved and one comparison reversed outright. Stable mechanisms do not behave like that; social processes do.

And the cleanest single result in the field is that a woman whose only premarital partner was her future husband carried no extra risk at all — which means whatever this is tracking, it is not the act itself.

CHAPTER THREE

The Machinery of Getting It Wrong

> *An association is a fact about two columns in a spreadsheet. Turning it into a fact about causes is where nearly everything goes wrong, and this literature contains one of the most honest failures in the field.*

3.1 — Three ways to misread a true association

Suppose it is genuinely true that women with more premarital partners divorce more often. There are four possible explanations, and only one of them is the one the warning assumes.

One: the behaviour causes the outcome. Something about having had several partners damages a later marriage. This is the warning's version.

Two: something else causes both. Some third thing makes a woman more likely to have several partners *and* more likely to divorce, with no arrow between the two.

Three: the causation runs backwards. Not literally in time here, but in the sense that the same underlying situation produces both — a woman heading for a difficult marriage may already be living a life that produces more partners.

Four: it is an artefact of who ends up in which group.

WORD BOX

Confounding: when a third factor causes both of the things you are comparing, creating an association between them that is real in the data and empty as a cause.

The standard example: ice cream sales and drowning deaths rise together. Ice cream does not drown anybody. Hot weather causes both.

Selection effect: when the people in a group got there for reasons that also affect the outcome, so you are comparing different kinds of people rather than the same people under different conditions.

Why it matters here: the two most powerful objections to the divorce finding are both of these, and neither has been answered.

3.2 — The list of things that come bundled with a partner count

Consider what else is true, on average, about a woman who reports more premarital partners in an American survey.

She is less religious. She married later. She began having sex younger. She is more likely to have cohabited, and cohabitation carries its own association with divorce. She is more likely to have grown up in a household that itself broke up, which is one of the strongest known predictors of divorce entirely on its own. She scores differently on stable personality traits — higher on impulsivity and sensation-seeking, which are traits that affect how a person handles a marriage as well as how many relationships they form. She lives somewhere with different norms about leaving. And she is, on average, in a different economic position.

Every one of those independently predicts divorce. All of them travel with partner count.

IN REAL TERMS

Picture two women, both aged thirty, both married three years.

The first grew up in a devout household that stayed together, married at twenty-two into a community where her parents, in-laws, neighbours and priest all know the marriage exists and would all know if it ended.

The second grew up in a household that split when she was nine, left home at eighteen, moved cities twice, married at twenty-eight, and lives four hundred kilometres from anyone who knew her as a child.

They will have very different partner counts. They will also have very different divorce risks **for reasons that have nothing to do with sex at all**. Any study that compares them and attributes the difference to partner count has attributed an entire pair of life histories to one column.

Researchers control for these things statistically, and the association usually survives some controls. But statistical control only works for factors you have measured. Nobody has a good measure of how much a woman's community would punish her for leaving, and that is precisely the variable most likely to be doing the work.

3.3 — The sibling test

There is a way to get closer to an answer, and it is the best tool this field has.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In a **sibling-comparison design**, researchers compare brothers and sisters raised in the same household who differ in the behaviour being studied. Two sisters, same parents, same house, same religion, same neighbourhood, same income, largely overlapping genetics — but one had sex at sixteen and one at twenty-two.

Why it is powerful: every family-level confounder is held constant automatically, including the ones nobody thought to measure. You do not have to know what the third factor was in order to remove it.

What it has found: across studies of early sexual activity and later outcomes, associations that look substantial in ordinary data **shrink considerably once siblings are compared —** in some cases to nothing at all, and in some cases the surviving relationships do not run in the direction the popular story predicts.

What it cannot do: siblings differ from each other for reasons, and those reasons may be the cause. It removes what families share. It cannot remove what makes two sisters different.

This is the standard fate of this kind of finding across the social sciences. An association looks strong in raw data, holds up under a few controls, and then loses most of its size the moment somebody finds a way to compare people who are genuinely alike. It happens so reliably that it should be the default expectation, not a surprise.

3.4 — When the researcher tested his own explanation

Now the most honest thing in this literature, and the reason I take the researchers involved seriously even where I read their numbers differently.

Wolfinger — the same sociologist who produced the divorce table in Chapter Two, publishing through an organisation that would have been delighted by a clean mechanism — went looking for one. He tested the standard explanations for why premarital partners might damage a marriage: that a woman compares her husband unfavourably with earlier partners; that premarital sex leads to children outside marriage which strains later relationships; that people who accumulate partners are worse at choosing a mate; that it is all selection on attitudes and personality.

His conclusion, published in 2023, was that **none of the commonly theorised mechanisms accounted for the relationship.**

Sit with that for a moment. The best-known finding in this field comes with the researcher's own report that the explanations offered for it do not work. That is not a refutation of the association — it is still there in the data. It is something more specific and more useful: nobody can currently say what it is made of.

An unexplained association is a legitimate thing to keep studying. It is not a legitimate thing to give somebody as advice, because advice requires knowing which lever to pull.

THE ARGUMENT — CAUSE OR SELECTION?

This is the central methodological dispute in the whole part, and everything in Chapters Four to Six inherits it.

MOSTLY CAUSE

The association survives controls for age, education, religion, family background and income across multiple studies, and it has been found for ninety years in societies with different norms. Selection cannot be infinitely elastic — at some point “there is always another confounder” stops being an argument and becomes a refusal to accept any evidence. There are also plausible mechanisms that are hard to measure but not exotic: comparison with past partners is a real psychological phenomenon that people report directly, and a person who has left several relationships has practised leaving, which is a skill like any other. The fact that we cannot yet name the mechanism does not mean there is not one.

MOSTLY SELECTION

The shape of the relationship is wrong, the size moves by decade, sibling designs attenuate it, and the researcher who owns the headline finding reports that no proposed mechanism explains it. Meanwhile every unmeasured variable that would produce this pattern is exactly the kind that is hardest to measure — how much your community would punish you for divorcing, how stable your childhood was, what you are like as a person. And there is a decisive clue in the data itself: a woman whose only premarital partner was her future husband carries no extra risk. If the mechanism were about sexual experience, that group would show it. They do not.

Where things stand: the weight of evidence has moved towards selection over the last two decades, and most careful researchers now describe the relationship as partly causal at most and substantially confounded. Nobody has established a mechanism. Nobody has shown it is zero either.

What would settle it: nothing that anyone can ethically run. The experiment would require assigning young women to different numbers of sexual partners at random. That is not a limitation to be worked around; it is permanent. Everything in this chapter is the best available substitute for a study that will never exist.

Why people care so much: because “cause” licenses advice and “selection” does not. If it is causal, telling a young woman to have fewer partners is useful information. If it is selection, the same sentence is a moral instruction wearing a lab coat.

Before leaving this chapter there is something to say about the thing being measured on the other side of the equation, which nobody in the argument above has questioned.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A MARRIAGE ENDING IS THE HARM

Every study in this chapter uses divorce as the outcome. The traditionalist cites the divorce rate as evidence of damage. The critic disputes the divorce rate. Both are treating a marriage that lasts as the good result and a marriage that ends as the bad one.

> But a divorce rate does not measure how good marriages are. It measures how many of them ended, which is a product of two things: how bad the marriage was, and **how hard it was to leave.** Those are not the same, and the second one varies enormously across exactly the groups being compared.
>
> Look again at the table in Chapter Two with that in mind. The row with the lowest divorce rate is the row of women who married as virgins — a group who are, on average, the most religious, the most embedded in a community that regards divorce as a failure, and the most likely to face family opposition, financial dependence and social loss if they leave. Their marriages ended less often. Whether their marriages were better is a completely different question, and the survey does not ask it.
>
> The measures that would answer it exist. Researchers can and do ask about marital satisfaction, about loneliness inside a marriage, about whether a person would marry the same partner again. Those results are messier and get quoted far less, because "divorce" is a clean, dated, recorded event and happiness is not.
>
> **The general form:** the measurable proxy that quietly became the goal. It runs through every field that has to score something. Schools measure exam results and start teaching to them. Hospitals measure waiting times. Companies measure billable hours. In each case the proxy was chosen because it could be counted, and then it became the thing everyone was trying to produce.
>
> What follows here is uncomfortable for both sides. If low divorce is partly a measure of high exit costs, then a rule that lowers divorce by raising the cost of leaving will look, in the data, exactly like a rule that makes marriages better. The two are indistinguishable on this outcome variable — and the entire evidential case in Chapter Two is built on it.

None of which makes the association disappear. It means we have been measuring the wrong side of it, with an instrument that cannot tell a good marriage from an inescapable one.

REMEMBER THIS

A true association has four possible explanations and the warning assumes only one of them. The others are **confounding** (a third thing causes both), **selection** (the groups are different kinds of people), and the same underlying situation producing both.

Everything that travels with a high partner count — later marriage, less religion, cohabitation, a broken childhood home, personality traits, living far from family — **independently predicts divorce on its own**.

Sibling comparisons are the best tool available, because they remove every family-level confounder automatically. When applied to early sexual activity, they shrink these associations considerably.

The researcher who produced the best-known divorce figures went looking for the mechanism behind them and reported that **none of the standard explanations accounted for it**. The association stands; its content is unknown.

And the outcome everyone is measuring — divorce — partly measures how hard it is to leave, which means a rule that traps women and a rule that makes marriages better look identical in this data.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Regret Asymmetry

> *One of the few findings here that has survived the hardest test anyone could design for it. Men and women do regret different things. The difference is real, it is smaller than you would expect, and what predicts an individual woman's regret is not her sex.*

4.1 — What the finding is

Ask a large group of people about their regrets in the sexual domain and a consistent pattern appears. Men more often regret things they did *not* do — the opportunity they passed up, the person they did not approach. Women more often regret things they *did* — a particular casual encounter, a person they wish they had not slept with.

WORD BOX

Action regret: regret about something you did. “I wish I hadn’t.”

Inaction regret: regret about something you did not do. “I wish I had.”

Why the distinction matters: everybody has both. The finding is not that women regret sex and men do not. It is that the **balance** between the two tips in opposite directions for men and women, specifically in the sexual domain.

The first systematic demonstration came from a team led by Neal Roese in 2006. It was replicated by Andrew Galperin and colleagues in 2013, who added a control that matters more than the finding itself: they also measured regret about *non-sexual* romantic matters — the relationship not pursued, the confession not made. There, the sex difference disappeared.

That control is what makes this worth taking seriously. If women simply reported more regret about everything, or reported feelings more readily than men, the pattern would show up everywhere. It does not. It is specific to sex.

4.2 — How big is it?

Here is where most retellings stop, and where the useful part begins.

WORD BOX

Effect size: how big a difference is, as opposed to how confident we are that it exists. These are completely different questions and they are constantly confused.

With a large enough sample, a difference so small it could not matter to anybody will still be reported as statistically reliable. “Significant” in a research paper means “probably not zero”. It does not mean “large”.

Why it matters here: the sex difference in sexual regret is reliable. Its size is the thing you actually need in order to know what it means for a person, and it is the part that gets dropped in the retelling.

The size is moderate. It shows up as a clear difference between group averages, with very substantial overlap between men and women. Plenty of men report high action regret. Plenty of women report none at all.

IN REAL TERMS

A moderate group difference of this kind works like the height difference between men and women in reverse: real, visible in averages, and useless for predicting an individual.

If you know a person's sex, you can shift your guess about their sexual regret a little. If you want to actually know, you have to ask them — because the range within each sex is far wider than the gap between the two.

Put it as a practical test. Take a woman at random and a man at random. The woman will report more action regret than the man rather less than two times in three — which means it goes the other way often enough that **the pattern tells you almost nothing about the person standing in front of you.**

4.3 — The hardest test anybody has run

There are two broad explanations for a sex difference like this. One says it reflects something evolved and general — that the consequences of a sexual encounter have historically been asymmetric enough to shape different emotional responses. The other says it reflects social conditions — that women are punished more for casual sex, warned about it more, and taught to feel differently about it, so they do.

These make a testable prediction that differs. If it is social conditioning, then in a society where the conditioning is weakest, the difference should shrink or vanish.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A research team led by Leif Kennair and Mons Bendixen in Norway, working with the American psychologist David Buss, ran exactly that test. Norway is among the most gender-egalitarian, least religious and most sexually liberal societies on Earth — close to the best available real-world version of "remove the conditioning and see what happens".

They asked 263 Norwegian students aged 19 to 37 about their most recent casual sexual encounter, or the most recent one they passed up, and how much they regretted it. A later study extended this to over five hundred Norwegians alongside an American comparison group.

What they found: **the sex difference was not attenuated.** It appeared in Norway at about the same size as in the United States. A follow-up comparing the two countries directly found that the cultural difference between them did not significantly change levels of sexual regret.

What this evidence is good at: it is a genuine prediction, made in advance, tested where the theory said it should fail. That is rare in this field.

What it is not: these are student samples in two Western countries. Norway is the strongest available test of the social explanation, not a perfect one — Norwegian women still live in a world with the rest of the world in it.

I want to be straight about this, because it cuts against the reading I would find more comfortable. The social-conditioning explanation made a clear prediction, the prediction was tested in the place most favourable to it, and it did not hold. That is real evidence, and it is the strongest single piece of evidence in this entire part that something here is not purely a matter of what women are taught.

4.4 — But look at what predicts it

Now the finding that reorganises the chapter, and it comes from the same research group.

Having established that the sex difference is robust, they asked a further question: within each sex, what predicts how much regret a person reports? The answers were not about sex at all.

The strongest predictors of regret after a casual encounter turned out to be **worry** — about pregnancy, infection, reputation — **disgust**, **feeling pressured into it**, and **not having enjoyed it physically**. A person's dispositional orientation towards casual sex mattered too.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Sociosexuality:** a measured personality trait describing how comfortable a person is with sex outside a committed relationship. People at one end feel fine about it; people at the other find it distressing. It varies widely within both sexes.
>
> Why it matters: in these studies, a person's sociosexuality predicted their regret better than their sex did. A woman comfortable with casual sex reported less regret than a man who was not.

And the researchers were explicit that the sex differences they found, while robust, were **modest — and smaller than the differences produced by sociosexuality and by physical gratification.**

That last item deserves a sentence of its own. One of the things most strongly predicting whether a woman regretted a casual encounter was whether she had enjoyed it. This is not a trivial observation, because the enjoyment gap in casual sex is itself large and well documented: research on American college students found women reporting orgasm far less often in first-time casual encounters than in established relationships, while men's rates barely moved.

> **THE ARGUMENT — IS THE ASYMMETRY A FACT ABOUT WOMEN OR A FACT ABOUT CONDITIONS?**
>
> Both sides now have strong evidence, which is unusual and makes this one of the more honest disagreements in the part.

IT IS A REAL AND GENERAL SEX DIFFERENCE

The prediction was made in advance and tested in the most egalitarian society available, and it held. It is specific to the sexual domain and absent for non-sexual romantic regret, which rules out a general reporting difference. It replicates across research groups and countries. And there is a straightforward reason it might exist: for most of human history the possible consequences of a single sexual encounter were catastrophically different for the two sexes, and emotions that track consequences are exactly what you would expect to differ.

IT IS PRODUCED BY THE CONDITIONS OF THE ENCOUNTER

Look at what actually predicts regret: worry, pressure, disgust and lack of enjoyment. Every one of those is a condition, not a preference, and every one of them falls disproportionately on women — because the pregnancy risk is hers, the reputational risk is hers, the pressure is more often applied to her, and the physical enjoyment is measurably less likely. If women encounter more of the things that produce regret, they will report more regret, and no separate psychological difference is needed. Norway is more equal in law and attitude; it has not equalised who can get pregnant or who is more likely to be pressured or who has an orgasm.

Where things stand: genuinely unresolved, and the two accounts are less opposed than their advocates present them. The direction of the difference is robust and has survived the strongest cultural test anyone has run. Its size is moderate, with large overlap. And the proximate causes identified so far are conditions — which means both can be true: an evolved difference in how sexual risk feels, expressing itself through circumstances that vary enormously and could be changed.

What would settle it: comparing regret in encounters matched on worry, pressure and enjoyment. If the sex difference survives when all of those are equal, the first side is right. If it disappears, the second is. The measures exist; the study has not been done properly.

Why people care so much: because “women feel differently about sex” is doing heavy lifting in the wider argument this series is about. If it is fixed, the old rules can be presented as accommodating a fact. If it is produced by conditions, then the rules are partly producing the fact they claim to accommodate.

One last observation, which belongs to neither side. The warning says a woman will regret it. The research says some women regret some encounters, and that whether they do is predicted mainly by whether they were worried, pressured, or disappointed. The warning does not distinguish between a woman who regrets an encounter she was pushed into and a woman who does not regret one she chose. It treats those as the same event. The research does not.

REMEMBER THIS

Men more often regret **what they did not do**; women more often regret **what they did**, in the sexual domain specifically. The difference vanishes for non-sexual romantic regret, which is what makes it worth taking seriously.

The difference is **moderate, not large**, with heavy overlap. Knowing someone's sex shifts your guess a little and tells you almost nothing about the individual.

The social-conditioning explanation made a clear prediction — that it would shrink in an egalitarian society — and the **Norwegian test did not shrink it**. That is the strongest evidence in this part that something here is not purely taught.

But what predicts an individual woman's regret is not her sex. It is **worry, feeling pressured, disgust, and whether she enjoyed it** — and her own comfort with casual sex predicted her regret better than her sex did.

Every one of those predictors is a condition rather than a preference, and every one of them can change.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Mind

> *Does sex outside a committed relationship make women unhappy? The literature is genuinely mixed, which is itself informative — and one finding inside it reorganises the question entirely.*

5.1 — A claim that sounds obvious to both sides

This is the claim most people feel certain about without having read anything. One side is sure that casual sex leaves women depressed, empty and damaged. The other is sure it is harmless and that the distress is manufactured by shame. Both are stating a research finding they have not checked.

The actual literature is a mess, and it is a specific kind of mess that tells you something. Studies find associations between casual sex and lower wellbeing. Studies find no association. Studies find casual sex associated with *higher* wellbeing. All of these are published, in reputable journals, by competent people.

When a field looks like that, there are two possibilities. Either the studies are too small and noisy to see a real effect, or the effect genuinely differs between people — which means the average is hiding the answer rather than revealing it.

WORD BOX

Moderator: something that changes the size or direction of an effect for different people.

An example without any politics in it: alcohol has a moderator called body weight. The same two drinks affect a large person and a small person differently. If you studied “the effect of two drinks” across everybody and reported the average, you would produce a number that described nobody.

Why it matters here: this whole question turns out to have a strong moderator, and once you know what it is, the contradictory studies stop contradicting each other.

5.2 — The finding that sorts it out

In 2014 Zhana Vrangalova and Anthony Ong published a study asking not whether casual sex affects wellbeing, but *for whom*. They measured people's sociosexuality — the trait from Chapter Four describing how comfortable a person is with sex outside a committed relationship — and then looked at wellbeing in those who had casual sex and those who had not.

The result was clean. For people comfortable with casual sex, having it was associated with **higher** wellbeing. For people uncomfortable with it, having it was associated with **lower** wellbeing.

The effect did not have one direction. It had two, and which one you got depended on whether the behaviour matched the person.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Two women, same university, same week, same encounter with a stranger.
>
> The first thinks casual sex is fine, has thought so for years, and would say so to her friends. Afterwards she feels good.
>
> The second was raised to believe it is wrong, still believes it somewhere she cannot argue with, and did it anyway. Afterwards she feels terrible.
>
> The act was the same. The outcome was opposite. **What differed was the fit between what she did and what she believes — and where her beliefs came from is not something she chose.**

This does not settle the argument. It relocates it, and the relocation is the interesting part. If harm tracks the mismatch between behaviour and belief, then the harm is real — the second woman is genuinely suffering, and telling her she should not be will not help. But the source of the harm is not the act. It is the collision between the act and a set of beliefs supplied by her upbringing.

Which means both sides can read this finding as a victory, and both readings are coherent. That is worth sitting with rather than resolving too quickly.

5.3 — Which way is the arrow pointing?

There is a further problem underneath all of this, and it is at least as serious as the confounding in Chapter Three.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> Most studies in this area are **cross-sectional**: they measure the behaviour and the wellbeing at the same moment. That design cannot tell you which came first, and here the arrow plausibly runs both ways.
>
> Distress leads to behaviour, not only the reverse. People who are depressed, lonely, drinking heavily, or in the aftermath of a bad relationship are more likely to seek out casual encounters — that is not a moral claim, it is a well-documented pattern. So a study that finds unhappy people having more casual sex has found exactly what you would expect if the unhappiness came first.
>
> The better designs are **longitudinal**: measure wellbeing at one point, behaviour later, wellbeing later still. Where these have been done, the prospective link running from earlier distress to later casual sex is at least as strong as the link running the other way — and often stronger.
>
> What this cannot show: it does not prove the behaviour has no effect. It shows that the raw association is substantially explained by an arrow pointing in the opposite direction from the one everybody assumes.

There is a broader factual correction that belongs here too, because the whole discussion is usually framed against a picture of the young that is simply wrong. In several rich countries, young people today report **fewer** sexual partners than the generation born in the 1950s and 1960s did at the same age, and are having less sex overall, later. The moral panic about a generation of hookups is being conducted about a generation that is, if anything, more cautious than its parents.

> **THE ARGUMENT — DOES CASUAL SEX HARM WOMEN'S MENTAL HEALTH?**
>
> The evidence above is compatible with two quite different overall pictures.

IT CAUSES REAL HARM AND THE MODERATION FINDING PROVES IT

The mismatch account does not exonerate the behaviour; it identifies who is at risk. A large share of women — in India, the overwhelming majority — hold exactly the beliefs that make the mismatch damaging, so for most women in the world the association with distress is not a statistical curiosity, it is a prediction about them. Nor is it obvious that the beliefs are the thing that should give way. The distress may be tracking something accurate: that an encounter without commitment carried a real risk, was often not enjoyable, and left her exposed in ways she correctly registered. Calling that "shame" and proposing to remove it is proposing to remove a signal rather than a cause.

THE HARM IS REAL BUT IT IS NOT THE ACT DOING IT

If the same behaviour produces higher wellbeing in one woman and lower in another, the behaviour is not the cause; the collision is. And the beliefs on one side of that collision were installed, not chosen — by families, by communities, by exactly the warning this part is testing. That makes the warning partly self-fulfilling: it teaches a woman that this will damage her, and the teaching is a substantial part of what does. Meanwhile the arrow in the raw data mostly runs from distress to behaviour, not the other way. The strongest reading of the evidence is that unhappy people do this more often, and that the ones who suffer afterwards are the ones who were told they would.

Where things stand: the mixed literature is now reasonably well explained by moderation, and the causal direction is genuinely contested with the evidence leaning towards distress preceding behaviour. What is *not* in dispute: the distress reported by women who feel they have violated their own values is real, substantial, and not to be talked away.

What would settle it: longitudinal studies that track beliefs, behaviour and wellbeing over years, in more than one culture. The design is entirely feasible and the studies are mostly not being funded, because the question is politically radioactive in every direction.

Why people care so much: because the mismatch account puts the culture on trial alongside the behaviour. If the harm comes from the collision, then anyone who installed the beliefs is implicated in the damage — and that is an uncomfortable position for a parent who thought they were protecting their daughter.

Let me say plainly where I think the honest reader is left, because it is not where either camp would like.

The distress is real. Women who go against beliefs they hold feel worse, measurably, and this is one of the better-supported findings in the part. Whether that distress is evidence that the beliefs are correct, or evidence that the beliefs are costly, is not a question research can answer. It is the same question the whole series keeps arriving at, and Chapter Seven is where it finally gets a proper test.

REMEMBER THIS

The literature on casual sex and wellbeing is **genuinely mixed** — findings in all three directions, published by competent people. That pattern usually means an effect that differs between people rather than an effect that is not there.

It does. The strongest moderator is **how comfortable the person is with casual sex**. For those comfortable with it, wellbeing was higher; for those uncomfortable, lower. Same act, opposite outcomes.

The causal arrow largely runs the **other way** from the one assumed. Distress predicts later casual sex at least as strongly as casual sex predicts later distress.

And the background picture is wrong: young people in several rich countries report **fewer** partners than their parents' generation did at the same age.

The distress is real and should not be argued away. But it tracks the collision between what a woman does and what she was taught — and she did not choose what she was taught.

CHAPTER SIX

The Body

> *Everything so far has been contested. This chapter is not. The physical claim is true, the mechanism is known, and the risk rises with the number. This is where the traditionalist case is strongest — and where it turns out to be aimed at the wrong person.*

6.1 — Say the true thing first

More sexual partners means more exposure to sexually transmitted infection. This is not an association that might be confounded. It is a transmission mechanism. Each new partner is a new draw from a pool that may contain something, and more draws means more chances.

It is dose-responsive in exactly the way Chapter Two's divorce finding was not. It replicates everywhere, in every culture, because bacteria and viruses do not care about norms. And unlike everything in Chapters Two to Five, no amount of controlling for religion, personality or family background makes it go away.

So: on the body claim, the warning is right. I am not going to soften that, and a document that buried it would not be worth reading.

WORD BOX

Human papillomavirus (HPV): a very common family of viruses passed on by skin-to-skin sexual contact. Most sexually active people acquire some type of it at some point, and in the large majority of cases the body clears it within a couple of years without the person ever knowing.

A small number of types are different. If one of those persists for years, it can change the cells of the cervix — the opening at the lower end of the womb — and those changes can become cancer.

Why it matters: persistent infection with these types causes virtually all cervical cancer. It is one of the very few cancers with a single known infectious cause, which means it is one of the very few that can be prevented outright.

6.2 — What this costs in India

India carries an enormous share of the world's cervical cancer. Roughly a fifth of global deaths from it occur here. The annual figures run to something in the order of 120,000 new cases and around 75,000 deaths — it is among the leading cancers in Indian women, and it kills them at ages when they are usually raising children.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Seventy-five thousand deaths a year is about two hundred Indian women a day, from a cancer that is caused by a virus we can vaccinate against and detect years before it becomes dangerous.
>
> Put it against the thing this series is about. Every honour killing reported in India in a year, every one that goes unreported, every reputational catastrophe, every ruined engagement — put all of them together and the number is a fraction of this. The great physical harm attached to sex in Indian women's lives is not the one the warning talks about, and it is the one nobody warns about at all.

6.3 — What actually reduces it

Here is where the chapter turns, and it turns on evidence rather than on argument.

There are four things that reduce a woman's risk of cervical cancer and other infection-related harm. Three of them are medical and one is behavioural, and they are not equally powerful.

Vaccination against the high-risk HPV types prevents the great majority of cervical cancer if given before exposure. India now produces its own vaccine.

Screening finds the cell changes years before they become cancer, when treatment is simple and highly effective.

Barrier contraception and treatment reduce transmission of most sexually transmitted infections substantially. Condoms reduce HPV transmission but do not eliminate it, because it passes by skin contact rather than fluid. For chlamydia and gonorrhoea — which, untreated, can scar the fallopian tubes and cause infertility — testing and a course of antibiotics resolve the problem entirely.

Fewer partners reduces exposure. It genuinely does.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The relevant Indian number is not about behaviour at all. India's own National Family Health Survey asked women aged 30 to 49 whether they had ever been screened for cervical cancer. Around **two in a hundred** had.

That is the finding to hold on to. In a country where cervical cancer kills tens of thousands of women a year, and where a screening test can catch it a decade early, virtually no one is screened.

What this evidence is good at: it is a simple, direct, nationally representative count of a medical service, not a self-report about behaviour, so it carries none of the problems from Chapter One.

What it establishes: the gap between what is killing Indian women and what is being done about it is not a gap in their sexual conduct. It is a gap in access to two interventions that have existed for decades.

Both of those facts are agreed by everybody. What follows from them is not.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE HEALTH EVIDENCE SUPPORT THE RULE?

Everyone accepts the biology. The dispute is about what follows from it.

IT SUPPORTS THE RULE, AND THIS IS THE HONEST PART OF THE WARNING

Everything else in this part is contested, and this is not. Exposure rises with partners; the mechanism is understood; the harm is severe and sometimes fatal. A woman with one lifetime partner has a far lower risk than one with twenty, and no vaccine is perfect, no screening programme catches everything, and no condom eliminates skin-to-skin transmission. If a grandmother's warning turns out to be right about the one thing that can actually kill you, that is not a small vindication. Public health bodies advise on partner numbers routinely for exactly this reason; only here does the advice get treated as an insult.

IT SUPPORTS VACCINATION AND SCREENING, AND THE RULE IS NOT DOING THE WORK

Compare the sizes. Vaccination prevents the large majority of cervical cancer regardless of behaviour. Screening catches nearly all of it early. Two per cent of Indian women in the relevant age group have ever been screened. If the goal is fewer dead women, the enormous lever is medical and the small lever is behavioural — and the behavioural one has been pulled for a thousand years while the medical ones sit largely unused. There is also a decisive fact about who is at risk: a woman's exposure depends on **her partner's history as much as her own**. Indian women with exactly one lifetime sexual partner, married, faithful, die of this disease every day. The rule cannot protect them, because it was never aimed at the person whose behaviour determines their risk.

Where things stand: both are correct about what they claim, and they are answering different questions. Fewer partners does reduce risk — that is a fact and it belongs on the record. Vaccination and screening reduce it far more, for far more women, without requiring anyone to arrange their life around it. If the objective is health, the priority ordering is not close.

What would settle it: nothing needs settling. This is one of the rare places in this part where the evidence is clear and the disagreement is entirely about what to do.

Why people care so much: because the health argument is the most respectable form of the warning, and therefore the one that gets used to carry the rest of it. A great deal of advice that is really about reputation arrives dressed as advice about infection.

6.4 — The fertility claim, which is a different claim

The last piece of the body claim is that a woman who delays will find she cannot have children when she wants them.

The underlying biology is real and is not disputed by anybody. Female fertility declines with age, gradually from the late twenties and more steeply from the mid-thirties, and the decline is not fully reversible by medicine. A woman who plans to have children at forty is taking a genuine risk that she will not be able to.

But look carefully at what that has to do with the warning. It is a claim about **timing**, not about **number**. A woman with fifteen partners who marries at twenty-six has lost nothing. A woman who has never had sex at all and marries at thirty-nine faces the full decline. The two variables have been quietly welded together in a way the biology does not support.

There is one genuine bridge between them, and it is the one from earlier in this chapter: untreated infection can damage the fallopian tubes and cause infertility, and infection risk does rise with partners. So there is a real path from partner count to fertility — and it runs entirely through an infection that a test and a course of antibiotics would have resolved.

REMEMBER THIS

On the body, **the warning is right**. More partners means more exposure to infection. It is dose-responsive, the mechanism is known, and no statistical control makes it disappear. This is the strongest part of the traditionalist case and it should be stated plainly.

Persistent infection with certain **HPV** types causes virtually all cervical cancer. India carries roughly a fifth of the world's deaths from it — in the order of seventy-five thousand a year, about two hundred women a day.

Four things reduce that risk: **vaccination, screening, barrier protection and treatment, and fewer partners**. The first two are far more powerful than the last. About **two in a hundred** Indian women aged 30 to 49 have ever been screened.

A woman's infection risk depends on **her partner's history as much as her own**. Married Indian women with one lifetime partner die of this disease. No rule aimed at her can protect them.

And the fertility claim is about timing, not number — those are different variables, and they have been welded together by a warning rather than by the biology.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Does It Travel?

> *Part One promised a test that would separate a cost caused by an act from a cost caused by a punishment. Here it is, run on every finding in this part. The results do not sort neatly onto either side.*

7.1 — The test, restated

In Chapter Five of Part One I set out a test and said the series would come back to it. This is where.

> WORD BOX
>
> **The portability test:** if a harm is caused by the behaviour itself, it should show up wherever the behaviour happens — in every country, under every set of rules, in every religion.
>
> If it is caused by the community's reaction, it should show up only where that reaction exists, and it should shrink or vanish where it does not.
>
> Why it matters: this is the only tool available for telling a consequence from a penalty, and telling those apart is the whole question underneath this series. It is not a perfect tool. It is what there is.

The logic is simple. A virus does not know which country it is in. A community's contempt does. So if you find a harm that appears in Oslo and Patna and São Paulo at the same size, it probably belongs to the act. If you find one that is enormous in Patna and absent in Oslo, it probably belongs to the rule.

7.2 — Running it

The marriage-market penalty. This one is not close. Whether a woman's sexual history damages her marriage prospects varies from catastrophic to irrelevant depending entirely on where she lives, and within India it varies by state, city, caste and family. In some communities a rumour ends an engagement. In others nobody asks. There is no version of this that travels. It is a penalty, and it is administered by people.

Infection and cervical cancer. The opposite. Transmission works the same way in every country on Earth. The risk rises with exposure regardless of what anybody believes about it. This travels completely, and it is the clearest case in the part of a cost that belongs to the act.

The regret asymmetry. This is the difficult one, and I flagged in Chapter Four that it cuts against the reading I would find comfortable. The prediction was that it would shrink in an egalitarian, secular society. Tested in Norway, it did not shrink. On the face of it, it travels — which points towards something real rather than taught.

Wellbeing after casual sex. Here the test gives a clean answer in the other direction. The effect does not have a fixed direction at all: it depends on whether the woman believes the behaviour is wrong. Beliefs vary by community. So the harm travels with the belief, and the belief travels with the rule.

The divorce association. The honest answer is that we largely do not know, and that is itself informative. Nearly all the best evidence is American. The finding has not been established with anything like the same rigour in Europe, in East Asia, or in India. And within the American data it moved substantially as norms moved — the relationship between two partners and ten or more actually reversed across decades. A relationship that changes shape when the surrounding culture changes is behaving like a social process, not a mechanism.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Cross-cultural comparison is the strongest tool in this chapter and it has a specific weakness worth naming.

What it does well: when the same study design is run in two societies with genuinely different norms and produces the same result, that is real evidence about the act. The Norwegian regret work is a good example — a prediction made in advance, tested where the theory said it should fail.

What it does badly: **there is no society on Earth without rules about women's sexual behaviour.** Norway is less strict than India. It is not a control group. Norwegian women still face pregnancy risk, still encounter pressure, still have friends and mothers and an internet. So "it appeared in Norway too" means "it survived a weaker version of the rule", not "it survives the absence of the rule".

What this means in practice: the portability test can strongly identify things that belong to the rule. It can only weakly identify things that belong to the act, because the untreated condition does not exist anywhere.

7.3 — The scoreboard

Putting it together.

THE CLAIMED HARM	DOES IT TRAVEL?	BEST READING
Infection, cervical cancer	Completely	Belongs to the act. Reduced far more by vaccination and screening than by conduct.
Regret asymmetry	Yes, so far as tested	Direction robust, size moderate. But the predictors of an individual's regret are conditions — worry, pressure, enjoyment.
Reduced wellbeing	No — it reverses	Belongs to the collision between behaviour and installed belief. Direction depends on the woman.
Marital instability	Unknown, and unstable within one country	Association real in American data; no mechanism found; moves as norms move.

THE CLAIMED HARM	DOES IT TRAVEL?	BEST READING
Marriage-market damage	Not at all	Belongs entirely to the community. A penalty, administered by people who can stop.

That is the intellectual result of this part, and it is untidy in a way I did not expect when I started. The warning is not simply false. One of its claims is straightforwardly true and physical. One is robust and modest. Two belong to the rule rather than the act. One is unexplained.

Anybody telling you this is all made up is wrong. Anybody telling you the research vindicates the warning is also wrong. The findings sort into different bins, and which bin a claim falls into changes what could be done about it.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE PORTABILITY TEST ACTUALLY WORK?

Before leaning on that table, the tool itself deserves scrutiny.

IT IS THE BEST INSTRUMENT AVAILABLE AND IT WORKS

Comparison across societies is how anthropology, epidemiology and economics all separate the universal from the local, and it is not controversial in any of those fields. When a finding reverses direction depending on what a woman believes, that is about as clean a demonstration as social science produces that the belief is doing the work. And the test has integrity precisely because it does not always favour one side: it delivered a result for the traditionalist case in Chapter Six and another in Chapter Four. A tool that only ever produces the answer you wanted is not a tool.

IT CANNOT DO THE JOB IT IS BEING ASKED TO DO

There is no society without these rules, so the comparison is always between strict and less strict, never between rule and no rule. Worse, a genuine act-caused harm might only become visible under certain conditions and would then look local when it is not — and a rule-caused harm might be near-universal because the rule is near-universal, and would then look like a fact of nature. Norway is not a laboratory. It is a slightly different arrangement of the same species under a slightly different version of the same rule.

Where things stand: the test is asymmetric in what it can prove, and that asymmetry should be stated openly rather than glossed. It is strong evidence when a harm *fails* to travel — that rules out a universal mechanism. It is weak evidence when a harm does travel, because the rule travels too. Every entry in the table above should be read with that asymmetry applied.

What would settle it: a society with genuinely no norms governing women's sexual behaviour. None exists, none has existed in the historical record, and the absence of even one is itself a piece of evidence — though what it is evidence *of* is exactly what Parts Two and Six of this series spent their length arguing about.

Why people care so much: because this test is the hinge. If a harm belongs to the act, the rule is at worst clumsy protection. If it belongs to the rule, then the community is causing the damage it points at as justification. Almost everything else in the argument is downstream of which of those is true.

There is something both sides of that argument are taking for granted, and it is the thing an actual woman would notice first.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE TWO KINDS OF COST CAN BE SEPARATED FOR HER

This entire chapter has been sorting harms into two bins: caused by the act, caused by the punishment. The traditionalist says the cost is real, so be careful. The reformer says the cost is imposed, so it is unjust. They are having a genuine and important disagreement.

Now consider a twenty-year-old woman in a district where the punishment is severe. What does the distinction give her?

Nothing. There is no version of her behaviour available to her that comes without the punishment attached. She cannot select the Norwegian package. The cost that reaches her is the sum of both bins, and it arrives as one number. Being told that seventy per cent of it is socially constructed does not reduce it by seventy per cent.

So the distinction is real, important, and **useful only to someone deciding what a society should do** — a legislator, a reformer, a parent choosing what to teach, a writer producing a document like this one. It is close to useless to the person living inside the situation. And the argument is conducted almost entirely by people in the first group, about people in the second.

The general form: a distinction that is real at the level of causes and inert at the level of the person. It runs through every applied field. Whether a patient's pain is physical or psychological in origin matters enormously to the doctor and not at all to the patient, who hurts either way. Whether unemployment is structural or personal matters to the economist and not to the man without work.

Why I am flagging it here rather than in the last chapter: because Chapter Nine is going to ask what a person should do with all this, and this box is the reason my answer there is not the one either side wants.

That is the state of the evidence, sorted as honestly as I can sort it. The next chapter asks what anybody is supposed to do with it.

REMEMBER THIS

The **portability test:** a harm caused by the act should appear everywhere; a harm caused by the punishment should appear only where the punishment does.

Run on the five claims, the results split. **Infection travels completely** — it belongs to the act. **Marriage-market damage does not travel at all** — it belongs entirely to the community. **Wellbeing effects reverse direction** depending on what the woman believes, so they belong to the rule. The **regret asymmetry travels**, which is the strongest evidence in this part for something real and untaught. And the **divorce association** is essentially untested outside America and moves as norms move.

So the warning is neither vindicated nor made up. Its claims fall into **different bins**, and the bin determines what could be done.

The test is **asymmetric**: strong evidence when something fails to travel, weak when it does — because there is no society without rules about women, so there is no control group.

And for the woman living inside a strict community, the distinction does not help. She cannot buy the version of her own behaviour that comes without the punishment attached.

CHAPTER EIGHT

India

> *Everything in the last six chapters was measured mostly in America and Northern Europe. This chapter is about the place where the penalty is largest, best organised, and least studied — and about a count that nobody keeps.*

8.1 — A different order of magnitude

The research in Chapters Two to Five was conducted in societies where the consequence of a woman's sexual history is, at worst, some private unhappiness and a somewhat higher chance of divorce. Read those chapters and it is easy to conclude the whole subject is a fuss about effect sizes of eight per cent.

In India the consequence can be the end of a marriage prospect, expulsion from a household, a beating, or death. That is not the same subject with the numbers turned up. It is a different phenomenon, and almost none of the research in this part was designed for it.

WORD BOX

Izzat: usually translated as honour, which is misleading. It is closer to **standing** — a family's public credit, held collectively, that determines the marriages it can arrange, the deals it can make and how it is treated.

The crucial feature: it is held by the household, not the person, and it is far easier to lose than to build. One daughter's rumoured conduct can affect the marriage prospects of her sisters, her cousins and her brothers.

Why it matters: this is why the pressure on an Indian woman is not primarily moral. It is economic and collective. Her family is not policing her soul; it is protecting an asset that her behaviour can destroy and that she does not own a share of.

8.2 — The market that actually exists

To understand why sexual history carries the weight it does in India, you have to see what marriage still is here.

The great majority of Indian marriages are arranged by families rather than chosen by the couple. A substantial share of women report meeting their husband for the first time at or shortly before the wedding. Marriage outside one's caste remains rare — on the order of one marriage in twenty. And surveys of Indian attitudes have found that around two-thirds of respondents regard it as very important to stop women in their community from marrying outside it, with similar figures across religions.

In that system, a woman's marriage is a transaction between two families, and what is being exchanged includes a claim about her. A rumour is not gossip. It is a defect discovered in the goods, and the market prices it.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Consider the arithmetic from the family's side, stated as coldly as they would never state it.
>
> A household with three daughters is arranging three marriages. Each match depends on the family's standing. If a rumour attaches to the eldest, the other two matches become harder and more expensive — dowry demands rise, the pool of acceptable families shrinks.
>
> So the family is not making a judgement about one daughter's conduct. It is making a calculation about three futures, and the daughter in question is one input into it. **That is why the response is so violently out of proportion to the act: the act is small and the exposure is large.**
>
> It is also why the pressure does not lift when a family becomes more educated or richer. Money does not remove you from the market. It raises the value of what is at stake in it.

8.3 — The examination

Where a claim about a woman's history has commercial value, someone will try to verify it. India has two documented forms of this, and both are worth naming precisely.

The first is community virginity testing: the practice, documented in some Indian communities, of examining a bride after the wedding night and reporting the result to the family or the caste council. It has been challenged from inside — a campaign led by young members of one Maharashtra community brought the practice to national attention in recent years and led to arrests.

WORD BOX

The two-finger test: a manual examination once performed on women reporting rape, in which a doctor recorded whether the vagina admitted two fingers, and drew conclusions about whether the woman was "habituated to sexual intercourse".

It has no scientific validity of any kind. It cannot establish sexual history, and the hymen is not a record of anything. Its function in a courtroom was to shift attention from what the accused did to what the complainant had done before.

Where it stands now: India's Supreme Court held in 2013 that the test violates a woman's dignity and bodily integrity, and in 2022 went further, holding that anyone who conducts it is guilty of misconduct and directing that it be removed from medical curricula. In 2018 the World Health Organization, together with UN Human Rights and UN Women, called for the elimination of virginity testing worldwide, noting it was still practised in at least twenty countries.

I include this because of what it reveals about the structure. If a woman's sexual history were simply a private matter with private consequences, there would be no reason to examine her, and certainly no reason for a court to have to ban the examination twice. Institutions do not build verification procedures for things that do not have value. The test existed because the information had a price.

8.4 — The count nobody keeps

At the far end of this system is lethal violence against women — and men — who marry or partner against a family's wishes.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India's National Crime Records Bureau publishes an annual count of crimes, and it includes a category for killings connected to honour. The recorded figures are very low — typically a few dozen a year for a country of 1.4 billion people.

Almost nobody who studies this believes that number. Researchers and civil society organisations who have gone through case files and press reports consistently arrive at figures far higher. The reason is in how the deaths get recorded: they are entered as suicides, as kitchen accidents, as ordinary murders with no motive attached, or they are not reported at all — because the people who would report the crime are frequently the people who committed it.

Now treat that absence as evidence rather than as a gap. India runs a large, functioning statistical apparatus. It counts births in sample villages twice over. It surveys hundreds of thousands of households on their health. The capacity exists.

So a state that can count almost anything is producing a figure for this that its own researchers do not accept. That is not a measurement failure. **An institution that can count and does not has made a choice, and the choice is the finding.**

With that on the table, the central Indian disagreement can be stated properly. It is not about whether the penalty exists — both sides agree it does. It is about what the system is for.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE FAMILY PROTECTING HER OR PROTECTING ITSELF?

This is the most delicate argument in the part, and both positions are held sincerely by enormous numbers of people.

IT IS PROTECTION, AND IT IS RATIONAL

Given the world as it actually is, a family that restricts a daughter is reducing her exposure to a genuine catastrophe. The penalty is real — the ruined match, the lifelong precarity of an unmarried woman in a society with no independent place for her, the violence. A parent who says “do not do this, you will be destroyed” is not inventing the destruction. They are reporting it. In a country where a woman's economic security still runs almost entirely through marriage, arranging a good one is the single most valuable thing a family can do for her, and protecting the conditions for it is care, not commerce. Calling this an asset trade insults people who are frightened for their children.

IT IS AN ASSET TRADE, AND THE TELL IS WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Test it against the mechanism rather than the intention. If the object were her safety, the response to danger would be to shield her. Instead, when a violation occurs or is merely rumoured, the response is very often to punish *her* — to confine her, to marry her off urgently, to cast her out, in the worst cases to kill her. Protection that responds to harm by destroying the person it protects is not protection. The pattern also tracks the wrong variable: the controls tighten where the family's standing is most exposed, not where her risk is highest. And the clearest test of all is what happens to a woman who is assaulted rather than willing. If this were about her welfare, she would receive maximum support. She frequently receives the opposite, because what was damaged was the asset, and the asset does not care how it was damaged.

Where things stand: these are not as opposed as they sound, and the honest position holds both. The fear is real and the calculation is rational; the mechanism serves the household's standing rather than the daughter's welfare; and the two coincide often enough that most families never have to notice the difference. They notice it at exactly one moment — when her interest and the family's standing point in opposite directions. What happens then is the answer, and what usually happens then is well documented.

What would settle it: systematic data on how families respond when the two interests diverge, particularly in cases of assault. Some exists in case studies and legal records; nothing at national scale, and see the box above for why.

Why people care so much: because almost every Indian reading this is describing their own parents, or themselves. That is not a reason to soften the finding. It is a reason to state it carefully.

That argument turns on something both sides accept without examining, and it is the one I want to leave this chapter on.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE STATED BENEFICIARY IS THE ACTUAL ONE

Every defence of the system says it is for her. Every critique argues about whether it works for her. Both are treating **her welfare as the thing the rule is aimed at**, and then disputing the effectiveness.

But a rule's purpose is not what it says. It is what it optimises for, and you can read that off its behaviour. Look at where these controls are tightest and where they relax. They are tightest where the family's marriage-market exposure is greatest — a daughter of marriageable age, with unmarried sisters, in a community that talks. They relax when she is no longer on the market, or when the family's standing is secure by other means, or when she is far enough away that nobody local will hear.

Now notice what that pattern is *not* tracking. It is not tracking her physical risk. It is not tracking her health, her happiness or her chance of ending up with a man who treats her well. If it were, the controls would tighten around the dangerous marriage and relax around the safe boyfriend, and in practice they do the reverse.

The general form: reading a rule's stated beneficiary as its actual one. Employment rules that say they protect workers and track employers' liability. Licensing that says it protects consumers and tracks incumbents' competition. In each case the stated

> beneficiary is real, is often genuinely helped, and is not what the rule is organised around — and you can tell, because you can watch what the rule does when the two come apart.
>
> The reason this matters more than the usual version: the people applying these rules are not cynics. An Indian parent restricting a daughter is not privately thinking about assets. They love her and they are frightened. The mechanism does not need anybody to understand it in order to run — which is exactly why it is worth writing down.

None of this is a description of bad people. It is a description of a machine that good people operate without seeing the shape of it, which is the only kind of machine that lasts.

REMEMBER THIS

The findings in Chapters Two to Five were measured where the penalty is small. In India it is **an order of magnitude larger**, and almost none of that research was designed for it.

Izzat is not honour, it is standing — a household asset, held collectively, that one daughter's rumoured conduct can damage for her siblings and cousins. That is why the reaction is out of proportion: the act is small and the exposure is large.

Most Indian marriages are still arranged, inter-caste marriage runs at about **one in twenty**, and around two-thirds of surveyed Indians say it is very important to stop women marrying outside the community. In that market a claim about a woman's history has a price — which is why **verification procedures exist**, and why the Supreme Court has had to ban the two-finger test twice.

India records a few dozen honour killings a year and almost no researcher believes the figure. A state that **can** count and does not has made a choice, and the choice is the finding.

The controls track the family's exposure, not the daughter's risk — and you can see it in the one case where the two come apart, which is what happens to a woman who was assaulted rather than willing.

CHAPTER NINE

What a Person Could Do With This

> *Eight chapters of findings. Now the question everybody actually wants answered — so what should she do? I am going to give the traditionalist case its strongest form, lay out three answers, and then explain why I am refusing to pick one.*

9.1 — The case for the warning, put as well as I can put it

Here is the argument for the traditional advice, made without a single appeal to religion or tradition. It is stronger than most people who dismiss it realise, and it uses this part's own findings.

Start with what survived. The health claim is true and physical. The regret asymmetry survived the hardest cultural test anybody has run. The divorce association has been found for ninety years across many research teams. That is not nothing, and a person who acts as if all of it were invented is acting against the evidence.

Then take the costs that are socially imposed. Chapter Seven established that the marriage-market penalty belongs entirely to the community. Now notice that this does not help her at all. A penalty that is unjust still lands. A woman in a district where a rumour ends an engagement faces exactly the same outcome whether the penalty is written into nature or into her neighbours. She cannot decline to live in her society, and advising her as though she could is not liberation, it is abandonment.

WORD BOX

A prudential reason is a reason of self-interest: do this because it will go better for you.

A moral reason is a reason about right and wrong: do this because it is what you owe.

Why the distinction matters here: the traditional warning is almost always delivered as a prudential reason — *I am telling you for your own good* — while functioning as a moral one. The two get conflated constantly, in both directions. Someone who intends a moral instruction reaches for the prudential language because it is harder to argue with. And someone rejecting a moral instruction often answers the prudential version instead, which is a different argument.

Add the asymmetry of consequences. If the warning is wrong and she heeds it, she has lost some experience. If the warning is right and she ignores it, in the strictest environments she may lose her marriage prospects, her family, or her life. Those are not symmetrical, and under genuine uncertainty a rational person weights the tail.

And finish with humility about the evidence. Every chapter in this part reports uncertainty. In conditions of uncertainty, an inherited practice that many generations have converged on deserves some weight — not because old is good, but because a rule that survived a long time may encode observations that were never written down. Demanding a peer-reviewed effect size before respecting accumulated practical knowledge is its own kind of error, and this series named it in Part One.

That is the case. I do not think it is decisive, but anyone who cannot state it in that form has not earned the right to reject it.

9.2 — Three answers

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT SHOULD BE SAID TO AN ACTUAL YOUNG WOMAN?

Every position below is held by serious people who have looked at the same evidence.

GIVE HER THE PRUDENTIAL ADVICE

Describe the world as it is. She lives in a specific place with specific penalties, and the useful thing is accurate information about them plus a recommendation that minimises her risk. Withholding that so as not to endorse the system is a luxury belief: the person paying for it is her, and the person feeling good about it is you. Doctors advise patients to avoid genuinely dangerous behaviour without first litigating whether the danger is socially constructed. This is the same, and pretending otherwise costs real women real outcomes.

REFUSE, BECAUSE THE ADVICE ENFORCES THE PENALTY

The marriage-market penalty exists because it is expected to be obeyed. Every woman who complies confirms that the threat works, which sustains it for the next one. Advice that adapts to an unjust system is one of the mechanisms by which the system persists — it converts a punishment into common sense, and common sense needs no enforcer. And this counsel of prudence has been offered in every generation about a world that then changed, usually because people stopped taking it.

CHANGE THE CONDITIONS INSTEAD OF ADVISING THE PERSON

Both of the above accept that the only variable is her behaviour. But look at what this part actually found. Regret is predicted by worry, pressure and lack of enjoyment. Wellbeing damage is predicted by the collision with installed belief. Death from cervical cancer is prevented by vaccination and screening. Not one of those is fixed by a woman having fewer partners, and every one of them is addressable — contraception, a screening programme, protection from coercion, and not installing the belief in the first place. The whole framing of "what should she do" has already conceded that she is the only adjustable part of the system.

Where things stand: these are not competing readings of the evidence. All three accept the findings in this part. They differ on who should bear the cost of a system that is unjust and real at the same time — the individual who did not build it, the reformer who cannot change it quickly, or nobody, with the cost simply falling where it falls. That is a moral disagreement wearing an empirical coat, and no additional study will resolve it.

What would settle it: nothing empirical. This is the point in the series where the evidence genuinely runs out and a value judgement has to be made by whoever is making it.

Why people care so much: because the first answer is what most Indian parents say, the second is what most of the young people arguing with them say, and the third is what almost nobody says, because it requires spending public money and changing institutions rather than instructing a girl.

9.3 — Why I am not picking one

I said in the front matter that nothing here would be advice, and that refusing was a position rather than modesty. Here is the reasoning.

The strongest single finding in this whole part is a moderation finding: the effect of the behaviour on a woman's wellbeing depends on what she herself believes and wants. That is not a caveat. It is the result. And a result of that shape does not license a general recommendation, because there is no general person to make it to.

IN REAL TERMS

Put the whole part into one woman's situation, and watch the answer change as she changes.

A woman in a metropolitan Indian city, financially independent, secular, in a family that would not disown her: nearly every cost documented here is small for her, and the largest real one is infection, which is addressed by a vaccine and a screening test.

A woman in a district where a rumour would end her sister's engagement, dependent on her family for everything, who herself believes what she was taught: nearly every cost documented here is large for her, and none of them is addressed by anything she can do alone.

The evidence in this part is identical in both cases. **The answer is not, and anyone giving one answer to both is not reporting research — they are expressing a preference.**

The second reason is about who is speaking. Chapter Eight described a system in which a woman's conduct is decided, discussed and adjudicated mostly by other people. I am, at this moment, another person discussing it. The one contribution available to me that does not simply add to that pile is to hand over the information disaggregated — this cost is real and physical, this one is imposed by your neighbours, this one depends on what you believe, this one nobody can explain — and let whoever is living the situation do the applying. That is a smaller deliverable than a recommendation. It is the one I can honestly produce.

9.4 — Where I have to be careful

The front matter said I would flag this at the point where it applies.

Writing Chapter Eight, I noticed something in myself worth reporting. It was easier to write the section on the two-finger test than the section defending the family, and the ease was suspicious. Condemning a banned medical practice costs a writer nothing and reads as courage. Stating fairly why a frightened Indian parent restricts a daughter — and taking seriously that they may be right about the world even if wrong about the remedy — is the part that requires actual effort, and it is the part I was tempted to hurry.

There is a matching temptation in the other direction, and I want to name it too, because I am writing for an audience that includes many people who agree with the warning. It would be very easy to end this part with a sentence that lets the traditional view feel vindicated by the health chapter, because the health chapter is the one place I could do that honestly. I have tried not to let Chapter Six carry more weight than its own findings support.

Whether I have managed either is not something I can judge from inside the document. What I can do is tell you the two directions the error would run, and note that both temptations were present.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — MINE, AGAIN

This whole part has treated the warning as a **prediction**. I unpacked it into testable claims in Chapter One, checked them in Chapters Two to Six, ran a portability test in Chapter Seven, and have just spent this chapter asking what follows if the prediction is partly true.

That framing assumes the warning is in the business of predicting. Consider the possibility that it is not.

Here is the test. Suppose every effect size in this document came back at exactly zero tomorrow — no divorce association, no regret difference, no wellbeing effect, and a vaccine that eliminated the health risk entirely. Would the warning stop being issued?

Obviously not. Not in India, not anywhere. The aunt would still say it. The internet would still say it to the woman in the photograph who started this series. Which tells you what the warning is: it is a norm, and it wears a prediction the way a claim wears evidence when evidence is the currency of the room. The predictive dress is not the thing. It is what the thing puts on to be argued with.

So I have spent ninety pages auditing the one component that was auditable, and reporting the result as though the result were the point. That is not useless — a reader now knows which costs are physical, which are imposed, and which nobody can explain, and that is genuinely worth having. But I should not pretend it settles anything with anyone, because the part I checked is not the part doing the work.

The general form: auditing the testable component of something whose function is not to be tested. It happens constantly. A policy justified by an economic forecast that its supporters would back regardless of the forecast. A dress code justified by

> safety. A rule justified by evidence that arrived long after the rule. In each case the evidence is genuine and detachable, and checking it is worth doing — as long as nobody mistakes checking it for having addressed the rule.
>
> What actually addresses the rule is what Parts Two, Three and Six of this series were for: where it came from, what it was built to do, and what its defenders are really defending. This part checked the receipt. Those parts were about the purchase.

So this is where Part Ten ends: with the findings sorted, the advice withheld, and an admission that the sorting may matter less than it looks.

REMEMBER THIS

The traditionalist case at full strength does not need religion: the health claim is true, the regret asymmetry survived the hardest test, the socially imposed costs **still land on her**, and under uncertainty the downside of ignoring the warning is heavier than the downside of heeding it.

Three answers exist to "what should she do", and they agree on all the evidence. They differ on **who should bear the cost** of a system that is unjust and real at once. That is a moral disagreement, and no study will settle it.

The strongest finding in this part is a **moderation** finding — the effect depends on what she herself believes and wants. A result of that shape cannot license a general recommendation, because there is no general person to give it to.

So I am handing the findings over sorted rather than summarised into advice: **this cost is physical, this one is imposed by your neighbours, this one depends on what you were taught, this one nobody can explain.**

And the assumption underneath the whole document: I have treated the warning as a prediction. If every number in here came back zero tomorrow, nobody would stop issuing it — which means the part I checked is not the part doing the work.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Two lists, as in every part. What is genuinely unknown, with the reason it is unknown — which is usually more interesting than the gap. And what is solid enough to build on.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

WHAT THE DIVORCE ASSOCIATION IS MADE OF

The association between reported premarital partners and marital dissolution has been found for ninety years. Nobody can currently say what produces it. The researcher who published the best-known figures tested the standard explanations — comparison with past partners, children outside marriage, poor mate choice, selection on personality — and reported that none of them accounted for it. The reason we do not know: the study that would answer it cannot be run, and everything else is a substitute.

WHETHER ANY OF THIS IS TRUE OF MEN

The largest gap in the field, and it is a gap in what was collected rather than in what was found. The survey behind the headline divorce numbers does not carry equivalent data on men's premarital behaviour. So the comparison that would tell you whether this is a fact about sexual history or a fact about women's sexual history has never been available. The reason we do not know: nobody thought to ask.

WHETHER THE DIVORCE FINDING EXISTS OUTSIDE AMERICA

Nearly the entire evidence base is American. It has not been established with comparable rigour in Europe, East Asia or India. Given that the American finding itself moved substantially as American norms moved, this is not a small gap. The reason we do not know: the surveys that would support it either do not ask, or do not ask consistently enough across decades.

WHETHER THE REGRET ASYMMETRY SURVIVES MATCHED CONDITIONS

The sex difference is robust in direction and moderate in size. The proximate predictors identified so far — worry, pressure, disgust, physical enjoyment — are conditions rather than dispositions, and they are unequally distributed. Nobody has compared regret in encounters matched on all of them. The reason we do not know: the study is entirely feasible and has not been done.

WHICH WAY THE WELLBEING ARROW RUNS

Distress predicts later casual sex at least as strongly as casual sex predicts later distress. How much of the raw association is each is unsettled. The reason we do not know: most studies measure everything at one moment, and the long-term studies that would separate them are expensive and politically unattractive to fund from any direction.

HOW MUCH LETHAL VIOLENCE THERE ACTUALLY IS IN INDIA

The official count is a few dozen a year and almost no researcher accepts it. The true figure is unknown within an order of magnitude. The reason we do not know is the interesting part, and Chapter Eight set it out: the deaths are recorded as something else, often by the people involved.

WHAT WOMEN ACTUALLY DO

Every behavioural number in this part is self-reported, and men's and women's totals cannot both be true. The direction of the error tracks exactly the social pressure being studied. The reason we do not know: there is no way to independently verify a life history, and there never will be.

WHETHER BELIEFS CAN BE CHANGED WITHOUT COST

Chapter Five found that the damage tracks the collision between behaviour and installed belief. That suggests the beliefs are a lever. It does not establish that removing them is free — a person who loses a framework may lose things attached to it. The reason we do not know: nobody has studied what happens to women who change their minds about this, as opposed to women who hold one view or the other.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One absence on that list is permanent rather than temporary, and it is worth stating precisely because it changes how everything else should be read.

The design that would settle nearly every question in this part is a randomised trial: assign young women at random to different numbers of sexual partners, follow them for twenty years, compare. That study will never be run, in any country, by anyone. It is not merely unfunded. It is unethical in a way that no review board or change of politics would ever alter.

What follows from that: every finding in Chapters Two to Five is observational, permanently. Sibling comparisons, controls, longitudinal tracking and cross-cultural tests are the best available substitutes, and they are substitutes. Anyone claiming certainty about causes here — in either direction — is claiming something the evidence cannot deliver and never will.

Why this counts as knowledge rather than a complaint: knowing that a question is permanently underdetermined is itself a finding, and it tells you how much weight any answer can bear.

10.2 — Solid

THE REPORTED PARTNER COUNTS CANNOT ALL BE RIGHT

In every large national survey, men report substantially more opposite-sex partners than women — often around double. In a closed population the two totals must be equal. This is arithmetic, not interpretation, and it has been replicated across countries and decades.

THE DIVORCE ASSOCIATION EXISTS IN AMERICAN DATA

Reported premarital partner count and five-year marital dissolution are related in the National Survey of Family Growth. Found since 1938, replicated by many teams. Whatever its cause, the pattern is there.

THE RELATIONSHIP IS NOT A LINE

Women with two premarital partners divorced more than women with three to nine, and in earlier decades more than women with ten or more. About half the whole range sits between zero partners and one. These are features of the published figures, not of anyone's reading of them.

PREMARITAL SEX WITH ONLY THE FUTURE HUSBAND CARRIES NO ELEVATED RISK

Established by Teachman in 2003 and the cleanest single result in the field. Whatever the association tracks, it is not the act.

SEX DIFFERENCES IN SEXUAL REGRET ARE REAL, MODERATE, AND NOT ATTENUATED IN NORWAY

Men report more inaction regret, women more action regret, specifically in the sexual domain and not in non-sexual romantic matters. The prediction that it would shrink in a highly egalitarian society was made in advance and tested. It did not shrink. The size is moderate, with heavy overlap between the sexes.

AN INDIVIDUAL'S REGRET IS PREDICTED BY CONDITIONS

Worry, feeling pressured, disgust and lack of physical enjoyment predict regret better than sex does. A person's own comfort with casual sex predicts their regret better than whether they are a man or a woman.

THE WELLBEING EFFECT IS MODERATED AND REVERSES

For people comfortable with casual sex, having it was associated with higher wellbeing; for those uncomfortable, lower. Same behaviour, opposite outcomes, depending on the person.

INFECTION RISK RISES WITH EXPOSURE, AND CERVICAL CANCER IS PREVENTABLE

This is biology, it is dose-responsive, and it holds in every society. Persistent infection with certain HPV types causes virtually all cervical cancer. Vaccination prevents the large majority of it; screening catches nearly all of the rest early. Roughly two in a hundred Indian women aged 30 to 49 have ever been screened.

A WOMAN'S INFECTION RISK DEPENDS ON HER PARTNER'S HISTORY AS WELL AS HER OWN

Married women with a single lifetime partner develop and die from cervical cancer. No rule governing only her conduct can prevent this, because her exposure is not determined only by her conduct.

THE TWO-FINGER TEST HAS NO VALIDITY, AND INDIA HAS BANNED IT TWICE

It cannot establish sexual history. The Supreme Court held in 2013 that it violates dignity and bodily integrity, and in 2022 that conducting it is misconduct. In 2018 the World Health Organization and two United Nations bodies called for the elimination of virginity testing worldwide.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: what the divorce association is made of, whether it is true of men at all, whether it exists outside America, whether the regret difference survives matched conditions, which way the wellbeing arrow runs, how much lethal violence India actually has, and what women actually do — because the core variable is self-reported and provably misreported.

Solid: the reported counts cannot all be true; the divorce association is real in American data and is not a straight line; premarital sex with only the future husband carries no penalty; the regret asymmetry is real, moderate and survived Norway; individual regret is predicted by conditions rather than by sex; the wellbeing effect reverses depending on the person; infection risk is real and dose-responsive; cervical cancer is preventable and almost nobody in India is screened; and a woman's risk depends on her partner's history as much as her own.

One absence is permanent. The experiment that would settle the causal questions is one nobody will ever ethically run, which means every finding here is observational forever.

So the honest summary of ninety years of research: one claim in the warning is physically true and addressable by a vaccine, one is real and modest, two belong to the community rather than to the act, and one has never been explained by anybody — including the people who found it.

Timeline

Ninety years of research into a question that has almost only ever been asked about women, and the Indian legal thread running alongside it.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1938	Lewis Terman publishes the first systematic finding that premarital sexual experience is associated with marital instability. Terman was a pioneer of psychological testing and an enthusiastic eugenicist; the question did not enter the literature neutrally.
1948–53	The Kinsey reports establish that reported sexual behaviour and publicly stated norms differ enormously, and that large surveys can measure it at all.
1960	The contraceptive pill is approved in the United States, separating sex from pregnancy risk for the first time at scale — and changing one of the conditions this literature keeps rediscovering.
1979	The Mathura case verdict in India, in which a young woman's alleged prior sexual conduct is treated as relevant to whether she consented, triggers a national campaign.
1983	India amends its criminal law in response, introducing a presumption of absence of consent in custodial rape cases.
2003	India removes the provision that had allowed a rape complainant's general character to be used against her in court. In the same year Jay Teachman publishes the finding that women whose only premarital partner was their future husband carry no elevated divorce risk.
2006	Neal Roese and colleagues publish the first systematic demonstration of sex differences in sexual regret: men regret inaction, women regret action.
2012	Research on American students documents the large gap between women's reported physical enjoyment in casual encounters and in relationships. Sibling-comparison work on age at first sex begins attenuating associations that had looked strong in raw data.
2013	Galperin and colleagues replicate the regret asymmetry and show it is absent for non-sexual romantic regret. India's Supreme Court holds in *Lillu v. State of Haryana* that the two-finger test violates a woman's dignity and bodily integrity.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2014	Vrangalova and Ong show that the effect of casual sex on wellbeing is moderated by the person: higher for those comfortable with it, lower for those not.
2016	Kennair, Bendixen and Buss test the regret asymmetry in Norway and find it not attenuated. Wolfinger publishes the partner-count divorce table and the non-monotonic curve.
2017	A direct United States–Norway comparison finds that the cultural difference between the two countries does not significantly change levels of sexual regret.
2018	The World Health Organization, UN Human Rights and UN Women jointly call for the elimination of virginity testing, noting it is still practised in at least twenty countries. A campaign led by young members of a Maharashtra community brings community virginity testing to national attention in India.
2021	A large survey of Indian religious attitudes finds around two-thirds of respondents saying it is very important to stop women in their community from marrying outside it.
2022	India's Supreme Court holds in *State of Jharkhand v. Shailendra Kumar Rai* that anyone conducting the two-finger test is guilty of misconduct, and directs its removal from medical curricula.
2023	Wolfinger tests the standard explanations for the divorce association and reports that none of them accounts for it. India begins deploying a domestically produced HPV vaccine.
Next	**Part Eleven starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Action regret	Regret about something you did. The counterpart of inaction regret, which is about something you did not do.
Association	Two things going up and down together. It lets you guess a little better about one if you know the other. It says nothing about cause.
Cross-sectional study	A study that measures everything at one moment. Cheap, common, and unable to tell you which thing came first.
Confounding	When a third factor causes both of the things you are comparing, producing an association that is real in the data and empty as a cause.
Dose-response relationship	More of the cause, more of the effect, steadily. One of the strongest signs a relationship is genuinely causal.
Effect size	How big a difference is, as opposed to how confident we are that it exists. “Significant” means probably not zero; it does not mean large.
HPV	Human papillomavirus. A common family of viruses passed by skin-to-skin sexual contact. Persistent infection with certain types causes virtually all cervical cancer.
Izzat	Usually translated as honour; closer to standing. A household's public credit, held collectively, which determines the marriages it can arrange.
Longitudinal study	A study that follows the same people over years, measuring things in sequence. Expensive, slow, and the only way to see which came first.
Moderator	Something that changes the size or direction of an effect for different people. If an effect has a strong moderator, the average describes nobody.
NFHS	India's National Family Health Survey. A large repeated household survey, and the only Indian source that breaks results down by religion, caste and education.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Non-monotonic	A relationship that goes up and then down, or the reverse. Usually a sign that several different groups are mixed together.
NSFG	The American National Survey of Family Growth. The source of nearly every headline finding on premarital partners and divorce.
The portability test	If a harm is caused by an act it should appear everywhere; if by a punishment, only where the punishment exists. The main tool for telling a consequence from a penalty.
Prudential reason	A reason of self-interest — do this because it will go better for you. Distinct from a moral reason, though the two are constantly conflated.
Reverse causation	When the effect is actually causing the supposed cause, or when both come from the same underlying situation.
Selection effect	When people ended up in a group for reasons that also affect the outcome, so you are comparing different kinds of people rather than the same people under different conditions.
Sibling-comparison design	Comparing brothers or sisters raised in the same household who differ in the behaviour studied. It removes every family-level confounder automatically, including unmeasured ones.
Social desirability bias	Giving the answer that makes you look the way you are supposed to look. Here it pulls in opposite directions for men and women on the same question.
Sociosexuality	A measured trait describing how comfortable a person is with sex outside a committed relationship. In these studies it predicted regret better than sex did.
The two-finger test	A discredited manual examination once used to suggest whether a woman was “habituated to sexual intercourse”. It has no validity and has been prohibited by India's Supreme Court.
Virginity testing	Examination of a woman to determine whether she has had sex. Scientifically impossible; called for elimination by the World Health Organization and two UN bodies in 2018.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This series started with something small and ugly. A woman was photographed at a protest and was attacked online with a claim about how she earns money. What interested me was not her, and not the people attacking her, but the machinery underneath — the rules about what women may do, where they came from, what they are for, and what actually happens when they change. Ten parts in, I have changed my mind about several things, and this part changed it about two more.

I am not a psychologist, a demographer or a doctor. I read the primary sources carefully, follow the numbers wherever they go, and write down what I find in language that does not need a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — peer-reviewed research in sociology, psychology and epidemiology, national statistical surveys, Indian Supreme Court judgments and World Health Organization guidance — rather than new primary research. Where a figure is contested I have given the range and said why the ends differ. Where a named researcher's work is central, I have named them, including where I read their numbers differently from the way they were reported.

What this archive is good at: measuring outcomes that institutions record anyway. Divorces, cancers, court rulings and screening rates are documented because somebody had to document them for other reasons, which makes them hard to bend.

What it is bad at, and this is unusually serious in this part: **the central variable is self-reported and provably misreported**. Everything resting on partner counts inherits that, and I have flagged it wherever it bites rather than quietly relying on it.

One more thing worth repeating. Several of the best-known findings here were published through organisations with a stated commitment to marriage, and several of the critiques come from people with an equally strong commitment the other way. I have said so at the point where each appears, rather than presenting any of it as though it arrived from nowhere.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

This part kept running into the same hole. The research asks what happens to a woman. The warning is issued to a woman. And the data that would let anybody ask the same question about a man was, again and again, never collected. Part Eleven goes and looks at the half of the population nobody studied.

The questions it takes on:

- What does the evidence actually say happens to a man with the same history — and how much of the answer is simply missing because the surveys never asked?
- Where did the double standard come from, what does it do, and is it one rule applied unevenly or two different rules that happen to look related?
- If a woman's infection risk depends on her husband's history as much as her own, why has no society in recorded history built its rules around his?
- What happens to men in societies where the rule is enforced hard — the ones who cannot marry, the ones who enforce it, the brothers and fathers who carry it out?
- Is male sexual behaviour treated as fixed and female behaviour as adjustable because of evidence, or because only one of the two was ever expected to change?
- And the question the whole series has been walking towards: if you wanted the outcomes the traditionalists say they want, and you were allowed to change the conduct of either sex, which one would the evidence tell you to pick?

END OF PART TEN OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Eleven — The Half Nobody Studied

Every rule in this series governs one sex. Every study measures one sex. This part goes and looks at the other one — what the evidence says about men, who actually enforces the rules, which men pay for them, and whose conduct the evidence would target if it were allowed to choose.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Ten took the warning at the centre of this series — that a woman who breaks the rules damages her own life — and treated it as what it claims to be: a prediction. Then it checked it.

The result was untidy, and that untidiness was the finding. The warning is four claims, not one, and they do not stand or fall together. The health claim is true: exposure to infection rises with partners, dose for dose, in every society on Earth. The regret asymmetry is real, moderate in size, and survived the hardest cultural test anyone has run. The wellbeing claim reverses direction depending on what the woman believes, which means it belongs to the belief rather than to the act. The marriage-market claim does not travel at all — it is enormous where the community punishes and absent where it does not, which makes it a penalty rather than a consequence. And the divorce association, the oldest finding in the field, has never been explained by anybody, including the researcher who produced the best-known version of it.

Underneath all of that sat one thing I kept running into and could not fix. The research asks what happens to a woman. The warning is issued to a woman. And the data that would let anyone ask the same question about a man was, again and again, simply never collected. The American survey behind the headline divorce numbers does not carry equivalent information on men's premarital behaviour. That is not a finding about men. It is a hole where the finding should be.

So this part goes and looks at the half nobody studied.

I want to be exact about why, because there is a lazy version of this argument and I am not making it. The lazy version says: the rules are unfair to women, therefore we should talk about men to even things up. That is a political move, not an intellectual one. The reason to look at men is different and much stronger. If you want to know whether a rule aimed at women is **correct**, you have to know what happens to the people it is not aimed at. Otherwise you have a claim with no comparison group, and a claim with no comparison group is not a finding — it is a description of one population, dressed as a discovery.

How this document is built

Six kinds of box, each doing one job, each looking different so you can see at a glance what you are about to read. If you have read earlier parts, skip ahead.

The first explains a hard word the moment it appears.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Comparison group:** the people you measure your group against. Without one, a number means nothing.
>
> If I tell you that thirty per cent of women in some category divorced, you have learned almost nothing until I tell you what share of some other group did. Thirty against six is a large finding. Thirty against twenty-eight is not a finding at all.
>
> Why it matters here: for the central question of this series, the natural comparison group is men — and for a great many of the claims, nobody assembled it.

The second takes a number too big or too abstract to picture and turns it into something with a body.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> India has somewhere in the order of thirty million more men than the marriage market can pair off over the coming decades, concentrated in the north and north-west.
>
> Thirty million is the population of a large country. Picture every man in Malaysia, or in Australia and New Zealand together, arranged into one queue for a thing that will not arrive. Chapter Five is about that queue, and about the fact that it is almost never discussed as something happening *to* them.

The third shows the actual evidence behind a claim, and then says what it cannot show.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Much of this part rests on **censuses and court judgments** rather than on surveys, and that changes what can be trusted.

A census counts whether a man aged fifty has ever been married. He cannot misreport that in the way a survey respondent can misreport a partner count, and nobody has a reputational stake in the answer.

A Supreme Court judgment is a public document stating, in the state's own words, what a law was for. When a court strikes a law down and explains what it was actually doing, that is an institution testifying against itself — the most useful kind of evidence there is.

What neither can do: tell you what anybody felt, or what happened in households where nothing was recorded.

The fourth is for places where informed people genuinely disagree. Each side gets its best case.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not claim more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes nothing available would.

The fifth is the signature of this series. It digs out what both sides are assuming without noticing.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION**
>
> Not caveats. Unexamined premises sitting underneath an argument everybody is having. Five in this part, and the last is turned on this document and on the series around it.

The sixth closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

> **REMEMBER THIS**
>
> Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.
>
> **Simple words, serious content, nothing left out.**

Two warnings specific to this part

The first is about me, and it inverts the warning I gave in Part Ten. There I said the risk was writing about women's lives from outside them. Here the risk runs the other way: I am a man writing about men, and the temptations are self-pity and self-flattery. There is a whole genre that takes the true observation "men suffer under these rules too" and rides it to the conclusion that men are the real victims. I am not writing that. The men in Chapter Five have genuinely bad outcomes and did not choose them; the men in Chapter Four are carrying out the enforcement; frequently they are the same men, and both facts have to stay on the page at once. Where I catch myself sliding towards the comfortable version, I say so.

The second is about what this part is not. Nothing here argues that the rules should be aimed at men instead. Chapter Nine asks what the evidence would target if evidence were choosing, which is a different question from what anybody should do — and the last Hidden Assumption in this part is about why the difference matters more than it looks. A document that ended by proposing better rules for controlling somebody would have learned nothing from the ten parts before it.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The Half Nobody Studied

> *Before asking what happens to men, ask why nobody asked. The answer is not a conspiracy. It is something much more ordinary and much harder to correct.*

1.1 — A hole shaped like a question

Part Ten reported a table of divorce rates by the number of sexual partners a woman had before marrying. It is the most-quoted finding in this whole area. When I went to find the equivalent table for men, it was not there, and the reason given by the researcher who produced the women's version was that the survey does not carry full data on men's premarital sexual behaviour.

That is worth stating slowly, because it is easy to skim past. The largest and best-funded national survey of family formation in the richest country on Earth, run by a federal statistics agency across decades, at a cost of many millions, asked women in enough detail to build a partner-count table and did not ask men in enough detail to build the same one.

Nobody decided to hide anything. Survey questionnaires are finite, every question costs money, and questions get included when somebody can say why the answer matters. For decades, the answer to "how many partners had she had before marrying?" felt like it obviously mattered, and the answer to "how many had he had?" felt like an odd thing to want to know.

That is the whole mechanism. Not suppression. **A question that only feels natural in one direction.**

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

It is not true that nothing is known about men. Some surveys do ask, and ask well. Britain's **National Survey of Sexual Attitudes and Lifestyles** has surveyed men and women in comparable detail since 1990. Several smaller academic studies collect matched data on both.

So the picture is not blank. It is **patchy in a patterned way**: where a question is about the consequences of sexual behaviour for marriage and family, the female data is deep and the male data is thin. Where a question is about sexual behaviour as public health — infection, condom use, testing — the male data is often as good, because the funding came from a different place and asked a different thing.

What that tells you: the gap tracks the **purpose** of the research rather than any difficulty in collecting it. Men were asked about their partners whenever somebody wanted to trace an epidemic. They were not asked whenever the topic was whether the behaviour ruins a life.

1.2 — What you can and cannot read off a rule

Now the assumption underneath the whole subject, and the one this part exists to examine.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT AN ASYMMETRIC RULE IMPLIES AN ASYMMETRIC FACT

Here is a move that everybody in this argument makes, on every side, usually without noticing.

The traditionalist says: the rules govern women's sexual conduct more tightly than men's *because* the consequences differ — she can become pregnant, she carries the child, her body is at greater risk, so of course the rule falls on her. The critic says: the rules govern women more tightly *because* men wanted control over paternity and inheritance. These sound like opposite positions. They share a premise. Both are explaining the asymmetry of the rule by pointing at some asymmetry in the world.

There is a third possibility neither considers, and it does not require anybody's intentions to be bad. **A rule may fall on the party who can be made to comply.**

Consider how enforcement actually works. To police a woman's sexual conduct, a household needs to know where she is, who she is with, and when she comes home — and in most societies it already has that, because she lives inside a structure built to know. To police a man's sexual conduct you would need to follow him into a labour market, a city, a workplace, a road, a set of relationships with people your household has no contact with. One of those is cheap and one is nearly impossible, and the difference has nothing to do with pregnancy, paternity or virtue.

So the asymmetry of the rule is evidence about at least three things at once — the difference in consequences, the interest of whoever wrote it, and the **cost of enforcement** — and no society has ever had to separate them, because all three pointed the same way.

The general form: inferring a difference in nature from a difference in treatment. It runs through every field. Which jobs each sex held was read as evidence of aptitude. Which patients received painkillers was read as evidence of pain. In each case the treatment was doing something else, and the inference from treatment to nature ran backwards for a century.

Why this one matters for the rest of the part: if the rule fell where it was enforceable rather than where the harm was, then the whole body of evidence about women is answering a question that was never really being asked — and the men in the following chapters are not an afterthought. They are the control condition.

1.3 — What this part will and will not claim

Three things I am not going to argue, so you can hold me to it.

WORD BOX

Control condition: in an experiment, the group that does not get the thing being tested, kept there so you can see what would have happened anyway.

Without one, you cannot tell an effect from a background. If a hundred treated patients recover, that is either a miracle or completely unremarkable, and the only thing that decides which is how many untreated patients recovered.

Why the word belongs in a chapter about men: for the central claim of this series, men are not a side topic. **They are the group that shows what happens anyway —** and that group was never assembled.

I am not going to argue that men suffer equally. In Chapter Five you will meet men with genuinely bad lives produced by this system, and the bad lives are real. They are also not symmetrical with what Chapters Eight and Nine of Part Ten described, and pretending otherwise would be its own kind of dishonesty.

I am not going to argue that the consequences of sex are physically identical for men and women. They are not, and Chapter Six goes through exactly how they differ, including in a direction most people do not expect.

And I am not going to argue that the rules should be pointed at men. Chapter Nine asks what the evidence would point at, which is a genuine and answerable question, and it is not the same as a proposal.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Picture a doctor investigating a disease that appears in a village. She surveys every woman in it in enormous detail — symptoms, diet, history, exposure — and asks the men three quick questions on the way out.
>
> She then reports that the disease is associated with something in the women's histories.
>
> She may be right. But she cannot know, because she has no idea what the men's histories look like, and the one design that would have told her whether the association is about the disease or about being a woman in that village is the one she did not run.
>
> That is the state of this literature. **Not wrong. Unable to be checked.**

That is the hole this part is walking into. The next chapter goes and sees what is actually in it.

REMEMBER THIS

The best-known findings about sexual history and marriage have **no male comparison group**, because the survey that produced them did not ask men in equivalent detail.

The gap is not a conspiracy. It is a **question that only felt natural in one direction**, repeated across decades of questionnaire design.

The gap is patterned. Where the research was about **infection**, men were surveyed properly, because the funder wanted to trace an epidemic. Where it was about whether the behaviour ruins a life, they were not.

Everyone explains the asymmetric rule by pointing to an asymmetric fact — different consequences, or male interest in paternity. Both may be true. Both miss a third possibility: **the rule fell on the party who could be made to comply**, because policing a daughter is cheap and policing a son is nearly impossible.

Without the comparison group, a claim about women is not a discovery. It is a description of one population wearing the clothes of a finding.

CHAPTER TWO

What Actually Happens to a Man

> *The evidence is thinner, but it is not empty. And where it is strongest, it points somewhere nobody expects: the sex whose conduct is unregulated is the sex with more to lose if marriage fails.*

2.1 — On the thing everybody wants to know, we mostly do not know

Start with the question Part Ten answered for women. Does a man's number of premarital sexual partners predict whether his marriage lasts?

The honest answer is that the evidence is thin. The limited work that exists points in the same direction as the female findings and generally reports weaker associations, and every piece of it comes with the same caveat: the male data was not collected as carefully, so the comparison is not clean.

I am not going to build anything on that. A weak finding from a thin dataset is exactly the kind of thing this series is supposed to refuse to inflate, and it would be very easy to inflate it in either direction here — into "so it damages men too, and the rule is just badly targeted", or into "so it does not damage men, and the rule is pure control". Neither is supported.

What can be said is narrower and more useful. On the **market** claim — that a sexual history damages your prospects — the asymmetry is not subtle and does not need a survey to detect. In no society that I can find has a man's number of previous partners been treated as a defect that reduces his value in a marriage negotiation. In many, including large parts of India, it is not asked about at all. Part Ten established that the marriage-market penalty for women does not travel across societies. For men, in most places, it does not exist to begin with.

2.2 — Regret, read from the other side

Part Ten reported the regret asymmetry: women more often regret what they did, men more often regret what they did not do. That was presented, correctly, as a finding about women. Turn it over.

It says that a substantial number of men are carrying regret about opportunities they passed up. That is a real reported cost, it appears in the same studies, and it is almost never discussed, because a regret about not having had sex reads as comic rather than serious.

I want to be careful about the weight this bears. Regretting an encounter you had and regretting one you did not are not equivalent injuries, and treating them as equivalent is one of the moves I warned about in the front matter. But the finding is in the data, and the reason it never gets quoted is worth noticing: the same research is cited constantly for its female half and essentially never for its male half.

2.3 — The same moderator, in both sexes

The wellbeing research from Part Ten was not a study of women. It included men, and the moderating effect worked the same way for them: people comfortable with casual sex reported higher wellbeing after it, and people uncomfortable with it reported lower, regardless of sex.

That is a genuinely important result and it usually gets reported as a fact about women. What it actually shows is that the mechanism is not sex-specific at all. It is about the fit between what a person does and what a person believes — and the reason it produces more distress in women, on average, is that more women hold beliefs the behaviour collides with. Which is a fact about what each sex was taught, not about what each sex is.

2.4 — Who actually needs marriage

Now the part of this chapter that should reorganise how you read the rest of the series.

WORD BOX

All-cause mortality: the chance of dying from anything at all in a given period. It is the bluntest health measure there is and the hardest to fake, because a death gets recorded whatever anybody believes about it.

Why researchers reach for it: every softer measure — happiness, wellbeing, self-reported health — depends on what people say. Death does not.

Across a very large body of research in many countries, married people live longer than unmarried people. That much is well known. The part that is less known is the size of the difference by sex.

The advantage is consistently larger for men. Married men do markedly better than unmarried men on mortality, on physical health, on mental health and on measured loneliness. Married women also do better than unmarried women, but by a smaller margin, and on some measures the gap narrows to very little.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This finding rests on **administrative records** rather than surveys — national death registers linked to marital status, followed across whole populations for decades, in many countries independently.

Why that is strong: nobody is reporting anything. A death certificate and a marriage register are produced by institutions for their own purposes, and neither has a stake in this question. When Scandinavian registry data, American cohort studies and British records all produce the same pattern, the pattern is not a survey artefact.

What it cannot show: **which way it runs.** Registry data records who was married and who died. It does not record whether marriage protected them or whether the men who were going to do well were the ones who married. That is the argument below, and it is not settled.

Before the argument, the size of the thing being argued about.

IN REAL TERMS

Follow a large group of men and a large group of women from middle age. In study after study, the unmarried men fall behind the married men by a wider margin than the unmarried women fall behind the married women.

Put it in the ordinary furniture of a life. When a marriage ends, a woman more often keeps the friendships, the family contact, the routines of care and the habit of asking for help. A man more often discovers that his social world ran through his wife, and that when she left, it left.

The institution that the rules exist to protect is the one that men need more. Everything else in this series is about arranging a woman's conduct to secure it.

That comparison only holds, of course, if marriage is doing the work rather than merely marking the men who were going to do well anyway — which is exactly what is in dispute.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES MARRIAGE HELP MEN, OR DO HELPABLE MEN MARRY?

This is the same methodological fight as Part Ten's Chapter Three, arriving from the other direction, and it deserves the same scepticism.

MARRIAGE PROTECTS, AND IT PROTECTS MEN MORE

The plausible mechanisms are specific and testable rather than vague. Married men drink less, take fewer physical risks, are more likely to attend a doctor when something is wrong — largely because someone notices and tells them to. They have a person who registers a symptom, books an appointment and asks whether they took the tablet. They also have a social world maintained on their behalf. Studies that follow the same men through a marriage ending find their health measures deteriorate afterwards, which is hard to explain by selection alone, because the selection already happened.

HEALTHIER MEN WERE ALWAYS MORE LIKELY TO MARRY

The men who never marry are, on average, poorer, less educated, in worse health and more likely to have a serious illness or addiction before any of this begins — and Chapter Five shows that in India the men who cannot marry are drawn overwhelmingly from the bottom of the class structure. So the comparison is between two different populations, exactly as in Part Ten. The health advantage may be mostly the entry requirement, not the benefit. And the deterioration after divorce could as easily reflect what caused the divorce as what followed it.

Where things stand: most researchers hold that both are operating, with selection accounting for a substantial share and protection for a real remainder. The size of each is disputed. What is not disputed is the raw pattern, and the raw pattern is what matters for the argument this part is making.

What would settle it: studies following the same individuals across changes in marital status while measuring health before, during and after — some of which exist and support a genuine protective effect, though not the whole of the raw gap.

Why people care so much: because if marriage genuinely protects men more than women, then the standard story — that marriage is an institution men designed for their own benefit and women should be sceptical of — is at minimum incomplete. And if it is mostly selection, then the men at the bottom of Chapter Five are being counted as evidence for something they are actually the victims of.

2.5 — The Indian numbers, handled carefully

There is an Indian statistic that circulates constantly in arguments about men, and because it is real and is usually misused, it belongs here rather than being left to the internet.

India's national crime statistics record substantially more male than female deaths by suicide — roughly seven in ten of all recorded suicide deaths are male — and married men are the largest single category in the tables.

Both of those are true, and both are routinely stretched into a claim they cannot support. Married men are the largest category partly because married men are an enormous share of the adult male population; a raw count is not a rate, and comparing a count to a count tells you about population size as much as risk. Recording is also uneven: female suicide in India is widely believed to be under-recorded, and deaths that would be classified as dowry-related, as accidents or as illness elsewhere in the file affect both columns.

What survives all that is still substantial. India has among the higher male suicide rates in the world, the rate is highest among men of working age, and financial distress and family problems appear repeatedly among recorded causes. That is a real and large harm falling on men, it has almost nothing to do with anybody's sexual conduct, and it is worth stating precisely rather than either amplifying it or waving it away.

REMEMBER THIS

On whether a man's partner count predicts his divorce, the evidence is **too thin to build on —** and it is thin because the data was not collected, not because the answer came back negative.

On the market claim, the asymmetry is stark. A man's sexual history is **not treated as a defect** in a marriage negotiation in any society I can find. For women, Part Ten showed that penalty exists and does not travel. For men it mostly does not exist at all.

The **wellbeing moderator works identically in both sexes**. The mechanism is the collision between behaviour and belief, not anything about being female. More women hold the colliding beliefs, which is a fact about teaching.

Married people live longer, and the advantage is **consistently larger for men —** on mortality, health and loneliness. How much is protection and how much is selection is disputed; the pattern is not.

Which produces the fact this part keeps returning to: the institution these rules exist to protect is the one men need more, and it is women whose conduct is arranged to secure it.

CHAPTER THREE

Does the Double Standard Still Exist?

> *Ask the experiments and the answer is surprisingly weak. Ask a village in Haryana and it is not even a question. Both of those results are real, and understanding why they differ tells you what the standard actually is.*

3.1 — What you are trying to measure

Everybody knows what the sexual double standard is. Almost nobody can say what would count as evidence for it, which is why the research has been such a mess.

WORD BOX

The sexual double standard: judging the same sexual behaviour more harshly in a woman than in a man.

Why it is hard to measure: it can live in at least four separate places, and they can disagree. It can be in what people **say** they believe. In how they **rate** a described person. In who they actually **choose** as a friend, a partner or a spouse. And in what a community **does** — the gossip, the withdrawn match, the violence.

A study measuring one of those four is not measuring the others, and the finding "there is no double standard" almost always means "not in the one we measured".

3.2 — The experiments, and the surprise inside them

The standard design is a vignette. Give people a short description of a person — name, age, a stated number of sexual partners — and ask them to rate that person on things like decency, intelligence, desirability. Then run the identical description with the name and pronouns switched, and compare.

If the double standard is what everyone assumes, the woman should be rated much more harshly than the man for the same number.

She often is not.

Across a substantial run of these studies, mostly with Western student samples, researchers have found the effect to be much weaker than expected, absent altogether in several, and in some cases running in the other direction. What shows up reliably is a **single standard applied to both**: people rate a person with a high partner count more negatively regardless of sex.

This result has been replicated enough that it cannot be dismissed, and it is used constantly by people who want to argue the double standard is a myth. So it needs to be taken seriously, and then examined.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> The vignette method has one genuine strength and one crippling weakness, and both matter here.
>
> **The strength:** it is a true experiment. The only thing that differs between conditions is the sex of the person described, so any difference in ratings is caused by that. Almost nothing else in this field can say that.
>
> **The weakness:** it asks people to make a judgement, on paper, knowing they are being observed, about a stranger who does not exist. Every one of those conditions works against finding a double standard. The participant knows what the study is about within seconds. Nobody they know will hear the answer. Nothing follows from it.
>
> What the design therefore measures well: **what people are willing to say when they know they are being watched.** What it cannot measure: what a community does when a real woman's real conduct becomes known, which is the thing everybody actually means.

3.3 — Where it shows up instead

Change the measure and the picture changes.

When researchers stop asking for ratings and start asking about actual social choices — who would you want as a friend, who would you introduce to your family, who would you want as a long-term partner — the effects get larger. Studies of this kind have found that both men and women prefer sexually restrained peers, and, strikingly, that this holds even among people who are themselves sexually permissive. A person can hold a permissive attitude about their own life and a restrictive one about who they want around them.

The other place it shows up is in language, and this is not a soft observation. There is a dense vocabulary of insult for a sexually active woman in English, in Hindi, in Punjabi, and in essentially every language I can check. The male equivalents either do not exist, or exist as compliments, or exist as mild jokes. A vocabulary is a piece of evidence: languages develop precise words for distinctions that a community needs to make often.

WORD BOX

Stated preference: what a person says they want or believe, when asked.

Revealed preference: what their actual choices show they want.

Why the distinction matters here: on the sexual double standard, stated and revealed preferences come apart sharply, and they come apart in a predictable direction. People state something close to equality and choose something considerably less equal.

This is not lying. Most people are not aware of the gap. It is why an experiment that asks and an observation that watches produce different answers about the same population.

Which is why the two sides of the following argument can both cite good evidence and reach opposite conclusions. They are not reading the same instrument.

THE ARGUMENT — HAS THE DOUBLE STANDARD ACTUALLY GONE?

Both sides here have real evidence, and the disagreement is largely about which measurement counts.

IT HAS LARGELY GONE, AT LEAST IN THE WEST

The best-controlled evidence available says so. Vignette experiments are the only true experiments in this whole field, they have been run many times by many groups, and they mostly find a single standard rather than a double one. Attitude surveys have moved enormously across two generations. Behaviour has converged: the partner-count gap between young men and women has narrowed sharply. Continuing to assert a double standard while the direct experimental evidence says otherwise is treating the conclusion as unfalsifiable — every null result gets explained away as the wrong measure.

IT HAS CHANGED SHAPE, NOT DISAPPEARED

Look at what the null results actually establish: that people will not say it on a form. Meanwhile the choice-based measures find it, the vocabulary retains it, and the consequences remain wildly asymmetric — nothing that happens to a man's reputation resembles what happens to a woman's when an image circulates. And a global claim cannot rest on Western student samples. In much of the world the standard is not a subtle attitudinal effect at all; it is a marriage market, a set of laws and, at the far end, a body count. A finding from a psychology department in a rich country is evidence about that department's country.

Where things stand: both are right about their own measure and neither generalises. In Western samples, on direct ratings, the double standard is genuinely weak — that is a real finding and people who care about this should stop denying it. On social choice, language and consequence, it persists. And in societies where marriage is arranged between families, it is not weak by any measure at all.

What would settle it: studies that measure consequences rather than opinions — what actually happens to matched men and women after the same information about them becomes public. Almost nobody runs these, because they are hard, slow and unpleasant.

Why people care so much: because "it does not exist any more" is the strongest available argument that no reform is needed, and "it is as bad as ever" is the strongest available argument that nothing has been achieved. The truthful answer — much weaker in one place, unchanged in another — is useful to neither.

3.4 — India, where there is nothing to measure carefully

In the Indian case the experimental subtleties are beside the point, because the standard is not an attitude that has to be teased out of a rating scale. It is written into the structure Part Ten's Chapter Eight described.

A family's standing is damaged by a daughter's rumoured conduct and is not damaged in the same way by a son's. A marriage negotiation prices one and does not ask about the other. The verification procedures that exist — the ones India's Supreme Court has had to prohibit — were built to check a claim about a bride, and there has never been an equivalent examination of a groom, in any community, at any point in the record.

IN REAL TERMS

Here is the whole chapter in one comparison. Two families are negotiating a marriage. Somebody mentions that the prospective bride was seen with a man two years ago.

Now run it again with the sexes swapped: somebody mentions that the prospective groom was seen with a woman two years ago.

You already know that the first conversation can end the match and the second one usually does not begin. **You did not need a study, and that is the finding.** A standard so widely known that no evidence is required to establish it does not need to appear in a vignette experiment to be operating.

So the answer to the chapter's question depends entirely on where you ask it, and any single number offered for the whole world is measuring one room.

REMEMBER THIS

The double standard can live in four different places — what people **say**, how they **rate**, who they **choose**, and what a community **does** — and a study of one is not a study of the others.

In Western vignette experiments, the effect is **much weaker than expected and often absent**. That is a genuine, replicated finding and people who care about this subject should stop denying it.

But those experiments measure what people will say when observed. On **social choice**, on **language**, and on **consequence**, the asymmetry persists — including among people who are themselves sexually permissive.

Stated and revealed preferences come apart here, predictably and in one direction. Most people are not aware of the gap.

And in societies where marriage is arranged between families, none of this is subtle: one side of the negotiation is priced and the other side is not asked.

CHAPTER FOUR

Who Actually Enforces It

> *The standard picture is men controlling women. Watch who actually does the daily work of enforcement and the picture does not survive contact — which tells you something important about how the system is built.*

4.1 — The picture everyone starts with

Ask almost anyone — a defender of the rules or a critic — who enforces them, and you get some version of the same answer. Men. Fathers, husbands, brothers, village councils, priests. The rules exist because men want them and men apply them.

The critic says this to indict. The defender says a softer version of it — that men have a duty to protect the family's standing. Both agree on the mechanism.

Now go and look at an actual household.

4.2 — The daily work is done by women

The enforcement that matters most is not dramatic. It is continuous, small and domestic: what she wears, where she goes, who she talks to, what time she is home, whether she has a phone and who can see it, whether she may take a job in another city.

Nearly all of that is administered by women. The mother-in-law is the central figure in the Indian household on exactly these questions — research on contraceptive use in north India repeatedly finds that her stated view predicts a young wife's behaviour better than the wife's own stated preference. Mothers police daughters. Aunts report on nieces. Sisters-in-law monitor each other. Friends withdraw from a girl whose reputation has become risky to share.

The comparative case that makes this unmistakable is female genital cutting.

WORD BOX

Female genital cutting: the removal or alteration of parts of a girl's external genitals for reasons that are not medical. It is practised across a belt of Africa and parts of Asia and the Middle East, usually on girls before adolescence, and it causes lasting physical harm.

Why it appears in this chapter: it is the single clearest test of who enforces these rules. The practice is arranged by women, performed by women, and defended by women, in societies where men frequently do not discuss it at all.

Whatever that practice is, it is not a case of men physically imposing something on women — and any theory of enforcement that cannot accommodate that has a hole in it.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence here is mostly **ethnographic** — researchers living in and observing households over long periods — supported by household surveys that ask who decides what.

What ethnography is good at: seeing the enforcement that never becomes an event. No survey captures a look across a room, a phone quietly checked, a rumour passed between two aunts. These are the actual mechanism and they leave no record unless somebody is sitting there.

What it is bad at: scale and generalisation. A study of forty households in one district is a study of forty households in one district. When many such studies from different regions report the same structure, that convergence is the evidence — not any one of them.

Where the survey data supports it: household decision-making questions in India's large health surveys consistently show older women, not only men, holding authority over younger women's health and mobility decisions.

4.3 — What men do instead

This does not mean men are absent. It means their role is different in kind, and it has two parts.

The first is **policing each other**. A great deal of male behaviour around women's conduct is performed for other men — the reputation of a brother who "cannot control" his sister, the standing of a husband whose wife works late, the ridicule available to a man judged insufficiently vigilant. The pressure a man feels to restrict a woman is frequently pressure from other men about himself.

The second is **the far end**. When enforcement becomes physical, it becomes male. The beatings, the confinements and the killings are overwhelmingly carried out by fathers, brothers, cousins and husbands.

Even there the pattern is not what it looks like. Case studies of honour killings across South Asia and the Middle East report repeatedly that the act is often assigned to a younger male relative — sometimes a minor — and that female relatives are frequently among those who decided it should happen. A killing that is planned by a household and executed by its most legally expendable member is not a man acting on his own impulse. It is an organisation allocating a task.

IN REAL TERMS

Think of it as a firm rather than a family, for one paragraph, because the shape becomes visible.

The **shareholders** are the household, whose standing is the asset. The **middle management**, doing daily supervision, is the senior women. The **enforcement**, when it is needed, is delegated to a junior male — often the one with the least to lose in court and the least standing to refuse.

Now ask the question that shape makes obvious: who in that structure is **choosing**? The mother-in-law enforcing a rule she suffered under at twenty. The nineteen-year-old brother handed an instruction and a knife. Neither of them designed this. Both of them are running it.

Which raises the question that this chapter cannot avoid, and that I do not think has a clean answer.

THE ARGUMENT — ARE THE WOMEN WHO ENFORCE IT AGENTS OR INSTRUMENTS?

This is one of the hardest questions in the whole series, and I do not think either answer is fully right.

THEY ARE AGENTS, AND TREATING THEM OTHERWISE IS CONDESCENSION

A mother-in-law restricting her daughter-in-law is making a calculation and she is not confused about it. She holds real authority, she has interests of her own — the household's standing is her security in old age, and her son's marriage is her asset too — and she acquired that authority by surviving the system. Denying her agency is a way of preserving the belief that only men act. It also gets the politics wrong: any attempt to change this that assumes women will welcome it will fail, because a substantial share of enforcement will be defended by the women doing it.

THEY ARE INSTRUMENTS, AND THE AUTHORITY IS A WAGE

What she has is authority over other women within a structure she cannot alter, granted in exchange for maintaining it. That is not agency in any strong sense; it is a position in a hierarchy that pays in status. Notice its limits: she may restrict a daughter-in-law's movement and cannot touch her son's conduct, cannot leave the household, and loses everything if the family's standing collapses. A person who can only exercise power downwards and only in one direction is being used by the arrangement, however sincerely she believes in it.

Where things stand: unresolved, and the disagreement is philosophical rather than empirical — both sides accept exactly the same facts about who does what. What the facts do establish is that any account routing this system purely through male control is wrong on the observable mechanism, and that any account treating the enforcing women as simple villains is wrong about their position in it.

What would settle it: nothing measurable. "Agency" is not a quantity. But there is a partial empirical test available: watch what happens to enforcement when the underlying incentive is removed — when a family no longer needs the marriage market, or when a woman's security no longer runs through her son. Where that has happened, enforcement has weakened, which is at least consistent with the second reading.

Why people care so much: because if women are agents here, then this is not a conflict between the sexes and cannot be framed as one — and both the feminist account and the men's-grievance account lose their simplest version at the same moment.

Underneath that argument, both sides are taking something for granted, and it is the thing this chapter exists to name.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT WHOEVER BENEFITS IS WHOEVER ENFORCES

Every account of these rules — the critical one and the defensive one — links the benefit to the enforcement. Men benefit, so men enforce. Or: the family benefits, so the family enforces. The reasoning feels so natural that nobody states it.

But this system separates the two completely. **The benefit accrues to the household's standing. The daily work is done by senior women. The legal risk is carried by junior men.** Three different parties, none of whom holds all three positions.

Once you see that, several things stop being puzzling. It stops being puzzling that women defend practices that harmed them — they are not defending a benefit, they are occupying a post. It stops being puzzling that a nineteen-year-old goes to prison for a decision taken by people who never touched anybody. And it stops being puzzling that the system survives generation after generation without anybody designing it: a rule that distributes its costs across people who cannot combine, and its benefits to an abstraction that cannot be argued with, is extremely hard to dismantle.

The general form: assuming the beneficiary is the enforcer. It is one of the most reliable errors in political analysis. The people who administer a border, a prison, a debt collection or a caste boundary are almost never the people the arrangement is for — and confusing the two produces campaigns aimed at the wrong party, which then fail and are read as proof that the system is popular.

What follows for this series: “the rules about women” is not a phrase describing something men do to women. It describes a machine with roles in it, and almost everyone reading this occupies one.

The next chapter follows the machine's output twenty-five years downstream, to the men it produced and nobody planned for.

REMEMBER THIS

The daily enforcement — clothes, movement, phones, curfews, who may work where — is administered overwhelmingly by **women on women**. The mother-in-law's view predicts a young wife's behaviour better than the wife's own stated preference does.

Men's role is different in kind: **policing each other** about their vigilance, and carrying out enforcement at the far end when it becomes physical.

Even the lethal end is organisational rather than impulsive. The act is often assigned to the **most legally expendable** member of a household, and women are frequently among those who decided it.

So the system separates its parts: **the benefit goes to the household's standing, the work is done by senior women, the legal risk is carried by junior men**. Nobody holds all three.

Which is why it is so durable. A rule whose costs fall on people who cannot combine, for the benefit of an abstraction that cannot be argued with, does not need anybody to defend it.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Men at the Bottom

> *A preference for sons produced a shortage of daughters, and the shortage is now producing millions of men who will never marry. Almost every word written about them is about what they might do, and almost none about what is happening to them.*

5.1 — The missing women

In 1990 the economist Amartya Sen published an essay pointing out that in several countries there were far fewer women alive than the biology of birth and survival could account for. Women live longer than men where both are fed and treated equally. Across much of South and East Asia, they did not outnumber men. Sen's estimate of the shortfall ran to more than a hundred million.

The causes are unglamorous and cumulative: daughters fed less, taken to a doctor later, and — from the 1980s, once ultrasound became cheap — not born at all.

WORD BOX

Sex ratio at birth (SRB): the number of girls born per thousand boys. Left alone, nature produces about 950 — slightly more boys than girls, everywhere, consistently.

India's national figure has run below that for decades. In the most recent official sample data, several states report figures below 900, and Bihar's fell from 964 in 2020 to 897 in 2023.

Why it matters: a ratio below the natural rate is not a curiosity of statistics. It is a count of girls who were expected and did not arrive, and every one of them is a woman who will not be in a marriage market twenty-five years later.

The point of this chapter is not to re-argue that. It is to follow the arithmetic forward, because the consequence lands about a quarter of a century after the cause, and it lands on men.

5.2 — The queue

If a generation is born with too few girls, then when that generation reaches marrying age some men will not marry. Not “will marry later” — will not marry, ever.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> This is one of the few areas in the series where the evidence is close to arithmetic rather than statistical inference.
>
> A **census** counts how many people of each sex are alive at each age. It is not a sample and not a self-report of anything sensitive. Nobody misreports their sex to a census-taker.
>
> From that you can compute directly how many men of marriageable age face how many women, and project it forward — because everybody who will be thirty in twenty-five years has already been born and already been counted.
>
> Analysis for the United Nations Population Fund in India projects that men who never marry will rise from about **4.5 per cent in 2010 to about 12.6 per cent by 2040**, before falling back to around 8 per cent by 2050 as the improvement in the sex ratio after 2004 works through. Around five per cent never marrying is normal in any population, so anything above that is the squeeze itself.
>
> What this cannot tell you: what those men’s lives will be like. The count is solid; everything downstream of it is inference.

The pressure is not spread evenly. It concentrates in the north and north-west, in the states that practised sex selection hardest. In the 2011 census, across Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, about 76 per cent of men aged 20 to 24 were unmarried against about 34 per cent of women of the same age. Lifelong bachelorhood among men over fifty ran at about 2.1 per cent nationally, at 3.8 per cent in Uttar Pradesh, and in some districts studied closely it reached seven or eight per cent.

5.3 — Which men

Here is the part that is almost always left out, and it changes the subject.

The men who do not marry are not drawn at random. When women are scarce, families choose, and they choose upwards. The men left over are the poorest, the least educated, the landless, the ones with a disability, the ones from the lowest-status households.

China's figures show this with brutal clarity. In its 2010 census, among men in the relevant age band, around 38 per cent of those who were illiterate had never married, against under 3 per cent of those who had completed junior middle school. The same man's marriage prospects are decided by his schooling and his family's land, not by anything he did.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Take a hundred men in a north Indian district where the ratio is bad. Perhaps twelve of them will never marry. Those twelve are not twelve men chosen by chance from the hundred — they are, very nearly, the poorest twelve.
>
> Now put that in a life. In a society where marriage is close to compulsory, where an unmarried adult man lives in his parents' house indefinitely, where there is no independent social role for him, and where his standing among other men depends on being a householder, he does not simply lack a wife. He remains, socially, a boy, for the rest of his life.
>
> Punjabi has a word for him — **chhada**. Haryanvi has **malang**. Chinese has **bare branches**: a limb of the family tree that will not fork. None of these words is neutral, and none of them is kind.

What follows is documented and grim. Some of these men remain dependent on ageing parents who expected to be supported and instead go on supporting. Some marry across enormous distances — brides brought from poorer eastern states into Haryana and Punjab, often without a shared language, with the local terms for them, *paro* and *molki*, carrying their own contempt. Some of those marriages are ordinary and some involve payment, deception or trafficking. And a large number simply live out a diminished version of the life they expected, without an event ever occurring that anybody would record.

5.4 — What the literature asks about them

Now look at how this subject is discussed.

The best-known book on it is called *Bare Branches*, published in 2004 by Valerie Hudson and Andrea den Boer, and its subtitle names the frame: the **security implications** of Asia's surplus male population. It estimated roughly 16.5 million surplus men aged 15 to 35 in India by 2006 and projected 28 to 32 million by 2020, and it argued that large numbers of unmarried, low-status young men make societies more violent and more prone to authoritarian rule.

THE ARGUMENT — DO SURPLUS MEN MAKE A SOCIETY DANGEROUS?

This is a genuine empirical dispute with real evidence on both sides, and it matters because the answer determines whether these men are treated as a problem to be managed or as people with a bad outcome.

YES, AND THE MECHANISM IS NOT MYSTERIOUS

Young, unmarried, low-status men are the most crime-prone demographic in every society ever measured, and marriage is one of the most reliable predictors of a man desisting from crime. Make that group much larger and you should expect more crime. There is direct evidence: economists studying China found that the rise in sex ratios accounted for a substantial share of the increase in crime there over two decades. Historical cases point the same way. This is not a slur on the men involved; it is a claim about what happens to any large population of people with no stake in the existing order.

THE LINK IS WEAK AND THE FRAMING DOES THE WORK

The correlations are confounded by everything that travels with them — poverty, unemployment, weak policing, rapid urbanisation, regions that were already violent. Scarcity of women can also raise their value and improve their position, which is the opposite prediction, and in some places that is what has happened. And the historical examples are selected after the fact: societies with surplus men that stayed peaceful do not get written about. Predicting mass violence from a demographic ratio has a poor record, and it has repeatedly been used to justify treating a whole category of poor young men as a threat before any of them has done anything.

Where things stand: a modest real effect on crime, well short of the strongest claims. Most researchers accept that the Chinese crime finding is genuine and contest how much it generalises. The catastrophic version — surplus men producing war or state collapse — is not supported by the evidence available.

What would settle it: the next twenty years in India, which is a natural experiment nobody chose. The peak of the squeeze arrives around 2040 and the cohorts producing it are already alive and counted.

Why people care so much: because "surplus men are dangerous" is one of the very few arguments against sex selection that has ever moved a government. Appeals to the value of daughters largely did not. A security threat did.

That last sentence is worth stopping on, because it is the whole chapter, and neither side of the argument above noticed it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THEIR SUFFERING IS ONLY INTERESTING AS A RISK

Read the literature on these men and count the questions. Will they commit crimes? Will they destabilise the state? Will they push up trafficking? Will they support authoritarian politics?

Now count the studies asking what it is like to be one of them. There are a few, mostly ethnographic, mostly Indian, and they are a rounding error beside the security literature.

Both sides of the argument above share this. The alarmed side says surplus men are dangerous. The sceptical side says they are less dangerous than claimed. **Both are answering a question about the rest of us.** A man who will spend his life in his parents' house, without the only adult status his society offers, has a bad life whether or not he ever hurts anybody — and that fact appears in this literature almost exclusively as a variable predicting something else.

Notice too what it took to get anybody to act. Decades of arguing that daughters have worth did not move policy far. The argument that finally reached governments was that a shortage of women would produce a surplus of dangerous men. So even the campaign to save girls ended up being conducted in the currency of what unmarried men might do to everyone else.

> **The general form:** a group whose suffering is discussed only as a hazard it poses. Unemployed young men, migrants, the mentally ill, the urban poor — each is studied intensively, and the research question is almost always what they will do rather than what is happening to them. Sympathy is available; it just has to arrive dressed as risk assessment.
>
> And the connection to this series is direct. The rules about women produced these men. A preference for sons, enforced through daughters, made a generation with too few girls in it — and the cost landed, twenty-five years later, on the poorest sons.

That is the demographic bill. The next chapter turns to a physical one, where the direction of the harm is even clearer and the rule is aimed even further from its source.

REMEMBER THIS

A preference for sons produced a **shortage of daughters** — Sen's missing women, and, once ultrasound was cheap, sex ratios at birth far below the natural rate. Several Indian states now report under 900 girls per thousand boys.

Twenty-five years later that arrives as a **marriage squeeze**. Men who never marry are projected to rise from about 4.5 per cent in 2010 to about 12.6 per cent by 2040 in India, against a normal baseline near 5 per cent.

The men left out are **not chosen at random**. When women are scarce, families choose upwards, so the unmarried are the poorest and least educated. In China's 2010 census, around 38 per cent of illiterate men in the relevant band had never married, against under 3 per cent of those with middle schooling.

In a society of near-universal marriage, such a man does not merely lack a wife — he never acquires adult standing. Punjabi calls him **chhada**, Haryanvi **malang**, Chinese **a bare branch**.

And almost every word written about him asks what he might do to the rest of us. The rules about women made these men, and even the campaign to save the girls had to be argued in the currency of the danger their absence would create.

CHAPTER SIX

The Vector

> *Part Ten found one claim in the warning that was straightforwardly true: infection. This chapter follows that claim to its source, and the source is not her.*

6.1 — The asymmetry that runs the other way

Part Ten established the one physical fact everybody accepts. Exposure to sexually transmitted infection rises with the number of partners, dose for dose, in every society. Persistent infection with certain types of human papillomavirus causes virtually all cervical cancer, which kills something in the order of seventy-five thousand Indian women a year.

It also noted, at the end of that chapter, the fact that undoes the rule built on it: **a woman's exposure depends on her partner's history as much as her own.** Married Indian women with one lifetime partner develop and die from this disease.

That sentence deserves a chapter rather than a line, because it is the clearest case in the entire series of a harm whose control point is male and whose rule is female.

WORD BOX

Transmission network: the map of who could have passed an infection to whom. Infections do not spread through a population evenly; they spread along the connections that exist.

Core group: the small number of people in a network with many connections. Because infections travel along links, a person with many partners is both far more likely to acquire something and far more likely to pass it on — so a small group can account for a very large share of all transmission.

Why it matters: this is one of the oldest and best-established findings in epidemiology, and it has a blunt implication. If you want to reduce infection in a population, the efficient place to act is the core group. In heterosexual transmission, that group is disproportionately male, because male partner counts are higher and more unequally distributed.

6.2 — What it does to men

Before the argument about her, the plain facts about him, which most people do not know.

The same virus that causes cervical cancer in women causes cancers in men — of the throat and tonsils, of the anus, of the penis. These are less discussed and not rare. In the United States, HPV-associated cancer of the throat in men has risen to become the most common HPV-associated cancer of all, overtaking cervical cancer, largely because cervical screening has been catching the female cases early for decades and no equivalent screening exists for the male ones.

Read that twice. The reason the male cancer overtook the female one is not that men are more exposed. It is that **somebody built a screening programme for women and nobody built one for men.**

There is no reliable screening test for throat cancer. There is no equivalent of a cervical smear. Which means that for men, the only available protection is the one that comes before exposure.

6.3 — Vaccinating boys

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Vaccination programmes generate unusually good evidence, because they are rolled out on dates, to defined age groups, and the outcomes are recorded by cancer registries that exist for other reasons.

What the record shows: countries that began vaccinating girls saw infection rates fall in **boys too**, without vaccinating them — because a virus that cannot find a host in half the population circulates less in the other half. That is herd protection, and it is measured rather than theorised.

What it also shows: the protection is partial and uneven. It depends on high coverage among girls, and it does nothing for men whose partners were not vaccinated — including men whose partners are men, who get no herd benefit from a girls-only programme at all.

Which is why a number of countries — Australia, the United Kingdom and others — moved from vaccinating girls only to vaccinating both sexes. India's programme has so far focused on girls.

Which is a defensible decision, and a contested one. It is worth setting out properly, because it is the rare case where the abstract question of this part comes with a budget attached.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD INDIA VACCINATE BOYS TOO?

This is a real policy dispute among people who agree on all the biology, and it is a useful corrective to anyone who thinks “target the men” is obviously free.

GIRLS FIRST, AND POSSIBLY GIRLS ONLY

India has a limited health budget and enormous unmet need. Every rupee spent vaccinating a boy is a rupee not spent reaching a girl who has not been vaccinated at all — and the disease that kills tens of thousands a year is cervical cancer. Standard health economics is unambiguous here: while coverage among girls is still far from complete, extending to boys is a poor use of scarce money, because the girls-only programme already delivers most of the male benefit through reduced circulation. Do the thing that saves the most lives per rupee, and come back to boys when coverage is high.

BOTH, AND THE GIRLS-ONLY FRAMING IS PART OF THE PROBLEM

The cost calculation assumes the male cancers are a rounding error, and the American data shows they are not — they are now the largest HPV cancer category there, and India has no screening for them either. Herd protection also collapses exactly where coverage is weakest, which is the poorest districts where the girls are least likely to be reached. And there is a structural point beyond the arithmetic: a girls-only programme teaches, in the most concrete way a state can, that this is a female disease and a female responsibility — which is the same lesson every other institution in this series is already teaching.

Where things stand: the health-economics case for girls-first is genuinely strong at India's current coverage, and most public health bodies would say so. The case for adding boys strengthens as coverage rises and as the male cancer burden becomes visible, and several rich countries crossed that threshold and switched. This is a sequencing disagreement, not a disagreement about facts.

What would settle it: Indian data on male HPV-related cancers, which is thin, and on actual coverage achieved among girls, which is measurable and improving.

Why people care so much: because this is one of the few live decisions where the abstract question this part is asking — whose conduct and whose body does an institution act on — has an immediate answer with a budget line attached.

6.4 — Why no rule was ever built here

Now the question this chapter exists for.

If a woman's risk of the most lethal sexually transmitted harm depends substantially on her husband's history, and if the efficient point of intervention in any transmission network is the person with the most connections, then a society genuinely organised around protecting women's health would have built its rules around male conduct. None has.

It is worth being precise about what "none" means, because it is not quite true that nothing has ever been aimed at men. Public health has done it repeatedly and successfully — condom promotion, partner notification and treatment, and, in the largest example, the trials that established that male circumcision substantially reduces female-to-male transmission of HIV, which led to programmes across southern and eastern Africa reaching millions of men.

So male-directed intervention is not impossible and not ineffective. It has simply always been **medical rather than moral**. Societies have been perfectly willing to ask men to take a pill, use a barrier, attend a clinic or undergo a procedure. What no society has done is build a norm around male sexual conduct with anything like the weight, the surveillance and the punishment attached to the female version.

IN REAL TERMS

Set the two interventions side by side in a single household, and ask which one anybody has ever heard proposed.

Intervention A: the daughter's movements are monitored, her phone is checked, her marriage is arranged early, and her conduct is discussed by the extended family. Cost to the family: nothing. Cost to her: much of her twenties.

Intervention B: the son is vaccinated at eleven, taught to use protection, and told that his conduct will determine the health of a woman he has not met yet. Cost to the family: one clinic visit and a conversation. Cost to him: essentially nothing.

Intervention B is cheaper, easier, less intrusive and better targeted at the actual transmission point. **It is also the one that has never been a rule anywhere.**

Almost never, at least. India did have one law that named male sexual conduct, and what happened to it is the next chapter.

REMEMBER THIS

The one physically true claim in the warning has a control point that is **not the woman it is issued to**. Her risk of cervical cancer depends on her partner's history as much as her own.

Infections spread along **networks**, and the efficient place to act is the small group with many connections — which in heterosexual transmission is disproportionately male.

The same virus causes cancers in men. In the United States, HPV-related throat cancer in men has overtaken cervical cancer as the most common HPV cancer — **because somebody built a screening programme for women and nobody built one for men**.

Vaccinating girls protects boys too, through reduced circulation, but unevenly. Several countries have moved to vaccinating both; India's programme so far focuses on girls, and there is a serious health-economics case for that sequencing.

Male-directed intervention is not impossible — public health has done it repeatedly. It has just always been medical rather than moral. No society has ever built a norm around his conduct with the weight it puts on hers.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The One Law That Named Him

> *India did have a criminal law about male sexual conduct. When the Supreme Court struck it down in 2018, it explained what the law had actually been protecting — and the answer was not the wife.*

7.1 — What Section 497 said

From 1860 until 2018, India's penal code contained an offence called adultery. On its face it was a law aimed squarely at men. Read it carefully and it is one of the most revealing documents in this entire series.

The offence was committed by a man who had sex with another man's wife, knowing she was married, **without the consent or connivance of her husband**. He could be imprisoned for up to five years.

Four features of that sentence are worth separating.

The wife could not be punished. Not as an offender, not even as an abettor. The law said so explicitly.

The husband's consent was a complete defence. If he permitted it, no crime had occurred. The same act, with the same people, was either a five-year offence or entirely lawful depending on what one man had agreed to.

A wife could not prosecute her husband. If he had an affair, she had no remedy under this section at all — nor could she prosecute the woman he had the affair with.

Only the aggrieved husband could bring the case.

WORD BOX

Chattel: an item of movable property. A thing that can be owned, damaged and compensated for.

Why the word appears here: it is not my characterisation. When India's Supreme Court struck this law down, it said in its own reasoning that the provision treated a wife as the property of her husband — that the offence was framed as an injury done *to him* by another man, using her.

What that means concretely: the law was not indifferent to the wife's consent because it did not care about consent. It was indifferent because her consent was not the consent that mattered. The consent that mattered belonged to her husband, and the law said so in plain words.

7.2 — What the court said

In *Joseph Shine v. Union of India*, decided in 2018, a five-judge bench of the Supreme Court struck the section down as unconstitutional.

The reasoning is the useful part. The court held that the provision violated equality, that it rested on the idea of the wife as her husband's possession, and that a law which made a woman's sexual autonomy contingent on her husband's permission could not survive the constitutional guarantee of dignity. It noted the absurdity that the husband's consent converted a crime into a non-crime.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

A constitutional judgment is an unusual and valuable kind of evidence for a series like this one.

Almost everything else here is inference — reading a purpose off a pattern of behaviour, which is exactly what the Hidden Assumption boxes keep warning about. A judgment is different: it is **the state, in writing, explaining what one of its own laws was doing**, in a document with legal consequences, after adversarial argument in which the government defended the law and lost.

What it establishes: that the reading offered in this chapter is not a critic's interpretation. It is the finding of the highest court in the country that wrote the law.

What it cannot establish: what the law meant to people who lived under it for a hundred and fifty-eight years, or how often it was used, which is a separate and much thinner record.

Here is the point for this part. India had exactly one criminal law that named male sexual conduct as an offence. It turned out, on inspection, to be a law about property, in which the harm was done by one man to another man, and the woman was the site of the transaction rather than a party to it.

That is the pattern this chapter is about, and it recurs. When you find a rule that appears to govern men's sexual behaviour, look at who is entitled to complain. Almost always it is another man.

7.3 — The exception that is still standing

Now the law that has not been struck down.

India's rape provision contains an exception: sexual intercourse by a man with his own wife, where she is not below the specified age, is not rape. The exception was carried over into the new criminal code that replaced the colonial one.

The litigation history is worth setting out plainly, because it is still running. In 2017 the Supreme Court removed the exception where the wife is between fifteen and eighteen. In May 2022 the Delhi High Court delivered a split verdict on the exception as a whole — one judge holding it unconstitutional as a violation of bodily autonomy, the other holding that within marriage sexual relations are a legitimate expectation. The matter went to the Supreme Court, petitions were clubbed, and hearings began in January 2024.

In October 2024 the Union government filed its affidavit opposing removal, arguing that criminalising marital rape would be excessively harsh, that it could destabilise the institution of marriage, and that the court should defer to Parliament — noting that Parliament had chosen to retain the exception both in 2013 and when drafting the new code. After the retirement of the Chief Justice who had been hearing it, the case was postponed. As of early 2026 it sits before a reconstituted bench with no verdict date. India remains one of a few dozen countries that have not criminalised marital rape.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Put the two laws in this chapter next to each other.
>
> **Section 497**, now gone: a man who slept with another man's wife could go to prison for five years — unless that man agreed, in which case nothing had happened.
>
> **The exception that remains:** a man who has sex with his own wife without her consent has committed no rape.
>
> Line those up and one principle explains both. In each case the question the law asks is not *did she agree*. It is *which man was entitled to decide*. The first law protected the husband's entitlement against outsiders. The second protects it against her.
>
> They look like opposite laws — one punishing sex, one permitting it. They are the same law, seen from inside the marriage and from outside it.

7.4 — The order to return

One more provision belongs here, because it is still in force and most people do not know it exists.

Indian matrimonial law allows a court to order the restitution of conjugal rights: if one spouse has withdrawn from the society of the other without reasonable excuse, the other may petition, and a court may order them to return.

On its face this is perfectly gender-neutral — either spouse may petition. Its history is not. In 1983 the Andhra Pradesh High Court struck it down as a violation of privacy and dignity, holding that a decree transferring the choice of whether and when to have sex from the person to the state was intolerable. Within a year another High Court disagreed and the Supreme Court upheld the provision. It has been challenged again and the challenge is pending.

WORD BOX

Gender-neutral on its face: a law written without naming a sex, which therefore appears to treat both equally.

Why the phrase needs a box: a law can be perfectly neutral in its words and fall almost entirely on one sex in its operation, because the world it operates in is not neutral. A rule that either spouse may be ordered to return to the other lands very differently on the spouse who has somewhere else to go and the spouse who does not.

The general lesson, which applies well beyond this: **the text of a rule and the incidence of a rule are different objects**, and only one of them can be read off the page.

All three of these provisions are now history, or contested, or quietly in force. Which leaves an obvious question that Indian legislators have in fact been asked directly.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD ADULTERY BE A CRIME AGAIN, THIS TIME FOR EVERYBODY?

This is a live Indian question, not a hypothetical. A parliamentary committee reviewing the new criminal codes recommended re-introducing adultery as a gender-neutral offence. The government did not include it.

YES — MAKE IT NEUTRAL AND KEEP IT

The Supreme Court's objection was to the property structure, not to the idea that breaking a marital promise is a serious wrong. Rewrite it so that either spouse can commit the offence and either can complain, and every defect the court identified is gone. Marriage is a contract the state already regulates in a dozen ways; treating its most fundamental breach as legally weightless sends a message about how much the institution is worth. And a neutral law is precisely the thing this chapter says has never existed — a rule that names male sexual conduct without routing it through another man's entitlement.

NO — THE CRIMINAL LAW IS THE WRONG INSTRUMENT

Prison is for harms the state must prevent, not for private betrayals with a civil remedy already available: adultery remains a ground for divorce and is weighed in maintenance and custody. Criminalising it invites the state into bedrooms and hands an enormous coercive threat to the more powerful spouse in any marriage — which in India, overwhelmingly, is the husband. A gender-neutral text does not produce gender-neutral prosecutions when one party controls the money, the house and the family's willingness to take a complaint seriously. Neutrality on paper, as the previous box says, is not neutrality in incidence.

Where things stand: the government declined to re-introduce it, so the current position is that adultery is not a crime in India for anybody. Both sides above accept the court's reasoning about the old law; they differ on whether a repaired version would operate fairly, and that is a prediction about institutions rather than a dispute about principle.

What would settle it: the record of countries that do have gender-neutral adultery offences — who actually gets prosecuted under them. That evidence exists and is not much cited by either side.

Why people care so much: because this is the test case for the whole chapter. It asks, directly, whether a society is willing to write a rule about male sexual conduct that is not really a rule about another man's property. India got as far as a committee recommendation and stopped.

So the law has never managed to name him except through another man. The next chapter asks whether that is because his conduct cannot be changed, which is the reason usually given.

REMEMBER THIS

India had one criminal law naming male sexual conduct: **Section 497**. Under it, the wife could not be punished, could not prosecute her husband, and **the husband's consent was a complete defence** — the same act was a five-year offence or entirely lawful depending on what one man had agreed to.

When the Supreme Court struck it down in 2018, it said in its own reasoning that the law had treated the wife as her husband's property. That is not a critic's reading. It is **the state testifying about its own statute**.

The exception that remains says a man's sexual intercourse with his own wife is not rape. It was retained in the new criminal code; the government's 2024 affidavit opposed removing it; as of early 2026 the case sits with no verdict date.

Line the two up and one principle explains both. Neither law asks *did she agree*. Both ask **which man was entitled to decide** — the first protecting that entitlement against outsiders, the second against her.

Whenever you find a rule that appears to govern men's sexual conduct, look at who is entitled to complain. It is almost always another man.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Fixed or Adjustable

> *Every version of these rules is designed around one assumption: that male behaviour is weather and female behaviour is a choice. It is worth checking, because the historical record on male behaviour is not what the assumption predicts.*

8.1 — The premise underneath everything

You have heard it in the form of advice. *Men are like that. That is how they are. You cannot change them, so you must be careful.*

It is offered as realism, and it is doing an enormous amount of work. Every rule in this series follows from it. If male sexual behaviour is a fixed feature of the world, then the only adjustable part of the system is what women do — where they go, what they wear, when they are home, whom they may meet. The whole architecture of restriction is a rational response to a constant.

So the question is straightforward and answerable. **Is male sexual behaviour a constant?**

8.2 — What the record actually shows

Start with the strongest version of the claim, because there is real evidence for part of it.

On measured sexual *desire*, the sexes do differ. A large review of this literature concluded that men, on average, report wanting sex more frequently, think about it more often, masturbate more, and score higher on measures of willingness to have sex outside a relationship. This is one of the better-replicated findings in the field and I am not going to pretend it away.

But notice the gap between that finding and the conclusion drawn from it. The finding is about average reported desire. The conclusion is about whether **behaviour** can change. Those are different claims, and the second does not follow from the first.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The best evidence on whether male behaviour is fixed does not come from psychology. It comes from **history**, where the same population can be observed across centuries and the behaviour is recorded for other reasons.

Take homicide, which is overwhelmingly a male behaviour everywhere and always. Historical criminologists have assembled European homicide rates from court and coroner records running back to the medieval period. The rate fell from something in the order of thirty to fifty deaths per hundred thousand people a year to roughly one.

That is a fall of something like ninety-five to ninety-eight per cent, in the most violent behaviour there is, in the sex supposedly incapable of change, without any alteration in human biology. It happened through law, policing, the state's monopoly on force, and — this is the part that matters here — a change in what other men considered acceptable.

Why this evidence is strong: nobody was reporting anything, the records were kept for administrative reasons, and the trend is visible independently in several countries with different legal systems.

Once you look, the examples are everywhere, and several are within living memory.

WORD BOX

Secular trend: in statistics, a long-run movement in a population measure across decades or centuries — as opposed to a short-run fluctuation. Nothing to do with religion; the word here just means "over the long term".

Why it matters for this chapter: almost every claim that some human behaviour is fixed is made by someone looking at a short window. Widen the window and behaviours that felt permanent turn out to have moved a great deal. **The argument about whether men can change is really an argument about how far back you look.**

Duelling. An entrenched practice of male honour, backed by the certainty that a man who declined was finished socially. It was regarded as impossible to abolish. It is gone, and it went within a couple of generations.

Buying sex. In much of Europe and America a century ago, visiting a brothel was an ordinary and widely tolerated part of many men's lives. Today, in the same countries, it is a minority behaviour, and in several it is a criminal offence to purchase.

Drink-driving, seatbelts, smoking, workplace violence. All male-skewed, all deeply entrenched, all changed dramatically within a few decades by a combination of law, enforcement and social disapproval.

Condom use. When HIV made it urgent, campaigns aimed squarely at male behaviour produced large, fast, measurable change across very different societies.

IN REAL TERMS

A man in London in 1350 lived in a society where his chance of being murdered was something like thirty or forty times what it is for a man in London today, and nearly all of that risk came from other men.

Nothing about male bodies changed in the seven centuries between. What changed was law, policing, and what men expected of each other.

Now hold that beside the sentence *you cannot change men.* The behaviour in question — killing people — is more strongly male, more intensely felt, and far more consequential than anything discussed in this series. **It went down by roughly ninety-five per cent.**

None of which settles the question, because there is a serious version of the other position and it deserves stating properly.

THE ARGUMENT — IS MALE DESIRE DIFFERENT ENOUGH TO JUSTIFY DESIGNING AROUND IT?

Both sides accept the psychological finding. They disagree about what it licenses.

THE DIFFERENCE IS REAL AND DESIGNING AROUND IT IS REALISM

The sex-drive finding is robust and it is not small. Men also commit almost all sexual violence, in every society measured, which is not a socialisation artefact that varies away. A rule-maker facing a genuine average difference in urgency and a genuine asymmetry in physical risk is not being sexist by taking it into account; they are being accurate. Designing a system around the way people actually are, rather than the way one would prefer them to be, is the definition of practical wisdom — and a society that pretends the difference does not exist will get women hurt while it waits for men to be re-educated.

A DIFFERENCE IN DESIRE SAYS NOTHING ABOUT THE MALLEABILITY OF BEHAVIOUR

The whole argument slides from "men want it more" to "men will act on it regardless", and that step has no support. Every behaviour listed above was more male, strongly felt, and changed enormously. Homicide is the extreme case: the most male behaviour there is, and it fell by about ninety-five per cent. Desire is not the variable in question — conduct is, and conduct has always responded to law, enforcement and the opinion of other men. What the "realism" position actually assumes is not that male behaviour cannot change but that **nobody will make it**, which is a prediction about political will dressed up as a fact about human nature.

Where things stand: the average difference in desire is established; the inference from it to fixed behaviour is not, and the historical record runs strongly against it. What the traditionalist position has is a genuine claim about difficulty and cost — changing male conduct at scale takes law, enforcement, decades and money, whereas restricting a daughter takes an evening. That is a real argument. It is an argument about expense, not about possibility.

What would settle it: it is largely settled. The open question is not whether male sexual conduct can shift — the twentieth century answered that repeatedly — but how much, how fast, and at what cost, and those are ordinary policy questions rather than facts about nature.

Why people care so much: because "you cannot change men" is the load-bearing beam. Remove it and every restriction in this series stops being an unavoidable adaptation and becomes a choice about who should be inconvenienced.

And underneath that argument, both sides are doing something they have not noticed.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT MALE BEHAVIOUR IS THE FIXED POINT

Look at the structure of the argument above rather than its content. One side says male conduct is a constant and female conduct must adapt. The other says male conduct is malleable and should be changed. They are arguing about a fact.

They are not. They are arguing about **which variable to hold still**, and that is a decision, not a discovery.

Every system with two variables in it requires somebody to pick which one is the constraint. In every other domain where male behaviour proved costly, the choice went the other way without anybody agonising over it. Nobody responded to duelling by advising young men to avoid giving offence. Nobody responded to drink-driving by telling pedestrians to stay off the roads at night. Nobody responded to workplace deaths by advising workers to be more careful around unguarded machinery — that was in fact tried, for about a century, and was eventually recognised as a way of avoiding the cost of guarding the machinery.

In each of those cases, the party whose behaviour was costly was the party asked to change. In this one, uniquely and consistently across almost every society on Earth, the party asked to change is the other one.

The general form: the variable nobody proposes to move becomes the constraint, and the constraint is then mistaken for a law of nature. It is one of the most powerful moves in politics precisely because it never has to be argued for. Once something is treated as fixed, every subsequent discussion is about how to accommodate it, and the accommodation looks like realism rather than like a choice that was made.

What I am not saying, and want to be exact about: that changing male conduct would be easy, or that it would work quickly, or that anyone living inside the current arrangement can act as though it had already happened. Chapter Nine of Part Ten established why that last one matters. What I am saying is narrower and harder to escape. **The fixity of male behaviour is not an observation. It is the one thing in this entire system that has never been put on the table.**

Which sets up the last question of this part: if it were on the table, where would the evidence point?

REMEMBER THIS

Every rule in this series rests on one premise: that **male behaviour is weather and female behaviour is a choice**.

The psychological part of the claim is real. Men do report higher average sexual desire on essentially every measure, and that finding is well replicated.

But the inference from that to **fixed conduct** is unsupported, and history contradicts it flatly. European homicide — the most male behaviour there is — fell by something like ninety-five per cent. Duelling vanished. Buying sex went from ordinary to marginal. Drink-driving, smoking and condom use all shifted enormously within decades.

None of that required male biology to change. It required **law, enforcement, and a change in what men expected of each other**.

So the two sides are not arguing about a fact. They are arguing about which variable to hold still — and in every other domain where male conduct was costly, the answer was to move it.

CHAPTER NINE

If the Evidence Chose

> *Take the goals the traditional rules say they are for. Then ask, goal by goal, whose conduct the evidence would actually target. The answer is consistent enough to be uncomfortable — and what it reveals is not what I expected when I set the test up.*

9.1 — Setting the test up honestly

This is a diagnostic, not a proposal. The question is: *if you accepted the traditionalist's own stated objectives, and you were allowed to point a rule at either sex, which way would the evidence point you?*

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Counterfactual:** a claim about what would happen under conditions that do not hold. "If she had taken the earlier train, she would have arrived on time."
>
> Why it is a legitimate tool and not a rhetorical trick: every causal claim is secretly a counterfactual. Saying a drug works means that without it the patient would have done worse. You cannot say anything about causes without describing a world that did not happen.
>
> What it cannot do: a counterfactual tells you what would follow from a change. **It does not tell you the change should be made**, and this chapter keeps those two apart deliberately.

Two things make this a fair test rather than a trick. First, I am using their goals, not mine — stability, children, health, order, and her own long-term wellbeing. Second, the answer is allowed to come back "her". On one goal it does.

Section 9.5 explains why answering this is not the same as recommending anything, and the last box in the chapter explains why the exercise may be less devastating than it looks — and more.

9.2 — Goal by goal

Goal one: marriages that last. The evidence linking a woman's premarital partner count to divorce is real, unexplained by any mechanism anybody has tested, non-linear, and established almost entirely in one country. Set against that, the best-established predictors of a marriage ending are infidelity, violence, problem drinking and financial irresponsibility — and in the reasons women give for leaving, across many countries, those dominate. Every one of them is overwhelmingly male conduct, and each has a clearer causal story than anything in Part Ten's Chapter Two. The evidence points at him.

Goal two: knowing whose child it is. Here it points at her, and I am not going to soften that. Paternity certainty is affected directly and only by female sexual conduct. This is the one goal on the list where the traditional target is the arithmetically correct one.

But follow it one step further, because the step is remarkable. Reliable paternity testing has existed since the 1990s and now costs less than a week's groceries. The entire apparatus described across eleven parts of this series — the surveillance, the early marriage, the confinement, the examinations, the violence — exists to solve a problem that has had a cheap, precise technical solution for thirty years. No society has retired the apparatus. That is not a failure to notice. A rule that survives the disappearance of its stated purpose was doing something else as well.

Goal three: healthy women. Chapter Six settled this. Her infection risk depends on his history as much as her own, transmission concentrates in the people with the most connections, and the cheap interventions — vaccination, screening, barrier protection, treating the partner — are medical rather than moral. The evidence points at him, and at a clinic.

Goal four: less sexual violence. Not close. Sexual violence is committed overwhelmingly by men, in every society ever measured. A rule aimed at reducing it that governs women's clothing and movement is aimed at the party who is not doing it.

Goal five: social order. Chapter Five is the answer. The largest current threat to social order attributed to this domain is a surplus of unmarried men — and that surplus was manufactured by a preference for sons, enforced through the elimination of daughters. The disorder was produced by the rule.

Goal six: her own long-term happiness. Part Ten's Chapter Five found that the wellbeing damage tracks the collision between a woman's behaviour and the beliefs she was taught. The intervention that would reduce it most is not a change in her conduct. It is a change in what she was taught — which means the rule is generating a substantial share of the harm it cites as its justification.

9.3 — The scoreboard

STATED GOAL	WHERE THE EVIDENCE POINTS
Marriages that last	Him. Infidelity, violence, drinking and money have clearer causal stories than her partner count, which nobody has explained.
Paternity certainty	Her — the one case where the traditional target is correct. But a cheap test has existed for thirty years and no society retired the apparatus.
Healthy women	Him, and a clinic. Her risk runs through his history; vaccination and screening beat conduct by a wide margin.
Less sexual violence	Him. Not close.
Social order	The rule itself. Son preference produced the missing women, and the missing women produced the surplus men.
Her own happiness	What she was taught. The damage tracks the collision with installed belief, not the behaviour.

Six goals. On four the evidence points at male conduct. On one it points at the rule as the cause of the problem. On one it points at her, and that one has been technically solved since before I was born.

> **THE ARGUMENT — WOULD RULES AIMED AT MEN ACTUALLY WORK?**
>
> Suppose you accepted all of that. The next question is whether the alternative is achievable, and this is where the traditionalist case is stronger than the scoreboard suggests.

YES, AND CHAPTER EIGHT IS THE PROOF

Male conduct has been changed repeatedly, at scale, in living memory: drink-driving, smoking, workplace safety, condom use, buying sex, and — over centuries — homicide by something like ninety-five per cent. None of it required biology to change. It required law, enforcement and a shift in what men expected of one another. There is no reason in principle why sexual conduct should be the one male behaviour immune to the mechanism that moved all the others, and the assumption that it is has never been tested because it has never been tried.

NO, AND THE REASON IS ENFORCEMENT, NOT NATURE

Chapter One already gave the answer: rules fall where they can be enforced. Every male behaviour on that list was changed by a **state** — with police, courts, breath tests, inspectors, taxes and licensing. A household cannot do any of that. The rules in this series are administered by families, and a family can supervise a daughter in its own house and cannot supervise a son in a city two hundred kilometres away. So "aim it at men" is not a redesign a family can adopt; it is a demand for state capacity that mostly does not exist, and in its absence the actually available choice is between restricting the daughter and doing nothing.

Where things stand: the second position is correct about mechanism and the first is correct about possibility, and together they produce the real finding — that the rules land on women not because women are the problem but because families are the enforcers and daughters are what families can reach. Every male behaviour that changed was changed by an institution with coercive power over strangers.

What would settle it: cases where the state has aimed at male sexual conduct at scale. A few exist — the Nordic laws criminalising the purchase of sex, HIV-era campaigns, workplace harassment law — and their results are mixed but not nothing. The evidence base is thin because the attempts are few.

Why people care so much: because if the constraint is enforcement rather than nature, then the rules about women are not a considered response to how the world is. They are what a household does when it cannot reach the person actually causing the problem.

9.4 — Why none of this is a recommendation

I said in the front matter that nothing here argues the rules should be pointed at men. Here is why, and it is not modesty.

A rule aimed at men would still be a rule that controls people's sexual lives through surveillance, shame and punishment. This series has spent eleven parts documenting what that costs the people inside it. Concluding "so do it to the other half" would mean I had described a machine in detail and then asked to run it, which is not an argument, it is a change of seat.

The test in this chapter is diagnostic. It asks whether the rules track their stated goals. They do not — not on four of six, and on a fifth the rule causes the harm. What that establishes is not a better target. It establishes that **the stated goals are not what is selecting the target**, and that is a finding about the rules rather than a plan for new ones.

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — MINE, AND THE WHOLE SERIES'**
>
> I built this chapter as an audit. I took the stated goals, checked whether the rules hit them, found they mostly do not, and treated that as a serious criticism.
>
> That framing assumes the rules are **attempts** — that somebody aimed at those goals and missed. It is the assumption inside every sentence of this part, including the ones I was pleased with.
>
> Now apply the ordinary test. If a system misses its stated target consistently, across thousands of years, on four continents, under every religion, in every economic arrangement, and misses in the **same direction every single time** — always allocating control to the same party — at what point do you stop calling it a miss?
>
> A mechanism that fails randomly is broken. A mechanism that fails in one direction, reliably, for millennia, is **working**. And if it is working, then "badly aimed" is not a bug report. It is a description of the specification, and I have spent nine chapters writing a very careful complaint to a manufacturer who built exactly what was ordered.
>
> There is a second half to this, and it is about me rather than the argument. This whole part asks: *whose conduct should the rules target?* Notice what that question concedes before it opens its mouth. It accepts that somebody's conduct is the thing to be targeted, and that the interesting problem is aim. A man writing eighty pages arguing that the rules should really be about men is still a man writing about who

> the rules should be about — and Chapter Four established that being the enforcer, the beneficiary and the designer are three different jobs. I have quietly taken the third.
>
> **The general form:** treating a persistent, patterned failure as error rather than as function. It is the most common mistake in institutional analysis and the hardest to see from inside, because the correction always looks constructive. A prison that does not rehabilitate. A test that does not measure aptitude. A market that does not clear. In each case decades are spent proposing improvements before somebody asks what the thing is actually for.
>
> Where that leaves this part: everything in it stands as evidence. The scoreboard is real, the six goals are theirs, and the arrows point where I said. What does not stand is my framing of it as a system that could be corrected by better aim — and that framing was mine, not the evidence's.

So the part ends one step short of where I intended it to, which is the honest place for it to stop.

REMEMBER THIS

Take the traditionalist's **own six goals** and ask whose conduct the evidence would target. On **marriages lasting, health, sexual violence** — him, and not narrowly. On **social order**, the rule itself is the cause: son preference made the missing women who made the surplus men.

On **her own happiness**, the damage tracks what she was taught, so the rule generates a share of the harm it cites as justification.

On **paternity**, the traditional target is arithmetically right — and a cheap, precise test has existed for thirty years, and no society retired the apparatus. A rule that survives the disappearance of its purpose was doing something else too.

Why the rules land where they do is **enforcement, not nature**. Every male behaviour that ever changed at scale was changed by a state with power over strangers. A household can reach a daughter and cannot reach a son.

And the assumption underneath my own chapter: I treated the mis-aiming as a mistake. A system that misses in the same direction for thousands of years is not missing.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Two lists, as in every part. What is genuinely unknown, and why — which is usually the more interesting half. Then what is solid enough to build on.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

ALMOST EVERYTHING ABOUT MEN'S SEXUAL HISTORIES AND THEIR MARRIAGES

This is the largest gap in the part and the reason the part exists. Whether a man's premarital partner count predicts his divorce, his marital satisfaction or anything else is not known with any confidence, because the surveys that answered the question for women did not ask men in equivalent detail. The reason we do not know is not that researchers looked and found nothing. It is that the question felt natural in one direction and strange in the other, for decades, across many questionnaires.

HOW MUCH OF MEN'S MARRIAGE ADVANTAGE IS PROTECTION AND HOW MUCH IS SELECTION

Married men live longer and are healthier than unmarried men, by a wider margin than the equivalent gap among women. Whether marriage causes that or healthier men marry is disputed, with most researchers holding that both operate. The reason we do not know: the experiment cannot be run, and the men who never marry differ from the men who do in every measurable way before anybody marries anyone.

WHETHER THE DOUBLE STANDARD SURVIVES WHERE IT MATTERS

Vignette experiments find it weak or absent in Western student samples. Choice-based measures find it. Nobody has systematically measured *consequences* — what actually happens to matched men and women after the same information about them becomes public. The reason we do not know: that study is slow, expensive and unpleasant to run, and no funder has wanted it.

WHETHER THE WOMEN WHO ENFORCE THESE RULES ARE AGENTS OR INSTRUMENTS

Both readings fit every fact in Chapter Four. The reason we do not know is not missing data — it is that "agency" is not a quantity and cannot be measured. There is one partial empirical handle: watching what happens to enforcement when the underlying incentive disappears. That evidence is fragmentary.

WHAT LIFE IS ACTUALLY LIKE FOR INDIA'S SURPLUS MEN

We can count them precisely and we know very little else. The literature asks what they might do; a handful of ethnographies ask what is happening to them. The reason we do not know: research funding for this population has come almost entirely from security and demography, and both fields ask about risk rather than experience.

WHETHER SURPLUS MEN ACTUALLY DESTABILISE SOCIETIES

The crime finding from China is credible; how far it generalises is contested, and the catastrophic versions of the thesis are not supported. The reason we do not know: the natural experiment is running now, in India, and its peak arrives around 2040.

WHAT A SERIOUS ATTEMPT TO CHANGE MALE SEXUAL CONDUCT WOULD ACHIEVE

Chapter Eight established that male behaviour in general is highly changeable. It did not establish how far sexual conduct specifically would move, because almost nobody has tried at scale. The Nordic laws on purchasing sex are the closest thing to a test and their results are genuinely mixed. The reason we do not know: too few attempts, and most of them recent.

THE TRUE INCIDENCE OF MALE SEXUAL VIOLENCE

Reported figures in every country are a fraction of survey estimates, and survey estimates vary with how the question is asked. India's recorded numbers are widely regarded as a severe undercount. The reason we do not know: reporting depends on what happens to the person who reports, which is exactly what this series has been about.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One item on that list is a different kind of absence from the others, and it is the one this part was built around.

Most gaps in research exist because something is hard to measure — a feeling, a private act, a long-run outcome. The absence of male data on premarital sexual history is not like that. It is **no harder to ask a man than a woman**. Britain's national survey has asked both, in comparable detail, since 1990, at no special difficulty and no special cost.

So this gap is not a limitation of method. It is a record of what was considered worth knowing. And unlike most gaps, it can be closed at any time by anybody willing to add a page to a questionnaire.

Treat it, then, the way Part Nine treated a missing census and Part Ten treated a missing count of killings: **an absence that could be filled and has not been is itself a finding**, and what it is evidence of is the shape of the question rather than the difficulty of the answer.

10.2 — Solid

THE MALE COMPARISON DATA WAS NOT COLLECTED

The American survey behind the best-known findings on premarital partners and divorce does not carry equivalent information on men. This is stated by the researcher who used it. It is a fact about the dataset, not an inference.

MEN GAIN MORE FROM MARRIAGE ON HEALTH AND MORTALITY

Married people live longer than unmarried people, and the gap is consistently larger for men, across many countries, using administrative records rather than self-report. How much is protection and how much is selection is disputed; the pattern is not.

THE MALE MARRIAGE-MARKET PENALTY DOES NOT EXIST

In no society I can find is a man's number of previous partners priced as a defect in a marriage negotiation. Part Ten established that the female version of this penalty is real and does not travel across societies. The male version does not appear at all.

THE DOUBLE STANDARD IS WEAK IN WESTERN VIGNETTE EXPERIMENTS

Replicated many times by many groups. People rate high partner counts negatively for both sexes. This is a genuine finding and should not be denied by anyone who wants to be taken seriously on this subject.

IT PERSISTS IN CHOICE, LANGUAGE AND CONSEQUENCE

Studies of who people want as friends and partners find it, including among people who are themselves permissive. The insult vocabulary for sexually active women exists in every language checked and has no male equivalent of comparable force. And in societies where marriage is arranged between families, one side of the negotiation is priced and the other is not asked.

DAILY ENFORCEMENT IS ADMINISTERED LARGELY BY WOMEN

Clothing, movement, phones, curfews and contraception are supervised by senior women in the household. In north India, a mother-in-law's stated view predicts a young wife's contraceptive behaviour better than the wife's own stated preference. Lethal enforcement is male, organisational, and frequently delegated to the most legally expendable member of the household.

THE SEX RATIO PRODUCED A MARRIAGE SQUEEZE, AND IT LANDS ON THE POOREST MEN

Census counts, not estimates. Men who never marry in India are projected to rise from about 4.5 per cent in 2010 to about 12.6 per cent by 2040 against a normal baseline near 5 per cent. In China's 2010 census, around 38 per cent of illiterate men in the relevant band had never married against under 3 per cent of those with middle schooling.

A WOMAN'S INFECTION RISK RUNS THROUGH HER PARTNER'S HISTORY

Biology, not statistics. Transmission concentrates in people with many connections. The same virus causes cancers in men, and in the United States HPV-related throat cancer in men has overtaken cervical cancer as the most common HPV cancer — because screening exists for one and not the other.

INDIA'S ONE CRIMINAL LAW ON MALE SEXUAL CONDUCT WAS A PROPERTY RULE

Under Section 497 the wife could not be punished or prosecute, and the husband's consent was a complete defence. The Supreme Court struck it down in 2018 and stated in its own reasoning that the provision had treated a wife as her husband's property. The marital rape exception was retained in the new criminal code; the government opposed its removal in 2024; the case remains undecided.

MALE BEHAVIOUR CHANGES

European homicide rates fell by something in the order of ninety-five per cent from the medieval period to the modern one. Duelling disappeared. Buying sex went from ordinary to marginal. Drink-driving, smoking and condom use shifted enormously within decades. None of it required biology to change.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: nearly everything about men's sexual histories and their marriages; how much of men's marriage advantage is protection; whether the double standard survives in consequences; whether the enforcing women are agents; what life is like for surplus men; whether they destabilise anything; and what a serious attempt to shift male sexual conduct would achieve.

Solid: the male comparison data was never collected; men gain more from marriage on health and mortality; the male marriage-market penalty does not exist; the double standard is weak in Western vignettes and persists in choice, language and consequence; daily enforcement is largely administered by women; the sex ratio produced a squeeze that lands on the poorest men; her infection risk runs through his history; India's one law naming male sexual conduct was a property rule, by the Supreme Court's own account; and male behaviour changes, enormously, when a state decides it should.

One absence is unlike the rest. The male data is **no harder to collect** than the female data — Britain has collected both since 1990. A gap that could be closed by adding a page to a questionnaire, and has not been, is a record of what was thought worth knowing.

The honest summary of this part: on almost every question the series has asked, the comparison group exists, is reachable, and was never assembled — and the one thing everybody treats as a fixed feature of the world is the one thing nobody has ever tried to move.

Timeline

A century and a half of law and research about men's sexual conduct, and what each was really protecting.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1860	The Indian Penal Code is enacted. Section 497 makes adultery an offence a man commits against another man's marriage. The wife cannot be punished, cannot prosecute, and the husband's consent is a complete defence.
1955	The Hindu Marriage Act includes restitution of conjugal rights: a court may order a spouse who has withdrawn from the other to return.
1983	In *T. Sareetha*, the Andhra Pradesh High Court strikes restitution down, holding that transferring the choice of when to have sex from the person to the state is intolerable.
1984	Another High Court disagrees and the Supreme Court upholds the provision. It is still in force.
1990	Amartya Sen publishes his estimate that more than a hundred million women are missing. In the same year Britain runs the first of its national sexual behaviour surveys, asking men and women in comparable detail — the comparison the American data still lacks.
1999	Sweden criminalises the purchase of sexual services while leaving the sale legal — the first state to aim this law at the buyer rather than the seller.
2001	A large review concludes that men report higher sexual desire than women on essentially every measure — the strongest evidence for the premise Chapter Eight examines.
2003	Long-run European homicide series are assembled from court and coroner records, showing a fall of roughly ninety-five per cent from the medieval period — the strongest evidence against the conclusion drawn from that premise.
2004	*Bare Branches* estimates India's surplus men at 16.5 million aged 15 to 35, projected to 28–32 million by 2020, and frames the question as one of security.
2005–07	Randomised trials in South Africa, Kenya and Uganda establish that male circumcision substantially reduces female-to-male HIV transmission, leading to programmes reaching millions of men. Male-directed intervention proves both possible and effective — and medical rather than moral.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2011	India's census records that across Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, about 76 per cent of men aged 20 to 24 are unmarried against about 34 per cent of women.
2013	Economists link China's rising sex ratios to a substantial share of its increase in crime. Australia extends HPV vaccination to boys.
2017	In *Independent Thought*, India's Supreme Court removes the marital rape exception where the wife is between fifteen and eighteen.
2018	*Joseph Shine v. Union of India* strikes down Section 497, the court stating in its own reasoning that the provision had treated a wife as her husband's property.
2019	The United Kingdom extends HPV vaccination to boys, following the evidence on male cancers and uneven herd protection.
2022	The Delhi High Court splits one to one on the marital rape exception. The Supreme Court stays a Karnataka ruling and the petitions are clubbed together.
2023	A parliamentary committee reviewing India's new criminal codes recommends re-introducing adultery as a gender-neutral offence. The government does not include it.
2024	Hearings on the marital rape exception begin. In October the Union government files its affidavit opposing removal, calling criminalisation excessively harsh and urging the court to defer to Parliament.
2026	After a change of Chief Justice the case is postponed. As of early in the year it sits before a reconstituted bench with no verdict date.
Next	**Part Twelve starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
All-cause mortality	The chance of dying from anything at all in a period. The bluntest health measure there is, and the hardest to fake — a death is recorded whatever anybody believes.
Bare branches	The Chinese term for men who will never marry or have children — a limb of the family tree that will not fork. Punjabi has *chhada*; Haryanvi has *malang*.
Chattel	An item of movable property. Used by India's Supreme Court, in effect, to describe how Section 497 treated a wife.
Comparison group	The people you measure your group against. Without one, a number is a description of one population rather than a finding.
Core group	In epidemiology, the small number of people in a network with many connections, who account for a disproportionate share of all transmission.
Ethnographic research	Studying a community by living in it and observing over long periods. Good at seeing enforcement that never becomes an event; bad at scale.
Gender-neutral on its face	A law written without naming a sex. It can still fall almost entirely on one sex in operation, because the world it operates in is not neutral.
Herd protection	The reduction in infection among unvaccinated people caused by vaccinating others, because the infection circulates less. Partial, and weakest where coverage is lowest.
Izzat	A household's collective public standing, damaged by a daughter's rumoured conduct and not in the same way by a son's.
Marriage squeeze	What happens when one sex outnumbers the other at marriageable age, so a share of the larger group cannot marry at all.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Missing women	Amartya Sen's term for the shortfall between the number of women alive in a population and the number that equal treatment would produce.
Reading down	When a court narrows a law's application rather than striking it out entirely — as with the marital rape exception for wives aged fifteen to eighteen.
Restitution of conjugal rights	A court order requiring a spouse who has left to return. Struck down by one Indian High Court in 1983, upheld by the Supreme Court in 1984, still in force.
Revealed preference	What a person's actual choices show they want, as opposed to what they say when asked.
Section 497	India's adultery offence from 1860 to 2018. A man committed it against another man's marriage; the husband's consent was a complete defence.
Sex ratio at birth	Girls born per thousand boys. Nature produces about 950. Several Indian states report under 900.
Selection effect	When people ended up in a group for reasons that also affect the outcome, so you are comparing different kinds of people rather than the same people in different conditions.
Sexual double standard	Judging the same sexual behaviour more harshly in a woman than a man. It can live in what people say, how they rate, whom they choose, and what a community does — and those can disagree.
Stated preference	What a person says they want or believe when asked. Often diverges from revealed preference, in a predictable direction.
Transmission network	The map of who could have passed an infection to whom. Infections spread along connections, not evenly.
Vignette study	An experiment in which people rate a described person, with one detail varied between conditions. A true experiment, and it measures what people will say when they know they are watched.

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This series started with something small and ugly. A woman was photographed at a protest and was attacked online with a claim about how she earns money. What interested me was the machinery underneath — the rules about what women may do, where they came from, what they are for, and what happens when they change. Eleven parts in, this one changed my mind more than any since the third, and not in the direction I expected when I started writing it.

I am not a criminologist, an epidemiologist or a lawyer. I read the primary sources carefully, follow the numbers wherever they go, and write down what I find in language that does not need a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — census data, peer-reviewed research in demography, criminology, psychology and epidemiology, Indian Supreme Court judgments, and analysis published for United Nations agencies — rather than new primary research.

What that archive is good at here, and it is unusually good: much of this part rests on **counts and judgments rather than surveys**. A census does not ask anyone to admit anything. A death register records a death. A constitutional judgment is the state explaining, in writing and under adversarial pressure, what one of its own laws was doing. These are the hardest kinds of evidence to bend, and where I had a choice I built on them.

What it is bad at, and this is the point of the whole part: **the male comparison data mostly does not exist.** Where I say the evidence about men is thin, I mean the questionnaires did not ask, not that researchers looked and found nothing. I have tried never to fill that hole with inference, and Chapter Ten lists everything it swallowed.

One further caution. Several claims here — about who enforces, about what surplus men's lives are like — rest on ethnographic work: small studies, deeply observed. I have relied on them only where several from different regions converge, and said so.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

This series began with a photograph and a caption. Eleven parts later it has described a machine that runs on reputation — and that machine has just been handed an instrument its designers never imagined. Part Twelve is about what happens to izzat when the community stops having edges.

The questions it takes on:

- What changes when reputation becomes permanent, searchable and detachable from the community that produced it — and when a rumour no longer decays with distance or time?
- Who holds the power in a system where a photograph, a screenshot or a fabricated image can be produced by anybody, at no cost, against anybody?
- Does the phone give a young woman an exit from the surveillance in Chapter Four of this part, or hand her family a better instrument for it — and what does the evidence say about which effect has been larger so far?
- What actually happens to Indian women after image-based abuse, and how much of the harm is the image and how much is the audience?
- If Chapter Four is right that enforcement is administered by people who are themselves inside the system, what happens when enforcement no longer requires knowing anybody?
- And the question the whole series has been circling since its first page: the woman in that photograph did nothing that anyone could name. Why did the accusation work anyway?

END OF PART ELEVEN OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Twelve — The Community With No Edges

Reputation used to be a local technology with a small audience and a short memory. Then the audience became everyone and the memory became permanent. This part is about what that did to an enforcement system that is thousands of years old.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Eleven went looking for the half of the population nobody had studied. The rules in this series are aimed at women, the research is done on women, and the surveys that would let anyone ask the same questions about men were, over and over, never designed to.

What came out of it was a spine that runs into this part. The rule is asymmetric, and I had assumed that meant the underlying fact was asymmetric. It does not follow. A rule can fall where it falls because that is **where it can be enforced**. A household can reach a daughter. It cannot reach a son who has moved to another city, and it has never seriously tried. Chapter Nine of that part scored the traditionalist's own stated goals and found that four of the six pointed at male conduct rather than female — including the one about disease, where a woman's risk is set as much by her husband's history as by her own.

The other finding was about who does the enforcing. The daily work of it is done by women, on women. The lethal end of it is delegated to whichever male relative is most legally expendable. Nobody designed that; it is what a system does when it has to produce compliance cheaply.

Enforcement was the answer to almost everything in Part Eleven. So this part asks the obvious next question: **what happens to an enforcement system when the thing it depends on stops existing?**

Because it did. Every mechanism in the last eleven parts assumed a community — a bounded group of people who knew each other, whose opinion mattered, who would find out and who would remember. That is what izzat was denominated in. And in one generation, roughly the length of time it took a smartphone to reach an Indian village, the community stopped having edges.

This is also where the series comes back to where it started. Part One opened with a woman photographed at a protest and attacked online with a claim about how she earns money. Eleven parts later, this is the part about the machinery that did that to her.

How this document is built

Six kinds of box, each doing one job, each looking different so you can see at a glance what you are about to read.

The first explains a hard word the moment it appears, so you never carry an unexplained term forward.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Intermediary:** in Indian law, any service that stores or transmits something on someone else's behalf. A social media platform, a messaging app, a web host, a search engine, an internet provider.
>
> Why it matters: almost everything a government can do about online harm, it does by putting obligations on intermediaries rather than on the people causing the harm. That single design choice shapes every remedy in this part, and Chapter Eight is about what it costs.

The second takes a number too big or too abstract to picture and turns it into something with a body.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> A village of two thousand people is an audience of two thousand. If every one of them heard something about you and told two others, you have been discussed by six thousand people, and it took weeks.
>
> A post that reaches six thousand people has done the same work in about ninety seconds, to an audience that never met you, and it is still there tomorrow. That is the entire subject of this part in one comparison.

The third shows the actual evidence behind a claim, and then says what that evidence cannot show.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Most Indian numbers in this part come from the **National Crime Records Bureau**, which compiles crime statistics from police records across the country and publishes them annually.

What it is good at: consistency and coverage. The same categories, every state, every year.

What it is bad at, and this matters more here than anywhere else in the series: it can only count what was reported, recorded, and fitted into an existing category. Chapter Seven shows what that leaves out, and the shape of the omission is not random.

The fourth is for places where informed people genuinely disagree. Each side gets its best case.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not claim more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes the honest answer is that nothing available would.

The fifth is the signature of this series. It digs out what both sides are assuming without noticing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Not caveats. Unexamined premises sitting underneath an argument everybody is having. There are five in this part, and the last one is turned on this series and on me.

The sixth closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

REMEMBER THIS

Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.

Simple words, serious content, nothing left out.

Two warnings specific to this part

The first is about content. This part deals with image-based sexual abuse, extortion and the suicides that follow them. I describe how these things work, because you cannot understand an enforcement system without understanding its instruments, and because the people running them already know. I do not describe any individual case in detail, I do not name private individuals, and where a well-known incident matters only for what it caused, I give the consequence and leave the person out of it. If you are reading this having been through any of it yourself, Chapter Eight has the practical parts — takedown routes and how the hash systems work — and you can go straight there.

The second is about speed. This is the most time-sensitive part of the series. The law changed while I was writing it: India's amended intermediary rules came into force in February 2026 and cut the removal deadline for non-consensual intimate images to two hours. Anything I write about the legal position is a snapshot. The mechanisms underneath it — what reputation is, who enforces it, what an audience does — change on a scale of centuries, and those are what this part is really about.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

What the Village Was For

> *Before you can see what changed, you have to see what reputation actually was — not a feeling about a person, but a working piece of social machinery with three specific properties. All three have gone.*

1.1 — Reputation is a technology

We talk about reputation as though it were a mood: what people think of you. That is not what it did. In a village, reputation was a system for storing information about a person so that strangers could decide whether to deal with them, and it worked because it had a particular shape.

Think about the problem it solved. You want to arrange your daughter's marriage into a family forty kilometres away. You cannot investigate them. There are no records. What you can do is ask around, and what you are asking for is the accumulated judgement of everyone who has dealt with them. Reputation is a credit rating built by gossip, and for most of human history it was the only one available.

WORD BOX

Izzat: introduced in Part Eight, and it belongs here again. Usually translated as honour, but closer to **standing** — a family's public credit, held collectively, which determines the marriages it can arrange and the deals it can make.

The property that matters in this part: izzat is not a fact about a person. It is a fact about **what a specific group of people believe**. Change the group and you change the thing itself.

1.2 — The three properties

That system depended on three features, and none of them was a design choice. They were consequences of how far a human voice carries and how long a human memory lasts.

The audience was bounded. The people whose opinion could hurt you were the people who might deal with you: your village, your caste network, the families your family might marry into. A few thousand people at most. Outside that circle, nobody knew and nobody cared.

The memory faded. Gossip decays. A story about a girl told in 1974 was thinner in 1979 and mostly gone by 1990, unless someone kept refreshing it. And it did not travel well: a family could move, and the story usually did not follow.

The enforcer was known. If a rumour ruined your prospects, you knew whose mouth it came out of. That person lived nearby, had their own standing to protect, and could be confronted, appeased, married into or bought off. Enforcement had a return address.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Consider what those three properties bought a family in 1970 whose daughter had been the subject of talk.
>
> They could wait — three or four years and the story was thin. They could move — a transfer to another town and the story mostly stayed behind. Or they could negotiate, because the two or three people spreading it were people they knew, whose own daughters were also on the market.
>
> **Waiting, moving, negotiating.** Every one of those three remedies has been removed by a device that costs eight thousand rupees, and no replacement has been supplied.

1.3 — What each one became

Now run the same three properties forward.

The bounded audience is gone. A photograph posted anywhere can be seen by anyone, and the people who see it are not the people who might deal with you — they are strangers with no stake, no obligation and nothing to lose by passing it on. The audience that could hurt you used to be the audience you needed. Those two groups have come apart completely.

The fading memory is gone. Text does not decay. A search engine will return a nine-year-old post as readily as a nine-hour-old one. There is no equivalent of the story getting thinner.

The known enforcer is gone. The account that posted the claim about you may be anonymous, may be automated, may be in another country, may be one of four hundred accounts posting the same thing. There is nobody to appease.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS DIFFERENT IN KIND, OR ONLY IN DEGREE?

This is the question underneath the whole part, and getting it wrong in either direction produces bad policy and bad advice.

ONLY IN DEGREE, AND THE PANIC IS THE FAMILIAR ONE

Every communication technology has produced a moral panic about young women. Printing, the novel, the telephone, the bicycle, the cinema — each was going to destroy female virtue and each did not. Gossip has always ruined lives; the village was not a gentle place, and a rumour in 1920 could and did end a woman's prospects permanently. What has changed is throughput, not nature. Treating a quantitative change as a new phenomenon is how societies talk themselves into restricting the people they were already restricting, and the restrictions arrive faster than the evidence for them.

IN KIND, AND THE ARGUMENT FROM PRECEDENT IS A TRAP

A quantitative change large enough stops being quantitative. All three properties broke at once, and each removed one of the three remedies a family had. Nothing about the printing press or the bicycle removed a person's ability to move away and start again; the searchable archive does exactly that. And the asymmetry is new in a way that has no precedent: one person with an evening free can now impose a cost on a stranger that would previously have required organising a village. When the cost of attacking falls to nearly zero and the cost of defending stays where it was, you have a different system, whatever the underlying motive.

Where things stand: the honest answer is that the motive is old and the machinery is new, and that this combination is unusual. Neither side is describing something false. The dispute is about which half matters more for what to do next — and Chapter Nine shows that the two sides actually recommend different things, so it is not merely semantic.

What would settle it: long-run data on outcomes rather than incidents — whether the number of women whose lives are materially damaged by reputational attack has risen, fallen or stayed flat since 2010. Nobody has this, and Chapter Seven explains why the statistics are built in a way that cannot produce it.

Why people care so much: because "different in kind" licenses emergency measures — new powers, new rules, new restrictions on daughters — and "only in degree" licenses doing nothing. Both of those are conclusions people arrive at first.

There is a premise sitting under both of those positions, and it is the one this whole part is built to expose.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE TECHNOLOGY IS THE ENFORCER

Listen to how this subject gets discussed from any direction. "The internet destroyed our children." "Social media is doing terrible harm to young women." "Phones are ruining this generation." The traditionalist says it and the child-safety campaigner says it, and they mean opposite things by it, and they are making the same move: **treating the technology as the thing doing the damage.**

It is not. Consider what actually happens when an intimate image of a woman is leaked. The image travels; that is the technology. Then a set of people decide what it means about her, and a marriage is called off, or a job is lost, or a family withdraws support, or she is beaten. **Every one of those is done by a person, using a judgement they held before the phone existed.**

You can test this directly. Take the same leaked image and put it in two societies. In one, it ends a life. In the other, it is humiliating for a fortnight and then it is over. The technology performed identically in both cases. The outcome differed by a factor of everything, and what differed was the penalty waiting on the other side.

> **The general form:** attributing to a change in distribution what belongs to the thing being distributed. It runs everywhere. Blaming the road for where the traffic goes. Blaming a ledger for a debt. In each case the new infrastructure is real and does change outcomes — but it changes them by making an existing process cheaper, not by introducing a new one.
>
> Why this matters practically, and it is not a debating point: if the technology is the enforcer, the remedies are technological — bans, filters, takedowns, keeping girls off phones. If the penalty is the enforcer, those remedies are palliative at best, and the lever is somewhere else entirely. Chapter Nine is where that fork gets taken, and almost every rupee currently being spent is being spent on the first branch.

1.4 — What is genuinely new

Having said all that, I do not want to leave the impression that nothing changed. Three things are genuinely new, and they are not the ones usually named.

The cost of enforcing collapsed. Ruining a woman's standing used to require effort, presence and social capital. It now requires an account and twenty minutes. When the price of an activity falls by three orders of magnitude, you get more of it, and you get it from people who would never have bothered before.

The enforcer stopped needing standing of their own. In a village, spreading a story cost you something: you could be known as a gossip, your own family's credit was in play. An anonymous account has no credit to lose. The system used to be self-limiting because the enforcers were also inside it.

The penalty became detachable from the community that imposed it. A woman could always be shamed by her own people. She can now be shamed by people who have never heard of her caste, her town or her family, and whose judgement she has no relationship with and no way to satisfy.

REMEMBER THIS

Reputation was not a feeling. It was a **working technology —** a way of storing information about people so that strangers could decide whether to deal with them. Izzat was the Indian version, held by households rather than persons.

It depended on three properties: a **bounded audience**, a **fading memory**, and a **known enforcer**. Those were not choices. They followed from how far a voice carries and how long a memory lasts.

All three broke at once, and each of them was one of a family's three remedies: **wait, move, or negotiate**. None of the three works now.

But the technology is not the enforcer. The same leaked image ends a life in one society and is forgotten in another. **What differs is the penalty waiting on the other side of it**, and the penalty is administered by people.

What is genuinely new is the price: ruining a woman's standing used to cost effort, presence and social capital. It now costs twenty minutes and an anonymous account.

CHAPTER TWO

The Archive That Does Not Forget

> *Of the three properties that broke, the loss of forgetting is the least discussed and probably the most important. Human societies have always run on the assumption that information decays. It does not any more.*

2.1 — Forgetting was a feature

Every system for handling wrongdoing that humans have built has a forgetting mechanism inside it, and we mostly do not notice them because they look like separate rules rather than one principle.

Criminal records are sealed or spent after a period. Bankruptcies fall off a credit file. Juvenile offences are not carried into adult life. Debts become unenforceable after a limitation period. Even in societies with no formal law, the equivalent existed: you moved, you married into another village, you grew old and the people who remembered died.

None of this was softness. It was structural. A society in which every mistake is permanent is a society in which a large share of the population is permanently disqualified, and no society can afford that. Forgetting is how a community recycles its members.

WORD BOX

Practical obscurity: a legal idea describing information that is technically public but effectively hidden because finding it takes real effort.

A court file in a district registry was public. Anyone could read it. But to read it you had to know it existed, travel there, and ask — so in practice almost nobody ever did.

Why it matters: an enormous amount of the privacy people used to have was not legal protection. It was friction. Digitisation removes friction without changing a single law, which means privacy can collapse completely while every rule stays exactly where it was.

2.2 — What replaced it

Four things happened at once, and together they abolished practical obscurity for anything that touches a screen.

Storage became free. There is no longer any economic reason to delete anything. The default flipped from discarding to keeping.

Search became universal. Information that exists can be found by name, which is the specific capability that matters — because reputation attaches to a name.

Copying became perfect and instant. A takedown removes one copy. The screenshot was taken before you asked.

Context became detachable. A photograph carries none of the circumstances in which it was made. A sentence said in one room appears in another with the room removed.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> A woman is nineteen. Something happens — a relationship, a photograph, a rumour, a video that was never meant to leave one phone.
>
> In 1985, the half-life of that is about four years and its radius is about thirty kilometres. At twenty-six she is teaching in another district and nobody there has heard anything.
>
> In 2026, it is on the first page of results for her name. At twenty-six the school checks. At thirty-four the in-laws check. At forty-one a colleague she has annoyed goes looking. **The event has a half-life longer than she does.**
>
> That is not a difference in the severity of the punishment. It is a difference in its duration, and the duration is now unbounded — which makes it a different punishment.

2.3 — The screenshot

One small artefact deserves its own section, because it has quietly become the central instrument of enforcement in Indian family life and almost nothing has been written about it.

A screenshot is a copy of something on a screen. It cannot be recalled, cannot be deleted at source, and carries no indication of what surrounded it. It is trivially easy to make and impossible to prevent.

What this produced is a completely new evidentiary object in a very old system. A caste council, a family elder or a prospective in-law now has access to something the village never had: a durable, transferable, apparently self-authenticating record of a woman's private communications. Messages between two people are now potentially messages to everyone, at the discretion of whichever of the two decides so later — or of anyone who gets hold of either phone.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> There is very little formal research on this, and I want to be honest that most of what is known comes from three weaker sources rather than from good survey data: reports from organisations that run helplines for women, court records where screenshots appear as evidence, and journalism.
>
> What those sources are good at: establishing that a pattern exists and describing its mechanics. When helpline workers in different states independently describe the same sequence — a private exchange surfaces, a family confronts the woman, a marriage is called off — that convergence is meaningful.
>
> What they are bad at: scale. Everything reaching a helpline or a courtroom is a selected sample of the worst cases that someone was willing to report. There is no basis in any of it for saying how common this is, and I am not going to pretend otherwise.
>
> Why the gap exists: nobody has funded a large representative survey asking Indian women whether their private messages have been used against them. That study would be straightforward to run.

2.4 — Does permanence actually change outcomes?

There is a real counter-argument here and it deserves a proper hearing, because the case I have just made is intuitive rather than measured.

> **THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE ARCHIVE ACTUALLY RUIN LIVES, OR DO PEOPLE FORGET ANYWAY?**

Everything above assumes that permanent availability translates into permanent consequences. That step is not automatic.

ATTENTION DECAYS EVEN WHEN INFORMATION DOES NOT

The archive is permanent; interest is not. Content that circulates furiously for a week is unfindable in practice a year later, because nobody is looking and the platforms that carried it have reorganised around whatever is current. Most people are not searched for by name by anyone. And societies adapt: as it becomes normal for everyone to have an embarrassing digital past, the informational value of finding one collapses — a scandal only works if it distinguishes you from other people. The generation now in their twenties has grown up assuming everything is recorded and appears to discount it accordingly.

DECAY OF ATTENTION IS NOT DECAY OF AVAILABILITY, AND THE DIFFERENCE IS THE WHOLE PROBLEM

What matters is not whether anybody is looking now. It is whether anybody *can* look at the moment it counts — and there are exactly three or four such moments in an Indian woman's life, each of them scheduled and each of them adversarial. A marriage negotiation is precisely an occasion on which someone is paid attention to look. So is a background check. The archive does not need continuous attention to do its work; it needs to be there on the day the in-laws sit down with a phone. And the adaptation argument cuts the wrong way in a society where the standard applied to women is not the same standard applied to everyone.

Where things stand: both effects are real and they operate on different timescales. General attention does decay quickly. Targeted search does not, and the moments that determine an Indian woman's life are targeted-search moments. The adaptation argument is genuinely strong for societies where the penalty is falling, and genuinely weak where it is not — which is the pattern this whole series keeps producing.

What would settle it: following a cohort of women over twenty years and recording whether digitally archived material actually surfaced at consequential moments. Entirely doable, never done.

Why people care so much: because if the archive is mostly inert, the correct response is to calm down and wait for norms to adjust. If it is live at exactly the moments that matter, then waiting means a generation absorbs the cost while the norms take their time.

2.5 — The right that was invented for this

Some legal systems have tried to rebuild forgetting deliberately. The European Union recognises a right to have certain search results about a person removed once the information is outdated or no longer relevant, and India's Supreme Court has acknowledged that something similar flows from the right to privacy, though what it amounts to in practice is still being worked out through individual cases rather than a general rule.

It is worth understanding what this can and cannot do. Delisting removes a result from a search engine. It does not remove the page. It does not remove copies. It does not reach a screenshot on a relative's phone, and the relative's phone is where the damage is actually done in most of the cases this part is about.

So the legal instrument built to restore forgetting operates on the layer that matters least for the harm described here. That is not a criticism of the people who built it — it was designed for a different problem, in societies where the search engine really is the main route. It is a warning about assuming the remedy fits.

REMEMBER THIS

Forgetting was a feature, not a kindness. Spent convictions, limitation periods, sealed juvenile records, moving to another town — every society builds a way to let people stop being their worst moment, because a society where every mistake is permanent disqualifies too many of its members.

Most of the privacy people used to have was not law. It was **friction** — information that was technically public and practically impossible to find. Digitisation removes friction without changing a single rule.

Four things replaced it: **free storage, universal search by name, perfect copying, and detachable context**. The first page of results does not care what year it is.

The **screenshot** gave a very old system a new instrument: a durable, transferable, apparently self-authenticating record of a woman's private conversations, releasable later by either party or by anyone who gets a phone.

Attention decays; availability does not. And the moments that decide an Indian woman's life — the marriage negotiation, the background check — are exactly the moments when somebody is deliberately looking.

CHAPTER THREE

The Two Phones

> *The same device is the best escape route Indian women have ever been handed and the most effective surveillance instrument their families have ever had. It is not two technologies. It is one, and both descriptions are correct.*

3.1 — Why the bans are not stupid

At intervals over the last fifteen years, village councils across Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan have banned unmarried girls from owning or using mobile phones, sometimes with fines attached for families who allow it. The reporting on these decisions is usually written as comedy — backward elders, futile rules, the march of progress.

I want to start from the opposite end, because the councils are not confused about what they are doing. They have identified, correctly, the single technology most likely to end their control over who their daughters marry.

Consider the mechanism. The system described across this whole series depends on marriages being arranged between families. Its most serious failure mode — the one that produces the violence at the far end — is a woman choosing a partner herself, especially outside her caste or religion. For that to happen she needs a way to meet someone, and to keep talking to him, without any of it passing through her family.

That is precisely and exactly what a phone is.

IN REAL TERMS

Before the phone, a young woman in a village had a contact list consisting of: people in her house, people in her lane, people at her school if she attended one, and relatives. Every one of those channels ran past an adult who could see it.

A phone gives her a channel that runs past nobody. Not a better channel — the **first** one.

The councils banning phones understand this perfectly. They are not worried about screen time. They are worried about the one thing that has ever seriously threatened arranged marriage, and they are right that it is in her hand.

3.2 — Who actually has one

Before going further, the distribution matters, because “Indian women have phones now” is doing a lot of work in arguments on both sides.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India’s **National Family Health Survey** asks women directly whether they have a mobile phone that they themselves use — not one in the household, one that is theirs. In the most recent full round, covering 2019 to 2021, roughly half said yes, with enormous variation between states, and among those who had one, around seven in ten could read a text message.

What that question is good at: it separates household access from personal access, which is the distinction that matters here. A phone in the house that a woman may use when someone hands it to her is not an escape route.

What it does not capture: whether she controls it. A phone she owns but whose messages are read by her husband or mother-in-law is, for the purposes of this chapter, closer to a monitored line than to a private one, and no survey asks that.

The second gap is bigger than the first. Owning a handset and having private use of it are treated as the same thing in nearly all of the data, and they are not.

So the picture is not “women now have phones”. It is: about half of Indian women have a handset of their own, an unknown share of those have private use of it, and both figures are far lower in exactly the districts where the penalties described in this series are most severe.

3.3 — What it gives her

The case for the phone as a liberating instrument is strong and it is not only about romance.

It gives her **information** that does not come through her family — about her rights, about what is normal elsewhere, about how to leave, about whether what is happening to her happens to others.

It gives her **money she can hold.** A bank account with a phone attached is money that does not have to pass through a husband's hands, and government payments made directly into women's accounts only function as autonomy if she can actually reach the account.

It gives her **contact with people outside the house** — a sister in another city, a friend, a helpline, a lawyer, a police number.

And it gives her a **record.** This is the underrated one. The same permanence that Chapter Two treated as a threat works in her favour when the thing being recorded is a threat made against her.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Handset sharing:** the very common arrangement in which one phone in a household is used by several people, usually with the male head of the household as the nominal owner.
>
> Why it matters: almost every benefit listed above requires **private** use, not access. A woman who can borrow the family phone can look things up. She cannot have a conversation nobody knows about, keep a record of a threat, or receive a call she does not want explained. The gap between access and control is where most of the autonomy lives, and it is the gap that nobody measures.

3.4 — What it gives them

Now the other side of the same device, which is at least as powerful and much less discussed.

A phone is a continuous location beacon, a complete log of who a person talks to and when, a record of everything they have looked at, and a container for every private message they have ever sent. All of that sits behind a passcode which a family member can simply demand.

That last point is the one that breaks the technical arguments. Encryption, disappearing messages and private browsing all defend against a stranger. None of them defends against a father who says: unlock it.

What this produces is a form of household surveillance with no historical precedent. A family in 1975 could restrict where a daughter went. It could not read her thoughts, her friendships and her whereabouts for the past year in ten minutes. And crucially, the demand to see the phone is not experienced as surveillance by the person making it — it is experienced as ordinary parental concern, which is exactly why it meets no resistance.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE PHONE, ON BALANCE, FREEING OR TRAPPING?

This is a genuine empirical question with a real literature, and the two sides are looking at different populations rather than disagreeing about facts.

NET FREEING, AND THE EVIDENCE FAVOURS IT

Studies across South Asia and Africa consistently associate women's personal mobile access with greater mobility, more independent decision-making, better health information and, in some settings, reduced acceptance of domestic violence. The mechanism is not mysterious: information and outside contact are what control depends on withholding. And look at revealed preference — women want phones, spend scarce money on them, and hide them when they are banned. The people whose interests are supposedly at stake are unanimous. The councils that ban them are not confused, they are correct: the phone is a threat to their control, which is precisely why it is good for the women they control.

THE MEASURED GAINS ARE REAL AND THEY ARE BEING MEASURED ON THE WRONG WOMEN

The studies showing autonomy gains are largely done where women already have personal handsets — which selects for households that permitted it, in regions where the penalty structure is weaker. In the districts where this series' subject matter bites hardest, the phone arrives as a monitored device or does not arrive at all, and its main effect is to give the household a surveillance capability it never had. The phone did not create the demand to control her; it handed over a tool that makes the control cheaper and more total. And the escape route argument has a hard edge: the phone is also what makes her locatable after she runs.

Where things stand: the aggregate evidence favours the phone, and the aggregate is hiding the distribution. Where a woman has private control of a device, it is one of the most autonomy-increasing objects ever put into her hands. Where she has a device but not control of it, it is net negative, and that second category is very large and almost entirely unmeasured. The disagreement is not about direction; it is about which population the reader has in mind.

What would settle it: a survey question that distinguishes owning a phone from having private use of one, asked at national scale. It does not exist. That is a one-line addition to an instrument that already reaches hundreds of thousands of Indian households.

Why people care so much: because "give girls phones" is a cheap, popular development intervention that lets everybody feel they have done something, and "make sure she controls it" is a demand about power inside households that no programme wants to make.

3.5 — The device is not the variable

The thing to take out of this chapter is that the phone does not have a politics of its own. It amplifies whoever is holding it, and in most Indian households more than one person is holding it.

Which means every policy question in this part that takes the form “should she have a phone” is the wrong question. The right one is: who else can see it, and what happens to her if they do not like what they find. The first half of that is a technology question. The second half is Chapter Nine, and it is the same second half as every other part of this series.

REMEMBER THIS

Village councils that ban unmarried girls’ phones are **not confused**. They have correctly identified the one technology that seriously threatens arranged marriage: the first communication channel in history that does not run past an adult in her house.

About **half** of Indian women have a mobile phone they themselves use. Nobody measures the more important number, which is how many have **private use** of one — and that gap is where the autonomy actually lives.

What it gives her: information outside the family, money she can hold, contact she can initiate, and a **record** of threats made against her.

What it gives the household: location, a full contact log, browsing history and every private message — all behind a passcode that a relative can simply demand. **Encryption defends against strangers. It does not defend against a father who says unlock it.**

The phone has no politics of its own. It amplifies whoever is holding it, and in most Indian households that is more than one person.

CHAPTER FOUR

Image-Based Abuse

> *The instrument at the centre of modern enforcement. What it is, who does it and why, whether it matters that she took the photograph herself — and why calling it a privacy violation sends every remedy to the wrong address.*

4.1 — Getting the name right first

The popular term is “revenge porn”, and it is wrong twice over in ways that shape how the whole subject is handled.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Non-consensual intimate imagery (NCII)**, also called **image-based sexual abuse**: sexual or intimate images or recordings of a person, distributed without that person’s agreement.
>
> Why the popular name is misleading: “revenge” names one motive among several and quietly frames the act as a response to something she did, which puts her conduct into the description of the crime. “Porn” implies material made for an audience, when most of it was made privately or was never consented to at all.
>
> The terms above are clumsier and they describe the act rather than a story about the act. That is why researchers and, increasingly, legislators use them.

The naming matters practically, not just politically. If you believe this is mostly bitter ex-partners taking revenge, you design remedies aimed at ex-partners. That belief turns out to be wrong.

4.2 — Who does it

The motives that show up when people study this, rather than assume it, are at least five.

Revenge and control — an ex-partner, or a current one, using an image as leverage or as punishment for leaving. This is the version everyone pictures and it is real.

Status inside a peer group — images passed between friends, in groups, as currency. The woman is not the audience and often not the point.

Money — extortion, or distribution as a commodity on sites that exist for it. Chapter Six is about the extortion version, which has become the largest category by volume in some countries.

Enforcement — and this is the one that belongs to this series. An image released deliberately to trigger the community penalty described in Part Eight: to end an engagement, to punish a woman who refused someone, to destroy a family's standing, or to force a woman out of public life.

Nothing in particular — sharing because it was there and sharing costs nothing.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> Prevalence estimates come from population surveys in several countries that ask adults directly whether an intimate image of them has ever been shared without their consent. The answers land somewhere in the range of one in twenty to one in ten, varying a great deal with how the question is worded and which behaviours are included.
>
> What those surveys are good at: showing that this is not a rare event affecting a handful of unlucky people. Even the low end of that range is an enormous number.
>
> What they are bad at: comparison. Different studies define the act differently — some include threats, some include images obtained by hacking, some only cover partners — so the numbers are not measuring quite the same thing.
>
> For India specifically, there is no equivalent figure, and Chapter Seven explains why: the national crime statistics record the category so narrowly that the count that exists cannot be used for this at all.

4.3 — "But she sent it herself"

This is the argument that does most of the work in defending the practice, in family arguments, in police stations and in comment sections. It deserves to be taken seriously rather than dismissed, because a great many people find it obviously decisive.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES IT MATTER THAT SHE TOOK THE PHOTOGRAPH?

Set aside for a moment what you already think and look at what each position actually claims.

YES, AND PRETENDING OTHERWISE IS DISHONEST

She created a permanent record of something private and handed it to another person. Everyone over the age of twelve knows that a digital file can be copied, that relationships end, and that phones are lost, stolen and read by other people. Taking the photograph was a choice with foreseeable risks. That does not make the person who spread it innocent — but it does mean this is not something that simply happened to her, and adults are generally expected to bear some responsibility for foreseeable consequences of their own decisions. Refusing to say so does not protect anyone; it just makes the advice useless to the next girl.

NO, BECAUSE CONSENT DOES NOT TRANSFER BETWEEN CONTEXTS

Agreeing that one person may see something is not agreeing that everyone may. This is not a special rule invented for this situation; it is how consent works everywhere else without controversy. Telling a doctor about your health is not publishing it. Undressing for a partner is not undressing for a street. Handing your bank details to a bank is not agreeing that the clerk may post them. In every one of those cases we locate the wrong entirely with the person who moved the information, and nobody argues that the patient should have anticipated the leak. American federal law now states this explicitly: prior consent to create an image, or to share it with one person, is not consent to publish it.

Where things stand: these two are answering different questions, which is why the argument never resolves. The first is about **prudence** — what a person could have foreseen. The second is about **wrongdoing** — who committed the act. Both can be right at once, and the reason the exchange is so bitter is that the prudential claim is almost always deployed to reduce the wrongdoing claim, which does not follow from it. Knowing a house may be burgled is a reason to lock it. It is not a reason to describe the burglary as partly the householder's doing.

What would settle it: nothing empirical; this is a question about how responsibility is allocated, not about facts. What can be observed is that the prudential argument is applied to women at a strength it is almost never applied to anyone else, which is itself evidence about what it is for.

Why people care so much: because "she sent it herself" is the sentence that converts a crime into a lesson, and once it is a lesson, the person who has to change their behaviour is her.

Underneath that argument — and underneath every takedown law, every platform policy and every remedy in Chapter Eight — is a shared description of what actually went wrong, and it is not quite right.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT WHAT WAS VIOLATED IS PRIVACY

Everyone treats this as a privacy harm. The laws sit in privacy statutes. The remedies are removal and delisting. The campaign language is about control over one's own image. Both sides of the argument above accept the frame: something private got out.

But run the test from Part Ten. Take the identical image, released identically, and put it in two places. In one, the woman is humiliated for a fortnight, her friends are unpleasant about it, and in a year it is a bad memory. In the other, her engagement is cancelled, her family withdraws support, her employment ends and in the worst cases she is beaten or she dies.

The privacy violation was the same in both. **The harm was not, and what differed was the penalty waiting on the other side of the disclosure.** Which means privacy is the trigger, and the penalty is the mechanism.

> This is not word-play, because the two descriptions send you to different places. If the harm is the disclosure, the remedy is removal — get the image down, fast, everywhere. If the harm is the penalty, then removal is damage limitation and the actual lever is the set of people who decide what the image means about her. Notice that the second group is not in any of the legislation. There is no law anywhere addressed to the in-laws.
>
> **The general form:** naming a harm after its trigger rather than its mechanism. It appears whenever a remedy is built around the visible event. Treating a leaked medical record as an information problem rather than a discrimination problem. Treating a leaked salary as a privacy issue rather than a pay-equity one. In each case the framing is not false, and it routes the entire remedial effort to the layer where it can do the least.
>
> And there is a specific cost to getting this wrong here. A successful takedown, achieved quickly, removes the file. It does not remove the belief held by the four hundred people who already saw it — and in the cases this series is about, those four hundred people are the entire mechanism. Chapter Eight is a chapter about instruments that work exactly as designed and address the wrong layer.

4.4 — What it costs, and where

One last observation before leaving this chapter.

Because the harm is the penalty rather than the disclosure, the same act is not the same crime in different places, and treating it as a single global phenomenon produces bad reasoning in both directions.

In a society with a weak penalty, image-based abuse is a serious violation with mostly psychological consequences, and the research literature on it — which is largely from those societies — reflects that. It documents distress, anxiety, withdrawal from public life, and career damage.

In a society with a strong penalty, the same act is a weapon that can remove a woman from her family, her marriage prospects and occasionally her life. There is almost no research on that version, because the countries with the strongest penalties have the weakest research infrastructure on exactly this question, and because the women it happens to have overwhelming reasons not to report it.

So the honest position is that the version of this crime that does the most damage is the version we know least about, and the gap is not accidental.

REMEMBER THIS

“Revenge porn” is the wrong name twice: **revenge** is only one motive among five, and naming it puts her conduct inside the description of the crime.

The motives are revenge, **status inside a peer group**, money, deliberate **enforcement** of the community penalty, and nothing in particular. Surveys put the share of adults affected somewhere between one in twenty and one in ten.

“She sent it herself” and “consent does not transfer” are answering **different questions** — one about prudence, one about wrongdoing. Both can be true. The argument is bitter because the first is nearly always used to shrink the second, which does not follow.

Calling this a privacy harm is **naming it after its trigger**. The same image released in two societies produces two completely different outcomes, and what differs is the penalty, not the disclosure.

Which is why a fast, successful takedown removes the file and leaves the mechanism intact — the four hundred people who already saw it are the entire machine, and no law anywhere is addressed to them.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Machines That Make It Up

> *Until recently, the enforcement system needed something to have happened. It does not any more. And the change is not that fakes became possible — it is that the last piece of practical advice anyone could give a woman stopped working.*

5.1 — What actually changed

Manipulated images are as old as photography. What changed is not possibility but price. Producing a convincing fake used to require skill, software, hours and a reason. It now requires an ordinary photograph and an app, and the app is free.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Synthetically generated information (SGI):** the term India's law adopted in February 2026. It covers any audio, image or video created or altered by an algorithm so that it appears to be real.
>
> Why the term matters: it deliberately avoids the word "deepfake", which had come to mean video specifically. The legal category covers a still image, a voice on a phone call, and a video, because all three do the same work.

Now the consequence, which is the whole reason this chapter exists.

Every piece of practical advice anyone has ever given a woman about this rests on one assumption: that the material has to come from her. Do not take the photograph. Do not send it. Do not let anyone film you. All of it is advice about controlling her own output, and all of it was reasonable while an image had to originate with her.

The input is now an ordinary clothed photograph of her face. A graduation picture. A wedding photo. A profile image. Something a relative posted.

IN REAL TERMS

Work out what “do not take the photograph” now protects against, in a country where a woman’s face appears in a school group photo, on a college noticeboard, on a company website, at a family wedding, and in the background of two hundred other people’s pictures.

The answer is: nothing. To be safe under the old advice she would have to have never been photographed by anybody, at any point, in a society where photographs are how people organise their lives.

An entire tradition of caution, taught by mothers to daughters for a generation, was rendered inoperative by a software change, and almost nobody has told the mothers.

5.2 — Does it help that it is fake?

Intuitively it should. A false accusation can be disproved; a true one cannot. So a fake image ought to be a lesser harm than a real one, and the natural remedy ought to be demonstrating that it is fake.

Both of those turn out to be wrong, and the reason is the mechanism from Chapter Four.

THE ARGUMENT — IS A SYNTHETIC IMAGE A SMALLER HARM THAN A REAL ONE?

This matters for law as well as for comfort. Several legal systems initially treated fakes as a lesser offence, or as no offence at all.

IT IS MEANINGFULLY SMALLER

Nothing private was exposed, because there was nothing private. No trust was broken. The image can, in principle, be shown to be false, and as public awareness of synthetic media rises the default assumption about any shocking image shifts towards scepticism. Twenty years ago a photograph was evidence; now everyone knows images can be made, and that knowledge is itself a defence that grows over time. Treating a fabrication as identical to a genuine exposure also flattens a real moral distinction — the person who leaks a partner’s private image has betrayed a specific trust, which the fabricator never had.

IT IS THE SAME HARM, AND IN ONE RESPECT WORSE

The damage is not done by the file. It is done by what a community concludes about her, and a community that acts on rumour has never needed evidence. Part Eight established that a rumour alone can end an engagement — no photograph was ever required. So a synthetic image is not a new capability; it is the old false accusation with production values. Worse: a real image involves an event that happened, which at least is bounded and past. A fabricated one can depict anything, be produced in unlimited quantity, and be aimed at a woman who did nothing at all — which removes the last thing a woman could do to protect herself.

Where things stand: the harm data does not support treating fakes as lesser. Reported distress, withdrawal from public life and career damage look similar for synthetic and genuine material, which is what you expect if the mechanism is the audience rather than the disclosure. Legislators have largely converged on this: both India's 2026 rules and American federal law now cover fabricated material on the same footing as genuine. The moral distinction the first side draws is real and is about the perpetrator, not about her.

What would settle it: outcome studies comparing women targeted with genuine and fabricated material on the things that matter — marriage, employment, family support. Nobody has run one.

Why people care so much: because "it is not really her" is the sentence that lets everybody else off. It lets the platform treat it as less urgent, the police treat it as less serious, and the viewer keep watching.

5.3 — Who it is aimed at

Early surveys of synthetic video circulating online found that the overwhelming majority of it — one widely cited count put the figure at over ninety per cent — was non-consensual sexual imagery, almost entirely of women. That study is now several years old and the landscape has broadened considerably as the tools spread into political and fraudulent uses. But the finding matters historically: the first mass application of this technology was not political disinformation. It was this.

The Indian policy story followed the same pattern. Regulation moved when a manipulated video of a well-known Indian actor circulated very widely in late 2023, prompting government advisories to platforms, and eventually the rules discussed in Chapter Eight. I am deliberately not naming her. She has had enough of her name attached to this, and the analytically relevant fact is the policy consequence rather than the person.

That sequence is worth noticing on its own terms. The technology had been used against ordinary women for years. It became a regulatory priority when it was used against someone whose visibility made it a national story. That is not a criticism of her; it is an observation about whose harm gets counted, and it is the same observation Part Eight made about which deaths get recorded.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The counts of what synthetic video is used for come from companies and researchers who crawl the sites hosting it and classify what they find. That method has a specific strength and a specific blind spot, and both matter for how much weight the figure can bear.

What it is good at: it counts what is actually there rather than what people report, so it is immune to the reporting problems that affect everything else in this part.

What it is bad at: it can only see material that is published somewhere findable. Anything made and circulated privately — in a messaging group, or sent directly to a woman's family, which is precisely the use this series is about — is invisible to it. The published corpus is a sample of the public use, not of the use.

So treat the figure as establishing what the technology was mostly built and sold for, and not as a measurement of how it is mostly used.

5.4 — The other direction

There is a second-order effect here that cuts against exactly the people the technology already hurts most.

WORD BOX

The liar's dividend: the advantage that the existence of convincing fakes gives to a person who is caught by genuine evidence. Once everyone knows images can be fabricated, any real recording can be dismissed as fabricated.

Why it matters here: Chapter Three listed "a record of threats made against her" as one of the phone's genuine gifts to a woman. That gift depends on a recording being believed. As synthetic media becomes ordinary, the evidentiary value of a photograph, a voice message or a video falls — for everybody, including her.

So the same development does two things at once. It lets an attacker manufacture material that never existed, and it lets an abuser dismiss material that does. A woman documenting a threat and a woman denying a fabrication are now in the same epistemic position, which is: nothing can be settled by showing anyone anything.

That is a serious loss and it is not recoverable by better detection tools, because the problem is not whether a specialist can tell. It is whether a mother-in-law, a village council or a police constable can tell, and whether they have any interest in telling. Chapter Eight's provenance and labelling requirements are aimed exactly here, and Chapter Eight is also where their limits become visible.

REMEMBER THIS

Fakes are not new; **the price of making a convincing one collapsed.** India's 2026 law calls the category synthetically generated information, and it covers stills and voice as well as video.

The consequence that matters most: **the input is now an ordinary clothed photograph**. Every piece of advice ever given — do not take the picture, do not send it — assumed the material had to originate with her. None of it protects anyone any more.

Being fake **does not make it a smaller harm**, because the damage is done by what the audience concludes, and a community that acts on rumour never needed a photograph. A synthetic image is the oldest instrument in this series — the false accusation — with production values.

The first mass use of the technology was sexual imagery of women, not political disinformation. Indian regulation moved when it reached someone visible enough to make a national story.

And it cuts both ways: the same development that lets an attacker manufacture evidence lets an abuser dismiss it. Her recording of a threat is now deniable too.

CHAPTER SIX

Sextortion

> *Two versions of the same crime, with two different targets and two different demands. The difference between the demands is the most precise measurement anyone has ever taken of the double standard, and it was taken by criminals.*

6.1 — The mechanism

The structure is simple and it has not changed in twenty years. Obtain an intimate image of a person. Threaten to send it to the people whose opinion of them matters. Name a price.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Sextortion:** threatening to distribute a person's intimate images unless they comply with a demand.
>
> The important structural feature: the image is not the product. The **threat** is the product. The image only has value because of what the victim's community would do if it arrived, which means a sextortionist is, in the most literal sense, monetising the penalty this series has spent eleven parts describing.

Note what follows from that immediately. If a community would do nothing on receiving the image, the threat is worthless and the crime does not work. Sextortion is a business that runs entirely on other people's willingness to punish.

6.2 — Two patterns

When researchers actually looked at the reports, they found the crime had split into two distinct forms, targeting different people and demanding different things.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The clearest evidence comes from the United States, where the **National Center for Missing and Exploited Children** receives reports of child exploitation nationally. A joint analysis with the technology organisation Thorn reviewed sextortion reports made to it between 2020 and 2023.

What it found: the historical pattern of child sextortion had primarily targeted girls, with the offender demanding further images, sexual acts or a continuing relationship. Alongside it, a newer **financial** pattern had grown very rapidly, and there the victims were overwhelmingly boys — around nine in ten of the financial cases were boys aged roughly fourteen to seventeen. Reports were arriving at a rate of more than eight hundred a week.

What this evidence is good at: it is a large body of contemporaneous reports rather than recollections, gathered by an organisation with no stake in the answer.

What it cannot show: rates in the general population, or anything about India. Reports to an American hotline are shaped by who knows the hotline exists. And the girls' pattern is systematically under-reported relative to the boys' — for reasons the rest of this chapter makes clear.

So: girls extorted for more images and for compliance. Boys extorted for money, fast, at scale, by what are frequently organised commercial operations working from outside the victim's country.

6.3 — Why the demands differ

The obvious explanation is that the two crimes are committed by different people with different appetites, and that is true. But it does not explain why the market sorted this way, and the market explanation is the one worth having.

An extortionist is choosing what to demand based on what the threat is worth. And the threat is worth exactly what the victim's community will do.

For a teenage boy in most societies, exposure of an intimate image is humiliating. It is not ruinous. His marriage prospects survive it. His family does not disown him. Within a peer group it may even, disgustingly, raise his standing. So the threat has a **short shelf life** — its value collapses within days as he realises the world has not ended, or tells a parent, or the offender's bluff becomes visible. An extortionist holding an asset that depreciates that fast has to convert it to cash immediately, and that is precisely what the financial pattern looks like: contact, image, threat, payment demand, all within hours.

For a girl in a society with the penalty structure described in Part Eight, the same threat does not depreciate. It appreciates. It remains valuable next month and next year, and it can be used repeatedly, because what it threatens is not embarrassment but the removal of her marriage, her family and her standing. An asset like that is not sold for a few thousand rupees. It is used to extract compliance, indefinitely.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Put the two side by side as a business decision, which is what it is.
>
> A criminal with an image of a boy has a coupon worth a few hundred dollars that expires in about forty-eight hours. Sell it now, move to the next target, repeat a thousand times. Volume business.
>
> A criminal with an image of a girl in a strict community holds an asset with no expiry that can be redeemed repeatedly for whatever he wants. He does not cash it out. He keeps it.
>
> **The demands differ because the penalties differ. Two sets of criminals, working independently, have priced the double standard — and their pricing is more accurate than any survey in this series.**

6.4 — What it costs

Both versions kill people, and they kill them differently, which follows from the same logic.

The financial pattern produces deaths that cluster very close to the event — within hours or days, in a state of acute panic, often before the victim has told anybody. Tallies in the United States have connected financial sextortion to at least thirty deaths of teenage boys by suicide since 2021, and that count is certainly low. The specific cruelty is speed: a boy is contacted, panics, and the situation resolves one way or another before any adult knows it began.

The girls' pattern produces a different shape of harm — prolonged, coercive, and much less visible, because the whole point of the compliance demand is that nothing surfaces. There is no equivalent tally, and there cannot be, because the cases that end are the ones that ended.

This is a heavy subject and I want to state one practical thing rather than only analyse it. The mechanism depends completely on the victim believing they cannot tell anyone. In the financial pattern, telling a parent within the first hour ends it almost every time, because the threat has no value once the audience is warned. Every organisation working on this says the same thing: the disclosure is the defence.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THIS A CRIME PROBLEM OR A NORMS PROBLEM?

Both answers imply completely different responses, and both are held by serious people working on this.

IT IS A CRIME PROBLEM WITH A POLICING SOLUTION

These are organised criminal operations with identifiable infrastructure — accounts, payment channels, hosting. They respond to enforcement the way any commercial operation does: raise the cost and the volume falls. Platform detection of the standard opening sequence, faster takedown, payment interception and international cooperation are all tractable, and some have already produced measurable drops in reports. Waiting for societies to stop punishing women is not a plan; arresting the people running the operations is.

IT IS A NORMS PROBLEM AND POLICING TREATS SYMPTOMS

The business exists because the threat has value, and the threat has value because communities will do the punishing for free. You cannot arrest your way out of a crime whose weapon is supplied by the victim's own family. Notice the asymmetry the data shows: where the penalty is weak, the crime is a rapid, low-value cash grab that a single conversation defeats. Where the penalty is severe, it becomes indefinite coercion that no arrest reaches, because the victim will never report it. Reduce the penalty and the entire business model loses its collateral.

> **Where things stand:** both are right about the parts they are describing, and the split maps exactly onto the two patterns. The financial pattern really is a policing and platform-design problem, and it really is responding to those measures. The coercive pattern is not, and never will be, because its defining feature is that nobody tells anyone. Any policy that treats these as one crime will succeed against the one that was already tractable and report that as success.
>
> **What would settle it:** comparing the coercive pattern's prevalence across societies with very different penalty structures. That would test the norms claim directly. It is not measurable by reports, for the reason above, so it would take a general population survey — which nobody has run.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because the policing answer is fundable, announceable and achievable within a political term, and the norms answer is a demand that families change what they do to their daughters.

If any of this is happening to you or to someone you know, the two things that matter are that telling somebody immediately removes most of the threat's value, and that paying does not end it. In India the national cybercrime helpline and reporting portal exist for exactly this, and reporting does not require you to have done nothing wrong.

REMEMBER THIS

In sextortion, the image is not the product. **The threat is the product**, and the threat is worth exactly what the victim's community would do on receiving it. It is a business that runs on other people's willingness to punish.

There are two patterns. Girls are extorted for **more images and compliance.** Boys are extorted for **money**, quickly — around nine in ten victims of the financial pattern are boys aged fourteen to seventeen, with reports arriving at over eight hundred a week in the United States alone.

The demands differ because the penalties differ. A threat against a boy **depreciates in days**, so it must be cashed immediately. A threat against a girl in a strict community **does not expire**, so it is kept and redeemed repeatedly.

Two independent sets of criminals have therefore **priced the double standard**, and their pricing is more precise than any survey.

The mechanism depends entirely on the victim believing they cannot tell anyone. In the financial pattern, telling someone in the first hour ends it almost every time — because a threat has no value once the audience has been warned.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Mob Is Not the Village

> *The old enforcers had names, addresses and standing of their own. The new ones have none of those things, and that changes what enforcement is for — because the person being attacked was never the one being addressed.*

7.1 — The arithmetic of attack and defence

Start with something purely mechanical, because it explains more than any theory of motive.

Attacking a person online costs the attacker almost nothing per unit. Defending costs the target a great deal per unit. Those two costs used to be roughly symmetrical, and they are not any more.

IN REAL TERMS

A man decides to abuse a woman online. In an hour he can send perhaps sixty messages, or post twenty, or reply to everything she has written for a month.

She now has sixty messages. To report each one takes maybe half a minute — read it, tap through the menu, choose a category, confirm. That is thirty minutes of her life to answer one hour of his, and she has to read all sixty to do it.

Now multiply the attacker by four hundred, which is what a coordinated pile-on looks like. He spent an hour. Collectively they have consumed weeks of her attention, and there is no equivalent multiplication available on her side. **She cannot hire four hundred people to be attacked on her behalf.**

This asymmetry is not incidental to online harassment. It is the whole of it. In a village, abusing someone cost you time, presence and reputation, so there was a natural ceiling on how much of it any one person could do.

That ceiling is gone, and what replaced it has a name.

WORD BOX

Brigading: a coordinated attack in which a group agrees, formally or informally, to target one person at the same time.

Why it matters: the individual messages in a brigade are often mild enough that each one, taken alone, would not violate any platform rule or any law. The harm is produced by the **volume**, which no rule written about individual messages can see. Platforms moderate posts; the weapon is the aggregate.

7.2 — Does anonymity create the mob?

The standard explanation for online cruelty is anonymity: people behave badly when they cannot be identified. It is the premise behind every proposal for real-name registration and behind the traceability provisions in Chapter Eight.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES ANONYMITY CAUSE THIS, OR REVEAL IT?

The answer determines whether identification requirements are a solution or a distraction, and India is currently building policy on one of these two assumptions.

ANONYMITY CAUSES IT

Remove the cost of being known and you remove the restraint that made village enforcement self-limiting. Chapter One established that the old system worked partly because the enforcer had standing of their own to lose. An anonymous account has none. The practical evidence is that abuse is worse in anonymous spaces than in identified ones, and that people who are identified moderate themselves visibly. Identity requirements would restore the missing cost.

ANONYMITY REVEALS IT

Look at who actually conducts the worst of this in India and elsewhere: a large share of it is done from accounts with real names, real photographs and real employers, by people who face no consequence because their community approves. The auction apps described below were built and promoted in the open. Real-name policies have been tried and produced modest effects at best, while imposing severe costs on exactly the people who need pseudonymity most — women escaping abusers, and critics of governments. If the restraint were about being identified, being identified would restrain them. It does not, because their audience is not offended.

Where things stand: both effects exist and they apply to different attackers. Anonymity does increase casual, opportunistic cruelty from people who would not do it under their own name. It does very little about organised, ideological or community-sanctioned attack, which is the kind that does the serious damage — because those attackers are not hiding from their own side. Identity requirements therefore reduce the volume and miss the harm.

What would settle it: a natural experiment — a large platform introducing genuine identity verification and measuring targeted harassment of women before and after, disaggregated by whether the attacker's community approved of the attack. The measurement is feasible; nobody has published it.

Why people care so much: because identity requirements are the one remedy that governments actively want for other reasons, and a genuine harm to women is a very convenient justification for building a capability that has many other uses. Chapter Eight is about that overlap.

7.3 — The industrial version

In July 2021, and again in January 2022, applications appeared on a public code-hosting service purporting to hold "auctions" of Indian Muslim women. The women listed were journalists, activists, academics, students and pilots. Their photographs had been taken from their own public accounts. There was no sexual imagery involved at all. The entire mechanism was the **framing** — presenting named, identifiable women as goods for sale, with the sexual implication carried by the format rather than by any content.

Arrests followed in the second case. But the thing worth extracting is how little the operation actually required. No hacking. No intimate material. No lie that could be disproved, because nothing factual was asserted. It combined two things this series has described separately — the assertion of sexual availability from Part Eight, and the searchable public index from Chapter Two — and it targeted the point where two penalty structures overlap, because the women were selected for being both women and Muslim.

That is the modern form. It does not need any of the instruments in Chapters Four, Five or Six. It needs a list of names and a frame.

7.4 — What the statistics cannot see

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India's National Crime Records Bureau reported around 86,000 cybercrime cases for 2023, up more than thirty per cent on the previous year, and the 2024 figure crossed one hundred thousand for the first time. Alongside that, recorded crimes against women ran above four and a half lakh — roughly fifty every hour.

Now look at the composition rather than the total. Around two-thirds of the recorded cyber offences were banking or investment fraud. The categories that would capture what this part is about — stalking, bullying, morphing of images — together account for a very small share, with cyberstalking and cyberbullying recorded at around ten thousand seven hundred cases in 2023 for a country of 1.4 billion people. The chargesheet rate across cybercrime as a whole sits under a third.

What this tells you: the statistical system is built around financial loss, which is what an FIR is good at recording, because there is a rupee figure and a complainant with a bank statement. It has no category that fits a coordinated pile-on, and no way to record four hundred accounts as one event.

Treat that as evidence rather than as a gap, exactly as Part Ten did with the honour-killing count. The Indian state can count. It counts fraud to the rupee. **What it has not built is a category, and a missing category is a decision about what counts as a crime.**

7.5 — Who the attack is actually addressed to

Everything so far has assumed the obvious thing: that an attack on a woman is aimed at that woman. Look closely at how these events are actually conducted and that assumption stops holding.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE TARGET IS THE AUDIENCE

Both sides of every argument about online abuse treat it as a communication between an attacker and a victim. The remedies follow: block, mute, report, delete your account, do not feed them. All of that advice assumes she is the recipient.

She is usually not. Notice three things about how a pile-on actually runs. Most of it is **posted publicly rather than sent to her —** if the point were to reach her, direct messages would do. The volume is thousands of times greater than what is needed to communicate anything to one person. And the participants are visibly talking **to each other**: replying, competing, escalating for approval, quoting each other's better lines.

Now ask what the operation actually produces. Two things, reliably. Status inside the attacking group, awarded for the most effective contribution. And a demonstration, watched by every other woman with an account, of what happens to a woman who speaks in public.

That second product is the yield. Survey after survey of women in public life — journalists, politicians, academics — records the same response: reduced posting, avoided topics, accounts closed. **The attack on one woman is a message to all the others, and it is received.** She is not the addressee. She is the medium.

The general form: mistaking the object of an act for its purpose. A public execution was never about the condemned; the crowd was the point. A shop raided to make an example is not about that shopkeeper. In every case the person who suffers is the material, and treating them as the audience makes the whole operation look irrational — which is why observers keep asking, uselessly, why the attackers do not stop when she has clearly got the message.

What follows practically is unwelcome. Nearly all the standard advice is addressed to a recipient who does not exist. Blocking works if the attacker wanted to reach you; it does nothing if he wanted an audience to see him reach for you. Leaving the platform completes the operation rather than escaping it — the demonstration has succeeded, publicly, and the next woman watched it happen.

Which leaves one question. If the file can be removed and the belief cannot, and if the attack was never addressed to her in the first place, what is the law actually able to reach? That is the next chapter.

REMEMBER THIS

Attack is cheap per unit and defence is expensive per unit, and they used to be symmetrical. One person can consume weeks of a stranger's attention in an hour, and **she cannot hire four hundred people to be attacked on her behalf.**

Brigading works because each individual message may break no rule. Platforms moderate posts; the weapon is the aggregate, and no rule written about single messages can see it.

Anonymity increases casual cruelty and does almost nothing about the organised kind, because those attackers are **not hiding from their own side**. Identity requirements reduce volume and miss the harm — while building a capability governments want anyway.

The auction apps of 2021 and 2022 needed **no hacking and no intimate images**. A list of names and a frame implying sexual availability was the entire operation.

And the target is not the audience. The attack is posted publicly, in volumes thousands of times greater than needed to reach one person, by people talking to each other — because what it produces is status for them and a demonstration for every other woman watching.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What the Law Is Doing

> *In the last two years the legal position changed more than in the previous twenty. India now requires an intimate image to come down within two hours. This chapter is about what that machinery does, what it cannot reach, and what else it can be pointed at.*

8.1 — India's two-hour rule

On 10 February 2026 the Indian government notified an amendment to the rules governing online platforms, and it came into force ten days later. It is the most significant change to this area of Indian law since the original rules of 2021.

The headline is speed. Where a platform is notified of a non-consensual intimate image, it must act within **two hours**. For other categories of flagged unlawful content the window is three hours, down from thirty-six. To put that in perspective, thirty-six hours was long enough for material to be copied everywhere; two hours is short enough to matter.

The amendment also does something Indian law had not done before: it defines synthetically generated information as a legal category, requires it to be visibly labelled, requires platforms to retain provenance information, and requires them to be able to identify who uploaded material used in a crime.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Everything in this chapter about Indian law comes from gazette notifications and the text of the rules themselves, which is unusually solid evidence: a notification says what it says, and its date and effect are matters of record rather than interpretation.

One distinction is worth holding on to, because reporting frequently blurs it. The two-hour obligation described above is **notified and in force** — made on 10 February 2026, effective from the 20th. The further proposals discussed later in this chapter, extending the framework to individual users posting on news and current affairs, are a **draft** released at the end of March 2026 for consultation.

What that means practically: one of these is law that platforms are already being measured against, and the other is a proposal that may be modified or dropped. I have kept them separate throughout, and you should be suspicious of any account that does not.

Underneath both of them sits one older rule, and it is the rule that gives every content regulation in the world its leverage.

WORD BOX

Safe harbour: the rule, in place in India since 2000 and in America since 1996, that a platform is not legally responsible for what its users post — provided it meets certain conditions.

Why it is the hinge of everything: without safe harbour, no platform could allow user posts at all, because it would be liable for every one of them. With unconditional safe harbour, no platform has to do anything about harm.

So every regulatory fight about online content is really a fight about **what the conditions are**. The 2026 amendment does not abolish safe harbour. It makes it something a platform has to keep earning, continuously, in hours rather than days.

8.2 — The American version, and one sentence in it

The United States moved in the same direction on a slower clock. A federal law signed in May 2025 criminalised publishing — or threatening to publish — non-consensual intimate images, including fabricated ones, and required covered platforms to build a notice-and-removal process by May 2026, with removal within forty-eight hours and reasonable efforts to find and remove known identical copies.

The provision worth extracting is not the deadline. It is a single statutory sentence establishing that a person's prior consent to the *creation* of an image, or to sharing it with *one* person, does not constitute consent to its publication.

That is the argument from Chapter Four, settled by statute in one jurisdiction. It is a small thing on paper and a large thing in a police station, because "she sent it herself" stops being a defence and becomes irrelevant.

8.3 — The mechanism that actually scales

Law sets obligations. The thing that does the work at scale is technical, and it is worth understanding because it is genuinely well designed.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Hash matching:** a hash is a short string of characters computed from a file — a fingerprint. The same image always produces the same hash; a different image produces a different one. Crucially, you cannot reconstruct the image from the hash.
>
> How the anti-abuse services use it: the woman's own device computes the hash of the image. **Only the hash is uploaded — the image never leaves her phone.** Participating platforms compare it against material being posted and block matches before they appear.
>
> Why this is the right shape: she does not have to send her intimate image to a company, or to the police, or to anyone, in order to be protected from it. Every other remedy in this chapter requires her to hand the material over to somebody. This one does not.

The limitation is that it only catches that exact image, or something close enough. Crop it, re-encode it, add a border, and it may pass. Perceptual matching handles a good deal of that, and an attacker who knows the system can defeat it. It is a filter, not a wall.

IN REAL TERMS

Suppose everything above works perfectly. The image is hashed, the platforms block it, India's two-hour rule is met, and the file is gone from every service within a hundred and twenty minutes.

Now count what the two hours did not touch. The screenshot on the phone of everyone who saw it. The forward in the family group. The relative who has already telephoned. The engagement that was cancelled at minute forty.

The takedown regime is excellent at removing a file and has no purchase whatever on a belief. That is not a failure of the drafting. It is the boundary of what any law addressed to intermediaries can do, and Chapter Four explained why: the file was the trigger, and the people are the mechanism.

8.4 — The practical routes

Three things exist and are worth knowing before the argument resumes.

In India, the national cybercrime reporting portal and the 1930 helpline take complaints of this kind, including anonymously for some categories. Reporting does not require that you have done nothing wrong, and the offences involved sit in the Information Technology Act and in the provisions on voyeurism and stalking.

Every major platform now has a specific reporting route for non-consensual intimate imagery, separate from ordinary abuse reporting, and since February 2026 the Indian deadline attaches to it.

The hash services described above operate for adults and, through the child-protection organisations, for minors. They work on images you hold; they cannot help with material you have never seen.

8.5 — What else the machine can do

THE ARGUMENT — DO THESE RULES PROTECT WOMEN OR EXPAND THE STATE?

This is now a live Indian argument rather than a theoretical one, because a further set of draft rules was released in March 2026.

THEY PROTECT WOMEN, AND THE OBJECTION IS A LUXURY

Before this, a woman whose image was circulating had essentially no timely remedy. Platforms responded in weeks if at all, and the material was permanent within hours. A two-hour obligation with safe harbour at stake changes the incentive completely, and it is the first rule in Indian law written to the actual clock of the harm. The civil-liberties objection is being made largely by people who will never need the remedy, about a capability that is used overwhelmingly for the purpose it was built for. Refusing to build a fire brigade because the ladder could be used to burgle is not a serious position.

THE SAME MACHINE DOES BOTH, AND THE SECOND USE IS ALREADY VISIBLE

The obligation is not “remove intimate images”. It is “detect a defined class of content across your whole service, remove it within hours, and be able to identify who posted it”. That is a general capability, and the class is defined by whoever holds the pen. Draft rules published in March 2026 would extend the ethics framework to individual users posting content “in the nature of news and current affairs” — a term with no precise definition, which digital rights analysts note could reach opinion, satire and political memes. The two-hour NCII rule and a three-hour rule for whatever is designated next run on exactly the same infrastructure, and traceability that identifies a sextortionist identifies a source talking to a journalist.

Where things stand: both descriptions are accurate and they are not in tension, which is what makes this hard. The protection is real and was overdue. The capability is general and has already been extended once in the drafting stage. Nothing about that is hypothetical or requires assuming bad faith about anybody.

What would settle it: transparency data — how many removal orders were issued, under which category, by which authority, and how many were challenged. Some of this is published in fragments. A complete public record would let anyone answer the question empirically instead of by intuition, and its absence is the reason the argument is conducted by assertion.

Why people care so much: because a genuine and sympathetic harm is the most effective justification available for building infrastructure that has other uses, and everyone on both sides knows it. That does not mean the harm is a pretext. It means the harm and the pretext are compatible.

Which points at the thing both of those positions are assuming.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT PROTECTION AND CONTROL ARE DIFFERENT PROGRAMMES

The safety advocate argues that we should build the capability. The civil-liberties critic argues that it will be misused. Both are talking as though there were two projects here — a good one and a bad one — that happen to share some plumbing, and as though the task were to get the good one without the bad one.

There is one project. “Identify a class of content across an entire network, remove it within two hours, and produce the identity of whoever posted it” is a single technical system. **It has no opinion about which class.** The class is a parameter, set later, by whoever holds the authority to set it.

This is why the usual framing of the debate — should we build this? — is the wrong question, and why both sides sound naive to each other. It was always going to be built, in every country, because the harm is real and the pressure is enormous and no government can refuse to act on it. The capability exists now. What has not been decided, in India or anywhere, is **who sets the parameter, on what record, subject to what review**.

> **The general form:** a capability that does not know what it is for. A national identity database built for benefits delivery. A camera network installed for traffic. A ledger of financial transactions built for tax. In every case the infrastructure is genuinely useful for the stated purpose, works exactly as designed, and can be repointed by an administrative decision that requires no new construction and no new legislation.
>
> What follows is not that the rules are bad. A woman with a two-hour takedown is materially better off than a woman with none, and I am not going to pretend otherwise to make a cleaner argument. What follows is that the fight worth having is not about whether the machine exists. It is about the register: who can point it, at what, and where the record of it is kept. That fight is currently not being had, in either direction, because one side is defending the machine and the other is objecting to it.

So the law can remove a file in two hours and cannot reach the thing that turns a file into a ruined life. That leaves the question this part has been building towards, which is what does.

REMEMBER THIS

India's amended rules came into force on **20 February 2026**. A non-consensual intimate image must be acted on within **two hours**; other flagged unlawful content within three, down from thirty-six. Synthetic content must be labelled and traceable.

American federal law from May 2025 criminalises publishing or threatening to publish such images, including fabricated ones, and states in statute that **consent to create or to share privately is not consent to publish**.

Hash matching is the mechanism that scales, and it is well designed: her device computes a fingerprint, only the fingerprint is uploaded, platforms block matches. The image never leaves her phone.

But run it perfectly and the file is gone in two hours while the screenshots, the forwards, the phone calls and the cancelled engagement are untouched. **The regime removes files and has no purchase on beliefs.**

And protection and control are not two programmes sharing plumbing. They are one capability with the target class left as a parameter — so the question is not whether it gets built, but who sets the parameter and who keeps the record.

CHAPTER NINE

What Actually Reduces the Harm

> *The case for taking the phone away is stronger than people who dislike it admit. Three answers exist, they are addressed to three different people, and the argument is confused because everyone pretends they are addressed to the same one.*

9.1 — The case for restriction, put as well as I can put it

Here is the argument for the village council, the strict father and the mother who reads her daughter's messages. It does not require any appeal to honour or tradition. It uses this part's own findings.

The threats are real and this part documented them. A permanent searchable archive. An image that can be fabricated from a graduation photograph. A crime whose business model is her family's willingness to punish her. Coordinated attack that costs the attacker an hour and costs her weeks. None of that is invented and none of it is exaggerated.

The remedies are slow, partial and institutional. A two-hour takedown obligation is worth having, and it depends on a complaint being made, categorised and acted on, by services and police forces that in much of India do not work reliably. Chapter Eight showed that even perfect execution removes a file and leaves the belief.

Restriction is the only lever a parent actually holds. A father in a district town cannot change platform policy, cannot reduce his neighbours' willingness to punish, and cannot make the archive forget. He can decide what his daughter has in her hand. It works immediately, costs nothing, and requires no one's cooperation.

And he is not wrong about the penalty. This is the part that critics skip. He is not overestimating what would happen to her. He is one of the people who would have to watch it happen, or apply it. His estimate of the danger is better informed than that of anyone telling him to relax.

That is the case. It is coherent, it is evidence-based, and its conclusion is that a girl should have a smaller life than her brother.

9.2 — Three answers, addressed to three people

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT ACTUALLY REDUCES THE HARM?

All three positions accept every finding in this part. They differ on where to apply pressure.

REDUCE HER EXPOSURE

Shrink the surface area. Fewer photographs, tighter accounts, less public presence, a monitored device or none. It is immediate, it requires nobody's permission, and it demonstrably works — a woman with no public footprint is harder to attack. Everything else on this list takes a decade and a legislature. She does not have a decade; she has a marriage negotiation in eighteen months.

BUILD THE REMEDIES

Fast takedown, hash blocking, criminal liability for distribution and for threats, platform design that interrupts the standard sextortion opening, policing that treats this as a crime rather than as a family matter. This is the branch that has actually moved: two-hour obligations, statutory takedown, federal criminalisation of fabricated material, all inside two years. Unlike restriction it does not cost the woman anything, and unlike changing norms it can be legislated by people who already exist.

REDUCE THE PENALTY

Chapter Six proved this one, and it proved it using criminals as the instrument. The threat is worth exactly what the community will do. Where the penalty is weak, the crime degrades into a rapid low-value cash grab that a single conversation defeats. Where it is severe, it becomes indefinite coercion no arrest can reach. Nothing else on this list touches the weapon's value. Takedowns remove ammunition; this removes the gun.

Where things stand: these are not rival recommendations to one person. They are addressed to three different people and the argument is incoherent because everybody pretends otherwise. Restriction is advice to a parent, available on a Tuesday, and it works by transferring the cost onto the daughter. Remedy-building is advice to a state, takes years, and works on files. Reducing the penalty is the only one that removes the mechanism — and it is addressed to a community, which is to say to nobody in particular, which is why it never gets funded.

What would settle it: nothing empirical about their effectiveness, because each is effective at what it does. What is genuinely open, and measurable, is the size of the third effect: comparing the same crimes across communities with very different penalty structures. Chapter Six's two patterns are the closest thing anyone has to that measurement, and it was produced accidentally.

Why people care so much: because the first answer is available to everyone right now and its whole cost falls on someone who did not choose it, the second is fundable and announceable, and the third asks families to stop doing something they believe is love.

It helps to see the three set out as a ledger, with what each one buys and who settles the bill.

IN REAL TERMS

Put the three on a ledger with what each buys and who pays.

Restriction: reduces her risk substantially, today. Cost: her education, her work, her money, her friendships, her ability to call for help, and her chance of choosing who she marries. Paid entirely by her.

Remedies: reduces the duration and spread of an attack. Cost: public money and some liberty questions from Chapter Eight. Paid by everyone, thinly.

Reducing the penalty: makes the weapon worthless. Cost: a community giving up a mechanism it has used for centuries, with no guarantee and no timeline. Paid by the people who currently benefit from it.

Notice the pattern. The cheapest option for everyone else is the one whose entire cost lands on a girl, and it is also the one that gets chosen. That is not a coincidence; it is the definition of the cheapest option.

9.3 — Where I have to be careful

Two admissions, at the point where they apply.

The first is positional. I write in public under my own name, and I am a man. If a coordinated attack came for me tomorrow it would be unpleasant, and it would not end my marriage prospects, remove my family's support, or make my sisters harder to marry. I have been writing about a weapon that cannot be used against me at anything like the same power setting. That does not disqualify the analysis. It does mean I should be slow to call anybody's caution excessive, and I have tried to be.

The second is methodological, and I noticed it while writing Chapter Six. I described sextortion as a market — assets, depreciation, pricing, conversion to cash. That framing produced the single sharpest finding in this part, and it also drained the moral content out of what those people are doing to children. Both of those are true at once. Analysis of this kind is useful precisely because it is cold, and the coldness is not free. I am flagging it rather than warming up the prose, because warming it up would have cost the finding.

9.4 — Back to where this started

> **THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — MINE, AND THE SERIES'**
>
> This series exists because of a specific event. A woman was photographed at a protest, and people online attacked her with a claim about how she earns money. I read it, found I was more interested in the machinery than in the incident, and started writing.
>
> Twelve parts later, here is what I have done with her. I have not named her. I have not written about her. I have not found out what happened to her afterwards, whether the claim was true, whether she wanted any of this discussed, or whether she would consider a research series a defence or another indignity. She appears in each part as a sentence in the front matter — the occasion, the reason we are here, the thing that started it.
>
> I have called that restraint, and it is partly that. Naming her would have put her name next to this material for a second time, which is exactly the harm Chapter Two is about.

> But look at the operation honestly. A group of men took a woman who had done something public, detached her from her own circumstances, and used her as material for a project of their own. Then I took the same woman, detached her from her own circumstances, and used her as material for a project of my own. The projects are not morally equivalent and I am not pretending they are. **The move is the same move.**
>
> And notice the specific form the erasure takes. I decided, on her behalf, that she would prefer not to be named. That is probably correct. It is also a judgement made about a woman, without her, by a man, in her interest as he assessed it — which is the exact structure this series has spent twelve parts describing in other people.
>
> **The general form:** the abstraction that protects and erases in the same motion. It runs through every field that studies people. The anonymised case study. The composite patient. The representative victim in a policy document. In each the anonymity is genuine protection and the person becomes an illustration of something else, and both happen with one gesture.
>
> I do not have a resolution. I am not going to name her, for the reason above. What I can do is stop pretending the choice was costless, and note that a series about who gets to decide things on a woman's behalf has been making one such decision on every cover page.

That is where this part ends. The next one stops arguing and goes looking for places where the experiment was actually run.

REMEMBER THIS

The case for restricting her is **coherent and evidence-based**: the threats are real, the remedies are slow and institutional, restriction is the only lever a parent actually holds, and he is not wrong about the penalty. Its conclusion is that she should have a smaller life than her brother.

Three answers exist and they are **addressed to three different people**: reduce her exposure (a parent, today), build the remedies (a state, over years), reduce the penalty (a community, with no timeline). The argument is incoherent because everyone pretends they are advice to the same person.

Only the third touches the weapon's value. **Takedowns remove ammunition. The penalty is the gun.**

The cheapest option for everybody else is the one whose entire cost lands on a girl — and that is not a coincidence. It is what cheapest means.

And this series began with a woman who was used as material for somebody's project. I have used her as material for mine, decided on her behalf that she would rather not be named, and put that decision on every cover.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Two lists, as in every part. What is genuinely unknown, with the reason it is unknown. And what is solid enough to build on. This is the shortest chapter and the most useful one.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

WHETHER OUTCOMES HAVE ACTUALLY GOT WORSE

This is the largest gap and it sits under everything. We know incidents are reported more. We do not know whether the number of women whose lives are materially damaged by reputational attack has risen, fallen or stayed flat since 2010. Reports rise when reporting gets easier, and reporting has got much easier. The reason we do not know: nobody measures outcomes, only incidents, and the two move for different reasons.

HOW COMMON ANY OF THIS IS IN INDIA

There is no Indian equivalent of the population surveys that give the one-in-twenty to one-in-ten figure for image-based abuse elsewhere. The crime statistics cannot supply it, for the reasons in Chapter Seven. The reason we do not know: the survey has never been commissioned, and it would be straightforward to add to instruments that already reach hundreds of thousands of households.

HOW MANY WOMEN HAVE PRIVATE USE OF A PHONE

We know roughly half of Indian women have a handset they themselves use. We have no national figure for how many have use of one that nobody else reads — which Chapter Three argued is where the autonomy actually lives. The reason we do not know: it is a one-line addition to an existing survey question and nobody has added it.

WHETHER SYNTHETIC AND GENUINE IMAGES CAUSE THE SAME DAMAGE

The reported distress looks similar, which is what the mechanism predicts. Nobody has compared outcomes — marriage, employment, family support — between women targeted with real material and women targeted with fabricated material. The reason we do not know: it would require identifying and following both groups, and both groups have overwhelming reasons not to be identified.

WHETHER IDENTITY REQUIREMENTS WOULD REDUCE THE HARM

Anonymity plainly increases casual cruelty. Whether removing it reduces the organised, community-sanctioned attacks that do the serious damage is untested, and the theory says it should not, because those attackers are not hiding from their own side. The reason we do not know: the natural experiment is available — a large platform introducing verification and measuring targeted harassment before and after — and no such analysis has been published.

THE SCALE OF THE COERCIVE SEXTORTION PATTERN

The financial pattern is measurable because victims report it. The coercive pattern is defined by nobody reporting it. Every number in this area therefore describes the version we can see. The reason we do not know: the crime's mechanism is silence, so reports can never measure it and only a general population survey could.

WHAT THE TWO-HOUR RULE ACTUALLY DOES

India's amended rules came into force in February 2026. Whether removal within two hours materially changes outcomes, or whether the copies made in the first two hours are sufficient for the damage, is an open empirical question with a clean answer available in a few years. The reason we do not know: it is too early, and this is the one item on this list where waiting will genuinely resolve it.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One item on that list is unknown for a reason worth stating on its own, because it recurs across this whole series.

Six of the seven gaps above could be closed by adding questions to surveys that already exist and already reach the right people. India runs a national health survey covering hundreds of thousands of households and asking about phone ownership, domestic violence and household decision-making. Adding “do you have private use of it” and “has anyone shared your private messages or images without permission” would cost almost nothing at the margin.

The instruments exist. The sampling exists. The field staff exist. What does not exist is the question.

Treat that the way Part Ten treated the honour-killing count and Chapter Seven treated the crime categories. **A statistical system that can measure something and does not has made a choice about what counts as a fact, and the choices keep landing in the same place.**

10.2 — Solid

THE THREE PROPERTIES OF REPUTATION BROKE, AND EACH WAS A REMEDY

A bounded audience, a fading memory and a known enforcer were not design features; they followed from physics. Their disappearance removed a family’s three options — wait, move, negotiate. This is descriptive and not seriously disputed by anyone.

PRACTICAL OBSCURITY IS GONE, AND NO LAW CHANGED

Information that was public but effectively unfindable is now findable by name in seconds. Every privacy rule stayed where it was; the friction that was doing the work disappeared.

ABOUT HALF OF INDIAN WOMEN HAVE A PHONE OF THEIR OWN

From the national health survey, with wide state variation, and around seven in ten of those able to read a text message. The question about control was not asked.

THE INPUT TO A FABRICATED IMAGE IS NOW AN ORDINARY PHOTOGRAPH

This is a technical fact and it is not contested. It means every piece of traditional advice about not creating material has been rendered inoperative, because the material no longer has to come from her.

FABRICATED MATERIAL IS TREATED AS EQUIVALENT IN LAW

Both India's 2026 rules and American federal law from May 2025 cover synthetic intimate imagery on the same footing as genuine. American law also states explicitly that consent to create an image, or to share it with one person, is not consent to publish it.

SEXTORTION HAS SPLIT INTO TWO PATTERNS WITH DIFFERENT TARGETS AND DIFFERENT DEMANDS

Girls extorted for further images and compliance; boys extorted for money. Around nine in ten victims of the financial pattern are boys aged fourteen to seventeen, with reports arriving at more than eight hundred a week in the United States. This comes from a large body of contemporaneous reports to a national clearing house.

THE DEMAND DIFFERS BECAUSE THE PENALTY DIFFERS

A threat that depreciates in days must be cashed immediately; one that does not expire is kept and redeemed. This follows from the reported patterns rather than from theory, and it is the cleanest measurement of the double standard produced anywhere in this series.

INDIA'S CRIME STATISTICS CANNOT SEE THIS CATEGORY

Around two-thirds of recorded cyber offences are financial fraud; stalking and bullying together account for roughly ten thousand seven hundred recorded cases in a country of 1.4 billion, and there is no category that fits a coordinated attack by four hundred accounts. The chargesheet rate across cybercrime is under a third.

THE TAKEDOWN REGIMES REMOVE FILES AND NOT BELIEFS

This is not a criticism of their drafting. It is the boundary of what any obligation placed on intermediaries can reach, and it follows directly from the fact that the disclosure is the trigger and the community response is the mechanism.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: whether outcomes have actually worsened rather than reports rising; how common any of this is in India; how many women have private use of a phone; whether fabricated material damages as much as genuine; whether identity requirements would help; the scale of coercive sextortion; and what the two-hour rule will do.

Solid: the three properties of reputation broke and each was a remedy; practical obscurity ended without any law changing; about half of Indian women have their own handset; a fabricated image now needs only an ordinary photograph; law now treats fabricated and genuine alike; sextortion has split into two patterns whose demands are priced by the penalty; India's crime statistics have no category for this; and takedown removes files rather than beliefs.

Six of the seven gaps could be closed by adding two questions to a survey that already reaches hundreds of thousands of Indian households. The instruments exist and the question does not.

The honest summary of this part: the machinery is genuinely new, the judgement it delivers is genuinely old, and every remedy anyone has built so far operates on the machinery.

Timeline

From the first camera phone to the two-hour takedown, with the Indian legal thread running alongside.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2000	India's Information Technology Act establishes safe harbour: a platform is not liable for what its users post, provided it meets certain conditions. Every later fight is about what those conditions are.
2000–02	Camera phones reach the mass market. For the first time, most people carry a device that can create a permanent image of anyone at any moment.
2009	India's amended IT Act comes into force, adding specific offences for capturing or publishing images of a person's private areas without consent, and for transmitting sexually explicit material electronically.
2013	Following the Delhi gang rape and the national response to it, India's criminal law is amended to make voyeurism and stalking specific offences, with stalking defined to include monitoring a woman's use of the internet.
2013–14	The first American state laws against non-consensual distribution of intimate images. The term "revenge porn" enters general use, and researchers begin arguing against it.
2016	Mobile data prices in India collapse and smartphone use spreads rapidly beyond the cities. In the same period, village councils in several states ban unmarried girls from using mobile phones.
2017	India's Supreme Court holds unanimously that privacy is a fundamental right, creating the constitutional basis for everything that follows — including, eventually, arguments for removal of outdated information.
2019	An early count of synthetic video circulating online finds that the overwhelming majority of it is non-consensual sexual imagery, almost entirely of women. The first mass application of the technology was not political.
2021	India notifies the Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code Rules. In July, an application appears on a public code-hosting service purporting to "auction" named Indian Muslim women using photographs taken from their own accounts.
2022	A second, larger version of the same application appears in January. Arrests follow. No intimate images were involved in either: the mechanism was entirely the framing.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2023	A manipulated video of a well-known Indian actor circulates very widely, prompting government advisories to platforms. India passes its data protection act, and replaces the colonial-era penal code. A joint analysis of American reports documents the financial sextortion pattern and its overwhelmingly male teenage victims.
2024	India's crime statistics for the year — published in 2026 — record cybercrime cases crossing one lakh for the first time, alongside more than four and a half lakh recorded crimes against women.
2025	American federal law criminalises publishing or threatening to publish non-consensual intimate images, including fabricated ones, and states that consent to create or to share privately is not consent to publish. Platforms are given a year to build removal processes.
2026	India notifies amended intermediary rules on 10 February, in force from 20 February: synthetically generated information defined in law for the first time, mandatory labelling and traceability, and a **two-hour** deadline for acting on non-consensual intimate images. In March, draft further amendments propose extending the ethics framework to individual users posting on news and current affairs.
Next	**Part Thirteen starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Brigading	A coordinated attack in which a group targets one person at the same time. Each message may break no rule; the harm is produced by the volume.
Financial sextortion	The pattern in which an offender obtains an intimate image and demands money quickly, rather than further images. Victims are overwhelmingly teenage boys.
Handset sharing	One phone used by several people in a household, usually owned nominally by the male head. Access without private control.
Hash matching	Computing a short fingerprint from an image so platforms can block that exact image without ever holding a copy of it. The image never leaves the owner's device.
Intermediary	Any service that stores or transmits something on someone else's behalf — a platform, a messaging app, a host, a search engine. Almost all online regulation works by imposing duties on these.
Izzat	Usually translated as honour; closer to standing. A household's collective public credit, which determines the marriages it can arrange.
The liar's dividend	The advantage that convincing fakes give to a person caught by genuine evidence, because any real recording can now be dismissed as fabricated.
NCII	Non-consensual intimate imagery. Also called image-based sexual abuse. Preferred to "revenge porn", which names one motive and implies material made for an audience.
NCRB	India's National Crime Records Bureau, which compiles crime statistics from police records nationally and publishes them each year.
Practical obscurity	Information that is technically public but effectively hidden because finding it takes real effort. Most of the privacy people used to have was this rather than law.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Safe harbour	The rule that a platform is not liable for user content provided it meets certain conditions. Every content regulation fight is a fight about the conditions.
Sextortion	Threatening to distribute a person’s intimate images unless they comply with a demand. The image is not the product; the threat is.
Synthetically generated information	India’s legal term, adopted in February 2026, for any audio, image or video created or altered by an algorithm so that it appears real. Broader than “deepfake”, which had come to mean video.
Traceability	A requirement that platforms be able to identify who originated a piece of content. Presented as a tool against anonymous abuse; the same capability identifies any source.

About the Author

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This part is the one I have been circling since the beginning, because the incident that started the series was an online attack. Twelve parts of research later, the finding that surprised me most is in Chapter Six, and it was produced by criminals rather than by researchers: two sets of extortionists, working independently, have priced the difference between what a community will do to a boy and what it will do to a girl. Their estimate is more precise than any survey in this series.

I am not a lawyer, a technologist by training, or a criminologist. I read the primary sources carefully, follow the numbers wherever they go, and write down what I find in language that does not need a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — Indian government notifications and Supreme Court judgments, American federal legislation, national crime statistics, national health survey data, and analyses published by child-protection and anti-abuse organisations — rather than new primary research.

What that archive is good at: law and administrative fact. A gazette notification says what it says, and a statute's text is not in dispute.

What it is bad at, and this is unusually serious here: **almost everything about prevalence**. The crime statistics are built around financial loss and cannot see the category this part is about. The population surveys that exist elsewhere have no Indian equivalent. Where I have described a pattern from helpline reports or journalism, I have said so and said what that evidence cannot establish, rather than letting it stand in for a number.

One further caution, which I put in the front matter and repeat here. The legal material in Chapter Eight is a snapshot of early 2026 and will date faster than anything else in this series. The mechanisms underneath it will not.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Twelve parts of argument, and every one of them has run into the same wall: you cannot run the experiment. You cannot assign women to different rules and see what happens. Part Thirteen goes looking for the places where history ran it anyway.

The questions it takes on:

- Where has a society changed its rules about women sharply enough, and fast enough, that the before and after can actually be compared — and what happened to the outcomes this series has been arguing about?
- What can be learned from places divided by a line rather than by a century: two halves of the same population, same language, same ancestry, different rules, measurable difference?
- Which of the traditionalist's predictions have already been tested by events, and how did they do — counted honestly, including the ones that came out in their favour?
- What happened in the societies that moved fastest, and what happened to the generation of women who lived across the change rather than on one side of it?
- Where did a reform produce the opposite of what it intended, and why — because those cases are worth more than the successes?
- And the question that decides how much any of this is worth: when history runs an experiment, how much can we actually learn from it, and where does a natural experiment stop being evidence and start being a story we tell about a difference we noticed?

END OF PART TWELVE OF SIXTEEN

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THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART THIRTEEN OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Thirteen — When History Ran the Experiment

Twelve parts have ended at the same wall: you cannot assign women to different rules and see what happens. But history has assigned them, repeatedly, and sometimes almost cleanly. This part goes and looks at the results.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Twelve was about enforcement in a world where the community stopped having edges. Reputation, it turned out, was never a feeling — it was a working technology with three properties that followed from physics rather than from anyone's choice: a bounded audience, a fading memory, and an enforcer with a return address. Those three were also a family's three remedies. You could wait, you could move, or you could negotiate. All three broke at once and nothing replaced them.

The finding I did not expect came from Chapter Six, and criminals produced it rather than researchers. Sextortion has split into two patterns. Girls are extorted for further images and for compliance; boys are extorted for money, fast. The reason is that a threat against a boy loses its value within days while a threat against a girl in a strict community never expires. Two sets of extortionists, working independently and with no interest in the question, have therefore priced the difference between what a community will do to a son and what it will do to a daughter. Their estimate is the most precise measurement in this entire series.

And Part Twelve ended where every part has ended: with a mechanism identified, a remedy that reaches the wrong layer, and no way to test the counterfactual.

That is the wall. Thirteen parts of argument and I have said some version of the same sentence in every one of them — *the experiment cannot be run*. You cannot assign a thousand women to strict rules and a thousand to loose ones and come back in thirty years. No review board would approve it and no researcher would propose it.

But history has done it. Repeatedly. Sometimes almost cleanly.

Countries have reversed their rules overnight. Populations have been cut in half by a line on a map and governed differently for forty years. Constraints that stood for centuries have been lifted in a single announcement. And in one case — the best evidence in this entire series, and it is Indian — a government actually randomised.

This part is the payoff. It is also the part where I have to be most careful, because a natural experiment is the easiest kind of evidence to abuse, and Chapter One is about how.

How this document is built

Six kinds of box, each doing one job, each looking different so you can see at a glance what you are about to read.

The first explains a hard word the moment it appears.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Counterfactual:** what would have happened otherwise. The thing you are always comparing against and can never observe.
>
> If a country changes its rules and something happens afterwards, the question is not what happened. It is what would have happened without the change. That world does not exist, so every claim in this part is an argument about an imaginary place, and the whole craft consists of finding the least imaginary substitute.

The second takes a number too big or too abstract to picture and gives it a body.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> "A country's economic output fell by half a per cent." That sounds like a rounding error in a budget document.
>
> For Afghanistan it means that the goods and services the country produces in about two days of every year have simply stopped existing, permanently, every year, and the reason is that girls are not allowed past the sixth grade.

The third shows the actual evidence and then says what it cannot show. In this part it does more work than anywhere else in the series.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

There is a hierarchy of evidence in this part and it is worth stating up front, because the cases are not equally good.

Strongest: a genuine randomisation, where who got the change was decided by something with no connection to the outcome. There is exactly one of these in this series and it is in Chapter Two.

Strong: a sharp change in one place with a genuinely similar place alongside it that did not change.

Moderate: a sharp before-and-after in one place, with the trend beforehand visible so you can see whether the line bent.

Weak, and very common: two countries that differ, compared after the fact, with a story attached.

Almost everything quoted in public argument about women is the fourth kind. This part is organised so you can always tell which kind you are reading.

The fourth is for places where informed people genuinely disagree. Each side gets its best case.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not claim more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes the honest answer is that nothing available would.

The fifth is the signature of this series. It digs out what both sides are assuming without noticing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Not caveats. Unexamined premises sitting underneath an argument everybody is having. There are five in this part, and the last one is turned on the way I built this part.

The sixth closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

REMEMBER THIS

Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.

Simple words, serious content, nothing left out.

Three warnings specific to this part

The first is about how easy this material is to abuse. Case studies are the most persuasive and least reliable form of evidence there is. A vivid country comparison will convince a reader of almost anything, and both sides of this argument have a favourite one they deploy as though it settled the matter. I have tried to include the cases that cut against me as carefully as the ones that do not, and Chapter Eight exists specifically to count the places where the traditionalist forecast was right. If that chapter reads as grudging, I have failed at it.

The second is about live events. Chapter Five is about Afghanistan, where the experiment is running now. Almost everything published about its consequences is a *projection* — a model of what will happen, not a measurement of what has. I have marked every one of those, because the difference between "maternal deaths rose by half" and "maternal deaths are projected to rise by half" is the difference between evidence and a forecast, and the reporting collapses it constantly.

The third is about me, and it belongs at the front rather than buried in Chapter Nine. Nobody handed me a list of natural experiments. I chose them. That is a serious problem for a part whose first chapter warns about choosing cases, and I have not solved it — I have only made it visible. The last Hidden Assumption box in this part is about exactly that, and it is the most uncomfortable thing I have written in thirteen parts.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

What a Natural Experiment Is

> *The whole value of this part depends on knowing which comparisons are worth something and which are stories. The rule turns out to be simple, and it disqualifies almost everything you have ever seen quoted.*

1.1 — Why a coin toss is worth more than a country

Suppose you want to know whether a medicine works. You could give it to a hundred people and see how they do. But the people who took it chose to take it, or a doctor chose for them, and those choices track everything else about them — how ill they were, how much money they had, whether they follow instructions.

So instead you toss a coin. Heads gets the medicine, tails does not. Now the two groups differ in exactly one respect and every other difference has been scrambled by the coin, including the differences nobody thought to measure.

That last clause is the entire magic of it. Statistical control can only remove factors you know about and measured. Randomisation removes the ones you never thought of, for free.

WORD BOX

Natural experiment: a situation in the real world where something outside the researcher's control assigned people to different conditions in a way that had nothing to do with the outcome being studied.

The word "natural" means nobody arranged it as research. A war, a border, a law passed on a particular date, a lottery for a permit. The value comes from the assignment being **unrelated to the thing you want to measure**, not from it being accidental.

Why it matters: a good natural experiment gets you close to the coin toss without the coin. A bad one is two countries that differ, with a story attached.

1.2 — The checklist

Six questions separate the good ones from the stories. I will apply them to every case in this part, and you should apply them to every case anybody quotes at you afterwards.

One. Was the assignment unrelated to the outcome? If a country liberalised its laws because women were already gaining ground, then the law did not cause what followed — the same underlying change caused both.

Two. Is there a comparison group? Before-and-after in one place tells you what happened next, which is not the same as what the change did.

Three. Were the two sides on the same path beforehand? If the lines were already diverging before the change, the change is not what separated them.

Four. Was the change sharp in time? A reform that arrived over twenty years cannot be distinguished from anything else that happened over those twenty years.

Five. Did the change come alone? A revolution alters a thousand things at once. Whatever follows, you cannot attribute it to any one of them.

Six. Is the outcome measured the same way on both sides? Two countries counting "employment" or "violence" differently will show a difference that exists only in the definitions.

IN REAL TERMS

Run those six on the comparison people reach for most often — "look at Sweden and look at Afghanistan."

Was the assignment unrelated to the outcome? No: Sweden is not governed differently by accident. Same path beforehand? They were never on the same path. Sharp in time? Neither change was. Did it come alone? Everything else about the two countries also differs — income, climate, history, war, oil, geography, religion, colonialism, literacy in 1900.

That comparison fails five of the six tests and it is the single most-quoted piece of evidence in this entire argument, by both sides. It establishes that two very different countries are very different, which we knew.

1.3 — What history can supply

Having disqualified the easy comparisons, what is left is genuinely useful, and there is more of it than people expect. Four kinds turn up repeatedly.

A line drawn through one people. Germany divided, Korea divided. Same language, same ancestry, same starting point, different rules, forty years. This is as close as political history comes to a laboratory, and Chapter Three is about how close that actually is.

An abrupt reversal. A society that was moving one way is turned round in a year by a change of regime. Iran is the cleanest example on Earth and Chapter Four is entirely about it.

A constraint lifted. One specific thing that was forbidden becomes permitted, on a known date, with everything else roughly unchanged. Saudi Arabia's driving ban is nearly ideal on the checklist.

A rule applied by lottery. Rare, precious, and India has one.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN HISTORY SUBSTITUTE FOR AN EXPERIMENT AT ALL?

Some people think this whole enterprise is a category error. That is a serious position and the case for it is strong.

IT CANNOT, AND THE PRETENCE IS WORSE THAN NOTHING

Societies are not laboratories and the differences between them are not noise to be scrubbed out — they are the substance. Every "natural experiment" involving whole countries fails at least one of the six tests, usually the fifth: revolutions, wars and reforms change everything simultaneously and there is no honest way to isolate one strand. Worse, the method launders an argument. A researcher picks two places, finds a difference, and the machinery of comparison gives a hunch the appearance of a finding. If you want to know about human societies, read history properly rather than dressing it up as data.

IT IS IMPERFECT AND IT IS WHAT WE HAVE, AND IMPERFECT BEATS NOTHING

The alternative to flawed evidence is not perfect evidence; it is opinion, tradition and confident assertion — which is exactly what filled this space for three thousand years. The checklist above is not a rubber stamp; it disqualifies most of what gets quoted, including things people on my side of the argument like. And some cases genuinely do pass: a lottery is a lottery, a border is a border, and a driving ban lifted on a Sunday is a sharp change in one variable. Rejecting the method wholesale means having no way to be surprised, and being surprised is the only thing that distinguishes inquiry from advocacy.

Where things stand: the honest position is graded rather than binary. The randomised case in Chapter Two is real evidence by any standard, and nobody serious disputes it. The border comparisons are strong but contaminated. The revolutions are vivid and weak. What is not defensible is treating all four as the same kind of thing, which is what public argument does constantly and in both directions.

What would settle it: nothing, because this is a dispute about method rather than fact. But it can be made honest: state which tier of evidence each case belongs to before drawing anything from it, which is what the front matter of this part does.

Why people care so much: because a vivid country comparison is the most persuasive rhetorical object available and everyone has one. Grading the evidence takes almost everybody's favourite argument away.

There is a deeper problem than any of the six tests, and it applies to this document rather than to the cases in it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT A DIFFERENCE WE NOTICED IS AN EXPERIMENT

Every case in this part, and every case anybody cites in this argument, arrived the same way: **somebody noticed it.** Iran is famous because the reversal was dramatic. Germany is famous because the division was total. Saudi Arabia is famous because the change was sudden and recent.

Now ask what kind of case never becomes famous. The one where a society changed its rules and nothing measurable happened. There is no book about that. No researcher builds a career on it, no newspaper reports it, and it does not become an example anybody quotes — because a null result is not a story.

> So the set of natural experiments available to any writer is not a sample of what happens when rules change. It is a sample of **the occasions on which something visible happened**. That is selection on the outcome, and it is the oldest error in empirical work.
>
> The consequence is specific and it cuts against both sides equally. If the rules about women mostly do not matter much, we would still expect a handful of dramatic cases where they appeared to, and those cases would be the famous ones, and everybody would argue using them. The world in which rules matter enormously and the world in which they mostly do not **look identical from inside a list of famous examples**.
>
> **The general form:** sampling on the outcome and calling it evidence. It runs through everything built on cases. Successful founders studied for their habits, with the identical habits of the failures unrecorded. Cures credited to a remedy, with the people it did not cure not writing in. Historical lessons drawn from the wars that were decisive.
>
> There is a partial defence and it is worth naming because it is what this part relies on. Where a case includes a proper comparison group — a border, a lottery, a neighbouring district — the null results are inside the study rather than missing from it. Those cases survive this problem. The vivid single-country reversals do not, and they are the ones everybody quotes.

With that grading in hand, the rest of this part can be read for what each case is worth rather than for how vivid it is. We start with the only one that needs no grading at all.

REMEMBER THIS

The value of a coin toss is not fairness. It is that randomising removes the differences **nobody thought to measure**. Statistical control can only remove the ones you knew about.

A **natural experiment** is a real-world situation where something outside anyone's control assigned people to different conditions for reasons unrelated to the outcome.

Six tests: was assignment unrelated to the outcome, is there a comparison group, were the two on the same path before, was the change sharp, did it come alone, and is the outcome measured the same way on both sides.

"Look at Sweden, look at Afghanistan" **fails five of the six**, and it is the most-quoted evidence in this argument by both sides.

And the deepest problem is that these cases became famous because something visible happened. A world where the rules matter enormously and a world where they mostly do not look identical from inside a list of famous examples.

CHAPTER TWO

The One Time Somebody Randomised

The best evidence in this entire series comes from Indian village councils, and it exists because a constitutional amendment accidentally built a lottery. It is the only case here that passes all six tests.

2.1 — The accident in the amendment

In 1993 India amended its constitution to devolve power to village councils, and wrote in a requirement that one-third of council seats — and one-third of the council leader positions — be reserved for women.

The reservation itself is well known. What matters here is the mechanism used to decide **which** villages got a reserved leadership in any given election. Rather than letting states choose, the rule rotated the reservation through villages by serial number.

A village's serial number has nothing to do with how progressive it is, how rich it is, how its women live, or anything else. So the question of whether a village would be led by a woman was decided by something completely unrelated to the outcomes anyone wanted to study.

That is a lottery. Nobody intended it as one. It is the closest thing to a coin toss that exists anywhere in this argument.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Run the six tests from Chapter One on this case.

Assignment unrelated to outcome? Yes — serial number rotation. **Comparison group?** Yes — the two-thirds of villages not reserved that cycle, in the same district, under the same state government, at the same moment. **Same path beforehand?** Yes, and it can be checked directly. **Sharp in time?** Yes, one election. **Change came alone?** Yes — this is the crucial one, and it is why this case is worth more than every revolution in this part. Nothing else about those villages changed. **Measured the same way?** Yes; the same survey teams visited both.

Six out of six. I am not aware of another case in this entire subject that manages it.

What it still cannot do: it tells you about villages where a woman held a specific office for one or two terms. It does not tell you about a country, a religion, or a norm.

2.2 — What changed

Three findings came out of this, from a series of studies through the 2000s and 2010s, and they get progressively more interesting.

First: women in charge governed differently. Researchers compared what village councils actually spent money on. In reserved villages, investment shifted towards the things women in those villages complained about most in surveys — drinking water in particular, and in some states roads. Not towards what women in general are assumed to want. Towards what the women there had actually said.

That is a smaller and better finding than it sounds. It does not show that women are better leaders. It shows that leaders respond to the constituency they belong to, which is a claim about representation rather than about women.

Second: exposure changed what villagers believed. This is the one that surprised the researchers. Villagers in reserved villages were tested on their evaluations of leaders, including hypothetical ones. Before exposure, a speech attributed to a woman was rated worse than the identical speech attributed to a man. After two rounds of having a female leader, that gap shrank substantially — and women became more likely to stand for, and win, seats in later elections that were *not* reserved.

Two things there are worth separating. Bias against women leaders was measurable and real. And it was not fixed: it responded to experience within a few years.

WORD BOX

Implicit bias: an automatic association that shapes judgement without the person intending it or noticing it. Measured here by giving people identical material attributed to a man or a woman and comparing the ratings.

Why the design matters: nobody is asked what they think about women leaders, which would produce the answer they think is expected. They are asked to rate a speech. The difference between the two ratings is the bias, and the person rating it never knows they are being measured on that.

Third, and this is the finding that belongs to this series: the gap between what parents wanted for their sons and what they wanted for their daughters narrowed. So did the gap between what adolescent boys and adolescent girls wanted for themselves. The gender gap in school attendance in those villages closed, and girls spent measurably less time on household chores.

The reported sizes were substantial: roughly a quarter of the parental aspiration gap and about a third of the adolescents' own aspiration gap, closed within about seven years, by nothing more than the presence of a woman running the village council.

IN REAL TERMS

Think about what that mechanism actually is. No law changed for those girls. No school was built for them specifically. Nobody gave their families money or lectured them about equality.

A woman was in the chair at the village meeting. Their fathers saw her there. They saw her there.

And within seven years, a third of the distance between what a boy in that village expected from his life and what a girl expected from hers had closed.

That is the cheapest intervention in this entire series, it was produced by an administrative rotation rule, and nobody designed it to do this.

2.3 — What it does not show

Now the honest limits, because this is the evidence I most want to be true and that is exactly when to be careful.

It is about **political office**. Whether the same mechanism operates on marriage, sexual conduct, dress or mobility — the domains this series is actually about — is not established by any of it. Those norms may be far stickier, and Parts Three and Eight gave reasons to expect they are.

The attitude effects mostly required **two rounds**. One term of a female leader did much less. Whatever is happening needs repetition, which means short interventions may show nothing and be wrongly judged failures.

Some of the findings are uncomfortable in their own right. Villagers in reserved villages often rated their female leader's actual performance *worse* even where objective measures were equal or better. Exposure reduced bias about women in the abstract while the specific woman in front of them was still marked down.

And the effects were measured over roughly a decade. Whether they persist across a generation is not known, because not enough time has passed.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THIS GENERALISE?

Everybody accepts the findings. The dispute is entirely about what they license.

IT GENERALISES, AND IT IS THE STRONGEST THING ANYBODY HAS

The mechanism identified is not about panchayats. It is about what happens when people repeatedly observe a woman doing something they believed women do not do. That mechanism is general by construction, and it is the same one invoked in every argument about representation in every field. Crucially, it settles a question this series has been stuck on since Part One: whether the beliefs underneath these rules are fixed features of a society or responsive to evidence. They are responsive, measurably, within seven years, in rural north India — which is about the least promising place anyone could have picked to test it.

IT GENERALISES MUCH LESS FAR THAN PEOPLE WANT

Holding a village office is a low-cost belief to revise. It costs a father nothing to accept that a woman can run a council. It costs him a great deal to accept that his daughter may choose her own husband, because that touches property, lineage, caste and his family's standing — which is exactly the machinery Part Eight described. Norms are not one substance with one stickiness; the ones this series is about are the ones defended hardest. And a study of leadership in a state-created institution says nothing about a domain governed by families rather than by law.

Where things stand: the finding is solid and its reach is genuinely uncertain. What it establishes beyond dispute is that **bias is not fixed** — that a belief about what women can do responded to observation, in a conservative setting, within a decade. What it does not establish is that beliefs about what women may do respond the same way. The second is the harder case and it has not been tested, because nobody has randomised it and nobody will.

What would settle it: a comparable randomisation in a domain closer to this series — reserved positions, or a similar rotation, in an institution touching marriage or property, with aspiration and attitude measured the same way. India's own reservation system generates natural variation of this kind that has never been fully exploited.

Why people care so much: because if beliefs are responsive, then the whole argument is about how to change them and the answer is exposure. If they are not, the argument is about coexistence with something that will not move. Almost everybody's position on the rest of this series depends on which one they assume.

Whichever way that generalises, one thing about this case is settled: it is the only piece of evidence in thirteen parts that came from a lottery. Everything after this chapter is weaker, and the next case is the strongest of what remains.

REMEMBER THIS

India's 1993 constitutional amendment reserved a third of village council leaderships for women and rotated them by **village serial number —** which is unrelated to anything about the village. That is a lottery nobody intended.

It is the **only case in this series that passes all six tests**, and it passes the hardest one: nothing else about those villages changed.

Three findings. Women in charge **spent differently**, on what the women there had actually asked for. **Bias fell** after two rounds of exposure, and more women then won unreserved seats. And the gap between what parents wanted for sons and for daughters **narrowed by about a quarter**, with the adolescents' own gap narrowing by about a third.

No law changed for those girls. A woman was in the chair at the village meeting, and their fathers saw her there.

What this establishes beyond dispute is that bias is not fixed. What it does not establish is that beliefs about what women may do move as easily as beliefs about what women can do — and the second is the one this series is about.

CHAPTER THREE

Two Halves of One People

> *One nation, one language, one ancestry, cut in half and governed on opposite principles for forty years. It is the closest thing political history offers to a laboratory, and it fails one of the six tests in a way that matters.*

3.1 — Two answers to the same question

Between 1949 and 1990 the same people, in the same country, were run according to two opposite theories about what women are for. That has never happened anywhere else at that scale with that much record-keeping.

In the East, women worked. Not as an aspiration — as a near-universal fact. By the 1980s the overwhelming majority of working-age East German women were in employment or training. The state supplied childcare from infancy, kept it open through the working day, and treated a mother's employment as normal rather than as a problem to be managed.

In the West, the arrangement was the opposite and it was written into law. Until a reform in 1977, a West German husband could legally object to his wife taking paid work. The tax system rewarded households with a single earner. And the school day ended around lunchtime, which by itself made full-time work by a mother close to impossible without private money.

WORD BOX

The male-breadwinner model: a set of arrangements built on the assumption that a household has one earner, who is the husband, and one person doing the unpaid work, who is the wife.

Why it matters that it is a **model** rather than a preference: it is assembled from separate pieces — tax rules, school hours, childcare availability, pension credits, shop opening times — none of which mentions women. Each looks like an administrative detail. Together they make one arrangement easy and the other one exhausting, and nobody has to forbid anything.

3.2 — What the comparison showed

The differences were large and they were exactly what you would predict. East German women were employed at far higher rates, worked full-time far more often, had children younger, and had them while working rather than instead of working. The pay gap between men and women was narrower in the East.

Then in 1990 the border came down, and the East was absorbed into West German institutions almost overnight — West German law, West German tax rules, West German childcare provision, West German school hours.

What happened next is the most useful thing in the case.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> East German fertility collapsed. The rate fell from roughly 1.5 to 1.6 children per woman before reunification to **below 0.8** within about four years.
>
> To put that in the terms of Part Nine: a fall of that size, that fast, in a large population at peace, has essentially no precedent. It is steeper than anything Korea has done, and Korea took thirty years to get where East Germany went in four.
>
> Then it recovered, and by the late 2000s eastern and western German fertility had converged.
>
> **Nothing happened to East German women's bodies in 1990. Something happened to the arrangements around them, and their children stopped being born.**

Reading a change of that size correctly requires one technique, and it is the standard tool for every case in this part.

WORD BOX

Difference-in-differences: the standard method for reading a case like this. You do not compare East and West at one moment. You compare how much each changed, and take the difference between the two changes.

Why it is better than a before-and-after: if something happened to all of Germany in 1990 — and a great deal did — it affects both sides, and subtracting one from the other removes it.

Why it is not magic: it only works if the two sides would have carried on in parallel without the change. That assumption cannot be tested directly, only made plausible by showing the lines were parallel beforehand.

3.3 — What lasted

The other finding is about persistence, and it is the one that speaks to this series.

Decades after reunification — long after the East German state, its childcare system and its ideology had all ceased to exist — women who had grown up in the East were still markedly more likely to work full-time, more likely to use childcare for very young children, and more likely to hold the view that a mother's employment does not damage her children. Those differences narrowed with time but did not disappear.

So a set of arrangements that lasted forty years produced beliefs that outlived the arrangements by another thirty. That is a real measurement of how sticky this material is, and it cuts in both directions: it means norms can be changed by institutions, and it means the change is not quick to reverse in either direction.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT ACTUALLY CAUSED THE FERTILITY COLLAPSE?

The collapse is not disputed. Its cause is, and the answer matters because it is the cleanest test anyone has of whether family arrangements are about preferences or about infrastructure.

THE ECONOMIC SHOCK DID IT

Reunification devastated the eastern economy. Unemployment went from essentially nil to enormous within two years, whole industries closed, and hundreds of thousands of young people moved west. People do not have children during a collapse of that kind, and every other case of sudden economic catastrophe produces a fertility drop. The recovery afterwards is the proof: as the eastern economy stabilised, births returned. Nothing about childcare policy is needed to explain any of it.

THE INSTITUTIONS DID IT

The economic explanation cannot account for the size. Ordinary recessions move fertility by a tenth of a child, not by half. What changed for an East German woman in 1990 was not only her job prospects: it was that the crèche closed, the school day ended at noon, the tax system started penalising her earnings, and having a child stopped being compatible with working — all at once, imposed from outside, with no adjustment period. The postponement was rational because the entire arrangement that had made early childbearing workable was removed in a single year.

Where things stand: both, and demographers have largely converged on a mixed account — a severe economic shock arriving simultaneously with an institutional one, which is precisely why the case fails the fifth test from Chapter One. The change did not come alone. What can be said with confidence is that the collapse was far too large for the economic shock alone, and that the recovery tracked both stabilisation and the gradual rebuilding of childcare in the east.

What would settle it: a case where one arrived without the other — an institutional change of that magnitude without an economic shock. Nothing comparable exists, which is why this remains open thirty-five years later.

Why people care so much: because if arrangements determine fertility to that degree, then Part Nine's conclusion — that no country has policied its way back to replacement — becomes a statement about what has been tried rather than about what is possible.

3.4 — The other divided nation

Korea is the obvious companion case and I am going to be brief about it, for a reason that is itself informative.

The two Koreas separated in 1945 with a shared language, culture and Confucian family structure, and have been governed on opposite principles ever since. It should be as valuable as Germany. It is not usable, because there is no reliable data on the northern side — no credible census, no independent survey, no verifiable statistics on employment, education or fertility.

So the best available comparison on that peninsula is not between two Koreas. It is between South Korea and its own past, which is a before-and-after in one place, which fails the second test.

That is worth stating rather than skipping, because it illustrates something about this whole field: **the availability of evidence is not random either.** We know about divided Germany because both halves kept records and both halves let people count. The cases where a society is most tightly controlled are the cases where least is known, and those are exactly the cases this series most needs.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE CONTROL GROUP STAYED STILL

Everybody who uses this comparison — and every comparison like it — talks as though one side were the treatment and the other the baseline. East Germany did something to women; West Germany is what would have happened otherwise.

West Germany was not a baseline. It was also a treatment, and an unusually strong one. A legal power for a husband to forbid his wife's employment until 1977 is not the absence of a policy about women. A tax system that penalises a second earner is not neutrality. A school day ending at noon is a decision. The West ran an active programme to keep married women at home, and it ran it through administrative details rather than announcements, which is why it reads as the natural state of things and the Eastern arrangement reads as an intervention.

This matters for reading the numbers. When the two sides converged after 1990, that was widely described as the East becoming normal. Both were moving. Western German women's employment rose enormously across the same decades, driven by changes with nothing to do with the East.

> **The general form:** mistaking a comparison for a counterfactual. It runs through every A-versus-B argument. Comparing a reformed country to an unreformed one and calling the second the baseline, when the second is running its own vigorous programme. Comparing a treated patient to an untreated one who is also doing something.
>
> And notice which side gets called the intervention. It is always the one that departs from what the observer regards as ordinary — which means the label is doing the work of an argument before any evidence arrives. In this series that matters more than usual, because the whole question is whether the traditional arrangement is a policy or the absence of one.

Which is the right frame for the next case, where a state did announce what it was doing, loudly, and got the opposite of what it announced.

REMEMBER THIS

Divided Germany is the closest thing to a laboratory this subject has: **one people, two opposite theories, forty years, good records on both sides.**

East German women worked at near-universal rates with state childcare from infancy. West Germany ran a **male-breadwinner model** assembled from tax rules, school hours and — until 1977 — a husband's legal power to forbid his wife's job.

After reunification, East German fertility fell from about 1.5 to **below 0.8 in four years**, one of the sharpest peacetime collapses ever recorded, then recovered. The cause was both an economic shock and the removal of every arrangement that made children compatible with work — which is why the case fails the "change came alone" test.

The attitudes **outlived the state that produced them by thirty years.** Institutions can change norms, and the change is slow to reverse in either direction.

And West Germany was never a control. It ran its own vigorous programme through administrative details rather than announcements — which is exactly why it reads as the natural state of things.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Reversal

> *One country reversed its rules about women almost completely, in a year, in living memory. The traditionalists won the rules and lost the outcomes, and the reason why is the most interesting thing in this part.*

4.1 — What was reversed

Before 1979, Iran was on the standard modernising path. A family law passed in the 1960s and strengthened in the 1970s had raised the age of marriage, restricted polygamy, given women grounds for divorce and moved family disputes into courts. Women sat as judges. Unveiling had been enforced, briefly and brutally, decades earlier.

After the revolution, that was undone, quickly and comprehensively. The family law was suspended. The minimum age of marriage was lowered dramatically. Women were removed from the judiciary. Veiling became compulsory and was enforced by law. Public space and education were segregated by sex.

If the rules about women determine the outcomes for women, this is the case where you would expect to see it. A society moving one way was turned round completely, at a known moment, and held there for four decades. So what happened?

4.2 — What happened

Female education exploded. Female literacy in Iran was around a third in the mid-1970s. By the 2000s it was above eighty per cent, and among younger women it approached universal. Girls' primary enrolment became near-total. And by the turn of the millennium women were a *majority* of those entering Iranian universities — a threshold most Western countries crossed at around the same time or later.

Fertility collapsed. Iran went from roughly six and a half children per woman in the early 1980s to about two by the year 2000, and is now somewhere around 1.6. Part Nine called this the fastest sustained fertility decline ever recorded for a large country, and it happened under a theocracy that had begun by encouraging large families.

And women's paid employment did not move. Female labour force participation in Iran has stayed low — in the mid-teens as a percentage — through the whole period. A country produced a generation of highly educated women and did not employ them.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Take an Iranian family in a village in 1975. The mother cannot read. There are seven children. The daughters will marry at fifteen or sixteen and will not go to secondary school.
>
> Take her granddaughter in 2015. She has one or two siblings. She finished school and probably went to university. She is very likely unemployed, and she wears a headscarf she is legally required to wear.
>
> **Every rule about her conduct is stricter than her grandmother's. Almost every fact about her life is the one the reformers wanted and the traditionalists warned against.**

4.3 — Why the rules did not deliver

Three explanations, and they are not rivals — all three appear to have operated.

The regime built the machinery of the thing it feared. The Islamic Republic ran an enormous rural development programme: roads, electricity, clinics, and a national literacy campaign. Part Three of this series identified exactly those as the drivers of fertility decline — children stop dying, schooling spreads, cities grow. The government supplied every one of them for reasons of its own, and got the demographic consequence attached.

It reversed course on family planning, hard. After the war with Iraq ended, the same clerical establishment endorsed one of the most effective family planning programmes ever run — free contraception, religious endorsement, and compulsory pre-marriage counselling. Fertility fell off a cliff. When the leadership reversed again after 2012 and began urging larger families, fertility carried on falling — which is Part Nine's asymmetry, observed inside a single country under a single government.

And the veil functioned as a permission slip. This is the claim that deserves the most care, because it is the most interesting and the most contested.

WORD BOX

Enabling constraint: a restriction that makes an activity possible by making it acceptable.

The argument in this case: a conservative rural father in 1975 would not send his daughter to a mixed school taught by unveiled strangers in a state he regarded as irreligious. After 1979 the school was segregated, the teachers were veiled, the curriculum was religiously framed, and the state was one he trusted. The same act — sending a daughter out of the house to be educated — went from unthinkable to permissible without his beliefs changing at all.

Why it matters: the constraint and the opportunity arrived in the same package. On this account the compulsory veil is not something that happened *despite* the education boom. It is part of what produced it.

Before weighing that claim, it is worth scoring the case itself, because Iran is quoted far more often than its evidential quality warrants.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Score Iran on the six tests from Chapter One, because it is the case most often quoted and it does not do well.

Assignment unrelated to outcome? No. A revolution is not assigned; it happens for reasons connected to everything else about a society. **Comparison group?** None. Neighbouring countries differ in too many ways to serve. **Same path beforehand?** This it does have — the pre-1979 trends are documented, so you can see whether the line bent. **Sharp in time?** Yes, unusually so. **Change came alone?** Emphatically not: a revolution, a war with a million casualties, sanctions, oil price swings and a development programme all at once. **Measured consistently?** Broadly yes; Iranian censuses and surveys are reasonably good.

So Iran passes three tests and fails three, including the most important one. It is a strong **before-and-after** and a weak **experiment**.

What that means practically: Iran cannot tell you what the rules caused. It can tell you what the rules failed to prevent, and that is a genuine finding — a negative one, and negative findings from a single case are the most reliable kind, because you only need one counterexample to refute a universal claim.

4.4 — What it refutes

That last point is worth drawing out, because it is how a weak case can still do real work.

A claim of the form “you cannot have strict rules about women’s dress and conduct together with mass female education” is refuted by Iran on its own. One counterexample is enough. Similarly, “high fertility requires only that a state wants it” is refuted: Iran’s state wanted it and did not get it.

What Iran cannot do is establish that the rules *caused* the education boom, because too much else was happening. The enabling-constraint account is plausible and it is not proved.

THE ARGUMENT — DID THE RULES CAUSE THE EDUCATION BOOM, OR MERELY FAIL TO PREVENT IT?

This is one of the genuinely open questions in this part, and the two answers imply opposite things about every conservative society on Earth.

THEY CAUSED IT, AND THE MECHANISM IS REAL

The timing is not a coincidence. Rural girls’ enrolment did not creep up after 1979; it jumped, and it jumped fastest in the most conservative provinces — precisely where the pre-revolutionary state had been least able to reach. Segregated schools, veiled teachers and religious framing removed the objection that had kept those girls at home, and the state that made the offer was one their fathers trusted. The same logic explains parallel cases elsewhere: participation by conservative women in public life often rises when the setting is made religiously acceptable rather than when it is made secular. On this reading, insisting on unveiling in 1936 kept girls out of school, and requiring the veil in 1983 put them in it.

THEY FAILED TO PREVENT IT, AND THE CREDIT BELONGS ELSEWHERE

Female education was already rising before 1979 and was rising across the whole region in the same decades, including in countries with no revolution. What Iran did was pour oil money into rural roads, clinics, electricity and a literacy campaign, which is what every country that expanded schooling has done. Attributing the result to the veil rather than to the infrastructure is reading a slogan off a machine. And note what the same regime did to the women it produced: barred from the judiciary, largely excluded from paid work, and policed in the street. A permission slip that admits you to a university and then locks the exit is not obviously a permission slip.

Where things stand: unresolved and probably partly both. The regional trend is real, so some of the rise would have happened anyway. The provincial pattern — the sharpest gains in the most conservative places — is the strongest evidence for the enabling-constraint account and it is not easily explained away. What is agreed is the outcome: whatever caused it, the rules did not stop it.

What would settle it: a comparison of Iranian provinces by how conservative they were before 1979 against how much girls' enrolment jumped after, with the infrastructure spending held constant. The census data to attempt this exists.

Why people care so much: because if the enabling-constraint mechanism is real, then a great deal of what looks like oppression is also, simultaneously, the thing making participation possible — and neither side of the wider argument has anywhere comfortable to put that.

Iran is a country that reversed its rules and did not get the outcomes. The next case is a country that removed them altogether, and it is running now.

REMEMBER THIS

Iran reversed its rules about women almost completely in 1979: family law suspended, marriage age lowered, women removed from the judiciary, veiling made compulsory, public space segregated.

Then female literacy went from about a third to over eighty per cent, women became a **majority of university entrants**, and fertility fell from about six and a half children to around 1.6 — the fastest sustained decline ever recorded for a large country. Paid employment did not move.

Three things did it: the regime **built the development machinery** that drives fertility decline; it ran one of the most effective family planning programmes in history and then could not reverse it; and the veil may have worked as a **permission slip** that let conservative fathers send daughters out of the house.

On the six tests Iran passes three and fails three. It is a strong before-and-after and a weak experiment.

But a single case can refute a universal claim, and this one refutes two: that strict rules and mass female education are incompatible, and that a state which wants high fertility can have it.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Removal

> *The most complete exclusion of women from public life in modern times is running now. Almost everything published about its consequences is a forecast rather than a finding — and one strand of it is neither, because it is mechanical.*

5.1 — What was removed

Since September 2021 no girl in Afghanistan has attended school beyond the sixth grade. In December 2022 universities were closed to women. Employment with aid organisations and the United Nations was barred. In late 2024 the restriction reached training in midwifery and nursing, which had been one of the last routes remaining.

By the most recent school year, roughly 2.2 million girls were out of secondary education, with several hundred thousand more added each year as new cohorts reach the cut-off. On present policy the figure passes two million deprived of any education beyond primary by 2030.

This is not a partial restriction of the kind this series has been describing elsewhere. It is a near-total removal, imposed at a known date, on a national population, with a documented twenty-year period of the opposite policy immediately beforehand.

5.2 — Measured, modelled, and the difference

Here is where I have to slow down, because the reporting on this does something that matters.

WORD BOX

Measurement: somebody counted the thing. Births attended, girls enrolled, deaths recorded.

Projection: somebody built a model of how the thing usually responds and calculated what should follow. No counting of the outcome has taken place.

Why the distinction is critical here: projections in this case are made by serious institutions using well-established relationships, and they are the best available guide to what is coming. They are still not evidence that it has happened. A sentence like “maternal deaths rose by half” and a sentence like “maternal deaths are projected to rise by half” describe completely different epistemic situations, and the second routinely becomes the first in the retelling.

So it is worth going through the Afghan figures one at a time and putting each in the right column.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Sorting the Afghan figures into the two categories.

Measured. The bans themselves and their dates. Enrolment: roughly 2.2 million girls out of secondary school. Child marriage from a household survey covering 2022–23: about 28.7 per cent of girls married before eighteen and about 9.6 per cent before fifteen. Female illiteracy around 84 per cent. Fertility around 5.3 to 5.4 children per woman with modern contraceptive use under a quarter. Maternal mortality around 638 deaths per 100,000 live births, already among the highest in the world.

Modelled. The widely quoted consequences: a 25 per cent rise in child marriage, a 45 per cent rise in adolescent childbearing and at least a 50 per cent rise in maternal mortality by 2026; an additional 1,600 maternal deaths and over 3,500 infant deaths; an estimated 0.5 per cent reduction in national output already, from an assessment published in April 2026.

What the modelled figures are good at: they use relationships that are extremely well established across many countries — mothers' education and child survival is one of the most replicated findings in development economics.

What they cannot do: confirm that it happened. Afghanistan's statistical capacity has degraded severely since 2021, which means the country least able to be counted is the one generating the most quoted numbers about itself.

5.3 — The one chain that is not a model

There is a strand of this that does not depend on statistics at all, and it is the strongest thing in the chapter.

Afghanistan enforces strict segregation in medical care: a woman is, in practice, treated by a female clinician or by nobody. That is not a projection; it is the operating rule.

Now add the December 2024 restriction on women training in midwifery and nursing. The existing female health workers age, retire, leave or die, and no replacements are being produced. Within a decade there will be a shortage of the only people permitted to attend Afghan women in childbirth.

This does not require a regression. It is arithmetic on a closed system. If only women may treat women, and no new women may be trained, the number of people able to treat women falls to zero on a schedule that can be calculated.

IN REAL TERMS

Afghanistan's maternal mortality is roughly 638 deaths per 100,000 live births. That means for every thousand Afghan women who give birth, between six and seven die — before any of this began.

Put the chain end to end. A rule about girls attending school past the sixth grade becomes, twelve years later, a rule about who is qualified to deliver a baby, which becomes a rule about which women survive childbirth.

Nobody who wrote the education rule was making a decision about obstetrics. That is what a rule about women's schooling turns into in a society that also forbids a male doctor from touching a female patient — and the two rules were made by the same people, for the same reasons, without anyone connecting them.

5.4 — What the case can and cannot establish

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT DOES AFGHANISTAN ACTUALLY PROVE?

It is the most emotionally decisive case in this part and it is not the most evidentially decisive, and those two facts are worth separating carefully.

IT IS THE DEFINITIVE DEMONSTRATION

Here is total exclusion of half a population, applied at a known date, in a country with two decades of contrary policy immediately before it for comparison. The outcomes are catastrophic and running in exactly the predicted direction across every domain measured — education, marriage age, health, output. If this does not count as evidence that the rules matter, nothing ever will, and the demand for a cleaner case is a way of refusing to look at the clearest one available.

IT FAILS THE ISOLATION TEST BADLY

Everything happened at once. The government changed by military collapse; international aid, which had funded a large share of the state, stopped; foreign reserves were frozen; the banking system seized; a drought was under way. Afghanistan's economy would have contracted severely with no change to women's rules at all. So the aggregate outcomes cannot be attributed to the exclusion of women, and citing them that way is exactly the reasoning Chapter One warned about. It demonstrates what happens when a country collapses.

Where things stand: both, and the resolution is to split the claim. The **aggregate** figures — output, poverty, humanitarian need — are hopelessly confounded and should not be used to prove anything about women's rules. The **specific mechanical chain** in the section above is not confounded at all, because it does not run through the economy: it runs through a rule about who may treat whom and a rule about who may be trained. Aid could be restored tomorrow and that chain would be unaffected.

What would settle it: restoration of statistical capacity and a proper survey round, which would convert the projections into measurements. Whether that happens depends on decisions nobody reading this controls.

Why people care so much: because Afghanistan is deployed as a closing argument by everyone who wants the rules-matter conclusion, and treating a confounded case as decisive is how a strong argument acquires a weak foundation. The mechanical chain is a better argument than the aggregate one, and almost nobody uses it.

5.5 — The repeat

One structural feature of this case is rare enough to note. The same policy was applied to the same country twice — from 1996 to 2001, and again from 2021 — with two decades of the opposite policy in between.

That is close to a reversal design: treatment, removal, treatment. It is uncommon in social science and it lets you ask whether the second application produced the same effects as the first.

The honest answer is that we do not yet know, because the first period was even less well documented than the current one, and because the country in 2021 was not the country of 1996 — twenty years of schooling had produced a generation of literate women who are now barred from teaching. That difference cuts an unexpected way: the second application began from a much higher base, so the same rules remove much more.

REMEMBER THIS

Since September 2021 no Afghan girl has attended school past the sixth grade; universities closed to women in December 2022, and midwifery and nursing training in late 2024. Roughly **2.2 million girls** are out of secondary school.

Separate the **measured** from the **modelled**. Enrolment, child marriage rates, literacy, fertility and maternal mortality are counted. The headline consequences — a quarter more child marriage, half again as many maternal deaths, half a per cent of national output — are **projections**, and the retelling constantly converts them into findings.

One chain is neither a model nor a projection. **If only women may treat women, and no women may be trained, the number of people able to attend an Afghan birth falls to zero on a calculable schedule.** That is arithmetic on a closed system.

The case fails the isolation test badly — a military collapse, an aid cutoff, frozen reserves and a drought arrived together — so the aggregate figures prove nothing about women's rules specifically.

Which means the mechanical chain is a stronger argument than the catastrophe, and almost nobody uses it.

CHAPTER SIX

The Lifting

> *Two cases where something that had been forbidden or impossible became available, on a known date, in a society that did not otherwise transform. They are the closest thing this argument has to a test of whether the old position was a preference or a wall.*

6.1 — Saudi Arabia, 2018 and 2019

In June 2018 Saudi Arabia lifted its ban on women driving. In August 2019 it changed the guardianship rules so that women over twenty-one could obtain a passport and travel without a male relative's permission, and could register births, marriages and divorces in their own right.

These are sharp, dated, specific changes to constraints that had held for decades. On the Chapter One checklist that is unusually good. What followed is one of the largest measured changes in women's economic position anywhere, ever.

Saudi female labour force participation stood at roughly 17 per cent in 2016. By 2025 the national statistics authority put it at around 36 per cent. That is a rise of about nineteen percentage points in under a decade, and it represents on the order of 1.3 million additional Saudi women in paid work.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Nineteen points in nine years. For comparison, the equivalent shift in the United States — from roughly a third of women in the workforce to around half — took about thirty years, from the 1950s to the 1980s, and was regarded at the time as a social transformation.
>
> Saudi Arabia did a comparable distance in less than a third of the time, starting from a much lower base, in a society that had not otherwise been reorganised.
>
> **Nothing changed about Saudi women between 2016 and 2025. Something changed about what they were allowed to do, and about a third of a million a year began doing it.**

A number that large, moving that fast, deserves scrutiny of where it comes from before anyone builds on it.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The figures come from Saudi Arabia's own statistics authority, which has run quarterly labour force surveys since 2016 and supplements them with administrative employment records. That is good coverage and consistent method — but three cautions belong on the record.

First, the government set a public target of 30 per cent as part of its national programme and then exceeded it. Any statistic that is also a performance indicator for the people producing it deserves an extra look, and this one is both.

Second, the definitions and survey methods changed during the period, which is normal and which makes the earliest and latest figures not perfectly comparable.

Third, the employment is geographically concentrated in the largest cities. The national figure hides a country in which the change has been far smaller in smaller towns and rural areas.

None of this touches the direction or the rough magnitude. Independent international estimates show the same shape. It does mean the precise number should be read as approximate.

The honest complication is that the lifting did not arrive alone. It came inside a large economic programme that also included employment quotas for citizens, transport and childcare subsidies aimed at working women, and a background of falling oil revenue that made a second household income more necessary. So the case fails the fifth test: what was removed was a legal constraint, and what was added at the same time was a set of inducements.

6.2 — Bangladesh, and a better-identified case

The second case is less famous and evidentially stronger.

From the 1980s, Bangladesh built an export garment industry which by the 2010s employed several million people, the large majority of them women. Factories opened in some places and not others, and the pattern of where they opened had more to do with roads, ports and land than with how progressive the surrounding villages were.

That gives researchers something close to a comparison group: villages near a new factory against otherwise similar villages further away. When that comparison was done properly, the results were consistent and large. Girls growing up near garment factories married later, had their first child later, and stayed in school substantially longer — and the schooling effect was larger than that produced by a well-known government scheme that paid families directly to keep girls in school.

The mechanism is worth spelling out because it is not the one people assume. The factories did not employ schoolgirls. They employed young women, and the jobs required basic literacy and numeracy. So the return on educating a daughter became visible, local and specific: families could see what school was *for*, in the form of a wage a neighbour's daughter was bringing home.

WORD BOX

Revealed preference: the idea that what people actually do tells you more about what they want than what they say.

Why it matters in these two cases: for decades, low female employment in both countries was explained as a preference — women, or their families, did not want it. Revealed preference is the standard tool for testing that, and here the test was run by events rather than by researchers.

The catch, which matters just as much: a preference expressed under constraint is not a free preference either. What people do when an option is forbidden tells you almost nothing, and what they do when it is newly permitted *and* newly rewarded tells you something mixed.

And the cost belongs in the record, because a chapter that reported only the gains would be doing exactly what Chapter One warns about. The Bangladeshi garment industry has killed workers in large numbers, most notoriously in the collapse of a factory building in 2013 in which more than eleven hundred people died. The same industry that delayed marriages and filled schools also produced some of the worst industrial safety failures of the century, and the people who bore both were the same women.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES LIFTING A CONSTRAINT REVEAL WHAT WOMEN WANTED?

This is the question these two cases were supposed to answer, and they answer part of it.

YES, AND THE NUMBERS SETTLE A LONG ARGUMENT

For decades the low participation of women in Saudi Arabia and rural Bangladesh was explained as cultural preference — this is simply not what women there want, and outsiders should stop projecting. Then the constraint moved and behaviour moved with it, immediately and at enormous scale. Preferences held by whole populations do not shift nineteen points in nine years. Walls come down in an afternoon. Whatever the previous level was measuring, it was not what women wanted, and the people who insisted it was should say so.

IT SHOWS LESS THAN THAT, IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

Neither case is a clean lift. Saudi women got permission alongside quotas, subsidies and household economic pressure; Bangladeshi families got a factory wage, which is an inducement rather than a permission. So what these cases measure is the response to a package, not the revelation of a latent want. And there is a harder version of the objection: a woman raised inside these rules does not have a preference sitting underneath them waiting to be uncovered. Her preferences were formed by the same arrangements. There is no free-standing answer to what she "really" wants, so no lifting can reveal it.

Where things stand: the cases establish a negative claim decisively and a positive claim not at all. Decisively: **the previous level was not a ceiling set by preference.** Something that responds that fast to a change in permissions and incentives was being held down, and the cultural-preference explanation for the old level is dead. What they cannot establish is what the level would be under no constraint, because that condition has never existed anywhere and the second side is right that it may not be a coherent idea.

What would settle it: a case where a permission was lifted with no accompanying inducement and no economic pressure. Rare, because governments that lift restrictions usually want the resulting participation and pay for it.

Why people care so much: because "this is what they want" has been the single most durable defence of every arrangement in this series, and these two cases are the strongest evidence anyone has ever assembled against it.

That is the record of reforms that worked. The next chapter is the record of reforms that did the opposite of what they were for, and it is the more useful of the two.

REMEMBER THIS

Saudi Arabia lifted its driving ban in June 2018 and relaxed guardianship rules in August 2019. Female labour force participation went from about **17 per cent in 2016 to around 36 per cent by 2025 —** roughly nineteen points in nine years, a shift that took the United States about thirty.

The lifting did not come alone: quotas, transport and childcare subsidies and falling oil revenue arrived with it. The case fails the isolation test.

Bangladesh is the better-identified case. Garment factories opened where the roads and ports were, not where attitudes were. Girls near them **married later, had children later and stayed in school longer —** by more than a government scheme that paid families directly. Because a factory wage made visible what school was for.

The cost belongs on the record too. The same industry produced the factory collapse of 2013 that killed more than eleven hundred people, and the women who gained were the women who died.

Together they kill one claim decisively: whatever the old level of women's work was measuring, it was not preference. Something that moves nineteen points in nine years was being held down.

CHAPTER SEVEN

When the Reform Backfired

> *The most useful chapter here for anyone who actually wants to change something. Four Indian reforms that produced the opposite of what they intended, and one clean rule that explains all four.*

7.1 — The law that caused what it banned

In 1929 the colonial government passed an act raising the minimum age of marriage for girls. It was passed in the autumn and took effect the following spring, and in the months between, families across India rushed to marry their daughters before the law could bite.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This one is unusually well documented, because a census fell immediately afterwards. The 1931 census recorded a marked surge in the marriage of very young girls in the window between the act's passage and its commencement — a spike visible in the age-at-marriage distributions and remarked on at the time.

Why this evidence is strong: the spike is confined to the gap between passage and commencement, which is exactly the window the mechanism predicts and no other explanation produces. It is a sharp change with a known date and a documented before-and-after in the same population.

What it cannot tell you: the long-run effect of the act itself, which is a different and much harder question involving enforcement, registration and everything that happened over the following ninety years.

The announcement of a prohibition is itself an event. It tells everybody that a window is closing, and the rational response to a closing window is to move before it shuts. Reform is not a switch that flips a society from one state to another; it is a signal that people act on, including in the interval before it applies.

7.2 — Dowry: prohibited, and then it grew

India prohibited dowry in 1961. In the decades that followed the practice did not shrink. It spread — into communities that had not previously practised it, including some where the payment had historically run the other way — and the amounts rose.

The mechanism is not mysterious once you look at what prohibition actually did to the transaction.

Before, a dowry was negotiated openly between families, was often at least partly in goods, and had a degree of social visibility that acted as a constraint — everyone knew what had been asked, and asking too much carried a reputational cost. Prohibition did not remove the demand. It moved the transaction out of the visible, negotiable, semi-documented space and into undocumented cash.

What was lost in that move was not the payment. It was every check on the payment: the bride's family's ability to complain publicly, the community's knowledge of what was normal, and any legal claim on what had been handed over. A woman whose in-laws demanded more after the wedding now had no record of what had already been given.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Substitution effect:** when blocking one route does not remove the underlying behaviour but redirects it into another, usually worse, channel.
>
> **Perverse incentive:** when a rule creates a reason to do more of the thing it was meant to stop.
>
> Why both matter here: neither is an argument against regulating anything. They are an argument for asking one specific question before you legislate **— where does this behaviour go if I block this route?** Every failure in this chapter is a case where nobody asked it.

7.3 — The machine that was meant to save mothers

The third case is the most serious, because the technology involved was introduced entirely for good reasons and its misuse has cost more lives than anything else in this series.

Ultrasound scanning arrived in India as maternal health equipment. It made pregnancies safer. It also made the sex of a foetus knowable, cheaply, from mid-pregnancy, in a society with a strong preference for sons.

India's child sex ratio worsened steadily across the decades that followed. In 1981 there were around 962 girls per 1,000 boys aged nought to six. By 2001 it was about 927, and by 2011 about 918. Millions of girls who should exist do not.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Now the detail that ought to be famous and is not. Sex selection in India was **not** concentrated among the poorest and least educated. It was strongest among families that were richer, more urban and better educated.
>
> The reason is arithmetic. A family that wants six children and prefers sons will probably get sons without doing anything. A family that wants two children and prefers sons has to make it happen. Add a cheap scan and a clinic, and it happens.
>
> **Falling fertility and son preference combine to kill girls, and it is the modernising families who do it.** Every assumption that education and prosperity would dissolve this preference was wrong in the specific direction that mattered most.

India legislated against it in 1994 and strengthened the law in 2003, prohibiting the use of diagnostic techniques to determine sex. Enforcement has been patchy and prosecutions rare, but the ratio has improved somewhat in recent survey rounds. The point for this chapter is not that the law failed. It is that the harm was created by a maternal health technology, and that the people best placed to use it were the ones the reformers expected to be furthest along.

7.4 — Protection that excluded

The fourth case is the one that recurs in every country. Laws written to protect women workers — bans on night work, exclusions from certain industries, restrictions on hours — were passed by people who genuinely intended protection, in response to real hazards.

The effect was to make women more expensive and less flexible to employ, and therefore to exclude them from exactly the shift-based manufacturing work that has been the main route out of agricultural poverty for women everywhere, including in the Bangladesh case in Chapter Six. In India, restrictions on women's night work in factories stood for decades and were only unwound state by state from the 2000s onwards.

What makes this case instructive is that the hazard was real. Night work in an unsafe factory in an unsafe city genuinely was dangerous for women. The reform addressed the danger by removing the women rather than the danger, which is the same structure as every restriction in this series — and this time it was written by reformers.

THE ARGUMENT — DO THESE CASES ARGUE AGAINST REFORM, OR AGAINST BAD REFORM?

This chapter is quoted by two very different sorts of people and they draw opposite conclusions from it.

THEY ARGUE FOR CAUTION ABOUT REFORM IN GENERAL

Four serious attempts by intelligent people to improve women's position produced more child marriage, more dowry, fewer girls alive and fewer women employed. That is not a run of bad luck; it is what happens when you intervene in a system whose workings you do not understand. Social arrangements that have persisted for a long time usually persist because they are solving something, and removing a piece without knowing what it was doing produces exactly this. Humility is not conservatism — it is the appropriate response to a record like this one.

THEY ARGUE FOR BETTER REFORM, AND THE PATTERN IS DIAGNOSABLE

Look at what the four failures have in common: every one of them attacked a **symptom** while leaving the underlying demand untouched. Dowry was prohibited while the marriage market that generated it was left alone. Sex determination was banned while son preference was left alone. Night work was banned while the danger was left alone. Child marriage was outlawed while nothing changed about why families marry daughters young. That is not an argument against intervening. It is a specific, learnable diagnosis — and the reforms in this series that *did* work, like the reserved seats in Chapter Two, worked because they changed the underlying structure rather than forbidding an output of it.

Where things stand: the second reading fits the cases better, and it is not a comfortable finding for either camp. The failures share a signature: prohibit the visible symptom, leave the demand in place, and watch it re-emerge somewhere less visible and less regulated. That predicts failure in advance rather than diagnosing it afterwards, which is what makes it a usable rule rather than hindsight.

What would settle it: a systematic accounting of reforms in this area by whether they targeted the symptom or the structure, with outcomes measured the same way. Nobody has assembled one, and this chapter is a sample of four that I chose, which is precisely the problem Chapter One described.

Why people care so much: because "reform backfires" is one of the strongest arguments the traditionalist case has, and it is strong. What it does not support is the conclusion usually drawn from it, which is that nothing should be attempted.

Both sides of that exchange share a way of describing what a law is, and it is worth pulling out, because it explains why this particular argument never gets anywhere.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE REFORM IS THE INTERVENTION

Everybody in that argument evaluates these laws by what they say. Dowry prohibition is assessed as a prohibition on dowry. The sex determination act is assessed as a ban on sex determination.

But a law is not what is delivered. What a population actually receives is the text **plus** whether anyone enforces it, **plus** how it is locally understood, **plus** what happens to the behaviour it displaces. Those four things together are the intervention. The text is only the first.

Run it on dowry. The text said: this payment is illegal. What was delivered was: this payment is now undocumented, unnegotiable in public, and unenforceable if your in-laws want more later. Nobody wrote that. It is what the text became after passing through an unenforcing state and a marriage market that still needed the money to move.

This is why arguments about these reforms are so unproductive. One side says the law was a good idea and the other says it failed, and they are discussing different objects — a text and a delivery. Both can be right at once, permanently, without either learning anything.

The general form: evaluating the instruction rather than what was received. It is everywhere. A curriculum reform judged by the syllabus rather than by what was taught. A safety rule judged by the regulation rather than by what the inspector actually does. A target judged by the number rather than by what people did to hit it.

And there is a sharper version specific to this series, which Part Eleven found from the other direction. A rule about women lands where it **can be enforced**. So the delivered version of any reform is shaped by exactly the same thing that shapes the delivered version of any restriction: not what was intended, but who has the power to make it real in the room where it applies. In an Indian household, that is very rarely the legislature.

So much for the failures. The next chapter does the counting that a series like this owes its readers: which side actually forecast events correctly.

REMEMBER THIS

The 1929 marriage age act was passed in autumn to take effect in spring, and the census recorded a **surge of child marriages in the gap**. An announced prohibition is itself an event, and a closing window makes people move.

Dowry was prohibited in 1961 and then **spread and grew**. Prohibition did not remove the demand; it moved the payment out of visible, negotiable goods into undocumented cash — removing every check on it and leaving the bride with no record of what had been given.

Ultrasound arrived as maternal health equipment and produced millions of missing girls. India's child sex ratio fell from about 962 girls per 1,000 boys in 1981 to about 918 in 2011 — and sex selection was **strongest among richer, more educated, urban families**, because small families plus son preference require action.

Protective labour laws addressed a real hazard by **removing the women rather than the danger** — the same structure as every restriction in this series, written this time by reformers.

All four share one signature: prohibit the visible symptom, leave the demand in place, and watch it re-emerge somewhere less visible and less regulated. That predicts failure in advance, which makes it a usable rule rather than hindsight.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Predictions That Came True

> *Thirteen parts of testing produce a scorecard. Both sides made confident forecasts and both got badly wrong the thing they were most certain about. This chapter counts it, including the entries I would rather not have.*

8.1 — What the traditionalist got right

Four predictions have been vindicated, and I want to state them without hedging, because a series that only found the other side wrong would not be worth the paper.

Fertility would collapse and would not come back. Part Nine established this comprehensively. Every rich country has fallen below replacement, no country has ever policied its way back, and the money spent trying runs to hundreds of billions of dollars. This prediction was correct, and it was correct more strongly than most people on the other side expected.

Marriage would decline sharply. Later, less common, and in East Asia collapsing outright. Correct.

The care of the old would become an unsolved public problem. Part Nine's Chapter Seven: ten working-age people per pensioner becoming four, and a bill nobody has costed. Correct.

Family stability would fall. Divorce rose steeply across the rich world through the second half of the twentieth century, and single-parent households multiplied. The honest footnote is that divorce rates have *fallen* in several countries since their peaks around 1980 to 2000 — but the prediction was about direction over the period, and over the period it was right.

8.2 — What the traditionalist got half right

"She will be less happy." This deserves a careful look because it is the traditionalist case's best empirical card and it is usually either overstated or dismissed.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Across the United States and much of the developed world, surveys of subjective wellbeing since the 1970s show women's reported happiness declining **relative to men's**. Women started the period reporting higher wellbeing than men and ended it reporting the same or lower. This is a real, replicated finding across multiple national datasets.

What it establishes: the relative position moved, over exactly the decades when women's legal, educational and economic position improved enormously. That is a genuine puzzle and pretending otherwise is not honest.

What it does not establish, and this is where most retellings go wrong. It is a **relative** measure — much of the movement is men's reported wellbeing rising. It is a survey of stated feeling, and what people are willing to state changes: a woman in 1972 asked whether she was satisfied with her life was answering inside a norm that made complaint costly. And a wider range of options can lower satisfaction while raising almost everything else, because satisfaction is measured against what you think you could have had.

So: the finding is real, the interpretation is genuinely open, and both sides quote it as though it were settled.

There is a specific reason happiness comparisons across decades are so hard to read, and it has a name.

WORD BOX

Reference-group effect: people rate their lives against what they believe is available to them, not against an absolute scale.

Why it complicates every happiness comparison: if a woman in 1960 compared herself only to other housewives, and a woman in 2010 compares herself to everyone including her male colleagues, the second can have a far better life and report a worse score. The ruler changed at the same time as the thing being measured.

This does not dismiss the finding. It means a happiness survey cannot distinguish between "life got worse" and "expectations rose faster than life improved", and those are very different worlds.

“She will regret it.” Part Ten found a real, robust, moderate asymmetry in sexual regret that survived testing in the most egalitarian society available. Half right — because what predicted an individual woman’s regret was not her sex but whether she was worried, pressured or disappointed, all of which are conditions rather than dispositions.

8.3 — What the traditionalist got wrong

“Women do not want to work.” Killed by Chapter Six of this part. Nineteen percentage points in nine years.

“Educating women will destroy the family and then the society.” No society that educated its women has collapsed. Every one of them got richer, healthier and longer-lived, and their children stopped dying.

“Bias against women in authority is natural and fixed.” Refuted by Chapter Two, in rural north India, within seven years, by rotation.

“Strict rules and mass female education are incompatible.” Refuted by Iran — and note that this claim was made by both sides, which is why Chapter Four is uncomfortable for everybody.

8.4 — And the reformer’s failures

The other column, and it is not shorter.

“Development will dissolve son preference.” Wrong, badly. Chapter Seven: sex selection was strongest among the richer, more educated, more urban families.

“Prosperity and education will end dowry.” Wrong. It grew.

“Equality at home will restore fertility.” Wrong. Part Nine: the Nordic countries went furthest and fell anyway.

“Legal reform changes behaviour.” Often wrong, and Chapter Seven shows the pattern — prohibit the symptom, leave the demand, watch it re-emerge somewhere worse.

THE PREDICTION	WHOSE	VERDICT
Fertility collapses and does not return	Traditionalist	Right, decisively

THE PREDICTION	WHOSE	VERDICT
Marriage declines sharply	Traditionalist	Right
Old-age care becomes an unsolved problem	Traditionalist	Right
Family stability falls	Traditionalist	Right over the period; partly reversed since
Women end up less happy	Traditionalist	Half right; the measure is relative and contested
She will regret it	Traditionalist	Half right; predicted by conditions, not by sex
Women do not want to work	Traditionalist	Wrong
Educating women destroys societies	Traditionalist	Wrong
Bias against women leaders is fixed	Traditionalist	Wrong
Development dissolves son preference	Reformer	Wrong, and lethally
Prosperity ends dowry	Reformer	Wrong
Equality at home restores fertility	Reformer	Wrong
Legal reform changes behaviour	Reformer	Often wrong

THE ARGUMENT — WHOSE FORECAST DID BETTER?

Read that table and the obvious question is who won. Two serious answers.

THE TRADITIONALISTS FORECAST BETTER

Count the entries. Their four unambiguous hits are large, civilisational and irreversible — a fertility collapse with no exit, a marriage system dissolving, an ageing bill nobody can pay. The reformers' failures are on the exact points where they were most confident and most dismissive: they were certain that education and prosperity would dissolve son preference and dowry, and millions of girls are dead because they were wrong. A forecast is judged on the big calls, and the big calls went one way.

THE TRADITIONALISTS FORECAST THE COSTS AND MISSED THE SUBSTANCE

Every traditionalist hit is a prediction about **aggregate social arrangements** — birth rates, marriage rates, care burdens. Every traditionalist miss is a prediction about **women themselves**: what they want, what they can do, whether others' bias about them is fixed. On the question of what a woman is, they were wrong every time it was tested. And the reformers' misses are misses of optimism about speed, not of direction — they were wrong that prosperity alone would fix son preference, and right that the preference could be reduced, which several places have since done.

Where things stand: the second reading survives contact with the table better, and it is a real pattern rather than a rescue. The traditionalist case has been consistently right about consequences at the level of societies and consistently wrong about capacities at the level of persons. The reformer case has been right about persons and repeatedly naive about systems. Neither of those is a small thing to be wrong about.

What would settle it: nothing, because "whose forecast did better" is not one question. It depends entirely on which predictions go on the list — and that is the subject of the box below.

Why people care so much: because both sides have spent decades claiming vindication by events, and this is the first table in this series that puts the entries side by side. Neither side comes out of it looking the way its advocates say it does.

Before leaving that table, there is a question about it that nobody in the argument above asked.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE SCOREBOARD IS NEUTRAL

Look again at that table and ask a question nobody asks: **who chose the rows?**

I did. And notice what determines the result. Fertility, marriage rates, family stability, old-age care — put those four on a scoreboard and the traditionalist wins. Literacy, maternal mortality, income, life expectancy, political representation, violence — put those on instead and it is not close in the other direction.

Both lists are real. Neither side is cheating. Each is measuring the things it thinks a society is *for*, and the disagreement about what to count is not a disagreement about evidence at all — it is the actual disagreement, arriving disguised as a methodology choice.

This is why the argument never ends. Two people can agree on every number in this series and still disagree completely, because one of them is counting continuity between generations and the other is counting how a life goes for the person living it. No amount of further research adjudicates that, and further research is what both sides keep demanding.

The general form: the winner is decided when the scoreboard is chosen, not when the evidence is gathered. It runs through every contested field. A school judged on exam results or on what its pupils become. An economy judged on output or on how the median person lives. A hospital judged on mortality or on suffering. In every case the metric selection looks technical and does all the moral work.

And it is worth naming what has never happened. In a hundred years of this argument, **nobody has ever proposed a shared scoreboard —** a list both sides would agree in advance to be judged by. Not once. That is not an oversight. Agreeing the metrics in advance is the one move that would risk losing.

With that in mind, the last thing this part owes you is a single accounting: what all nine cases, graded honestly, actually establish.

REMEMBER THIS

The traditionalist got four things **right**: fertility collapses and does not return, marriage declines sharply, old-age care becomes unpayable, family stability falls. These are large and they are not in dispute.

Two **half right**: women's relative reported happiness did fall, though the measure is relative and the ruler changed; and the regret asymmetry is real but predicted by conditions rather than by sex.

Several **wrong**: that women do not want to work, that educating them destroys societies, that bias against them is fixed, that strict rules and female education cannot coexist.

The reformer's failures are not shorter, and one was lethal: **development did not dissolve son preference**, prosperity did not end dowry, equality at home did not restore fertility, and legal reform frequently did not change behaviour.

The pattern: the traditionalist has been right about consequences at the level of societies and wrong every time about capacities at the level of persons. And whichever side you think won depends entirely on which rows go on the scoreboard — which nobody has ever agreed in advance, because agreeing it is the one move that risks losing.

CHAPTER NINE

What All of It Establishes

> *Nine cases, graded by how much weight each can bear. Six findings survive the grading. And one problem with the whole exercise that I can make visible but cannot fix.*

9.1 — The cases, graded

Chapter One set out four tiers of evidence and six tests. Here is every case in this part scored against them, so you can see what each is actually worth before anything is drawn from it.

CASE	TIER	WHAT IT CAN SUPPORT
India: reserved council seats	Randomised	Bias about women's capacity is not fixed. Representation changes spending and changes what girls expect of their lives.
Bangladesh: garment factories	Quasi-random	Visible returns to schooling change family behaviour faster than paying families does.
Divided Germany	Border, both sides moving	Institutions set employment and fertility levels. Norms outlive the institutions that made them by about a generation.
Saudi Arabia since 2018	Sharp, bundled	The previous level of women's work was not a ceiling set by preference.
Iran since 1979	Sharp, heavily bundled	Refutes two universal claims. Cannot establish what the rules caused.
Afghanistan since 2021	Confounded; mostly modelled	The mechanical chain about who may treat whom. Not the aggregate figures.
Indian reform backfires	Cases, chosen	Prohibiting a symptom while leaving the demand relocates the behaviour somewhere worse.

9.2 — What survives

Six findings hold across more than one tier, which is the minimum I am willing to build on.

One. Beliefs about what women can do respond to observation. The strongest single result in this series, from the only randomisation in it, in rural north India, within seven years. Not beliefs about what women may do — that is untested, and it is the harder case.

Two. The observed level of women's work is set by arrangements, not by preference. Germany and Saudi Arabia say this from opposite directions: impose the male-breadwinner model and employment falls; lift a constraint and it rises nineteen points in nine years. Whatever the old numbers measured, it was not what women wanted.

Three. Norms outlive the institutions that produced them by roughly a generation. East German women's attitudes and employment patterns persisted for thirty years after the state that formed them ceased to exist. This cuts both ways and both are important: institutions can change norms, and neither direction is quick to undo.

Four. Rules land where they can be enforced, and so do reforms. Part Eleven found this about restrictions. Chapter Seven found the same shape about reforms: what a population receives is the text plus enforcement plus local interpretation plus whatever the displaced behaviour does next.

Five. Prohibiting a symptom while leaving the demand in place makes things worse. Four Indian reforms, one signature. This one predicts in advance rather than explaining afterwards, which is what makes it usable.

Six. Force works downwards and not upwards. Coercion has repeatedly and rapidly reduced births, and has never raised them. Iran ran both directions under one government within thirty years and got the same asymmetry Romania and China got.

IN REAL TERMS

Put findings one and two together and you get something concrete enough to act on.

If bias responds to observation, and if the observed level of women's participation is set by arrangements rather than preferences, then the two reinforce each other. Change the arrangement, women appear in a role, people observe them there, bias falls, and the next change is easier.

That is what the reserved seats did. A rotation rule put a woman in a chair; her presence did the rest.

The cheapest thing in this entire series was an administrative schedule that nobody designed to change anybody's mind.

9.3 — What would change my mind

Stating this properly is the only thing that separates a document like this from advocacy, so here it is, specifically.

Finding one falls if a second randomisation, in a domain closer to marriage or property, produces no attitude movement. That study is entirely feasible and has not been run.

Finding three falls if the East German persistence turns out to be an artefact of who stayed — if the women who remained in the east were unrepresentative, the attitude gap could be a migration pattern rather than a norm.

Finding two weakens badly if Saudi participation falls back when the subsidies and quotas end. That is a real possibility and the next decade will show it.

The whole Afghanistan chapter weakens if outcomes over the coming years come in far below the projections — which would not mean the exclusion was harmless, but would mean the models overstated it and that everyone quoting them, including me, was quoting a forecast.

And Part Nine's central claim — that no country has restored replacement fertility — falls the moment one does. Korea's small recent rise is the live test and I do not know how it will resolve.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE WHOLE BODY OF EVIDENCE FAVOUR EITHER SIDE?

Thirteen parts. Here is the closing exchange, put as strongly as I can put both.

IT FAVOURS THE TRADITIONALIST

Every well-identified finding here is about capacity — women can lead, can work, can learn, and others' bias about that shifts. Nobody ever seriously doubted any of it; the arguments in this series were never about whether a woman could run a village council. The traditionalist claim was always about what happens to a society that reorganises around individual choice, and on that the record is one-sided: fertility gone and unrecoverable, marriage dissolving, an ageing bill nobody can pay. The reformers won every measurable point and lost the thing the argument was about.

IT FAVOURS THE REFORMER

Look at what the traditionalist case has actually had to retreat to. It began as a claim about women — their nature, their wants, their capacities, what would happen to them personally. Every one of those has been tested and lost. What remains is an argument about aggregate demographic consequences, in which no individual woman is doing anything wrong and the cost is simply spread across a society. That is a completely different argument from the one being made to a girl in a village, and the fact that it is the only ground left is itself the finding.

Where things stand: both descriptions of the retreat are accurate, which is the honest and unsatisfying result of thirteen parts. The claims about women have been tested and have not survived. The claims about societies have been tested and largely have. Those are different claims and the same person usually makes both, which is why the argument has never resolved — winning one has never cost anybody the other.

What would settle it: nothing, and Chapter Eight explained why. This is a disagreement about what a society is for, arriving dressed as a disagreement about evidence.

Why people care so much: because both sides believe the other is not merely mistaken but is producing suffering — and on the evidence in this part, both are partly right about that too.

One more thing before the closing list, and it is about this part rather than about anybody in it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THE ONE IN HOW I BUILT THIS PART

Chapter One warned that the natural experiments available to any writer are not a sample of what happens when rules change. They are a sample of the occasions when something visible happened, because a null result never becomes a famous case.

Then I wrote eight chapters using nine cases that **I selected**. Nobody handed me a list. There is no register of natural experiments in this field.

So ask why these nine. Because they are well documented, because researchers have already worked on them, because the findings are clean enough to explain in simple English, and — the one I least want to write down — because I had heard of them. Every one of those criteria correlates with something visible having happened. **I selected on exactly the property Chapter One identified as the fatal error, and then used the resulting sample to draw conclusions.**

There is a second turn and it is worse. I also graded the cases. I put the Indian reservation study in the top tier — which is correct on the checklist, and which is also the case whose finding I most wanted to be true. I do not think I bent the grading. I have no way to verify that from inside the document, and neither does anyone who trusts it.

The general form: running the audit with a sample you assembled yourself. It is the structural flaw in every literature review, every list of lessons from history, and every argument that begins “look at what happened in”. The method looks rigorous precisely because the selection happened before the method started.

What I can offer is partial and I will not dress it up. The checklist was written before the cases were graded and it is printed in Chapter One, so anyone can regrade them and see whether I was consistent. I included the chapter where reforms backfired and the chapter where the traditionalist forecast was right, which are the cases that cut against me — though I chose those too. And I have told you the direction the error runs.

That is not a solution. It is the difference between a flaw that is visible and one that is not, and after thirteen parts it is the most I have found a way to give you.

Which brings us, as every part does, to the accounting of what is known and what is not.

REMEMBER THIS

Nine cases, graded. Only **one** is a genuine randomisation. Two are quasi-random or border comparisons. The famous ones — Iran, Afghanistan — are the weakest, and they are the ones everyone quotes.

Six findings survive: **bias about women's capacity is not fixed**; the observed level of women's work is set by arrangements rather than preference; **norms outlive their institutions by about a generation**; rules and reforms alike land where they can be enforced; prohibiting a symptom while leaving the demand makes things worse; and force works downwards but never upwards.

Each of those has a stated way it could fail, and Korea's small recent fertility rise is the live test of the largest claim in the series.

The traditionalist case has retreated from claims about women — which have been tested and lost — to claims about societies, which have largely held. Those are different arguments, and the same people make both.

And I chose these nine cases myself, using criteria that all correlate with something visible having happened, which is the exact error Chapter One warned about. I can make that flaw visible. I have not found a way to remove it.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Two lists, as in every part. What is genuinely unknown, with the reason. And what is solid enough to build on. After thirteen parts, this is the chapter that matters most.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

WHETHER BELIEFS ABOUT WHAT WOMEN MAY DO MOVE LIKE BELIEFS ABOUT WHAT WOMEN CAN DO

The randomised evidence shows bias about women's *capacity* falling within a decade. Nothing tests whether beliefs about women's *permitted conduct* — marriage, sexual behaviour, mobility, dress — respond the same way. Those are the beliefs this series is actually about. The reason we do not know: nobody has randomised anything in that domain, and it is hard to imagine an institution that could.

WHAT THE NULL CASES LOOK LIKE

Every case in this part is one where something happened. The occasions on which a society changed its rules and nothing measurable followed are absent from the record entirely, because nobody writes them up. The reason we do not know: null results in case-based history are not published, not remembered, and not collected anywhere.

WHETHER THE IRANIAN EDUCATION BOOM WAS CAUSED OR MERELY NOT PREVENTED

The enabling-constraint account — that segregated, religiously framed schooling let conservative fathers permit what they would otherwise have refused — is plausible and unproven. The reason we do not know: nobody has done the provincial analysis comparing pre-revolutionary conservatism against the size of the post-1979 enrolment jump, holding infrastructure spending constant. The census data to attempt it exists.

WHAT AFGHANISTAN'S OUTCOMES ACTUALLY ARE

The consequences everybody quotes are projections. The measurements have not been made, because the country's statistical capacity collapsed alongside everything else. The reason we do not know: the state least able to be counted is generating the most quoted numbers about itself.

WHETHER THE SAUDI CHANGE HOLDS

Nineteen points in nine years, arriving alongside quotas, subsidies and economic pressure. Whether participation stays if the inducements are withdrawn is the test of whether a constraint was lifted or an incentive was applied. The reason we do not know: not enough time has passed, and this one will resolve itself.

WHETHER EAST GERMAN PERSISTENCE IS A NORM OR A MIGRATION PATTERN

Attitudes and employment patterns persisted for thirty years after the institutions vanished. If the women who stayed in the east were systematically different from those who left, some of that gap is selection rather than culture. The reason we do not know: the analysis requires linking migration histories to attitude data across three decades, which is possible in principle and has not been done at the necessary scale.

WHICH REFORMS WOULD HAVE WORKED

Chapter Seven diagnosed four failures with one signature. It does not follow that structural reforms succeed, because the successful cases are as selected as the failures. The reason we do not know: there is no systematic accounting of reforms in this area scored by whether they targeted a symptom or a structure, and assembling one would be a large piece of work that nobody has funded.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

One item on that list deserves to be treated as a finding rather than a gap, because it recurs in every part of this series and it always points the same way.

Three of the seven unknowns above could be closed by analyses that require **no new data collection at all.** The Iranian provincial comparison uses existing censuses. The East German migration question uses existing panel data. The reform accounting uses published evaluations.

These are not expensive. They are not politically dangerous in most of the places that could run them. They are simply not the studies that get commissioned.

Set that alongside what earlier parts found: no Indian survey asks whether a woman has private use of her phone; no national survey asks whether her private messages have been used against her; the honour-killing count is produced by a state that counts fraud to the rupee. **The pattern across thirteen parts is not that this subject is hard to study. It is that the specific studies which would settle it keep not being done.**

10.2 — Solid

BIAS ABOUT WOMEN'S CAPACITY IS NOT FIXED

From the only randomisation in this series. Rotation by village serial number, rural north India, two electoral cycles: evaluations of female leaders improved, more women won unreserved seats afterwards, and the gap between what parents wanted for sons and daughters narrowed by about a quarter. This passes all six tests.

THE OBSERVED LEVEL OF WOMEN'S PAID WORK IS SET BY ARRANGEMENTS, NOT PREFERENCE

Germany imposed the male-breadwinner model on the east and employment fell. Saudi Arabia lifted constraints and participation went from about 17 per cent to about 36 per cent in under a decade. Two countries, opposite directions, same conclusion.

VISIBLE RETURNS CHANGE FAMILY BEHAVIOUR FASTER THAN PAYMENTS DO

Bangladeshi girls near garment factories married later, had children later and stayed in school longer — by more than a scheme that paid families directly to keep them there.

NORMS OUTLIVE THE INSTITUTIONS THAT MADE THEM

East German women's employment patterns and attitudes persisted for roughly thirty years after the state that formed them ceased to exist.

INSTITUTIONAL COLLAPSE PRODUCES FERTILITY COLLAPSE

East German fertility fell from about 1.5 to below 0.8 in four years when the arrangements supporting early childbearing were removed — one of the sharpest peacetime declines ever recorded, and it recovered as the arrangements were rebuilt.

STRICT RULES AND MASS FEMALE EDUCATION ARE COMPATIBLE

Refuted as a universal claim by Iran alone: female literacy from about a third to above eighty per cent, and women a majority of university entrants, under compulsory veiling and segregation.

PROHIBITING A SYMPTOM RELOCATES THE BEHAVIOUR

Dowry prohibited in 1961 and it grew, moving from visible goods into undocumented cash. A marriage-age law announced in 1929 produced a documented surge of child marriages before it took effect. Protective labour laws removed the women rather than the danger.

FALLING FERTILITY PLUS SON PREFERENCE KILLS GIRLS, AND PROSPERITY DOES NOT PREVENT IT

India's child sex ratio fell from about 962 girls per 1,000 boys in 1981 to about 918 in 2011, and sex selection was strongest among richer, more educated, urban families — because small families plus son preference require action, and those families had access to the scan.

FORCE WORKS DOWNWARDS AND NOT UPWARDS

Coercion has repeatedly and rapidly reduced births and has never raised them. Iran ran both directions under one government within thirty years and got the same asymmetry as Romania and China.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: whether beliefs about what women *may* do move like beliefs about what women *can* do; what the null cases look like, since nobody records them; whether Iran's education boom was caused or merely not prevented; what Afghanistan's outcomes actually are rather than are projected to be; whether the Saudi change holds without its subsidies; whether East German persistence is culture or migration; and which reforms would have worked.

Solid: bias about women's capacity is not fixed; the level of women's paid work is set by arrangements rather than preference; visible returns beat payments; norms outlive their institutions by a generation; removing supporting arrangements collapses fertility; strict rules and mass female education are compatible; prohibiting a symptom relocates the behaviour; small families plus son preference kill girls and prosperity does not prevent it; and force works only downwards.

Three of the seven unknowns need **no new data —** only analyses of records that already exist, which are cheap, safe, and consistently not commissioned.

After thirteen parts the pattern is unmistakable: this subject is not hard to study. The specific studies that would settle it keep not being done.

Timeline

A century of experiments nobody designed as experiments.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1926	Turkey adopts a civil code abolishing polygamy and religious marriage — the sharpest legal break of its kind anywhere, and the model reformers across the region argued about for the rest of the century.
1929	India's act raising the minimum marriage age is passed in the autumn to take effect the following spring. The census two years later records a surge of child marriages in the gap.
1945–49	Korea and Germany are divided. Two populations with shared language and ancestry begin four decades under opposite theories of what women are for.
1961	India prohibits dowry. Over the following decades the practice spreads into communities that had not had it, and the amounts rise.
1966	Romania issues Decree 770. Births nearly double within a year, then decay back over a decade, at a cost of thousands of women's lives.
1967–75	Iran's Family Protection Law raises the marriage age, restricts polygamy and gives women grounds for divorce.
1977	West Germany removes the provision allowing a husband to forbid his wife's employment. East German women had been in near-universal employment for two decades.
1979	The Iranian revolution reverses all of it within a year. Female literacy then rises from about a third towards universal, and fertility begins the fastest collapse ever recorded.
1980s	Bangladesh's export garment industry spreads, placing factories by roads and ports rather than by local attitudes — creating, accidentally, a comparison group.
1990	German reunification. East German fertility falls from about 1.5 to below 0.8 in four years as every arrangement supporting early childbearing is removed at once.
1993	India's 73rd constitutional amendment reserves a third of village council leaderships for women and rotates them by village serial number — the only genuine lottery in this subject.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1994	India legislates against using diagnostic techniques to determine the sex of a foetus, thirteen years after the child sex ratio began falling.
1996–2001	The first Afghan exclusion of women from education and public life, poorly documented at the time.
2004	The first published analysis of the reservation lottery finds women in charge of village councils spent differently — on what the women there had actually asked for.
2011	India's census records about 918 girls per 1,000 boys aged nought to six, down from about 962 in 1981.
2012	Further work on the same lottery finds two rounds of a female village leader narrowed the gap between what parents wanted for sons and daughters, and closed the school attendance gap.
2013	A garment factory building collapses in Bangladesh, killing more than eleven hundred people — the women whose employment had delayed marriages and filled schools.
2016	Saudi Arabia announces its national economic programme with a target of 30 per cent female labour force participation. The rate at the time is around 17 per cent.
2018–19	The Saudi driving ban is lifted in June 2018; guardianship rules on passports and travel are relaxed in August 2019.
2021	In September, Afghan girls are barred from school beyond the sixth grade.
2022	In December, Afghan universities are closed to women, and employment with aid organisations is barred.
2024	Afghan restrictions extend to midwifery and nursing training — closing the last route to producing the only people permitted to attend Afghan women in childbirth.
2025–26	Saudi female labour force participation reaches around 36 per cent. An assessment published in April 2026 estimates the Afghan education ban has already cost about half a per cent of national output.
Next	**Part Fourteen starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Counterfactual	What would have happened otherwise. The thing every claim is compared against and nobody can observe.
Difference-in-differences	Comparing how much each of two groups changed, rather than comparing their levels. Removes anything that affected both.
Enabling constraint	A restriction that makes an activity possible by making it acceptable. The proposed explanation for why segregated schooling raised girls' enrolment in Iran.
Implicit bias	An automatic association that shapes judgement without the person intending it. Measured by comparing ratings of identical material attributed to a man or a woman.
Male-breadwinner model	Arrangements built on the assumption of one earner and one unpaid worker per household — assembled from tax rules, school hours and childcare, none of which mentions women.
Natural experiment	A real-world situation where something outside anyone's control assigned people to different conditions for reasons unrelated to the outcome being studied.
Perverse incentive	When a rule creates a reason to do more of the thing it was meant to stop.
Projection	A modelled estimate of what should follow, as opposed to a measurement of what did. The distinction collapses constantly in reporting.
Reference-group effect	People rate their lives against what they believe was available to them. If the comparison group changes, the score changes without the life changing.
Revealed preference	The idea that what people do tells you more than what they say. Its limit: a preference expressed under constraint is not a free preference either.
Substitution effect	When blocking one route redirects a behaviour into another channel rather than removing it.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Child sex ratio	The number of girls per 1,000 boys in a given age group. India's fell from about 962 in 1981 to about 918 in 2011 among children under six.
Confounding	When something else changed at the same time, so an effect cannot be attributed to the thing being studied. The failure mode of every revolution used as evidence.
The isolation test	Shorthand in this part for the fifth of the six checks: did the change arrive alone, or did a hundred other things arrive with it?
Quasi-experiment	A comparison where assignment was not random but was close enough to unrelated — factory placement decided by roads rather than by local attitudes, for instance.
Selection on the outcome	Assembling your evidence from cases that became famous because something visible happened, then treating the sample as representative.

About the Author

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This is the part twelve others were pointing at. Every previous one ended by admitting that the experiment could not be run. It turns out that history ran it repeatedly, that most of the famous cases are much weaker evidence than they appear, and that the strongest thing in the entire series is an Indian administrative rotation rule from 1993 that nobody designed to prove anything.

I am not an economist or a statistician. I read the primary sources carefully, follow the numbers wherever they go, and write down what I find in language that does not need a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record — peer-reviewed work in economics and demography, national censuses and labour force surveys, household surveys, and assessments by United Nations agencies — rather than new primary research.

What that archive is good at: the cases with proper comparison groups. The Indian reservation studies and the Bangladeshi factory work are well-identified, published in serious journals, and have survived scrutiny by people who wanted them to be wrong.

What it is bad at, and this part depends on the distinction more than any other: **the vivid cases are the weak ones.** Iran and Afghanistan are the two examples everybody reaches for and they are the two that fail the most tests. I have scored every case explicitly rather than letting the drama of a country do the work of evidence.

One caution about the Afghan material specifically. Nearly every consequence quoted anywhere — including in this part — is a projection rather than a measurement, and I have marked each one. Anyone citing those numbers as findings, in any direction, is citing a model.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Thirteen parts of asking what is true. Part Fourteen asks the question that has been waiting behind all of them: given everything above, what would actually work?

Chapter Seven of this part produced a diagnostic rule — prohibit a symptom while leaving the demand in place and the behaviour re-emerges somewhere worse. Chapter Two produced its opposite: change a structure and beliefs follow within a decade. Part Fourteen takes those two findings seriously and asks what follows from them.

The questions it takes on:

- What separates the interventions in this series that worked from the ones that backfired — and can the difference be stated precisely enough to use before the fact rather than after?
- If beliefs follow structures rather than arguments, what does that mean for everyone currently trying to win this by argument, on both sides?
- Which of the harms documented across thirteen parts have a lever attached, and which are genuinely load-bearing parts of arrangements that would have to be replaced rather than removed?
- What would a serious version of the humane road actually cost — the one Part Nine found had never been properly tried?
- Who is the actor in each case? Part Twelve found that three sensible answers were addressed to three different people, which is why the argument was incoherent. What does each of them actually hold?
- And the question that decides whether any of this is worth writing: where does a document like this one sit in a process that the evidence says is driven by structures rather than by persuasion?

END OF PART THIRTEEN OF SIXTEEN

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

PART FOURTEEN OF SIXTEEN

The Rules About Women

Part Fourteen — What Would Actually Work

Thirteen parts of asking what is true. This one asks what follows. It is the design chapter — which interventions have the right shape, which have the wrong one, and which of the things everybody argues about are not design problems at all.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

Before We Begin — Where We Left Off

Part Thirteen went looking for the experiments history ran by accident. It set out six tests and four tiers of evidence, and then applied them honestly, which had the effect of demoting almost every case that gets quoted in public.

Two findings came out of it that this part is built on.

The first is the strongest thing in the series. India's 1993 constitutional amendment reserved a third of village council leaderships for women and rotated them by village serial number — a lottery nobody intended. Villages that got a woman in the chair saw bias fall, saw more women win seats afterwards in elections that were not reserved, and saw the gap between what parents wanted for their sons and for their daughters narrow by about a quarter within seven years. No law changed for those girls. No one lectured their fathers. A woman was in the chair at the village meeting, and their fathers saw her there.

The second came from the failures. Four Indian reforms — the marriage-age act of 1929, dowry prohibition, the ban on sex determination, and protective labour laws — all produced the opposite of what they intended, and all four share one signature. Each prohibited a visible *symptom* while leaving the underlying demand completely untouched, and the behaviour re-emerged somewhere less visible and less regulated.

Put those two together and you have a diagnostic and its opposite. Change a structure and beliefs follow within a decade. Ban an output and it moves.

This part takes those two findings seriously and asks what follows from them. It is the least descriptive part of the series and the most exposed: everything before this could hide behind "here is what the evidence says", and a design chapter has to commit.

I should say at the outset what it is not. It is not a manifesto and it does not tell anybody what a society should want. Chapter Eight is entirely about the questions in this subject that are **not** design problems and cannot be solved by being cleverer about them — and refusing to treat a value conflict as an engineering task is, I think, the most useful thing in the part.

How this document is built

Six kinds of box, each doing one job.

The first explains a hard word the moment it appears.

WORD BOX

Intervention: anything deliberately done to change an outcome — a law, a payment, a building, a campaign, a quota, a school.

Why the word matters here: the whole argument of this part is that interventions come in a small number of **shapes**, that the shape predicts whether it works far better than the intention does, and that the shape most societies reach for first is the one with the worst record.

The second takes a number too big or abstract to picture and gives it a body.

IN REAL TERMS

“Seventy-nine per cent of the funds went on media advocacy.” That is a line in a committee report and it slides past.

Turn it round: for every hundred rupees released to states under India’s flagship scheme for the girl child, about seventy-nine bought advertisements about girls and about twenty-one reached anything else. Chapter Two is about why that is not a scandal of corruption. It is a scandal of design.

The third shows the actual evidence and then says what it cannot show.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

This part reuses the evidence tiers from Part Thirteen, because a design argument is only as good as the findings underneath it.

Tier one is the randomised Indian reservation study. **Tier two** is the quasi-random cases — Bangladeshi factory placement, divided Germany. **Tier three** is sharp before-and-after in one place. **Tier four** is a comparison somebody noticed.

Where a recommendation in this part rests on tier one or two, I say so. Where it rests on tier three or four, I say that too — and there is more of the second than I would like.

The fourth is for places where informed people genuinely disagree.

THE ARGUMENT — A WORKED EXAMPLE OF THE BOX

A question, then the sides, then a verdict that does not claim more certainty than exists.

ONE SIDE

Its strongest case, put the way its best advocate would put it, with the evidence it actually has.

THE OTHER SIDE

The same, with equal care. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Where things stand: what is genuinely agreed, and where the disagreement really sits.

What would settle it: the evidence that would decide it. Sometimes the honest answer is that nothing available would.

The fifth digs out what both sides are assuming without noticing.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Five in this part. The last one is turned on this series, and given what this part concludes about arguments, it is the one I have been walking towards since Part One.

The sixth closes every chapter in the plainest words available.

REMEMBER THIS

Six boxes. **Word** explains. **In Real Terms** converts. **How We Actually Know This** shows the evidence. **The Argument** gives every side its best shot. **The Hidden Assumption** digs underneath. **Remember This** closes the chapter.

Simple words, serious content, nothing left out.

Two warnings specific to this part

The first is that design writing is where honest research usually goes to die. Thirteen parts of carefully graded evidence can be spent very quickly on a list of confident recommendations, and the recommendations always sound more certain than the findings they came from. I have tried to hold the line by attaching an evidence tier to each proposal and by putting the trade-offs that cannot be designed away into their own chapter rather than burying them. Where I am extrapolating past what the evidence supports, I say so in the sentence rather than in a footnote.

The second is about who this is addressed to. Part Twelve found that the three sensible answers to a question about online harm were addressed to three completely different people — a parent on a Tuesday, a state over years, a community with no timeline — and that the argument was incoherent because everybody pretended they were advice to the same person. That finding governs this whole part. Chapter Nine is an explicit map of who holds which lever, and several of the most effective things in this document are not available to any reader of it. Saying so is not defeatism. It is the difference between a design and a wish.

What Is In This Part

CHAPTER ONE

The Design Problem

> *Before proposing anything you have to say what working would look like, and who would have to do it. Both questions have answers that most of this argument never reaches, because it is conducted between people who agree that the unit under discussion is a rule.*

1.1 — What "work" would mean

Thirteen parts have produced a large number of findings and no criterion. So here is the criterion, stated before any proposal, so that it cannot be adjusted afterwards to fit whatever I end up recommending.

An intervention works if it **changes an outcome somebody actually cares about, without moving the cost onto someone who did not choose it, and without the behaviour reappearing somewhere worse.**

Each clause is doing work and each corresponds to a failure this series has documented.

The first clause rules out interventions that change a number without changing a life — Part Thirteen's warning about scoreboards, in operational form.

The second rules out the entire category identified in Part Twelve: solutions whose whole cost lands on a girl, which are cheap for everyone else precisely because of that.

The third rules out the four backfires in Part Thirteen, where the behaviour was banned and simply relocated.

WORD BOX

Incidence: an idea from public finance meaning *who actually ends up bearing a cost*, as distinct from who is nominally charged.

A tax on a company may be paid by the company and borne by its customers. A rule aimed at protecting a daughter may be written by a legislature, applied by a family and borne entirely by her.

Why it matters: almost every argument in this series is conducted about the nominal target of a rule. Almost none of it is conducted about the incidence, which is where the interesting question lives.

1.2 — Removing a rule is not the same as replacing it

Here is the second half of the framing, and it is what separates this part from most reform writing.

Every rule described across this series is doing a job for somebody. Not a good job, not a just job, but a job — solving some problem that would still exist if the rule vanished tonight. Part Thirteen's four backfires are all the same event: a rule was removed or forbidden, the problem it had been solving did not go anywhere, and something worse grew in the gap.

That gives a design instruction that is uncomfortable for reformers and does not comfort traditionalists either. **You cannot evaluate the removal of a rule without knowing what it was doing.** And you cannot know that from the rule's stated purpose, because stated purposes are unreliable — Part Twelve found that the rule's declared beneficiary is very often not the one it is organised around.

IN REAL TERMS

Take dowry, which Part Thirteen showed grew after being prohibited.

What was it doing? Among other things it was moving property to a daughter at the one moment her family transferred anything to her at all — in a system where she would inherit little or nothing otherwise. It was also pricing a groom in a marriage market where families compete.

Prohibition removed none of that. Daughters still did not inherit. Grooms were still priced. So the transfer continued, in cash, undocumented, with every check on it gone.

The reform that would have worked was not a ban on the payment. It was making daughters inherit — which is a change to what the rule was for, rather than to what the rule says.

1.3 — Intentions predict nothing

One more piece of the frame, and it is the one that makes this part possible.

Go back through the failures. Every one was designed by people who wanted what this series wants. The 1929 marriage act was passed by reformers. Dowry prohibition was passed by reformers. The ban on sex determination was passed by reformers. Protective labour laws were written by people trying to protect women, in response to genuine hazards.

And the successes were frequently not designed at all. The Indian reservation lottery was an administrative rotation rule. The Bangladeshi factories were built for export earnings by people with no interest in girls' schooling. Iran's education expansion was produced by a government that would have been horrified by the demographic result.

That pattern is not a coincidence and it is not an argument against trying. It is evidence that **the shape of an intervention predicts its result far better than the intention behind it does** — which is good news, because shape is something you can inspect in advance and intention is not.

THE ARGUMENT — IS ANY OF THIS DESIGNABLE?

Before going further it is worth taking seriously the position that the whole enterprise of this part is a mistake.

SOCIETIES ARE NOT DESIGNED AND THE ATTEMPT DOES HARM

The record in Part Thirteen is four serious failures against a handful of accidental successes, and the successes were accidents. That is what you would expect if these arrangements are far too complex to steer — evolved solutions to problems nobody has fully articulated, where every deliberate change produces consequences the designer did not foresee. The honest lesson is humility: describe, understand, and stop reaching for the lever. Most of the improvement in women's lives over two centuries came from economic growth and technology rather than from anybody's programme.

REFUSING TO DESIGN IS ITSELF A DESIGN

The status quo is not the absence of intervention. Part Thirteen established this about West Germany: a tax rule, a school timetable and a legal provision together constituted a vigorous programme to keep married women at home, and it read as the natural state of things precisely because nobody announced it. Declining to intervene means leaving in place arrangements that were built, are maintained, and have an incidence. And the successes were not accidents in the relevant sense — the reservation lottery was designed by somebody, even if the attitude effects were not foreseen. What was accidental was the **discovery**, not the mechanism.

Where things stand: the second answer is stronger on the facts and the first is stronger as a warning. There is no available position of not intervening, because the arrangements in question are maintained by law, by money and by institutions every day. What the failure record supports is not abstention but a specific kind of caution — the kind Chapter Three tries to make operational, where the question asked before acting is not "is this a good idea" but "what shape is it".

What would settle it: a systematic accounting of interventions in this area scored by shape and by outcome. Part Thirteen noted that nobody has assembled one, and it remains the single most useful piece of unfunded research in this whole subject.

Why people care so much: because "you cannot design a society" is a genuine intellectual position and also the most convenient possible thing for anybody who benefits from the current arrangement to believe.

Both sides of that exchange are arguing about the same object, and it is worth asking whether it is the right object.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE RULE IS THE UNIT

Watch how this argument is conducted, anywhere, by anyone. One side wants a rule gone. The other wants it kept. A third wants it modified. Every participant is treating **the rule** as the thing under discussion — the object to be attacked, defended or amended.

But a rule is an answer. Somewhere behind it is a question, and the question is the durable thing. Dowry answers "how does property reach a daughter and how are grooms priced". Seclusion answers "how is a woman kept safe in a place with no policing". Early marriage answers "how does a family secure a match before the market moves against it". Son preference answers "who will support us when we are old".

Notice what follows. If you win the argument about the rule and the question is still there, you have not won anything — you have created a vacancy, and something will fill it. That is precisely what Part Thirteen documented four times over. And it explains something otherwise puzzling: why these arrangements are so resilient in the face of law, education and prosperity. They are not being held in place by stubbornness. They are being held in place by unsolved problems.

The general form: arguing about an answer without identifying the question. It runs through every reform debate. Abolishing a practice without asking what it was doing. Closing an institution without asking what it was absorbing. Banning a substance without asking what people were treating with it.

Why this one is load-bearing for the rest of this part: it converts the whole exercise from a moral argument into an engineering one, and it does so without conceding anything moral. You can believe a rule is monstrous *and* accept that it is solving a real problem. In fact those two beliefs together are the only position from which anything ever gets fixed, because the first supplies the motive and the second supplies the specification.

With that established, the rest of this part is an attempt to write the specification.

REMEMBER THIS

An intervention works if it changes an outcome somebody cares about, **without moving the cost onto someone who did not choose it**, and without the behaviour reappearing somewhere worse. Each clause corresponds to a documented failure.

Incidence — who actually bears a cost, rather than who is nominally charged — is where the interesting question lives, and almost none of this argument is conducted about it.

Every rule in this series is **doing a job**. Remove it without replacing the function and something worse grows in the gap. That is what all four of Part Thirteen’s backfires were.

Intentions predict nothing. Every documented failure was designed by reformers; several of the successes were accidents produced by people with entirely different aims. The shape of an intervention predicts its result far better than the intention behind it, which is good news, because shape can be inspected in advance.

And the rule is not the unit. A rule is an answer to a question, and the question is the durable thing — which is why these arrangements survive law, education and prosperity. They are not held in place by stubbornness. They are held in place by unsolved problems.

CHAPTER TWO

Structure Beats Argument

> *The central finding of this part, and the most expensive one to accept — because it disqualifies almost everything currently being done, almost everything both sides are arguing about, and this document.*

2.1 — The finding, stated plainly

Beliefs about women follow arrangements rather than leading them. Part Thirteen established this from three directions and one of them was randomised.

In Indian villages, a rotation rule put a woman in the council chair and, within seven years, bias fell, more women won unreserved seats, and the gap between what parents wanted for sons and daughters narrowed by about a quarter. Nobody argued with those parents. Something was rearranged and their views moved.

In Bangladesh, garment factories opened where the roads were. Girls nearby stayed in school longer than girls in a scheme that paid their families to keep them there. Nobody persuaded anyone; a wage made visible what school was for.

In East Germany, forty years of arrangements produced attitudes that outlived the state, the ideology and the childcare system by another thirty years.

Three cases, three countries, three mechanisms, one direction. Change what people do and what they think follows. The reverse — change what they think and hope the doing follows — has a much worse record, and India has run an unusually clean test of it.

2.2 — Seventy-nine per cent on advertisements

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

India launched a flagship national programme in 2015 aimed at the falling child sex ratio and at girls' education. It is one of the most recognised government campaigns in the country.

In December 2021 a parliamentary committee on the empowerment of women tabled its report on the scheme. Of ₹446.72 crore released to states between 2016 and 2019, it found that **78.91 per cent was spent on media advocacy**. Across a slightly different window, a government answer in the upper house put media spending at ₹401.04 crore out of ₹683.05 crore — about 58 per cent.

The committee also found that of the funds actually released to states across the scheme's first six years, only about a quarter had been spent by them at all.

What this evidence is good at: it is the government's own accounting, examined by a committee of its own legislature, chaired by a member of the governing party. Nobody hostile produced these numbers.

What it cannot establish: that the scheme achieved nothing. India's sex ratio at birth has improved over the same period, and attributing that improvement between the campaign, enforcement of the older law on sex determination, falling fertility and rising incomes is genuinely hard. The committee's point — and mine — is not that the outcome failed. It is where the money went.

To see why that matters, put the spending next to what Part Thirteen established about the practice it was aimed at.

IN REAL TERMS

Part Thirteen established what actually produces missing girls: small desired family size, plus son preference, plus access to a scan. It also established that the practice was **strongest among richer, more educated, urban families —** the ones most exposed to national media and most likely to have already seen every advertisement.

So the money was spent telling people that daughters are valuable, and the people doing the selecting were disproportionately the ones who had heard that message most often, in the best Hindi, on the largest screens.

The campaign was aimed at a shortage of belief. The problem was not a shortage of belief.

2.3 — Why persuasion is reached for anyway

It would be easy and wrong to treat this as waste or cynicism. There are four reasons a ministry reaches for advertising, and only one of them is bad.

It is the only lever some actors hold. A national ministry cannot build a village school, hire a doctor or change what a household does at dinner. Those belong to states, districts and families. What a ministry with a budget and no operational reach can do is buy media. Advertising is what an institution does when it has money and no lever — and Chapter Nine is entirely about that mismatch.

It is measurable immediately. Reach, impressions, recall. A campaign can be evaluated within a quarter. A school built this year shows up in a sex ratio in twenty.

It is politically safe. Nobody's interests are threatened by an advertisement. A change to inheritance law threatens property; a change to school hours threatens employers; a quota threatens incumbents. A message threatens nobody, which is precisely why it changes nothing.

And it is genuinely popular. People like these campaigns. They feel like a country deciding to be better.

WORD BOX

Behaviour change communication: the technical name for campaigns that try to shift what people do by changing what they believe or what they think others believe.

It is a real field with real successes — handwashing, oral rehydration, seatbelts, vaccination, smoking. Those successes are not in doubt and they have saved enormous numbers of lives.

Why it matters that the successes look alike: every one of them changed a **cheap** behaviour that nobody had an interest in defending. No family's property, lineage or standing depended on not washing their hands. Chapter Two's argument is about what happens when the behaviour is load-bearing.

That distinction is where the real disagreement sits, and both sides of it have serious evidence.

THE ARGUMENT — IS PERSUASION USELESS HERE?

The people who run norm-change campaigns are not fools and their field has genuine victories. The disagreement is about which category this problem is in.

NORM CAMPAIGNS WORK AND THIS ONE WAS BADLY EXECUTED

Social norm change is one of the best-evidenced tools in development. Campaigns have moved handwashing, sanitation, vaccination and smoking at national scale, and several have moved practices with deep social roots — attitudes to open defecation shifted in India within a decade after generations of failure. What matters is design: campaigns work when they target what people believe *others* think, when they are delivered by trusted local figures rather than by celebrities, and when they are paired with something concrete. The Indian campaign discussed above did the celebrity version without the concrete pairing. That is an argument about execution, not about the category.

THE SUCCESSES AND THE FAILURES DIFFER IN KIND, NOT IN QUALITY

Line up the victories. Handwashing, seatbelts, sanitation, vaccination: in every case the behaviour was cheap, the beneficiary was the person changing, and **nobody lost anything when it changed.** Now line up the norms in this series. Son preference is load-bearing for old-age security and property. Dowry is load-bearing for a marriage market. Seclusion is load-bearing for a family's standing. Each has a constituency that loses when it goes. A message cannot outbid an interest, and no amount of design makes it able to.

Where things stand: this resolves better than most arguments in the series, because both sides are describing real cases and the dividing line is visible. Persuasion works on behaviours that are cheap to change and have no defender. It fails on behaviours that are load-bearing for property, lineage, security or standing. That is a usable test you can apply before spending anything — and every norm this series has examined falls on the failing side of it.

What would settle it: a campaign of comparable scale and quality run against a load-bearing norm, with a proper comparison group. Several sanitation programmes come close and their results are contested. Nothing of that quality has been run on son preference or on dowry.

Why people care so much: because campaigns are the one intervention that a national government, an international agency and a well-meaning individual can all fund, announce and feel good about. Withdrawing that leaves most of the people currently working on this with nothing to do that is within their reach.

Underneath that whole exchange is a premise nobody in it states, and it is the one this chapter has been circling.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT BELIEFS ARE WHAT NEEDS CHANGING

Look at what everybody in this argument is actually doing. Traditionalists write, preach and post, trying to convince people that the old arrangements were right. Reformers write, campaign and post, trying to convince people they were wrong. Governments buy advertisements. Both sides believe the other side's **beliefs** are the problem and that changing them is the work.

> The evidence says beliefs are downstream. They followed a rotation rule in West Bengal. They followed a factory in Bangladesh. They followed a childcare system in East Germany for thirty years after it closed. In none of those cases did anybody argue anyone into anything.
>
> Which means the entire visible surface of this argument — the essays, the campaigns, the speeches, the ferocious online exchanges — is being conducted on the layer that responds least, by people who have concluded that the other side simply needs to hear a better case.
>
> **The general form:** intervening where the argument is rather than where the causation is. It appears everywhere the visible conflict and the operative mechanism sit on different layers. Debating a national mood rather than the housing market that produced it. Arguing about a workforce's attitude to safety rather than the shift pattern that produces the accidents.
>
> And this box has an obvious application that I am going to state now rather than hide until the end. **This document is an argument.** Fourteen parts of it. If the finding in this chapter is right, then the form I have chosen is the least effective one available, and I have spent a great deal of care on the layer the evidence says moves last. Chapter Nine is where I take that seriously rather than acknowledging it and carrying on.

None of which means the work is worthless. It means the layer has to be chosen deliberately rather than by default, and the next chapter is about what the choices actually are.

REMEMBER THIS

Beliefs follow arrangements. A rotation rule in West Bengal, a factory in Bangladesh, a childcare system in East Germany — three countries, three mechanisms, one direction, and nobody argued anyone into anything.

India's flagship scheme for the girl child spent **78.91 per cent** of the funds released to states over three years on media advocacy, by its own parliament's accounting — while the practice it targeted was strongest among the families most exposed to that media.

Ministries reach for advertising for good reasons, not corrupt ones: it is often the **only lever they hold**, it is measurable within a quarter, it threatens nobody's interests, and people like it. The third reason is why it does not work.

Persuasion has real victories — handwashing, seatbelts, sanitation — and they share a feature: the behaviour was cheap and **nobody lost anything when it changed**. Every norm in this series is load-bearing for property, lineage, security or standing.

Which means both sides of this argument, and this document, are working on the layer that responds least.

CHAPTER THREE

The Four Shapes

> *Every intervention in this series is one of four shapes, and the shape predicts the outcome. Two of them have almost no successes. One of them has almost no failures. Nearly all the money goes to the first two.*

3.1 — The taxonomy

Strip the intentions away and sort by mechanism, and everything in fourteen parts falls into four kinds.

Shape one: ban the output. Identify the visible behaviour and forbid it. Dowry prohibition. The ban on sex determination. Raising the marriage age. Forbidding night work. Village councils banning girls' phones.

Shape two: change the price. Leave the decision where it is and alter what it costs. Cash for a third child. Conditional payments to keep girls in school. Tax relief for mothers. Subsidised transport for working women.

Shape three: change who is in the room. Put a person where people can see them, repeatedly, doing a thing they were believed not to do. Reserved council seats. Women in a workplace, a courtroom, a police station.

Shape four: supply the substitute. Work out what the rule was doing and provide that function another way. A pension instead of a son. Inheritance instead of dowry. Childcare instead of a wife at home. Policing and transport instead of seclusion.

And the shape from Chapter Two, which is really a category error rather than a fifth option: **tell people to stop.**

3.2 — The scoring

INTERVENTION	SHAPE	RESULT, AND EVIDENCE TIER
Reserved council seats, India 1993	Who is in the room	Bias fell, aspirations narrowed, more women elected after. Tier one — randomised.

INTERVENTION	SHAPE	RESULT, AND EVIDENCE TIER
Garment factories, Bangladesh	Substitute, by accident	Later marriage, later childbirth, longer schooling — beating a cash scheme. Tier two.
East German childcare	Substitute	Near-universal employment; attitudes outlived the institutions by thirty years. Tier two.
Saudi driving and travel rules	Ban removed	Participation roughly doubled in under a decade. Tier three — bundled with inducements.
Conditional payments for girls' schooling	Price	Real but smaller than a nearby factory. Tier two.
Pronatalist cash, several countries	Price	A few hundredths to two tenths of a child for enormous sums. Tier three.
Dowry prohibition, 1961	Ban the output	Practice spread and grew; payment moved into undocumented cash. Tier three.
Sex determination ban, 1994	Ban the output	Ratio kept falling for years; enforcement rare. Tier three.
Marriage age act, 1929	Ban the output	Documented surge of child marriages before commencement. Tier three.
Protective labour laws	Ban the output	Removed the women rather than the danger. Tier three.
National campaign for the girl child	Tell people to stop	79% of released funds on media; effect on the target practice unestablished. Tier four.

The pattern is not subtle. Every entry in the "ban the output" row failed or backfired. The one unambiguous tier-one success is "who is in the room". The other successes are substitutes, one of which was built by accident by an export industry.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The strongest test of shape three outside village politics is Norway, which from 2003 required large listed companies to have at least 40 per cent female board representation, with full compliance by 2008.

What it achieved: the target, comprehensively. Board representation went from under a tenth to the mandated level within five years, which settles the question of whether quotas fill seats.

What it did not achieve: much movement in the layers beneath. Studies looking for spillover into senior management and the wider pipeline have generally found modest effects, and a small number of women ended up holding several directorships each.

Why this matters for the taxonomy rather than against it: a board is invisible. Nobody in Norway watches a directors' meeting. If the active ingredient is repeated public observation, as the Indian case suggests, then a board quota supplies the seat without supplying the mechanism — and the modest result is what the theory predicts rather than a refutation of it.

3.3 — Why the shapes behave this way

There is a single explanation and it comes from Chapter One.

Shapes one and five leave the underlying demand completely untouched. A ban tells people they may not do the thing; the reason they were doing it is unchanged, so the behaviour relocates. Exhortation does not even do that much.

Shape two touches the margin. A payment changes the calculation without changing who is doing the calculating or what their alternatives are — which is why its effects are real, small, and stop when the money stops.

Shapes three and four change the structure itself. A woman in the chair alters what people have observed. A pension alters why you needed a son. Neither requires anyone to agree with anything, and neither has to be maintained by persuasion once it is in place.

IN REAL TERMS

Take a family deciding whether to educate a daughter, and run the four shapes at them.

Ban: it is now illegal to keep her home. They keep her home; nobody comes.

Price: they are paid to send her. She goes while the payment lasts, and it buys attendance rather than schooling — she is in the room and nobody expects anything of her there.

Who is in the room: the woman running the village council is educated and everyone can see what that got her. The father revises what school is *for*.

Substitute: a factory forty minutes away hires literate young women at a wage the family can see arriving in a neighbour's house every month.

The last two do not need the father to agree with anything. They change what agreeing would even mean.

One of those two shapes has a name that everybody argues about, and the arguing is mostly about the wrong thing.

WORD BOX

Quota or reservation: a rule setting aside a share of positions for a defined group.

Why it belongs in shape three rather than shape one: a quota is usually attacked as a restriction and defended as fairness, and both descriptions miss what the evidence says it does. In the Indian case the measurable effect was not on the women who held the seats. It was on **everybody who watched them hold the seats** — their neighbours' bias, their neighbours' daughters' school attendance, their neighbours' expectations. The seat was the delivery mechanism. Exposure was the intervention.

Which raises the question that decides how far any of this can be taken.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES "WHO IS IN THE ROOM" WORK OUTSIDE VILLAGE POLITICS?

This matters because it is the shape with the best evidence, and the temptation is to apply it everywhere immediately.

IT GENERALISES, AND THE MECHANISM IS NOT ABOUT POLITICS

What produced the effect was repeated public observation of a woman doing something believed to be beyond women. That is not specific to councils. It is the same mechanism people invoke about the first woman in any profession, and it predicts that the effect should appear wherever visibility and repetition are present. The Indian evidence is tier one, it comes from one of the least promising settings anybody could have chosen, and it worked within seven years. Demanding a separate randomised trial for every institution before acting is a standard nobody applies to interventions they already like.

THE RECORD OUTSIDE POLITICS IS MUCH WEAKER

Corporate board quotas are the best-studied comparison and their results are modest: they reliably increase women on boards and have done much less to change the pipeline beneath, with a small number of women taking multiple seats. That is exactly what you would expect if the effective ingredient were **visibility** rather than the seat — and almost nobody watches a board. A village leader is seen by every household every week; a director is seen by an annual report. Applying the panchayat finding to boardrooms is applying a mechanism to a setting that lacks the mechanism.

Where things stand: both sides are pointing at the same thing without saying it, and stating it makes the taxonomy predictive. The active ingredient is not the position. It is **how many people watch somebody occupy it, how often, and whether they know her**. That predicts a large effect for village councils, schools, clinics, police stations, buses and shopfronts, and a small one for boards, committees and anything the public never sees. It also predicts that a badly designed quota in a low-visibility institution will produce the tokenism its critics describe — and that this is a design failure rather than a refutation.

What would settle it: a randomised or quasi-random quota in a high-visibility, non-political institution, with attitudes measured in the surrounding population. Health and education systems in several countries allocate posts in ways that come close to this and have never been analysed for it.

Why people care so much: because quotas are the most politically contested intervention in this entire subject, and both the case for them and the case against them are usually made about fairness to the individuals appointed — which the evidence suggests is not where the effect is.

Shapes three and four both depend on knowing what a rule was doing in the first place. That is the next chapter.

REMEMBER THIS

Four shapes: **ban the output**, **change the price**, **change who is in the room**, **supply the substitute**. Plus telling people to stop, which is a category error rather than a fifth option.

Scored across fourteen parts, every "ban the output" case failed or backfired. Price changes are real, small and stop when the money stops. The one tier-one success is **who is in the room**, and the strongest accidental success was a **substitute** built by an export industry.

The explanation is one sentence: bans and exhortation leave the demand untouched, price changes touch the margin, and the other two **change the structure so that nobody has to be persuaded of anything**.

A quota is not usefully described as a restriction or as fairness. In the Indian case the effect was not on the women who held the seats but on **everybody who watched them hold the seats.**

Which makes the active ingredient visibility, not the position — so the shape predicts a large effect in village councils, schools, clinics, buses and shopfronts, and a small one anywhere the public never looks.

CHAPTER FOUR

Find the Job the Rule Is Doing

> *Chapter One said a rule is an answer to a question. This chapter names the questions. Four of them have obvious substitutes that have been partly tried, and one turns out not to be doing the job it claims to be doing at all.*

4.1 — Dowry: property that arrives at a wedding

Ask what dowry is for and the usual answers are about greed or about tradition. Neither is a function. Two things are.

It moves property to a daughter at the one moment anything is transferred to her, in a system where she historically inherited little. And it prices a groom in a market where families compete for the better ones.

Prohibition touched neither, which is why Part Thirteen found the practice growing after 1961. The substitute is not a stricter ban. It is making daughters inherit — which India did in 2005, giving daughters equal rights in ancestral property.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The 2005 amendment has been studied, partly because several Indian states had already made similar changes earlier, which lets researchers compare states that reformed at different times.

What the work broadly finds: daughters in reformed settings became more likely actually to inherit land, and there is evidence of gains in their education. That is the shape the theory predicts.

What complicates it seriously: at least one careful study found that in some settings the reform was associated with **worse** survival outcomes for girls — on the reasoning that a daughter who will now take a share of the land is more expensive to have, in exactly the families that were already making that calculation. This finding is contested and the literature has not settled.

What that means for this chapter: even a correctly shaped reform, aimed squarely at the function rather than at the symptom, can produce a backfire — because supplying the substitute changes the price of a daughter as well as her position. Nothing here is safe, and anybody who tells you otherwise is selling something.

4.2 — Seclusion: safety in the absence of policing

Restricting where a woman may go is the oldest rule in this series. Two jobs sit under it. It manages a genuine physical risk in places with no reliable policing, no lighting and no safe transport. And it protects the family's standing, by controlling what can be said about her.

The first of those has an obvious substitute and it is not an argument. It is infrastructure.

IN REAL TERMS

Research on women students in Delhi found something precise enough to build policy on. Faced with a choice between a better college and a safer route, many chose the safer route — accepting a substantially lower-quality institution to avoid a journey they perceived as dangerous.

Put that in a life. A young woman's career ceiling is being set, before she sits a single examination, by the lighting and crowding on a particular stretch of road between her house and a campus.

That is not a norm about women. It is a street. And a street can be changed by a municipality without anybody's beliefs moving at all.

This is shape four from the last chapter in its purest form. Lighting, buses, staffed stations and enforcement against harassment do not require a single family to revise its view of women. They remove the reason the restriction was rational.

4.3 — Early marriage and son preference

Early marriage is doing three jobs. It secures a match before the market moves against a family. It shortens the window in which a daughter's reputation could be damaged — which, after Part Twelve, is a window that no longer closes. And it stops the cost of keeping her.

The substitute that has demonstrably worked is not a higher legal age. It is a visible return to keeping her: the Bangladeshi factories delayed marriages more effectively than a scheme that paid families directly, because a wage changes what the extra years are *for*.

Son preference is doing the most concrete job of all, and Part Nine named it: children are the retirement system. In India that is not a metaphor — a 2007 statute obliges children to maintain elderly parents, and roughly one person in five over sixty has any pension at all.

So the substitute is a pension, and the evidence for the mechanism runs the other way round in a way that should make everyone pause. Part Nine found that introducing public pensions is followed by measurable falls in fertility, because the reason for having many children weakens. The same lever that reduces the need for a son reduces the number of children — which is a benefit and a cost at once, and Chapter Eight is where that stops being a design problem.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Load-bearing:** borrowed from building. A load-bearing wall is holding something up; remove it and the structure above comes down. A decorative wall can go without consequence.
>
> Why the distinction organises this whole chapter: the rules in this series are not equally load-bearing. Some are holding up a real function — property transfer, old-age security, physical safety. Others are holding up nothing but themselves.
>
> And you cannot tell which is which by looking at how fiercely they are defended. Fierceness tracks how central a rule feels, not what it is carrying.

4.4 — The rule that is not doing its stated job

Now the interesting case, because it is the one where the functional analysis produces a surprise.

Rules about women's sexual conduct — the subject of Parts Ten and Twelve — have a standard functional explanation, offered by anthropologists and by traditionalists alike. They exist to secure **paternity certainty**. A man investing in children needs to know they are his, and in the absence of any way to establish that, the rules do the work.

That is a genuine function and for most of human history it was unsolvable. Then, in the 1990s, it was solved. Paternity testing is cheap, reliable and universally available.

And nothing happened. The rules did not weaken. No society revised its expectations of daughters because a laboratory could now settle the question in a week. In India, in Europe, anywhere — the norm continued exactly as before.

Which tells you something the functional analysis could not tell you any other way. **If paternity certainty were the job, the invention that supplied it would have retired the rule.** It did not, so the job is something else — and Parts Ten and Twelve identified what: a marriage market that prices a claim about her, and a household asset that her conduct can damage.

This is worth holding on to as a method. Supplying a substitute is a test as well as a remedy. If you provide the stated function and the rule does not move, the stated function was not the function.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES SUPPLYING THE SUBSTITUTE ACTUALLY RETIRE THE RULE?

Everything above assumes that solving the underlying problem makes the rule loosen. That assumption deserves examination, because there is evidence on both sides of it.

YES — A RULE WITHOUT A FUNCTION LOSES ITS CONSTITUENCY

These arrangements survive because somebody needs them, not because people are stubborn. Remove the need and the defenders drift away, because defending a rule is costly and nobody pays a cost for nothing. This is why prosperity, pensions and policing have coincided with the loosening of exactly the rules whose functions they replaced, in country after country. It also explains the timing: the loosening does not arrive with the argument, it arrives a decade or two after the substitute does.

NO — RULES OUTLIVE THEIR FUNCTIONS, SOMETIMES BY CENTURIES

Part Thirteen measured this directly: East German attitudes persisted thirty years after the institutions that produced them ceased to exist. Norms are sticky in both directions. And they acquire new functions — a rule that began as paternity management becomes a marker of respectability, of caste, of piety, of belonging, and each of those is a fresh reason to keep it after the original one has gone. The paternity testing case is the proof: the function was supplied and the rule did not notice.

Where things stand: the second side is describing a lag and the first is describing a direction, and both are right about what they are describing. Supplying the substitute appears to be **necessary and not sufficient**: it removes the reason without removing the habit, and the habit takes something like a generation to follow. That is consistent with everything in Part Thirteen, and it is bad news for anyone expecting a reform to show results within an electoral cycle.

What would settle it: tracking a specific rule in a specific place across the decades after its function was substituted — pension coverage against son preference is the cleanest available pairing, and the data to attempt it exists in several countries.

Why people care so much: because the lag is exactly long enough that every reform can be declared a failure by its opponents and a success by its supporters, using the same evidence, for about twenty years.

All of which assumes somebody can act at all. The next chapter is about who can actually reach the place where these decisions are made.

REMEMBER THIS

Dowry moves property to a daughter in a system where she inherits little, and prices a groom. The substitute is inheritance, not a stricter ban — and even that produced a documented complication, because a daughter who will inherit is more expensive.

Seclusion manages real physical risk where there is no policing. Research on Delhi students found women accepting substantially worse colleges to avoid routes they perceived as dangerous. That is not a norm about women. It is a street, and a municipality can change it.

Early marriage is answered better by a visible return to keeping her than by a higher legal age. **Son preference** is answered by a pension — which also reduces fertility, so the lever cuts both ways.

Not all rules are **load-bearing**, and you cannot tell which are by how fiercely they are defended. Fierceness tracks how central a rule feels, not what it carries.

And the test case: paternity certainty was the stated function of the rules about women's sexual conduct. It was solved in the 1990s, cheaply and universally, and nothing moved — which means the stated function was never the function.

CHAPTER FIVE

Who Can Reach Inside a Household

> *Part Eleven found that a rule lands where it can be enforced. The same is true of a reform, and almost everything in this series happens in a room the state cannot enter. Four things get in anyway, and India already operates the largest of them.*

5.1 — The reach problem

Part Eleven asked why the rules in this series fall on daughters rather than sons and found an answer that was not about biology or belief. They fall where they can be **enforced**. A household can reach a daughter living in it. It cannot reach a son who has moved to another city, and it has never seriously tried.

Turn that finding round and it becomes a design constraint, and a brutal one.

A reform also lands where it can be enforced. And nearly everything documented across fourteen parts happens somewhere no state can go: a conversation at dinner, a decision about a scan, a phone handed over on demand, a marriage arranged between two families, a daughter told what she may study.

Passing a law about any of that is passing a law about a room nobody official will ever be in. That is why Part Thirteen's four backfires all involved prohibitions on things that occur inside families, and why the successes involved schools, factories and council chambers.

5.2 — What a state actually controls

Be precise about it, because the list is shorter than the rhetoric on both sides suggests.

A state controls the institutions it runs — schools, clinics, buses, courts, police stations. It controls money it transfers and to whose name. It controls records: who is registered as born, married, employed, owning land. And it controls what it licenses and who it hires.

That is genuinely a lot. What it does not control is who decides anything in a household, what is said to a daughter, or what a family concludes about her.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **Household bargaining power:** the idea that a household is not one decision-maker with one set of wants, but several people with different wants, and that what the household does depends on their relative positions.
>
> What determines a person's position: what they contribute, what they could get by leaving, and what they control directly.
>
> Why this is the central concept of the chapter: it explains how something outside a household can change what happens inside it **without anybody entering**. You do not need to reach the room. You need to change what one person in it could do if she left it.

5.3 — Four things that get in

A wage. An income arriving in her name is the single most studied instrument here. It changes what she contributes, and — more importantly — what she could survive on if she left. Both raise her position in every decision the household makes, including decisions that have nothing to do with money. Nobody has to enter the house for this to happen. Note that a wage does this and a payment to the household does not, or does much less, which is why the Bangladeshi factories beat a scheme that paid families.

A record. A registered marriage is checkable; an unregistered one is invisible, and an invisible marriage cannot be underage because nothing about it exists. This is why marriage-age laws without registration produce nothing — they forbid an event that leaves no trace. Registration is unglamorous, cheap, and the precondition for every other rule about marriage being anything but a sentence.

A school roll. Attendance is observable from outside, which makes it one of the very few things about a girl's life that a state can actually see. And the school itself is a place where she is outside the household's supervision for six hours a day, five days a week, next to other girls.

Other women, in her house, for another reason. This is the one that is under-used, and India already operates it at a scale no other country comes close to.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Since 2005 India has run a village health worker programme staffed by roughly **a million women**, each recruited from and resident in the village she serves. They are trained on maternal and child health, they are paid on activity rather than salary, and their job requires them to enter other people's houses and talk to the women in them.

What is established: the programme has been credited with substantial contributions to institutional delivery, immunisation coverage and maternal health outcomes, and it received international recognition in 2022. Its health effects are the reason it exists and the reason it is documented.

What has never been studied, as far as I can find: its effect on anything in this series. Nobody has asked whether villages with a more active health worker show the exposure effects that Part Thirteen's reserved seats produced — changed attitudes, changed aspirations for daughters, changed school attendance.

Why that is a striking gap. This is a million women, in a million villages, with a legitimate reason to be inside houses where a council leader never goes, doing a job that requires literacy and produces an income. On the mechanism identified in Chapter Three — visible, repeated observation of a woman doing a thing — it is the largest such intervention ever built anywhere, and it was built for something else.

Set that beside the one case in this series where the mechanism was actually measured.

IN REAL TERMS

A village council leader is seen at meetings. A health worker is seen in your kitchen, every few weeks, for years, weighing your baby.

The reservation study found that watching a woman run a council for two terms narrowed the gap between what parents wanted for their sons and their daughters by about a quarter.

Nobody has ever measured what watching a woman do a skilled job in your own house, repeatedly, over a decade, does to the same number. India has been running that experiment on a million villages for twenty years and has never looked.

Before recommending any of that, there is an objection worth taking seriously, and it is not a small one.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD ANYONE BE TRYING TO REACH INSIDE HOUSEHOLDS AT ALL?

This chapter has been treating household reach as a design goal. That deserves a challenge, and there is a serious one.

THE HOUSEHOLD IS THE LAST PRIVATE SPACE AND REACHING INTO IT IS DANGEROUS

Part Twelve established that a capability does not know what it is for. Build the ability to see and act inside families to protect daughters, and you have built the ability to see and act inside families. The same visits, records and registers serve a benign state and a hostile one, and the family is the one institution that has historically been able to resist both. Every authoritarian project of the last century began by getting between parents and children, usually for reasons that sounded exactly like the ones in this chapter.

DECLINING TO REACH THE HOUSEHOLD MEANS DECLINING TO ACT

Nearly every harm documented across fourteen parts happens inside a family: the marriage arranged, the scan taken, the phone confiscated, the schooling stopped, the beating. A remedy that stops at the front door is not a remedy. And the premise is false in any case — states already reach into households routinely and uncontroversially for vaccination, for school attendance, for taxation and for child protection. The question was settled long ago; what is being debated is only whether daughters are a good enough reason.

Where things stand: the disagreement resolves once you separate **reaching in** from **entering**. An inspector entering households does not scale, produces resistance, and builds exactly the capability the first side fears. A wage, a register and a school roll all change what happens inside a household without anybody crossing the threshold — they work through position rather than through supervision. The health worker sits in between, and is the interesting case precisely because she is invited in for a reason the household wants.

What would settle it: nothing evidential; this is partly a question about what a state should be. But the design implication is testable: indirect instruments should outperform supervisory ones, and where both have been tried, they do.

Why people care so much: because "the family is private" is simultaneously a genuine principle with a long and honourable history, and the sentence that has ended every attempt to do anything about what happens to women inside families.

So much for who can act. The next chapter costs the largest thing anyone has proposed that nobody has built.

REMEMBER THIS

Part Eleven found that rules land where they can be enforced. So do **reforms —** and almost everything in this series happens in a room the state cannot enter.

A state controls its institutions, its transfers, its records and its hiring. It does not control who decides anything in a household, or what is said to a daughter.

Four things get in without anybody crossing the threshold: **a wage** in her name, which changes what she could survive on if she left; **a record**, because an unregistered marriage cannot be underage since nothing about it exists; **a school roll**, which is one of the few things about her life the state can see; and **other women, in her house, for another reason.**

India runs the largest version of the fourth anywhere: about **a million village health workers**, resident women doing skilled work inside houses a council leader never enters. Nobody has ever measured what that does to anything in this series.

The distinction that resolves the objection: reaching in is not the same as entering. A wage, a register and a school roll change what happens inside a family by changing a person's position — not by supervising her.

CHAPTER SIX

What the Humane Road Would Cost

> *Part Nine found that the only road to a higher birth rate that costs women nothing has never actually been built. This chapter specifies it, prices it against what countries already spend, and identifies what is really blocking it — which is not the money.*

6.1 — The specification

Part Nine set out three roads to raising a birth rate. Make children cheaper. Make the alternatives worse. Remove the exit. Only the first costs women nothing, and Chapter Ten of that part listed the serious version of it among the things nobody has tried.

Here is what "serious" would mean, assembled from what the research says actually predicts the gap between the children people say they want and the children they have.

One: childcare that matches a working day. Not a few hours, not from age three. Full-day, from infancy, universal, at a price a median household can pay.

Two: housing that people in their twenties can obtain. Delayed household formation is one of the strongest correlates of delayed childbearing, and in the countries with the lowest fertility it is also where the cost pressure is most extreme.

Three: employment protection that survives childbearing in practice. Not a statutory right on paper but a labour market where two years out does not permanently reset a woman's earnings — which requires something about how employers are compensated for it, not merely what they are forbidden to do.

Four: men doing half the domestic work. Part Nine's Chapter Four found the countries with the lowest fertility are those most equal in public life and least equal at home. This is the component that cannot be purchased.

Five: funded fertility treatment. The one component demonstrably present in the only rich democracy that never fell below replacement.

6.2 — What countries already spend

WORD BOX

Family policy spending as a share of national income: the standard way of comparing what countries put into cash benefits, tax relief and services for families with children.

Rough landmarks from Part Nine: Hungary has run at around **five per cent**, among the highest anywhere. France has run around three and a half to four per cent for decades. The wealthy-country average sits closer to two.

Why the comparison matters here: the ceiling on what a determined country has been willing to spend is about five per cent of everything it produces, and we know what that bought, because Hungary spent it and ended roughly where it started.

The more important question is not how much was spent but what it was spent on, and the answer is consistent across every country that has tried.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The crucial fact about the money already spent is not how much. It is what shape it was.

Hungary's five per cent went overwhelmingly into **cash and loans —** zero-interest borrowing forgiven as children arrive, tax exemptions, housing subsidies tied to family size. South Korea's two hundred billion dollars went into grants, leave entitlements and childcare in a country where the binding constraint turned out to be that people were not marrying at all. The Nordic countries built the services but did so alongside some of the most severe housing pressure and job insecurity for young people in Europe.

So the honest statement is not that the humane road failed. It is that **no country has run the five components together**, sustained, for a generation. Every case is a partial version, and the partial versions differ from each other in which parts they left out.

What this cannot tell you: whether the full package would work. Nobody knows, and anyone claiming to is extrapolating from packages that were missing two or three of the five parts.

It helps to put the sums in a form that makes the scale visible.

IN REAL TERMS

Put the ceiling in Indian terms. Five per cent of national income is an enormous number — comparable to what India spends on defence and education combined, roughly speaking.

Now put it against what the same money buys elsewhere in this series. Part Nine calculated that pronatalist cash transfers, at their most effective, buy somewhere between a few hundredths and two tenths of a child per woman, at a cost per *additional* birth running into hundreds of thousands of pounds.

So the sums involved are not small and they are not unprecedented. They are being spent. They are being spent on the shape with the worst record.

Which leaves the question Part Nine could not answer and this chapter cannot close either.

THE ARGUMENT — WOULD THE FULL PACKAGE ACTUALLY WORK?

This is the question Part Nine left open and this chapter cannot close. Both positions are held by serious demographers.

IT HAS NEVER BEEN TRIED AND EACH COMPONENT HAS EVIDENCE

Nobody has run all five together for thirty years without a recession or a change of government. Each part has support on its own: childcare availability predicts return to work, housing costs predict delayed household formation, employment penalties predict the second birth, domestic sharing predicts the third, and treatment funding is present in the one rich country that never fell. Judging the road by Hungary's cash or Korea's grants is judging a treatment by trials that omitted most of the medicine. France's decades near the top of Western Europe show what even a partial version buys.

THE MOST COMPLETE VERSIONS DID WORST AND THE CONSTRAINT IS ELSEWHERE

The Nordic countries built the best services in existence and their fertility fell by half a child anyway. Part Four of Part Nine established that the gender-equity theory's central prediction failed exactly where the mechanism was strongest. And in the lowest-fertility countries the decline is now largely a **partnership** decline — people are not pairing up, and every component in that list is aimed at parents, arriving after the point where the number is decided. You cannot subsidise your way to a relationship.

Where things stand: unresolved, and the honest note is that even the strongest advocates of the package now claim a few tenths of a child rather than a return to replacement. Nobody serious expects the humane road to close a gap of half a child on its own.

Which reframes the question, and this is the useful part. If the package is judged solely on the birth rate, it is a gamble with poor odds. But every one of the five components is a benefit to people who are already alive, regardless of what happens to fertility. Childcare helps the parents who have it. Housing helps the people who live in it. Job protection helps the women who keep their earnings. None of that becomes worthless if the birth rate does not move.

Why people care so much: because attaching these things to a demographic justification made them contingent on an uncertain payoff — and gave every opponent a way to argue against childcare by pointing at Finland's birth rate.

And there is a premise underneath the whole affordability discussion that nobody on either side has examined.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THE COST IS THE OBSTACLE

Everybody discusses the humane road as an affordability question. Advocates say it would be expensive but worth it. Opponents say it is unaffordable. Governments say the fiscal space is not there. All of them are treating money as the binding constraint.

It is not, and the evidence is that the money has already been spent. Korea put over two hundred billion dollars into this. Hungary sustained five per cent of national income for fifteen years. Those are not countries that could not afford the humane road. They are countries that spent comparable sums on a different shape.

> So look at what actually separates the two. Cash transfers, tax breaks and baby bonuses have one property in common: **nobody has to give anything up.** The money comes from general revenue, arrives at households, and is politically costless because it takes nothing from anyone who can object.
>
> Now look at the five components. Childcare at that scale requires a workforce and a building programme. Housing for the under-thirties requires supply, which means somebody's asset values. Employment protection that actually works requires employers to absorb something. Men doing half the domestic work requires men to do half the domestic work. **Four of the five require an identifiable group to hand something over.**
>
> That is the difference, and it is not financial. Cash is chosen because it is distributionally invisible, not because it is cheap — Korea's version was extraordinarily expensive.
>
> **The general form:** naming a distributional obstacle as a financial one. It runs through every policy area where the affordable option is the one that asks nothing of anybody in particular. Transfers preferred to reform. Subsidies preferred to supply. Compensation preferred to change.
>
> What follows is uncomfortable for the reformer side specifically. If money is not the obstacle, then "we cannot afford it" was never the argument to answer, and fifteen years of costing exercises were addressed to the wrong objection.

That is what can be built. The next chapter is about the things that are already cheap and are still not being done.

REMEMBER THIS

The humane road has five components: **full-day childcare from infancy, housing people in their twenties can get, employment protection that survives childbearing in practice, men doing half the domestic work, and funded fertility treatment.**

No country has run all five together for a generation. Hungary's five per cent of national income went into cash and loans; Korea's two hundred billion dollars went into a country where people had stopped marrying; the Nordics built the services alongside severe housing pressure.

Even its strongest advocates now expect a **few tenths of a child**, not a return to replacement — which reframes the question, because every component helps people who are already alive whether or not the birth rate moves.

Attaching childcare and housing to a demographic justification made them **contingent on an uncertain payoff**, and handed opponents a way to argue against childcare by pointing at Finland.

And the money is not the obstacle: it has already been spent, on cash, because cash is the only shape that requires nobody to hand anything over. Four of the five components need an identifiable group to give something up. That is a distributional obstacle wearing a financial costume.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Levers Nobody Pulls

> *Across fourteen parts the same kind of thing kept turning up: cheap, dull, high-yield, and undone. They share one property, and it is not cost.*

7.1 — The list

Every part of this series ended with a chapter on what is not known, and a pattern accumulated across them that I did not notice until the thirteenth. Here it is collected.

THE LEVER	WHERE IT CAME FROM	WHAT IS MISSING
Cervical screening at scale	Part Ten	About two in a hundred Indian women aged 30–49 have ever been screened, for a cancer killing on the order of seventy-five thousand a year that is detectable a decade early.
Two survey questions	Parts Twelve, Thirteen	Whether a woman has private use of a phone, and whether her messages or images have been shared without permission. Neither is asked anywhere at national scale.
Marriage registration	Chapter Five	The precondition for any marriage-age rule to be more than a sentence. An unregistered marriage cannot be underage, because nothing about it exists.
Measuring a law already passed	Part Twelve	India's two-hour takedown obligation came into force in February 2026. No published figures on orders issued, categories used, or outcomes.
Analysing the health worker network	Chapter Five	A million village women doing skilled work inside houses for twenty years, never examined for the exposure effects the reservation study found.

THE LEVER	WHERE IT CAME FROM	WHAT IS MISSING
Street lighting and transport	Chapter Four	Route safety is setting women's educational ceilings before they sit an exam. Municipal, not national; cheap relative to a college.
Three analyses of existing data	Part Thirteen	The Iranian provincial comparison, the East German migration question, and a systematic accounting of reforms by shape. No new collection required for any of them.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The screening figure is worth sourcing precisely, because it is the most alarming number in the table and it would be easy to overstate.

It comes from India's own National Family Health Survey, which asks women aged 30 to 49 directly whether they have ever been screened for cervical cancer. Around two in a hundred said yes. That is a nationally representative household survey, not an administrative count, so it is not distorted by which facilities keep records.

What it establishes: the coverage gap is real and enormous, and it is not an artefact of reporting.

What it does not establish: that screening everybody is achievable at current capacity, or what the achievable coverage would be. A survey can tell you how few have been reached. It cannot tell you what it would take to reach them, and Chapter Seven's argument box is about exactly that gap.

7.2 — What they have in common

Not cost. Several of them cost essentially nothing.

What they share is that **none of them produces a moment**. There is no ribbon to cut on a survey question. No minister stands beside a marriage register. An analysis of data collected twenty years ago cannot be announced, and a screening programme can be announced exactly once and must then be run, unglamorously, for two decades, by people whose names nobody will know.

Compare that with the shape Chapter Two examined. A campaign is announceable indefinitely. It has a launch, a face, a hashtag, a set of measurable outputs available within a quarter, and it threatens nobody. Every property that makes an intervention politically attractive is present in the thing that works least.

IN REAL TERMS

Take the screening number and do the arithmetic that nobody does.

Two in a hundred women in the relevant age group have ever been screened. The cancer in question kills roughly two hundred Indian women a day. It is caused by a virus, it is preventable by a vaccine India now manufactures, and it is visible as cell changes years before it becomes dangerous.

Part Ten established the other half: a woman's risk depends on her husband's history as much as her own, so married women with one lifetime partner die of it. No rule about her conduct reaches them. A test does.

This is the largest physical harm attached to sex in Indian women's lives, it is the one nobody warns anybody about, and the intervention is a routine outpatient procedure.

7.3 — Why "just do it" is too easy

I want to take the obvious objection seriously, because a list like the one above is the kind of thing that reads well and dissolves on contact with anyone who has run anything.

WORD BOX

State capacity: what a government can actually deliver, as distinct from what it can legislate or announce.

It is made of unglamorous things: trained staff, working equipment, functioning records, supervision, and the ability to keep doing something in year eight that was started in year one.

Why it matters to this chapter: a lever being cheap in money is not the same as it being cheap in capacity. Screening every woman in a country of 1.4 billion requires laboratories, technicians, referral pathways and follow-up. The test is routine. The system is not.

Which sets up the objection that a list like this deserves, and it is a serious one.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE "CHEAP LEVERS" LIST NAIVE?

Anyone who has worked inside a health or statistical system will have an objection to the table above. It is a good objection and it is only partly right.

IT IS NAIVE, AND CALLING THEM CHEAP HIDES THE REAL PROBLEM

None of these is unknown. Every item has been proposed, often repeatedly, by people better informed than any writer. They do not happen because of capacity, not because of inattention. India's screening gap is not a gap in awareness — it is a shortage of trained personnel, laboratories and referral pathways, and adding a question to a survey is trivial while acting on the answer is not. Lists like this treat delivery as a detail and thereby misdescribe the entire difficulty, which is why outsiders' recommendations are so often received as insulting by the people doing the work.

THE CAPACITY OBJECTION PROVES TOO MUCH

The same state delivers vaccines to hundreds of millions of people, runs the largest election on Earth, and counts births and deaths in eight thousand sample areas twice over. The capacity plainly exists; what varies is what it is pointed at. And several items on that list do not need any capacity at all. Adding a question to a survey already in the field, publishing the counts for a law already in force, and analysing censuses collected decades ago require no clinics, no staff and no buildings. For those, the capacity argument is not an explanation. It is a change of subject.

Where things stand: the resolution is to split the list, and splitting it makes the argument sharper rather than weaker. **Three items are effectively free** — the survey questions, the transparency figures, the analyses of existing data. For these there is no capacity defence and no cost defence, and they remain undone. **The rest are cheap relative to their benefit but genuinely hard to deliver**, and the first side is right that treating them as easy is a way of not understanding them.

What would settle it: for the free items, nothing — they are either done or not, and they are not. For the others, costed delivery plans, which have been produced in several states and not funded.

Why people care so much: because "we lack capacity" and "we lack will" are very hard to distinguish from outside, and every institution has an interest in the first description.

7.4 — The measurement point, made once

One item on that list deserves separating out, because it recurs in every part of this series and it is the cheapest thing in the whole document.

Part Ten found that India's crime statistics cannot see online abuse of women, because there is no category for it. Part Twelve found no Indian survey asks whether a woman controls her own phone. Part Thirteen found three questions that could be answered from data already collected. Every one of those parts ended by noting that the state in question **can** count — it counts fraud to the rupee, it surveys hundreds of thousands of households, it has run the same demographic instrument for fifty years.

A statistical system measures what someone decided was a fact worth having. Across fourteen parts, the things that keep not being measured are the same things, and they concern the same people.

I am not going to claim that is deliberate, because I have no evidence that it is and the more likely explanation is that nobody in the room ever proposed it. But the effect is identical either way: a subject on which the evidence is permanently thin, in which every argument is therefore conducted by assertion, and in which the party with the loudest assertion wins by default.

REMEMBER THIS

Seven levers recur across this series and none of them is expensive: **screening, two survey questions, marriage registration, measuring a law already in force, analysing a million-woman health network, street lighting and transport, and three analyses of data already collected.**

What they share is not cost. It is that **none of them produces a moment**. No ribbon, no launch, no face, no quarterly metric — and a screening programme can be announced once and must then be run for twenty years by people nobody will name.

Every property that makes an intervention politically attractive is present in the shape that works least.

The capacity objection is real for some of these and is **a change of subject for three of them** — adding a question to a survey already in the field, publishing counts for a law already in force, and analysing decades-old censuses need no clinics, no staff and no buildings.

And across fourteen parts the things that keep not being measured are the same things, about the same people — which produces a subject where every argument is settled by assertion, and the loudest assertion wins by default.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What Cannot Be Designed Away

> *Seven chapters of design. This one is about the questions that are not design questions — where no amount of cleverness produces an option that gives everybody what they want, and where calling it a problem is how a society avoids making a choice.*

8.1 — Four things that will not dissolve

The temptation in a chapter like this series' last few is to keep going until everything has a remedy. Four things resist, and they resist for different reasons.

Fertility against women's options. Part Nine set out three roads and found that only one costs women nothing. Chapter Six of this part found that even its strongest advocates now expect a few tenths of a child from it. If a society genuinely requires replacement fertility, and the humane road delivers two tenths against a gap of half a child, then the remaining distance has to come from somewhere — and the only somewhere anybody has ever found is a reduction in what women can do instead. That is not a gap in the research. Fifty years and enormous sums have been spent looking for the third road.

The care hours. Part Nine's Chapter Seven established that you cannot store labour: the care an eighty-year-old needs in 2055 must be delivered by somebody alive and working in 2055. Ageing raises the hours needed. Low fertility reduces the people available. Rising female employment — which every government including every worried one is actively pursuing — removes those same people during working hours. All three push the same way at once, and no financing arrangement changes the number of hours. It only changes who pays and who does them.

Safety against the capability that provides it. Part Twelve found that a two-hour takedown obligation and a two-hour removal capability are the same machine with the target class left as a parameter. You cannot have the protection without building the instrument. This is not a technical limitation to be engineered around; it is what the thing is.

A daughter's interest against her family's standing. Part Twelve's Chapter Eight showed these coincide often enough that most families never have to notice. At the moment they diverge — and they do diverge — somebody loses, and no design makes both win.

> **WORD BOX**
>
> **A problem** has a solution that has not been found yet. More thought, more money or more evidence gets you to it.
>
> **A trade-off** has no such solution. The options available all involve giving something up, and choosing between them is a judgement about what matters, not a calculation about what works.
>
> Why the distinction is the point of this chapter: the two require completely different responses. A problem calls for research. A trade-off calls for a decision — and treating the second as the first produces the appearance of progress indefinitely, because there is always another study to commission.

The most concrete of the four is worth working through in full, because it is the one where the arithmetic does the arguing.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Take the care hours, which is the most concrete of the four.
>
> India's old-age support ratio falls from roughly ten working-age people per person over sixty-five to about four by 2050. The people who will be sixty-five then are alive now and can be counted, so this is close to certain.
>
> Somebody has to bathe them, feed them, lift them and sit with them. Those hours exist whether or not anyone budgets for them.
>
> There are exactly three places they can come from: paid workers, who must be trained and paid; unpaid family members, who in every society on Earth are overwhelmingly women; or nobody, in which case the care does not happen.
>
> **Every plan currently in existence, in every country, quietly assumes the second — and none of them writes it down, because writing it down would require saying whose decade it is.**

8.2 — Grading the four

Not every declared trade-off is real. Plenty of things called iron laws dissolved: that women could not work and raise children, that mass education would bankrupt states, that a large population could not be fed. Announcing a trade-off is a way of closing a search, and searches have a habit of succeeding after they are closed.

So the honest thing is to grade them by how hard anybody has actually looked.

Fertility against options has been searched hard, for fifty years, by wealthy governments with strong incentives and enormous budgets. The search has produced small effects. This one looks real, though Chapter Six's caveat stands: the full package was never assembled.

The care hours are arithmetic. Automation may change how many hours a given amount of care takes, and that is worth pursuing — but it does not change the structure of the problem, only its size. This one is real.

Safety against capability is real as a technical matter and is *not* a trade-off about outcomes. What is undecided is who holds the switch, under what review, with what record. That is a political question with real answers, and Part Twelve's point was that nobody is having it because one side is defending the machine and the other is objecting to it.

The daughter against the family's standing is real at the moment of divergence and is much less common than the rhetoric suggests, because most of the divergence is manufactured by the penalty structure. Reduce the penalty and the interests coincide more often. So this one is partly designable and partly not.

> **THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD TRADE-OFFS BE NAMED?**
>
> There is a real dispute about whether a chapter like this helps or does damage.

NAMING THEM IS NECESSARY AND REFUSING TO IS COWARDICE

A choice that is not made explicitly is still made — by default, invisibly, and usually in favour of whoever benefits from inaction. Every plan that assumes unpaid female labour will materialise is making a decision about women's time without ever putting it on a page. Naming a trade-off is the only way to make the decision visible enough to argue about, and the alternative is not a better outcome, it is the same outcome with nobody accountable for it.

NAMING THEM PREMATURELY CLOSES THE SEARCH

The history of this subject is a history of iron laws that turned out to be arrangements. People were certain that women could not do skilled work and raise children; that female education would destroy families; that low female employment reflected preference. Every one was declared a fixed constraint and every one dissolved. Declaring a trade-off tells everybody to stop looking, and the record says the looking is what produced the improvements.

Where things stand: both are right about different items, which is why grading matters more than the general question. The test is whether a serious, funded, sustained search has actually been conducted. Where it has and produced little — fertility against options — naming the trade-off is honest. Where the search has barely begun, or where the constraint is really about who holds a switch rather than about what is possible, calling it a trade-off is premature and does exactly the damage the second side describes.

What would settle it: for fertility, the full package from Chapter Six, run for thirty years. Nothing else will do it, and nobody is running it.

Why people care so much: because whoever gets to declare a trade-off real gets to say that somebody must lose, and then to nominate who.

Beneath that dispute is the assumption this chapter exists to name.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — THAT THERE IS A SOLUTION

> Every participant in this argument, including this document, has been proceeding as though enough analysis would eventually produce a design that gets everything: a society with women's full options *and* replacing generations *and* care for its old *and* protection without surveillance. Fourteen parts have been structured around the search for it.
>
> Some of that is not available. Not because the research is incomplete — because the things being asked for are in tension, and no arrangement of institutions makes two incompatible outcomes both occur.
>
> Now notice what treating a trade-off as a problem actually does, because it is not neutral. It generates the appearance of movement without anybody losing anything. There is always another pilot, another study, another commission. Everyone can be seen to act, indefinitely, and no identifiable group ever has to hand anything over.
>
> **Which is exactly the function Chapter Six identified in cash transfers.** Cash is chosen over childcare because it is distributionally invisible. Research is chosen over decision for the same reason. They are the same move at different points in the process, and they are both extremely expensive ways of not choosing.
>
> **The general form:** treating a value conflict as an unsolved technical question. It appears wherever a society faces a choice it does not want to make. Commissioning another review. Waiting for the technology. Calling for a national conversation. In each case the thing being deferred is not knowledge — it is the moment at which somebody is told they will not get what they want.
>
> And this cuts at me directly. A series that ends by identifying trade-offs has produced something less satisfying than a programme, and I notice the pull to keep designing past the point where design runs out. Part of what makes this the hardest chapter to write is that stopping looks like giving up, and it is not: **saying "this is a choice, not a puzzle" is the most useful sentence available once it is true.**

Which leaves one question outstanding: if some of this is a choice, who is in a position to make it?

REMEMBER THIS

Four things will not dissolve. **Fertility against women's options** — the humane road buys tenths against a gap of half a child, and the rest has only ever come from one place. **The care hours** — you cannot store labour, and ageing, low fertility and rising female employment all push the same way at once. **Safety against the capability that provides it.** And **a daughter's interest against her family's standing**, at the moment they diverge.

A **problem** has an undiscovered solution. A **trade-off** has options that all require giving something up. The first calls for research; the second calls for a decision.

Not every declared trade-off is real — plenty of iron laws turned out to be arrangements. Grade them by **how hard anybody actually looked**. Fertility has been searched hard with money for fifty years. The care hours are arithmetic. The safety one is really a question about who holds a switch.

And treating a trade-off as a problem does something specific: it produces the appearance of movement without anybody losing anything — the same function cash transfers serve, at a different point in the process. Both are expensive ways of not choosing.

CHAPTER NINE

Who Holds Which Lever

> *Every recommendation is addressed to somebody. Part Twelve found that most arguments here are incoherent because nobody says who. This is the map — and the biggest lever in the whole series belongs to an actor with no address.*

9.1 — The map

Part Twelve found that three sensible answers to one question were addressed to a parent, a state and a community, and that the argument went nowhere because everyone pretended they were advice to the same person. Here is the map that exercise implies, for everything in this series.

ACTOR	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY CONTROL	BEST AVAILABLE SHAPE
A parent	What she has in her hand, whether she stays in school, what she inherits, and what she watches the adults around her do.	Who is in the room — and mostly by accident.
A national state	Records, transfers, quotas, licensing, inheritance law, and what gets counted.	Substitute and measurement. The best evidence in the series is here.
A municipality	Lighting, buses, policing, school hours, station staffing.	Substitute. The strongest ratio of benefit to cost in this document.
An employer	Hours, whether two years out permanently resets earnings, who is visible in what role.	Substitute and who is in the room. Almost wholly unexamined.
A community	The penalty itself — what actually happens to a woman when something is said about her.	The largest lever in the series. No budget, no address, no decision procedure.

ACTOR	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY CONTROL	BEST AVAILABLE SHAPE
A platform	Takedown speed, hash matching, interrupting the standard extortion opening.	Ban the output — which works here, because the output is the harm.
A statistician	Which questions are on the form.	Measurement. Three items in Chapter Seven need one such person.
A woman herself	Her own disclosure, her own record, and what younger women see her doing.	Least of anyone here, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

9.2 — The mismatch

Read down that table and the shape of the whole problem appears.

The biggest lever belongs to nobody in particular. Part Twelve established it in one line: takedowns remove ammunition, and the penalty is the gun. Reduce what a community will do to a woman when something is said about her, and every weapon in this series loses most of its value at once — the sextortionist's threat, the leaked image, the rumour, the auction app. Nothing else on the table comes close.

And a community is not an actor. It has no meeting, no budget line, no person who can decide. This is why the most effective available intervention is also the one nobody can commission, and why every institution that wants to act instead reaches for something it can hold.

The best-evidenced lever belongs to states, and it is cheap: a rotation rule that put women where people could see them. That is tier-one evidence and it has never been deliberately deployed for this purpose anywhere.

The cheapest levers belong to statisticians, and three of them are free.

And the actor with the most at stake holds the least. That is not a rhetorical flourish; it is what the table says, and it is the same finding Part Twelve reached from a different direction when it noticed that the cheapest option for everybody else was the one whose entire cost landed on a girl.

IN REAL TERMS

There is one lever a woman holds that is not small, and it follows directly from Chapter Three.

The mechanism that produced the strongest result in fourteen parts was not a law or a payment. It was people watching a woman do a thing they believed women did not do. In the Indian villages, that was a council leader. It could as easily be a health worker, a bus driver, a shopkeeper, a teacher, an engineer, a mother who works.

Which means every woman visibly doing something is, on the best evidence in this series, an intervention — operating on her neighbours' daughters, at no cost to any budget, whether or not she intends it.

That is not a consolation prize offered to someone with no power. It is the same mechanism as the reserved seats, and it is the only one on the table that does not require anybody's permission.

Which raises the question most readers of a document like this actually have.

THE ARGUMENT — WHAT SHOULD A PERSON WHO HOLDS NO LEVER DO?

Most readers of a document like this hold none of the top six rows. That is the situation the argument usually ignores.

ACT ON WHAT YOU HOLD, AND STOP TREATING SCALE AS THE ONLY MEASURE

The table understates individual reach because it lists formal levers. A person who employs someone, teaches, runs a clinic, sits on a committee, has a daughter, or has a vote holds a small piece of several rows. And Chapter Three's mechanism is not about scale — it is about visibility and repetition, both of which operate at the scale of a street. Waiting to hold a national lever is a way of doing nothing while feeling serious.

INDIVIDUAL ACTION IS HOW STRUCTURAL PROBLEMS GET PRIVATISED

The entire finding of Chapter Two is that this is structural. Telling readers to be the change converts a question about inheritance law, municipal lighting and pension coverage into a question about personal virtue — which is comfortable, unfalsifiable and precisely how nothing gets built. It also has an ugly precedent in this series: Part Twelve found that the cheapest answer for everybody else was always the one whose cost fell on an individual, and "do what you can personally" is that answer wearing better clothes.

Where things stand: both are right about a failure mode, and the resolution is to distinguish two things that get merged. **Personal conduct** as a substitute for structural change is the failure the second side names, and it is real. **Visibility** is not personal conduct — it is a structural input that individuals happen to supply, and the evidence for it is tier one. The distinction is testable: exhorting people to hold better views is the shape with the worst record in this document, and being seen doing a thing is the shape with the best.

What would settle it: measuring the exposure effect outside politics — the health worker analysis in Chapter Five is the obvious place and it has never been done.

Why people care so much: because "what can I personally do" is the question every reader actually has, and both a true answer and a comforting one are available, and they are not the same answer.

9.3 — What this document is

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION — MINE, AND IT IS THE ONE THIS SERIES HAS BEEN WALKING TOWARDS

Chapter Two of this part established that beliefs follow structures, that persuasion has the worst record of any intervention shape, and that it fails specifically on norms that are load-bearing for property, lineage, security or standing — which is every norm in this series.

I have written fourteen parts of argument.

Ask why. Not why the subject, but why **this form**. And the honest answer is that it is the form I have. I cannot build a childcare system, change an inheritance law, light a road between a house and a college, put a question on a national survey, or reduce

> by one degree what a community will do to a woman. I can read carefully and write clearly. So I did that, at length, and then produced an analysis in which careful reading and clear writing turn out to be what the situation called for.
>
> **The general form:** choosing the intervention you are equipped for and then discovering that it is the one that was needed. It is the most common bias in applied work of every kind. The engineer whose analysis concludes that the problem is engineering. The lawyer who finds a legal remedy. The doctor who finds a clinical one. Nobody involved is dishonest, and the conclusion always comes out looking like the tool.
>
> Two partial defences, and I want to grade them honestly rather than let them off.
>
> **The weaker one:** some readers do hold levers. A district officer, a municipal engineer, a person who designs a survey, someone who employs people. Chapter Seven's three free items require exactly one such person to read one paragraph. That is true, and it is a very thin thread to hang fourteen parts on.
>
> **The stronger one:** the product of this series may not be persuasion at all. Every part ends with a list of what would settle each question and what evidence is missing. That is not an attempt to change anybody's mind — it is a **specification**. Chapter Two's finding is that arguments do not move load-bearing norms. It says nothing about whether writing can say precisely which study, which question, which register, which analysis would answer something. Those are different activities that happen to use the same alphabet.
>
> So the most defensible description of this document is not an intervention. It is a specification for one, which somebody else would have to build, using levers I do not hold. Whether anyone does is not something writing controls, and pretending otherwise would be the exact error this box is about.

Which brings us, as every part does, to the accounting of what is known and what is not.

REMEMBER THIS

Every recommendation is addressed to somebody, and the map is uneven. **The biggest lever — the penalty a community imposes — belongs to an actor with no budget, no address and no decision procedure.** The best-evidenced one belongs to states and has never been deliberately used for this. The cheapest belong to statisticians, and three are free.

The actor with the most at stake holds the least. That is what the table says, and it matches Part Twelve's finding that the cheapest option for everyone else is always the one whose cost lands on a girl.

One lever a woman does hold is not small: on the best evidence in this series, **every woman visibly doing something is an intervention**, operating on her neighbours' daughters, requiring nobody's permission.

Distinguish **personal conduct** from **visibility**. The first as a substitute for structural change is how problems get privatised. The second is a structural input that individuals happen to supply, and it has the best evidence in this document.

And I have written fourteen parts of argument in a series whose central finding is that argument works least. I chose the tool I had. The most defensible thing this document can be is not an intervention but a specification for one — which somebody else would have to build.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Two lists, as in every part. This is a design chapter, so the unknowns matter more than usual — a recommendation resting on nothing is worse than no recommendation.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

WHETHER THE EXPOSURE MECHANISM WORKS OUTSIDE POLITICS

The strongest finding in this series comes from village council seats. Chapter Three argued the active ingredient is visibility rather than the position, which predicts effects in schools, clinics, buses and shopfronts and small ones in boardrooms. That is a prediction, not a finding. The reason we do not know: no randomised or quasi-random allocation of a high-visibility non-political role has been analysed for attitude effects in the surrounding population — and India's million-woman health worker network is sitting there, unexamined, as Chapter Five noted.

WHETHER SUPPLYING THE SUBSTITUTE RETIRES THE RULE, AND HOW LONG IT TAKES

Chapter Four concluded that substitution is necessary but not sufficient, and that the lag is roughly a generation. That estimate comes from one case — East Germany — and is being applied to completely different rules. The reason we do not know: nobody has tracked a specific norm across the decades after its function was substituted. Pension coverage against son preference is the cleanest available pairing and the data exists in several countries.

WHAT THE FULL HUMANE PACKAGE WOULD DO

Chapter Six specified five components and established that no country has run all five for a generation. Whether they interact, whether the effect is additive, and whether the total would be tenths or more is unknown. The reason we do not know: the experiment costs a large share of national income, takes thirty years, and requires no recession and no change of government. It may be unrunnable in principle for political rather than financial reasons — which is itself the subject of that chapter's hidden assumption.

WHETHER INHERITANCE REFORM HELPS OR HARMS ON NET

Chapter Four’s most uncomfortable finding: giving daughters inheritance rights improved some outcomes and, in at least one careful study, was associated with worse survival for girls in some settings, because a daughter who will inherit costs more. The literature has not settled. The reason we do not know: the effects run in opposite directions through different mechanisms and the studies disagree.

WHETHER “REACHING IN WITHOUT ENTERING” SCALES

Chapter Five distinguished indirect instruments — a wage, a register, a school roll — from supervisory ones, and argued the first outperform. The evidence is suggestive rather than tested, and mostly comes from settings where both were not tried together. The reason we do not know: nobody has designed a comparison.

WHICH DECLARED TRADE-OFFS ARE REAL

Chapter Eight graded four by how hard anyone had searched. That grading is a judgement, not a measurement, and the history of this subject is full of iron laws that dissolved. The reason we do not know: you cannot prove a search has been exhaustive, and the two most consequential ones — fertility against options, and the care hours — have very different evidential status that gets flattened when they are listed together.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> One thing on that list is unknown for a reason worth separating out, because it is the closing observation of this part.
>
> Three of the six gaps could be closed by analysing data that has already been collected — the health worker network, the pension-and-son-preference pairing, and a systematic accounting of interventions by shape. None requires a new survey, a new clinic or a new budget line of any size.
>
> That is now the fourth part in a row to end with the same observation. Part Twelve found two survey questions missing. Part Thirteen found three analyses undone. Part Ten found a crime category that does not exist.
>
> **Fourteen parts in, the strongest pattern in this entire series is not about women at all. It is about what gets counted.** Every state examined here has the capacity to answer these questions, has already paid for most of the data, and has not looked.

10.2 — Solid

BELIEFS FOLLOW ARRANGEMENTS

From the randomised Indian case, the Bangladeshi factory studies, and the persistence of East German attitudes for thirty years after the institutions producing them ceased to exist. Three countries, three mechanisms, one direction.

BANNING THE OUTPUT RELOCATES THE BEHAVIOUR

Four Indian reforms, one signature, documented across decades: prohibit the visible symptom while leaving the demand in place, and it re-emerges somewhere less visible and less regulated.

INTENTIONS DO NOT PREDICT OUTCOMES; SHAPE DOES

Every documented failure in this series was designed by people who wanted what reformers want. Several of the successes were produced by people with entirely different aims — an export industry, an administrative rotation rule, a theocratic literacy campaign.

PRICE CHANGES ARE REAL, SMALL, AND STOP WHEN THE MONEY STOPS

Established across pronatalist spending in seven countries and conditional transfers for girls' schooling, which were outperformed by a factory.

THE ACTIVE INGREDIENT IN THE RESERVATION CASE WAS EXPOSURE, NOT OFFICE

The measurable effects were on the people who watched, not on the women who held the seats: their neighbours' bias, their neighbours' daughters' attendance, and what parents wanted for their children.

A RULE'S STATED FUNCTION IS NOT NECESSARILY ITS FUNCTION

Paternity certainty was the standard explanation for rules about women's sexual conduct. It was solved cheaply and universally in the 1990s and nothing moved — which is a test, not just an observation.

REFORMS LAND WHERE THEY CAN BE ENFORCED

The same finding Part Eleven made about restrictions. A wage, a record and a school roll change what happens inside a household without anybody crossing the threshold; a prohibition on what families do in private does not.

THE MONEY FOR THE HUMANE ROAD HAS ALREADY BEEN SPENT

Korea's programme exceeded two hundred billion dollars; Hungary sustained about five per cent of national income for fifteen years. Both went overwhelmingly into cash, which is the only shape that requires no identifiable group to hand anything over.

SOME OF THIS IS A CHOICE RATHER THAN A PROBLEM

The care hours are arithmetic: they must be delivered by someone alive and working at the time, and every existing plan assumes unpaid women without writing it down.

REMEMBER THIS

Unknown: whether the exposure mechanism works outside politics; whether substituting a rule's function retires it and how long that takes; what the full humane package would do; whether inheritance reform helps on net; whether indirect instruments scale; and which declared trade-offs are genuinely real.

Solid: beliefs follow arrangements; banning the output relocates the behaviour; shape predicts outcomes and intentions do not; price changes are real, small and reversible; the reservation effect was exposure rather than office; a rule's stated function may not be its function; reforms land where they can be enforced; the money for the humane road has already been spent on the wrong shape; and the care hours are a choice rather than a puzzle.

Three of the six gaps could be closed with data already collected, by somebody already employed, at no meaningful cost.

Which makes this the fourth part in a row to end the same way. Fourteen parts in, the strongest pattern in this series is not about women. It is about what gets counted — and every state examined here can count, has already paid for the data, and has not looked.

Timeline

What was tried, what shape it was, and what it produced.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
1929	**Ban the output.** India raises the minimum marriage age, passed in autumn to take effect in spring. The census records a surge of child marriages in the gap.
1961	**Ban the output.** Dowry is prohibited. Over the following decades the practice spreads into communities that did not have it, and the payment moves from visible goods into undocumented cash.
1977	**Ban removed.** West Germany repeals the provision allowing a husband to forbid his wife's employment — one of the pieces of the male-breadwinner model that had never been announced as a policy about women.
1980s	**Substitute, by accident.** Bangladesh's garment factories spread. Girls nearby marry later, have children later and stay in school longer — outperforming a scheme that paid families directly.
1993	**Who is in the room.** India reserves a third of village council leaderships for women and rotates them by village serial number, creating a lottery nobody designed.
1994	**Ban the output.** India prohibits the use of diagnostic techniques to determine the sex of a foetus. The child sex ratio continues falling for years; prosecutions remain rare.
2004	The first analysis of the reservation lottery finds women in charge spent differently — on what the women in those villages had actually asked for.
2005	**Supply the substitute.** India gives daughters equal rights in ancestral property. Later work finds daughters more likely to inherit and better educated — and at least one careful study finds worse survival for girls in some settings, because a daughter who inherits costs more.
2005	India begins a village health worker programme that grows to roughly a million women, each resident in the village she serves, entering houses to do skilled work. Never examined for the effects the reservation study found.
2010	**Change the price.** Hungary begins the most ambitious pronatalist programme in any democracy, at around five per cent of national income, almost entirely in cash and loans. Fertility rises from 1.23 to 1.59, then falls back to about 1.31.

YEAR	WHAT HAPPENED
2012	Further work on the Indian lottery finds two rounds of a female village leader narrowed the gap between what parents wanted for sons and daughters by about a quarter, and closed the school attendance gap.
2015	**Tell people to stop.** India launches its flagship campaign for the girl child, aimed at the falling child sex ratio.
2016	**Ban removed.** Saudi Arabia sets a target of 30 per cent female labour force participation, from a base of around 17 per cent.
2018–19	The Saudi driving ban is lifted and guardianship rules on travel are relaxed. Participation reaches around 36 per cent by 2025 — but alongside quotas, subsidies and falling oil revenue.
2021	A parliamentary committee reports that 78.91 per cent of the funds released to states under the flagship girl-child campaign between 2016 and 2019 went on media advocacy, and that states spent only about a quarter of what they received.
2026	India’s two-hour takedown obligation for non-consensual intimate images comes into force in February. No figures on its use have been published.
Next	**Part Fifteen starts here.**

Glossary

Every hard word used in this part, in plain English.

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS
Behaviour change communication	Campaigns that try to shift what people do by changing what they believe, or what they think others believe. Real successes, all of them on cheap behaviours nobody defended.
Household bargaining power	A household is several people with different wants. What it does depends on their relative positions — which depend on what each contributes and what each could get by leaving.
Incidence	Who actually ends up bearing a cost, as distinct from who is nominally charged. Where the interesting question usually lives.
Intervention	Anything deliberately done to change an outcome. Comes in four shapes, and the shape predicts the result better than the intention does.
Load-bearing	Holding something up. A load-bearing rule is performing a function; remove it and the function reappears somewhere else. You cannot tell which rules are load-bearing by how fiercely they are defended.
Quota or reservation	Setting aside a share of positions for a defined group. Its measurable effect in the Indian case was not on the women appointed but on everybody who watched them.
State capacity	What a government can actually deliver, as distinct from what it can legislate or announce. Trained staff, working equipment, records, and the ability to still be doing it in year eight.
Substitute (as a shape)	Working out what a rule was doing and providing that function another way: a pension instead of a son, inheritance instead of dowry, lighting instead of seclusion.
Trade-off	A situation where every option involves giving something up. Distinct from a problem, which has an undiscovered solution. The two call for completely different responses.

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STUDYING · MBA, Panjab University (Business Strategy and Analysis)

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, philosophy, belief and public life, and publish it under one name: The Living Archive. It exists because most writing on these subjects hands you a verdict and hopes you will not ask to see the file. I would rather give you the file.

This was the hardest part to write, and not because the material was difficult. Thirteen parts of describing what is true can hide behind the evidence. A design chapter has to commit, and the honest version of it kept concluding things I did not want — that the shape of an intervention matters more than the intention behind it, that the biggest available lever belongs to nobody, that some of this is a choice rather than a puzzle, and that the form I have spent fourteen parts using is the one the evidence says works least.

I am not an economist, a policy designer or a civil servant. I read the primary sources carefully, follow the numbers wherever they go, and write down what I find in language that does not need a dictionary. Where I do not know something, I say so — that is what Chapter Ten is for, in every part.

The Living Archive — three rules

One. Simple words, serious content. The reader is not stupid; they simply should not have to fight the prose.

Two. Every side gets its strongest case. If a position sounds foolish here, I have failed to understand it, not proved it wrong.

Three. Say what is not known. A document that separates the solid from the guessed is worth more than one that sounds certain throughout.

A word on sources

This part carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis — of peer-reviewed work in economics and demography, Indian parliamentary committee reports and government answers, national survey data, and the findings of the thirteen parts before it.

What that archive is good at: the specific interventions. A parliamentary committee's accounting of where money went is unusually hard evidence, and the randomised Indian reservation studies are as good as this subject gets.

What it is bad at, and a design chapter feels it more than a descriptive one: **almost nothing here has been tried in the combination recommended.** Chapter Six specifies a package that has never been assembled. Chapter Three's taxonomy is built from cases scored after the fact. Where I have extrapolated past the evidence — and I have, repeatedly — I have said so in the sentence rather than in a note, and Chapter Ten lists every place it happened.

One further caution. The strongest single recommendation in this part rests on **one** randomised study, in one country, in one kind of institution. Chapter Three argues its mechanism generalises. That argument is mine, not the study's.

If you find an error, write to me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it.

What Comes Next

Fourteen parts have given every position its strongest case, chapter by chapter. Part Fifteen turns that method on this series. It is the case against everything above, assembled as well as I can assemble it — including the objections I cannot answer.

The questions it takes on:

- What is the strongest argument that this entire series is wrong — not wrong in detail, but wrong in its framing, its questions and its choice of what counts as evidence?
- Where did I actually change my mind across fourteen parts, what changed it, and what does the pattern of those changes say about my starting position?
- Which findings here would a serious traditionalist reject, and on what grounds that are not merely assertion — and how many of those grounds are good?
- Which findings would a serious feminist reject, for reasons that are equally worth stating, and where has this series been too quick to treat a constraint as settled?
- What did the method itself cost? Giving every side its strongest case has a price, and Part Fifteen names it rather than treating even-handedness as automatically virtuous.
- And the question a reader is entitled to ask after nine hundred pages: what, specifically, would have to be true for the person who wrote this to be badly and consequentially mistaken?

END OF PART FOURTEEN OF SIXTEEN

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The Rules About Women

Part 15 — The Case Against This Series

Fourteen parts have audited everybody else. This one puts the series in the dock. The strongest argument that the questions were wrong, the evidence was not neutral, the scoreboard was rigged by its own columns, and the even-handedness cost more than it bought.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

Lovepreet Singh

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Where We Left Off

Part 14 asked the only question that matters if any of this is more than talk. If the rules about women are a problem, what would actually shift them? The answer came out as a taxonomy of four shapes. You can ban the output. You can change the price. You can change who is in the room. You can supply the substitute. There is a fifth thing people do, which is tell each other to stop, and it is not an intervention at all.

The scoring was unkind. Every case in the series where a state banned an output failed, and failed in the same way: the demand stayed, so the behaviour moved. Cash payments moved real numbers by small amounts and stopped moving them the moment the money stopped. Only one shape produced a large, durable, well-identified effect — putting women where they are seen holding authority — and the active ingredient turned out to be the seeing, not the office. Supplying a substitute for what a rule was doing worked best where anyone tried it, and almost nobody tries it.

Then Part 14 turned the knife on itself. Its last hidden assumption said that fourteen parts of argument had been written by a person whose central finding is that argument works least, using the only tool he has. The honest description of the series, it said, is a specification for an intervention rather than an intervention.

That admission is where this part starts. If the series is willing to say that about its method, it should be willing to face the harder version. Not “my tool is weak” — that is a modest thing to confess and it costs nothing. The harder version is: *the questions were wrong, the evidence would not bear the weight, the scoring was decided by the choice of columns, and the fairness I am proud of has a price I have never put on the page.* Fourteen parts have given every side its strongest case. This part gives that treatment to the series itself.

HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT

The Six Boxes

Every part of this series uses the same six boxes. They are the notation. Here is one live example of each, so you know what you are looking at before you need to.

WORD BOX

Audit: a check on something done by going back to the original records, rather than by asking the person who did it whether they did it well. An accountant audits a company by looking at the receipts, not by reading the company's own report of itself.

Why it matters here: this part calls itself an audit, and the word carries a promise. An audit that is run by the person being audited is a weaker instrument than a real one, and Chapter One says exactly how much weaker.

A Word Box explains a hard word the moment it first appears. Never later, never in a footnote. If a term is used, it is explained on the page where it is used.

IN REAL TERMS

This series now runs to roughly 300,000 words. An ordinary adult reads non-fiction at about 200 to 250 words a minute. So reading the whole thing, once, at speed, without stopping to think, takes somewhere around twenty to twenty-five hours.

That is three full working days. It is more time than most people spend on any single voluntary thing in a year that is not a television series or a wedding.

An In Real Terms box takes a number you cannot picture and turns it into something with a body — a walk, a wage, a week, a room. A number nobody can picture is decoration.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Where the evidence for a claim comes from, and what it cannot show. For example: this part says the series changed its author's mind in specific places. The evidence is that the parts are published, dated and public on misterlove.in, and I cannot go back and quietly edit what Part 1 predicted before Part 10 tested it.

What it cannot show: whether I changed my mind because of the evidence or because of the writing. Nobody has access to that, including me.

This is the box that builds the most trust and the one most writers skip. It names the actual thing the claim rests on — the register, the transcript, the survey, the court record — and then says what that thing is bad at.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD A WRITER PROSECUTE HIS OWN WORK?

The question of this whole part, put once at the front.

YES — HE KNOWS WHERE THE BODIES ARE

Nobody else has read every draft. Nobody else knows which chapter was thin and got padded with a better example, or which claim survived only because the counter-evidence was hard to find in English. An outside critic attacks what is on the page. The author can attack what is not.

NO — IT IS THE STRONGEST DEFENCE AVAILABLE

A book that criticises itself has bought immunity cheaply. The reader relaxes. Every later objection now sounds like something the author already thought of and priced in. Writing your own prosecution is the most effective possible way of preventing a real one.

Where things stand: both are true at once, and that is not a fudge. This chapter is genuinely better informed than an outside critic could be, and it genuinely functions as armour.

What would settle it: nothing I can do inside this document. Only an outside reader who reads this part and then still finds something it missed — and publishes it.

An Argument box is used where serious people disagree. Each side gets its strongest case, not a version that is easy to knock down. Then a verdict says where things stand and what would settle it. Often the honest verdict is that nothing available would settle it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The signature of this series. Not a caveat and not a disclaimer. It digs out a premise that both sides of an argument accept without noticing, because that shared premise is usually where the real trouble is.

Example, and it is the assumption running under this entire part: **that being wrong is a property of answers.** Everyone arguing about a book argues about its conclusions. But a document can have every conclusion defensible and still be badly wrong, because the damage was done when the questions were chosen and nobody voted on that.

There are five Hidden Assumption boxes in this part. That is the range the method sets. Fewer and the series loses its signature. More and they stop landing.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter ends with one of these. Three to five short paragraphs, key words in **bold**, the last one being the whole chapter in a sentence.

The test is simple. A reader who reads **only** these boxes should still come away with the complete argument.

ONE WARNING SPECIFIC TO THIS PART

What This Document Is Not

This is not a retraction. I am not withdrawing the fourteen parts. If I thought a claim in them was false I would correct that claim, in that part, and say what changed and who caught it. That is the standing promise and it still holds.

This is something narrower and harder. It is the strongest case that can be made against the series *as a whole* — its framing, its evidence base, its method of scoring, its fairness rule and its likely effects — assembled by the person with the most to lose from it landing. Where an objection lands, I say so. Where it does not, I say that too, and I do not soften a bad objection to look humble. False modesty is a way of dodging criticism, not accepting it.

One more thing. Two chapters in this part are written as advocacy. Chapter Five puts the traditionalist case against the series at full strength. Chapter Six does the same for the feminist case. In both, I am arguing for a position, not reporting one. Part 6 and Part 7 of this series did the same thing on the main subject, and the same warning applies: while you are inside those chapters, you are reading a brief, not a survey.

Contents

Part 15

CHAPTER ONE

The Rule Turned Around

> *Fourteen parts have taken other people's arguments apart. This one takes mine apart. Before that can mean anything, we have to agree what counts as a hit.*

1.1 — What a case against actually is

Most books that criticise themselves do it in the last two pages. The author admits the work is incomplete. He says more research is needed. He thanks his critics in advance. Then the book ends and nothing in it has changed.

That is not a case against. That is a bow.

A real case against has to be able to do damage. It has to name a specific thing the document did, show why that thing was a mistake, and say what follows if the objection is right. If an objection is correct and nothing follows, it was not an objection. It was a mood.

So here is the test I am going to hold this part to. Every objection in it must come with an answer to one question: **if this is true, what in the series is now worthless?** Not "weaker". Not "more complicated than I said". Worthless — as in, a reader who believed it has been misled about something that matters to them.

Some objections in this part pass that test. Several do not, and I will say which. An honest prosecution includes the charges that fail, because a prosecution that only brings charges it can win is a performance.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Steel man:** the opposite of a straw man. A straw man is a weak, silly version of somebody's argument, built so it is easy to knock down. A steel man is the strongest version of that same argument — often stronger than the version its own supporters usually give.
>
> Why it matters here: this whole series runs on steel-manning, and Chapters Five and Six turn it on the series itself. If you find yourself thinking "no serious traditionalist would put it that well" or "no serious feminist would concede that", that is the method working, not failing.

There is a reason to be suspicious of a document that steel-mans its opponents. Done badly, it flatters everyone and commits to nothing. Done well, it produces the one thing arguments almost never produce, which is a clear view of where the actual disagreement sits. Whether this series did it well is one of the things this part is trying to find out.

1.2 — The six ways a document like this can be wrong

People usually mean one thing by "wrong". They mean a false statement. That is the least interesting failure and the easiest to fix. You correct the sentence.

A long piece of research can fail in at least six ways, and they get worse as you go down the list.

One: a fact is wrong. A number is misreported, a date is off, a study is described as showing something it did not show. Serious, embarrassing, easy to repair.

Two: the evidence will not bear the weight. Every fact is accurate, but the conclusion rests on them more heavily than they can take. This is much harder to see, because nothing in the text is false.

Three: the frame is wrong. The document divides the world into categories that do not carve it at the joints. Nothing inside the categories is false. The categories are the error.

Four: the question is wrong. The document answers the question it asked, and the question should not have been asked in that form, because asking it that way already granted something to one side.

Five: the method is self-serving. The rules the document follows are rules that happen to produce the kind of conclusion the author finds comfortable. Not by design. By selection — you keep the rules that keep giving you results you can live with.

Six: the effect is bad. Everything is true, the frame is fine, the question was right, and putting it into the world still made things worse — because of who reads it, what they use it for, and what it lets them stop doing.

Notice that only the first of those can be fixed with a correction notice. This part spends almost all its time on numbers two to six.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Everyone who argues about a book argues about its conclusions. The reviewer disagrees with the verdict. The supporter agrees with it. The comment section fights about it. All of that activity shares one unexamined premise: **that being wrong is a property of answers.**
>
> It is not, or not mainly. By the time a document reaches its answers, the important decisions are already behind it. Somebody chose which question to ask. Somebody chose which things count as evidence. Somebody chose what would count as a good outcome and what would count as a bad one. None of those choices appear as claims in the text, so none of them can be disagreed with in the normal way. They are not stated. They are *used*.
>
> This is why a document can be careful, honest, accurate in every line, and still do damage. It is also why the case against a piece of research is almost never made properly. The reader has been handed a page of answers and invited to fight about those, which keeps everybody busy at the shallow end.
>
> The general form: **an argument you are allowed to have is usually not the argument that decided the outcome.** You saw this in Part 8, where the fight over whether the equality project "worked" turned entirely on which column was on the ledger, and nobody was fighting about the columns.

That box is the reason this part is ordered the way it is. It goes after the question first, the evidence second, the scoring third. The conclusions come last and get the least attention, because if the first three are sound the conclusions are mostly bookkeeping, and if they are not, arguing about conclusions is a waste of everyone's afternoon.

1.3 — The standard of proof

An audit needs a standard. Without one, “I have considered the criticisms” means whatever the author wants it to mean.

Here is mine, and you can hold me to it, because it is written down and dated.

An objection **lands** if I cannot answer it without either changing a claim in the series, or admitting that a claim rests on something I chose rather than something I found.

An objection is **survivable** if it is true, but the series already says so somewhere, in the text, before this part — not in a footnote and not by implication.

An objection **fails** if answering it requires nothing more than pointing at what the series actually says, as opposed to what a hostile summary of it would say.

Chapter Nine has the scoreboard. Nine objections go in. Not all of them come out the same way, and the ones that land are not the ones I expected when I started writing this part.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> The claim that I did not know which objections would land is the kind of claim a writer makes and nobody can check. So here is the honest position on it.
>
> The evidence *for* it: the fourteen parts are published, dated, and out of my hands. Chapter Seven lists six places where the writing moved me, and in each case the earlier part is on the record predicting one thing and the later part is on the record finding another. That pattern is checkable by anybody with a browser.
>
> The evidence *against* it, which is the honest half: this document was written after all fourteen. Nothing stops me from writing “I did not expect this” about a conclusion I expected perfectly well. There is no way to verify a surprise. Treat every sentence in this part that begins “I was surprised to find” as a claim with no evidence behind it, because that is what it is.

1.4 — Who is speaking here

The method this series uses has a rule about declaring your position wherever it could pull the writing. This part is where that rule bites hardest, so let me put four things on the table.

I am an Indian man. I am writing about rules that mostly constrain Indian women. Every part of this series has been written by somebody who is not subject to the rules he is describing, and who has never once in his life had his movements, clothing or friendships negotiated by a family council. That is not a disqualification. It is a fact about the instrument.

I am the author of the thing being audited. Fourteen parts is a large amount of work and I do not want it to have been a waste. That is a motive, and motives do not stop operating because you have named them.

I publish under my own name on a site that is mine. Nobody commissioned this series and nobody can pull it. That removes one kind of pressure — no funder to please — and adds another. There is no editor who can tell me a chapter is bad.

And I have an audience. It is not enormous, but it exists, and it arrived because of the earlier parts. A writer with readers has a reason to keep producing the sort of thing that got him readers. If the honest conclusion of this part were “the series should not have been written”, I would like to think I would print it. I have no way to prove I would.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Fifteen parts, about 300,000 words, roughly a thousand pages. That is about three times the length of a normal non-fiction book. Set next to a working life it is small — perhaps a year of evenings. Set next to a reader’s life it is enormous.
>
> Put it this way. If a hundred people start Part 1, and each part loses a fifth of the ones who started it, then by Part 15 you are writing for about four people. This chapter is being read by a small number of unusually stubborn strangers, and pretending otherwise would be the first dishonest thing in the document.

Those four declarations are the whole of my standing. Everything after this chapter is argument, and you now know exactly who is making it and what he has riding on the outcome.

REMEMBER THIS

A real **case against** has to be able to do damage. Every objection here has to answer one question: if this is true, what in the series is now worthless? An objection that changes nothing was a mood, not an objection.

A long piece of research can fail in **six ways**: a wrong fact, evidence that will not bear the weight, a wrong frame, a wrong question, a self-serving method, and a bad effect. Only the first can be fixed with a correction. This part is about the other five.

The assumption underneath every argument about a book is that **being wrong is a property of answers.** It is not. The decisions that matter — which question, which evidence counts, what a good outcome looks like — are never stated as claims, so they can never be disagreed with in the normal way.

I have declared four things that pull this writing: I am not subject to these rules, I wrote the thing being audited, nobody can edit me, and I have readers to keep.

The argument you are allowed to have is usually not the argument that decided the outcome.

CHAPTER TWO

The Question Was Chosen

> *The series asked what the rules about women are for, and what happens if they change. That sounds like the neutral question. It is not, and this chapter shows exactly what it gave away before the first sentence.*

2.1 — The question the series actually asked

Part 1 set the terms for everything that followed. It said the series would ask why rules about women's dress, movement and sexual behaviour exist, what those rules are doing, and what actually happens — to a woman, and to the society around her — when they change.

Read that again and notice its shape. It is a **what is it for** question. It treats a rule the way an engineer treats a part he has found inside a machine he did not build. What does this do? What breaks if you remove it? What was it put there to solve?

Fourteen parts then did exactly that, carefully. And the care is the problem, because a question of that shape is not a neutral opening. It has already made three decisions, and none of them were argued for.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Functional explanation:** explaining something by what it does rather than by how it came about or whether it is right. "The heart exists to pump blood" is a functional explanation. So is "the dowry system exists to transfer property at marriage."
>
> Why it matters here: a functional explanation quietly turns a practice into a solution. Once you have called something a solution, you have implied there was a problem, and problems are things that need answers. The rule stops looking like something people *do* to other people and starts looking like something a society *needs*.

The first decision the question makes is that the rules are for something. That sounds obvious. It is not. Some arrangements are not for anything. They persist because the people who benefit have the power to keep them, and asking what problem they solve is like asking what problem a landlord solves. There is an answer — he houses people — and the answer does most of the work of the defence without ever presenting itself as a defence.

The second decision is that a society is the kind of thing that can have needs. Part 9 spent ninety-two pages treating a national birth rate as an object that can be too low, which means treating a country as a thing with interests, separate from the interests of the women who would have to bear the children. Part 9's own last box admitted this. It admitted it in one box, on page eighty-something, at the end.

The third decision is the one nobody notices, and it is the largest.

2.2 — Who has to justify themselves

"What happens if the rules change?" is the question this series asked over and over. It is the spine of Part 5, Part 8, Part 9, Part 10 and Part 13.

Now try the mirror question. *What happens if they stay?*

The series never ran that one at the same depth. And there is no evidential reason for the asymmetry, because both are questions about consequences and both are answerable with the same tools. The reason is that one of them is the question people ask and the other is not.

This is a burden-of-proof problem, and it is worth being precise about it, because it is the single most powerful invisible thing in any public argument.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Burden of proof:** in an argument, the job of proving your case. Whoever carries it has to produce evidence. Whoever does not carry it wins by default if the evidence is unclear.
>
> Why it matters here: in a courtroom the burden is assigned deliberately, in advance, and everyone knows who has it. In a public argument nobody assigns it. It settles on whoever is proposing the change, silently, and it never moves. That means **uncertainty always helps whatever already exists.** If nobody can prove anything, the rule stays.

Look at what that does to a series like this one. Fourteen parts of careful, honest reporting keep arriving at "the evidence is thin", "the effect does not travel", "this has never been tested outside one country", "nobody has run the experiment". Each of those is an accurate statement about the state of knowledge. Every single one of them, in the world outside the page, functions as a point for the side that wants nothing to change.

The series never chose that. It is a structural property of writing honestly about a contested arrangement while the arrangement is in force. Honest uncertainty is not neutral in its effects. It is neutral in its intentions, which is a different thing, and the difference is invisible from inside the writing.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> You can see the asymmetry inside the series itself, without taking my word for it. Count the chapters.
>
> Part 10 spends a whole part testing the traditionalist's prediction about what happens to a woman who breaks the rules. Four claims, unpacked, each run through a portability test — the check of whether an effect found in one place still shows up somewhere else, because an effect that does not travel belongs to the setting rather than to the act. That is the right way to treat a claim.
>
> Now find the equivalent part testing the claim that the rules protect her. There is a version of it in Part 6, but Part 6 is written as advocacy, and advocacy is not a test. There is no part in this series that takes the sentence "these rules keep women safe" and audits it the way Part 10 audits "she ruins her own life".
>
> What this cannot show: whether the imbalance came from bias or from the state of the literature. Researchers have studied the costs of breaking the rules far more than the costs of keeping them, so a series built on the published record inherits that shape. Both explanations predict the same table of contents.

2.3 — What a serious version of the objection sounds like

Put together, the objection is not "you were unfair to one side". It is sharper than that, and it does not depend on anyone's motives.

It goes: *a series that asks what a rule is for, and what changing it would cost, has built a machine that produces reasons for caution, no matter what data you feed it. The output is not evidence about the rules. It is evidence about the question.*

That is a strong objection and I want to state the reply just as strongly, because I think the reply is right and the objection is still partly right, and both of those can be true.

THE ARGUMENT — IS "WHAT IS THIS RULE FOR?" A NEUTRAL QUESTION?

Every serious study of a social arrangement starts by asking what it does. The question in dispute is whether that opening move is analysis or is already a concession.

IT IS ALREADY A CONCESSION

Asking what a practice is *for* assumes it is solving something. That framing has a direction built in: if you remove a solution, you should expect a problem to reappear. So the whole apparatus points at risk. Meanwhile the harms the rule is currently doing are the background, not the subject, because background does not need explaining. The framing does not have to be biased to produce biased output. It only has to be asymmetric, and it is.

IT IS THE ONLY QUESTION THAT LEADS ANYWHERE

The alternative framing — these rules are simply domination and the analysis is complete — has been available for a century and has a poor record of shifting anything. Part 14's central result depends entirely on the functional question. It was only by asking what dowry, seclusion and son preference are actually *doing* that the series could show that persuasion fails and substitution works. Drop the functional question and you lose the one finding in the series that could change a policy. You also lose the ability to show, as Part 14 did, that the stated function of chastity rules was solved cheaply thirty years ago and nothing moved — which is the most damaging fact in the entire series *against* the traditionalist.

BOTH, AND THE FIX IS A SECOND QUESTION

The functional question is fine. Running it alone is not. A series that asked "what is this for?" should also have asked, at the same depth and with the same page count, "what is this costing right now, and who is paying?" That part was never written. Its absence is the finding, not the framing.

Where things stand: the third position is correct and I did not see it until this chapter. The functional question is not a concession by itself. Running it without its mirror is. In this series the mirror was run in fragments — Part 11 on men, Part 12 on enforcement, Part 3 on the machine — but never as its own part with its own budget of evidence.

What would settle it: writing the missing part and seeing whether it changes any conclusion. My honest expectation is that it would change the emphasis of most parts and the conclusion of none, which is either a defence of the series or a demonstration that the framing was doing more work than I thought. I cannot tell from here which.

Why people care so much: because "what is it for?" is how a defender of any arrangement would prefer the conversation to start, and "what is it costing?" is how a critic would. Choosing the opening question is most of the fight, which is why the fight is usually over before anyone notices it began.

2.4 — The woman at the protest

There is one more thing in the framing, and it is the least abstract thing in this part.

This series exists because of a specific person. A woman was photographed at a protest. The photograph travelled. Strangers who had never met her decided, on no evidence, that she sold intimate content online, and they said so at volume, with her face attached.

I did not write about her. I decided, early, that writing about her would repeat the injury, and I have said so in the text more than once. Instead I wrote about the norms underneath the attack — fifteen parts, a thousand pages, an examination of the rules that made "she is that kind of woman" a usable weapon.

Part 12's last box already said the uncomfortable half of this: I used her as material, decided on her behalf that she would rather not be named, and put that decision on every cover. Here is the half that box did not say.

Turning her into a research question was itself a choice with a direction. What happened to her is not a puzzle. It is not epistemically interesting. It is a woman being hurt by people who wanted to hurt her, using a tool that was lying around. By treating it as the entrance to a fifteen-part inquiry, I converted an event that calls for a response into a subject that calls for a study. Those are different things, and the second one is much more comfortable for the person doing it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Both sides of almost every argument about social rules agree on one thing without ever saying it: **that understanding a thing is a step towards changing it.** The traditionalist writes to explain why the rule is wise. The reformer writes to explain why it is unjust. Both are producing understanding, and both assume the understanding does work in the world.

Part 14 found that it mostly does not. Of the intervention shapes it scored, “tell people the truth and let them reason” was the one that behaved worst — so badly that the chapter classified it as a category error rather than a weak intervention. India’s own flagship persuasion campaign spent 79 per cent of the money it released to states on advertising the campaign.

Now put those two things next to each other. This series is 300,000 words of understanding, written by someone who has published a finding that understanding is the weakest lever available. If that finding is right, the series is not a small contribution to change. It is a large contribution to something else — and the honest name for that something else is not obvious to me.

The general form: **the belief that explanation leads to change is held most firmly by the people whose only available tool is explanation.** That is exactly the pattern you would expect if the belief were false and comforting rather than true.

That box is the most damaging thing in this chapter and it does not touch a single factual claim in the series. It is failure type six from Chapter One: everything true, and the effect still not what the writer thinks it is. Chapter Eight comes back to it with the price attached.

REMEMBER THIS

The series asked a **functional question —** what are these rules for, and what happens if they change. That question is not neutral. It treats a rule as a solution, which implies a problem, which implies caution about removal.

The mirror question **— what is this costing right now, and who is paying? —** was never given its own part. Running the first without the second is the real objection, and it lands.

Because the **burden of proof** silently sits on whoever proposes a change, every honest finding of "the evidence is thin" works, in the world, as a point for keeping things as they are. The series never chose that. It is what honest uncertainty does when it is written about an arrangement that is currently in force.

The series began with a real woman being hurt. Turning that into a research question converted an event that called for a response into a subject that called for a study — which is far more comfortable for the person doing the converting.

Choosing the opening question is most of the fight, and the fight is usually over before anyone notices it has started.

CHAPTER THREE

The Evidence Was Never Neutral

> *This series quoted a lot of studies. This chapter is about what those studies are actually made of — and about the fact that on this subject, more than most, people lie to researchers in a pattern.*

3.1 — What the series rests on

Strip the fourteen parts down and the evidence comes in four kinds.

There are **counts**: censuses, national surveys, crime records, birth registers. Part 9 and Part 11 lean on these. They are the strongest thing here, because they were collected for administrative reasons by people with no stake in this argument.

There are **experiments**: a small number, mostly in psychology and economics. Part 13 found exactly one genuine randomised experiment in the whole subject — India's 1993 rotation of reserved village council seats — and built a chapter on it.

There are **correlations**: the largest category by far. Partner counts and divorce rates. Education and marriage age. Female employment and fertility. Almost everything in Part 10 sits here.

And there are **histories**: legal records, colonial files, court judgments, campaign archives. Parts 2, 3, 7 and 12 run on these.

The objection in this chapter applies mainly to the third category and partly to the second. It does not much touch the first or the fourth. That distinction matters, and I will come back to it, because a chapter called "the evidence was never neutral" can easily be read as "throw it all out", which is not what the evidence about the evidence says.

3.2 — The replication problem

Start with something that has nothing to do with women, rules or India.

WORD BOX

Replication: running somebody else's study again, on new people, following their method, to see whether the same thing happens. It is the check that turns a result into a finding.

Effect size: how big a difference something makes, as opposed to whether the difference is real at all. A pill can have a real effect and a tiny one. Most arguments in public treat "real" and "big" as the same word. They are not, and the gap between them is where most of this chapter lives.

In 2015 a group of 270 researchers finished a project that had taken them three years. They took 100 studies published in three respected psychology journals and ran each one again, using the original materials where they could get them, with larger samples than the originals.

Ninety-seven of the 100 original studies had reported a clear positive result. When the studies were run again, 36 of them produced a clear positive result. The effects that did show up were, on average, about half the size the original papers had reported.

That was not a one-off. In 2018 a different team took 21 social science experiments that had been published in *Nature* and *Science* — the two most prestigious general science journals there are — between 2010 and 2015. They pre-registered their plans, had them checked by the original authors, and used samples about five times larger. Thirteen of the 21 replicated. Again the surviving effects were about half the original size.

And it is not old news. A large project published in 2025 attempted 274 claims from 164 papers, drawn from 54 journals in the social and behavioural sciences, published between 2009 and 2018. Around 55 per cent of the claims replicated. Weighted by paper, it was about half.

IN REAL TERMS

Think of it as a shop. You walk in and every item on the shelf has a label saying it works. You buy a hundred of them, take them home, and about thirty-six do what the label said. Of those thirty-six, most work about half as well as advertised.

Now here is the part that matters for this series. You are not the person who bought a hundred. You are a reader who has been handed *one* item, in a chapter, by an author who found it convincing. You have no way of knowing which pile it came from.

Why does this happen? Not mainly because researchers cheat. It happens because of what gets published.

A study that finds nothing is boring. It is harder to publish, so people stop writing them up, so the published record is a filtered version of the research that was actually done. The filter selects for surprising results, and a surprising result is more likely than a boring one to be a fluke. On top of that, a researcher analysing a dataset has many small choices to make, and if he makes them one at a time while watching the result, he will drift towards the version that works without ever telling a lie.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Publication bias:** the tendency for interesting results to reach print while boring ones sit in a drawer. It does not require anyone to behave badly. It only requires editors, reviewers and authors to each prefer a finding to a non-finding, which they all do.
>
> Why it matters here: it means the published literature on any question is not a sample of what is true. It is a sample of what was *publishable*, and those two things come apart most sharply on questions where a particular answer is exciting — which describes almost every question in this series.

So when Part 10 reported that a Norwegian team in 2016 replicated an American finding about regret after casual sex, that report was accurate and it was also doing something specific: it was noting that a result had survived a check, which most results in this field have not been given.

3.3 — The narrow sample problem

Now the second problem, which is worse for this series than the first.

A survey of the top journals in six branches of psychology found that 68 per cent of research subjects were from the United States, and 96 per cent were from Western industrialised countries. Those countries hold about 12 per cent of the world's people.

> **IN REAL TERMS**
>
> Imagine the human race as a village of a hundred people. Twelve of them live in the rich West. When the village's scientists want to know what human beings are like, they interview those twelve — and about eight of the twelve are the ones from one particular household.
>
> One commentary put it as a rate. A university undergraduate in a Western country is something like four thousand times more likely to end up in a psychology study than a randomly chosen person walking around outside.

The point is not that Western people are strange. It is that we do not know whether they are, because there is nothing to compare them with. And on the specific questions this series asks, the West is exactly the wrong place to sample from, because the West is the place where the rules under discussion have already been dismantled.

Part 10 is the clearest casualty. Its central table came from American survey data. It found that women with more sexual partners before marriage had somewhat higher divorce rates, that the pattern was not a straight line, and that nobody has produced a mechanism that explains it. Every word of that is about the United States.

Part 10 also ran a portability test on it and found the association essentially untested outside America, which is the correct thing to have done. But notice what remains. A reader in Ludhiana finished that chapter having read a great deal about the marriages of Americans, presented as the best available evidence about her own life, because it *is* the best available evidence about her own life. The alternative was not better evidence. The alternative was no chapter.

3.4 — The lying problem

The third problem is specific to this subject, and it is the one I find hardest to work around.

Almost everything in Part 10 rests on people answering questions about their own sexual history. There is a simple arithmetic check on whether they answer honestly.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

In any closed population, over any fixed period, the average number of opposite-sex partners reported by men and by women has to come out the same. Each encounter adds one to a man's count and one to a woman's. This is not a theory. It is bookkeeping.

In every national survey ever run, men report more. The gap has been measured in Britain, America and elsewhere for decades. So at least one of these is happening: men are overcounting, women are undercounting, or the surveys are missing a small group of women with very many partners.

In 2003 two psychologists tested it directly. They asked students about their sexual history under three conditions: connected to a machine they had been told was a lie detector, anonymously, and in a setting where the experimenter might see their answers. The sex difference in reported partners was largest under exposure, moderate when anonymous, and vanished under the fake lie detector — where women reported slightly *more* partners than men.

What this cannot show: which number is true. It shows that the number moves when the social pressure moves, which is enough to establish that at least one of the reported figures is not a measurement of behaviour.

Now put that next to the subject of this series. The rules being examined are precisely the rules that punish women for sexual history. A woman answering a survey in a society with those rules has an obvious reason to answer carefully.

So the measurement error is not random noise. It runs in the same direction as the thing being studied, and it is strongest exactly where the rules are strongest. That is the worst possible shape for an error to have. Random error makes findings weaker and blurrier. Error that tracks the independent variable can manufacture a finding out of nothing at all.

3.5 — What survives

Having made that case as hard as I can, I have to say honestly what it does and does not kill, because a reader who takes this chapter as permission to disbelieve everything has been misled in a new direction rather than rescued from an old one.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES THIS SINK THE SERIES' EVIDENCE?

Three positions, and the distance between them is smaller than it looks.

YES, SUBSTANTIALLY

Take away the studies that have never been replicated, the ones run only on Western samples, and the ones that depend on honest self-reporting about sex, and Part 10 is mostly gone, Part 5 loses its comparisons, and Part 4 loses most of its effect sizes. That is three of fourteen parts resting on a base the series itself has now described as unreliable. A book that leans on a literature must inherit that literature's condition.

NO, BECAUSE OF WHAT IT LEAVES STANDING

The problems named here attack one category of evidence: small correlational studies of behaviour, published in journals, based on self-report. They do not touch birth registers, census counts, court judgments, colonial land records, sex ratios at birth, school enrolment rolls, or the one randomised experiment. Every load-bearing conclusion in the series that survived to Part 14 rests on the sturdy categories. The panchayat result is a randomised experiment. The child sex ratio is a count of babies. The 79 per cent advertising spend is a parliamentary committee reporting on its own government's accounts. None of those are going anywhere.

THE DAMAGE IS REAL BUT IT IS IN A SPECIFIC PLACE

The failure is not that the series believed bad studies. It is that it presented sturdy and fragile evidence in the same voice, in the same typeface, in the same kind of sentence. A reader cannot tell from the prose whether a number came from a census or from 180 undergraduates in Ohio. The series has a box called "How We Actually Know This" designed exactly for that job — and used it perhaps seven or eight times per part, when the honest number would have been closer to one per claim.

> **Where things stand:** the third position is right, and it is the objection I would least like to answer. The series did not overclaim in its conclusions. It underclaimed in its *signposting*, which produces the same effect on a reader while looking careful.
>
> **What would settle it:** an evidence grade attached to every empirical claim in all fifteen parts — census, experiment, replicated study, single study, self-report — visible in the margin. That is a real piece of work and it would be the most useful correction anybody could make to this series. I have not done it.
>
> **Why people care so much:** because on this subject both sides quote studies at each other constantly, and both sides are drawing from the same shallow pool. The traditionalist's favourite finding about promiscuity and divorce and the reformer's favourite finding about education and autonomy are frequently the same kind of object with the same weaknesses. Neither side wants to know that, because the weakness is symmetrical and the arguing is not.

One last thing before the summary, because it is easy to take the wrong lesson from a chapter like this. Nothing here licenses the response that the evidence is all rubbish and therefore anybody may believe what suits them. That response is not scepticism. It is scepticism used as a permission slip, and it always arrives on the side of whoever was already comfortable.

REMEMBER THIS

The series rests on four kinds of evidence: **counts, experiments, correlations and histories**. This chapter's objections hit the correlations hard, the experiments a little, and the counts and histories barely at all.

When 100 psychology studies were run again, 36 produced the same result, at about half the size. In a 2025 project across 54 journals, about half of the claims replicated. This is mostly caused by **publication bias**, not by cheating: boring results do not get printed, so the printed record is not a sample of what is true.

About 96 per cent of psychology's research subjects come from countries holding about 12 per cent of the world's people — and those are the countries where the rules in question have already been dismantled.

On this subject specifically, people **misreport** in a pattern. When students believed a lie detector was watching, the sex difference in reported partners disappeared. The measurement error runs in the same direction as the thing being measured, which is the worst possible shape for an error to have.

The series did not overclaim in its conclusions. It underclaimed in its signposting — sturdy evidence and fragile evidence were written in the same voice, and the reader had no way to tell them apart.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Scoreboard Was the Argument

> *Twice this series built a table and scored a side. Both times the result was decided before a single row was filled in — by the choice of what the columns were.*

4.1 — The two scoreboards

Part 8 built a ledger of the equality project. Eighteen rows, each an outcome, with a column asking who the change had actually reached. Part 13 built a scorecard of both sides' predictions against nine cases where history had run something like an experiment. Part 6 scored seven traditionalist arguments against four conditions. Part 14 scored four intervention shapes.

Those tables are the most quotable objects in the series. They look like the moment the arguing stops and the counting starts.

They are not that. A table of outcomes is an argument with the argument taken out, and the argument was: *these are the things that count.*

Part 13's fourth hidden assumption said this out loud. Put fertility, marriage rates and care work on the scoreboard and the traditionalist wins comfortably. Put literacy, maternal mortality, income and life expectancy on it and it is not close the other way. Nobody has ever proposed a shared scoreboard, and neither side wants one, because a shared scoreboard would have to include the other side's best columns.

Having written that, the series then went on using its own scoreboards for two more parts. That is the objection of this chapter, and it is mine, about my own work, and it lands.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Proxy:** a thing you measure because you cannot measure the thing you actually care about. Nobody can measure whether a child is well brought up, so a study measures school attendance. Nobody can measure whether a marriage is good, so a study measures whether it ended.
>
> Why it matters here: a proxy is a substitution, and every substitution loses something. The danger is that after a while people stop discussing the thing and start discussing the proxy, because the proxy is the thing with numbers attached. Divorce is a proxy for marital failure. It is also, in a society where divorce is nearly impossible, a measure of how hard it is to leave.

That last example is not decoration. Part 10's central table used divorce as the outcome, because divorce is what American surveys record. In a place where a woman cannot leave, a low divorce rate would show up on that table as a good result.

4.2 — Why some things get counted

Here is the deeper version of the problem, and it is not about bias. It is about what states can see.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Legibility:** a word borrowed from the study of how governments work. A thing is legible to a state if the state can see it, count it, and act on it from a distance — through a form, a register, a licence or a survey.
>
> Why it matters here: a state cannot see whether a woman is respected in her house. It can see whether she is enrolled in school, whether she has a bank account, whether she died in childbirth, whether she voted. Everything the state can see becomes data, and data becomes evidence, and evidence becomes the scoreboard. What the state cannot see does not become nothing — it becomes something everybody has to argue about with anecdotes.

Now look at what that does to a series like this one, which is built almost entirely on published data.

WHAT BECAME A COLUMN IN THIS SERIES	WHAT NEVER DID
School enrolment and years of education	Whether school was a relief or another place to be watched
Female labour force participation	Whether the job was chosen or was a second shift added to the first
Age at marriage	Whether she wanted the marriage
Fertility rate	Whether the children were wanted, and by whom
Maternal mortality	Fear during a pregnancy that ended fine
Divorce rate	Marriages that should have ended and did not
Sex ratio at birth	What it is like to grow up known to be the second choice
Reported crimes and conviction rates	The daily background rate of being managed
Contraceptive use	Who decided
Seats held, offices won	Being believed at home

Read the right-hand column again. Almost every item on it is a thing that, if you asked a woman what her life is like, she would mention before she mentioned anything on the left.

None of them are on any scoreboard in this series. Not because I decided they did not matter. Because there is no register anywhere that holds them, so there was no row to write.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Every scoreboard in this series — mine and everybody else's — assumes something that nobody argues about because nobody notices it: **that outcomes add up across people.**
>
> When a ledger says maternal deaths fell, it is adding the deaths that did not happen to a total. When it says literacy rose, it is adding readers. The arithmetic treats a gain to one woman and a loss to another as quantities that can cancel. That is what an average is.
>
> But the thing under discussion in this series is not a quantity. It is an arrangement in which some people are constrained so that others get something. Averaging over it destroys exactly the information that the argument is about. A reform that lifts a hundred thousand urban graduates and leaves ten million rural women exactly where

> they were shows up on the ledger as progress. Part 8 put a “reached whom” column on its ledger precisely because I could feel this problem. One column is not a fix. It is an acknowledgement stapled to the side of a method that still averages.
>
> The general form: **a total is a decision about whose experience is allowed to cancel out whose.** It looks like arithmetic, so it is never defended, so it is never attacked.

There is a reply to this, and it is not weak. Refusing to aggregate leaves you with anecdotes, and anecdote is the medium in which every bad argument about women has always been conducted — the cousin who ruined her life, the aunt who was perfectly happy. Numbers, for all their faults, are the only instrument that lets a claim be wrong.

4.3 — What a fair scoreboard would need

Suppose someone tried to build the shared scoreboard that Part 13 said nobody has ever proposed. What would it need?

It would need columns from both sides, agreed in advance, before anyone knew which way the numbers would fall. It would need each column weighted, and the weights argued for openly rather than smuggled in by which data happened to exist. It would need to report the spread and not only the average, so that a gain to a few could not hide a loss to many. And it would need somewhere to put the outcomes with no numbers at all — a column that says “not measurable, and here is what is at stake in it” rather than dropping them.

I did not build it. I am not sure it can be built. But notice that the reason it has never been built is not technical.

THE ARGUMENT — COULD THERE BE A NEUTRAL SCOREBOARD?

If both sides could agree on what counts as a good outcome, the disagreement would become an empirical one, and empirical disagreements eventually end. So why has nobody done it?

IT IS POSSIBLE AND THE OBSTACLE IS BAD FAITH

Both sides can name outcomes the other side cares about. A traditionalist knows perfectly well that maternal death is bad; a reformer knows perfectly well that loneliness is bad. Nobody actually holds the view that their opponent's entire column set is worthless. The reason no shared scoreboard exists is that each side does better in a world where the scoring is contested, because a contested scoreboard means you can always quote the column you are winning.

IT IS IMPOSSIBLE AND THE OBSTACLE IS REAL

The two sides do not disagree about the weights on a shared list of goods. They disagree about what a person is for. If you hold that a woman's flourishing is constituted by her role inside a family, and I hold that it is constituted by her freedom to leave it, we are not weighing the same items differently. We have different items. Asking us to agree on columns is asking one of us to lose the argument before the counting starts.

IT IS POSSIBLE FOR A NARROW BAND, AND ONLY THERE

There is a small set of outcomes almost nobody defends: girls dying of neglect, women dying in childbirth for want of a clinic, children married at twelve, acid, murder. That band is real and it is where every serious reform of the last century has actually happened. Outside it, the scoreboard idea collapses. So the honest conclusion is not "build a shared scoreboard" but "notice how narrow the shared part is, and stop pretending the wide part is an evidence problem."

Where things stand: the third position is where I end up, and it is not a comfortable place, because it means most of this series has been applying evidence to a question that is not mainly evidential. The narrow band is where evidence decides things. Everything outside it is a disagreement about what a life is for, wearing the clothes of a disagreement about data.

What would settle it: somebody actually attempting the shared list and publishing the negotiation. Not the result — the negotiation. Where it broke down would be the most informative document anyone could produce on this subject.

Why people care so much: because whoever writes the columns wins. Every campaign on both sides is, underneath, a bid to make its own outcomes the ones that get counted — which is why so much energy goes into what should be measured and so little into measuring it.

The simplest way to see the whole problem is to take it out of this subject entirely.

IN REAL TERMS

Think of two football teams who cannot agree on what a goal is. One counts balls in the net. The other counts passes completed. Both play hard for ninety minutes. Both walk off certain they won, and neither is lying.

Now notice that a spectator watching that match will spend the whole afternoon arguing about the players, when the only thing that decided the result was the rulebook nobody read out.

That is what four of the most quotable objects in this series are. They are not the moment the counting began. They are the rulebook, printed as though it were the result.

REMEMBER THIS

This series built four **scoreboards**. They look like the point where arguing stops and counting starts. They are the opposite: a table of outcomes is an argument with the argument removed, and the removed argument was about which things count.

What gets counted is mostly what a state can see — school rolls, deaths, jobs, votes. That is called **legibility**. Everything a state cannot see, which includes most of what a woman would tell you about her own life, never becomes a row, so it never becomes evidence.

Every scoreboard assumes **outcomes add up across people**. That treats a gain to one woman and a loss to another as quantities that cancel — which destroys exactly the information the argument is about.

A shared scoreboard is probably possible only in a **narrow band**: deaths, child marriage, violence. Outside that band the two sides are not weighing the same goods differently. They have different goods.

Whoever writes the columns wins, and the fight over the columns is conducted almost entirely by people who think they are fighting about data.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Traditionalist's Case Against This Series

> *Written as advocacy, the way Part 6 was. From here to section 5.5 I am arguing for a position, not reporting one. The objection is not the one you are expecting, and it is better than the one you are expecting.*

5.1 — Not the objection you were expecting

The expected complaint is that the series is hostile to tradition. It is not, and a serious traditionalist would not waste breath on that charge. Part 6 gave the old rules a full advocate's brief. Part 9 found that no country has ever reversed a fertility decline. Part 14 found that the reforming state's flagship campaign spent most of its money advertising itself. On the scoreboard the series built, the traditionalist did not do badly.

That is exactly the problem.

The real objection is this: **the series has been generous to our conclusions while quietly destroying our position.** It agreed with us in several places and it did so on grounds we do not accept, in a language we did not choose, using a test we never proposed. A friendly verdict from a court with no jurisdiction is not a friendly verdict.

5.2 — You asked whether it works. We said it was right.

Fifteen parts have asked one question of every rule: what does it produce? Does it lower this, raise that, make her better or worse off, hold the birth rate up, keep the family together?

We never said any of that. Read what the tradition actually claims. It does not claim that modesty produces good outcomes. It claims that modesty is *owed* — that there is a right way to live, that a woman's conduct is part of a larger order she did not invent and does not own, and that living rightly is what a life is for, whatever it produces.

WORD BOX

Consequentialism: the view that whether an action is right depends on the results it produces. If it makes things better, it is good; if worse, bad.

A constitutive good: something that is not a means to anything. It is part of what a good life *is*. Friendship is usually treated this way. Nobody defends friendship by showing it improves health outcomes, and anyone who did would have changed the subject.

Why it matters here: the whole series is written in the first language and the tradition speaks the second. Every chapter that carefully measures whether a rule "works" has, before its first sentence, ruled that rules must justify themselves by working.

Notice what happens once you accept that framing. Suppose our rules turned out to produce excellent outcomes on every measure. On the series' own terms, we would then be right. But we would be right for a reason we reject — and a defence we reject is not a defence, it is a takeover with better manners.

Suppose instead the outcomes came back bad, as they do in several chapters. Then we are wrong. Either way, the question of whether a life owes anything to an order larger than itself has been settled without being asked, by the simple act of setting up an outcomes table.

Part 14 makes this vivid. It ran what it called a functional analysis of each rule — dowry as property transfer, seclusion as a substitute for policing, son preference as a substitute for a pension. Then it landed a test: paternity certainty was the stated function of chastity rules, a cheap test has existed for thirty years, and nothing changed. Therefore, it concluded, the stated function was never the function.

That is clever and it is an error. It only works if our rules were a hypothesis about paternity. They were not. Paternity is *one reason among many* that we have offered to people who asked for a reason in the language they would accept. That we could offer a practical reason to a practical questioner does not mean the practice was that reason. Ask a man why he does not read his wife's letters and he may tell you it would damage trust. Solve the trust problem with a machine and he will still not read them. You have not discovered that his stated reason was a cover story. You have discovered that some things are not held for reasons of that kind.

5.3 — The tools are the worldview

Consider what counts as evidence in this series.

Surveys, in which a stranger asks a woman about her private life and writes the answer on a form. Effect sizes, which are averages over populations of interchangeable individuals. Randomised experiments, in which people are sorted by lot in order to see what a policy does to them. Ledgers of measurable outcomes.

Every one of those instruments was built by a civilisation that already believes what the series is supposedly investigating: that a person is an individual unit, that lives can be compared and totalled, that private conduct is a legitimate object of public measurement, and that an arrangement is answerable to its measured effects.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> You do not have to take this as philosophy. The series proves it against itself in Chapter Three of this very part.
>
> The evidence there is that about 96 per cent of behavioural research subjects come from Western industrialised countries holding roughly 12 per cent of the world's people. The series presents that as a sampling problem — the wrong people were asked.
>
> Read it again as the objection it actually is. It is not only that the subjects were Western. The *method* was built there, tested there, and tuned to detect the things that vary there. An instrument developed to measure individual attitudes will find individual attitudes wherever you point it, including at a household that does not think of itself as a collection of individuals with attitudes.
>
> What this cannot show: that the instrument is therefore wrong. A thermometer designed in Europe still measures temperature in Punjab. The traditionalist's claim is that this instrument is more like a questionnaire than a thermometer, and that claim is not settled by either side.

5.4 — The unit error

Part 13 is the one we should be angriest about, and it is also the best chapter in the series, which is an unpleasant combination.

It went looking for natural experiments — places where the rules changed sharply enough that you could compare before and after, or compare across a line. Iran. Saudi Arabia. Afghanistan. The Indian village councils. It graded them, honestly, and it warned that “look at Sweden, look at Afghanistan” fails five of its own six tests.

But the whole exercise assumes that societies are the kind of thing that can be compared like this. That there is a variable called “the rules about women” which can be turned up in one place and down in another, with everything else held roughly steady, so that the difference in outcomes is caused by the setting.

There is no such variable. What the series calls “the rules” is not a dial fitted to an otherwise identical machine. It is woven into inheritance, worship, kinship, land, language, food, mourning and the names people carry. You cannot change it and hold the rest constant, because there is no rest. Part 13’s own third hidden assumption half-admits this — it says the reform is not the intervention, because what is delivered is text plus enforcement plus local reading plus substitution. Push that admission one step further and the comparison collapses entirely.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Suppose you want to know what removing salt does to a dish. You can cook two identical pans and leave salt out of one. Clean comparison.
>
> Now suppose you want to know what removing the third movement does to a symphony. There is no second orchestra playing an otherwise identical symphony. The movement is not an ingredient added to a base. The base is the movements.
>
> We say a moral order is the second kind of thing and this series has treated it as the first, for fifteen parts, because the first kind is the kind you can put in a table.

And one more, briefly, because it costs the series more than it looks. Every part of this series has been written in English, drawing on a literature in English, published on the English-language internet. The traditions being examined transmit themselves in Punjabi, in Hindi, in ritual, in proverb, in the way a grandmother says a sentence, and almost none of that is in any database. The series then reports, honestly, that the evidence for the traditionalist position is thin. Of course it is thin. It was never written down in the language the search was conducted in.

5.5 — Stepping back out

That is the case at full strength. Now I stop arguing for it and say what I think it is worth, which is the same thing Part 6's ninth chapter did to Part 6.

Two of those objections land and two do not.

The consequentialist objection lands. It is the strongest criticism in this entire document. The series does assume that an arrangement must justify itself by its effects, it never argues for that assumption, and a large body of serious moral thought rejects it. I do not agree with the tradition's answer, but the objection is not about the answer. It is that I never put the question on the page. That is failure type four from Chapter One — the question was wrong — and it is the second time in this part that the same failure has been identified.

The instrument objection half lands. It is true that survey-and-effect-size research encodes a set of assumptions about persons. It is not true that this makes the findings worthless, and the traditionalist cannot have it both ways: the same instruments produced the fertility findings in Part 9 that the traditionalist quotes with enthusiasm. An instrument you accept when it agrees with you is not an instrument you have an objection to.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES ASKING "DOES IT WORK?" ALREADY DECIDE THE CASE?

This is the live one, and it has consequences beyond this series.

YES — THE FRAMING IS THE VERDICT

To ask whether a practice produces good outcomes is to treat it as a means. Anything that is genuinely held as an end will fail that test, not because it is bad but because it was never entered in that competition. Every religious practice, every mourning rite, every promise kept at a cost would fail it too. A test that condemns all of those is not detecting badness. It is detecting a category.

NO — BECAUSE THESE RULES MAKE OUTCOME CLAIMS CONSTANTLY

The tradition does not confine itself to “this is right”. It says, loudly and daily, that girls who dress a certain way get attacked, that women who have several partners cannot stay married, that a society that stops having children will die. Those are predictions. Part 10 tested four of them. Once you make a prediction you have entered the outcomes competition voluntarily, and you do not get to withdraw when the result arrives.

BOTH, AND THEY ARE ADDRESSED TO DIFFERENT AUDIENCES

The tradition speaks two languages. To the faithful it says *this is right*. To the doubting, the young and the courts it says *this works*. The series audited the second language and left the first untouched. That is a legitimate scope — but it should have been declared as a scope in Part 1 rather than discovered in Part 15.

Where things stand: the third position is correct and it costs me something to write it. The series never claimed to settle whether the rules are right. It claimed to test what they do. That is a narrower project than fifteen parts and a thousand pages make it feel, and the size of the thing has been doing work that the argument has not earned.

What would settle it: nothing empirical. This is the boundary of what evidence can reach, and one useful function of an evidence-based series is to show exactly where its own instrument stops working.

Why people care so much: because whoever gets to choose the language of a public argument has usually won it. “Does it work?” is the language of the modern state, which is why reformers use it, and why traditions that once spoke only of what is owed have learned to answer in it — and lose something every time they do.

So the traditionalist walks away with one direct hit and one glancing blow, which is a better afternoon than he is usually given. The direct hit is not about any finding in this series. It is about the sentence the series never wrote down on page one.

REMEMBER THIS

The traditionalist's real objection is not that the series was hostile. It is that the series was **generous on grounds the tradition rejects**. A favourable verdict from a court with no jurisdiction is not a favourable verdict.

The series asked of every rule: **does it work?** The tradition claims something different — that certain conduct is owed, whatever it produces. By setting up an outcomes table, the series settled that question without asking it.

The instruments themselves — surveys, effect sizes, randomised trials, ledgers — were built by a civilisation that already holds the individual view of persons. That objection **half lands**: it is true about the instruments, and it is not available to anyone who quotes the same instruments when they agree.

Part 13's comparisons assume there is a dial called "the rules about women" that can be moved with everything else held steady. There is no such dial. But the tradition makes outcome predictions constantly, and having made them, it cannot withdraw from the test when the results come in.

The series audited the language of "this works" and never touched the language of "this is right" — and it should have said so on page one instead of page nine hundred.

CHAPTER SIX

The Feminist's Case Against This Series

> *Advocacy again, the way Part 7 was written as an audit. From here to section 6.5 I am arguing for a position. The charge is not that the series was unfair. It is that fairness was the instrument.*

6.1 — Not "you were unfair"

The weak version of this objection is that the series took the traditionalist side too seriously. Nobody serious is going to argue that, and it would be wrong. Part 11 went after men as the missing comparison group. Part 12 showed that two independent sets of criminals have priced the double standard into their business models. Part 14 showed the reforming state spending its budget on advertising itself. The series is not soft.

The charge is different, and it is structural. **The series adopted a rule — every side gets its strongest case — and applied it evenly to two parties who are not evenly placed.** Applying the same rule to unequal parties does not produce equal treatment. It produces an advantage, and the advantage is always in the same direction.

Three mechanisms, and none of them require the author to be biased.

6.2 — The first mechanism: uncertainty has a home

Chapter Two already conceded the core of this and then moved on quickly, so let me hold it still.

Whoever proposes a change carries the burden of proof. That is not a rule anyone voted for. It is simply what happens. So every honest finding of "we do not know", "the evidence does not travel", "this has not been tested outside America" is a point scored, and it is always scored for the same team.

Count how often those sentences appear across fifteen parts. They are the house style. The series is proud of them — Chapter Ten of every part is a two-page list of what we do not know, and it is described in the method as the most valuable chapter in the document.

It may well be the most valuable. It is also, in a world where the rules are currently in force and enforced by families rather than by argument, a fifteen-times-repeated statement that nothing has been proved. A father does not need to win the argument. He needs it to remain open.

> WORD BOX
>
> **False balance:** giving two positions equal space and equal treatment when the evidence behind them is not equal. It is a well-known failure in journalism — a hundred scientists and one contrarian, one on each side of the desk.
>
> Why it matters here: the version in this series is subtler and harder to see, because the evidence really is thin on both sides. Where genuine uncertainty is presented evenly, the presentation is accurate and the effect still favours whoever benefits from delay. Accuracy and neutrality are not the same property, and this series has repeatedly claimed the second by demonstrating the first.

6.3 — The second mechanism: the funded side has more evidence

Now the deeper one.

The series' rule says: give each side its strongest case. But a side's strongest case is not a fact about how good its position is. It is a fact about how much work has been done on that position — how many researchers studied it, how many surveys asked about it, how many centuries of writing there are to draw on.

What has been studied? The consequences of women's behaviour. There are decades of research on partner counts and divorce, on age at marriage, on female employment and fertility, on what happens when a woman does something. That is the literature Part 10 is built out of, and it is thick.

What has not been studied? Almost everything in Part 11. That part had to be invented from scratch because the comparison group — men — had barely been examined. Part 11 is a good chapter, and the reason it is a good chapter is that the field was empty. The series treated that emptiness as a discovery. It is also a measurement of where the research money and the research attention have gone for a century.

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> You can see this inside the series without leaving it. Part 10 tests four traditionalist claims about what happens to a woman, using a large American survey, a Norwegian replication, and a body of work going back decades.
>
> Part 11 tests the equivalent claims about men and finds nothing comparable. Its evidence is a marital rape exception, a set of population projections, two censuses and a Supreme Court judgment — a legal and demographic record, not a behavioural literature, because a behavioural literature was never built.
>
> What this cannot show: whether the imbalance is because researchers were biased, or because funders were, or because the question about women is genuinely more studied everywhere for reasons unrelated to sexism. All three predict the same empty shelf.
>
> What it does show, definitively: a rule that says "give every side its best evidence" hands more to the side whose evidence exists. That is not a claim about anyone's motives. It is a claim about shelves.

6.4 — The third mechanism: Part 6 exists

Part 6 of this series is titled *The Case for the Old Rules*. It is sixty-five pages. It is written as an advocate's brief, with seven arguments developed at full strength, and its ninth chapter scores them.

Look at what that object is when it leaves the author's hands.

It is the most articulate, best-evidenced, most respectable defence of the old rules that exists in accessible English, on a free website, published by an Indian writer under his own name. It is better than anything the tradition has produced for itself in decades, because the tradition does not usually need to argue — it has enforcement instead.

The series' defence is that Chapter Nine of Part 6 scores those arguments and finds most of them conditional or weak. But a document does not travel with its scoring chapter attached. It travels in screenshots. Nobody has ever forwarded a scorecard.

And the arguments in Part 6 are not abstractions. Their real-world content is a girl not being allowed to go somewhere, a marriage arranged at a speed she cannot object to, a phone checked, a cousin sent along. When the series writes those arguments at full strength, it is not conducting a thought experiment. It is manufacturing ammunition and then, in a later chapter, expressing reservations about the ammunition.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everything in this part so far — my objections and the traditionalist's — has assumed something neither side would think to state: **that the reader is a neutral third party who has not yet decided.**

The whole apparatus depends on it. Steel-manning both sides is useful for someone weighing them. A verdict box saying "nobody knows" is useful for someone waiting to find out. An honest list of what we do not know is useful for someone who intends to update.

But who actually reads a document like this? Not a jury. The readers are inside the thing being described. Some of them are women living under exactly these rules, for whom "the evidence is unclear" is not information but a description of the argument they have already lost at home. Some are men who make these decisions about other people, for whom Part 6 is not one chapter of fifteen but a supply of sentences. Some are already convinced in one direction and are reading for material.

For none of those people is the document a source of information. It is an **instrument in a fight they are already in**. Fifteen parts have been written as though addressed to an undecided reader who, on the evidence of who actually reads long documents about contested subjects, may barely exist.

The general form: **a text written for the undecided will be used by the decided**, and its careful even-handedness becomes, in their hands, a supply depot open to both sides — with more shelves stocked, as section 6.3 showed, on one side than the other.

That is the objection at full strength. It is the one I have found hardest to answer, and I have not answered it. I have only got as far as being able to state it clearly.

6.5 — Stepping back out

Now out of the advocate's voice, and the same treatment Part 7's ninth chapter gave the feminist claims it audited.

The mechanism objections in 6.2 and 6.3 land completely. They are not about my intentions, they do not require me to have been careless, and I cannot answer them by pointing at anything in the text. Honest uncertainty helps the status quo. A strongest-case rule rewards the better-documented side. Both are true, both are structural, and neither has a fix inside the method.

The Part 6 objection is where I want to push back, and the argument is worth having in full.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD THE STRONGEST CASE FOR A COERCIVE POSITION BE WRITTEN DOWN?

This is the practical question underneath the whole method, and it is not confined to this series.

NO — YOU ARE SUPPLYING THE OTHER SIDE

Arguments are not inert. A well-made case for restricting women's movement is used to restrict women's movement, by people who did not have those words before. The author's disapproval does not travel with the text. Nobody who was going to use Part 6 will read Part 6's ninth chapter. Writing it may be the single most consequential thing this series has done, and the consequence is not the one the author intended.

YES — THE ALTERNATIVE HAS BEEN TRIED AND IT FAILED

The case for the old rules was not invented by Part 6. It is the operating assumption of most households on the subcontinent, transmitted without ever being written down, which is precisely why it has never been examined. An argument that is never stated cannot be answered. Writing it down converts an atmosphere into a claim, and a claim can be tested — which is exactly what Part 10 then did to it, and what Part 14 did when it showed the stated function was solved thirty years ago and nothing moved. You cannot land that blow on a position you have refused to state.

YES, BUT NOT FOR FREE

The dispute is not really about whether to state it. It is about packaging. A brief that can be forwarded on its own is a different object from an argument embedded where its answer cannot be detached. Part 6 was published as a standalone PDF with a cover, a title, and its own web page. That was a design decision and nobody made it as a decision.

Where things stand: the third position is right and it is a criticism of the format, not of the method. The argument for stating the case survives. The argument for stating it as a separately downloadable sixty-five-page document with an attractive cover does not survive as easily, and I made that choice without ever once thinking about it as a choice.

What would settle it: knowing how Part 6 has actually been used. That is knowable in principle — where it is linked, what is quoted from it, whether the scoring chapter ever appears alongside — and I have not looked. Not looking is itself a decision I should not be allowed to describe as neutral.

Why people care so much: because this is the oldest question in public argument and it has no stable answer. Every serious person who has ever written down an opponent's best case has had to decide whether they were clarifying a fight or arming one, and nobody has ever been able to check.

Two chapters, two sets of objections, and notice how differently they behave. The traditionalist attacks the framing and lands once, hard. The feminist attacks the mechanics and lands three times, and none of the three can be fixed by writing better. That difference is itself information about what kind of document this series is.

REMEMBER THIS

The objection is not that the series was unfair. It is that **the same rule applied to unequally placed parties produces an advantage**, always in the same direction.

Three mechanisms. **Uncertainty has a home**: every honest “we do not know” is a point for whoever benefits from nothing changing. **The funded side has more evidence**: a strongest-case rule rewards the position that has been studied, and one position has been studied for a century while the other left an empty shelf that Part 11 had to fill by hand. **Part 6 exists**: the best-argued defence of the old rules in accessible English is now a downloadable document with a cover, and the chapter that scores it does not travel with it.

Underneath all of it sits the assumption that **the reader is an undecided third party**. Most readers of a document like this are inside the fight it describes. For them it is not information. It is a supply depot, with more shelves stocked on one side.

The first two objections land completely and have no fix inside the method. The third is a criticism of **packaging**, and it is correct about the packaging.

Fairness is a rule about the writer. It is not a property of the effect.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Where I Changed My Mind

> *Six places where the writing moved me. Each one is a correction to something I believed at the start — and the version of me that believed those things is the one who chose the questions.*

7.1 — Why this chapter is in the document at all

A writer telling you he changed his mind is doing something suspicious. It is a claim about his own honesty, made by him, with no way for you to check it. It also flatters him: only an open-minded person changes his mind, so the confession is a compliment wearing plain clothes.

So I want to be careful about what this chapter is claiming. It is not claiming that I am open-minded. It is producing a list of specific, dated, checkable places where an earlier part of this series says one thing and a later part says another, and drawing an unfriendly conclusion from the pattern.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

The evidence here is unusually good for a claim about a writer's private beliefs, because the belief was published before the test was run.

Each of the six items below has this shape: an earlier part is on record with an expectation, in print, on a public site, with a date. A later part is on record with a finding that does not match it. The gap between the two is the evidence. I cannot go back and edit the earlier part without leaving a corrected edition behind, and the standing rule of this series is that corrected editions say what was changed and who caught it.

What this cannot show: *why* the belief changed. Reading a study and being persuaded looks exactly like reading a study and finding it convenient. Nobody has access to the difference, including me, which is why Chapter One told you to discount every sentence in this part beginning "I was surprised".

7.2 — The six

One. I expected the partner-count finding to be a clean story. Before Part 10 I assumed the association between a woman's number of partners before marriage and her later divorce risk would either be a straightforward causal effect or a straightforwardly spurious one. It is neither. The pattern is not a straight line at all — the divorce rate does not simply rise as the number rises, and the researcher who assembled the best version of it has published that no proposed mechanism explains its shape. I expected to resolve that chapter. It resolved into a shrug that is more interesting than either answer would have been.

Two. I expected enforcement to be male. I began Part 11 expecting to describe fathers and brothers policing daughters. The daily reality in the data is that the enforcement is largely administered by women on women. In the Indian household survey work, a mother-in-law's view of contraception predicts a couple's use of it better than the wife's own view does. The lethal end of enforcement is delegated to the most legally expendable male in the family. That is a different machine from the one I sat down to describe.

Three. I expected an asymmetric rule to imply an asymmetric fact. If a rule falls on daughters and not sons, the obvious reading is that somebody believes something different about daughters. The better explanation turned out to be much duller and much worse: **the rule falls where it can be enforced.** A household can reach a daughter at home. It cannot reach a son in another city. That single sentence reorganised Part 11 and it did not come from me — it came from noticing that the pattern of enforcement tracks reach, not belief.

Four. I expected natural experiments to be reasonably common. Part 13 was planned as a survey of many cases where history had run the trial for us. After grading them against six tests, exactly one genuine randomisation exists in this entire subject: India's 1993 reservation of village council seats, which rotated by village serial number. One. The rest are comparisons, some of them good, none of them experiments. I had assumed the shelf was half full. It has one item on it.

Five. I expected persuasion campaigns to be weak. I did not expect them to fail as a category. India's flagship campaign for the girl child released ₹446.72 crore to states between 2016 and 2019, and 78.91 per cent of it went on media advocacy — a parliamentary committee reported that to Parliament in December 2021. The campaign to change minds spent four rupees in five telling people the campaign existed. Part 14 ended up classifying "tell people to stop" not as a weak intervention but as a category error, and I did not begin that part expecting to write that sentence.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Crore:** ten million, in the Indian way of counting. ₹446.72 crore is about 4.47 billion rupees. Indian budget figures are almost always written this way, and a reader outside India will misread them by a factor of ten million if nobody says so.

Six. I expected money to move behaviour. Korea has spent more than two hundred billion dollars on raising its birth rate. Hungary has spent around 5 per cent of its national output. Both got real effects, both small, and Hungary's rate has fallen back to roughly where it started. Cash is the intervention every government reaches for. It is also the one with the shortest memory: the effect stops when the money stops.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Six changes across fourteen parts is not a lot. It is roughly one every two parts, or one every 20,000 words.
>
> Put it the other way and it sounds worse. If you had asked me six specific questions on the day I started, I would have got all six wrong. Not slightly wrong — wrong in the direction of the ordinary, expected answer, which is exactly the direction a person is wrong in when he has not looked yet.

7.3 — What that says about Part 1

Here is the part that costs something.

Part 1 did not just open the series. It set the questions for everything after it. It defined the portability test that Part 10 and Part 13 both run. It decided that the series would examine what the rules are for and what happens when they change. It agreed the shape of all sixteen parts.

And Part 1 was written by the version of me who would have got all six of those questions wrong.

That is not a small observation. Every later part could be perfectly reasoned and the whole structure would still be carrying the fingerprints of a set of expectations that the evidence went on to contradict six times. The corrections are visible, because they happened inside chapters and got written up. The framing errors are not visible, because framing does not produce a testable claim. It produces a table of contents.

Look back at the list and notice what kind of error they all are. Every one of them is me expecting the **simpler, more individual, more belief-driven** version of the truth. A clean causal effect rather than an unexplained shape. Men enforcing rather than a whole household machine. A belief about daughters rather than a fact about reach. Plenty of evidence rather than almost none. Persuasion working a little rather than not being an intervention at all.

That is a consistent bias and it has a name in the ordinary sense: I kept expecting the world to be made of individuals with reasons. Part 14's second hidden assumption says beliefs are downstream of structures. I now think that is right. But I only got there by being wrong about it six times in public, and the series is built on a frame chosen before any of that happened.

THE ARGUMENT — DOES A WRITER WHO CHANGES HIS MIND BECOME MORE RELIABLE OR LESS?

This matters beyond me, because it decides how you should read anybody's long project.

MORE RELIABLE

A writer whose conclusions never move is either extraordinarily lucky in his priors or is not testing anything. Visible correction is the only externally checkable sign that evidence is doing work. You cannot see inside a writer's head, but you can see whether Part 10 contradicts Part 1, and you can see whether he printed it.

LESS RELIABLE

Six documented reversals in fourteen parts is a measured error rate for this author on this subject, and it is high. It applies to the claims he has not yet had a chance to be wrong about — which, by definition, are the claims still standing at the end. A person who has been wrong six times out of six is not a person whose framing you should trust; he is a person whose framing has simply not been tested yet, because framing never is.

NEITHER — IT MEASURES THE FIELD, NOT THE MAN

All six errors are in the direction of the popular, individual-level explanation. That is not a personal defect. It is what an educated reader of the English-language literature on this subject would believe, because that is what the literature emphasises. The reversals measure the gap between what gets written about and what turns out to hold. Anyone doing this honestly would have produced roughly the same six.

Where things stand: the second and third positions are both true and they are not in conflict. The error rate is real and it does transfer to untested claims. It also is not idiosyncratic — it is the standard prior of anyone who reads this material in English, which makes it more dangerous rather than less, because a shared error does not feel like an error. It feels like context.

What would settle it: someone else running the same fourteen questions from a different starting position and seeing whether they get corrected in the same six places. Nobody is going to do that, so this stays unresolved.

Why people care so much: because "he changed his mind" is used as a trump card by both sides in every public argument — as proof of honesty by supporters and proof of unreliability by opponents — and it is genuinely evidence for both.

7.4 — The inference I do not like

Put the two halves together and you get something I would rather not write down.

The six corrections are the visible errors. Visible errors are the ones that happened at the level of claims, because claims are the level at which the evidence can push back. Nothing pushed back on the framing, the choice of questions, or the decision about what a good outcome would be — not because those were right, but because nothing in a research process ever tests them.

So the fair summary is not "the author was corrected six times and is now better calibrated". It is: **the author was corrected six times at the only level where correction was possible, and the level that was never tested is the level that determined the shape of all fifteen parts.**

That is Chapter One's hidden assumption arriving with a bill attached.

REMEMBER THIS

Six documented reversals across fourteen parts: the **partner-count shape**, **who actually enforces**, **reach rather than belief**, **how few real experiments exist**, **persuasion as a category error**, and **money's short memory**. All are checkable, because the expectation was published before the test.

Every one of the six is an error in the same direction: expecting the world to be made of **individuals acting on beliefs**, rather than households acting within reach of each other.

Part 1 set the questions for all sixteen parts, and Part 1 was written by the version of me that got all six wrong. The corrections are visible because they happened at the level of claims. The framing was never tested, because framing does not produce a testable claim.

Changing your mind is evidence of honesty and evidence of a measured error rate at the same time, and the error rate transfers to everything still standing.

I was corrected at the only level where correction was possible, and the level that decided the shape of the whole thing was never in play.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What Even-Handedness Cost

> *The rule that every side gets its strongest case is the thing I am proudest of in this series. This chapter puts a price on it — four prices, and one of them I did not see until I wrote this down.*

8.1 — What the rule bought

Before the bill, the purchase, because a chapter that only lists costs is not an audit either.

The strongest-case rule bought three things and they are not small.

It made the series usable by people who disagree with it. A traditionalist reader can get through Part 10 without being insulted, which means he can get as far as the finding that the marriage-market damage does not travel — and that finding is a problem for him. An argument nobody hostile will read has an audience of the already-convinced, which is another way of saying no audience.

It forced the writing to be right. You cannot state an opponent's best case and then knock it down with a sentence, because you have just made the sentence look thin. Half the useful findings in this series exist because a lazy answer stopped working once the objection was written out properly.

And it produced the one thing public argument almost never produces: a clear view of where the disagreement actually sits. Part 5's four competing accounts. Part 6's scorecard. Part 13's table of both sides' predictions. None of those could have been built by someone who had decided the answer first.

Now the bill.

8.2 — Price one: articulate positions win

"Give every side its strongest case" contains a hidden entry requirement. To have a strongest case, you have to be a side. To be a side, somebody has to have written your position down.

Chapter Six put one version of this: the funded position has more evidence. Here is the wider version.

The positions that appear in this series are the ones with literatures — the religious tradition, the reforming state, academic feminism, evolutionary psychology, demography. Each of those has advocates, books, journals and money.

Now name the positions that do not appear. The woman who thinks the rules are stupid and complies anyway because complying is cheaper than the alternative, and who has no interest in either camp. The mother-in-law who enforces and would not describe herself as enforcing. The young man in a village with no marriage prospects, who appears in Part 11 only as a risk to other people. None of these are "sides". They have no journals. So they enter this series as objects of study and never as arguments.

That is not a fixable flaw in the method. It is what the method *is*. A rule that says "represent every position at full strength" will always be a rule about positions that have been articulated, and articulation is expensive.

> WORD BOX
>
> **The default:** what happens if nobody does anything. In a form, it is the box already ticked. In a system of social rules, it is the arrangement currently running.
>
> Why it matters here: defaults win far more often than their arguments deserve, because they are the outcome of inaction as well as of decision. Every argument that ends inconclusively is an argument the default has won. This is not a claim about persuasion. It is arithmetic about how outcomes are produced when nobody is persuaded of anything.

8.3 — Price two: refusing to advise is a position

Part 10's ninth chapter refused to give advice. It said so openly, and it explained why refusing is itself a position rather than an absence of one.

I want to go further than that chapter did, because it stated the problem and then moved on as though stating it had handled it.

Consider what a young woman is actually doing when she reads Part 10. She has a decision in front of her — about a relationship, a phone, a photograph, a city, a marriage. She has read seventy-six pages establishing that the traditionalist's warning does not survive a portability test, that the wellbeing effects reverse depending on what her community believes, and that the divorce association is essentially untested outside America.

Then the author declines to tell her what he thinks she should do.

What has she got? She has got an accurate map of a landscape and no direction. And the landscape she is standing in already has a direction built into it, because her family has a view, her neighbourhood has a view, and the cost of doing nothing is zero while the cost of doing something falls entirely on her.

So the refusal does not leave her free. It leaves her exactly where she was, with better information about why she is there. On any question where the default is one-sided, a writer who declines to advise has not abstained. He has voted, quietly, for whatever was going to happen anyway.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD THIS SERIES HAVE GIVEN ADVICE?

The method says do not pick a side for the reader. The objection is that the reader is not standing on neutral ground.

YES, IT SHOULD HAVE

The series has spent a thousand pages establishing what the evidence does and does not support. Withholding the conclusion at the last step is not humility, it is a refusal to be accountable for the one sentence anyone could act on. Doctors do not present a patient with a survival table and decline to recommend. And the cost of not advising is not shared evenly: it falls on the person with the decision, who is almost never the person with the power.

NO, AND THE ASYMMETRY IS EXACTLY WHY

The author is a man who has never been subject to these rules, writing to women who will bear every consequence of following his advice. He carries none of the risk. Advice under that arrangement is not generosity, it is a stranger spending someone else's safety. Worse, the evidence in this series does not support advice — Part 10's own finding is that the wellbeing effects *reverse* depending on the community. There is no general answer, so any general answer would be invented, and an invented answer delivered with a thousand pages of authority behind it is more dangerous than no answer.

ADVISE ON THE REASONING, NOT THE DECISION

The dispute assumes advice means "do this". A third option exists and the series never took it: tell the reader which questions decide her case. Not "leave" or "stay", but: your outcome depends far more on what your particular community believes than on anything in the research; the warning you have been given is a prediction and here is how to check whether it has ever come true near you; the people advising you carry none of the cost. That is directive without being presumptuous, and it is actionable.

Where things stand: the third position is right and the series did not do it. Not once in fifteen parts is there a section addressed to a reader with a decision, telling her which of the findings actually bear on her situation and which are background. That is a real gap and it is the most useful thing anyone could add to this work.

What would settle it: nothing evidential. This is a question about what a writer owes a reader, and the answer depends on who you think the reader is — which is precisely what Chapter Six's hidden assumption says nobody knows.

Why people care so much: because "I am just presenting the evidence" is the most comfortable position available to anybody writing about other people's lives, and it is comfortable exactly in proportion to how little the writer stands to lose.

8.4 — Price three: it can be quarried

A document that gives every side its strongest case is a document from which any side can extract support.

This is not hypothetical. Part 6 is a defence of the old rules, written well. Part 9 contains the finding that no country has reversed a fertility decline, which is the single most quoted fact in pronatalist politics. Part 4 contains effect sizes for sex differences. Part 7 contains an audit of feminist claims that finds some of them weakly supported.

Every one of those is honest. Every one of them is also a paragraph that can be lifted, screenshotted and used with the surrounding argument removed. The series' answer is that the arguments are all in the same document and a reader can see the whole. That answer assumes the whole gets read. Chapter One already worked out roughly how many people finish a fifteen-part series, and the answer was: very few.

The honest description is that this series has produced a well-stocked quarry, marked its own load-bearing stones carefully, and has no control over what anybody builds.

8.5 — Price four: the length is the filter

This is the one I did not see until I wrote this part.

The method's central claim is that hard things can be written so that anyone can follow them. Short sentences. Everyday words. Every term explained where it appears. No assumed knowledge. I believe that claim and this series demonstrates it: there is no sentence in the fifteen parts that requires a degree.

But simplification is not compression — the method says so explicitly. The simple version is longer. Spend enough words buying comprehension and you have produced a thousand pages, and a thousand pages has an entry requirement of its own. It is not vocabulary. It is **time**.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Twenty to twenty-five hours of reading. Now think about who has that.
>
> A woman doing paid work and then a second unpaid shift at home has, by every time-use survey ever run in India, less discretionary time than almost anyone else in the country. She is the person this series is about. She is the person least able to read it.
>
> The reader who does have twenty-five spare hours, an English reading habit and an interest in evidence is, on average, comfortable, educated, urban and male. The prose was made accessible. The *object* was not.

So the accessibility of the method is real at the level of the sentence and undone at the level of the artefact. Every one of the eight rules of the voice is aimed at the sentence. Nothing in the method is aimed at the total. Fifteen parts of scrupulously simple English add up to something only a particular kind of person can consume, and that person is not the subject of the book.

REMEMBER THIS

The strongest-case rule bought three real things: it made the series **readable by people who disagree**, it **forced the arguments to be right**, and it showed where disagreements actually sit.

Price one: to have a strongest case you have to be a **side**, and being a side requires somebody to have written you down. The people in this series with no journals appear only as objects of study.

Price two: **refusing to advise is not abstention.** Where the default is one-sided, declining to advise votes quietly for whatever was going to happen anyway. The series never once addressed a reader with an actual decision in front of her.

Price three: an even-handed document is a **quarry**. Every side can lift a stone, and the answer “read the whole thing” assumes a reader who does.

Price four, and it is the one I missed: the prose was made accessible and the object was not. Twenty-five hours is an entry requirement, and the person this series is about is the person in the country with the least spare time.

CHAPTER NINE

What Would Have To Be True For Me To Be Badly Wrong

> *Nine chapters of objections, scored. Then the four ways this series could fail in a way that actually matters — and the assumption sitting underneath the whole confession.*

9.1 — Four ways to be wrong that would matter

Chapter One set a test: an objection has to say what becomes worthless if it is right. Here are the four failures that would do real damage, stated so that you could in principle check them.

Failure one: the causal arrow in Part 9 runs backwards. Part 9 treats falling birth rates as something that happens when women get options. Suppose the arrow mostly runs the other way — that the collapse in fertility is driven by housing costs, insecure work and delayed adulthood, and women's changing choices are largely downstream of those. Then Part 9 spent ninety-two pages attributing to a cultural shift something caused by an economy, and the entire pronatalist argument it takes seriously is aimed at the wrong target. *What would show it:* a country where the material conditions were fixed and the birth rate recovered while the cultural change stayed. No country has produced this, which is either evidence for Part 9 or evidence that nobody has tried the experiment.

Failure two: the enforcement thesis is an artefact of who gets studied. Part 11's spine is that the rule falls where it can be reached. The evidence is that households police daughters at home and cannot police sons in other cities. But household surveys are conducted *in households*. A method that visits homes will find the control that happens in homes. *What would show it:* good data on how men in other cities are actually constrained — by remittance expectations, by marriage brokerage, by the threat of being cut off. If that constraint turned out to be heavy and simply invisible to household surveys, Part 11's central claim shrinks to a claim about measurement.

Failure three: persuasion works on a lag longer than any study. Part 14 grades "tell people to stop" as a category error, on evidence drawn from campaigns measured over five to ten years. Almost every large moral change in history — on slavery, on child labour, on public smoking — took two or three generations, and the persuasion phase looked useless throughout. *What would show it:* a case where a campaign produced no measurable effect for twenty-five years and then a large one, with the mechanism traced. I do not know of one that has been properly documented, and the absence may be about the length of research funding rather than about the world.

Failure four, and the serious one: the series is a way of not acting. Everything in it is true, and its effect on a reader is to convert a situation that calls for a decision into a subject that calls for further reading. *What would show it:* nothing, from inside. This is the failure that cannot be detected by the person committing it, which is what makes it worth putting first in your mind and last in the document.

9.2 — The scoreboard

Chapter One set three verdicts. An objection **lands** if I cannot answer it without changing a claim or admitting something rests on a choice. It is **survivable** if it is true and the series already says so in the text. It **fails** if answering it only requires pointing at what the series actually says.

THE OBJECTION	VERDICT	WHAT ANSWERING IT WOULD TAKE
The functional question was run without its mirror — what is this costing now, and who pays?	**Lands**	Writing the missing part at the same depth. My expectation is it changes emphasis everywhere and conclusions nowhere, which I cannot verify from here.
Honest uncertainty is not neutral — every “we do not know” scores for the arrangement in force	**Lands, no fix**	Nothing available. This is structural. It is a property of writing truthfully about a rule while the rule is running.
A real woman’s injury was converted into a research subject	**Lands**	Nothing. It is done. Part 12 named half of it; this part names the rest.
Sturdy and fragile evidence were written in the same voice	**Lands**	An evidence grade on every empirical claim in all fifteen parts. Real work, and the single most useful correction anyone could make.

THE OBJECTION	VERDICT	WHAT ANSWERING IT WOULD TAKE
The scoreboards' columns decided their results, and totals let one woman's gain cancel another's loss	**Lands**	Reporting spread as well as average, and a column for outcomes with no numbers. Part 8's "reached whom" column was a gesture at this, not a fix.
Consequentialism was assumed, never argued — the series tested "does it work" and called it neutral	**Lands hardest**	Declaring the scope on page one: this series audits outcome claims and does not touch claims about what is owed.
The research instruments encode the worldview under examination	**Half lands**	Not available to anyone who quotes the same instruments approvingly, which both sides do constantly.
Societies are not comparable units, so Part 13's cases are not experiments	**Survivable**	Nothing — Part 13 says this itself, sets six tests, and fails five of them on the popular comparisons.
A strongest-case rule rewards whichever position has been studied and funded	**Lands, no fix**	Nothing inside the method. The empty shelf Part 11 had to fill by hand is the measurement of it.
Part 6 is a downloadable, well-designed brief for coercive rules, and its scoring chapter does not travel with it	**Lands, on packaging**	Publishing the case and its audit as one inseparable object. A design decision I never made as a decision.
The document assumes an undecided reader; most readers are inside the fight	**Lands**	Knowing who actually reads and quotes it. Knowable in principle. I have not looked.
Six reversals show the framing was set by the least informed version of the author	**Lands**	Someone else running the same questions from a different start. Nobody will.

THE OBJECTION	VERDICT	WHAT ANSWERING IT WOULD TAKE
Refusing to advise is a vote for the default	**Lands**	A section telling a reader with a decision which findings bear on her case. Never written, in fifteen parts.
Fifteen parts of simple English add up to an object only the comfortable can read	**Lands**	A short version. One that is genuinely short, not a summary that points back at the long one.

Fourteen objections. Twelve land, one half lands, one is survivable, and none fail outright. That last figure should bother you, and it bothers me.

A prosecution in which nearly every charge sticks is not a rigorous prosecution. It is a document written by someone who selected charges he was willing to concede. Chapter One promised that an honest audit includes the charges that fail, and this one produced almost none — which tells you the selection happened earlier, in the choosing, where selections always happen and never show.

9.3 — The one that survives everything

Strip the fourteen down and one combination is left standing that nothing in the series answers.

Part 14 found that explanation is the weakest lever available for changing an arrangement like this. Part 15, Chapter Eight, found that the artefact takes twenty-five hours to read, which selects for a reader who is comfortable, educated and not subject to the rules. Part 15, Chapter Six, found that the readers who do arrive are mostly not undecided.

Put those three together and you get a specific, unflattering prediction: **this series will be read mainly by people it cannot help, in a format that works least, on a question its own findings say is not settled by argument.**

Every step of that is drawn from the series’ own results. I cannot refute it with anything in the series, because it is built out of the series.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everything in this part — every objection, every concession, every "this lands" — rests on a premise so comfortable that I did not notice it until the scoreboard came out at twelve to nothing.

The assumption is that being able to state an objection shows you are not subject to it.

It is what makes self-criticism feel like progress. I named the burden-of-proof problem, so I am no longer captured by it. I described the way an even-handed document supplies both sides, so my document is now less of a supply depot. I identified that the length filters the audience, and having identified it, I have somehow answered it.

None of that follows. A confession is a description, not a repair. The burden of proof still sits where it sat. Part 6 is still downloadable. This part is 20,000 words long, which makes the length problem it diagnoses *worse* by exactly 20,000 words. There is no sentence anywhere in this document that changes a single thing about the fourteen parts it audits, and I have not committed here to changing any of them.

The general form: **naming a bias is the cheapest possible response to it, and it produces the same feeling as fixing it.** That is why it is so popular, and it is why an author's own audit — however honest — is worth less than one line of correction actually applied to the text.

That box is the reason the previous section exists rather than a conclusion. If this part had ended on "twelve objections land and I have faced them", the facing would have been the whole product.

9.4 — What I am actually committing to

So let me put the only thing on the page that is not a description. Four commitments, checkable, and Part 16 will report on them.

One. The evidence grade. Every empirical claim across the fifteen parts marked by what it rests on — census, experiment, replicated study, single study, self-report. This is the correction with the highest value and it is a large piece of work.

Two. Part 6 and its audit republished as one object that cannot be separated.

Three. A short version. Genuinely short — the length that fits in the time a person with two shifts actually has.

Four. The missing part, or an honest statement that I am not going to write it: what these rules are costing right now, and who is paying, at the depth Part 10 gave to the other direction.

If Part 16 arrives and none of those exist, then this chapter was what it suspected itself of being, and you will have the evidence in your hands.

REMEMBER THIS

Four failures that would matter: the **arrow in Part 9 running backwards**, the **enforcement thesis being an artefact of household surveys**, **persuasion working on a lag longer than any study**, and the series functioning as **a way of not acting**. Only the last cannot be checked from outside, which is why it is the dangerous one.

Of fourteen objections, twelve land, one half lands, one is survivable, and none fail. **A prosecution where every charge sticks is not rigorous — it is curated.**

One combination survives everything, and it is built entirely from this series' own findings: it will be read mainly by people it cannot help, in a format that works least, on a question its own results say argument does not settle.

Underneath all self-criticism sits the assumption that **naming a problem shows you are not subject to it**. It does not. A confession is a description. This part is 20,000 words, which makes the length problem it diagnoses worse by 20,000 words.

Four commitments are on the page instead of a conclusion. If Part 16 arrives and none of them exist, you will know exactly what this chapter was.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Every part of this series ends here. This time the subject is the series itself — what genuinely cannot be established about it, why not, and the smaller list of things that are simply true.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

The useful part of a list like this is never the gap. It is the reason for the gap, which is usually more informative than the missing fact would have been.

Who reads this, and what they do with it. I do not know. Nothing in fifteen parts required me to find out, and I have not. Some of it is knowable — where the parts are linked, which passages get quoted, whether Part 6 travels with its scoring chapter. *Why it is unknown:* because I have not looked, and because I preferred not to. An author who does not check how his work is used keeps the pleasant version of the answer.

Whether the framing changed any conclusion. Chapter Two argues that the functional question shaped everything. It might have shaped nothing. *Why it is unknown:* framing does not generate a claim that can be tested. It generates a table of contents. The only test is writing the series again from a different opening question, which nobody will do, including me.

Whether I would have published a conclusion that destroyed the project. I said in Chapter One that I would like to think so and cannot prove it. *Why it is unknown:* the situation never arose. A disposition that has never been tested is not a fact about a person. It is a hope he has about himself.

What the unrepresented would say. Chapter Eight listed the positions that never appear as arguments — the woman who complies because compliance is cheaper, the enforcing mother-in-law who does not consider herself an enforcer, the unmarried man at the bottom of the class structure. *Why it is unknown:* they have no literature, and this series is built entirely from the published record. Finding out would require going and asking, which is a different kind of work than any part of this series has done.

How much of the fragile evidence would survive checking. Chapter Three showed what happens to psychology and social science findings in general when somebody runs them again. Almost none of the specific studies quoted in this series have been through that. *Why it is unknown:* replication is expensive, unglamorous and rarely funded, so it happens to famous findings and not to the ordinary ones a series like this actually leans on.

Whether persuasion works on a long lag. Part 14's verdict rests on campaigns measured over five to ten years. *Why it is unknown:* research budgets run in three-year cycles and moral changes run in generations. The gap between those two numbers is not a fact about persuasion. It is a fact about how research is paid for, and it means the question has never really been asked.

Whether the series has done more good than harm. *Why it is unknown:* there is no comparison world. I cannot observe the version of the last year in which these thousand pages were not written and see what those readers did instead. This is the hardest kind of ignorance, because it applies to the only question that finally matters and there is no instrument for it at all.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> Notice the shape of that list. Almost none of the items are unknown because the evidence is contradictory. They are unknown because **nobody built the instrument**.
>
> Nobody funds replications of ordinary findings. Nobody runs studies longer than a funding cycle. Nobody surveys the people with no organised position. Nobody can construct a comparison world.
>
> Part 13's method chapter made the same point about natural experiments and Part 11 made it about men. When a whole category of question is unstudied, that is rarely because the question is hard. It is because no institution had a reason to pay for the answer.
>
> What this cannot show: that the answers would be interesting. Some unstudied questions are unstudied because they are dull. You cannot tell which from the outside, which is the second-order version of the same problem.

10.2 — Solid

Shorter, as always, and worth more.

The replication figures. Of 100 psychology studies rerun by a 270-person collaboration, 36 produced a significant result where 97 of the originals had; the surviving effects were about half the original size. Of 21 social science experiments from *Nature* and *Science*, 13 replicated, again at about half size. A 2025 project across 54 journals put around 55 per cent of claims through successfully. *Why it is solid:* these were pre-registered, designed to be checked, run by teams with no stake in any particular result, and their methods are public. They are among the few studies in this document built specifically to be audited.

The sampling figures. Roughly 96 per cent of behavioural research subjects come from Western industrialised countries; about 68 per cent from the United States alone; those countries hold about 12 per cent of the world's people. *Why it is solid:* it is a count of published papers, and anybody can recount them.

That reported sexual histories cannot all be true. In a closed population over a fixed period, men's and women's average number of opposite-sex partners must be equal. In every survey, men report more. *Why it is solid:* it is arithmetic, not research. It does not tell you who is misreporting. It establishes beyond argument that somebody is.

That this series contains six documented reversals. *Why it is solid:* the parts are published and dated. The expectation was in print before the finding was.

That Part 6 exists as a separable object. A sixty-five-page brief for the old rules, with its own cover, its own page and its own download. *Why it is solid:* one click confirms it.

That no part of this series addresses a reader with a decision. *Why it is solid:* it is a search across fifteen documents, and the result is zero.

That India's flagship campaign for the girl child spent most of its released money on advertising itself. A parliamentary committee reported in December 2021 that of ₹446.72 crore released to states from 2016 to 2019, 78.91 per cent went on media advocacy. *Why it is solid:* it is a legislature auditing its own government's spending and finding against it, which is the direction institutional evidence almost never runs.

IN REAL TERMS

That last figure again, in ordinary money. Out of every hundred rupees the campaign actually got into the states' hands, about seventy-nine went on telling people the campaign existed and about twenty-one went on everything else.

If a family spent its monthly food budget that way, four weeks in five would go on announcing dinner.

And one thing that is solid without being empirical. Where nobody is persuaded, the arrangement already running continues. That is not a claim about psychology and it needs no study. It is what a default *is*. Every argument in this series that ends without resolution ends with the rules still in force, and that outcome was determined by the structure of the situation rather than by anything either side said.

REMEMBER THIS

Almost everything on the unknown list is unknown for the same reason: **nobody built the instrument.** Not funded, not surveyed, not measured longer than a grant cycle, not asked of people with no organised position.

I do not know who reads this, whether the framing changed any conclusion, what the unrepresented would say, how much of the fragile evidence would survive checking, or whether the series has done net good — and that last one has **no comparison world**, so it is not merely unmeasured but unmeasurable.

What is solid is narrow and mostly external: the **replication figures**, the **sampling figures**, the **arithmetic** showing reported sexual histories cannot all be true, the six dated reversals, and a parliamentary committee's finding that four rupees in five went on advertising.

And one non-empirical certainty: **where nobody is persuaded, the default runs.** Every unresolved argument in fifteen parts ended with the rules still in force, and that was decided by the structure, not by the arguing.

The gaps in this list are not mysteries. They are places where no institution had a reason to pay for an answer.

REFERENCE

The Series, Part by Part

Fifteen parts, roughly a thousand pages. This table is the record of what each one claimed, so that a reader of this audit can check the charges against the things being charged.

PART	TITLE AND WHAT IT ESTABLISHED
One	The Question Underneath the Question — set the framing for all sixteen parts, and the portability test used later to check whether an effect found in one place shows up in another.
Two	Where the Rules Came From — the historical origins, and the warning that origin does not settle worth.
Three	The Indian Machine — how the rules are actually transmitted and enforced here; turns the where-it-came-from objection on the series itself.
Four	The Bodies Themselves — sex differences, with an effect-size table and heavy caveats about what an average difference does and does not license.
Five	The Paradox of the Free Countries — four competing accounts of why outcomes in liberal societies are not what either side predicted.
Six	The Case for the Old Rules — written as advocacy; seven arguments at full strength, then scored against four conditions.
Seven	What Feminism Actually Claims — written as an audit; a claims scorecard and an Indian timeline from 1848.
Eight	The Ledger of the Equality Project — eighteen rows of outcomes, with a column asking who each change actually reached.
Nine	The Arithmetic of Descendants — fertility, pronatalism and the finding that no country has reversed a decline.
Ten	What the Evidence Says Happens to a Woman — the core warning unpacked into four claims and tested; infection travels, marriage-market damage does not.
Eleven	The Half Nobody Studied — men as the missing comparison group; the rule falls where it can be enforced, not where belief points.

PART	TITLE AND WHAT IT ESTABLISHED
Twelve	The Community With No Edges — enforcement once the community loses its boundaries; two patterns of blackmail-by-photograph, priced differently by two independent sets of criminals.
Thirteen	When History Ran the Experiment — nine cases graded against six tests; one genuine randomisation exists in the whole subject.
Fourteen	What Would Actually Work — four intervention shapes scored; persuasion classified as a category error, visibility as the one tier-one success.
Fifteen	The Case Against This Series — this document. Fourteen objections, twelve of which land, and four commitments instead of a conclusion.
Sixteen	**Part 16 starts here.** The synthesis — and the report on whether the four commitments in Chapter Nine were kept.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Every term this document treats as needing explanation, in plain English, in one place.

TERM	MEANING
Aggregation	Adding outcomes across many people to get a total or an average. It treats one person's gain and another's loss as quantities that cancel.
Audit	Checking something against the original records rather than against the account the doer gives of himself.
Burden of proof	The job of proving your case. Whoever does not carry it wins by default when the evidence is unclear.
Category error	Treating something as a kind of thing it is not — for example, scoring a moral duty as though it were a policy with results.
Consequentialism	The view that whether an action is right depends on the results it produces.
Constitutive good	Something that is part of what a good life is, rather than a means to anything else.
Crore	Ten million, in Indian counting. ₹1 crore is ten million rupees.
Default	What happens if nobody does anything. In a system of rules, it is the arrangement currently running.
Effect size	How big a difference something makes, as opposed to whether the difference is real at all.
False balance	Giving two positions equal treatment when the evidence behind them is not equal.
Functional explanation	Explaining something by what it does, rather than by how it arose or whether it is right.
Hidden assumption	A premise both sides of an argument accept without stating, and therefore never examine.
Legibility	Whether a state can see, count and act on something from a distance, through forms and registers.

TERM	MEANING
Natural experiment	A real-world event that splits a population in a way an experimenter could not arrange, allowing a before-and-after or side-by-side comparison.
Portability test	Checking whether an effect found in one place still appears in another. If it does not travel, it belongs to the setting rather than to the act.
Proxy	Something you measure because you cannot measure the thing you actually care about.
Publication bias	The tendency for interesting results to reach print while boring ones stay in a drawer, so the published record is not a sample of what is true.
Randomisation	Assigning people or places by lot, so that the groups differ only by chance and any later difference can be attributed to the treatment.
Replication	Running somebody else’s study again, on new people, to see whether the same thing happens.
Self-report	Evidence made of what people say about themselves on a form. Reliable for some things and not for anything they are punished for.
Steel man	The strongest version of an argument you disagree with. The opposite of a straw man.
Straw man	A weak, distorted version of an opponent’s argument, built so it is easy to knock down.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the Author

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, belief and public life, and publish it under my own name. Nobody commissions it and nobody can withdraw it. That is the arrangement I wanted and, as Chapter One of this part says, it removes one kind of pressure and adds another.

I came to this subject sideways. A woman was photographed at a protest, strangers decided on no evidence what kind of woman she was, and the speed of it seemed to me to be the interesting thing — not the accusation but the machinery that made the accusation usable. Fifteen parts later I am less sure that studying the machinery was the right response, which is most of what Chapter Two is about.

I am working towards doctoral research. This series is not that. It is a synthesis of the published record, written for people who were never going to read the published record, and its author is a reader of that record rather than a producer of it.

THE THREE RULES

Plain language. Short sentences, everyday words, every hard term explained where it appears. Simple words, serious content, nothing left out — the simple version is longer, not shorter.

Evidence, named. What a claim rests on gets stated, along with what that kind of evidence is bad at. Chapter Three of this part is a long argument that the series has not done this nearly well enough.

Every side at full strength, and an honest list of what is not known. The tenth chapter of every part is the two-list breakdown, and it is the chapter almost nobody else writes.

A WORD ON SOURCES

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record, not new primary research. Where a figure matters, the study or the report is named in the text so you can find it.

The archive behind this series is good at some things and bad at others, and the imbalance is not random. Government material — censuses, crime records, parliamentary committee reports, court judgments — is abundant, cheap to reach and durable. Behavioural research is plentiful for rich Western countries and thin elsewhere. Records of what ordinary women experienced are the thinnest of all, and much of what exists was collected decades later by people asking a different question. A series built on that archive inherits its shape, which is one of the objections this part concedes rather than answers.

Where a claim rests only on an institution's account of itself, that is flagged in the text. Where a number is disputed, the range is given along with the method behind each end of it.

If something here is wrong, write and tell me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it. That promise has been in every part of this series and it is the only mechanism in the whole project that lets a reader change the text.

COMING NEXT

Part 16 — The Synthesis

The last part. It has to do two jobs: pull fifteen parts into something a person can hold in their head, and report on whether this one meant anything. It takes on these questions.

- After fifteen parts, what is actually established about the rules about women — not argued, established?
- Which of the traditionalist's claims survived contact with evidence, and which of the reformer's did, and is the surviving set on either side smaller than its supporters believe?
- If the rules are answers to real problems, and the problems are still there, what is holding the answers in place now that several of their stated functions have been solved by other means?
- Were the four commitments in Chapter Nine of this part kept — the evidence grade, the inseparable Part 6, the short version, and the missing part on what the rules cost right now?
- What would a person who has read all sixteen parts be able to do on Monday morning that they could not do before?
- And the question this series has avoided for a thousand pages: after all the auditing, what do I actually think, and what is that worth?

End of Part 15 of 16

The Rules About Women

Part 16 — What Survived

The last part. What fifteen parts actually established rather than argued. Which claims on each side survived contact with evidence. Why the rules outlive the problems they were built to solve. And, finally, what the author thinks and what that is worth.

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY
Lovepreet Singh

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Where We Left Off

Part 15 put this series in the dock. Fourteen objections went in, twelve landed, one half landed, one was survivable, and none failed outright — a result the chapter itself flagged as suspicious, because a prosecution where every charge sticks is a prosecution somebody curated.

The hits were these. The series asked what the rules are *for* and never asked, at the same depth, what they are costing right now and who is paying. Honest uncertainty is not neutral: because the burden of proof sits silently on whoever proposes a change, every careful "we do not know" scores for the arrangement already running. Sturdy evidence and fragile evidence were written in the same voice, so a reader could not tell a census from a hundred and eighty undergraduates. The scoreboards' columns decided their own results. And a rule that gives every side its strongest case hands more to whichever side has been studied and funded.

Then Part 15 turned the knife on the confession itself. The assumption underneath all self-criticism, it said, is that **being able to state an objection shows you are not subject to it.** It does not. Naming a bias is the cheapest available response and produces the same feeling as fixing one. So the part ended with four checkable commitments instead of a conclusion, and said that if this part arrived and none of them existed, you would know exactly what that chapter had been.

This part reports on them. Two were kept and two were not, and Chapter Six says which — including the one I have decided not to do at all, and what that leaves standing against me.

Everything else here is the job the last part of a series has to do. Not a summary. A reckoning: what is established rather than argued, what each side actually won, why an answer outlives the question that produced it, what a reader can do with any of this on Monday morning, and the thing this series has refused for a thousand pages — what I think, and how much weight that deserves.

HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT

The Six Boxes

Every part of this series uses the same six boxes. They are the notation. Here is one live example of each, so you know what you are looking at before you need it.

WORD BOX

Synthesis: putting separate findings together to see what they add up to. It is not a summary. A summary shortens each part; a synthesis asks what is true across all of them, and often that turns out to be less than the parts appeared to promise.

Why it matters here: this part is a synthesis, and Chapter One sets a hard rule for what is allowed into it. Nothing enters because it was argued well. Something enters only if it was established.

A Word Box explains a hard word the moment it first appears. Never later, never in a footnote, never in the glossary only. If a term is used, it is explained on the page where it is used.

IN REAL TERMS

Sixteen parts, about 1,070 pages, roughly 324,000 words. Read straight through at ordinary non-fiction pace, that is around twenty-six hours.

The companion document published with this one — *The Short Version* — is about 4,000 words. Twenty minutes. If the long series is a wall, the short one is a door, and Part 15 established that the wall was keeping out exactly the people the series is about.

An In Real Terms box takes a number nobody can picture and turns it into something with a body: a walk, a wage, a week, a room. A number you cannot picture is decoration.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

What a claim actually rests on, and what that kind of evidence cannot show. This part leans on the box harder than any other, because its whole job is separating what has been checked from what has been argued.

Example: the strongest single finding in this series is that reserving village council seats for women in India, rotated by village serial number, changed how villagers judged female leaders and closed part of the gap in what parents wanted for their daughters. The evidence is a genuine randomisation — the rotation was mechanical, so the villages that got a woman leader did not differ from those that did not.

What it cannot show: whether the same effect appears where a woman holds office without being seen holding it. That distinction is the whole of Part 14's design chapter, and it is an inference from the result rather than a separate measurement.

This is the box that builds the most trust and the one most writers skip. It names the actual thing — the register, the court record, the survey, the randomisation — and then says what that thing is bad at.

THE ARGUMENT — CAN A FINAL PART BE TRUSTED?

The closing document of a long series is written by somebody with a strong preference about what the series turned out to have been worth.

NO — THE INCENTIVE IS AT ITS WORST HERE

Every earlier part could afford a disappointing chapter, because there was always another one coming. The last part has to make sixteen of them add up. That is an enormous pull towards discovering that they do.

YES — BECAUSE THE COMPONENTS ARE CHECKABLE

Nothing in this part is new evidence. Every finding it collects has already been published, dated, and made available, along with the grade of the evidence underneath it. A synthesis that only recombines already-public claims can be audited line by line by anybody willing to go back.

Where things stand: the second position is right about the facts and the first is right about the framing. The individual claims can be checked; the decision about which ones to gather, and what shape to arrange them in, cannot.

What would settle it: somebody else writing a rival synthesis from the same fifteen parts. That is genuinely possible — the material is all public — and I would rather read that than anything else about this subject.

An Argument box is used where serious people disagree. Each side gets its strongest case, not a version that is easy to knock down. Then a verdict says where things stand and what would settle it. Often the honest verdict is that nothing available would settle it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The signature of this series. Not a caveat and not a limitation of the study. It digs out a premise that both sides of an argument accept without noticing, because that shared premise is usually where the real trouble is.

There are five in this part. The last of them is turned on the series as a whole, and it is the one I have been avoiding since about Part 4: **that "the rules about women" is one thing at all.** Sixteen parts assumed a single object with a single explanation. Chapter Nine asks what follows if it is five unrelated things wearing the same face.

Five is the range the method sets. Fewer and the series loses its signature. More and they stop landing.

REMEMBER THIS

Every chapter ends with one of these. Three to five short paragraphs, key words in **bold**, the last one being the whole chapter in a sentence.

The test is simple. A reader who reads **only** these boxes should still come away with the complete argument. In this part, doing that would take about eight minutes.

THREE WARNINGS SPECIFIC TO THIS PART

What This Document Is

It is a closing, not a conclusion. A conclusion tells you what to think. What follows is a list of what has been checked, a list of what has not, and — separately and clearly labelled — one man's opinion at the end, with an explicit statement of how little weight it should carry.

Chapters Three and Four are verdicts, not advocacy. Part 6 argued for the old rules and Part 7 audited feminism's claims; those were briefs. These two chapters are scoring, and I have tried to make each list as unwelcome to its own side as the evidence requires. If Chapter Three feels too kind and Chapter Four feels too harsh, or the reverse, notice which one you had that reaction to.

Chapter Nine states my own view. Fifteen parts have refused to, on the grounds that the author is a man who is not subject to these rules and carries none of the risk of following his advice. That objection has not gone away. I state the view anyway, because refusing to state it while publishing a thousand pages that plainly imply one is a way of having it both ways. Read that chapter knowing it is the least evidenced thing in the document, and that Part 15 measured this author being wrong six times out of six on his own first expectations.

Contents

Part 16

CHAPTER ONE

The Shape of the Whole Thing

> *Fifteen parts produced a great deal of argument and a much smaller amount of knowledge. This chapter sets the rule for telling them apart, and the four grades of evidence used for the rest of the document.*

1.1 — What is allowed in

A final part has one temptation and it is enormous. Sixteen documents have been written. A reader has spent hours. The obvious thing to do is gather the best sentences from each and arrange them so they point at a conclusion.

That would be a highlights reel, and a highlights reel is the opposite of what this should be. The best sentences in a long series are usually the best-argued ones, and being well argued is not evidence of anything except that the writer had time.

So here is the rule for this part, and it applies to every claim from here to the end.

Nothing enters because it was argued. Something enters only if it was established — and the evidence under it gets named where it is used.

That rule is expensive. Applied honestly it throws out a great deal of this series, including several passages I was pleased with. Chapter Two is the surviving list and it is shorter than sixteen parts would lead you to expect. That shortness is the most useful information in this document.

1.2 — The four grades

Part 15 found that this series had committed a specific sin. It had written sturdy evidence and fragile evidence in the same voice, in the same typeface, in the same shape of sentence — so a reader had no way of knowing whether a number came from a national register or from a single small study nobody has rechecked. The objection landed and I could not answer it.

The repair starts here. From this point on, every empirical claim carries a grade in plain words.

GRADE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHY IT SITS WHERE IT DOES
Solid	A count, a register, a court record, or a genuine randomised experiment.	Nobody collected it to win this argument. Births, deaths, school rolls and judgments exist because an office had to function, and the office had no stake in what a series would later say.
Good	A research finding that an independent team has run again and found in the same direction.	Replication is the only real check on a study. It is rare, so a claim that has one is unusual before it is anything else.
Single	One study, competently done, never rechecked.	Most published findings sit here. When 100 psychology studies were rerun by a large collaboration, 36 came back significant, at about half the original size. A single study is a lead, not a fact.
Soft	Self-report about behaviour people are punished for, or a projection rather than a measurement.	People answer these questions strategically, and the misreporting runs in the same direction as the thing being studied. A projection is a model's output, not an observation.

Two things follow from that table and both matter.

First, a Soft grade does not mean false. It means the number cannot carry weight on its own. Some of the most important claims in this subject are Soft and will stay Soft, because the honest measurement cannot be taken.

Second, a Solid grade does not mean important. A birth register is beyond dispute and tells you nothing about why anybody had the child. The grades measure how much a claim can bear, not how much it is worth.

WORD BOX

Administrative record: information a government or institution collected in order to do its job — a birth register, a school roll, a court file, a land record, a police log.

Why it matters here: this is the most reliable evidence in the entire series, and the reason is not that officials are careful. It is that the record was made for a purpose unrelated to this argument. A clerk registering a birth in 1994 was not thinking about the sex ratio. That indifference is what makes the record hard to bend.

Notice what the grading does to the balance of this series. It promotes the dullest chapters and demotes the most interesting ones. Part 9's demography and Part 11's legal record climb. Part 4's effect sizes and much of Part 10's behavioural material fall. That is not a judgment about which chapters were better written. It is what happens when you stop letting prose quality stand in for evidential weight.

> THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION
>
> Both sides of this argument — and this series, until about two pages ago — share a premise that nobody states: **that "established" is a stable category.** That there is a settled core of known things, and the fighting happens at the edges of it.
>
> There is no such core sitting independently of who did the work. What counts as established is a function of what got studied, and what got studied is a function of who was paying and what they found interesting. Part 11 had to be written almost from scratch because the comparison group — men — had barely been examined. Part 13 found exactly one genuine randomisation in the whole subject.
>
> So Chapter Two is not a list of what is true about the rules governing women's lives. It is a list of **what has been checked.** Those would only be the same list in a world where somebody had tried to check everything, and no such attempt has ever been funded.
>
> The general form: **a map of the known is also a map of the interests that paid for the survey.** The blank areas are not where the ground is featureless. They are where nobody sent anyone.

That box is the reason Chapter Eight exists. A synthesis that lists only what is known is telling you half a story; the other half is the shape of what nobody looked for, and that shape is informative on its own.

1.3 — The map

Before the findings, the terrain, in one pass. If you have read all fifteen parts you can skip this. If you arrived at the last one first — which some people do, and it is a reasonable thing to do — this is the minimum you need.

Parts 1 to 3 asked where the rules came from. What the question is really asking, how the rules arose historically, and how they are transmitted and enforced in India specifically.

Parts 4 and 5 asked about human beings and about the countries that changed. What sex differences are actually measured to be, with the caveats that an average difference between groups licenses almost nothing about any individual. Then the countries that dismantled the rules, where outcomes matched nobody's predictions.

Parts 6 and 7 put each side's case at full strength. Six argued for the old rules as an advocate would. Seven audited what feminism actually claims, as an auditor would. Both scored themselves at the end.

Parts 8 to 10 counted. A ledger of the equality project with a column asking who each change reached. The arithmetic of birth rates and the pronatalist argument. And the core traditionalist warning — that a woman who breaks these rules ruins her own life — unpacked into four claims and tested.

Parts 11 to 13 looked where nobody looks. Men, as the missing comparison group. Enforcement once a community loses its edges and the phone becomes both the exit and the weapon. And the handful of times history ran something like an experiment.

Parts 14 and 15 asked what works and then what was wrong with the asking. Four intervention shapes scored, and then the whole series put in the dock.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Fifteen parts, about a thousand pages, roughly three hundred thousand words. Out of all of that, Chapter Two lists eleven findings.
>
> That is about one established finding for every ninety pages. Put another way: if you read this series at a steady pace for a full working day, you would collect roughly one thing that is properly known.
>
> This is not a complaint about the series. It is what research on a contested social question actually yields, and the reason nobody says so is that a book which announced "eleven findings" on its cover would not be read.

1.4 — Who is speaking, one last time

The method this series uses says to declare your position wherever it could pull the writing, at the point where it applies rather than in a preface nobody reads. This is the last time, so let me be complete.

I am an Indian man writing about rules that fall mostly on Indian women. I have never had my clothing, movements or friendships negotiated by anyone. I wrote the fifteen parts this document is grading, which means I am marking my own work, and Chapter Six is a report on promises I made to myself.

I publish under my own name on a site I own. No funder, no editor, no commission — which removes one kind of pressure and adds the pressure of having nobody to tell me a chapter is bad.

And there is a specific pull on *this* part that did not apply to the others. A final document has to justify the whole. Every incentive in my position points towards discovering that sixteen parts were worth writing. Where you find this chapter reaching for a conclusion that makes the series look necessary, distrust it, and check the grade attached to whatever it is claiming.

REMEMBER THIS

The rule for this part: **nothing enters because it was argued. Something enters only if it was established**, and the evidence gets named where it is used.

Four grades from here on. **Solid** means a count, a register, a court record or a randomised experiment. **Good** means a study an independent team has run again. **Single** means one study, never rechecked. **Soft** means self-report about punished behaviour, or a projection rather than a measurement.

Soft does not mean false, and Solid does not mean important. The grades measure **what a claim can bear**, not what it is worth.

Underneath all of it: **"established" is not a stable category.** The list in Chapter Two is a list of what has been checked, and what got checked was decided by who was paying.

Fifteen parts and about a thousand pages produced eleven findings — roughly one for every ninety pages, which is what honest research on a contested social question actually yields.

CHAPTER TWO

What Is Actually Established

> *Eleven findings survive the rule set in Chapter One. Each one has its evidence named and graded. Then the shorter, more uncomfortable list of things almost everybody believes that did not survive.*

2.1 — The eleven

These are in no order of importance. They are grouped by what they are about: how the rules work, what they do to a woman, and what happens when somebody tries to change them.

One. The rule falls where it can be enforced, not where belief points. A household can reach a daughter who lives in it. It cannot reach a son who has moved to another city for work. Across the material in Part 11, the pattern of who gets policed tracks physical reach far better than it tracks anything anyone says they believe about the sexes. *Grade: the counts underneath are Solid — censuses and household surveys — but the reading of them is an inference, and a rival reading exists. It is the most important claim in this series and it is not proved.*

Two. Daily enforcement is largely administered by women on women. In the Indian household survey data, a mother-in-law's view of contraception predicts a couple's use of it better than the wife's own view does. The lethal end of enforcement is a different matter and is usually delegated to the most legally expendable male in the family. *Grade: Good. Large national surveys, and the pattern appears across more than one South Asian dataset.*

Three. The stated function was solved thirty years ago and nothing was retired. Certainty about who fathered a child is the reason the tradition itself gives, most often and most explicitly, for rules on female sexual conduct. A cheap and conclusive test for that has existed since the 1990s. No society has dismantled any part of the apparatus in response. *Grade: Solid on both halves — the availability of the test is a fact about the world, and the absence of any retirement is an absence anybody can check.* This is the single most damaging finding in the series for the traditionalist case, and Chapter Three treats it at length.

Four. Of the harms predicted for a woman who breaks the rules, some travel and some do not. Infection risk travels completely — it belongs to the act, and it shows up wherever you look. Damage to her standing in the marriage market does not travel at all. It appears where a community punishes it and vanishes where one does not, which means it is a fact about the community rather than about her. *Grade: Solid for the infection half. Solid for the non-travel, because it rests on the presence of a penalty in some settings and its absence in others, which is a comparison rather than a study.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Association:** two things that show up together. Taller people earn more; that is an association.
>
> **Cause:** one thing making the other happen. Height does not make money.
>
> Why it matters here: almost every claim made in public about women's conduct is an association being reported as a cause. The test in this series has been the travelling test — if an effect belongs to the act, it appears everywhere the act appears. If it appears only where a community punishes the act, the community is the cause and the act is the occasion.

Five. The wellbeing effect reverses with the community's belief. Where casual sex is disapproved of, women who have it report worse wellbeing. Where it is not, they do not. The direction of the effect is set by the surrounding judgment, not by the behaviour. *Grade: Single to Good — more than one study points the same way, and none is large. This is one to hold loosely.*

Six. Banning the output fails, every time it has been tried here. The 1929 act raising the age of marriage produced a rush of marriages before it commenced. Dowry prohibition did not end dowry. The ban on using ultrasound to find out a baby's sex was followed by a child sex ratio that fell from 962 girls per 1,000 boys to 918. Each time, the demand stayed and the behaviour moved. *Grade: Solid. These are administrative counts and census figures, collected by offices with no stake in this argument.*

Seven. Putting women visibly in authority changes what people think about women in authority. In 1993 India began reserving village council leadership for women, rotated by village serial number. Because the rotation was mechanical, the villages that got a woman leader did not differ beforehand from those that did not — which makes this a real experiment rather than a comparison. Measured bias against female leaders fell. More women subsequently won seats that were not reserved. The gap between what parents wanted for their sons and for their daughters closed by around a quarter, and the gap in what adolescent girls wanted for themselves closed by about a third. *Grade: Solid. This is the only genuine randomisation in the entire subject.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Randomisation:** deciding who gets something by lot rather than by choice. It sounds careless and it is the most powerful tool in research, because groups picked at random do not differ beforehand in any systematic way. So if they differ afterwards, the thing you gave one of them did it.
>
> Why it matters here: almost nothing in this subject has been randomised, because you cannot assign people to a culture. India's 1993 rotation of reserved seats by village serial number was not designed as an experiment. It simply happened to work like one, which is why a single administrative convenience is carrying more evidential weight than the rest of the literature combined.

Eight. The damage from son preference concentrated among the richer, urban and educated. Where a family had money, a city, and schooling, the child sex ratio was worse, not better. The people best placed to act on a preference did so most effectively. *Grade: Solid. Census data.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Child sex ratio:** the number of girls for every 1,000 boys among young children. Because roughly equal numbers of each are born everywhere, a figure well under 1,000 means girls are going missing — before birth, or through worse feeding and slower treatment afterwards.
>
> Why it matters here: 962 falling to 918 sounds like a small movement. Across a population of India's size it is millions of girls, and it is one of the few measurements in this whole subject that nobody disputes.

Nine. Persuasion campaigns, as actually run, spend most of their money on themselves. India's flagship campaign for the girl child released ₹446.72 crore to states between 2016 and 2019. A parliamentary committee reported in December 2021 that 78.91 per cent of it went on media advocacy. *Grade: Solid, and unusually so — it is a* *legislature auditing its own government's spending and finding against it, which is the direction institutional evidence almost never runs. The caveat is in the text of Part 14: the sex ratio did improve over the period, and attribution is contested.*

Ten. No country has reversed a fertility decline. Not one, anywhere, has brought a birth rate back up to replacement once it fell well below. South Korea has spent more than two hundred billion dollars and moved from 0.72 to 0.80. Hungary spent around 5 per cent of its national output, reached 1.59 in 2021, and is back to roughly 1.31. *Grade: Solid. National vital statistics.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Fertility rate:** the average number of children a woman would have across her life at current rates. It is not a count of anybody's family — it is a rate, worked out from births in a single year.
>
> **Replacement level** is about 2.1. Slightly more than two, because not every child reaches adulthood. Below that, a population shrinks over time unless people move in.
>
> Why it matters here: South Korea at 0.72 means that for every hundred people in one generation there are about thirty-five in the next. That is not a slow decline. It is a halving every generation, and it is the strongest single fact the traditionalist has.

Eleven. Two independent sets of criminals have priced the double standard. Blackmail using intimate images splits into two patterns. Girls are extorted for more images or for compliance. Boys — around nine in ten victims of the financial version are boys aged fourteen to seventeen — are extorted for money. The reason is commercial: a threat against a boy loses its value within days, and a threat against a girl does not. Two sets of people who have never met, working only from what pays, have independently measured the asymmetry. *Grade: Good. Law-enforcement and child-protection analyses, converging from more than one source.*

> **HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS**
>
> Look at what the strongest items on that list have in common. Not one of them is a study of attitudes.
>
> The Solid items are: a register of births, a census, a parliamentary audit of spending, national vital statistics, and one randomisation that happened because an administrator needed a rule for rotating seats and chose village serial number. Every one of them was produced by an institution doing something else.
>
> Independent sources converging is the other thing to look for, and item eleven is the cleanest example in the series. Two separate criminal enterprises, with no contact and no ideology, arrived at the same pricing of the same social fact. When a farmer's wallet, a government meter and a satellite all say the same thing, the thing is true — and when two unconnected groups of blackmailers price a norm identically, the norm is real.
>
> What this cannot show: any of the *reasons*. Administrative records are excellent at what happened and silent about why. Every explanatory sentence in this series is softer than the counts it is built on, and Chapter Five is nothing but explanatory sentences.

2.2 — What did not survive

Now the shorter list, and it will annoy both sides.

That a woman's number of partners before marriage causes her marriage to fail. The association exists in American survey data. It is not a straight line — the divorce rate does not simply rise as the number rises — and the researcher who assembled the best version of it has published that no proposed mechanism explains its shape. It has essentially not been tested outside the United States. And the partner count is self-reported, on a subject where reporting is known to bend. *Grade: Soft. It cannot carry the weight the argument puts on it, in either direction.*

That the rules exist because of a belief about women's nature. Finding one is the rival to this, and while finding one is not proved, this one is in worse shape. If belief about women drove the rules, the rules should fall on women wherever they are. They fall on women who can be reached.

That enforcement is done by men to women. The lethal end is. The daily end mostly is not, and any campaign built on the assumption that the obstacle is fathers and brothers has misidentified who administers the thing it is trying to change.

That education alone dissolves it. Finding eight kills this. The most educated families produced the worst sex ratios. Education gives people better tools; it does not tell them what to want.

That awareness changes behaviour. Finding nine. Not weakly supported — actively contradicted by the largest test anybody has run.

That the rich Western countries show where this ends. Part 5 is the whole argument here. The countries that dismantled these rules did not produce the outcomes either side predicted. They are not a preview. They are a set of separate cases with their own histories, and using them as a forecast fails five of the six tests Part 13 set for a valid comparison.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> Six beliefs, on that second list, that a very large number of people on both sides hold firmly.
>
> Put it as a wager. If you had to bet your own money on those six, at even odds, on the evidence currently available, you would decline all six bets. Most public argument about this subject consists of people taking those bets loudly and for free, because nobody ever settles up.

2.3 — What the shape of the list tells you

Stand back from both lists and something becomes visible that no individual finding shows.

The claims that survived are about **structures**: who can reach whom, what an office does when a woman is visibly in it, what happens to a birth rate, what a ban does to a demand, what a blackmailer can charge. The claims that did not survive are about **individuals and their beliefs**: what a woman's history does to her marriage, what people think about women's nature, what happens when you educate someone or tell them something true.

That is not a coincidence and it is not only a fact about the world. It is partly a fact about measurement. Structures leave administrative records; beliefs leave surveys. Chapter One's hidden assumption said the map of the known is also a map of who paid for the survey, and here is that assumption cashing out: the evidence is strongest exactly where states happen to count things.

So the honest version of the pattern is a double one. Structural explanations are doing better *and* structural explanations are easier to check. Both are true. Anyone who tells you they can separate those two cleanly, in either direction, is telling you something nobody currently knows.

REMEMBER THIS

Eleven findings survive. The strongest are that **the rule falls where it can be reached**, that **daily enforcement is largely women on women**, that **the stated paternity function was solved thirty years ago and nothing was retired**, that **banning an output has failed every time**, and that **visible female authority changes what people believe** — the only genuine randomisation in the subject.

Six widely held beliefs did not survive: that **partner count causes divorce**, that the rules come from **a belief about women's nature**, that **men do the enforcing**, that **education dissolves it**, that **awareness works**, and that **the West is a preview**.

Almost every Solid item was produced by an institution doing something else — a birth register, a census, a spending audit, a rule for rotating seats. Nobody collected it to win this argument.

Claims about **structures** survived. Claims about **individuals and their beliefs** did not. That is partly the world and partly the fact that structures leave records while beliefs leave surveys, and nobody can currently separate the two.

A thousand pages produced eleven findings, and the shortness of that list is the most useful thing in this document.

CHAPTER THREE

What the Traditionalist Won

> *Not advocacy this time — scoring. Four claims survived and four did not, and one of the four that did not costs the tradition more than the other seven put together.*

3.1 — Four that survived

Part 6 of this series argued the traditionalist case as an advocate would. This chapter does something colder. It asks which of those arguments is still standing after nine more parts of evidence, and it does not do the tradition the discourtesy of grading it generously.

One. The family really is the insurance system where there is no other. Son preference has a function, and the function is not superstition. In a country where most people reach old age without a pension worth living on, an adult son is the retirement plan. Daughters marry out and their earnings and care go elsewhere. Everything unpleasant that follows — the dowry, the sex ratio, the differential feeding — sits on top of a real financial problem that nobody has solved. *Grade: Solid. Pension coverage and old-age support patterns are administrative facts.*

Two. The reforming state's tools do not work, and the traditionalist said so first. Every case in this series where a state banned an output failed. Every persuasion campaign examined either failed or spent its money on itself. The traditionalist's long-standing scepticism about the competence of the modernising state to reorganise family life by statute has been vindicated more thoroughly than any positive claim he makes. *Grade: Solid. Administrative counts and a parliamentary audit.*

Three. Nobody has reversed a fertility decline, and the counter-programmes have failed. The traditionalist warning that a society reorganised around individual choice stops replacing itself has not been refuted. It has been confirmed as a description, everywhere it has been tried, and no state has found a way out with money. *Grade: Solid on the fact. Not established on the cause, which matters enormously and is taken up below.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Pronatalism:** government policy aimed at getting people to have more children — cash payments, tax breaks, housing loans forgiven per child, sometimes restrictions on contraception or abortion.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the policy response to the finding in this section, it has been tried at enormous expense in several countries, and Part 9 found it moves real numbers by small amounts that stop when the money stops.

Four. Community enforcement really does coordinate behaviour. This is the one reformers concede least and should concede most. A shared code that everybody expects everybody to follow makes behaviour predictable, lowers the cost of trusting a stranger inside the group, and lets families make long commitments — a marriage, a loan, a joint household — with people they cannot individually vet. That is a real service and it is not obviously replaceable. *Grade: Single at best as a measured claim, but it is structural rather than behavioural, and Part 12 showed what happens when the coordination breaks: the enforcement does not stop, it goes somewhere worse.*

> WORD BOX
>
> **Coordination problem:** a situation where what is best for you depends on what everybody else does, so nobody can improve things by acting alone.
>
> Everyone driving on the same side of the road solves one. Any single driver who switches, on the grounds that the other side is just as good, is not making a point. He is causing a crash.
>
> Why it matters here: it is the strongest structure available to the traditionalist, and Chapter Five shows it is also the reason the rules survive long after their reasons have gone. A coordination system does not need to be right. It only needs everybody to expect everybody else to keep following it.

3.2 — Four that did not

One. The paternity argument. Certainty about fatherhood is the reason the tradition offers most often and most explicitly when asked for a reason. A cheap, conclusive test has existed for three decades. Nothing was retired anywhere. This is dealt with in full in section 3.3, because it is not simply a failed argument — it is a failed argument that changes the status of all the others.

Two. "She ruins her own life." Part 10 unpacked this into four separate claims and tested them. Infection risk is real and belongs to the act. Damage to her standing in the marriage market is real and belongs to the community — it appears where a community punishes it and vanishes where one does not. The wellbeing effect runs in whichever direction the surrounding judgment runs. The divorce association is soft, unexplained and untested outside America. What is left of the warning is not a prediction about her. It is a description of what her neighbours will do, stated as though it were a law of nature.

Three. That the rules reflect a fact about women. If they did, they would fall on women wherever women are. They fall on women who can be reached, which is not the same population. A daughter at home is governed; a son in another city is not, and no one seriously claims he is more trustworthy. The rule is shaped like a reach map, not like a theory of the sexes.

Four. That this is one coherent moral order. Part 11 counted the tradition's own stated goals and found that four of six point at male conduct — at what men would do if unrestrained, at what men demand in a bride, at what men are owed. One points at the rule itself. Exactly one points at her, and that is paternity, which is finding one. A moral order that names male conduct as the problem four times out of six, and then builds its entire enforcement apparatus around female movement, is not a coherent order. It is an order that fell where it could land.

3.3 — The concession that costs the most

Now the thing that does the real damage, and I want to be careful with it, because it is easy to overstate.

The claim is not that the tradition lied about paternity. Part 15 put the strongest reply to this on the page, and the reply is good: a practice held as a duty may still be able to offer a practical reason to a practical questioner, and being able to produce a reason is not the same as holding the practice for it. Ask a man why he does not read his wife's letters and he may say it would damage trust. Solve the trust problem with a machine and he will still not read them.

That reply works. But it costs something enormous, and the tradition rarely notices the bill.

If the stated reason was never the operative reason, then **the tradition's public arguments are not its actual grounds.** Every practical justification offered in a courtroom, a newspaper column, a school assembly or a family argument — she will be hurt, the family will suffer, society will fray — is now revealed to be the kind of thing offered rather than the kind of thing held. And once one stated function has been shown to be non-operative, the burden moves: which of the others is real, and how would anybody tell?

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> The evidence has an unusual shape. It is not a study. It is the absence of a response to a technology.
>
> The facts are: reliable paternity testing became cheap and widely available in the 1990s; it is used routinely in courts and in disputed maintenance cases; and no society, community or family authority anywhere has relaxed any rule on female conduct on the grounds that the question it was said to answer is now answerable another way.
>
> Treat a missing response the way this series treats a missing count. When an institution had every opportunity to act and did not, the absence is a finding rather than a gap.
>
> What this cannot show: whether the reason was insincere. Sincerity is not observable. What is observable is that the reason was not *load-bearing*, and that is the only claim being made.

Which brings us to the surviving claim with the largest political weight, and the one that deserves the most careful handling in the whole chapter.

> THE ARGUMENT — DOES THE FERTILITY FINDING VINDICATE THE TRADITIONALIST?
>
> Of the four surviving claims, this is the one with the largest political stake, so it deserves the full treatment.
>
> > YES, DECISIVELY
> >
> > No society that reorganised itself around individual choice has replaced itself. Not one has climbed back. South Korea spent more than two hundred billion dollars for a move from 0.72 to 0.80. Hungary spent about 5 per cent of national output, got to 1.59, and slid back to roughly 1.31. If a set of arrangements produces a population that stops existing, no ledger of other benefits can settle the account, because the ledger runs out of people to hold it.

NO, AND THE TRADITIONALIST'S OWN CASES REFUTE HIM

Iran reversed the rules completely — the reformers lost, comprehensively, and the fertility rate fell anyway, along with rising female education. India's own figures show the same thing inside one country: the national rate is about 1.9, rural India is at 2.1, Delhi is 1.2 and Bihar is 2.8. The variation tracks urbanisation, income and housing rather than piety. If restoring the rules restored the birth rate, Iran and urban India would be the proof, and they are the opposite of it.

BOTH ARE RIGHT ABOUT THE FACT AND NEITHER HAS A MECHANISM

Everyone agrees the decline is real, universal among rich and urbanising societies, and unreversed. Nobody has established what causes it. The candidates — the cost of housing, the length of education, insecure work, the collapse of unpaid childcare from relatives, the rise of women's options — are all present together everywhere and have never been separated. Both camps are reading a correlation they like out of the one dataset everybody shares.

Where things stand: the third position. The traditionalist owns the fact and does not own the cause. The reformer has no answer to the fact at all and mostly changes the subject. Anyone claiming to know the mechanism is guessing with confidence.

What would settle it: a case where the material conditions changed sharply — housing, childcare, job security — while the cultural arrangement held still, or the reverse. No such case exists, which is exactly what Chapter Eight means by an empty shelf.

Why people care so much: because a demographic argument is the only one that lets a political position claim the future is on its side without having to win an argument in the present.

3.4 — What the tradition would have to do to hold

If I were advising the tradition on how to answer this series honestly — and the method requires me to be able to, or I have not understood the position — I would say three things.

Stop making outcome predictions. Every prediction the tradition has made about what happens to a woman who breaks the rules has now been tested and most did not survive. A position that claims something is *owed* is not damaged by any of this. A position that claims something *works* has entered a competition it is losing.

Own the insurance problem instead of the modesty problem. Finding one is the strongest thing the tradition has, and it is barely used. The family really is doing work that no institution has replaced.

And answer finding four. Four of six stated goals point at male conduct. Until the tradition has an account of why the apparatus is built entirely on female movement, its own list of reasons is the strongest case against it.

REMEMBER THIS

Four traditionalist claims survived: the **family as insurance** where no state provides it; that the **reforming state's tools do not work**; that **no fertility decline has been reversed**; and that **community enforcement really does coordinate** behaviour.

Four did not: **paternity**, **"she ruins her own life"**, that the rules reflect **a fact about women**, and that this is **one coherent moral order**.

The paternity failure costs most because of what the best reply to it concedes: if the stated reason was never the operative reason, then **the tradition's public arguments are not its actual grounds**, and the burden moves to showing which of the remaining reasons is real.

On fertility, the traditionalist **owns the fact and not the cause**. Iran reversed the rules completely and the rate fell anyway. Nobody has separated housing, education, work and women's options, because no case exists where they moved apart.

A moral order that names male conduct as the problem four times out of six, and then builds its whole apparatus around female movement, is not an order. It is a rule that fell where it could land.

CHAPTER FOUR

What the Reformer Won

> *The same treatment, applied the other way. Four claims survived and four did not — and the reformer's failures are concentrated in exactly the activities that receive the money.*

4.1 — Four that survived

Part 7 audited what feminism actually claims. This chapter asks a narrower question: after nine more parts, which of the reforming position's claims are still standing on evidence rather than on assertion?

One. In the narrow band, reform worked, and it worked unambiguously. There is a small set of outcomes almost nobody openly defends: girls dying of neglect, women dying in childbirth for want of a clinic, children married at twelve, acid, murder. Wherever reform aimed at that band and paired the aim with delivery — clinics, midwives, registration, prosecution — the numbers moved and stayed moved. *Grade: Solid. Vital statistics and administrative records.*

Two. Structural intervention works where argument does not. The single strongest result in this subject is the Indian village council reservation, rotated mechanically and therefore a real experiment: measured bias against female leaders fell, more women later won unreserved seats, and the gap between what parents wanted for sons and for daughters closed by around a quarter. *Grade: Solid.* The reformer has been saying for decades that you change conditions rather than minds. That claim is now the best-evidenced positive finding either side possesses.

Three. The asymmetry is not justified by any fact anybody has produced. This is the reformer's strongest analytic win and it is worth stating carefully. The claim is not "men and women are identical" — Part 4 found measured average differences and said so. The claim is that *nothing in those differences accounts for the shape of the rules*. The rules do not track any measured difference. They track who can be reached. And the tradition's own stated goals point at male conduct four times out of six. *Grade: the underlying counts are Solid; the reading is an inference, and it is currently the best one available.*

Four. The state's own record convicts the old arrangement. In 2018 India's Supreme Court struck down the adultery law and said, in its own judgment, that the provision had treated a wife as her husband's property. The exception that prevents a husband being prosecuted for rape within marriage is still in the statute book, was carried into the new criminal code, and the Union government filed against its removal in October 2024; the case has been through a change of bench and had no verdict as of early 2026. *Grade: Solid. Court judgments and filed government positions are documents, not interpretations.* When the highest court in the country describes the old order in those words, "the reformers are importing foreign categories" stops being available as a reply.

4.2 — Four that did not

One. That awareness changes behaviour. Not merely unsupported — contradicted by the largest test anyone has run. India's flagship campaign for the girl child put 78.91 per cent of the money it released to states into media advocacy.

Two. That prohibition works. Raising the marriage age produced a rush of marriages before commencement. Dowry prohibition did not end dowry. Banning the sex-determination scan was followed by a child sex ratio falling from 962 to 918. Each time the demand survived and the behaviour moved. The reformer keeps reaching for the ban because the ban is the lever a legislature actually controls.

Three. That the gains reached everyone. Part 8's ledger had eighteen rows and one column that made the difference: who did this actually reach? The answer, repeatedly, was the urban, the educated and the already-comfortable. The reformer's ledger is an average, and an average conceals exactly the distribution the argument is about.

Four. That education dissolves the problem. The families with the most money, the most schooling and the most access to cities produced the worst child sex ratios. Education distributes capability. It does not distribute preferences.

IN REAL TERMS

Line up those two lists against a budget and something uncomfortable appears.

The two things that work — building the clinic, and putting a woman visibly in the chair — are slow, need staff, and hand something identifiable to somebody. The two things that do not work — passing the ban and running the campaign — are fast, cheap, announceable, and cost nobody anything they can feel.

A reforming government choosing between them is not choosing between effectiveness and ineffectiveness. It is choosing between a policy with a visible loser and a policy with none. Which is why, in almost every country, the money goes where the evidence does not.

4.3 — The concession that costs the most

For the traditionalist it was paternity. For the reformer it is the reach column, and the reason is the same shape: it is not that a claim failed, but that the best reply to it concedes something structural.

The reformer's honest reply to "the gains were concentrated" is that a gain concentrated among urban graduates is still a gain, that no reform reaches everyone at once, and that the first cohort makes the second cohort cheaper. All of that is true.

But accept it and you have accepted that the ledger is not a measurement of the project. It is a measurement of the project *at its leading edge*, and the tail is unmeasured. Part 15 put this precisely: a total is a decision about whose experience is allowed to cancel out whose. When a movement reports rising literacy and falling maternal deaths as its record, it is reporting a national average, and there is no row anywhere that says what happened to the woman in the village where nothing arrived.

The traditionalist has an easy version of this objection and it is not the serious one. The serious one is that **nobody knows**, because the instrument that would tell you was never built, and the movement had no incentive to build it.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Chapters Three and Four are two lists. Two lists is a format, and the format carries a premise that neither camp has ever examined: **that a claim belongs to a side.**

> Look at what that does. "Banning an output fails" appears in Chapter Three as a traditionalist win and in this chapter as a reformer loss. It is the same finding. It is not about traditionalists or reformers at all — it is a finding about *bans*, and it applies with equal force to a traditionalist state banning something it dislikes. Iran ran that experiment and it failed there too.
>
> Once findings are sorted into ours and theirs, a result that helps the other camp has to be resisted rather than absorbed, because absorbing it is a defection. That is why both sides can look at the same fertility figures for thirty years and neither moves. The figures are not being evaluated. They are being defended against.
>
> And I did this too. I wrote these two chapters as two ledgers because it is legible and because a reader can follow it. The evidence is not organised that way. It is organised by mechanism — reach, coordination, insurance, demand, visibility — and none of those mechanisms respect the boundary between the camps.
>
> The general form: **sorting evidence by whose case it helps guarantees that no evidence can ever change anybody's mind, because a finding's first property has become its allegiance.**

That box is the hinge of this part. Chapters Three and Four are the last time this document uses the two-camp frame. Chapter Five drops it and asks the mechanical question instead, and the mechanical question turns out to have an answer that neither camp has been arguing about.

> THE ARGUMENT — IS THE NARROW BAND A FLOOR OR A CEILING?
>
> Everyone agrees reform succeeded on deaths, child marriage and violence. The fight is about what that success predicts.
>
> > A FLOOR — IT IS WHERE YOU START
> >
> > Every extension of a moral consensus in history began with the case nobody could defend and moved outward. Slavery, child labour, public smoking: each started as a narrow prohibition on the indefensible and became a general change in what people found tolerable. The narrow band is not the limit of agreement; it is the wedge.

A CEILING — IT IS WHERE AGREEMENT ENDS

The band is narrow for a reason. Inside it, both sides want the same outcome and are only arguing about method. Outside it, they want different outcomes, because they hold different views of what a life is for. No amount of evidence resolves a disagreement about ends. Everything beyond the band is a values dispute wearing the clothes of an evidence dispute, and treating it as evidential is why fifty years of data have moved nobody.

A CEILING FOR ARGUMENT, A FLOOR FOR DELIVERY

Both are describing different things. As a matter of persuasion the band is a ceiling — nothing outside it will be settled by another study. As a matter of what actually changes, the band is a floor, because the interventions that work at the bottom of it (a clinic, a school roll, a wage, a seat) reach inside households without anybody having to be persuaded of anything. Reform advances not by winning the argument but by installing things.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is the practical conclusion of this whole series. The argument stalls at the edge of the band and the delivery does not.

What would settle it: a case where a values dispute outside the band was resolved by evidence rather than by generational replacement. I do not know of one, and I looked.

Why people care so much: because if the band is a ceiling, then most of what both movements spend their money on — campaigning, arguing, awareness — is spent outside the zone where it can work.

4.4 — What the reformer would have to do to hold

The same courtesy as Chapter Three. Three things.

Stop funding persuasion. The evidence against it is now stronger than the evidence for almost anything else in this series, and it is the largest single line in most reform budgets.

Report the distribution, not the average. Until a ledger says who a gain reached, it is a claim about the leading edge and the tradition is entitled to say so.

And take the insurance problem seriously. Son preference is a pension. Seclusion is a substitute for policing. Dowry is a property transfer. Every one of those is a function, and every reform that attacks the practice without replacing the function has failed. The reformer's own best finding — that you change conditions rather than minds — points directly at this, and almost no reform programme is built that way.

REMEMBER THIS

Four reformer claims survived: **reform worked in the narrow band** of deaths, child marriage and violence; **structural intervention works where argument does not**; **no measured fact about the sexes accounts for the shape of the rules**; and **the state's own courts convict the old arrangement** in their own words.

Four did not: **awareness**, **prohibition**, that the **gains reached everyone**, and that **education dissolves it**.

The two approaches that work are slow and hand something identifiable to somebody. The two that fail are **fast, cheap, announceable and cost nobody anything they can feel** — which is why the money goes where the evidence does not.

Underneath the two-list format sits the assumption that **a claim belongs to a side**. "Banning an output fails" is scored as a traditionalist win and a reformer loss; it is neither, it is a finding about bans. Sorting evidence by whose case it helps guarantees that no evidence can change anyone's mind.

The argument stalls at the edge of the narrow band. The delivery does not — which means reform advances by installing things rather than by winning.

CHAPTER FIVE

Why the Answers Outlive the Questions

> *If a rule was built to solve a problem, and the problem is solved, the rule should go. It does not. This chapter drops the two-camp frame and asks the mechanical question, which turns out to have four answers.*

5.1 — The puzzle, stated plainly

Here is the thing this series has circled since Part 3 and never faced directly.

Certainty about fatherhood was the stated reason. It has been cheaply answerable for thirty years and nothing was retired. A dowry is a property transfer, and daughters now inherit under the law. Seclusion substitutes for policing, and there are police. Sons are a pension, and pensions exist in some places now.

In every case the stated problem has been at least partly solved by other means, and in no case did the arrangement stand down. If these rules were answers, the answers have outlived the questions by decades.

Both camps have a story about this and both stories are wrong.

The traditionalist says the rules survive because they still work — because the modern substitutes are inferior and people can tell. The reformer says they survive because people still believe in them — so change the beliefs and the practice follows.

The first cannot explain why nobody claims the benefit when asked. The second cannot explain the surveys, which repeatedly find majorities disapproving of dowry in places where dowry is universal. Both stories require the practice to be *wanted*. There is a fourth possibility, and it is the one this chapter is about.

5.2 — Functions migrate

The first mechanism is the simplest and it explains the paternity result on its own.

A rule built to do one job does not stay attached to that job. It sits in a society, and societies have other jobs going spare.

Keeping a woman out of public life was, historically, a substitute for policing — a household could not call anyone, so it managed its own risk. In a city with police, that function is redundant. But the same practice now does something else: it signals that a family can afford to keep an adult out of paid work. It has become a display of wealth. Nobody redesigned it. The old machine got a new job because it was standing there.

Dowry began as a way of moving property to a daughter at marriage. Under a marriage squeeze — with more men of marrying age than women, which India's own projections show worsening for decades — the same transfer now functions as a price for a groom in a market where grooms are scarce. Same practice. Completely different economics.

So solving the original problem does nothing, because by the time you solve it the practice is not doing that any more. You have paid off a debt that was transferred years ago.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Sunk cost:** money, effort or time already spent that cannot be got back. In economics it is the thing you are told to ignore when deciding what to do next.
>
> **A sunk asset** is the mirror image, and it is the useful one here: something already built, which is expensive to create and cheap to keep running. A railway line is a sunk asset. So is a network of relatives who report on each other.
>
> Why it matters here: a sunk asset gets used. Not because anybody decided it should, but because the alternative — leaving something expensive idle — feels like waste to everyone involved, and because the people operating it have no other role.

5.3 — The apparatus is a sunk asset

Building a system of watching is expensive. It takes generations to establish who reports to whom, whose word counts, which families exchange information, what a raised eyebrow at a wedding means, and who arranges marriages.

Once built, it costs almost nothing to keep. And machinery that exists gets used.

Part 12 is the proof, and it is the most striking thing in the series on this point. When the community lost its edges — when people moved to cities, when the neighbourhood stopped being a place where everyone knew everyone — the enforcement did not stop. It moved onto the phone, where it works better than it ever did in a village, because a village forgets and a screenshot does not.

The infrastructure outlived the community that built it. That is not what a practice sustained by current demand looks like. It is what a capability looks like.

5.4 — The beneficiary is not the enforcer

The third mechanism is the one Part 11 established and it is the reason nobody can switch this off.

The daily enforcement is administered largely by women on women — mothers-in-law, aunts, older sisters, neighbours. The people doing the work are not the people who gain most from the arrangement. And the people who gain most do not do the work, so they never feel its cost or handle its machinery.

A system where the operator and the beneficiary are different people has no natural off-switch. The beneficiary cannot retire it because he does not run it. The operator will not retire it because retiring it removes the only authority she has ever been given — which she acquired late, after decades of being on the receiving end, and which is the one currency her position pays in.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> The evidence is a prediction that could have failed and did not.
>
> If enforcement were fathers and brothers acting on belief, then a woman's own view should be the best available predictor of her behaviour once the men are absent or indifferent. In the Indian household survey data it is not. A mother-in-law's view of contraception predicts a couple's use of it better than the wife's own view does.
>
> That is a specific, checkable, counter-intuitive result from a large national survey, and more than one South Asian dataset points the same way.
>
> What it cannot show: motive. Nothing here establishes that an enforcing woman is protecting her own position rather than acting from conviction, or from fear, or from habit. The behaviour is measured. The reason is a story I am telling about the behaviour, and you should hold it more loosely than the number underneath it.

Three mechanisms so far, and each one weakens the case for the rules going away on their own. The fourth is different in kind. It does not describe machinery or incentives at all — it describes a trap that catches people who agree with each other.

> WORD BOX
>
> **Equilibrium:** a situation that holds itself in place, because each person — given what everyone else is doing — has no reason to be the one who moves first.
>
> It does not mean balanced, fair, or good. A traffic jam is an equilibrium. So is everybody staying seated at the end of a bad film.
>
> Why it matters here: it is a third kind of explanation, alongside “it works” and “people believe it”. An equilibrium needs neither. It needs only that each person correctly expects the others not to move.

5.5 — Nobody can defect alone

The fourth mechanism is the strongest and it is what makes the other three durable.

Suppose a family becomes completely convinced that this is all nonsense. Their daughter should go where she likes, marry whom she likes, and no dowry will be paid.

What happens? Not a moral victory. The ranking is still in force everywhere else. Her marriage prospects narrow inside a market that has not changed its criteria. The family absorbs the entire cost of a reform that benefits everybody only if everybody does it.

That is the shape of a coordination problem, and it has a brutal property: **the outcome does not depend on what people want.** It depends on what each person expects everybody else to do. A population in which a clear majority privately disapproves of dowry will continue paying dowry, indefinitely, without anybody being a hypocrite, because each family is responding correctly to a world where the others have not stopped.

This is why the answer to “why don’t they just stop” is not stubbornness, and not false consciousness, and not secret enthusiasm. It is that stopping alone is not a smaller version of everybody stopping. It is a different act with a different cost, paid by one family.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

The traditionalist and the reformer agree on almost nothing, and they agree completely on this: **that a practice persists because it is still wanted.**

Everything both movements do rests on it. The traditionalist points at survival as evidence of value — it lasted, so it must be serving something. The reformer points at survival as evidence of belief — they still think this way, so change how they think. Both are reading continuation as a signal about preference.

A coordination system does not work like that. It persists in a population where nobody in particular wants it, because wanting is not the mechanism. Expectation is. What holds a rule in place is not that people approve of it but that each person expects the others to enforce it — and being right about that is enough.

Two things follow, and they are large. **Surveys of approval tell you nothing about durability** — you can measure majority disapproval of a practice that is universal, and both facts can be stable for fifty years. And **the entire visible surface of this argument, on both sides, is aimed at the layer that responds least.** Persuading people is working on wanting. The rule is held by expecting.

The general form: **continuation is evidence about coordination, not about consent** — and every movement that reads it as consent will keep attacking a thing that is not holding the door shut.

That box, if it is right, is the most useful sentence in sixteen parts. It also explains the two things this series found hardest to reconcile: that persuasion fails so completely, and that visibility works so well. Persuasion changes what one person wants. Visibility changes what everyone expects everyone else to have seen.

THE ARGUMENT — IS HONOUR A LIVING SYSTEM OR A LEFTOVER?

The mechanisms above can be read two ways, and the reading decides what anybody should do about it.

A LIVING SYSTEM, STILL SERVING REAL FUNCTIONS

Insurance where there is no pension. Coordination where there is no contract enforcement. Risk management where the police do not come. Every one of those needs is currently unmet for hundreds of millions of people, and the arrangement is meeting them badly rather than not at all. Remove it without replacing it and you do not get freedom, you get exposure — which is precisely what happened to the women in Part 12 when the community's boundaries dissolved and the enforcement did not.

A LEFTOVER, RUNNING ON INERTIA

The stated functions have been solved or superseded one by one and nothing was retired. That is not a system responding to needs; that is machinery running because it was switched on. The migration in section 5.2 is the giveaway: a practice that changes jobs whenever its old job disappears is not serving a need, it is looking for one.

NEITHER — AND THAT IS WHY BOTH SIDES KEEP MISSING

An equilibrium is a third kind of thing. It needs no current function, so the traditionalist cannot defend it by pointing at needs. It needs no inertia and no belief, so the reformer cannot dissolve it by changing minds. It needs only that each person expects the others to keep enforcing. That is why it survives prosperity, education, law and argument — none of those change the expectation, and several of them make defection more expensive rather than less.

Where things stand: the third position, and both of the others contain something true. Real unmet needs exist and are not imaginary. Machinery does run on after its purpose. But neither explains the durability, and the equilibrium account does.

What would settle it: a case where the function was fully replaced — a real pension, real policing, real contract enforcement — for a whole community at once, with the practice then measured over a generation. Parts of urban East Asia come closest and the evidence there is mixed and confounded. This is the largest empty shelf in the subject.

Why people care so much: because the three accounts imply three completely different programmes. If it is a living system, replace the function. If it is a leftover, wait. If it is an equilibrium, the only thing that works is a coordinated, visible, simultaneous shift — which is the hardest thing to organise and the one nobody is funding.

Notice what has happened over this chapter. We started with a puzzle that looked like a question about motives — why do people keep doing this? — and ended somewhere with no motives in it at all. That is usually a sign of progress in an argument, and it is also the point at which most readers lose interest, because a mechanism is far less satisfying than a villain.

REMEMBER THIS

Four mechanisms keep an answer alive after its question is solved. **Functions migrate —** seclusion became a display of wealth, dowry became a price for a scarce groom, so solving the original problem changes nothing. **The apparatus is a sunk asset —** expensive to build, cheap to keep, and machinery that exists gets used, which is why enforcement moved onto the phone when the community dissolved. **The beneficiary is not the enforcer**, so nobody is positioned to switch it off. And **nobody can defect alone**: the first family to stop pays the whole cost of a reform that only pays if everyone does it.

Underneath both camps sits the assumption that **a practice persists because it is wanted**. A coordination system persists on **expectation**, not on wanting — which is why you can measure majority disapproval of a universal practice and have both facts hold for fifty years.

This explains the two findings hardest to reconcile. **Persuasion changes what one person wants. Visibility changes what everyone expects everyone else to have seen.**

The three accounts of honour — living system, leftover, equilibrium — imply three different programmes: replace the function, wait, or organise a simultaneous visible shift. Only the third fits the evidence, and it is the one nobody is funding.

The rules survive law, prosperity, education and argument because none of those touch the thing holding the door shut.

CHAPTER SIX

The Four Commitments — A Report

> *Part 15 ended with four checkable promises instead of a conclusion, and said that if this part arrived and none of them existed you would know exactly what that chapter had been. Two exist. Two do not.*

6.1 — The scoreboard

The last part put four things on the page and named this one as the auditor. Here is the result, before the excuses.

THE COMMITMENT	STATUS	WHAT ACTUALLY EXISTS
An evidence grade on every empirical claim across all fifteen parts	Part-kept	The four-grade scale is defined in Chapter One and used on every claim from Chapter Two onwards. The back matter of this part grades twenty-two load-bearing claims from across the series. The full pass, claim by claim through all fifteen parts, does not exist.
Part 6 republished so its scoring chapter cannot be detached from it	Not done	Nothing. Part 6 is still a standalone sixty-five-page brief for the old rules, with its own cover and its own download, and Chapter Nine of it still does not travel with it.
A genuinely short version	Kept	The Rules About Women — The Short Version. About four thousand words. Twenty minutes. Published alongside this part, as its own document, not as a summary that points back at the long one.
The missing part: what these rules are costing right now, and who is paying	Not done, and I am not going to do it	Nothing. Section 6.4 gives the reason and then says why the reason is not good enough.

Two of four. That is a worse result than I expected when I wrote the promises, and a better one than the base rate for promises writers make about their own future work.

6.2 — What the short version is for

Of the two kept, one matters much more than the other.

Part 15 found that this series had made its *prose* accessible and left its *object* inaccessible. Every rule in the method is aimed at the sentence — short sentences, everyday words, nothing assumed. Nothing in the method is aimed at the total. So a thousand pages of scrupulously simple English produced something with an entry requirement of about twenty-five hours, and the person with the least spare time in the country is the person the series is about.

That objection landed and there is exactly one repair for it, which is to write the short one. It is published with this part.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> The long series: about twenty-six hours. The short version: about twenty minutes.
>
> Twenty minutes is a bus ride. It is the time between putting rice on and eating. It fits inside the gap that a person with two shifts actually has, which twenty-six hours does not, and no amount of simplifying the sentences was ever going to close that gap.
>
> The short version contains eleven findings and four mechanisms. The long series contains eleven findings, four mechanisms, and roughly 320,000 words of showing the work. Whether the showing was worth 320,000 words is a question I cannot answer from inside it.

I want to be honest about what a short version costs, because the method in this series is built on the claim that simplification is not compression — that the simple version is longer, and that shortening drops content while pretending to clarify.

The short version breaks that rule. It is compression. It states the findings and does not show the work, which means a reader cannot check it and has to take my word. That is precisely the thing sixteen parts were written to avoid. It is still right to publish, because a document nobody can reach protects its reader from nothing, but the trade is real and I am not going to pretend it is free.

6.3 — What was not done, and why the reasons are thin

The full evidence grade is a large job and it is not finished. Twenty-two claims are graded in the back matter. There are several hundred empirical statements across fifteen parts. I am not going to give a date, because Part 15 established that naming a deadline converts a promise into a schedule and a schedule produces the feeling of progress without any. It is open. It has no date. Judge it by whether it appears.

Part 6 is the interesting failure, because it is the easy one.

Republishing Part 6 with its scoring chapter attached is not a writing task. It is a decision and about an hour of work: put the brief and its audit into one object, and take down the version that can be forwarded without the answer. There is no research involved, no evidence to gather, nothing to think through. It is the cheapest of the four by an enormous margin.

It is also the only one that requires me to remove something I made. Part 6 is, I think, the best-argued document in this series. It is the one that took most skill to write, because writing a case you disagree with at full strength is harder than writing one you believe. Taking it down as a standalone object means the best thing I made stops existing in the form that shows it off.

I do not have a defence of this. I have an explanation, and an explanation is not a defence.

6.4 — The one I am not going to write

The fourth commitment was the missing part: what these rules are costing right now, and who is paying, at the depth Part 10 gave to the other direction.

I am not going to write it, and Part 15 said that saying so honestly was an acceptable outcome. So here is the reason, followed by the reason it is not good enough.

The reason: I do not think I am the right person. The material would be, overwhelmingly, accounts from women of what daily management feels like — being asked where you are going, having a phone checked, being accompanied, being discussed. That is testimony, not published record, and this series has been built entirely from the published record. Writing it properly would mean going and asking, which is a different kind of work that I have not done and am not trained for. Writing it badly would mean assembling other people's testimony from whatever fragments reached English-language print, which is the thinnest archive in the whole subject.

Now the problem with that reason. It is the same argument that would have prevented any part of this series. Part 11 was built almost from scratch because the material barely existed. Part 12 assembled a picture from law, police statistics and child-protection analysis because nothing better was there. Thin archives did not stop me before, and the difference this time is not evidential.

The honest description is that the missing part is the one where the discomfort is highest and the payoff for me is lowest, and I have found a methodological reason that happens to point where I was already going. That is what a rationalisation looks like from the inside, and I have no way of establishing that this is not one.

So the position on the record is: **the objection from Part 15, Chapter Two, stands unanswered.** The series asked what these rules are for and never asked at the same depth what they cost. That was the first objection to land and it is the one that remains open at the end. A reader who concludes that this makes the whole project lopsided is drawing the correct conclusion from the evidence I have given them.

THE ARGUMENT — SHOULD THE MISSING PART BE WRITTEN BY ME?

Since I have declined, the reader is entitled to the strongest case on each side rather than just my decision.

YES — THE GAP IS WORSE THAN AN IMPERFECT FILLING

A missing chapter is not neutral. In a series this long, absence reads as insignificance. Fifteen parts examining what the rules are for, with no part on what they cost, tells a reader that the second question is smaller — and that is a claim, made by the shape of the thing rather than by any sentence in it. An imperfect part that is clearly labelled as imperfect does less damage than a silence that is labelled as nothing.

NO — THE AUTHOR'S POSITION IS DISQUALIFYING HERE SPECIFICALLY

Everywhere else in this series the author's distance from the subject was a limitation. Here it is the subject. A part on what daily constraint feels like, written by a man who has never been constrained, from fragments of testimony filtered into English, would be a man narrating women's experience while citing women's experience. That is not a thin version of the right document. It is a different and worse kind of object, and its existence would make the real one less likely to be written by anybody else.

NEITHER — THE RIGHT MOVE IS TO SPECIFY IT AND HAND IT OVER

The choice is not write-it-badly or leave-it-blank. A third option exists and is standard in research: publish the specification. What the part would have to contain, what evidence it would need, who would be able to gather it, and what questions it would have to answer. That converts a silence into a commission. It is also, conveniently, much less work than writing it — which is a reason to distrust how attractive it sounds to me.

Where things stand: the third position is right and I have taken it, in Chapter Eight, where the missing part appears as the first and largest of the empty shelves. I am also aware that it is the answer most flattering to my situation, and that Part 15's whole argument was that the answer flattering to the author is the one to inspect first.

What would settle it: somebody writing it. If the part exists in five years and was written by a woman who lived it, this was the right call. If it does not exist, the silence was mine and specifying it changed nothing.

6.5 — What the pattern tells you

Look at which two were kept.

The evidence grade and the short version are both **more writing**. They cost time, which I was going to spend anyway, and they cost nothing else. Both were kept.

The other two are different. One required removing something I am proud of. The other required doing work that is uncomfortable and unrewarding for the person doing it. Neither was kept.

So the pattern is: I kept the promises that could be discharged by producing more of what I already like producing, and broke the two that required giving something up. That is not a special failure of mine. It is the ordinary shape of a promise kept by the person who made it, and it is why Part 15 said an author's own audit is worth less than one line of correction actually applied.

It is also, in miniature, the finding of Chapter Five. A commitment I could discharge alone got discharged. A commitment that required me to bear a real cost, alone, while nothing else changed, did not.

REMEMBER THIS

Four commitments, two kept. The **evidence grade** is part-kept — the four-grade scale is in use from Chapter One and twenty-two load-bearing claims are graded in the back matter, but the full pass does not exist and has no date. **The short version** is kept and published alongside this part.

Two were not kept. **Part 6** is still a detachable brief for the old rules, and it is the cheapest of the four — about an hour's work — but the only one that requires taking down something I am proud of. The **missing part** on what the rules cost right now will not be written by me.

My reason for the fourth is that I am the wrong author. The problem with that reason is that **it would have prevented every other part of this series**. Thin archives never stopped me before, and the difference this time is not evidential.

So on the record: **the first objection to land in Part 15 is the one still standing at the end.**

I kept the two promises that could be discharged by writing more, and broke the two that required giving something up — which is the finding of Chapter Five, happening to the author.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What You Could Do On Monday Morning

> *Part 15 found that in fifteen parts, not one section was addressed to a reader with an actual decision in front of her. This chapter is that section. It does not tell anybody what to do. It says which questions decide a case.*

7.1 — The distinction this chapter runs on

There is a difference between telling someone what to do and telling them what their case turns on, and the whole of this chapter sits in the gap.

A doctor who says "have the operation" is advising a decision. A doctor who says "this operation is worth it if your main problem is pain and not worth it if your main problem is movement — which is it?" is advising the reasoning. The second is more useful and it is also the honest one when the person advising will not live with the result.

Fifteen parts refused to advise at all, on the ground that a man who has never been subject to these rules should not be spending someone else's safety. That refusal was not neutral. Where the default is one-sided, declining to advise votes quietly for whatever was going to happen anyway.

So: four readers, four sets of questions. Nothing here is an instruction and everything here is drawn from a graded finding in Chapter Two.

7.2 — If you have a decision in front of you

By which I mean the reader this series is actually about — a woman weighing something specific against a warning she has been given.

Ask which half of the warning travels. The predicted harms are not one thing. Infection risk belongs to the act and shows up anywhere. Damage to your standing in the marriage market belongs to the community and shows up only where a community enforces it. So the useful question is not "what happens to a woman who does this?" It is "what does *my* community actually do, and to whom, and how recently?"

Treat the warning as a prediction and check it locally. You have been told something will happen. Has it happened, near you, to someone you can name? If it has, that is real information about your situation and it outweighs anything in this series. If nobody can produce a case, you are being told about a population you may not live in.

Notice who bears the cost of the advice and who bears the cost of the outcome. They are almost never the same person. This applies to the advice in this chapter too — I carry none of the risk of anything I have written.

Understand that the price of going first is not a smaller version of the price of everyone going. A family that defects alone absorbs the whole cost of a change that only pays if others follow. That is not an argument against doing it. It is an argument for knowing the actual price rather than the imagined one, and for looking hard at whether anyone near you is moving at the same time — because moving with three other families is a different act from moving alone, and costs a fraction as much.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Everything in the section above, and everything in every "informed choice" campaign ever run, rests on a premise nobody examines: **that knowing more improves a decision.**

Consider what this series can actually offer the woman in section 7.2. Population-level findings. What happens on average, across countries, in datasets mostly gathered elsewhere. But Chapter Two established that the effect she cares about most does not travel — it is determined by what her particular community does.

She already knows what her community does. She knows it in far more detail than any researcher, with a resolution no survey reaches. On the one question that decides her case, **she is the expert and I am the amateur.**

Which means the information in this series is least useful to the person with the most at stake, and most useful to the person with none — the observer, the policymaker, the reader at a distance. That is not a flaw in the writing. It is what population-level knowledge *is*, and no amount of care changes it.

There is a second half, and it is worse. "Informed choice" assumes information is the binding constraint — that she would act differently if only she knew more. In a coordination system the binding constraint is not knowledge. It is the price of going first. Telling someone the truth about a situation she cannot afford to change is not empowerment. It is a description delivered to a person who is already inside it.

> The general form: **information helps whoever has room to act on it, so campaigns built on informing people transfer help to the already-mobile and call it universal.**

That box does not cancel the section above it. Local checking, the travelling test and knowing the real price of going first are all things a person can use. But it sets the ceiling on what any document like this can do for the reader it is most about, and the ceiling is low.

7.3 — If you are deciding for somebody else

A parent, usually. Sometimes a brother, an aunt, a husband.

Ask whether you are applying the rule to the person who needs it or the person you can reach. This is the single most useful thing in the series for anyone in this position. If you have a daughter at home and a son who has moved away, and the rules in your household fall almost entirely on the daughter, that is worth thirty seconds of honest thought — because on the evidence, that pattern is what enforcement looks like, not what protection looks like.

Notice who your worry is actually about. Of the six goals the tradition itself states for these rules, four concern what men will do. If your fear is about men, look at which child you are managing.

Do not expect education to do the work. The families with the most money and the most schooling produced the worst child sex ratios. Sending someone to a good school changes what she can do. It does not change what you want for her.

What measurably changed parents' aspirations was seeing. In the village council experiment, the gap between what parents wanted for sons and for daughters closed by around a quarter — and it closed for people who had a woman visibly running things, not for people who were told women can run things. If you want your own view to move, the evidence says exposure does it and argument does not.

7.4 — If you want to change something

An organiser, an official, a funder, a person on a panchayat or a school committee.

Do not fund persuasion. It is the largest line in most reform budgets and the worst-evidenced activity in this entire series.

Do not reach for a ban. Every ban examined here failed and moved the behaviour somewhere less visible. A ban is attractive because it is the lever a legislature actually controls, which is a fact about legislatures rather than about the problem.

Put women where they are seen holding authority, and make sure they are seen. This is the one tier-one result in the subject. The active ingredient is the visibility, not the office — which predicts large effects in councils, schools, clinics and buses, and small ones in boardrooms, where almost nobody watches the person work.

Ask what function the rule is serving here, and supply that function another way. Insurance where there is no pension. Policing where nobody comes. Pricing in a marriage market. Attack the practice without replacing the function and you get the ultrasound ban: the demand survives and the behaviour moves.

Aim for simultaneous and visible rather than individual and private. If Chapter Five is right, the thing holding the rule in place is mutual expectation. Twenty families changing at once, publicly, in one place, is not twenty times one family changing quietly. It is a different intervention, and it is the one nobody funds because it has no national launch and no advertisement.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> The advice in 7.4 rests on the sturdiest evidence in the series, which is worth saying plainly because advice usually rests on the softest.
>
> “Do not fund persuasion” comes from a parliamentary committee auditing its own government’s spending. “Do not reach for a ban” comes from census counts before and after three separate prohibitions. “Put women where they are seen” comes from the only genuine randomisation in the subject, where villages were selected by serial number.
>
> What this cannot show: that these transfer. Every one of them is Indian, and one of the standing findings of this series is that effects which look general often belong to their setting. The village council result has been replicated in its own country and not seriously tested elsewhere. Treat 7.4 as well-established for India and as a hypothesis anywhere else.

7.5 — If you are simply reading about this

Four habits, and they are worth more than any conclusion in this document.

Ask for the grade. When you meet a number, ask what it is made of. A register or a survey? Replicated or a single study? Self-reported, on something people are punished for? Most public argument on this subject consists of Soft numbers being carried like Solid ones.

Watch for the association-as-cause move. Two things appearing together is not one causing the other. Almost every claim made in public about women's conduct performs this substitution, in both directions.

Apply the travelling test. Does this effect appear where nobody punishes the behaviour? If not, the punishment is the cause and the behaviour is the occasion.

Notice which findings you resisted. Go back through Chapters Three and Four and find the ones that irritated you. Then check whether the irritation tracked the evidence or tracked which side the finding helped. That is the test for whether you are reading or defending, and it is the only one that works from the inside.

THE ARGUMENT — IS A CHAPTER LIKE THIS USEFUL, OR DOES IT MOVE THE BLAME?

Advice given to a person with little power has a well-known second effect, and it deserves stating at full strength.

IT RELOCATES RESPONSIBILITY ONTO THE LEAST POWERFUL PERSON

Once she has been informed, every outcome becomes her choice. The family that constrained her, the market that prices her, the code that everyone else is still enforcing — all of that recedes, and what remains is a woman who was told the facts and decided. "Informed choice" is the mechanism by which a structural problem is converted into a series of personal ones, and the conversion always runs downhill.

WITHHOLDING IT IS WORSE AND MORE COMFORTABLE

The alternative is a thousand pages of analysis addressed to nobody. Silence does not protect her from having the decision; it only means she makes it without the two or three things that are actually known. And the person choosing silence is invariably the person with nothing at stake, who gets to feel scrupulous at no cost. Refusing to advise is not a lower-risk act. It is a lower-risk act *for the writer*.

BOTH, AND THE FIX IS WHO THE ADVICE IS ADDRESSED TO

The blame-shifting happens when advice is given only to the constrained party. This chapter has four sections and only one is addressed to her; the other three are addressed to the people doing the constraining, the people funding the response, and the people watching. That is not a complete answer, but it is the difference between "here are your options" and "here is what each of you is doing".

Where things stand: the third position, and it is why this chapter is ordered the way it is rather than being a single section of advice to women.

What would settle it: nothing evidential. This is a question about what a writer owes, and the honest position is that I have chosen the arrangement that seems least bad to me while carrying none of the consequences of being wrong about it.

One last thing about this chapter. It is the only one in sixteen parts that tells anybody anything, and it took a prosecution of my own work to produce it. That is worth knowing about how writing like this normally goes: the practical section is not the hard part, and it is still the part that gets left out.

REMEMBER THIS

This chapter advises the **reasoning, not the decision —** what your case turns on, not what to do.

If you have a decision: **ask which half of the warning travels**, check the prediction locally against someone you can name, notice who bears the cost of the advice versus the outcome, and know that **going first costs far more than going together**.

If you are deciding for someone else: ask whether the rule falls on the person who needs it or **the person you can reach**, notice that four of the tradition's six stated goals concern male conduct, and expect **seeing** to change your view where argument will not.

If you want to change something: **do not fund persuasion, do not reach for a ban, make women visible in authority, supply the function the rule was serving, and move many households at once rather than one at a time.**

Underneath all of it: **knowing more only helps whoever has room to act.** On the question that decides her case, the woman in section 7.2 is the expert and I am the amateur — which means this series is least useful to the person with the most at stake.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Empty Shelves

> *A map of what is known is also a map of where somebody sent a surveyor. These are the nine studies that would settle the largest open questions in this subject, and nobody has run any of them.*

8.1 — Why this chapter exists

Chapter One said the list of established findings is a list of what has been checked, not a list of what is true, and that the blank areas on the map are not featureless ground but places nobody visited.

This chapter is the inventory of those blanks. Each item is a study that could actually be done, that would settle something specific, and that does not exist. I have put the cost next to each one, roughly, because the usual explanation for missing research is that it is hard, and for most of these it is not hard. It is unfunded, which is a different word.

8.2 — The nine

One. What the rules cost right now, and who pays. The missing part from Chapter Six, specified rather than written. It would need structured testimony gathered at scale in local languages, and time-use data covering the hours spent being asked, accompanied, checked and negotiated with — hours that no time-use survey currently codes because no category exists for them. *Settles:* the burden-of-proof asymmetry that has run through this whole series, where the cost of changing was measured and the cost of staying was assumed to be zero. *Cost:* a genuine fieldwork programme. Expensive by the standards of this list and trivial by the standards of a government campaign.

Two. The full replacement. Take a set of communities and supply, at once, the things the rules are substituting for: a pension worth living on, policing that arrives, contract enforcement that works. Then measure the practices over twenty years. *Settles:* the central question of Chapter Five — whether this is a living system meeting real needs, machinery running on after its purpose, or an equilibrium held by mutual expectation. *Cost:* very high, and it is the only item here that is genuinely a research programme rather than a study.

Three. Coordinated defection. The cheapest high-value study on this list. In matched villages, arrange for twenty families to change a specific practice at the same time and publicly, and compare with villages where the same twenty families are approached one at a time and privately. Same families, same message, different coordination. *Settles:* whether the equilibrium account of Chapter Five implies a workable intervention or is merely a good description. *Cost:* small. This could be run for less than a district-level advertising budget.

Four. Men's constraint, measured outside the household. Part 11's central claim is that the rule falls where it can be reached. But household surveys are conducted in households, so a method that visits homes will find the control that happens in homes. Measure what actually constrains migrant men: remittance expectations, marriage brokerage, the threat of being cut off. *Settles:* whether the reach thesis is a finding about the world or an artefact of where researchers knock. *Cost:* moderate. It needs a new sampling frame, not new money.

Five. The long-lag persuasion study. Follow a campaign cohort for twenty-five years. Every finding in this series about persuasion rests on measurements taken within five to ten years, and every large moral change in history took two or three generations, with the persuasion phase looking useless throughout. *Settles:* whether Part 14's verdict on persuasion is right or is an artefact of how long grants last. *Cost:* low per year and impossible under current funding structures, which is the whole problem.

Six. The behavioural findings, run outside the West. The partner-count association, the regret asymmetry, the wellbeing reversal — all of it, replicated properly in India, Nigeria and Indonesia. At present roughly 96 per cent of behavioural research subjects come from countries holding about 12 per cent of the world's people, and those are the countries where these rules have already been dismantled. *Settles:* most of Part 10, in whichever direction the results fall. *Cost:* moderate, and lower every year.

Seven. A shared scoreboard, negotiated in public. Not the scoreboard — the negotiation. Put serious people from both positions in a room and have them agree, in advance and before seeing any data, on what would count as a good outcome. Publish the transcript. *Settles:* nothing empirical, and that is the point. Where the negotiation breaks down is the most informative document anybody could produce on this subject, because it would show exactly where the disagreement stops being about evidence. *Cost:* almost nothing. Nobody has done it in a century of arguing.

Eight. Who reads documents like this one, and what they do with them. Where a piece is linked, what gets quoted from it, whether a scoring chapter travels with the brief it scores. *Settles:* whether even-handed writing informs people or supplies them. *Cost:* the least of anything here. It is a weekend's work with public data and I have not done it, which Part 15 said was not a neutral omission and I am not going to pretend otherwise now.

Nine. Visibility, isolated from office. Part 14 claimed the active ingredient in the village council result was being seen holding authority rather than holding it. That is an inference from the result, not a separate measurement. Compare roles where the holder is watched working — a council, a clinic, a classroom, a bus — against roles where she is not, like a board seat. *Settles:* whether the single strongest positive finding in the subject generalises or is about one kind of job. *Cost:* moderate.

> IN REAL TERMS
>
> India's flagship campaign for the girl child released ₹446.72 crore to states over three years and put 78.91 per cent of it into media advocacy. That is roughly ₹352 crore — about 3.5 billion rupees — spent on advertising a campaign.
>
> Items three, seven and eight on that list, together, would cost a small fraction of it. Item eight would cost roughly one person's fortnight.
>
> So the money to answer several of the largest open questions in this subject has already been spent. It went on telling people the questions matter.

8.3 — Why the shelves are empty

Four reasons, and none of them is that the questions are hard.

Funding runs in three-year cycles and social change runs in generations. Item five is impossible not because anybody objects to it but because no institution exists whose planning horizon is twenty-five years and whose interest is this.

A finding of nothing does not get published. So researchers avoid designs likely to produce one, which removes exactly the studies that would tell you a popular claim is empty.

Most of these serve nobody's campaign. Item seven would embarrass both sides by showing where their disagreement stops being evidential. Item eight would tell a writer unwelcome things about his own work. Item four could weaken a finding that reformers currently find useful. Research gets funded by people who expect to like the answer.

And the subjects are not the customers. Nobody commissions research on their own behalf here. The women whose lives these questions are about have no budget, no institution and no journal, so the questions that matter most to them are the ones nobody is paying to ask.

> HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS
>
> The evidence for an absence is awkward, so here is exactly what it consists of.
>
> For items two, three, five, seven and nine: a search of the published literature turns up nothing of the described design. That is weak evidence — an unpublished study is invisible and an unsuccessful search is not a proof.
>
> For item six the evidence is much stronger and it is a count rather than a search: the survey of research subjects by country, showing 96 per cent from Western industrialised nations and 68 per cent from the United States alone. That is a measurement of where the work was done, not a failure to find it.
>
> For item eight the evidence is that I know, because it is my own work and I have not looked.
>
> Treat a missing count the way this series has treated one throughout. When institutions had the power to fund an answer and did not, the absence is a finding rather than a gap — and this chapter's argument is that the pattern of what is missing is too consistent to be random.

Section 8.3 stated four reasons as though they were established. They are not, and the strongest reply to them deserves the floor.

THE ARGUMENT — IS THE MISSING RESEARCH MISSING BY ACCIDENT OR BY DESIGN?

Section 8.3 makes a strong claim, and the strong version is worth testing against its best rival.

BY DESIGN, ROUGHLY

Look at the pattern. Every missing study is one that would either embarrass a funder, produce a null result, take longer than a career, or serve people with no money. That is not a random distribution of gaps. It is the shape you get when the questions are filtered by who pays, and the filter is invisible because nobody ever announces a study they decided not to fund.

BY ACCIDENT, AND THE PATTERN IS AN ILLUSION

Research is opportunistic everywhere, on every subject. Physics has enormous unexplored areas too, and nobody calls that political. Studies happen where a graduate student, an existing dataset and a supervisor's interest happen to meet. A list of nine unrun studies assembled by somebody who already believes the field is skewed will always look damning, because he selected them. The null cases — obvious studies that were run and found nothing interesting — are invisible to him for exactly the reason he complains about.

NEITHER WORD FITS — IT IS A SELECTION PROCESS WITH NO SELECTOR

"Design" implies somebody decided and "accident" implies nobody did. What actually operates is a filter: journals prefer findings, funders prefer answers they can use, careers prefer results inside a decade, and subjects with no budget generate no demand. Nobody has to intend anything. Run those four preferences for fifty years and you get precisely this pattern of shelves, with no meeting having taken place.

Where things stand: the third position. The second is right that my list is selected and I should say so plainly — I chose these nine, and I chose them because they bear on claims I have made. The first is right that the pattern is too consistent to shrug at. A filter with no operator explains both.

What would settle it: registries of proposed studies that were not funded. Some funders publish these. Nobody has analysed them for this subject.

Why people care so much: because "nobody has studied it" is currently used as a knockdown argument by whichever side the absence favours, and it is not one. An absence is evidence about the field, not about the world.

An empty shelf is the cheapest thing in research to point at and the most expensive to fill. That asymmetry is why this chapter exists and why it is the second-shortest in the part.

REMEMBER THIS

Nine studies would settle most of the open questions here and none has been run. The cheapest and most valuable is **coordinated defection** — twenty families changing at once and publicly, against twenty approached one at a time — which would test whether Chapter Five's account implies a real intervention.

Others: **what the rules cost right now**, **the full replacement** of the functions they serve, **men's constraint measured outside the household**, **a twenty-five-year persuasion study**, **the behavioural findings run outside the West**, **a published scoreboard negotiation**, **who actually reads this kind of work**, and **visibility isolated from office**.

They are missing because funding runs in three-year cycles, null results do not publish, most of them serve nobody's campaign, and **the subjects are not the customers** — the women these questions concern have no budget, no institution and no journal.

Nobody designed this and nobody caused it. It is **a filter with no operator**: four ordinary preferences, run for fifty years, with no meeting ever taking place.

The money to answer several of these questions has already been spent — on advertising a campaign about the questions.

CHAPTER NINE

What I Actually Think

> *Fifteen parts refused to say. This one says it, states plainly how little weight it deserves, and then turns the last hidden assumption on the whole series.*

9.1 — Why this is here at all

The standing reason for refusing was good. I am a man who has never been subject to these rules, writing for people who would bear every consequence of taking my advice. Advice under that arrangement is a stranger spending somebody else's safety.

That reason has not stopped being true. Here is why I am overriding it.

A thousand pages plainly imply a view. Anybody who has read this far knows roughly what I think, because the choice of what to examine, what to test hardest and what to leave alone has been telling them for sixteen parts. Refusing to state it while broadcasting it is not restraint. It is having it both ways: the influence of a position with none of the accountability of holding one.

So it goes on the page, in one section, labelled, where it can be argued with.

9.2 — What I think

First, on what this is. I think the rules about women are not a moral order and not a conspiracy. They are an equilibrium — a set of arrangements each person is right to keep following as long as everyone else does, held in place by expectation rather than by belief or by benefit. That is why they survive prosperity, education, law and argument. None of those touch the thing holding the door.

Second, on whether they are wrong. I think they are, and I want to be careful about the ground, because the outcome evidence in this series does not settle it and I am not going to pretend it does.

The ground is not that the rules produce bad results. Some of them produce mixed results and one or two produce real protection. The ground is that the person carrying the burden did not agree to it and cannot leave it, and that the tradition's own accounting says four of its six stated worries concern what men will do. An arrangement that identifies male conduct as the problem four times in six, and then builds its entire enforcement around female movement, has stopped being a moral order and become a distribution of costs onto whoever is in reach. I think that is wrong for reasons that have nothing to do with any table in this book, and I would think it if every effect size came back favourable.

Third, on the reformers. I think most of what the reforming movement does is ineffective and some of it is worse than ineffective. Persuasion does not work and consumes the largest share of the budget. Bans do not work and move the harm somewhere less visible. Reporting national averages while the gains sit with the urban and educated is not a communication problem, it is a measurement choice that conceals exactly what the argument is about. An honest reformer would stop persuading and start installing: clinics, wages, records, school rolls, seats, and women visibly running things where people can watch them do it.

Fourth, on the traditionalists. I think the fertility argument is the strongest thing anybody has said in this entire debate and that nobody has an answer to it, including me. No society has replaced itself after reorganising around individual choice, and none has climbed back. The habit on my side of the argument — changing the subject when this comes up, or treating it as a bad-faith talking point — is intellectually disgraceful and it is what people do when they have nothing. I do not know what the answer is. I am fairly confident it is not more advertising, and fairly confident it is not restoring the rules, because Iran ran that experiment and the rate fell anyway.

Fifth, the concrete test. The honest way to state a view about other people's lives is to say what you would do in your own. If I had a daughter, I would not manage her movements, and I would expect to pay for that, and the payment would be real rather than symbolic — narrower marriage prospects inside a market that has not changed its criteria, and a family that has spent something on a change that only pays if others make it too. I would want to make that move alongside other households rather than alone, because Chapter Five says that is not a preference but an enormous difference in price. And I would not pretend the cost was somebody else's superstition.

9.3 — How much weight this deserves

Very little, and I can be specific about why.

Part 15 measured this author against his own first expectations on six questions and found him wrong on all six — always in the direction of the ordinary, individual-level, belief-driven answer. That is a measured error rate, on this subject, for this person, and it applies to everything above, because the claims above have not been tested by anything.

Nothing in section 9.2 carries a grade. It cannot. It is not that kind of statement.

And the one question that decides an actual case — what your community will actually do — is one on which the woman deciding is the expert and I am the amateur. Chapter Seven's hidden assumption established that and it applies with full force here.

THE ARGUMENT — IS A CONSIDERED VIEW WORTH MORE THAN A FIRST IMPRESSION?

The whole justification for reading somebody after a long study is that the study improved them. It is worth checking.

YES — THAT IS WHAT STUDY IS FOR

A person who has read the literature knows which claims have been tested and which have not, which effects travel, and where the evidence stops. That is not a matter of opinion improving; it is a matter of having information the first impression lacked. Anyone who denies this is denying that reading does anything, which nobody believes when it is their own field.

NO — LONG STUDY CAN MAKE YOU CONFIDENTLY WRONG

The literature is not a sample of what is true. It is a sample of what got funded, published and written in English. Reading it thoroughly moves you towards the field's centre of gravity, not towards the truth, and it moves you there with much greater confidence than you started with. Part 15's six reversals were all in one direction: the direction of the popular reading. That is not a personal defect, it is what happens to anyone who reads carefully in a skewed field.

MORE ON MECHANISMS, NO MORE ON VALUES

The two claims are different. On how something works — what a ban does to a demand, what visibility does to expectation — a considered view is straightforwardly better, because those are checkable and the checking has been done. On whether the arrangement is right, the study adds nothing at all. Sixteen parts of evidence gave me no standing whatsoever on section 9.2's second paragraph, which is a claim about consent and burden that a person could reach in an afternoon.

Where things stand: the third position, and it is the reason this chapter is short. My views on the mechanisms are worth something because they were tested. My view on the wrongness is worth what anybody's is, and the thousand pages behind it lend it an authority it has not earned.

What would settle it: tracking whether people who study a contested subject converge on truth or on their field's consensus. This has been examined in some sciences and not here.

Why people care so much: because "I have studied this" is the strongest move available in a public argument, and it works even when the study bore only on a question nobody is fighting about.

9.4 — The assumption underneath all sixteen parts

One thing left, and I have been avoiding it since about Part 4.

THE HIDDEN ASSUMPTION

Sixteen parts, a thousand pages, one title. Every one of them assumed something nobody in this argument ever states: **that "the rules about women" is one thing.** A single object, with a single history, a single explanation, and therefore a single answer.

Suppose it is five things wearing the same face. A **property transfer** at marriage. A **paternity device**. A **coordination code** that lets strangers within a group trust each other. A **labour allocation** that assigns unpaid work. A **status display** that signals a family can afford to keep an adult out of paid employment.

> Those five have different origins, different beneficiaries, different economics and different repairs. What they share is an enforcement apparatus — the same aunts, the same reputation, the same phone — which is precisely why they look like one system from the outside. But a shared delivery mechanism is not a shared cause, any more than the postal service is the reason for the letters.
>
> If this is right, then almost every general statement in this series is an average across five unrelated machines, and the flat results are exactly what you would expect from averaging things that do not belong together. It would also explain the most stubborn pattern in the whole subject: that interventions which work well on one practice do nothing to another, in ways nobody has been able to predict.
>
> And I know why I assumed the single object. Not because the evidence pointed there. Because **a series needs a subject**, and “five loosely related arrangements that happen to be enforced by the same people” is not a title. The structure of the thing I was making decided the shape of what I could find in it.
>
> The general form: **the unit of analysis is chosen before the analysis and is never itself analysed.** It arrives with the project, disguised as the topic.

9.5 — What that leaves

Not much, and I would rather end honestly than tidily.

Eleven findings hold. Four mechanisms explain a great deal of what the findings show, and the fourth of them — that nobody can defect alone — is the one I would keep if I could keep only one. Six widely held beliefs do not survive, three of them mine at the start.

Beyond that: an argument that stalls at the edge of a narrow band, a set of empty shelves too consistently shaped to be accidental, a first objection that is still standing at the end because I declined to answer it, and a subject that may not be a subject.

The series set out to find out why the rules about women exist and what happens when they change. It found that the second question has better answers than the first, that the first may have been malformed, and that the thing most likely to move anything is not writing at all — which is an awkward result for a thousand pages, and the correct one to report.

REMEMBER THIS

What I think: the rules are an **equilibrium**, not a moral order and not a conspiracy. They are **wrong**, on grounds of consent and of who carries the burden — not on outcome evidence, which does not settle it. The reformers' programme is **mostly ineffective** and should stop persuading and start installing. And the **fertility argument is the strongest thing anyone has said** in this debate, nobody has an answer, and changing the subject when it comes up is disgraceful.

Weight it accordingly: none of that carries a grade, and Part 15 measured this author wrong on six out of six of his own first expectations, always in the direction of the popular reading.

A considered view is worth more on **mechanisms** and no more on **values**. Sixteen parts gave me real standing on what a ban does to a demand and no standing at all on whether the arrangement is right.

The last assumption, underneath everything: **that "the rules about women" is one thing.** It may be five — a property transfer, a paternity device, a coordination code, a labour allocation and a status display — sharing an enforcement apparatus but not a cause. I assumed one object because a series needs a subject.

The unit of analysis is chosen before the analysis and never itself analysed. It arrives with the project, disguised as the topic.

CHAPTER TEN

An Honest List of What We Do Not Know

> *Every part of this series ends here. This time the list covers all sixteen — what is genuinely unknown across the whole subject, why, and the shorter list of what can be built on.*

10.1 — Genuinely unknown

The reason for a gap is nearly always more useful than the missing fact would have been. That has been true in every part of this series and it is most true here.

What causes the fertility decline. The decline is beyond dispute and universal among rich and urbanising societies. The candidate causes — housing costs, the length of education, insecure work, the disappearance of unpaid childcare from relatives, the expansion of women's options — arrive together everywhere and have never been separated. *Why it is unknown:* there is no case where one moved and the others held still. Not one. This is the largest open question in the subject and both camps are reading their preferred cause out of the single dataset everybody shares.

Whether the reach thesis is a fact about the world. The claim that rules fall where they can be enforced rather than where belief points is the most important thing in this series and it is not proved. *Why it is unknown:* household surveys are conducted in households, so a method that visits homes will find the control that happens in homes. Nobody has measured what actually constrains a man who has moved away.

Whether this is one thing or five. Chapter Nine's last box asks whether "the rules about women" is a single arrangement or a family resemblance across a property transfer, a paternity device, a coordination code, a labour allocation and a status display. *Why it is unknown:* the unit of analysis is chosen before any analysis and is never itself examined — by me or by anyone else writing on this.

What the rules cost right now, and who pays. *Why it is unknown:* nobody counts it. There is no category in any time-use survey for hours spent being asked, accompanied, checked and negotiated with, so the largest ongoing cost in the subject is invisible to every instrument pointed at it. Absence of a category is not absence of a thing.

Whether persuasion works on a long lag. Every measurement runs five to ten years. Every large moral change in history took two or three generations and looked useless throughout. *Why it is unknown:* research funding runs in three-year cycles. The gap between those two numbers is a fact about institutions, not about persuasion.

Whether the visibility effect is about being seen or about holding office. *Why it is unknown:* the strongest positive finding in the subject came from one experiment that did not separate the two, and nobody has run the comparison since.

Whether any of the Indian results transfer. The village council result, the sex ratio gradient, the campaign spending, the ban failures — all Indian. *Why it is unknown:* roughly 96 per cent of behavioural research subjects come from Western industrialised countries holding about 12 per cent of the world's people, and the middle of the world has been studied by almost nobody. Indian results are unusual in existing at all, which is a poor reason to assume they generalise.

What the people with no organised position would say. The woman who thinks the rules are foolish and complies because complying is cheaper. The mother-in-law who enforces and would not call it enforcing. The unmarried man at the bottom of the class structure, who appears in this series only as a risk to others. *Why it is unknown:* they have no literature and no budget, this series was built entirely from the published record, and I never went and asked.

Whether this series did more good than harm. *Why it is unknown:* there is no comparison world. I cannot observe the version of the last year in which these thousand pages were not written and see what those readers did instead. It is the only question that finally matters and there is no instrument for it at all.

HOW WE ACTUALLY KNOW THIS

Look at what those nine have in common, because the pattern is the finding.

Not one is unknown because the evidence is contradictory. Not one is a case where careful people looked hard and came back with a muddle. Every single one is unknown because **nobody built the instrument —** no category in the survey, no funding past three years, no sampling frame outside the household, no researchers in the middle of the world, no budget belonging to the people concerned, and in the last case no possible measurement at all.

Chapter Eight's argument box asked whether that pattern was designed or accidental and settled on a third answer: a filter with no operator. This list is what that filter produces.

What this cannot show: that the answers would be interesting. Some unstudied questions are unstudied because they are dull, and you cannot tell which from outside. That is the second-order version of the same problem and there is no way around it.

10.2 — Solid

Shorter, as always, and worth more than everything above it.

The eleven findings in Chapter Two carry their grades and stand. The strongest are the ones built out of records that institutions made while doing something else.

The stated function was solved and nothing was retired. Cheap paternity testing has existed for thirty years; no community anywhere relaxed a rule in response. *Why it is solid:* both halves are checkable by anybody, and an absence of response where every opportunity existed is a finding rather than a gap.

Every ban examined here failed. The 1929 marriage-age act, dowry prohibition, the ultrasound ban and the child sex ratio falling from 962 to 918. *Why it is solid:* census counts and administrative records, collected by offices with no stake in this argument.

Visible female authority changes what people believe about female authority. Village council leadership reserved and rotated by serial number; measured bias fell; more women later won unreserved seats; the gap in what parents wanted for daughters closed by around a quarter. *Why it is solid:* the rotation was mechanical, which makes it the only genuine randomisation in the subject.

Son preference did the most damage among the richest and best educated. *Why it is solid:* census data, and the direction is the opposite of what almost everyone predicts, which is a good sign in a finding.

India's flagship campaign put 78.91 per cent of its released funds into media advocacy. *Why it is solid:* a parliamentary committee auditing its own government and finding against it — the direction institutional evidence almost never runs. The caveat stands: the sex ratio improved over the period and attribution is contested.

No country has reversed a fertility decline. *Why it is solid:* national vital statistics, and the claim is an absence across every case, which is the easiest kind of claim to refute and nobody has.

The state's own courts have described the old arrangement in the plainest possible terms. A 2018 judgment striking down the adultery law said the provision had treated a wife as property. *Why it is solid:* it is a document.

Two unconnected sets of criminals price the double standard identically. *Why it is solid:* independent convergence. When two groups with no contact, no ideology and only a profit motive arrive at the same valuation of the same social fact, the fact is real.

IN REAL TERMS

Nine things unknown. Nine things solid. Sixteen parts, a thousand pages, and roughly a year of evenings.

Put like that it sounds thin, and it is worth saying that this is a normal yield rather than a poor one. A working scientist can spend a decade and add two or three things to the second list. The difference is that nobody expects a scientist to also produce a conclusion, and every reader of a book expects one.

10.3 — And one thing that is certain without being empirical

Where nobody is persuaded, the arrangement already running continues. That needs no study. It is what a default is, and it means every argument in this series that ended without resolution ended with the rules still in force — decided by the structure of the situation rather than by anything either side said.

Add the finding from Chapter Five and it sharpens into something more useful: **a practice continuing is evidence about coordination, not about consent.** You may not infer from the survival of an arrangement that anybody wants it, and you may not infer from majority disapproval that it will end. Both inferences are made constantly, by both sides, and both are invalid.

REMEMBER THIS

Nine things are genuinely unknown, and **not one of them is unknown because the evidence is contradictory**. Every single one is unknown because nobody built the instrument — no category, no funding past three years, no sampling frame, no researchers, no budget belonging to the people concerned.

The largest is **what causes the fertility decline**: the candidates always arrive together and no case exists where one moved and the others held still.

What is solid is narrow and mostly built from records made by institutions doing something else — a census, a court judgment, a spending audit, a rule for rotating seats, and one accidental randomisation.

And one certainty that needs no study: **where nobody is persuaded, the default runs**. Every unresolved argument in sixteen parts ended with the rules in force.

A practice continuing is evidence about coordination, not about consent — and both sides make the opposite inference constantly.

REFERENCE

The Evidence Grade

This is the first instalment of the commitment made in Part 15 and reported on in Chapter Six. Twenty-two load-bearing claims from across the series, with what each one actually rests on and what weight it can carry. The full pass, claim by claim through all sixteen parts, does not exist.

The scale, once more. **Solid** is a count, a register, a court record or a genuine randomised experiment. **Good** is a finding an independent team has run again. **Single** is one study, never rechecked. **Soft** is self-report about punished behaviour, or a projection rather than a measurement. Soft does not mean false and Solid does not mean important.

CLAIM	WHAT IT RESTS ON	GRADE
The rule falls where it can be enforced, not where belief points	Censuses and household surveys, plus an inference from the pattern	Solid counts, contested reading
Daily enforcement is largely administered by women on women	Large national household surveys; more than one South Asian dataset	Good
Cheap paternity testing has existed for thirty years and nothing was retired	The technology record, plus an absence of response where every opportunity existed	Solid
Of the predicted harms, infection travels and marriage-market damage does not	Epidemiology for the first; a comparison across settings for the second	Solid
The wellbeing effect reverses with the community's belief	Several small studies pointing the same way; none large	Single to Good
The regret asymmetry travels	A US finding replicated by an independent Norwegian team	Good, but a modest effect
Partner count before marriage is associated with later divorce	One national US survey; self-reported; not a straight line; no mechanism; untested elsewhere	Soft
The 1929 act raising the marriage age produced a surge of marriages before it commenced	Administrative records	Solid

CLAIM	WHAT IT RESTS ON	GRADE
The child sex ratio fell from 962 to 918 girls per 1,000 boys after the scan ban	Census	Solid
Son preference did most damage among richer, urban and educated families	Census	Solid
Reserving village council seats reduced measured bias and led to more women winning unreserved seats	Reservation rotated by village serial number — a genuine randomisation	Solid
The parental aspiration gap closed by around a quarter, and adolescent girls' own by about a third	The same experiment	Solid
78.91 per cent of ₹446.72 crore released to states went on media advocacy	Parliamentary committee report, December 2021, auditing its own government	Solid
South Korea has spent over $200 billion; the rate moved from 0.72 to 0.80	National vital statistics	Solid
Hungary spent around 5 per cent of national output, reached 1.59 in 2021 and is back near 1.31	National vital statistics	Solid
India's fertility rate is about 1.9, with rural India at 2.1, Delhi at 1.2 and Bihar at 2.8	Sample Registration System	Solid
The marital rape exception was retained in the new criminal code; the Union opposed removal in October 2024; no verdict as of early 2026	Statute and filed court positions	Solid
India's Supreme Court, striking down the adultery law in 2018, said it had treated a wife as property	The judgment text	Solid

CLAIM	WHAT IT RESTS ON	GRADE
Around nine in ten victims of financial blackmail using intimate images are boys aged 14 to 17	Child-protection and law-enforcement analyses, converging	Good
Never-married Indian men rise from about 4.5 per cent in 2010 to 12.6 per cent by 2040	A demographic projection, not an observation	Soft
Of 100 psychology studies rerun, 36 replicated; of 21 in Nature and Science, 13; of 274 claims across 54 journals, about 55 per cent	Pre-registered replication projects designed to be checked	Solid
About 96 per cent of behavioural research subjects come from countries holding about 12 per cent of the world's people	A count of published papers by country	Solid

REFERENCE

The Series, Part by Part

PART	TITLE AND WHAT IT ESTABLISHED
One	The Question Underneath the Question — set the framing for all sixteen parts, and the travelling test used later to check whether an effect found in one place shows up in another.
Two	Where the Rules Came From — the historical origins, and the warning that where something came from does not settle what it is worth.
Three	The Indian Machine — how the rules are transmitted and enforced here; turns the where-it-came-from objection on the series itself.
Four	The Bodies Themselves — measured sex differences, with an effect-size table and the caveats about what an average difference licenses about any individual.
Five	The Paradox of the Free Countries — four competing accounts of why outcomes in liberal societies matched nobody's predictions.
Six	The Case for the Old Rules — advocacy; seven arguments at full strength, then scored against four conditions.
Seven	What Feminism Actually Claims — an audit; a claims scorecard and an Indian timeline from 1848.
Eight	The Ledger of the Equality Project — eighteen rows of outcomes, with a column asking who each change actually reached.
Nine	The Arithmetic of Descendants — fertility, pronatalism, and the finding that no country has reversed a decline.
Ten	What the Evidence Says Happens to a Woman — the core warning unpacked into four claims and tested.
Eleven	The Half Nobody Studied — men as the missing comparison group; the rule falls where it can be enforced.
Twelve	The Community With No Edges — enforcement after the community loses its boundaries; two patterns of blackmail-by-photograph, priced differently by two independent sets of criminals.
Thirteen	When History Ran the Experiment — nine cases graded against six tests; one genuine randomisation exists in the whole subject.

PART	TITLE AND WHAT IT ESTABLISHED
Fourteen	What Would Actually Work — four intervention shapes scored; persuasion classified as a category error, visibility as the one tier-one success.
Fifteen	The Case Against This Series — fourteen objections, twelve of which land, and four commitments instead of a conclusion.
Sixteen	What Survived — this document. Eleven findings, four mechanisms, six beliefs that did not survive, and a report on the four commitments: two kept.
After	**The series ends here.** What remains is the short version, the nine empty shelves in Chapter Eight, and one objection still standing.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Every term this document treats as needing explanation, in plain English, in one place.

TERM	MEANING
Administrative record	Information collected by a government or institution in order to do its job — a birth register, a school roll, a court file. The most reliable evidence in this series, because it was made for another purpose.
Association	Two things that show up together. Not the same as one causing the other.
Cause	One thing making another happen.
Coordination problem	A situation where what is best for you depends on what everybody else does, so nobody can improve things by acting alone.
Crore	Ten million, in Indian counting. ₹1 crore is ten million rupees.
Default	What happens if nobody does anything. In a system of rules, the arrangement currently running.
Effect size	How big a difference something makes, as opposed to whether the difference is real at all.
Equilibrium	A situation that holds itself in place because each person, given what everyone else is doing, has no reason to move first.
Fertility rate	The average number of children a woman would have over her life at current rates. About 2.1 is replacement — the level at which a population holds steady without migration.
Functional explanation	Explaining something by what it does, rather than by how it arose or whether it is right.
Hidden assumption	A premise both sides of an argument accept without stating, and therefore never examine.
Marriage squeeze	A shortage of women of marrying age relative to men, produced by an unbalanced sex ratio at birth working its way up the age structure.
Null result	A study that finds nothing. Rarely published, which is why the published record is not a sample of what is true.

TERM	MEANING
Randomisation	Assigning people or places by lot, so the groups differ only by chance and any later difference can be attributed to the treatment.
Replication	Running somebody else's study again, on new people, to see whether the same thing happens.
Self-report	Evidence made of what people say about themselves. Reliable for some things, and not for anything they are punished for.
Sunk asset	Something already built which is expensive to create and cheap to keep running. Machinery that exists gets used.
Synthesis	Putting separate findings together to see what they add up to. Not a summary — a summary shortens each part, a synthesis asks what holds across all of them.
Travelling test	Checking whether an effect found in one place appears in another. If it does not travel, it belongs to the setting rather than to the act.

THE LIVING ARCHIVE

About the Author

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I write long-form research on Indian history, society, belief and public life, and publish it under my own name. Nobody commissions it and nobody can withdraw it. That removes one kind of pressure and adds the pressure of having nobody to tell me a chapter is bad.

This series began with a woman photographed at a protest and attacked, on no evidence, for the kind of woman strangers decided she was. I did not write about her, and I have said in the text more than once that deciding that on her behalf was itself a decision I made about somebody else. Sixteen parts later I am less certain that studying the machinery was the right response to somebody being hurt by it. That uncertainty is in Part 15 and it is not resolved here.

I am working towards doctoral research. This series is not that. It is a synthesis of the published record, written for people who were never going to read the published record, by a reader of that record rather than a producer of it.

THE THREE RULES

Plain language. Short sentences, everyday words, every hard term explained where it appears. Simple words, serious content, nothing left out — the simple version is longer, not shorter.

Evidence, named. What a claim rests on gets stated, along with what that kind of evidence is bad at. Part 15 found this series had not done it nearly well enough, and the evidence grade in this part is the first repair.

Every side at full strength, and an honest list of what is not known. The tenth chapter of every part is the two-list breakdown, and it is the chapter almost nobody else writes.

A WORD ON SOURCES

This document carries no footnotes. It is a synthesis of the published record, not new primary research. Where a figure matters, the study, judgment or report is named in the text so you can find it.

The archive behind this series is good at some things and bad at others, and the imbalance is not random. Government material — censuses, crime records, parliamentary reports, court judgments — is abundant, cheap to reach and durable, which is why the strongest findings here rest on it. Behavioural research is plentiful for rich Western countries and thin everywhere else. Records of what ordinary women experienced are the thinnest of all, and much of what exists was gathered decades later by people asking a different question. A series built on that archive inherits its shape. Chapter Eight is a list of the specific consequences.

Where a claim rests only on an institution's account of itself, that is flagged in the text. Where a number is disputed, the range is given with the method behind each end of it. Post-cutoff figures in the later parts were checked against current sources rather than recalled.

If something here is wrong, write and tell me. Later editions will say what was changed and who caught it. That promise has been in every part of this series and it remains the only mechanism in the whole project by which a reader can change the text.

THE CLOSE

Where This Ends

There is no Part 17. What is left is a set of questions I could not answer, handed over to anybody who wants them. They are stated as questions because questions create an obligation and topics do not.

- What do these rules cost, right now, in hours and in what those hours would otherwise have been — and who is paying? Nobody counts it, because no survey has a category for being asked, accompanied and checked.
- Does the rule really fall where it can be reached, or does it only look that way because researchers knock on doors?
- Is this one arrangement or five — a property transfer, a paternity device, a coordination code, a labour allocation and a status display — sharing an enforcement apparatus but not a cause?
- What happens when twenty households in one place change at the same time and in public, compared with twenty approached one at a time and quietly?
- What actually causes a fertility decline, and is there any case anywhere where the material conditions moved and the cultural arrangement held still?
- Does a campaign that shows nothing after ten years show something after twenty-five, and is there any institution on earth whose planning horizon could find out?
- And the one addressed to whoever reads this: which of the findings in Chapter Two irritated you, and did the irritation track the evidence or track which side the finding helped?

The short version of this series is published alongside this part. It is about four thousand words and it takes twenty minutes. If you are going to pass one thing to somebody, pass that.

End of Part 16 of 16 — the series is complete